

EDITED BY

CAROLYN J.
SHARP



≡ The Oxford Handbook of
THE PROPHETS

THE OXFORD HANDBOOK OF
THE PROPHETS

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CAROLYN J. SHARP

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ABBREVIATIONS

MODERN SOURCES

AB	Anchor Bible
ABD	<i>Anchor Bible Dictionary</i> . Edited by David Noel Freedman. 6 vols. New York: Doubleday, 1992
ABRL	Anchor Bible Reference Library
AcOr	<i>Acta Orientalia</i>
ACW	<i>Ancient Christian Writers</i>
AGJU	Arbeiten zur Geschichte des antiken Judentums und des Urchristentums
AIL	Ancient Israel and Its Literature
AJSR	Association for Jewish Studies Review
ANEM	Ancient Near East Monographs
ANEP	<i>The Ancient Near East in Pictures Relating to the Old Testament</i> . 2nd ed. Edited by James B. Pritchard. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1994
ANET	<i>Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament</i> . Edited by James B. Pritchard. 3rd ed. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1969
AOTC	Abingdon Old Testament Commentaries
ARM	Archives royales de Mari
ATD	Das Alte Testament Deutsch
ATR	<i>Anglican Theological Review</i>
ATSAT	Arbeiten zu Text und Sprache im Alten Testament
AYBRL	Anchor Yale Bible Reference Library
BA	<i>Biblical Archaeologist</i>
BASOR	<i>Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research</i>
BBB	Bonner Biblische Beiträge
BBC	Blackwell Bible Commentaries
BBET	Beiträge zur biblischen Exegese und Theologie
BCT	<i>Bible & Critical Theory</i>

BEATAJ	Beiträge zur Erforschung des Alten Testaments und des antiken Judentum
BETL	Bibliotheca Ephemeridum theologicarum Lovaniensium
BHK	<i>Biblia Hebraica</i> . Edited by Rudolph Kittel. Leipzig: Hinrichs, 1905–1906
BHS	<i>Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia</i> . Edited by Karl Elliger and Wilhelm Rudolph. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 1983
BHQ	<i>Biblia Hebraica Quinta</i> . Edited by Adrian Schenker et al. Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2004–
<i>Bib</i>	<i>Biblica</i>
BibEnc	Biblical Encyclopedia
<i>BibInt</i>	<i>Biblical Interpretation: A Journal of Contemporary Approaches</i>
BibInt	Biblical Interpretation Series
BJSUCSD	Biblical and Judaic Studies from the University of California, San Diego
BKAT	Biblischer Kommentar: Altes Testament
<i>Bsac</i>	<i>Bibliotheca sacra</i>
<i>BT</i>	<i>The Bible Translator</i>
BWANT	Beiträge zur Wissenschaft vom Alten und Neuen Testament
<i>BZ</i>	<i>Biblische Zeitschrift</i>
BZAW	Beihefte zur Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft
CBET	Contributions to Biblical Exegesis and Theology
CBOTS	Coniectanea Biblica Old Testament Series
CBQ	<i>Catholic Biblical Quarterly</i>
CBQMS	Catholic Biblical Quarterly Monograph Series
CC	Continental Commentaries
CCSL	Corpus Christianorum: Series Latina. Turnhout: Brepols, 1953–
CEB	Common English Bible
CHANE	Culture and History of the Ancient Near East
<i>CurBR</i>	<i>Currents in Biblical Research</i>
<i>CurBS</i>	<i>Currents in Research: Biblical Studies</i>
CTU	<i>The Cuneiform Alphabetic Texts from Ugarit, Ras Ibn Hani, and Other Places</i> . Edited by Manfred Dietrich, Oswald Loretz, and Joaquín Sanmartín. Münster: Ugarit-Verlag, 1995
DJD	Discoveries in the Judaean Desert
DSD	<i>Dead Sea Discoveries</i>
ECC	Eerdmans Critical Commentary
EJL	Early Judaism and Its Literature

ET	English translation
ETL	<i>Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses</i>
ExpTim	<i>Expository Times</i>
Exuz	Exegese in unserer Zeit
FAT	Forschungen zum Alten Testament
FCB	Feminist Companion to the Bible
FOTC	Fathers of the Church
FOTL	Forms of the Old Testament Literature
FRLANT	Forschungen zur Religion und Literatur des Alten und Neuen Testaments
GCS	Die griechischen christlichen Schriftsteller der ersten [drei] Jahrhunderte
GKC	<i>Gesenius' Hebrew Grammar</i> . Edited by Emil Kautzsch. Translated by Arthur E. Cowley. 2nd ed. Oxford: Clarendon, 1910
GNB	Good News Bible
HAR	<i>Hebrew Annual Review</i>
HALOT	<i>The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament</i> . Ludwig Koehler, Walter Baumgartner, and Johann J. Stamm, Translated and edited under the supervision of Mervyn E. J. Richardson. 4 vols. Leiden: Brill, 1994–1999
HAT	Handbuch zum Alten Testament
HBM	Hebrew Bible Monographs
HBS	Herders Biblische Studien
HBT	<i>Horizons in Biblical Theology</i>
HeBAI	<i>Hebrew Bible/Ancient Israel</i>
HThKAT	Herders Theologischer Kommentar zum Alten Testament
HS	Holiness School
HSM	Harvard Semitic Monographs
HTR	<i>Harvard Theological Review</i>
HUBP	Hebrew University Bible Project
HUCA	<i>Hebrew Union College Annual</i>
IBC	Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching
IBHS	<i>An Introduction to Biblical Hebrew Syntax</i> . Bruce K. Waltke and Michael O'Connor. Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 1990
IBT	Interpreting Biblical Texts
ICC	International Critical Commentary
Int	<i>Interpretation</i>
ISBL	Indiana Studies in Biblical Literature

JAAR	<i>Journal of the American Academy of Religion</i>
JANES	<i>Journal of the Ancient Near Eastern Society</i>
JBL	<i>Journal of Biblical Literature</i>
JFSR	<i>Journal of Feminist Studies in Religion</i>
JHS	<i>Journal of Hebrew Scriptures</i>
JJS	<i>Journal of Jewish Studies</i>
JR	<i>Journal of Religion</i>
JNES	<i>Journal of Near Eastern Studies</i>
JNSL	<i>Journal of Northwest Semitic Languages</i>
JSCE	<i>Journal of the Society of Christian Ethics</i>
JSem	<i>Journal of Semitics</i>
JSJ	<i>Journal for the Study of Judaism in the Persian, Hellenistic and Roman Periods</i>
JSOT	<i>Journal for the Study of the Old Testament</i>
JSOTSup	<i>Journal for the Study of the Old Testament Supplement Series</i>
JSP	<i>Journal for the Study of the Pseudepigrapha</i>
JSSM	<i>Journal of Semitic Studies Monograph</i>
JTS	<i>Journal for Theological Studies</i>
KAT	Kommentar zum Alten Testament
KHC	Kurzer Hand-Commentar zum Alten Testament
KTU	<i>Die keilalphabetischen Texte aus Ugarit</i> . Edited by Manfred Dietrich, Oswald Loretz, and Joaquín Sanmartín. Münster: Ugarit-Verlag, 2013
LAI	Library of Ancient Israel
LHBOTS	The Library of Hebrew Bible/Old Testament Studies
LSTS	Library of Second Temple Studies
MdB	<i>Le Monde de la Bible</i>
NABR	New American Bible, Revised Edition
NCB	New Century Bible
NEA	<i>Near Eastern Archaeology</i>
NEchtB	Neue Echter Bibel
NET	New English Translation
NETS	<i>A New English Translation of the Septuagint</i> . Edited by Albert Pietersma and Benjamin G. Wright. New York: Oxford University Press, 2007
NICOT	New International Commentary on the Old Testament
NIV	New International Version
NJB	New Jerusalem Bible

NJPS	<i>Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures: The New JPS Translation according to the Traditional Hebrew Text</i>
NovTSup	Supplements to Novum Testamentum
NRSV	New Revised Standard Version
NSKAT	Neuer Stuttgarter Kommentar: Altes Testament
OBO	Orbis Biblicus et Orientalis
OBT	Overtures to Biblical Theology
OTG	Old Testament Guides
OTL	Old Testament Library
OTM	Old Testament Message
OTS	Old Testament Studies
<i>OtSt</i>	<i>Oudtestamentische Studiën</i>
<i>PEQ</i>	<i>Palestine Exploration Quarterly</i>
PG	Patrologia Graeca [= Patrologiae Cursus Completus: Series Graeca]. Edited by Jacques-Paul Migne. 162 vols. Paris, 1857–1886
PHSC	Perspectives on Hebrew Scriptures and Its Contexts
PTM	Princeton Theological Monographs
<i>RBL</i>	<i>Review of Biblical Literature</i>
<i>RevQ</i>	<i>Revue de Qumran</i>
ROT	Reading the Old Testament
SAA	State Archives of Assyria
SAAB	<i>State Archives of Assyria Bulletin</i>
SAAS	State Archives of Assyria Studies
SANT	Studien zum Alten und Neuen Testaments
SaNT	Studia Aarhusiana Neotestamentica
SBB	Stuttgarter biblische Beiträge
SBLDS	Society of Biblical Literature Dissertation Series
SBLMS	Society of Biblical Literature Monograph Series
SBLRBS	Society of Biblical Literature Resources for Biblical Study
SBLSCS	Society of Biblical Literature Septuagint and Cognate Studies
SBLSS	Society of Biblical Literature Semeia Studies
SBLSymS	Society of Biblical Literature Symposium Series
SBLWAW	Society of Biblical Literature Writings from the Ancient World
SBS	Stuttgarter Bibelstudien
SBT	Studies in Biblical Theology

SEÅ	<i>Svensk exegetisk årsbok</i>
SemeiaSt	Semeia Studies
SHBC	Smyth & Helwys Bible Commentary
SHR	Studies in the History of Religions
SJOT	<i>Scandinavian Journal of the Old Testament</i>
SJT	<i>Scottish Journal of Theology</i>
SOTSMS	Society for Old Testament Studies Monograph Series
StBibLit	Studies in Biblical Literature
STDJ	Studies on the Texts of the Desert of Judah
SupJSJ	Supplements to the Journal for the Study of Judaism
SymS	Symposium Series
TDOT	G. J. Botterweck and H. Ringgren (eds.), <i>Theological Dictionary of the Old Testament</i> . Translated by J. T. Willis; 14 vols. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1974–1993
TLZ	<i>Theologische Literaturzeitung</i>
TRE	<i>Theologische Realenzyklopädie</i> . Edited by Gerhard Krause and Gerhard Müller. Berlin: de Gruyter, 1977–
UBL	Ugaritisch-biblische Literatur
UF	<i>Ugarit-Forschungen</i>
VT	<i>Vetus Testamentum</i>
VTSup	Supplements to Vetus Testamentum
WBC	Word Biblical Commentary
WGRW	Writings from the Greco-Roman World
WMANT	Wissenschaftliche Monographien zum Alten und Neuen Testament
WO	<i>Die Welt des Orients</i>
WTJ	<i>Westminster Theological Journal</i>
WUNT	Wissenschaftliche Untersuchungen zum Neuen Testament
WW	<i>Word and World</i>
YJS	Yale Judaica Series
YOSR	Yale Oriental Series, Researches
ZAW	<i>Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft</i>
ZBKAT	Zürcher Bibelkommentar Altes Testament
ZDPV	<i>Zeitschrift des deutschen Palästina-Vereins</i>
ZWT	<i>Zeitschrift für wissenschaftliche Theologie</i>

ANCIENT AUTHORS

Clement of Alexandria

Paed. *Paedagogus*

Clement of Rome (Pseudo)

2 Clem. *Epistula ad Corinthios B*

Eusebius

Dem. ev. *Demonstratio evangelica*

Ignatius of Antioch

Ign. Phld. *Ignatius, To the Philadelphians*

Ign. Magn. *Ignatius, To the Magnesians*

Ign. Smyrn. *Ignatius, To the Smyrnaeans*

Jerome

Epist. *Epistulae*

Comm. Ezech. *Commentariorum in Ezechielem libri XVI*

Comm. Isa. *Commentariorum in Isaiam libri XVIII*

Vir. ill. *De viris illustribus*

Tract. Marc. *Tractatus in Evangelium Marci*

Justin Martyr

Dial. *Dialogus cum Tryphone*

1 Apol. *Apologia i*

Origen

Cels. *Contra Celsum*

Comm. Matt. *Commentarium in evangelium Matthaei*

Comm. Rom. *Commentarii in Romanos*

<i>Hom. Ezech.</i>	<i>Homiliae in Ezechielem</i>
<i>Hom. Isa.</i>	<i>Homiliae in Isaiam</i>
<i>Hom. Jer.</i>	<i>Homiliae in Jeremiam</i>
<i>Hom. Lev.</i>	<i>Homiliae in Leviticum</i>
<i>Hom. Num.</i>	<i>Homiliae in Numeros</i>
<i>Hom. I Reg.</i>	<i>Homiliae in I Reges</i>
<i>Princ.</i>	<i>De principiis</i>

Polycarp

<i>Pol. Phil.</i>	<i>Polycarp, To the Philippians</i>
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Tertullian

<i>An.</i>	<i>De anima</i>
<i>Apol.</i>	<i>Apologeticus</i>
<i>Marc.</i>	<i>Adversus Marcionem</i>

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INTRODUCTION

CAROLYN J. SHARP

THE present volume is designed to introduce readers to key interpretive issues and important resources in the study of the Latter Prophets of the Hebrew Scriptures. The contributors here are expert guides. Each is a seasoned navigator of tidal streams of scholarly traditions and methodological models, countless eddies of technical issues, and the surges and ebbs of broader interpretive questions. Each is a wise pedagogue for the uninitiated and the scholar alike. The purpose of this introductory essay is to invite readers into the landscape, roughly sketched, within which the individual studies in this volume are situated. The reading list at the end of this piece has been limited to works treating Israelite prophecy generally. For works on individual prophetic books and specific topics, the reader is encouraged to explore the bibliographies concluding the relevant essays.

MODERN SCHOLARSHIP ON THE LATTER PROPHETS

Scholarship on the Latter Prophets has traversed some expansive terrain since the flourishing of modern critical study in the classic works of such luminaries as Bernhard Duhm, Sigmund Mowinckel, Abraham J. Heschel, and Gerhard von Rad.¹ Contemporary scholarly study of the writing prophets is now responding to creative pressure from a substantial shift in methodological norms that has been taking shape over the past thirty-five years. The twentieth century saw an explosion of scholarly work on what A. R. Pete Diamond has called the “genetics” of biblical prophetic texts.² Discoveries of documents at sites such as Ugarit, Mari, Emar, and Nuzi aided comparativists in situating dimensions of ancient Israelite intermediation with more precision in the broader ancient Near Eastern context. The discovery of manuscripts of biblical prophetic texts at Qumran illuminated aspects of ancient scribal practice and gave scholars much to analyze concerning text-critical relationships among proto-Masoretic and proto-Septuagintal (Old Greek) texts and text families. Empiricist assumptions reigned

in scholarly debates regarding the historical prophets; a great deal of ink was spilled in arguments regarding the chronological dating of biblical texts and traditions. Inquiries into the theological, political, and ethical aims of the prophets focused on recovering the supposed *ipsissima verba* of the historical prophets through studies of discrete oracles assumed to reflect originally oral delivery. Central to this endeavor was an appreciation for the figure of the prophet as an inspired and rhetorically gifted individual. As Ronald L. Troxel puts it, “For much of the twentieth century, scholars viewed a prophetic book as a repository of utterances by the prophet named at the outset, even if those are en-crusted with additions that obscure their meanings. The goal of identifying the original words of the prophet was inspired partly by Romanticism’s fascination with ‘great men’ who propounded ground-breaking ideas” (2012: 4).

Israelite prophecy was understood by many scholars to have been a sociopolitical office, but the underlying emphasis in a substantial number of monographs and articles was on the personal experience and “message” of each prophet. The words of Heschel are instructive here, if hyperbolic in tone:

The prophet is no hireling who performs his duty in the employ of the Lord. The usual descriptions or definitions of prophecy fade to insignificance when applied, for example, to Jeremiah. “A religious experience,” “communion with God,” “a perception of His voice”—such terms hardly convey what happened to his soul: the overwhelming impact of the divine pathos upon his mind and heart, completely involving and gripping his personality in its depths. . . . (1962: 31)

In research focusing on the prophet as historical figure, literary strata in the prophetic books were analyzed and editorial additions were identified, the latter often discounted as unimaginative accretions unworthy of the prophet in whose book they appear. Form-critical work on the prophets attended to presumed original orality and discrete formal units of text; connections among units and larger rhetorical purposes to which smaller sections might be subsumed were not at the forefront of concern. Redaction critics, too, were engaged in identifying earlier material, working by the lights of a compositional model of presumed *Kerne* of authentic words, obscured by later accumulations of derivative material. While editorial *Tendenzen*, redactional bridges, and catchwords were duly noted, many redaction critics stopped short of interpreting prophetic books as complex literary wholes. Scholars interested in the theological claims of the prophets focused on canonical shaping of received traditions within the biblical texts and sensitive exposition of the prophets’ themes,³ but these generative ways of reading, too, tended to be grounded in historical-positivist assumptions that gave no accounting of the role of the reader and paid little attention to the slippages and ambiguities of language.

This long-standing interest in compositional genetics was met in the latter part of the twentieth century by a renewed attention to poetics. Literary and rhetorical criticisms have flourished, catalyzed by engagement with philosophers of language and demonstrating particular interpretive care taken with words, syntax, and tropes. This is clear in the influential work of Walter Brueggemann (2001 and many other works). As

Brueggemann notes, “Partly out of rhetorical criticism and partly out of the crucial work of Paul Ricoeur on imagination, it became generally evident that texts—in particular biblical texts—are acts of imagination that offer and purpose ‘alternative worlds’ that exist because of and in the act of utterance” (2001: x). Analysis has been directed with new force toward the effects of metaphorization and other rhetorical tropes, the construction of the prophetic persona, and the interplay of narratives, poetry, and diverse genres within biblical prophetic books. Thematic trajectories are traced with considerable nuance within and among prophetic texts. Readings focus increasingly on rhetorical and performance-related dimensions of textual representation, and work on intertextuality has gained deeper traction in scholarly discourse on the prophetic books.⁴

The past two decades have witnessed sophisticated theorizing of the intersections between historical and literary readings. This shift has been perceptible in the launch of journals such as *Biblical Interpretation* and *The Bible and Critical Theory*, as well as in the guild’s attention generally to the lively interrogatory dynamic generated among the assertions of historical positivism and postmodern modes of inquiry. Essays in a deconstructive mode, while still relatively few in number, have had a salutary impact on scholarly views of biblical language and prophetic signifying.⁵ In many quarters, one finds increasingly adept theorizing of texts, readers, interpretive methods, and reading communities. Where biblical scholars of earlier generations contented themselves with occasional references to Max Weber, Clifford Geertz, and René Girard, scholars in recent years have drawn in more sustained ways on a host of influential theorists such as Frantz Fanon, Mikhail Bakhtin, Henri Lefebvre, Emmanuel Lévinas, Jacques Derrida, Paul Ricoeur, Julia Kristeva, Gayatri Spivak, Homi Bhabha, and Judith Butler. Scholarly analysis of the prophets is increasingly utilizing postcolonial theory, memory studies, and cultural-anthropological analyses of the social body and sacred space. Hermeneutical approaches that were once decidedly marginal in biblical studies have made considerable gains in the guild. Worthy of note is the growing interest in trauma studies and war studies.⁶ In the insightful words of Stulman and Kim, to read the Latter Prophets is

to encounter a montage of harsh and discordant voices, sometimes fractured beyond recognition and almost always immersed in pain, at risk, and on the margins. Such dissonance should not be surprising given the excess of violence and centrality of war. It may not be an overstatement to describe written prophecy in the Hebrew Bible as ancient war literature. . . . If there is a center (*Mitte*) of this literary tradition, it may be war itself. (2010: 6)

Finally, study of the prophets is being shaped by a notable turn to reception history. Significant support for this line of inquiry is being offered by several major publishers. Among other initiatives, one may cite the Blackwell Bible Commentary series, the Smyth & Helwys Bible Commentary series, and the Eerdmans Illuminations series, all of which promote a central place for reception history in the work of interpretation.

Thus the dawning of the twenty-first century has witnessed the continuation of vibrant avenues of traditional research, but also important reconfigurations of scholarly

perspectives on the prophets. Scholars delve more deeply into the literariness of prophetic books, are becoming less tentative about appropriating insights from critical theory, and are giving sustained attention to newer methodologies that interrogate the epistemological and hermeneutical norms of particular readers and reading communities. The language of “paradigm shift” is regularly employed when changing methodologies have destabilized conceptual frameworks upon which earlier generations had relied. In the study of the biblical prophets, it cannot yet be said that the dominant conceptual framework has fully changed. Historicist research still commands the field in biblical studies at the major research universities. Ideological criticisms of all stripes—feminist, womanist, postcolonial, Marxist—are still marginalized by many dominant-culture scholars as demonstrating narrow interests and subjective reading practices of a small group of readers, rather than as a potent and intellectually rigorous set of challenges to the fundamental hermeneutical assumptions of “scientific” (German *wissenschaftliche*) modes of historical inquiry. Thus it may be premature to speak of a paradigm shift here. But scholars of the Latter Prophets have been laboring for years now to bring methodologically sophisticated and well-theorized approaches into the foreground of our guild’s practice. If some academic contexts continue to be dominated by traditional redaction criticism, erudite speculation about diachronic *realia*, and an insistent naïveté regarding the unresolvable complexity of relationships connecting historical context and textual representation, nevertheless a productive dissensus between older paradigms and newer approaches is well underway.⁷

INTRODUCTORY TEXTBOOKS AND OTHER GUIDES

Many fine introductions to the Latter Prophets are available for those with little or no background in the study of ancient prophecy. Among those well worth consulting are Petersen 2002, Stulman and Kim 2010, Lundbom 2010, Matthews 2012, and Troxel 2012, as well as the chapter “The Prophets” in Hans M. Barstad’s 2010 book, *A Brief Guide to the Hebrew Bible*.⁸ Reception history will be of interest even for the novice. Attentiveness to historical-contextual and reader-oriented hermeneutics can prove generative for those wishing to consider ways in which the Latter Prophets have been interpreted in art, music, literature, and other cultural arenas. Isaiah has long been a focus of reception-historical work due to its unparalleled influence on Christian theology, Ezekiel’s vivid imagery has catalyzed much interest in the history of reception, and the dramatic story of Jonah has garnered an impressive share of attention from artists and poets.⁹

The scope of contemporary scholarship on the Latter Prophets is vast. Even key monographs from the past five years cannot be summarized here in any detail. The following describes several collections that pursue major critical queries and intellectual

trajectories with which scholars of biblical prophecy have been engaged in the past twenty years.¹⁰ Many other valuable resources are identified in the chapters of this volume.

"The Place Is Too Small for Us": The Israelite Prophets in Recent Scholarship, edited by Robert P. Gordon, was published in 1995. All of the essays are reprints, with the exception of introductory and concluding pieces by the volume's editor. Twenty essays date from before 1985; only eight were published in 1990 or later. Thus the volume functions more as a survey of perspectives from the 1970s and early 1980s than as evidence of scholarship in the 1990s. The book opens with a review of scholarship on the prophets from 1875 through the late 1980s by Gordon, who also supplies learned introductions to the book's seven sections. Following are two essays on the ancient Near Eastern background; two essays on ethics and prophetic oracles of salvation; twelve essays on rhetoric, discourse theory, poetics, and drama in the prophetic books; eight essays on the roles of the prophet as framed in sociological or anthropological terms; six essays on the literary structure, redaction, and canonical shaping of prophetic texts; four essays on development of the prophetic tradition in post-exilic Judaism and early Christianity; and three pieces mapping future trajectories in scholarship on the prophets, two of which were seen from vantage points in 1984 and 1989. One notes the scholarly interest in metaphor theory, inner-biblical interpretation, and scribalization, research trajectories that have grown expansively as scholarship on the prophets has continued. No influence from poststructuralist and postmodern approaches to textuality is visible in this volume. Fierce interpretive debates have animated other text-focused disciplines since the 1960s, with the arrival of deconstruction in the United States; this ferment is nowhere addressed in the volume, although it may be glimpsed in the editor's anxiety that "doctrinaire dismissals of older approaches" could result in a "neologistic tyranny" that "assumed far more about what *cannot* be known about the workings of Israelite prophecy . . . than the evidence justifies" (Gordon 1995: 26). Feminist analysis, the most venerable of the ideological criticisms within biblical studies, is engaged by none of the thirty-seven contributors, only one of whom is female; gender as an analytical category is not discussed.¹¹ For those beginning work on the biblical prophets, *The Place Is Too Small for Us* can serve as an authoritative survey of older perspectives on biblical prophecy and, obliquely, as an example of the suspicion about newer interpretive methods that has characterized many in this generation of scholars.¹²

Recent Research on the Major Prophets, edited by Alan J. Hauser, was published in 2008. This collection offers highly detailed essays on the state of critical inquiry into Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel. For each prophet, the reader encounters reprints of influential earlier pieces—all laudably substantive, and none earlier than 1993—and newer work as well. Some of the previously unpublished pieces could constitute an excellent education in prophetic scholarship all on their own. Hyun Chul Paul Kim draws out important dimensions of inquiry into intertextuality and reader-response work on Isaiah. Roy F. Melugin addresses scholarly debates concerning the literary-structural, thematic, and theological unity of Isaiah in diachronic and synchronic modes of engagement. A. R. Pete Diamond frames sophisticated hermeneutical questions about the book of

Jeremiah, giving attention to postmodern challenges to historical empiricism and naïve understandings of textuality while judiciously affirming the strengths of older methods where he can.

In *The Production of Prophecy: Constructing Prophecy and Prophets in Yehud* (2009), edited by Diana V. Edelman and Ehud Ben Zvi, essays by eight contributors explore the ancient scribal practices and interpretive norms that shaped the prophetic books into authoritative scriptural writings for Jews in the exilic and post-exilic periods. This volume represents a burgeoning area of research that seeks to theorize not only pragmatic aspects of compositional and transmission processes, but also conceptual issues concerning ways in which Judean scribal culture functioned to support a view of prophetic texts as written revelation. Contributors investigate ways in which scribes were engaged in “creation of a shared past” (Edelman: 29) via shared memories and discourses that made sense of Judeans’ sociopolitical experiences in the neo-Babylonian period and beyond. The movement away from the notion of the charismatic historical personage is expressed trenchantly by Philip R. Davies, who urges that scholars “understand the prophecy of the Hebrew Bible as a literary phenomenon rather than . . . chase the mirage of a set of uniquely inspired individuals” (69). Erhard Gerstenberger, too, calls for distance from the old consensus: “Traditional concepts like prophets as authors, prophets as heads of schools, and prophets as messengers are largely untenable” (123). As is evident here, the divide between phenomenologically oriented historicist modes of inquiry and newer literary studies has become pronounced. *The Production of Prophecy* guides the reader into the positions of those who argue that many biblical traditions and texts are late scribal constructions.

Recent scholarly monographs on individual prophetic books are far too many in number to be engaged here. Perhaps most instructive for the novice may be volumes that treat several of the prophets using an integrative range of historical, literary, and cultural-studies methods. Three excellent works in this category can be recommended as an invitation to further exploration: Mary E. Mills’s 2007 book, *Alterity, Pain, and Suffering in Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel*; a 2010 collection, *The Aesthetics of Violence in the Prophets*, edited by Julia M. O’Brien and Chris Franke; and a 2015 volume, *Concerning the Nations: Essays on the Oracles against the Nations in Isaiah, Jeremiah and Ezekiel*, edited by Else K. Holt, Hyun Chul Paul Kim, and Andrew Mein.¹³

ESSAYS IN THIS VOLUME

The present collection is organized into three major divisions (Parts I, II, and III) and eight subsections. Each major division foregrounds a broad avenue of inquiry—contextualizing, interpreting, or engaging—simply as a heuristic means of grouping the chapters under its aegis. The underlying logic is that while the reading and analysis of ancient texts involves all three sorts of hermeneutical praxes, certain methods and projects have one or another mode at the center.

In Part I, “Contextualizing the Prophets,” under the rubric “Ancient Social and Cultic Contexts,” scholars trace out trajectories in the social and cultural contextualization of Israelite prophecy. In Chapter 1, Martti Nissinen reflects on the diverse roles, methods, and functions of prophetic intermediation in the ancient Near East, providing a judicious assessment of the nature of the historical sources for this comparative work. In Chapter 2, Lester L. Grabbe analyzes the complex relationship between Israelite prophecy and priesthood, describing priestly methods of divination and illustrating the overlap between prophetic and clerical functions in ancient Israel. In Chapter 3, Jill Middlemas considers issues associated with the generation of prophetic texts in and after diaspora, noting relevant historical *realia* and analyzing theological and political themes concerning exile and repatriation. Jon L. Berquist argues in Chapter 4 for the formative nature of the Persian period for Judean identity and cultural resilience, exploring the significance of Persian imperial practices for post-exilic Judean religion and politics. In Chapter 5, Stephen L. Cook considers early apocalyptic ideation and related themes in Israelite prophetic literature, framing the issues within trajectories representing the Aaronide, Levitical, and Zadokite priestly parties.

The next subsection, “Historical Methods and Textual Representation,” gets at the interplay of materiality and written representation, the latter construed as technical scribal praxis and as the conceptualization of community figured through Israelite historical memory. In Chapter 6, Brent A. Strawn explores the relation of material culture to prophetic texts at the intersection of archaeological, iconographic, and redaction-critical inquiries, illuminating valences of leonine imagery having to do with royal authority, the inescapability of divine punishment, and more. In Chapter 7, Eberhard Bons analyzes philological issues involved in transmission of the prophetic books in the Hebrew, Old Greek, Qumranic, and Vulgate traditions, demonstrating that theorizing editorial interventions, scribal errors, and translational choices is profoundly important for the interpretation of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Book of the Twelve. In Chapter 8, H. G. M. Williamson lays out questions of method critical for the reconstruction of the political and social-historical contexts that shaped the prophetic books, then traces poetic, rhetorical, and ideological dimensions of the prophets’ constructions of history.

In Part II, “Interpreting the Prophets,” the subsection entitled “Literary Criticism” guides the reader into a rich array of interpretive concerns that are primarily literary in nature. Engaged here are questions of genre, structure, and themes as key features of meaning-making in the prophetic books; the importance of metaphor for the prophets’ communicative strategies; and redaction criticism as a skilled means of interrupting, redirecting, and otherwise shaping received texts. Topics in literary criticism could fill a massive encyclopedia in their own right. The reader will glimpse in these essays erudite allusions to subjects well worth further investigation, among them characterization, point of view, dialogue, and irony. In Chapter 9, Ulrich Berges discusses the history of research on Isaiah; exploring the merits of various diachronic and synchronic models, he notes the book’s keen interest in scribalization and attends to historical factors that may be adduced to explain continuities and discontinuities in the Isaianic traditions. In Chapter 10, Mark Leuchter underlines the importance of Jeremiah for larger theories

of composition and text criticism of the Hebrew Bible; he investigates the book's textual disruptions, elucidates seven major themes, and discusses the historicity of the Jeremiah traditions and the book's contested relationship to Deuteronomistic texts. In Chapter 11, Andrew Mein underscores the structural and thematic coherence of Ezekiel, demonstrates that political and theological crises catalyzed by the Babylonian Exile underlie the prophet's harsh rhetorics of judgment, explores the figuring of Ezekiel as prophet and priest, and probes the power of the prophet's graphic visions and symbolic actions. In Chapter 12, Rainer Kessler guides the reader into structural and literary features of the Book of the Twelve, analyzing elements shared across this diverse corpus for their probative force in the endeavor to read the Twelve as a unity, then moving to scholarly debates about redaction-critical theories and the formation of the book. In Chapter 13, Anthea E. Portier-Young analyzes intersections of the prophetic and the apocalyptic that animate the book of Daniel; she elucidates historical distinctions among mantic, divinatory, and revealed wisdoms, and foregrounds the importance of the category of religious imagination for understanding the text. Julia M. O'Brien explores in Chapter 14 the significance of metaphorization for prophetic ideation, reviewing scholarly work on metaphor and its impact on feminist and trauma studies of the prophets, then exploring implications of the disruptive nature of metaphorical discourse for the language of theology. In Chapter 15, Barbara Green suggests that understanding genre involves not only the recognition of formal literary features but also collaboration between text and reader regarding shared assumptions, cultural cues, and intended functions; describing semantic features operative in the prophetic texts, she illustrates the utility of genre analysis for interpretive efforts sensitive to literary dimensions such as tone. James D. Nogalski demonstrates in Chapter 16 the importance of redaction criticism for understanding the heterogeneity of prophetic books in matters stylistic, thematic, and historical; working from material and text-critical considerations, he offers a broad-ranging assessment of scribal insertions and expansions, editorial frames, and local textual glosses that are key for interpretation of prophetic texts.

The "Topical Studies" subsection presents three areas of inquiry that are flourishing in contemporary scholarship on the prophets: figurations of the prophet as invented character, interpretation of the prophetic books through the lens of trauma studies, and the vexed problem of violence in prophetic rhetoric and theology. In Chapter 17, Else K. Holt reviews classic and late-modern commentators' positions on the persona of the prophet, framing her discussion by means of Jungian psychology, ethnological insights into masks and performance art, scholarly work on the genre of biography, and debates about the constructed nature of characterization in ancient texts. In Chapter 18, Louis Stulman engages the prophetic books as disaster literature designed to assist meaning-making in the aftermath of war and build communal resilience in the face of loss and liminality; he argues for the instrumentality of prophetic utterances and sign-acts in reconfiguring Judean subjectivity in the wake of trauma. In Chapter 19, L. Juliana Claassens guides readers into difficult questions surrounding the hermeneutical appropriation of violent prophetic texts, exploring the merits of six scholarly proposals; she

affirms the value of deconstructive modes of reading and urges resistance to violence via emphasis on liberative and restorative metaphors for divine agency.

Under the banner of “Reception History” are organized five essays that offer critical reflection on the interpretation of the prophets in particular socially and historically situated reading communities. In Chapter 20, Alex P. Jassen explores ways in which the sectarians at Qumran utilized prophetic texts to undergird the authority of their political and halakhic positions; emphasizing the fluidity of scriptural status and interpretation in the Second Temple period, he analyzes scribal citation practices, exegetical techniques, and glosses and expansions as important for understanding interpretive sensibilities and identity formation writ larger in the Dead Sea scrolls. In Chapter 21, J. Ross Wagner highlights New Testament writers’ use of a remembered prophetic past and claims for the continuity of the person and activities of Jesus of Nazareth with that past, demonstrating the importance of prophetic oracles for New Testament texts’ hermeneutics of fulfillment, ethical formation in Christian discipleship, and right perception of the purposes of God. In Chapter 22, Isaac B. Gottlieb invites readers into the plurality of early rabbinic uses of prophetic texts; he explores many topics of interest, including rabbis’ efforts to reconcile halakhic contradictions between the Torah and Ezekiel, their hermeneutical work with the tension between divine judgment and promise in Hosea 1–3, and their readings of Jonah to emphasize the centrality of repentance in rabbinic Judaism. In Chapter 23, Ronald E. Heine analyzes second-, third-, and fourth-century Christian expositions of prophetic texts and their connections to the Gospels, noting a focus on Isaiah in early Christian liturgics and homiletics; working with examples of Alexandrian and Antiochene exegesis of Isaiah 6:1–8, he demonstrates patristic soundings in christology and Trinitarian doctrine in the work of Origen, Eusebius, Jerome, and John Chrysostom. In Chapter 24, Mary Chilton Callaway describes visually rich and ideationally complex versions of Scripture encountered by medieval interpreters; she explores ways in which medieval dramatic performances, ecclesial statuary, debates about hermeneutics, and triumphalist theologizing refracted Christian social struggles and points of contestation in medieval times.

Part III, “Engaging the Prophets,” begins with the subsection “Situated Readings,” in which scholars engage critically with questions of the norms, convictions, and social locations of interpreters and their effects on the production of readings, hermeneutical models, and scholarly discourse. In Chapter 25, Marvin A. Sweeney addresses diverse roles of the prophets in contemporary Jewish theology; important issues include the function of prophetic discourse to mediate and explain the disruption of Torah ideals, the prophet understood as guarantor of the transmission of Jewish tradition, and Jewish theologians’ interest in divine pathos and the holiness of God. In Chapter 26, Christl M. Maier analyzes foundational strategies of feminist biblical interpretation of the prophets, exploring issues that include the roles of male and female prophets; feminist critical debates about misogynistic tropes and sexualized language in the prophetic books; and the effects of gender hierarchies on scholars’ construal of female bodies, figurations of the Divine, and women’s participation in religious rituals in ancient Israel and Judah. In Chapter 27, Valerie Bridgeman presents womanist biblical criticism as a

critical practice that foregrounds resistance to injustice, interrogation of interpretive systems with their implicit power structures and norms, and the use of imagination in producing liberatory readings; identifying Black women's experiences and concerns as centrally relevant to interpretation, she engages portrayals of women and children in the prophets, urging attentiveness to themes of economic class and poverty. In Chapter 28, Gale A. Yee analyzes historical and socioeconomic factors in the production of Israelite prophetic texts; emphasizing the material importance of economic power differentials in monarchical-era systems of agriculture and trade, she provides a materialist reading of the book of Amos to illustrate the sorts of political and economic conflicts that shaped prophetic witness. In Chapter 29, Steed Vernyl Davidson works with postcolonial categories to investigate discursive refractions of empire and resistance in the prophetic corpora; conceptualizing the prophet as one entangled in complicated performances of imperial power, he analyzes ways in which the prophets (re)inscribe imperial authority, with valences along a spectrum from complicity to insurgence in the theologizing historiographies and imagined futures they offer to their communities. In Chapter 30, Jennifer J. Williams reviews the aims and praxes of queer biblical interpretation, among them the interrogation of literary ambiguity and the deconstruction of hegemonic articulations of discursive power; noting connections with reader-response criticism, feminist constructivism, and use of the vulgar and the parodic in "camp" performance, she offers a critical queer reading of prophetic texts involving tropes of agricultural fecundity and wetness. In Chapter 31, Amy Kalmanofsky argues that postmodernity's affirmation of the contestability and contingency of textual meanings constitutes both challenge and opportunity for those who reconstruct biblical theology on the far side of hermeneutics of suspicion; exploring representations of the body in prophetic texts, she considers the effects of images of bodily violation, the narrativization of prophetic embodiment, and the prophet's body as site of resistance in Jeremiah 20.

The subsection "Interdisciplinary Interventions" investigates affinities and complications arising when engagement of the prophets is performed from vantage points within theological disciplines other than biblical studies. In Chapter 32, Shannon Craigo-Snell considers the productive ordering of Christian affections by means of prophetic articulations concerning the formation of heart, mind, and will in faithfulness; deploring the compromising of theological capacities in cultures based on commodification and injustice, she argues that such cultures are in need of Scripture-based prophetic interventions. In Chapter 33, Traci C. West shows the importance of responsible appropriation of the prophetic heritage for Christian social ethics; showcasing several instructive examples, she analyzes the use of prophetic texts by Walter Rauschenbusch on matters of economic justice and labor rights, then evaluates Emilie Townes's use of the form of communal lament in advocacy for better health care in African American communities. In Chapter 34, Michael S. Koppel grounds Christian pastoral care in the biblical notion of covenant relationship, limning connections between the prophets and contemporary pastoral praxis in such dimensions of communal life as the use of imagination to encourage mutual care, the redirecting of anger, the development of a disposition of listening for the Holy, and the fostering of capacity for empathic accompaniment. In

Chapter 35, Leonora Tubbs Tisdale and the editor consider recent homiletical practice and new possibilities for appropriations of the prophets in Christian preaching; engaging key themes, rhetorical strategies, and modes of performativity in the prophetic corpora, they seek to make visible the panoply of resources that await the preacher beyond the calls for social justice that are so often associated with the biblical prophets.

Finally, under the rubric of “Future Horizons in the Study of the Prophets,” essays by Walter Brueggemann and Lena-Sofia Tiemeyer sketch trajectories for future research. In Chapter 36, Brueggemann expects an increased diversity in methodological approaches, both historical and otherwise; he looks for enhanced visibility of newer ways of reading, especially rhetorical, post-critical, post-colonial, and reception-history approaches that honor the subversive character of the biblical witness. In Chapter 37, Tiemeyer hopes for more sustained dialogue with those of opposing hermeneutical views, urges that feminist and gender-studies scholars broaden the scope of biblical issues with which they engage, and is eager for more substantive collaboration between Anglophone and German-speaking scholars; she anticipates the burgeoning of researches into scribalization, ancient social contexts, psychologizing approaches associated with trauma studies, and reception history.

As is usual for volumes of this scope, lacuna remain. The overwhelming predominance of North American and European scholars here must be named and interrogated. It reflects power differentials at work in the demographics of the guild of biblical studies, as well as ongoing problems of access to venues of professional participation for scholars from the Southern Hemisphere and from developing countries. But it also may be taken to illustrate contestations enlivening our field regarding the dominance of *wissenschaftliche* approaches that decline to investigate the subject position of the interpreter. Some scholars who work in colonial and postcolonial contexts, or who identify with a marginalized positionality vis-à-vis dominant cultures in North America or Western Europe, may not allow themselves the dubious luxury of writing from an ostensibly “objective” location. Their representation, then, in traditional monograph series, certain peer-reviewed journals, and other publishing venues may be less robust than is desirable, which may in turn have had an impact on their visibility for a *Handbook* of this type. The focus in the present volume on Anglophone and German-language contributions speaks to the centrality of those culture groups in professional biblical studies, but it also reveals the peripheries of the editor’s expertise, including her limited conversance with Spanish-language biblical scholarship.¹⁴

Several authors withdrew too close to the production deadline for the editor to secure contributions from others. An invited essay on “Prophecy in the Pre-exilic Context” was to describe sociopolitical and literary antecedents for the emergence of the writing prophets. On that topic, the reader might begin with Grabbe’s and Yee’s essays here, which offer important insights on prophets in the Deuteronomistic History, and then consult three essays in Boda and Beal (2013): “Prophecy as Prediction in Biblical Historiography,” by John Van Seters (93–103); “Jeroboam and the Prophets in 1 Kings 11–14: Prophetic Word for Two Kingdoms,” by Lissa M. Wray Beal (105–124); and “Presumptuous Prophets Participating in a Deuteronomic Debate” by K. L. Noll

(125–142). An invited piece on “Contemporary Christian Readings of the Prophets” would have rounded out the section on situated readings. In its absence, the homiletics essay by Nora Tubbs Tisdale and the editor has been accorded the latitude to explore a wide variety of issues in Christian homiletical approaches to the prophets.

NOTES

1. Influential classic works include Bernhard Duhm, *Das Buch Jesaia* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1892), *Das Buch Jeremia* (KHC 11; Tübingen: J. C. B. Mohr [Paul Siebeck], 1901), *Anmerkungen zu den zwölf Propheten* (Giessen: A. Töpelmann, 1911), and *Israels Propheten* (Tübingen: J. C. B. Mohr [Paul Siebeck], 1916); Sigmund Mowinckel, *Zur Komposition des Buches Jeremia* (Kristiana: J. Dybwad, 1914) and *Prophecy and Tradition: The Prophetic Books in Light of the Study of the Growth and History of Tradition* (Oslo: J. Dybwad, 1946; repr. in *The Spirit and the Word: Prophecy and Tradition in Ancient Israel*, ed. K. C. Hanson; Fortress Classics in Biblical Studies; Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg Fortress, 2002); Gerhard von Rad, *Die Botschaft der Propheten* (Munich and Hamburg: Siebenstern Taschenbuch, 1967), condensed from his *Theologie des Alten Testaments*, Vol. II, *Die Theologie der prophetischen Überlieferungen Israels* (Munich: Chr. Kaiser, 1960).
2. See A. R. Pete Diamond's introduction in *Troubling Jeremiah* (ed. A. R. Pete Diamond, Kathleen M. O'Connor, and Louis Stulman; JSOTSup 260; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1999), 15–32.
3. Preeminent among biblical theologians who have inquired into canonical shaping is Brevard S. Childs; see especially his *Isaiah* (OTL; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2001). Walter Brueggemann is a master expositor of prophetic themes in theological terms with the entire biblical canon in mind. See not only his *The Prophetic Imagination* (2001) but also the way in which prophetic texts feature in his writing across many topics in collections such as *The Word That Redescribes the World: The Bible and Discipleship* (ed. Patrick D. Miller; Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2006) and *The Word Militant: Preaching a Decentering Word* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2007).
4. See, e.g., Conrad 2003, a semiotic study with chapters subtitled “Reading Jeremiah in the Light of Amos” (92–160), “Reading Ezekiel in the Light of Jonah” (161–181), “Reading Isaiah in the Light of the Other Prophets of Vision” (182–242), and “Reading the Twelve in the Light of the Major Prophets” (243–267).
5. Essays important in the scholarly turn to semantic ambiguity and polysemy in prophetic texts include Timothy K. Beal, “The System and the Speaking Subject in the Hebrew Bible: Reading for Divine Abjection,” *BibInt* 2 (1994): 171–189, which focuses on Micah 1; Francis Landy, “In the Wilderness of Speech: Problems of Metaphor in Hosea,” *BibInt* 3 (1995): 35–59; James R. Linville, “What Does ‘It’ Mean? Interpretation at the Point of No Return in Amos 1–2,” *BibInt* 8 (2000): 400–424.
6. Helpful for situating historical and literary analyses of the prophetic literature within war studies are Brad Kelle, *Ancient Israel at War 853–586* (Essential Histories 67; Oxford: Osprey, 2007); Brad E. Kelle and Frank Ritchel Ames, eds., *Writing and Reading War: Rhetoric, Gender, and Ethics in Biblical and Modern Contexts* (SBLSymS 42; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2008); Brad E. Kelle, Frank Ritchel Ames, and Jacob

- L. Wright, eds.; *Warfare, Ritual, and Symbol in Biblical and Modern Contexts* (AIL18; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2014).
7. Here I borrow the coinage of Ewa Plonowska Ziarek in her *An Ethics of Dissensus: Postmodernity, Feminism, and the Politics of Radical Democracy* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2001). Ziarek defines “dissensus” as “the irreducible dimension of antagonism and power in discourse, embodiment, and democratic politics” (1). Her notion of an “unavoidable yet productive dissonance” among engagements characterized by “antagonism, freedom, [and] obligation” (2) is useful for considering the mutual interrogations among different methods within biblical studies.
 8. Hans M. Barstad, *A Brief Guide to the Hebrew Bible* (translated from the Norwegian by Rannfrid Thelle; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2010), 98–132.
 9. Instructive in the reception history of the prophets are John F. A. Sawyer, *The Fifth Gospel: Isaiah in the History of Christianity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996); Brevard S. Childs, *The Struggle to Understand Isaiah as Christian Scripture* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2004); Andrew Mein and Paul M. Joyce, eds., *After Ezekiel: Essays on the Reception of a Difficult Prophet* (LHBOTS 535; New York and London: Bloomsbury T & T Clark, 2011); Yvonne Sherwood, *A Biblical Text and Its Afterlives: The Survival of Jonah in Western Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000); Jacob Neusner, *Rabbinic Theology and Israelite Prophecy: Primacy of the Torah, Narrative of the World to Come, Doctrine of Repentance and Atonement, and the Systematization of Theology in the Rabbis’ Reading of the Prophets* (Studies in Judaism; Lanham, MD: University Press of America, 2008).
 10. A detailed resource useful for scholars in other fields is Brad E. Kelle, “The Phenomenon of Israelite Prophecy in Contemporary Scholarship,” *CBR* 12 (2014): 275–320.
 11. Those interested in feminist analysis may consult Christl M. Maier’s Chapter 26 in the present volume, “Feminist Interpretation of the Prophets,” and the bibliography cited there. Two additional resources are Athalya Brenner, ed., *Prophets and Daniel* (FCB, Second Series; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 2001), and Jonathan Stökl and Corinne L. Carvalho, eds., *Prophets Male and Female: Gender and Prophecy in the Hebrew Bible, the Eastern Mediterranean, and the Ancient Near East* (AIL 15; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2013).
 12. Another valuable collection of reprinted pieces on prophecy is Ronald E. Clements’s *Old Testament Prophecy: From Oracles to Canon* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1996). Clements has been influential in twentieth-century biblical scholarship on the prophets; erudite insights are evident on every page of this collection. See also Yehoshua Gitay, ed., *Prophecy and Prophets: The Diversity of Contemporary Issues in Scholarship* (SemeiaSt; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 1997). For an authoritative older treatment of historical issues in the study of prophecy, see Joseph Blenkinsopp, *A History of Prophecy in Israel* (revised and expanded; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1996).
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PART I

.....

CONTEXTUALIZING
THE PROPHETS

.....

*A. Ancient Social
and Cultic Contexts*

CHAPTER 1

PROPHETIC INTERMEDIATION IN THE ANCIENT NEAR EAST

MARTTI NISSINEN

“PROPHECY” and “prophet” are words that have many meanings. In modern languages, the word “prophecy” is sometimes used to refer to prediction of the future, and the word “prophet” to describe a person who claims, or is believed, to be able to tell what will happen in the future. In ancient sources and societies, however, the predictive activity of the people commonly called “prophets” is but another aspect of *mediation of divine knowledge*. Accordingly, the principal function of what is called “prophecy” in biblical and ancient Near Eastern scholarship is today seen as intermediation rather than prediction.

PROPHECY AS INTERMEDIATION

As a scholarly concept, “prophecy” is created and maintained by the academic community that provides the matrix within which it works. In this sense, “prophecy” is a scholarly construct that must be defined and agreed upon (Nissinen 2013). There is a widespread consensus among biblical and ancient Near Eastern scholars to use the word “prophecy” for the intermediation of divine knowledge by non-technical means, constituting a process of communication consisting of four essential components: first, the allegedly divine *sender* of the message; second, the *message* proper, together with its verbal or symbolic performance; third, the *prophet*, that is, the transmitter of the message; and fourth, the *recipient(s)* of the message (Weippert 2014: 231–232; orig. 1988/1997). Moreover, the prophetic performance has to be acknowledged by a *community* that ultimately decides whether or not it was to be appreciated as transmitting a divine word.

The prophetic process of communication is not a one-way street from the deity through the prophet and eventual go-betweens to the recipients, but a form of social communication: the community keeps prophecy alive and ultimately makes it functional.

The preceding definition of prophecy, albeit often with some modifications, is widely accepted (e.g., de Jong 2007: 31; Stökl 2012: 7–11); however, the consensus has not reached Classical scholars, who usually prefer to use the words “oracle” and “seers” for what biblical and ancient Near Eastern scholars call “prophecy” and “prophets” (cf. e.g., Flower 2008; Kajava [ed.] 2013). The divergent terminology is largely due to the centuries of separate lives of the academic disciplines, but to some extent also to differences in the source materials and the phenomena documented in them.

PROPHECY AS DIVINATION

As another form of attaining divine knowledge, prophecy should not be regarded as distinct from divination, let alone as its antonym, but, rather, as one of its many modes. The basic motivation of divination grows out of uncertainty about the future and the risk human ignorance might cause when making important decisions, whether private or political. The very idea of divination presupposes the idea of superhuman agency managing things that happen in the world of humans; hence divination belongs to standard patterns of coping with superhuman agents (cf. Pyysiäinen 2009). Such patterns are historically and socially contingent and exist in different cultures independently from each other. In the ancient Eastern Mediterranean, divine knowledge was acquired by different means, especially by astrology, hepatoscopy, exorcism, and augury, typically practiced by highly educated people. Divinatory methods were based on the conviction that gods actually communicate with the people. Gods were thought to be free to communicate with anyone by any given means, but most divinatory methods required the management of specific techniques and skills, and not every person was acknowledged as a qualified diviner.

Since all divination is understood as communication between heaven and earth, every diviner, not just the prophet, is basically an intermediary between the human and divine worlds (Pongratz-Leisten 1999). What makes prophecy distinguishable from other forms of divination in the ancient world is the lack of the use of inductive or technical methodology, such as observing the livers of sacrificial animals, the stars, or the flight of birds. In contrast, prophecy is understood as a non-technical, intuitive, or inspired kind of divination, with the prophet acting as mouthpiece of the deity. Prophetic divination, unlike scholarly divination, was not related to scribal learning, systematic organization and categorization of phenomena, or any kind of empirical methodologies. No specific set of skills required of prophetic diviners can be discerned from the sources, but the ability to reach an altered state of consciousness and to combine it with a convincing public behavior and performance was probably a general expectation.

WHO ARE THE “PROPHETS” IN ANCIENT TEXTS?

Persons acting as intuitive or inspired intermediaries are known by several designations in ancient Eastern Mediterranean texts, whether biblical and Near Eastern (Stökl 2012) or Greek (Lampinen 2013). The word family “prophet” in modern languages derives from the Greek *prophētēs* (masc.)/*prophētis* (fem.), with which the Septuagint virtually always translates the Hebrew *nābî*’ (masc.)/*nēbî’ā* (fem.), the standard biblical terms for a prophetic intermediary, male or female. Other common Hebrew designations for a prophetic intermediary are *hōzē* and *rōē* (“seer”), and nouns from the root *hṣh* are used for prophets in other Semitic languages as well.

In Greek sources, the use of the word *prophētēs* is less coherent. It may designate an inspired intermediary, but, as at Didyma, it could also be the title of the temple official who publicized the oracles of the female prophet called *prophētis*. Depending on the source, the prophetic intermediaries may carry other Greek titles, such as *mantis* (masc./fem.), which means “diviner” in general, and *promantis*, which is more often than not used for female prophets at Delphi and Didyma.

While the Greek terminology makes no strict distinction between inspired and technical divination, the cuneiform texts in the Akkadian language have specific vocabulary for prophetic intermediaries that never overlaps with designations of technical diviners. The most common word denoting a “prophet” is *muḥḥûm* (masc.)/*muḥḥûtum* (fem.) in the Old Babylonian dialect, corresponding to the Neo-Assyrian *maḥḥû* (masc.)/*maḥḥûtu* (fem.). This word has a wide temporal and geographical distribution, and it is derived from the verb *maḥû* (“to go into a frenzy”), which connects prophecy with an altered state of consciousness. Another designation known from Old Babylonian texts is *āpilum* (masc.)/*āpiltum* (fem.) (“answerer” or “spokesperson”), suggesting an intermediate role in the divine-human communication. The same is true for the word *raggimu* (masc.)/*raggintu* (fem.) (“proclaimer”), which is the standard word for prophecy in Neo-Assyrian oracles and letters. Other titles carried by prophets in cuneiform sources include *šēlūtu* (## 74, 114)¹ and *assinnu* (## 7, 22, 23, 124, 126), which are not prophetic titles but refer to other roles of the persons in question; the otherwise unknown word *qammatum* (## 7, 9, 13), used for one female individual at Mari; and *nabûm* (#26), which may be understood as a title of a diviner etymologically related to the Hebrew *nābî*’.

Each principal designation for a prophetic intermediary highlights one aspect of the prophetic performance. While *raggimu* refers to the proclamation of the divine message and *āpilum* to its interpretation (especially if understood as “spokesperson” or “interpreter” rather than “answerer”; cf. Merlo 2004; Stökl 2012: 43), *muḥḥûm*/*maḥḥû* indicates the state of mind in which the message was received. Otherwise, it is difficult to recognize clear and systematic differences among the socio-religious profiles of people for whom these designations are used. What unites them is that none of them is known to have been involved in technical divination. At Mari, the *muḥḥûm* seems to have been

more closely bound with the temples, while the *āpilum* had a more independent agency; in addition, ecstatic behavior is directly associated only with the *muḥḥûm/mahḥû*. This has given reason to the assumption that while *āpilum* and *raggimu* stand for “professional” prophets, the *muḥḥûm/mahḥû* were primarily cultic ecstatics who sometimes prophesied (Stökl 2012). However, whenever the sources reveal anything more specific about the function of *muḥḥûm/mahḥû*, it is virtually always related to prophetic intermediation; hence the *muḥḥûm/mahḥû* fully corresponds to the current definition of a “prophet.”

SOURCES OF ANCIENT NEAR EASTERN PROPHECY

The Nature of the Sources

Everything we know about prophets and prophecy in the ancient Eastern Mediterranean is dependent on written documents. The Hebrew Bible notwithstanding, the corpus of texts documenting prophetic activities and/or the presence of prophets in the ancient Near East consists of approximately 175 texts ranging from the twenty-first to the second century B.C.E. and covering considerable parts of the Near East (Nissinen 2003). Places where prophets and/or prophecy are documented at some point include several cities in Assyria (Arbela, Nineveh, Assur, Calah) and Babylonia (Babylon, Akkad, Uruk, Ur, Dilbat, Larsa, Kiš, Sippar, Nerebtum), Syrian cities (Mari, Terqa, Der, Aleppo, Tuttul, Andarig, Qaṭṭunan, Hamat, Til Barsib, Chagar Bazar, Harran), and Levantine sites (Byblos, Amman, Deir ‘Alla, Lachish). The principal Greek oracle sites were Delphi, Didyma, Dodona, and Claros, flourishing in different periods of time.

Considering the large area and the huge time span, the documents of ancient Near Eastern prophecy are not very numerous, and the distribution—whether chronological or geographical—is anything but even. Roughly seven-eighths of the available written evidence comes from two sites: the eighteenth-century B.C.E. archives of the city-state of Mari, and the seventh-century B.C.E. archives of the Neo-Assyrian Empire at Nineveh. There are conspicuous white spots on the map, such as the city-state of Ugarit, where divination was certainly practiced, but no traces of prophetic activity have been preserved. The texts usually called “Egyptian prophecies” are, in fact, not based on prophetic activity in the previously defined sense; however, some texts accompanying the Egyptian royal cult and recording divine words delivered to the king may refer to the function of priests as intermediaries (Hilber 2013). In the Hittite sources, various kinds of technical divination, such as extispicy and augury, are well known, but it is difficult to identify in them inspired divination other than dreams (see Mouton 2007); at the best, the “man of god” (*šuniyant*) mentioned in the Second Plague Prayer of Muršili II, alongside dreams and oracles, may be taken as representing a Hittite prophet (Weippert 2014: 234–235).

The extant documentation of the ancient Near Eastern prophecy is not only uneven and haphazard—it also consists of very different kinds of sources: written oracles, letters reporting prophetic appearances and dreams, legal and administrative documents, word lists, paraphrases of prophecy in literary contexts, and literary fiction. The types of textual transmission ultimately determine what kind of information is obtainable from each source, and this must be kept in mind when one set of sources is compared with another (Schaper 2013). The available textual sources provide us with everything from firsthand transcript to literary fiction; hence it is absolutely necessary to recognize the function of each text type, since texts were written and preserved for different purposes. Moreover, it is important to distinguish between (quasi-)primary and secondary sources. All written records of oral prophetic messages are, in a way, secondary because of their very writtenness: the words that once came out of the prophets' mouths were necessarily exposed to material restrictions, selection, and memory of the person who wrote them down. However, some texts at our disposal are early transcripts of spoken prophecies, whether in form of an oracle report or as a quotation in a letter, close enough to the oral performance to be considered primary sources. Perhaps the most "neutral" records are the legal and administrative texts that provide us with hard evidence of the presence of prophets in a certain city or temple but rarely tell us much about the prophetic performances. These, again, are described or referred to in royal correspondence, always from the point of view of the writer and for the writer's purposes. Oracle reports in royal archives can be read as reliable accounts of spoken prophetic words; however, even they do not necessarily give a balanced and unbiased picture of prophecy of their time, because certain prophecies were filed away, while others were not. Therefore, even the primary sources do not represent a full portrait of the prophetic phenomenon at a given time and place, but yield only a partial view of it. What we do not see is due to the accident of discovery, and also to deliberate selection. The role of intentional construction becomes even more significant in secondary sources such as quotations of prophetic words in royal inscriptions or descriptions of prophetic performances by biblical and Greek writers.

While the volume of the documentation is tiny as such, its temporal and geographical distribution makes prophecy appear as a constant feature in the Near Eastern socio-religious milieu. The small number of written sources vis-à-vis their large if uneven distribution indicates that prophecies were typically oral performances that never ended up in a written form. Prophecies were sometimes quoted or summarized in written documents, either because the recipient was out of reach, or because the message was found to be of special importance. Written prophecies seem usually not to have been meant for long-time preservation. It is probably not coincidental that the two locations from which the majority of the sources come, Mari and Assyria, also possess the biggest archives found in the Near East.

The Sources from Mari

The Mari archives have brought to light more than fifty letters and some twenty other texts quoting prophetic oracles or mentioning prophets; some of this material is still

unpublished (## 1–65; Durand 1988; Charpin 2012). Most of the letters date from the time of the last king of Mari, Zimri-Lim (ca. 1775–1761 B.C.E.); a few are from the time of his predecessor, Yasmaḥ-Addu (ca. 1792–1775 B.C.E.). The letters form part of Zimri-Lim's correspondence with his high officials, diviners, and royal women. While the diviners wrote their reports themselves, prophecies and dreams typically were reported to the king in letters written by others who paraphrase the prophecies in the letters, among other issues. The overwhelming majority of the letters is addressed to Zimri-Lim; other recipients include King Yasmaḥ-Addu (## 3, 14), Addu-duri, the mother of Zimri-Lim (# 45), and some persons belonging to the entourage of the king, Dariš-libur (# 33) and Šu-nuḥra-Ḫalu (Charpin 2014: 32–33). All letters with prophetic quotations are addressed to members or officials of the court, which presents the prophetic activity as serving primarily royal interests. The significance of divination in general and prophecy in particular to the king of Mari cannot be doubted, but it must be noted that the royal emphasis is due to the preservation of the documents in the royal archives, which leaves the non-royal functions of prophecy in shadow.

Only one letter has a prophet as its sender: Atamrum, prophet of Šamaš, commissions a scribe to write a letter to the king (# 48), and this letter, containing four different prophecies, has been preserved on another tablet (# 4). Otherwise, the letters are sent by the king's officials, as well as governors and royal representatives in other cities such as Terqa, Babylon, Tuttul, and Aleppo. A considerable portion of the letters is written by royal women who played an important role as the king's closest advisors: Queen Šibtu (## 17–18, 21–24, 41), the queen mother Addu-duri (## 5, 35, 42, 43), the king's sister Inib-šina (## 7, 14), and his daughter Šimatum (# 44). All these people belong to the usual correspondents of the king—only one group of regular letter-writers is missing, conspicuously but understandably: the diviners in their numerous letters never report prophetic performances.

The letters report on prophecies delivered not only at Mari and in other cities of the kingdom (Terqa, Der, Nahur, Saggaratum, Qaṭṭunan), but even outside its borders in Aleppo, Andarig, or Babylon, corresponding to the wide distribution of the prophetic phenomenon in the Near East. The topics dealt with in the majority of the letters fall roughly in two categories: the king's politics and the maintenance of temples. Many prophecies reported in the letters proclaim the victory of Zimri-Lim over the rebellious Yaminite tribes (## 10, 38) and kings appearing as his rivals and adversaries, such as Hammurapi of Babylon (## 19, 20, 22), Hammurapi of Kurdâ (# 4), Išme-Dagan of Ekallatum (## 17, 48), and Ibalpiel II of Ešnunna (## 7, 9, 12, 13). The royal women frequently quote prophecies to convince Zimri-Lim of the need to protect himself (## 7, 14, 23). In addition to prophecies related to warfare, two letters written by Nur-Šin report the divine demand for righteousness and justice: "When a wronged man or woman cries out to you, be there and judge their case" (# 1; cf. # 2). In this particular case, the justice concerns the ownership of a property located near the city of Aleppo. The maintenance of temples and their worship is another frequently discussed topic in the letters, and cultic instructions are often accompanied by prophetic words. Zimri-Lim is prompted to take care of the cults of the dead, such as the *kispum* and *pagrā'um* offerings (## 30–31,

38), and to deliver different kinds of cultic equipment to the gods (## 3, 4, 16). Many times he is reminded of his negligence in performing offerings required from him (## 1, 24, 25, 27, 28, 29), or in attending to the needs of cultic personnel (# 8).

In addition to the letters, prophets are mentioned in a number of ritual texts and administrative documents from Mari. Male and female prophets appear together with musicians and other cultic functionaries in the royal ceremony of the ritual of Ištar, which was the most important annual festival at Mari (## 51, 52). Administrative texts mention prophets awarded for their services, often with ordinary garments (## 54–59), but sometimes with more valuable gifts such as silver (## 61–63), lances of bronze (# 60), or a donkey (# 53). The single literary reference to prophecy in the sources from Mari is the *āpilum* who delivers the sign, or appears himself as the sign, of the king's victory in the *Epic of Zimri-Lim* (# 64), a unique literary work glorifying the military victories of Zimri-Lim and celebrating the divine support of his kingship (Guichard 2014).

Texts from Assyria

The second major corpus of evidence of prophecy comes from sixth-century B.C.E. Assyria (## 68–118; Parpola 1997; see also Nissinen 1998). The Neo-Assyrian corpus comprises eleven clay tablets including twenty-nine individual prophetic oracles addressed to Esarhaddon (681–669 B.C.E.) and Assurbanipal (668–627 B.C.E.), kings of Assyria. Of the eleven tablets, three or four (## 68–88 plus, probably, what remains of # 89) contain up to ten individual oracles collected on one tablet, while the rest of the oracles are written each on their own individual tablet. The individual tablets represent the first edition of a written oracle, that is, a report based on a draft written immediately upon the prophetic performance, of which a carefully designed copy was filed away in the archive along with other divinatory reports. The prophecies do not appear as a separate genre, and the scribes could imitate the style of the prophecies in other texts, such as the *Dialogue between Assurbanipal and Nabû* (SAA 3 13; Atkinson 2013) written by the scribe who also wrote the prophecy in # 94.

The collections of prophecies consist of individual oracle reports selected and composed to form a thematic collection, representing the second stage of editing. All collections date from the time of Esarhaddon. The oracles, originally dating to 681–679 B.C.E., deal with his rise to power (## 68–77), his enthronement (## 84–88), and the beginning of his reign (## 78–83). The collections were compiled a few years later, in 673 B.C.E., to endorse Assurbanipal's investiture as the crown prince of Assyria. The collections provide rare evidence of a *relecture* of the prophetic word in a new historical situation, which indicates that the prophecies considered worth preserving were available to the circle of scribes who had access to the royal archives. In the Assyrian case, the reuse of prophecies never developed into prophetic literature comparable to the biblical prophetic books; nevertheless, the scribes who authored, for instance, the Nineveh A inscription of Esarhaddon (RINAP 4 1) used prophecies (*šipir mahḫê*) among other divinatory reports as their source material.

The Assyrian prophecies available to us are the result of a process of transmission and preservation motivated by the kings' purposes to provide evidence of the divine knowledge concerning their rule. They emerge from specific situations in which the kings needed such knowledge; hence they represent a historically contingent and socially determined construct of prophecy corresponding to the state religion and ideology (Parpola 1997: xviii–xliv). Their main, if not only, concern is the king, who appears in quasi-messianic terms as the divinely chosen ruler who has a specific relationship with the goddess Ištar, the most common divine speaker in Assyrian prophecies. Among central topics related to the king are the legitimacy of his succession, the consolidation of his rule, his world dominion and personal safety, and reconciliation between heaven and earth. As in the case of Mari, the solid royal focus of the prophecies available to us blocks the view of non-royal functions of prophecy in the Assyrian Empire.

In addition to the oracles proper, there are well over twenty Neo-Assyrian texts—royal inscriptions, letters, administrative documents, cultic texts, and a treaty—alluding in one way or another to prophets (*raggimu/raggintu* or *maḥḥû/maḥḥûtu*) or their pronouncements. The royal perspective remains dominant even in these sources; in particular, the prophecies paraphrased in the inscriptions of Esarhaddon and Assurbanipal (## 97–101) represent the very same orthodox ideology as the oracles. Some sources, however, add some information on the use of prophecy and prophetic performances in Assyria. The Vassal Treaty of Esarhaddon acknowledges the possibility that even the prophets may be found among people who speak against the king and the crown prince (102), and such a case is actually documented in the letters of Nabû-reḥtu-ušur, who reports on an alleged word of Nusku spoken by a slave girl, according to which the rule of Esarhaddon would come to an end (## 115–117).

Scholars and officials writing to the king sometimes justify their opinion with a prophetic quotation in their letters (## 106, 107), but they may also express negative feelings toward prophets because of the king's special favor toward them (# 105) or because of a failed oracle (# 108). Prophetic performances in a ritual or temple context are reported in a few letters (## 109, 111, 113), and prophets once appear as being present in a sickness ritual (# 118). A ritual function of the prophets is suggested also by a decree of expenditures for ceremonies in the Ešarra temple in Assur in 809 B.C.E., mentioning female prophets in the section concerning the divine council (# 110).

Other Cuneiform Texts

Further evidence of the existence of prophets and prophecy in Mesopotamia is scattered among a haphazard selection of individual texts ranging from the twenty-first to the second century B.C.E. and covering considerable parts of the ancient Near East (## 66–67; 119–135). The texts represent different genres, such as lexical lists, administrative documents, omen texts, letters, and oracles. Taken together, in spite of its piecemeal character, this documentation gives surprisingly rich information about the socio-religious function of prophets in the ancient Near East.

Old Babylonian prophetic documents include two oracles to Ibalpiel II, the ruler of the Ešnunna and a contemporary of Zimri-Lim of Mari (## 66–67). The oracles, possibly going back to Ibalpiel's enthronement, are ideologically reminiscent of the Assyrian oracles that date more than a millennium later. Two further Old Babylonian texts have recently been identified as prophecy: a dialogue of the goddess Nanaya and a person identifiable as a prophet regarding a new ruler of Uruk; and an oracle of victory for King Šamšu-iluna spoken by the goddesses Zubaba and Inanna from Kiš (Dalley 2010). Decrees of delivery of food rations and other goods from the Old Babylonian period mentioning prophets have been preserved from the cities of Dilbat (TCL 1 57), Larsa (CM 33 1; TCL 10 34; 39), Ur (TS 1), Sippar (IM 50.852), Nerebtum in Ešnunna (OECT 13 263), Chagar Bazar (Chagar Bazar 176), Tuttul (KTT 53; 306), and even from the Elamite capital Susa (MDP 18 171).

Babylonian prophetic oracles have not been preserved from later periods, but some administrative texts testify to the presence of prophets in Neo- and Late Babylonian periods (## 130–133; LKU 51). An astronomical diary from the year 133 B.C.E. reports the ecstatic performance of a messenger of Nanaya in Babylon and Borsippa, inviting an aggressive response from the local authorities (## 134–135). Administrative texts from Assyria include a Middle-Assyrian food rations list in which male and female prophets appear together with *assinnus* among the personnel of the temple of Ištar at Kar-Tukulti-Ninurta (# 123), and an outlay of a substantial amount of copper to a prophet at Tušḫan in the year 611 B.C.E., that is, after the collapse of Nineveh (ZTT 25; Parpola 2008).

Lexical lists and omen texts (## 120, 124–129; Erimḫuš III; LBTA 2 1; OIP 114 122; SpTU 3 116) do not document the prophets' whereabouts, let alone their oracles; interestingly, however, they regularly associate prophets not only with other non-technical diviners such as dreamers but also with frenzied people (*zabbu/zabbatu*) and the ambiguously gendered cult functionaries, *assinnu* and *kurgarrû*.

Sources from the West

The prophetic phenomenon in the West Semitic milieu is documented only by a handful of texts, which are, however, enough to testify to the presence of prophets in the Iron Age Levant. Zakkur, king of Hamath, celebrates in his inscription from ca. 800 B.C.E. (# 137) his victory over seventeen neighboring kings who laid a siege against him in Hazrak, after having received an oracle of Baalšamayin, his patron deity, through seers and visionaries (*ḫzyn*, *ʾddn*). The inscription of Deir 'Alla from circa 700 B.C.E. (# 138) reports a vision of the seer (*ḫzh*) Balaam son of Beor, also known from the Hebrew Bible (Numbers 22–24), and the content of the vision is a cosmic catastrophe ordained by the council of gods. The roughly contemporaneous Amman Citadel inscription (# 136) does not mention a prophet, but can be interpreted as an oracle of salvation of Milkom, the patron god of the Ammonites. As to Iron Age Palestine, one of the Lachish ostraca from the late seventh century quotes a one-word oracle—"Beware!"—spoken

by a prophet (# 139). The word *nābi'* appears also one or two other letters from Lachish (# 141 and, possibly, # 140).

Prophetic performances in the Levant in earlier times can be found even in two texts written in a non-Semitic language. The Egyptian Report of Wenamon from the eleventh century B.C.E. (# 142) relates how Wenamon gets into difficulties in Byblos and is relieved only when Amon, his god, possesses a seer ('*dd*) who goes into a frenzy and prophesies to the prince of Byblos on his behalf. A tenth–ninth century B.C.E. Luwian stele of Hamiyata, king of Mazuwari (Til Barsib), mentions a prophet giving cultic orders to establish the storm-god Tarhunza after a victorious battle (Tell Ahmar 6 §§ 21–23; Hawkins 2006).

Written and Literary Prophecy

Prophetic texts, especially biblical ones, are often read as achievements of individual thinkers, rather than products of societies that used written documents for a variety of purposes. However, the scribal process that produced the texts we have at our disposal is a secondary development with regard to the spoken, “authentic” prophecies. To all appearances, prophets were not supposed to be able to write in any part of the ancient Eastern Mediterranean (Nissinen 2014). The author of the written prophecy, therefore, is the person who adjusted the spoken prophecy to the available space and scribal conventions, deciding what was worth writing down. But this is not the end of the process: the prophetic material was selected by archivists, who chose what they wanted to file away or dispose of. Therefore, the words uttered in the oral performances remain inaccessible. For the same reason, the written sources at our disposal yield only a partial picture of prophetic activities in the ancient Eastern Mediterranean.

The question of how and why prophecy became written down and eventually developed into literature is related to the aims and needs of the communities that perpetuated the process, and hence to the sociology of the scribal culture. Textual evidence of prophetic oracles can be roughly divided into two categories: written prophecy and literary prophecy (Lange 2006). *Written prophecy* means written records of orally delivered prophetic oracles. These could be prepared for archival purposes, as the Assyrian tablets, but the use of written media could also serve as a surrogate for the oral proclamation if the addressee was out of reach; this is typically the case when prophecies are reported in letters, such as those from Mari, Assyria, or Lachish. Both ways, the purpose is to convey what the author has seen as the essential contents of the oral performance. *Literary prophecy*, on the other hand, is scribal interpretation of prophecy, either transcending earlier prophecies from the performance situation and recontextualizing in new literary environments, or creating entirely new literary oracles as a part of the editorial history of the given text. Literary prophecy is represented by prophetic quotations in Assyrian and West Semitic inscriptions, but especially by the prophetic books of the Hebrew Bible.

Secondary use of written prophecy is attested already by the collections of prophecies in Assyria, and the Deir 'Alla inscription, the “book” (*spr*) of Balaam, can be interpreted

as a secondary compilation of originally independent texts. The Hebrew Bible, however, documents a development that seems not to have happened elsewhere in the Near East, that is, the emergence of prophetic books. In the Persian and Hellenistic periods, prophecy became literary and thus lived on in a textualized form, and the interpretation of earlier texts became a divinatory act. Therefore, it makes sense to use the concept of *biblical prophecy* as referring to prophecy as represented in the literary world of the Hebrew Bible, historically deriving from *ancient Hebrew prophecy*, of which no primary sources except for two or three letters from Lachish (## 139–141) have been preserved.

PROPHECY, SOCIETY, AND RELIGION

Possessed Intermediaries

Seeing visions and receiving divine messages can hardly be considered to belong to the everyday experience of the human being. Anthropological evidence shows that the alleged communication with the divine often happens in a physio-psychological state called “ecstasy” or “trance,” or, especially with the (emic) assumption of a superhuman agent, “possession” or “inspiration.” This terminology pertains to different aspects of an altered state of consciousness, usually accompanied by a performance that makes the performer recognizable as an inspired speaker.

Ample evidence suggests that the altered state of consciousness was an acknowledged element of the public behavior of the prophets (Nissinen 2010). The Akkadian verb *maḥû* implies frantic behavior, and several Near Eastern texts mention ecstatic prophetic performances (## 23, 24, 33, 115, 134, 142). In the newly found fragment of Tablet V of the Epic of Gilgameš, Enkidu says to Gilgameš: “Be furious, like a prophet (*āpilum*) go into frenzy!” (George and Al-Rawi 2014: 78–79).² The Greek inspired speakers, such as the Pythia at Delphi, were believed to experience divine possession when prophesying (e.g., Plato, *Phaedrus*, 244a–245a; cf. Flower 2008: 88–91). A number of persons in the Hebrew Bible engage in prophetic ecstasy, make spirit journeys, and see heavenly things (Num 11:25; 1 Sam 10:10; 19:20; 2 Kgs 5:26; 6:17; Ezek 3:12–15; 8; 11; 37:1–14; 40–48; cf. Paul in 2 Cor 12:1–5).

Being possessed by the divine was probably seen as a necessary precondition for intermediation everywhere in the ancient Eastern Mediterranean. More often than not, however, it is not indicated in the sources how the prophetic possession was expected to manifest itself or whether it took place at all. It is probable that people who were believed to be able to transmit divine messages were recognized by their behavior, but the expectations varied as to what kind of comportment was regarded as prophetic. Anthropological evidence proves that possessed performances need not be erratic and uncontrolled, and the altered state of consciousness does not prevent a prophet from delivering an immediately intelligible message (see Stjerna 2001 on Finnish sleep-preachers). Some early Christian writers, however, regarded frenzied behavior as a

pagan habit, whereas a true biblical or Christian prophet was strictly controlled and non-ecstatic, even under divine inspiration (Origen, *Princ.* 3, 3, 4–5; Lactantius, *Inst.* 1, 4, 2–3; see Kaltio 2013: 210–213).

Gender: Divine and Human

The ancient Eastern Mediterranean sources present prophecy as a strongly gendered category (Stökl and Carvalho [ed.] 2013). The very idea of intermediation implies the “notion of penetration of a human by a divine agent, and casts the prophet into the role of the passive, penetrated, god-possessed female, even when the prophet is, as is usually the case, male” (Kraemer 2013: 291). The agency mediating between the divine and human worlds was likewise gendered: the deities were both male and female, and the prophets were either male, female, or even of undefinable gender—the gender role of the *assinnu* who sometimes acts as a prophet is ambivalent enough to be the subject of scholarly debate (cf. Zsolnay 2013).

At Mari, the prophets mostly spoke the words of the state god Dagan and Annunitum, the local manifestation of Ištar; other deities speaking or mentioned as the patron deities of a prophet in Mari prophecies include the male gods Adad, Ikrub-El, Itur-Mer, Nergal, and Šamaš, and the goddesses Belet-ekallim, Diritum, Hišamitum, and Ninhursag. The Ešnunna oracles are spoken by Kititum, a manifestation of Ištar, and in Assyrian prophecies, Ištar is by far the foremost deity of prophecy, most often as Ištar of Arbela or as Mullissu (Ištar of Nineveh). A few prophecies in Assyrian sources are also introduced as words of male deities such as Assur, Bel (Marduk), Nabû, and Nusku. In the extant sources documenting Levantine prophecy, the divine speakers of prophecies are exclusively male gods such as Baalšamayin, Milkom, and Yahweh. In Greece, the principal oracle sites were temples of Apollo, the Greek oracular deity par excellence, or Zeus, as in the case of Dodona.

As to the human party of the prophetic communication, about two-thirds of the prophets in the Mari documents are men, whereas in Assyrian texts, two-thirds are women, probably because of the prominence of Ištar as the oracular deity and the great significance of her temples in the Neo-Assyrian era. In the West Semitic sources, all prophets are of male gender, and in the Hebrew Bible, some fifty male prophets prevail over against half a dozen prophetesses, which may or may not correspond to the actual gender distribution of ancient Hebrew prophets. In Greece, the inspired intermediaries at Delphi, Dodona, and Didyma are women, while male prophets are known from Claros.

The prophetic agency could be claimed and enacted by men and women alike. This can be partly explained by the local prominence of certain deities and their cults, but also by the divine-human gender matrix, in which the humans play the passive role anyway; hence even women could act as mouthpieces of the divine. However, the sources indicate that the agency of the prophets was not purely instrumental, but rather that they also executed an independent agency. Speaking divine words gave especially non-male

individuals the opportunity to make their own voice heard as well. On the other hand, the suspicion of the male-dominated environment toward prophecies spoken by non-male persons shows itself at Mari in the more frequent verification of prophecies spoken by a woman or by an *assinnu* than was the case with words transmitted by male prophets (Hamori 2012).

Prophets and Temples

The close affiliation between prophets and temples becomes evident from the entire source material, whether Mesopotamian, Greek, or biblical (Nissinen 2012). Temples were centers of the symbolic, mythological universe, where the people participated in the divine presence, which made them an ideal venue for divine-human communication, even by means of prophecy. Some temples feature as particularly important venues of prophetic performances—not only Delphi, Didyma, and Claros, the “big three” Greek sites of Apollonian prophecy, but also the temple of Dagan in Terqa in the kingdom of Mari and the temple of Ištar in the Assyrian city of Arbela.

Prophetic performances took place in temples more typically than other types of divination. A temple can often be imagined as the implied setting of the prophetic oracle even where this is not explicitly mentioned, as in the Zakkur inscription where the word of Baalšamayin follows the prayers of the king of Hamat (# 137). In the correspondence of Mari, the authors of the letters repeatedly report how prophets “arise” (*tebû*) in temples to deliver a divine message (e.g., # 5, 29, 42), and prophets are often identified by the name of a deity—for instance, Annu-tabni, prophetess of Annunitum (# 58)—which probably indicates an affiliation with the temple of the patron deity. The prophets’ participation in cultic activities is attested in the case of the ritual of Ištar, which includes an interplay between prophets and musicians (## 51–52). Neo-Assyrian letters, too, sometimes mention prophecies uttered in temples (e.g., # 111), and the colophons of written oracles localize a prophet by the name of a city. When the colophon says, “Tašmetu-ereš, the p[rophet], prop[hesied this i]n Arbela” (# 91), this can be taken as a reference to a prophecy uttered in the temple of Ištar in Arbela, which was the principal source of Assyrian prophecy. In the Hebrew Bible, the books of Samuel and Kings include narratives in which a place of worship is explicitly or implicitly presented as the venue of the prophetic performances (1 Sam 2:27–36; 1 Kgs 11:29–39; 14:1–18). The prophetic books tend to juxtapose priests and prophets (Jer 2:8; 4:9–10; 5:31; 6:13–15; 8:1, 10–12; 23:11, 33; 26:7–8, 16; 29:1; Hos 4:4; Zeph 3:4; cf. 2 Kgs 23:2), and prophets, such as Jeremiah, are brought to the temple over and over again (Jer 7:1–15; 26:1–19; 28; 38:14).

Belonging to the temple personnel was not as such the prerequisite of the prophetic role. As gods were believed to be free to communicate with anyone, prophetic dreams and oracles could be received and communicated by any ordinary person whose agency and social status were otherwise limited in that community, such as a slave. It is usually difficult to know whether a prophet who performed in a temple actually was employed by it (Fleming 2004). Nevertheless, prophets were permanently present in the major

Greek oracle sites, Mesopotamian administrative documents from different times mention prophets among the temple personnel (## 110, 119, 123, 130; CM 33 1; LKU 51), and the strong presence of prophets in the temple of Ištar in Arbela indicates their permanent function in the worship of the goddess; some of them actually lived in the temple as votaresses (## 74, 114). The temples provided the most likely setting for the activity of “professional” prophets, that is, persons whose permanent role and source of income was prophetic intermediation.

Whether or not permanently affiliated with the temples in (or about) which the prophets prophesied, they are often to be found as advocates of temples and their worship. The letters from Mari repeatedly report prophecies ordering the king to perform sacrifices, sometimes rebuking him for his negligence in this respect. The Assyrian correspondence includes prophecies concerning the temple property, indicating even some clashes between prophets and temple administrators (## 111, 113). Assurbanipal mentions dreams and prophetic oracles prompting him to renovate the temple of the Lady of Kidmuri in Calah (# 99), and the same happened later in the Greek world: the Didymean priests consulted the oracle in order to speed up the completion of the construction works of their temple (*DI* 47). In Greek temples, dedications to gods were based on instructions pronounced by an oracle, for instance, “Hermias to Zeus Hypsistos, a thank-offering in accordance with an oracle” (*DI* 129). Oracular responses from Delphi and Didyma recorded in primary sources such as inscriptions are, for the most part, related to cult and religion (Fontenrose 1988: 96), and many of the preserved oracles from Claros (Merkelbach and Stauber 1996) give cultic instructions.

Even in biblical prophecy, the significance of the temple of Jerusalem as the site and symbol of the divine presence is beyond any doubt. Especially in the books of Haggai, Zechariah, and Ezekiel, the temple of Jerusalem exceeds every other topic in importance. The so-called cultic criticism of the biblical prophets (e.g., Isa 1:11–17; 58; Amos 5:21–24; Hos 6:4–6; Mic 6:6–8; Zech 7:5–10), often interpreted as an expression of ideological antiritualism, should be interpreted as a concern for, rather than as an antagonism to, the temple worship. That these texts present the religious order as failing to maintain the symbolic universe does not diminish the significance of the temple as its center.

Prophets and Kings

Prophecies are virtually always addressed to kings in the ancient Near Eastern texts: Zimri-Lim of Mari, Ibalpiel of Ešnunna, Esarhaddon and Assurbanipal of Assyria, Zakkur of Hamath, or the Prince of Byblos. In Greek sources, too, kings are frequently found consulting oracles—not only rulers of Greek city-states but also kings of more remote lands. The Delphic oracle, for instance, was consulted by Gyges, Alyattes, and Croesus (kings of Lydia), Arkesilaos II and III of Cyrene, Ptolemy of Egypt, Philip II of Macedonia, and the Roman emperors Augustus, Nero, and Julian (see the catalog in Fontenrose 1978: 240–416). Even in the Hebrew Bible, kings from Saul to Zedekiah turn to prophets, and prophecy accompanies the rise and fall of kingship in Judah and Israel.

Throughout the source material, there is a conspicuous affiliation between the institutions of prophecy and kingship. Prophecy had a political function as the source of divine knowledge necessary for the appropriate maintenance of the society, whether a Near Eastern monarchy or a Greek city-state. All over the ancient Eastern Mediterranean, rulers consulted prophets, among other diviners, to find legitimation for their rule and actions. Prophets may not generally have enjoyed quite as high an appreciation as technical diviners who, at least in Mesopotamia, belonged to the king's immediate entourage; nevertheless, prophecy was another medium through which the king was informed of the divine favors as well as his own duties (Charpin 2012; Pongratz-Leisten 1999). On the other hand, prophets, like other diviners, depended on the royal recognition of their divinatory skills.

The communication between prophets and kings, therefore, was bidirectional: kings turned to prophets to receive divine advice, and prophets made the king conversant with the divine will, and sometimes also with their own needs (e.g., # 8). The patterns of communication between prophets and kings appear to be similar throughout the sources. Prophecies may be solicited, as is usual in Greek sources, or unsolicited, as is more often than not the case in the Near East; the Hebrew Bible knows both options. The majority of extant Near Eastern prophecies are supportive and favorable to the kings, but the position of the prophets as mouthpieces of the divine enabled even a critical stance toward their actions. Judgmental prophecies are less common in the texts available to us; this does not necessarily indicate that they were not proclaimed as often as oracles of encouragement and salvation, although it seems to have been less than usual to preserve such messages for posterity.

The strong royal emphasis of the extant Near Eastern texts may go back to their origin in royal archives. It is conceivable that private persons, too, turned to prophets in the ancient Near East, but the extant sources do not let us know much about such communication. In Greek sources, the typical inquirer of an oracle is not a king but a citizen of a city-state, and the Greek sources, unlike the Near Eastern ones, allow us to see the role of private people as addressees of prophetic intermediation. The somewhat different role of kings as consultants of Greek oracles may also be due to different political structures. The principal Greek oracle sites were more independent of the rulers than the Near Eastern prophets, and they also had a more international character. The Delphic Pythia delivered oracles to kings coming from different corners of the Mediterranean, while the Assyrian prophets would rather communicate only with the Assyrian king. Moreover, insofar as the secondary source material reveals historical realities, the Greek oracles were less dependent on the state ideology that characterizes the prophecies preserved from Mesopotamia. The Hebrew Bible, again, constitutes a specific case with its unique editorial history. The encounters between prophets and kings are embedded in a secondary literary setting, which makes it difficult to reconstruct historical circumstances. While the function of the prophets is by and large the same as in other ancient Near Eastern sources, the relationship between kings and prophets appears as more immediate and the role of the prophets as more independent than in any Near Eastern source. On the other hand, the harsh antagonism

toward kings and kingship in the Hebrew Bible is unparalleled and may reflect post-monarchic ideologies.

PROPHECY: A COMMON EASTERN MEDITERRANEAN PHENOMENON

The ancient Near Eastern, Greek, and biblical texts make available a manifold, if fragmentary, documentation of prophetic intermediation. Enough commonalities can be found in this large source material to warrant the assumption of the existence of a common ancient Eastern Mediterranean prophetic phenomenon. The common features include the social function of inspired intermediation as one type of divination; the socio-religious context of the prophets in temples; the political significance of prophecy for the institution of kingship; the altered state of consciousness as the precondition of prophesying; and the gender matrix allowing the prophetic agency of both male and non-male persons.

The comparison between the source materials also reveals differences, of course, both in the historical image of the prophetic phenomenon and in the function and purpose of the sources themselves. The differences may demonstrate both continuity and discontinuity and, therefore, do not disprove the historical connection. There is no reason to believe that Greek, Mesopotamian, and biblical prophecy represent three distinct and disconnected socio-religious phenomena; neither is there a need to look for an “authentic” source of prophecy asking “who was first?” or “first from where?” Instead, the study can focus on family resemblances; in any case, the Eastern Mediterranean sphere is geographically restricted enough to increase the probability of historical connection and cultural interaction.

NOTES

1. Henceforth, the numbers of texts (#) refer to Nissinen 2003.
2. I thank Daniel E. Fleming for drawing my attention to this text.

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CHAPTER 2

PROPHECY AND PRIESTHOOD

LESTER L. GRABBE

THROUGH the nineteenth and much of the twentieth centuries, prophecy and the priesthood in ancient Israel were widely seen as opposed institutions, and priests and prophets as antithetical groups. Prophets tended to be favored in biblical scholarship, while priests were often viewed negatively. This goes back to the work of Julius Wellhausen, who postulated a form of “prophetic religion” that was dynamic and spiritual, in contrast to “legal” and cultic religion (represented especially by the priesthood) that was ossified and mechanical (see Wellhausen 1985, 2001; Knight 1983). More recent scholarship, in the late twentieth and the early twenty-first centuries, has taken a much more nuanced approach, seeing the two institutions of prophets and priests as much more closely related—even in many ways two sides of the same coin. It is this intimate relationship that will be explored in the rest of this chapter, to see how prophets and priests not only differed in certain essential ways, but also carried out many of the same functions within Israelite society.

PRIESTS AND PROPHETS AS INTERMEDIARIES

Both prophets and priests were intermediaries between the divine and the human realms, though they carried out this task of mediation in often rather different ways. The basic way that priests connect with the godly realm is via the cult, often including offerings and sacrifices of various sorts. In ancient Israel, animal sacrifice was the main function of priests, but the priesthood was an important vehicle for approaching and worshipping the deity. From the earliest recorded times to the fall of the Temple to the Romans in 70 C.E., temples or other cult places were the primary means and location of worship, and temple priests were the main religious personnel. In addition to altar sacrifice, which could be vegetable (in some cases) as well as animal, there are other types of liturgy, which are also commonly found, including in the Jerusalem temple: praying, singing, dancing, playing musical instruments, and perhaps even dramatic

performances (cf. 1 Chronicles 23, 25). It was this leading and conducting of the temple ritual that formed the main intermediary function of priests.

Prophets received messages from the divinity (by various means through the divine spirit, including audition, vision, direct address), which they then passed to the relevant human recipients. Their mediation was thus primarily of a divine message, whereas priests also mediated forgiveness, reconciliation, and grace. Many scholars would classify prophecy as a form of divination. What do we mean by “divination” in this context? What sorts of activities are included under divination? Many think of divination primarily in terms of the manipulation of mechanical devices, such as casting lots or interpreting the inner organs of sacrificed animals (extispicy). And many forms of divination are at least in part done by mechanical manipulation, ranging from dice and cards to shells on a tray or a basket of objects with mystical significance to mathematical grids. They would also include the priestly *Urim* and *Thummim*, which, it has been cogently argued, were a form of lot giving binary responses, and the ephod (see discussion in the following paragraphs).

Prophecy, however, would be a type of “spirit divination” (in this context, “divination” means basically contact with the divine). Note, for example, that the “spirit of God” (*rûāḥ ʾēlōhîm* [1 Sam 10:10]) came on Saul, causing him to prophesy. In this case, he was not seeking YHWH, but there are many instances in which a prophet sought to communicate with the divine. The deity might appear or communicate spontaneously, but a message might also be sought by various methods. For example, Elisha sought a message from YHWH by the use of music (2 Kgs 3:15).

PRIESTLY FORMS OF DIVINATION

As for the priestly forms of engaging the deity, there were several of these. A primary one was sacrifice, in which forgiveness for sin or a blessing could be asked from God, or simply as an expression of thanksgiving, which is itself a form of communication with the divine. Other liturgical forms involved music and singing, possibly recitation or even drama, and symbolic action. Yet another means for the priests of Israel to determine God’s will was by the *Urim* and *Thummim* (Ex 28:30; Lev 8:8; Deut 33:8) and by means of the ephod. Although we cease to read about the *Urim* and *Thummim* and the ephod as the text progresses in its account of Israel’s history, they are clearly attested in a number of texts associated with the early monarchy. Where mentioned, they are always treated positively and are considered vital for certain sorts of decisions, and even occasionally receive notice in late texts (e.g., Ezra 2:63; Neh 7:65).

Exactly how the *Urim* and *Thummim* worked is partly a matter of speculation, but there are hints that they were a sort of divine lot. This is indicated by the statement in 1 Samuel 14:41, though only in the Septuagint or Old Greek translation (the Hebrew Masoretic text seems to be textually corrupt here, as in a number of places in the books of Samuel), which states, Saul said, “LORD, God of Israel, why will you not answer your

servant with a sign? If the sin is with me or my son Jonathan, give *dēlous* [*Urim*]. If you say, though, 'It is in your people Israel,' give rather *hosiotēta* [*Thummim*]." This implies that a simple binary question was put that could be answered by either a yes or a no, or by choosing one of two possibilities.

As for the ephod, we have several episodes in which it was used to ascertain the will of YHWH in particular situations. The first example concerns the Ephraimite Micah in the book of Judges (Judges 17). According to the text, he set up a silver image and a house cult, with ephod and teraphim (Judg 17:5; *teraphim* seem to have been household images). He was joined by a young Levite who became his priest (Judg 17:7–13). Danites seeking territory sent men to spy out the land (Judges 18). When offered hospitality in Micah's house, they inquired of God about their mission through the Levite. The Levite made the inquiry and delivered the message that their mission would be successful. How he inquired of YHWH and how YHWH revealed the message to him are not portrayed in the text. It should be noted that Micah's is not a pagan cult. Although there is an image, the cult is dedicated to YHWH (Judg 17:13). The priest is a Levite, and he inquires of YHWH. Later, when they were migrating to Laish (Dan in the north), the Danites offered the Levite the chance to be their priest, and he accepted. (On the curious identity of this Levite, see later discussion in this chapter.)

The ephod's relationship to the *Urim* and *Thummim* is not completely clear, though it also apparently functioned as a form of divination. According to the Pentateuch (Ex 28:6–35; 39:2–26), it is a part of the high priest's garments, covering the upper part of the body. Yet it is associated with the *Urim* and *Thummim* in that the breastplate attached to the ephod also housed the *Urim* and *Thummim* (Ex 28:30; Lev 8:7–8). In 1 Samuel 14, while Saul was fighting the Philistines, Ahijah the priest bore the ephod (v 3). Saul's son Jonathan conducted his own personal attack against the Philistines. When Saul noticed Jonathan's absence, he apparently called for the ephod to consult (14:18: the MT has him calling for the *ārōn* "ark" but the Septuagint has *ephoud* "ephod"; some defend the reading "ark," but nowhere else in the text is the ark used in divination; hence, most scholars accept the reading "ephod"). Hearing a commotion in the Philistine camp, however, Saul interrupted the priest's inquiry and proceeded to attack the Philistines (vv 19–20). After an initial victory, Saul proposed to continue the fight by making a night assault. The men approved, but the priest suggested that they consult God (1 Sam 14:36). Saul inquired (*š'l*) of God by asking a question that could be answered by yes or no, but God did not respond (14:37). Once again, the precise mode of the answer is unclear, since a binary means of divination would normally yield one of two possible answers. For example, if you flip a coin, you get the result of either "heads" or "tails." Yet in this case, YHWH somehow gives no answer, making the mode of inquiry and answer puzzling. To resume, Saul, assuming from this lack of an answer that someone had sinned, sought out the guilty party by means of the *Thummim*, according to the MT (vv 38–42), though the Septuagint seems to refer to both the *Urim* and the *Thummim* (as noted earlier). This suggests two separate lots, one showing one alternative to a binary question and the other the other alternative. How it was possible to have no response at all (14:37), then? This might be an indication that the ephod is being consulted and that its means

of response was more complicated than just a binary response. In any case, it seems to be the priest who made the official inquiry to God on behalf of the king, and he judged that God had not responded.

This reminds us of a later passage where Saul is trying to determine from God how to respond to the Philistine threat, but there is no divine response, “whether by dreams or *Urim* (and *Thummim*) or prophets” (1 Sam 28:6; cf. 28:15). This indicates the variety of ways in which there was a divine response to human concerns. As a side point, but a very important one, however, no clear distinction is made between priestly divination and prophetic pronouncement. Also, it should be noted that dreams are a mode of divine revelation. In many passages, reference is made to prophets having visions, but dreams are less often mentioned. Yet dreams are also a medium used by the deity, especially for messages to prophets (Num 12:6; cf. also Deut 13:2–6 [Eng. 13:1–5]; Jer 23:25–28; Joel 3:1 [Eng. 2:28]).

David also made use of the ephod. When he was in the wilderness fleeing from Saul, Abiathar the priest came to him, apparently bringing an ephod (1 Sam 23:6, Hebrew slightly problematic). David was able to use it to avoid Saul, who was pursuing him (1 Sam 23:8–13). The types of questions put to the ephod are those that can be answered with a yes or no. He later consulted YHWH (šl bYHWH) by means of the ephod when his village of Ziklag had been raided and his wives and children taken captive (1 Sam 30:6–8). After becoming king, he also “inquired of YHWH” about which city to settle in (2 Sam 2:1), about fighting the Philistines (2 Sam 5:19, 23), and he “sought YHWH’s face” (i.e., inquired of YHWH: pi. *bqš ‘et-pěñê YHWH*) about a famine (21:1, 23). The methods of inquiry and reply are not indicated in these passages, but the first could easily have been the *Urim/Thummim* or the ephod, with yes/no answers. The response to the question about the famine is more likely to have been by vision or prophet (cf. 1 Sam 28:6) because the answer would have been harder to elicit by a bipolar form of inquiry. However, skilled diviners can learn a surprising amount even from binary answers alone, so it is possible that the *Urim* and *Thummim* or ephod were intended here.

In sum, what we see is a significant overlap in one important priestly and prophetic function. Each institution had its own sphere, but in inquiring of the divine world for direction and communicating of decisions, the priesthood had a capacity as well as the prophets. Dreams could come to anyone, yet they were a medium also associated with prophets. But this does not exhaust the overlap between the priestly and prophetic functions, and the next section will explore more of these.

THE OVERLAP OF PRIESTLY AND PROPHETIC FUNCTIONS

The seeming entanglement of priestly and prophetic functions should not surprise us, if we consider comparisons from other cultures. An important religious figure in many

societies is the *shaman*. Although the appropriateness of this term beyond the original figure (identified among certain Siberian tribes by ethnographers) is sometimes debated, most anthropologists accept that the role exists in a variety of cultures, especially in Asia and in indigenous cultures in North and South America. Whether shamans ever existed in ancient Israel is debated, though figures such as Samuel and Elijah and Elisha have traits most similar to the classical shaman figure. Shamans have characteristics in common with priests but also with prophets. They act as intermediaries between the community and the divine realm. The shaman is consulted on various matters by members of the community, especially with regard to illness and healing, but also concerning lost objects. On any matter of major concern to the community—including famine, support of hunting or agriculture, disease, warfare—the shaman would be expected to exercise his or her powers (the traditional gender of the shaman varies greatly among different societies). Samuel initially had priestly functions (1 Sam 2:18–21) and continued to exercise these throughout his life. But he acted as community leader (“judge”: 1 Sam 7:15–17) in the tradition of the pre-monarchy judges (as is sometimes the case with shamans). Finally, he was a prophet (1 Sam 3:1–18; 9:6–9). Elijah is labeled a prophet, but he is also known for his healings, which seem to include acts of raising the dead (1 Kgs 17:8–24), while Elisha has parallel powers (2 Kgs 4–8; 13:14–21).

One of the points often overlooked is the fact that many prophets were from the ranks of ordinary priests or of priestly families. The first person to consider is Samuel, who combined the duties of priest, prophet, and judge (1 Sam 3; 7:15–17; 9:9). He is an unusual figure and will be discussed further later in the chapter. Another prime individual was Jeremiah, from a priestly family from Anathoth (Jer 1:1). Likewise, Ezekiel was a priest who had been taken into captivity in Babylonia (Ezek 1:3). It has also been suggested that Amos had some sort of cultic office, though this is very uncertain (see the discussion and references in Paul 1991: 34–35). Prophets were also often associated with the temple and the royal court. David had his own personal prophets: Gad the seer and Nathan the prophet (see further in the following section).

The chief cultic figure or priest was the king himself (Grabbe 1995, especially ch. 2). We find that various kings offered sacrifices, even though this was a priestly function. Saul offered sacrifice (1 Sam 13:8–13): he was criticized for this, not because of the act as such but because he did not wait for Samuel as instructed. David offered sacrifice (2 Sam 6:13). Solomon sacrificed in Bethel the day before he had a dream in which God offered him anything of his choice (1 Kgs 8:62–64). This is often overlooked because the biblical text tends to try to hide this fact, as is well illustrated by the example of King Azariah (also called Uzziah). In 2 Kings 15:1–7, Azariah is said to be a good king (except for not removing the high places), but YHWH struck him with leprosy. No explanation is given as to why this happened. However, in the later parallel account in 2 Chronicles 26:3–23, Uzziah (as he is called in Chronicles) contracts leprosy as punishment for trying to offer incense in the temple. As the priests tell him, “It is not for you, Uzziah, to offer incense to YHWH but for the priests, the sons of Aaron who have been hallowed, to offer incense” (2 Chr 26:18). This represents a priestly view, after the monarchy had ended, but was not the case when kings ruled Israel and Judah. In general, the present form of the text tends

to hide the king's cultic predominance. For example, the Deuteronomist has the king copy out the book of the law for himself to study (Deut 17:18–20); apart from making the king subordinate to the Law, it more subtly suggests that the king is also subordinate to the priesthood.

OTHER EXAMPLES OF PROPHETS AND PRIESTS

As a preface to this section, we should take note of two points. First, one of the things we find throughout the biblical text is how intertwined prophets are with the temple and priesthood. Far from being opposed to the temple and priesthood, most prophets in the Bible are intensely concerned with priests and the temple, and even their criticisms show this desire to make these institutions better and stronger, not do away with them. Second, as noted in the previous section, we should also consider the fact that under the monarchy the chief cultic official was the king: the king was at the top of the religious hierarchy, not the high priest, as so often assumed. Therefore, it is worth considering interactions with prophets by the Israelite and Judahite kings as a part of this survey.

The first figure who is referred to as a prophet in the narrative is Abraham, who is called on to intercede for Abimelech (Gen 20:7), but in many ways the first example of a prophetic figure is Joseph in the book of Genesis. He is not labeled as a prophet in the text, but he has many of the characteristics of a prophet, especially in his ability to interpret Pharaoh's dreams (Gen 41:1–36). Yet he is also able to practice divination by means of his cup (Gen 44:5). This is in a time before a formal priesthood is supposed to have existed; nevertheless, Joseph is said to have married the daughter of the priest of On (Gen 41:45). Earlier Jewish commentators saw no problem with this, but for rabbinic figures the question of intermarriage with members of another race was a difficulty, since the Egyptians (Mizraim) were thought to be descended from Noah's son Ham (Gen 10:6), an ancestor of the Gentiles (as well as a group said in the biblical text to have been cursed by God). They resolved the problem in various ways, one of which was to see her as a daughter of Dinah and Shechem (cf. Gen 34:2) who was adopted by Potiphera (*Pirqê de Rav Eliezer* 38). Thus, according to this explanation, Asenath was a close relative of Joseph and not of an alien race.

In the view of Deuteronomy 18:15–22, Moses was the model of the prophet. Of his family, Aaron was the first priest (Ex 28:1), but his sister Miriam is called a “prophetess” (Ex 15:20). Yet we also find that there was a tradition of a priesthood descended from Moses. As discussed earlier, Judges 17–18 talks about a Levite who is hired by the family of Micah, and then later adopted by Danites, setting up a new colony in the north of Israel. The interesting point is that “the Levite,” at this point, seems to be identified as Jonathan, son of Gershom son of Moses (Judg 18:30). The name “Moses” (*mšh*) has been altered in the text by the addition of an *n* to make it Manasseh (*mnšh*), but the additional

letter is written partly above the line. It is generally accepted that the original text read “Moses.” This priest is a descendant of Moses, and his ancestor Gershom is said to be a son of Moses, whereas Gershom is normally said to be a son of Aaron (e.g., 1 Chr 6:1). This is clearly a different tradition—and an embarrassing one—a surviving indication of a Mosaic priesthood otherwise unrecorded in the biblical tradition. No wonder a scribe attempted to change the name “Moses” to “Manasseh”!

Little mention is made of prophets between Moses and Samuel. We have one brief reference to a prophet in Judg 6:8–10, who appeared at a time when Israel was oppressed by Midianites and warned them that their troubles were caused by worshiping the gods of the Amorites. But then YHWH sent an “angel” (later in the account he seems to be YHWH himself) to call Gideon to deliver the Israelites (6:11–8:28).

In the time of Samuel and Saul, we first come across a phenomenon known as the “band or company of prophets” (*ḥevel nēvî'im*: 1 Sam 10:5, 10) or perhaps even “senate or school of the prophets” (*lahāqat hannēvî'im*: 1 Sam 19:20) or simply “disciples or sons of the prophets” (*bēnē hannēvî'im*: 2 Kgs 2:3). First, they are simply a group of prophets coming down from a high place of worship (1 Sam 10:10–11); however, the next time they are mentioned, Samuel is at their head (1 Sam 19:18–24). We hear nothing further about them until the time of Elijah and Elisha. When the time comes for Elijah to leave the earth, he goes to two separate groups of the “sons of the prophets” at Bethel and Jericho with whom he seems to have a connection (2 Kgs 2:3–18). Elisha is involved with the “sons of the prophets” on a number of occasions and seems to be their leader (2 Kgs 4:1, 38–41; 6:1–7; 9:1–3). It is interesting that those involved with this phenomenon are those we noted earlier as being shaman-like: Samuel, Elijah, Elisha. Whether this is significant is unclear, since we have so little information.

The court of King David contained both priestly and prophetic figures, on whom David relied for advice and insight from the divine world. One prophetic individual was Nathan the prophet. He appears at a number of crucial points during David’s rule (e.g., 2 Sam 7:1–17; 12:1–14). The other main prophet was Gad the seer. He is referred to in 1 Chronicles 21:9 as “Gad, David’s seer (*ḥōzeh*),” but he is “Gad the prophet (*nāvî*), David’s seer (*ḥōzeh*)” in 2 Samuel 24:11. In both 1 Chronicles 21 and the parallel passage of 2 Samuel 24, David sins by taking a census of the young men capable of military service. It is Gad who brings the message of God’s displeasure. These prophetic figures functioned alongside the chief priests and seem to have shared certain sorts of duties or activities. Nathan and Gad are often mentioned together with Zadok, indicating their partnership in advising David (2 Sam 24:11; 1 Kgs 1:8, 26, 32, 34, 38, 44–45). Zadok and Abiathar functioned as a duo of chief priests under David (2 Sam 17:15; 19:12; 20:25). Abiathar was discussed earlier. Zadok is a curious figure in 1 and 2 Samuel. He first appears in 2 Samuel 8:17, with no introduction, as one of two priests. Surprisingly, no genealogy is given for him in 1–2 Samuel, and we are left to guess at his origins. The silence here cannot be accidental since a good deal is usually made of appropriate descent for priests. A full discussion is not possible here, and it will only be noted that Zadok is often thought to have been formerly a Jebusite priest of the original Jerusalem cult who came over to David (see further Grabbe 2003; Schaper 2000: 93, 270).

According to the text (which is our only real source), after the time of David prophets appear sporadically in narratives about the Israelite or Judean court: if there was a regular office of court prophet, we are not informed of this. Curiously, Solomon is not linked to a particular prophet. Nathan the prophet is associated with the scheme to get Solomon made king and then with anointing him to that office, as is Zadok the priest (1 Kgs 1:7–45), but both disappear from the story afterward. Solomon is criticized for being led astray by his “foreign women” (1 Kgs 11:1–13); the text continues that “YHWH” spoke to him and predicted that he will take away all the kingdom, except for one tribe, and give it to a servant (1 Kgs 11:11–13). How YHWH spoke to him is not specified. Possibly it was directly, but this is seldom the way that God would act. More likely is that a prophet delivered the message, but we do not know for sure.

Some of the most interesting episodes have to do with the various prophets associated with Ahab (1 Kgs 17–22). The most significant one is Elijah. In confronting the prophets of Baal, Elijah carries out the priestly function of repairing an altar of YHWH on Mount Carmel and offering a sacrifice on it (1 Kgs 18:30–39). It is interesting that one of Ahab’s ministers, Obadiah, hides a hundred prophets to protect them from Jezebel (1 Kgs 18:4), though why they are not mentioned subsequently, especially as giving assistance to Elijah in his difficulties, is a puzzle. Later, contrary to the impression sometimes given, the 450 prophets consulted by Ahab were not pagan prophets but prophets of YHWH, just like Micaiah who gave a different message (1 Kgs 22:5–28). The question is whether they might have been cultic prophets, connected with the temple, since Ahab as the head of the temple would probably have freely called on temple resources for his needs when it suited him. The question of cultic prophets will be discussed in a special section later in the chapter.

Amos has an episode relating to the Bethel temple (Amos 7:10–17). The priest of Bethel reacts to Amos’s preaching by sending a message to King Jeroboam that Amos is preaching conspiracy (7:10–11). He then confronts Amos directly, telling him to return to Judah. Amos responds by prophesying that Amaziah’s wife would be ravaged, his children slain, and he himself exiled to die in a foreign land (7:16–17). Apart from his opposition to Amos, there is nothing unusual about Amaziah. He is a family man, who conscientiously carries out his duties at a royal shrine by passing relevant information to his patron the king, and who maintains the sanctity and tranquility of the temple by trying to drive away one whom he regards as a troublemaker and fraud—a *foreign* troublemaker and fraud, since Amos was a Judahite in Israelite territory. What this does not suggest is that there is necessarily a natural opposition between the institutions of priesthood and prophet.

Another curious situation was that with regard to Hezekiah (2 Kgs 18–20). As a “righteous king,” he would be expected to give heed to prophetic pronouncements. Indeed, he does do that, but a particular point to note is that the main prophet attached to his court was Isaiah. He played a prominent part in the Hezekiah tradition, not least in 2 Kings 18–20 (which describe the siege of Jerusalem by Sennacherib, as well as other episodes; these chapters are repeated with only a few minor differences of wording in Isaiah 36–39). Isaiah had his call in the temple (Isa 6) but was often in the royal palace and the

presence of the king with messages and business (in addition to 2 Kgs 18–20, see Isa 7:3–9).

The next major prophet presented in the biblical text is in the time of King Josiah. This was the female prophet Huldah, at the time the book of the law was supposedly found in the temple when it was being cleaned under the orders of Josiah (2 Kgs 22:12–20). The scroll was given to the high priest Hilkiah, who had it brought to the attention of the king. The king took the initiative to consult the prophetess Huldah, who delivered a message to Josiah about the future of Jerusalem and his own future. In this case, temple, priest, and king were all involved with one of the few female prophets in the Hebrew Bible. When Josiah concluded a covenant with the deity on behalf of the people, he associated the prophets and priests, as well as the people, with the ceremony (2 Kgs 23:1–3).

The last years of the kingdom of Judah, in the late seventh and early sixth centuries B.C.E., reveal several prophets in the biblical text. The most notable is Jeremiah, who not only had access to the king (at least some of the time) but was also intimately associated with the temple. As already noted, he himself was of a priestly family from Anathoth, though there is no evidence that he ever served at the altar. As a prophet he sometimes condemns both priest and prophet (Jer 23:11). He often spoke in the temple or at the temple gate (Jer 7:1–2; 19:14–15; 20:1–3; 26:2–19; 28; 38:14; cf. 36:5–20), and there were times when he had access to a room in the temple itself (35:2–4). He was sometimes opposed by temple personnel (“priests and prophets,” in Jer 26:7, 8, 11, 16), but at other times such personnel were his followers or at least consulted him. A good example is the priest Pashhur, son of Immer, the chief administrator of the temple, who had Jeremiah flogged and imprisoned overnight (20:1–3). Yet later on, when Zedekiah became king, he sent Zephaniah, son of the priest Maaseiah, to Jeremiah to ask for prayer on his behalf (Jer 37:3). Then, after Nebuchadnezzar had invested Jerusalem, King Zedekiah sent Pashhur, son of Malchiah, along with the priest Zephaniah, son of Maaseiah, to inquire of YHWH (21:1–2). Zephaniah later emerges as an important priestly figure in the temple who receives a letter attacking Jeremiah and demanding his restraint (though Zephaniah seems to take no action against Jeremiah [Jer 29:25–32]).

Another prophet, often overlooked (because he seems to be presented as a false prophet in the text) is Hananiah (Jer 28). He is a prophet of YHWH and speaks in the name of YHWH (even though Jeremiah claims that he was not sent by YHWH [Jer 28:15]). His message to Jeremiah is delivered in the temple, in the presence of the priests (Jer 28:1). Jeremiah’s reply is also in the presence of the priests (Jer 28:5). The temple as the stage for this prophetic contest, with the priests as the main audience, illustrates the importance of the temple to at least some prophets. Hananiah opposes Jeremiah and predicts that the Babylonian threat will soon be removed. In that sense, he is the mirror image of Jeremiah. He prophesies by YHWH (not by Baal, cf. Jer 2:8); he opposes Jeremiah, just as Jeremiah opposed other prophets; and his message is just the opposite of Jeremiah’s, in that he predicts salvation from Nebuchadnezzar. The prophecies of Hananiah about deliverance from the Babylonians are much like those of Isaiah about deliverance from the Assyrians. Thus, the “false prophet” Hananiah is really little different from the “true prophets,” Isaiah of Jerusalem and Jeremiah, except for the specific time and place of his prophecy.

Finally, we have the rather enigmatic figure of Uriah son of Shemaiah (Jer 26:20–23). He appears only briefly on the scene, though his persona seems similar to that of Jeremiah. Certainly, his message seems to be in the same vein as that of Jeremiah. But he upsets King Jehoiakim, who seeks to have him put to death. For some reason (perhaps he did not have the powerful officials protecting him that Jeremiah did), Uriah was extradited from Egypt, to which he had fled, and then was executed at the command of King Jehoiakim. Jeremiah, Uriah, and Hananiah all prophesy in YHWH's name but with different messages and different fates. Uriah dies violently for his preaching; Jeremiah, who has a similar message, escapes because of friends at court; and Hananiah dies a natural death, allegedly as a result of Jeremiah's prophecy.

We also seem to have mention of a prophet in a letter from a military officer during the final period of fighting with the Babylonian army before the fall of Jerusalem. This is among the Lachish letters. Letter number 3 refers to an individual known as the "prophet" (3.20: *hnb*). It has been argued that his role in the letter was to intercede with YHWH for the nation (Barstad 1993). This brief mention is intriguing but tells us little. Some have speculated that the prophet was Jeremiah, but that is only a guess. As just noted, there were other prophets known during this time.

Prophets are mentioned in 1 and 2 Chronicles who occur nowhere else in the Hebrew Bible. In 1 Chronicles 9:22 a seer (*rō'eh*) named Samuel helps David to establish the temple gatekeepers in their office. (The gatekeepers, while not priests as such, were temple personnel.) 1 Chronicles 25:1–6 associates the sons of Asaph and others who sing and play with prophesying (this is discussed further under "The Question of Cultic Prophets"). Some of these "prophesied" to the accompaniment of musical instruments (1 Chron 25:1–3).

An episode in which Judah was threatened by a coalition of Moabites and Ammonites, including the inhabitants of Mount Seir, is described in 2 Chronicles 20 (1, 10, 22–23). When Jehoshaphat addressed a congregation of Judahites, calling on YHWH to protect them (2 Chr 20:3–13), Jahaziel (son of Zechariah son of Benaiah son of Jeiel son of Mattaniah the Levite, belonging to the sons of Asaph) responded with a message when the spirit of YHWH came on him: they were not to fear but to let YHWH fight the battle (2 Chr 20:14–19). The next day the soldiers of the opposing army fought among themselves, killing each other and leaving nothing but corpses and vast spoil for the Judahites to take (2 Chr 20:20–28). It is not stated that Jahaziel is a prophet, but his position among the sons of Asaph suggests that he functions as a prophet, at least in this instance (cf. 1 Chr 25:1 where the sons of Asaph "prophesy").

In 2 Chronicles 24:17–27, YHWH sent prophets to bring Israel back to him when Joash abandoned the true path after the death of Jehoiada the high priest, but he failed to heed them. Finally, Zechariah, son of Jehoiada the high priest, rebuked the people for forsaking YHWH, but they stoned him to death. As a result, Joash was attacked by the Arameans, wounded in the battle, and his courtiers assassinated him. (None of this episode occurs in 2 Kings except for a reference to Joash's assassination in 2 Kgs 12:19–21.)

Haggai and Zechariah describe the prophets Haggai and Zechariah, son of Iddo, and their support of Zerubbabel and Joshua in rebuilding the temple and restoring the

religious situation in Judah at the beginning of the Persian period. Some of this is paralleled in Ezra 5, though the chances are that this information is simply taken from the books of Haggai and Zechariah rather than being independent memory (Williamson 1983). In Ezra 6:14, Haggai and Zechariah also encourage the progress of building the temple, in a statement not taken from the extant books of Haggai and Zechariah (since it mentions the completion of the temple), though it is an easy inference from them.

THE QUESTION OF CULTIC PROPHETS

Although the Hebrew Bible text is not explicit about cultic prophets, Mowinckel already made a case for cultic prophecy in his *Psalmenstudien*, in what is probably still the best study of the question (cf. also Grabbe 1995: 112–113). A. R. Johnson's work (1962) has become a standard treatment of the subject in English. Some of the arguments used in favor of postulating the existence of cult prophets are the following:

1. In several passages we read of prophetic groups or guilds ("sons of the prophets"). For example, the story of Samuel associates him with a school of prophets (1 Sam 19:18–24), yet he is also the chief cultic figure in Israel at the time. As noted earlier, prophetic guilds are also associated with Elijah and Elisha, both of whom are similar to Samuel in being shaman-like figures, with some priestly as well prophetic characteristics.
2. Many of the attacks on "false" prophets imply that they work in groups and proclaim only peace and good for Israel. Under Ahab, not only the prophets of Baal (1 Kgs 18–19) but also 400 prophets of YHWH are patronized by the court and seem to function as a group or guild (1 Kgs 22). As the king, Ahab was also the chief cultic official and would have been regarded as justified in using temple personnel as a royal resource.
3. David had the court priest Zadok and also two court prophets, Nathan the prophet and Gad the seer. The prophets could have been part of the temple establishment, just as Zadok was, since the king also had authority over the temple during the time of the Israelite kings. Some later prophets seem to have had an intimate relationship with the temple.
4. 1 and 2 Chronicles indicate that some of the Levites prophesied: 1 Chronicles 25:1–6 associates the sons of Asaph and others, who sing and play to the accompaniment of musical instruments, with prophesying. And 2 Kings 23:2 mentions that the priests and prophets went up with the king to the temple. That itself seems to hint at a cultic position for these particular prophets, but also the parallel passage in 2 Chronicles 34:30 has "Levites" instead of prophets. One of the sons of Asaph gives what seems to be a prophecy to Jehoshaphat (2 Chr 20:14–17). Some of these were sons of Heman, the seer (*rō'eh*) of the king who pronounced "words of God" (25:5). Elsewhere, Heman is called a "singer" (1 Chr 6:18; 15:19; 2 Chr 5:12).

At the time of Hezekiah, 2 Chronicles 29:25 makes reference to the Levites as players of musical instruments (as established by David, Gad the seer, and Nathan the prophet). This has all been interpreted to mean that the books of Chronicles are indicating that the former cult prophets have been assimilated into the Levites and temple singers.

5. The language used and the themes treated by some of the canonical prophets suggest that the writers functioned in the cult. For example, Psalms 60, 75, 82, and 110 look very much like prophetic utterances, even though a part of the Psalter. The sons of Asaph who prophesy in 1 Chronicles 25 are evidently cult figures, in that a number of psalms are ascribed to them (Ps 50, 73–83). The sons of Hanan b. Igdaiah, “the man of God,” had a chamber in the temple (Jer 35:4). If he was a prophet, he could well have been a cultic prophet.
6. Some prophecies in the Bible, especially the oracles against foreign nations (e.g., Amos 1–3; Jer 1:4,10; 28:8, 25, 46–51 [MT = LXX: 25:1–13; 46:1–51:58, but different order; 25:15–38]; Isa 13; 15–25; Ezek 25–32; Num 22:36–24:25), have been thought to originate with prophets in the temple, whose concern—indeed, part of whose job—was to make sure that Israel or Judah was defended against external threats. Even if some or all these passages were by non-cultic prophets, they could well have been imitating the oracles of cultic prophets.

The existence of cult prophets is now accepted throughout scholarship, even if some of these arguments carry more weight than others. The real debate revolves around whether any of the written prophetic books arose from cult prophets. Perhaps the canonical prophets most often accepted as being cultic are Habakkuk and Nahum (cf. Jeremias 1970, though he sees no evidence for Nahum). On the other hand, there has been a good deal of resistance to seeing some of the “classical” prophets as having come out of the cult. For example, the proposals that Amos and Jeremiah were cult prophets (Reventlow 1962; Würthwein 1950) have met with little sympathy. Yet one cannot deny the close association that figures like Isaiah and Jeremiah had with the temple.

SUMMARY AND CONCLUSIONS

Several points have emerged from our survey of prophets in relationship to priests and the priesthood. These can be summarized as follows:

1. Contrary to the picture found in some research of the past, priests and prophets were not in opposition to one another. That is, the institutions were not opposed to each other, though prophets might well criticize individual priests or even the priesthood as a whole when it seemed to be corrupt; likewise, priests might well denounce prophets that they thought were venial or false. Many prophets were in fact from priestly families or background, including Samuel, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel.

2. Both priests and prophets served as intermediaries between the divine and human worlds. Although the main means of fulfilling this role for the priesthood was leadership of the sacrificial system, priestly modes of divination were very much parallel with prophetic oracles from God: the ephod and the *Urim* and *Thummim*. Prophets communicated more directly with the divinity, sometimes by prayer but also by receiving revelations, whether auditions, visions, or a visitation from the divine spirit.
3. Even though the priestly and prophetic institutions were generally clearly distinguished, for a few individuals the roles were very much combined. One thinks of the role of *shaman*, known in some cultures as the main religious specialist, which united healing, intercession for the community, and communication from the divine world all in one individual. Shamans were rare in ancient Israel, but some individuals (such as Samuel, Elijah, and Elisha) appear to exhibit traits very similar to the classical figure of the shaman known from Siberia.
4. Cultic prophets are not labeled as such in the biblical text, yet it seems evident from modern studies (drawing on a variety of original texts) that there were cultic prophets in ancient Israel, including some stationed at the Jerusalem temple. Levites who were skilled in singing may have replaced them or even may have served in that role in later times.
5. The so-called “bands or sons of the prophets” are a curious phenomenon. They occur only on certain occasions in the text, though they most probably continued in existence over a considerable period of time. It is interesting, however, that they are associated with Samuel, Elijah, and Elisha, three figures who look most like the persona of the shaman known from other cultures. There may be some connection with cultic prophets here.
6. It is often overlooked that the king was the chief cultic figure, as long as the Israelite and Judahite monarchies existed. David and Solomon are pictured as performing priestly functions at various times without criticism or comment. Yet some later kings are condemned for “interfering” with temple matters. This criticism probably represents a later priestly view that regarded the king as subordinate to the priesthood, but this was clearly not the case while kings ruled. Thus, prophetic messages sometimes censured the king not for political actions—or not *just* for political actions—but for breaches of the divine law, or even the failure to promulgate or enforce godly teaching as the prophet saw it.

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CHAPTER 3

PROPHECY AND DIASPORA

JILL MIDDLEMAS

ALTHOUGH there were many prophetic figures attested to within the historical traditions of ancient Israel—Elijah, Elisha, and Huldah, to name just a few—who engage in activity more or less consistent with prophets in the ancient Near East (ANE) more generally,¹ diasporic prophecy is really a phenomenon discernible within collections of divine words gathered together in conjunction with prophetic figures in books with thematic emphases. The collection of prophecies into organized blocks of material linked to a prophet is what distinguishes prophecy in ancient Israel from that of other cultures within the ANE, where such was never accomplished, as far as we are able to reconstruct based on the sources available. Classical prophecy represents a body of literature “that attests to or grows out of (i.e., is generated by) the activity of Israel’s prophets” (Petersen 2002: 3). It is convenient to regard prophetic books such as Amos, Hosea, and Isaiah, to name only a few, as collections of material that include words thought to have originated with a prophetic figure or circle, words about a prophet, and words held to be in keeping with or an extension of a prophet’s oracles. In this way, prophecy is not tied to individuals who steered the course of history with their inspiring words of God so much as referring to collections that are the result of a long process of transmission and editorial activity. Prophecy in ancient Israel was thought to transcend historical circumstances to be relevant for later generations and in differing circumstances. This becomes especially clear when we consider the relation of prophecy to diaspora. This overview serves a threefold purpose: to introduce the major lines of thinking about the phenomenon of prophecy in ancient Israel at the current time; to explain what is meant by diaspora, especially as a counter to, but inclusive of, Exile;² and to survey literature and themes associated with diaspora.

At one time, the individual prophets were regarded as the true heralds of the faith of ancient Israel. Much early study on the phenomenon of ancient Israelite prophecy conducted in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries sought, therefore, to capture the actual words spoken by the prophets for whom the books were named, in order to understand an original divine message and its form, separate from later editors and disciples (Clements 1976: 51–75; Tucker 1985). In more recent years, the canonical shape has

been regarded as itself authoritative, and inquiry has focused on how the shape of the whole book, rather than its individual parts, functions to convey a coherent message. In addition, prophecy was discussed by interpreters according to the means of revelation and its relationship or distinction to its ANE context (the classic study is Lindblom 1973). In addition, the growth of interest in the use of social science approaches in biblical studies has generated a series of analyses informed by anthropological studies that have emphasized the role of prophets as central (part of the political and social establishment and speaking in an advising capacity) and peripheral (on the outskirts and speaking against the establishment), as well as the roles of prophetic figures as seers, *nēvi'im*, shamans, and so on (Grabbe 1995; Petersen 1981; Wilson 1980).

It is more common in recent years, however, to discuss prophetic books as collections of material that reflect the teaching of a prophetic figure as well as the disciples or school that preserved his words, along with editorial activity that placed the book in its present arrangement and collected material to it while doing so. Concomitantly, much prophetic analysis accounts for the interpretations of a tradition that arose from the need to reveal a new and fresh word to the community in changing historical and social circumstances, or what is also known as its redaction history. In this way, the study of prophecy referred to here refrains from attention to a prophet as the bearer of the divine word, focusing instead on prophetic collections or additions to collections as revelation to humankind in and responding to diaspora circumstances. Prophecy associated with diaspora contexts and ideology includes copious anonymous material like that found in Second or Deutero-Isaiah (Isaiah 40–55), as well as that associated with prophetic figures, such as Jeremiah or Ezekiel, for example. In this respect, attention to prophecy exposes how the understanding of revelation alters over time, so that prophetic activity is more fully regarded as communal property rather than the words of an individual. Prophecy can thus be related to diaspora, even though not directly stemming from it. The prophecy of Amos, for example, includes material that seems to reflect circumstances associated with the Babylonian Exile, but the book of Amos and the prophet therein are linked directly to the events that transpired in the northern kingdom in the eighth century B.C.E. and not to diaspora per se. Diaspora provided the backdrop and also the impetus for the actualization of prophecy in other locations and for subsequent generations. An explanation of diaspora and its subunit Exile provides for greater understanding of how this is so, and it is to this topic that we now turn.

WHAT IS DIASPORA?

Deportation, exile, and relocation were martial tactics utilized by many nation-states in the ancient world, but they were perfected as an imperial mechanism of control by the Neo-Assyrians. Deportation and forced relocation were employed in the ancient world in order to punish, subdue, and exact loyalty from other nations or areas of unrest within an empire. The inhabitants of the kingdoms of ancient Israel were

subjected to a series of recorded and unrecorded deportations during their periods of existence. Each instance led to diaspora, or the spreading out of the former inhabitants of the kingdoms of ancient Israel beyond their traditional and national borders. The two most prominent circumstances in ancient Israel that resulted in diasporas significantly affecting the nation-states and the literature stemming from them are attributed to the fall of the northern kingdom with its capital in Samaria in 722/721 B.C.E. and the destruction of the southern kingdom with its capital in Jerusalem in 587/586 B.C.E. In spite of the fact that the dispersal of Jews existed from a two-stage Assyrian conquest (735 and 722, respectively) coterminous with the collapse of the northern kingdom in the eighth century B.C.E., diaspora tends to be discussed by biblical interpreters in conjunction with the defeat and destruction of the southern kingdom of Judah and the time period subsequent to it—the Exile. Walter Brueggemann, for example, suggests that “. . . exile evoked the most brilliant literature and the most daring theological articulation in the Old Testament” (Brueggemann 1997: 3). The reference to Exile here is made to the Babylonian Exile, that is, the time period of and the circumstances surrounding the fall of Jerusalem in 587. In contrast and more consistent with prophetic editorial activity as understood here, Ernest Nicholson includes the collapse of the northern kingdom as instrumental to the creative generation of prophetic literature: “A new age in the history of prophecy sprang to life after the shock of the events of 587 that was as creative and foundational as that of the eighth century prophets” (Nicholson 2010: 166). This overview uncovers the interpretation and reinterpretation that accompanied and followed the diasporas of the northern and southern kingdoms, regarding both as instrumental to the generation of prophecy in ancient Israel.

While the topic at hand is diaspora, that is, the dispersal of Jews beyond their national borders, it is important to mention Exile because much prophetic literature is thought to be written, reacting to, and addressing concerns among the Judahite exiles in Babylonia. Exile is thus a subset, albeit an important one, of diaspora and refers to a (re)location of inhabitants from Jerusalem and significant parts of the kingdom of Judah to the heartland of Babylonia at the time of the fall of Jerusalem to the Babylonians in the sixth century B.C.E. The deportations were thought to be temporary rather than permanent, but Jews continued to live and thrive in Babylonia well beyond the Old Testament period. While in Babylonia, the former Judahites were settled in enclaves along the Euphrates River as well as in the capital. Artisans, craftsmen, and slaves were set to work on imperial projects, the former Davidic king Jehoiachin and his family received rations from the authorities, and the local Jewish communities had a relative degree of self-autonomy under the leadership of elders. In Mesopotamia, Jewish communities interacted daily with diverse ethnic and religious groups and were confronted by the iconography and the idolatry of the Babylonian king and his gods. The written sources for this period include biblical material such as Jeremiah 43–44 for the exile in Egypt and Jeremiah 28–29, 50–51, the book of Ezekiel, and Isaiah 40–55 for references to the Babylonian Exile. Non-biblical sources include the Weidner documents referring to the rations of the Davidic family while in Babylon (*ANET* 308), the Murashu documents of Jewish family transactions in Babylon in the mid- to late fifth century B.C.E., and Aramaic documents from

a Jewish military colony in Egypt (also fifth century B.C.E.). These sources indicate that the Jews in diaspora settings remained relatively free, were settled in communities together, had a degree of self-autonomy and self-governance with the elders playing significant leadership roles for the communities in Babylonia, and assimilated culturally by speaking the language of the empire and intermarrying. How benign the situation was for deportees forcibly relocated to new lands is a matter of debate, but more recent studies like that of Daniel Smith-Christopher (2002) emphasize the human cost of the Mesopotamian policies. In particular, Smith-Christopher's work highlights the religious and communal responses to disaster with greater appreciation for human suffering, trauma, and feelings of separation and imprisonment reflected in biblical literature associated with and subsequent to the Babylonian Exile.

Smith-Christopher utilized refugee studies and analyses of exiled groups conducted by anthropologists in order to draw new insights about the actual situation of exile, compared to those afforded by studies that typically focus on the generation and creation of thought. Closer attention to ethnographic anthropological studies reveals that a view focused on exile alone is too narrow in scope. In ethnographic anthropological studies of the circumstances of and religious reactions to diaspora, the term refers to individuals and groups who have migrated, involuntarily or voluntarily, from a home country to reside in another land. Diaspora studies of religion focus on attitudes toward the homeland and the maintenance of and innovations in religious identity therein. Typical themes include reactions to and expressions of loss and separation, longing for home, and thoughts about and relationship to the homeland. Judahites were dispersed in many settings following the collapse of Judah in the sixth century B.C.E.—the Old Testament records that they fled voluntarily to Egypt and the surrounding nations, while a portion of the population of the former kingdom of Judah, the religious and political leaders in the main, but including craftsmen, artisans, and whole families, were forcibly deported to Babylonia. Equally, Israelites were exiled and in exile following the collapse of the northern kingdom. The situation of Judahites and Israelites residing in locations outside the homeland represents the situation since the late eighth century B.C.E.

At the same time, exile becomes loosed from its historical moorings in literature in which links to the land of origin are created, but without stressing longing for the homeland, return, and repatriation. Additional light on reactions to living in a foreign environment can be shed from close attention to the dynamics of interaction and reaction in the diaspora stories of Joseph, Daniel, Esther, and Mordecai, studied with anthropological analysis in mind. What becomes clear is that different attitudes toward diaspora, including concepts typically associated with Exile such as expressions of loss and longing for home, are replaced by the general acceptance of the present location, with expatriates deploying religious and non-religious strategies for adaptation to living in a foreign environment and maintaining kinship, group, and religious ties (Middlemas 2015). The reality of diaspora according to the literary deposit, then, is that systemic collapse resulted in the dispersal of Jews, some of whom expressed anger, disenchantment, and the desire for return and repatriation, while other individuals and groups adapted to living outside the homeland and were content to maintain a distinct identity therein. Foreign

environments are considered threatening to individuals and to groups of Jews, as well as conducive to constructive integration, even success. Diaspora, then, is more than Exile, and the Old Testament prophetic literature responded to the reality of Jews living outside the homeland on a long-term basis in many different ways.

Nevertheless, on the whole, the prophetic literature seems to favor a return to the homeland, the reunification of the northern and southern kingdoms, and the gathering of the dispersed. It is only rarely, as in Jeremiah's letter to the exiles (Jer29:1–9), that prophecy reflects a positive interpretation of long-term living away from the land of ancestry. Prophecy also lays the foundation for the presentation of exile as a necessary condition for a realigned relationship with YHWH and thus determinative for community membership as found in the book of Ezra (Middlemas 2012). Moreover, in Jeremiah's so-called Book of Consolation (Jer 30–31), poems in which exile points to a political and geographical situation are redacted so that the concept becomes a cipher for the human condition and estrangement from YHWH and the need for repentance rather than repatriation (Halvorson-Taylor 2012). In the prophetic literature, exile is an indispensable component of prophetic thought because it is regarded as divine judgment that is a necessary precursor to a new commitment to YHWH and to one's neighbor. Exile comes to represent divine punishment that will be overturned according to the divine will. In addition, it becomes associated with a radical upheaval in the world order that is initiated by ancient Israel's god, who acts salvifically in world events to renew creation and also divine commitment to a chosen people and a chosen place, and who gathers the dispersed to a location that will be the meeting place between heaven and earth.

PREDICTIONS OF DIASPORA/EXILE IN THE PROPHETS

Important insights on the theme of deportation in the prophetic literature arise in the first place from the consideration of the prevalence of the threat of exile in the oracles of judgment. Exile appears quite prominently in announcements of the coming Day of the LORD,³ or that time when it was thought that YHWH would manifest the divine self in history in order to act retributively on behalf of the covenant people. The prophets, beginning with Amos (Amos 5:18–20), turn the notion of the Day of YHWH around by regarding it as a time of judgment on the covenant people for failing to abide by their obligations to YHWH and their fellow citizens and threaten the punishment of exile. Exile is a prominent theme in the prophetic literature, as Robert Carroll has found in his careful study of the tropes of diaspora, exile, and restoration (1997). While the focus in Amos is almost exclusively on disaster, with concomitant predictions of the comprehensive deportation of the northern kingdom (8:2), prophecies found in the other Minor Prophets as well as Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel are shaped by the themes of exile and restoration.

Threats of deportation are made to foreign nations in the oracles against the nations, as well as to the Israelites and the Judahites of the northern and southern kingdoms, respectively. Various nations are threatened with exile or “scattering to the winds” within prophecies of judgment, including Aram (ancient Syria) and Ammon in the book of Amos (1:5, 15, respectively), Assyria in the book of Nahum (3:18), and Philistia in Zephaniah (2:2, 4–7; cf. Mic 1:10–12, Ezek 25:16). Most prophetic books include a section of oracles against foreign nations; Babylonia and Egypt are especially targeted and threatened with destruction and deportation, for example, in Jeremiah and Ezekiel. Similarly, the northern kingdom is doomed to destruction and its people are to be subjected to forced relocation in Amos (5:5, 27; 7:17; 9:9), which is a fate that will likewise overtake the inhabitants of the southern kingdom of Judah (Mic 1:16; Isa 5:13; 6:12). In addition, Isaiah of Jerusalem threatens exile to Syria and to the northern kingdom for their attempts to subjugate Judah during what is referred to as the Syro-Ephraimite crisis (see Isa 8:4).

The books of Jeremiah and Ezekiel, which include prophecies that span the time before and after the conquest of Judah by the Babylonians, also raise the threat of exile against the people of Judah for covenant infractions. Exile in the book of Jeremiah is a reference to a historical event that has been or is just about to be concluded (Jer 1:3; 27:20; 29:1, 4, 7, 14; 39:9; 40:1; 43:3; 52:28, 29, 30). At one point, this type of historical retrospect is made in order to assert that the current king will also suffer the fate of exile (Jer 22:10–12). Otherwise, it is used as the threat of punishment for covenant infractions against the nation (Jer 5:19; 13:19; 16:10–13; 18:7; 20:4) and also the king and the queen mother (Jer 22:26 and implied in 13:19; cf. Jer 22:10–12 and 2 Kgs 24:15). In Ezekiel, the threat of exile comes vividly to the fore in sign-acts performed by the prophet, in which he acts out aspects of the imminent punishment of the homeland and its inhabitants to an audience in Babylon. In his actions, the prophet symbolizes the duration of the exile (Ezek 4:4–8) and the scattering of a third of the population to the wind (5:1–4). These prophecies are reinforced by an interpretation that refers three times to the scattering of the people (Ezek 5:5–17) and by the insertion about eating unclean food in a foreign land (Ezek 4:12–15; cf. Hos. 9:3) amid a sign-act about the rationing that will accompany siege conditions in the capital. The most lengthy symbolic act said to be performed by the prophet appears when he takes the baggage of a deportee and goes into exile (Ezek 12:1–9), which is also refracted to refer to King Zedekiah (vv 10–16) and a more general diaspora (vv 15–16) in later interpretations. Otherwise, certain prophecies predict exile with the language of “scattering to the winds” (Ezek 17:21).

Prophets of the eighth century, a group that includes Amos, Hosea, Isaiah, and Micah, predicted national exile as punishment for violating the Yahwistic covenant. Kings, too, were threatened with exile, namely by Amos, who prophesies that King Jeroboam would die in an unclean, that is, foreign, land (Amos 7:14; cf. Ezek. 12:10–16; 17:11–21). Their words were understood at a later time to have been fulfilled in the course of history and therefore to have been conveying a new word at a later time to the southern kingdom of Judah. After the fall of the northern kingdom, it is thought that the prophecies of Amos and Hosea were gathered together within prophetic circles in the southern kingdom.

These traditions of collating and updating attest to the ways in which diaspora, both the threats of it as well as the actual event itself, generated new traditions and interpretations of prophecy.

DIASPORIC PROPHETIC LITERATURE AND TRADITIONS

Prophecy and the Dispersion of the Northern Kingdom

Amos and Hosea are thought to have prophesied to the northern kingdom a message of coming destruction in the eighth century B.C.E.⁴ Their prophecies highlighted social injustice (predominant in Amos) and illicit cultic behavior (predominant in Hosea), both considered to be violations of the covenant with YHWH, and the prophets predicted exile, death, and destruction as a consequence. Because the oracles of the prophets were considered to have come to pass with the events that transpired in the eighth century, and they accounted for covenant with YHWH in terms deemed appropriate for the southern kingdom as well, the prophecies of Amos and Hosea were preserved and reactualized to speak a fresh word subsequent to the fall of the northern kingdom. What this means is that the actual words of the prophets that had been preserved by their disciples were updated at a later time and over several periods to be a type of “living prophecy,” such that the words of Amos and Hosea announcing destruction and exile for covenant infractions were seen to be relevant to the inhabitants of the southern kingdom.

Amos prophesied the destruction of the kingdom of Israel and indicated reasons for this divine decision. What distinguishes Amos as the first classical prophet is the announcement of the total end of the northern kingdom as the people of God, which implied also the cessation of the covenant between YHWH and Israel (Amos 3:2; 5:1–2; 8:1–2; 9:7–8). The rather bleak prophetic message attributed to Amos is, therefore, grounded in the covenant tradition, “You only have I known of all the families of the earth; therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities” (3:2), and was deemed to have come to pass in the Assyrian conquest of 722. That the book’s arrangement displays various organizing principles—a double heading placed at its beginning to situate the prophet in a historical and eschatological framework (1:1–2), the location of the oracles against the nations in chapters 1–2, the sequencing of the vision reports to end with the cessation of intercession (ch. 7; 8:1–3; 9:1–4), and the appearance of a series of woe oracles together in chapters 5–6—attests to an editorial hand. Equally, other messages seem to have been added in later times and with a southern kingdom perspective. Some of the clearest examples are the inclusion of Beersheba, a village in the far south of Judah, in prophecies otherwise directed to the northern kingdom (5:5; 8:14) and the reference to “the booth of David” (9:11). It is widely thought that at least two redactions

of material took place, with the first occurring around the time of the reforms attributed to Hezekiah and Josiah of Judah in references to Bethel, and a second thought to have taken place close to or immediately following the destruction of Judah in the sixth century B.C.E. The Bethel redaction included material that predicted destruction also for the southern kingdom, whereas the collapse of Judah resulted in the generation of prophecies of salvation to provide hope for at least the return of the Davidic kingdom (9:11–12), if not also the reunification with the northern kingdom (9:14), as well as a return from exile (9:12, 15).

The prophecies associated with Hosea are equally thought to have been fulfilled with the conquest of Samaria in 722 and are commonly thought to have been subjected to a series of redactions in Judah. A first redaction is associated with the period shortly after the fall of the northern kingdom and directs a positive word to Judah for its faithfulness (Hos 1:7; 11:12b). As with Amos, additional editorial activity is thought to have taken place in conjunction with the fall of the southern kingdom, and predictions of its destruction for covenant infractions are related to this time (4:15a; 5:5b; 6:11a; 10:11b; 12:2a). A third redactional layer offers a glimmer of hope beyond the gloom of judgment and raises the possibility of a future united kingdom of Israel and Judah under the leadership of a Davidic monarch (3:5; cf. 1:10–21, esp. v 11). Passages expressing future hope after destruction are also sometimes associated with this layer. Although it is difficult to know for sure, the material inserted at a later time to speak a fresh word to new circumstances bears the imprint of the Deuteronomic school. In particular, a Deuteronomic scribe seems to have added the superscription (1:1), a prediction of the return of the exile (11:10c), and a concluding wisdom-type saying (14:9).

The prophecies of Amos and Hosea were regarded to have been fulfilled in the events that transpired in the kingdom of Israel and thus constituted examples of the true word of YHWH. As such, they offered a prophetic interpretation applicable to the southern kingdom because the divine word was regarded as having lasting value beyond its immediate circumstances. Moreover, the prophecies of Hosea that emphasized covenant and YHWH's formation of a special people in the events of the Exodus, along with the emphasis in Amos on ethical behavior consistent with the covenant and, indeed, the Ten Commandments, were thought to have inspired the Deuteronomic reform movement. How much their prophecies preceded the law and therefore contributed to its formation remains a matter of debate, given that they may have arisen from a common tradition, and prophecy does not play a significant role in the book of Deuteronomy and is subject to strict guidelines therein (Deut 13; 18:15–22). Nevertheless, it is widely agreed that the words of Hosea and Amos at least inspired further thinking by the Deuteronomic school. The diaspora or exile of the northern kingdom led directly or indirectly to the adoption of the words of the prophets of the northern kingdom by theologians in the southern kingdom and led to the tradition of gathering prophecies into a coherent and organized whole. Moreover, specific themes like that of the Exodus tradition are refracted in diaspora prophecy, such that the foundation for a new idea about re-entry into the promised land is conceived of as a new exodus prophesied to the Babylonian exiles (Jer 16:14–15; 23:7–8; and esp. Second Isaiah). This is one of

the themes that cuts across the diaspora literature and does not belong only with the prophecies associated with the Babylonian Exile. The creativity that accompanied the fall of the northern kingdom would lay the foundation for the tradition of prophecy associated with the exile of the southern.

Prophecy and the Deuteronomistic Traditions

The Deuteronomistic History (DtrH), or the edited historical presentation found in Joshua to Second Kings introduced by parts of the book of Deuteronomy, contains a layer of material that highlights and emphasizes the important role of prophets within the history of the two kingdoms of ancient Israel. Although it continues to be debated whether this is actually a redactional layer of material or a feature of the historical traditions incorporated as the history came together, what is agreed is that prophets are inextricably intertwined with the fate of the kingdoms. For instance, a prominent theme is that the failure to heed the prophetic word leads directly to the downfall of the kingdoms. In the Deuteronomistic inserted speech summarizing the reasons for the fall of the northern kingdom and actualizing it for Judah (2 Kgs 17:7–23), it is said, “Yet YHWH warned Israel and Judah by every prophet and every seer, saying, ‘Turn from your evil ways and keep my commandments and my statutes, in accordance with all the law that I commanded your ancestors and that I sent to you by my servants the prophets.’ They would not listen but were stubborn, as their ancestors had been, who did not believe in YHWH their God” (2 Kgs 17:13–14). At other points in the history, prophets offer repentance as an option to avoid divine judgment (2 Sam 12; 1 Kgs 21) as well as the threat of destruction (1 Kgs 13). Had the kings and the populace heeded the words of the prophets sent by YHWH and repented or changed their current behavior, the disasters that befell Samaria and Judah could have been avoided (2 Kgs 17:13, 23; 20:16–18; 22:15–20; 24:2, 13). In this respect, the Deuteronomistic editors writing after the situation of Exile attribute a significant, albeit anonymous, role to prophecy in the DtrH. At the same time, prophecy is judged on the basis of its veracity, and the issue of true versus false prophecy becomes determinative for the interpretation of individual prophets. Prophetic words that materialize in historical events are judged to be true, whereas those that do not materialize are considered false. This distinction becomes important within the DtrH as well as among the individual prophets (Jer 28; 29:24–32; Ezek 34:1–6).

The book of Jeremiah, which foretells the destruction of the southern kingdom and is dated to the years leading up to and following the fall of Jerusalem, contains a significant amount of material that belongs to one or more layers of Deuteronomistic redactional activity. Since Duhm first proposed and Mowinckel more clearly worked out prose speeches similar to sermons scattered throughout Jeremiah, there have been repeated refinements of the ideology of this layer, as well as the dates of the different redactions, some of which are thought to belong to the Second Temple period. At the same time, it is clear that these types of additions are consistent with

the poetry associated with the prophet and are not all necessarily Deuteronomic, but date from a later time after the deportations that accompanied the Babylonian conquest of Judah.

The prose layer seeks to explain that the judgment on the southern kingdom had to be a total destruction in order to provide the opportunity for a new relationship with YHWH in the land, with Jerusalem as its capital and the Temple as its only sanctuary. The prose sermon-like material contains the theme of repentance (Jer 7:3; 18:7–11; cf. 26:3), which is consistent with the emphasis on repentance or turning to YHWH in the DtrH. In the first half of the book, the prose sermons generally introduce longer sections of material (Jer 2:1–6:30; 7:1–10:25; 11:1–17:27; 18:1–20; 18:21–24:10). These units function as revelation wherein the possibility of repentance is gradually closed down; they indicate how important traditions in which the people had placed hope (Temple, covenant, the election of ancient Israel, societal and political leaders) would be destroyed. The prose narrative shows the inevitability of exile. In addition, the parable of the good and the bad figs illustrates that Yahwistic salvific intentions are for the restoration of the exiles, rather than those who remained in Judah or fled to Egypt (Jer 24; cf. 29). Like the DtrH, which correlated the prophet's words with events, the prose sermons reveal that the people seal their own fate by dismissing Jeremiah. The rejection of the prophet was correlated with the rejection of YHWH and thus was seen to be determinative for the fate of the kingdom.

Finally, another type of editing appears to have taken place in conjunction with redaction of many of the minor prophetic books after the fall of Jerusalem in 587 and appears as a first stage in the joining of the Minor Prophets into a collection that continued well into the Second Temple period. Although reconstructions of how the Minor Prophets were joined into a distinct collection remain controversial, a number of scholars are working out the relationship of the twelve shorter prophetic books and the links between them, with a view toward an overarching redactional purpose. What is sometimes referred to as the Book of the Four Prophets includes the prophecies of Hosea, Amos, Micah, and Zephaniah, which may have been joined together through catch words and phrases to be a short authoritative collection (Nogalski 1993). The superscriptions that set the prophetic words into a historical framework are remarkably similar (Hos 1:1; Amos 1:1; Mic. 1:1; Zeph 1:1), as are certain recurring themes. Although the joins between the books have been seen to derive from the Deuteronomic school and thus share commonality with the DtrH and the Deuteronomic passages in Jeremiah, such a clear connection is not at all certain. In the Book of the Four Prophets, the prophecies directed to the northern kingdom by Hosea and Amos seem to be accepted as authoritative, as they are placed in parallel to two of the southern kingdom prophets of judgment, Micah and Zephaniah. The prophets are described as bearers of the divine message that, once rejected, leads to divine judgment including the loss of land. Common to all is the prominent theme that judgment is purifying and leads to a future-oriented salvation. At the same time, each prophetic book (i.e., Hosea, Amos, Micah, and Zephaniah) had an existence independent of a joint collection, and how they are meant to be read as a whole remains a matter of debate at the present time.

Prophecy and the Exilic Diaspora

The Deuteronomic sections of Jeremiah (sometimes referred to as JerD) are only part of a larger work that deals with the time surrounding the collapse of Jerusalem and the kingdom of Judah. A historical interlude separate from the Deuteronomy-like material within the book of Jeremiah deals with events subsequent to the fall of Jerusalem, the deportation of members of its populace, and the flight of other Judahites to voluntary exile in Egypt, and will be briefly considered here. In addition to the book of Jeremiah, there are two major prophetic collections associated with the events of the Babylonian Exile: Ezekiel and Second Isaiah (Isaiah 40–55).

The historical traditions associated with Jeremiah present him as resolutely committed to remaining in the land of Judah (Jer 40:4–6) and enabling the resurgence of the community not taken into exile. Certain prophecies indicate blessing for those who remain in the homeland as long as they continue to be committed to YHWH (27:8–11; 38:17–20). At the same time, the prophetic material reveals an awareness of Judahites in diaspora in other locations, as in Egypt for example, but the message for them is negative and condemnatory (Jeremiah 24; 44). Unlike the Babylonian exiles, who are to prosper on foreign soil and eventually be gathered back to the homeland by YHWH (Jer 29), the refugees in Egypt are connected with the false worship that brought down the kingdom and so are condemned to future destruction. Although diaspora is a reality mentioned within the book of Jeremiah, it is not the main concern of the historical material, which suggests opportunities for those remaining in Judah.⁵ The prophet Jeremiah takes on a role here that will be found in other prophecies linked to the Babylonian Exile, which is to advise a dispersed community from the location of the homeland. Among the prophecies found in the book are messages of hope directed to those remaining in Judah, to paradigmatic individuals, and above all to the exiles. As we will see, the attribution of a hopeful future to the community in exile, which is gradually being identified as the *golah* (or “the exile”), is a theme that becomes prominent in the literature of this period and beyond.

The book of Ezekiel is more homogeneous than Jeremiah. Dated prophecies with only one exception follow in sequential order; the book opens with the call of the prophet and proceeds with a series of oracles of judgment on Judah (chs. 1–24) and oracles against the nations (chs. 25–32), ending with a collection of oracles of salvation (chs. 33–48). Interspersed are a series of visions, including the three visions of the deity at the prophet’s call (chs. 1–3), the impurity at the temple (chs. 8–11), and the restored Temple and community (chs. 40–48) as well as the vision of the dry bones in which Ezekiel intercedes for the community languishing in Babylonia (ch. 37). Thematically, it conveys an almost singular message designed to explain the destruction of Judah and Jerusalem; YHWH’s purposes for reconstituted religious ritual, leadership, and community are available to certain individuals following the systemic collapse that coincided with the fall of Jerusalem by those who heed the prophetic word. It is a carefully structured literary work anchored in historical events whose purpose is to persuade the reader/audience to the prophet’s viewpoint by placing the interpreters among the exiles in Babylonia. Given

such a high degree of homogeneity, it is no wonder the book is thought to be the unified composition by one author, or essentially the prophecies of Ezekiel to which accretions have been added by disciples of the prophet, often spoken of as a school. Probably one of the most persuasive interpretations of its history of redaction at the present time is that by Thomas Krüger, who suggested that an edition of Ezekiel was made in Babylon and was associated with a prophet of this name, and was later updated in Judah (1989). Apocalyptic visions like that of the Gog/Magog cycle in chapters 38–39 were added much later.

It is the prophetic collection that has the greatest claim to be referred to as an exilic book, in that the prophet Ezekiel is portrayed as having been commissioned in Babylonia, and his message is directed exclusively to the exiles. Moreover, the dates associated with his prophecy all occur within the period thought of as the Exile—the call of the prophet occurs in 593 (Ezek 1:2) and the last dated prophecy is 571 (Ezek 29:71), which does not mean that they all have their provenance within these dates, but rather that the book presents itself as intimately connected with this period and geographical location. Furthermore, Ezekiel's prophecies are directed to the members of the *golah* (the biblical term for the exiles; Ezek 1:1; 3:11, 15; 10:15, 20; 11:24), and promises of restoration are given exclusively to this group (see Ezek 11:14–25). Moreover, the prophet places himself among the deportees taken together with Jehoiachin through the phrase “the year of our exile” (Ezek 33:21; 40:1). Ezekiel, who is located among the deportees in Babylon, is portrayed as a sentinel who observes the actions of an army from a distance and announces the downfall of Jerusalem and the southern kingdom (Ezek 3:17; cf. Hos 9:8). Until a second commissioning (Ezek 33:7), he is forbidden to intercede for the people, whether in the homeland or among the exiles (Ezek 14:1–11; 20:20–31). Although situated in Babylonia, on two occasions Ezekiel is transported in otherworldly visions to observe what is taking place in the homeland—the rampant cultic abuses that occasion its destruction (chs. 8–11) and the renewal of divine presence that generates cultic and societal restoration (chs. 40–48). These scenes emphasize the diaspora setting of the prophecies.

The fall of Jerusalem concludes the oracles of doom. Moreover, the sign-acts that visually portray the destruction of the capital and its environs in the first half of the book are concluded with a final one that resonates with the destruction of the city through the death of Ezekiel's wife (Ezek 24:15–24). In addition, the report of the fall of the city at the beginning of a series of oracles of salvation directed to Jerusalem and Judah (Ezek 33:21) sets the stage for the turn to restoration for its leaders (Ezek 34), the land (chs. 35–36), its inhabitants (ch. 37), and the temple, the capital, cultic personnel, and community (chs. 40–48) that concludes the book. From an exilic point of view, then, the book of Ezekiel offers an explanation for the complete annihilation of Jerusalem and its political, social, and religious structures and how YHWH 's purposes are for renewal, but only once a complete caesura has taken place and only in order to magnify the divine name and reputation. Exile is necessary to facilitate divine renewal. In common with Amos 8:2, which prophesied that a complete end was necessary, Ezekiel vividly portrays the grounds for such a radical divine decision to the *golah* community and provides a way to think of

renewal and reconstruction subsequent to it. His is a programmatic vision meant to spell out more accurately how the people can continue to maintain the covenant of their God, with the emphasis on the power of YHWH who acts on behalf of the divine reputation. The visions of the prophet, among other things, indicate the mobility of the deity and God's ability to be in and outside the homeland, thus among the covenant people, as a "little sanctuary" or a "sanctuary for a little while" (Ezek 11:16).

Isaiah 40–55 has a different historical background (*viz.*, the Babylonian period and ascension of Cyrus), outlook (prophecies of salvation in the main, with sin and judgment a thing of the past), and themes (promises of return to and the rebuilding of Jerusalem, the role of suffering in redemption, a new Exodus, YHWH as creator linked with YHWH as redeemer, polemics against the idols) than the previous 39 chapters of Isaiah, some of which have been attributed to an Isaiah of Jerusalem who prophesied in the eighth century B.C.E. during the period of Neo-Assyrian might. Second Isaiah is, therefore, linked to the Babylonian Exile, and parts, if not its entirety, were composed therein. Like Ezekiel, Second Isaiah was once regarded as a fairly homogeneous unit of prophecies, even though the thematic emphases between chapters 40–48 and 49–55 differ. Chapters 40–48 reveal historical concerns, such as a focus on Jacob/Israel as a national entity, polemics against idols, and pronouncements of the divine choice of the Persian ruler Cyrus as an earthly king (shepherd and messiah) raised up by YHWH to facilitate a return from exile, interspersed with great declarations of YHWH as redeemer, creator, incomparable, and without equal. In distinction, the concluding chapters (49–55) focus on more communal concerns through the alternating descriptions of and declarations to the suffering servant (Isa 49:1–13; 50:4–11; 52:13–53:12) and the downtrodden Jerusalem personified as a woman in mourning (Isa 49:14–50:3; 51:9–52:12; 54:1–17).

Although chapters 40–48 are distinguishable from 49–55 on the basis of thematic emphases, serious redactional-critical inquiry has not followed these more general lines. Rather, different blocks of material are separated out, starting already with the Servant Songs isolated by Bernhard Duhm (Isa 42:1–4; 49:1–6; 50:4–9; 52:13–53:12), but including also the salvation oracles to Jerusalem portrayed as a woman and the praise of Cyrus, for example. Redactional studies have raised a number of interrelated themes, isolated them to distinct layers of editorial activity, and posited them to many different dates of composition well beyond the exilic age. It is fair also to say that the majority of interpreters have understood Second Isaiah as either belonging entirely to the period of the Exile (although one could draw it down to just before the biblical chronological time period associated with Haggai and Zechariah 1–8) or to at least beginning within the Exilic period and extending well into the Persian period. The prophecies of Second Isaiah are also typically situated among the exiles in Babylonia, but cogent concerns have been raised about either the exclusive provenance therein or even not at all (Barstad 1997). A middle-ground approach has been offered by Rainer Albertz, among others, which smooths some of these issues, but is controversial nonetheless (2001). The prophecies appear to have two conclusions, roughly coexistent with chapters 52 and 55, which suggest two main editions of the book, with a first including Isaiah 40:1–5, 9–52:15 and a second including 40:6–8, 55:1–11. That these could equally be located in different

settings, as with the book of Ezekiel (initial work by the prophet in Babylon and the continuation and development of his prophecies by disciples who shared his thinking upon return to Judah/Jerusalem) would provide an explanation for some of the arguments advanced by Hans Barstad, for example, for a Judahite provenance.

Second Isaiah is a mixed composition attributed to an anonymous prophet whose call appears in Isaiah 40:1–8 and possibly again at 49:1–6, and who may have had a hand in gathering together and editing the prophecies associated with Isaiah of Jerusalem (Williamson 1994). Some important themes appearing in the work include the joining of the concept of YHWH as redeemer who will facilitate world events (the raising up of Cyrus, the defeat of Babylon) to facilitate the return of the exiles to the homeland with the concept of YHWH as Creator. This is a new type of juxtaposition that is associated with Second Isaiah that can be equated with the equally important emphasis on the comparison of the deity of ancient Israel with the (non-)deities of Babylonia represented in statued forms. Polemics against the idols (Isa 49:19–20 and 41:6–7; 42:17; 44:9–20; 45:16–17, 20b; 46:5–8), although once removed from the original oracles of Second Isaiah, are now understood as an integral part of them, even if not originating from the prophet. The polemics focus attention on the lack of the efficacy of the idols worshiped as gods by the Babylonians and highlight the creative activity and the efficacy of the divine word of YHWH, the deity of the exiles, who is transcendent and incomparable. The passages function to persuade the exiles to reject the allure of “foreign” worship and to insist on YHWH’s continuing power to save; they are intimately related to countering Mesopotamian belief in the consecration of divine statues. Another innovation during this time and within this prophetic collection is the juxtaposing of the experiences of the (male) suffering servant and the (female) city of Jerusalem, who are both comforted with promises of salvation and who are the beneficiaries of divine intervention. It may be that these two figures represent the two main communities of the Babylonian exilic period, the *golah* community in Babylon and the Judahite community that remained in the homeland following the disaster, such that salvation oracles are made to join the two communities in the future purposes of YHWH and to address the suffering experienced by both (Middlemas 2007).

Prophecy and the Ongoing Diaspora

The roots of apocalyptic thought, which shares a degree of commonality with eschatological themes in prophecy more generally, tend to be associated with the prophetic literature of the Exilic period. Apocalyptic elements were developed more systematically in post-exilic prophecy, partly as a response to the situation of the ongoing diaspora of the inhabitants of ancient Israel, but mostly due to the failure of the realization of prophetic promises. In this way, exile (as temporary relocation from the homeland) and diaspora (as successful or long-term settlement outside the homeland) continue to exert influences on prophetic conceptions of those who constitute YHWH’s community. The linking of prophecies or prophetic figures that mention Exile to apocalyptic visions

attest to the biblical memory of Exile and experiences of land loss. To be sure, the roots of apocalyptic narrative, with its elements of otherworldly visions and intervening messenger figures, can be traced also to the prophet Ezekiel, but the development of the tradition extends far beyond the time associated with the Exile. Deportation led to an ongoing exile and two examples, Obadiah and Daniel, provide an entry to the apocalyptic development of prophetic traditions that are relevant to a discussion of diaspora. Apocalyptic themes that reflect most clearly the influence of exile and diaspora are prophecies of the reunification of the northern and southern kingdoms and the return of the people scattered “to the winds” or the “four corners of the earth,” and the resumption of Davidic rule.

The book of Obadiah is a short collection of 21 verses pronouncing judgment on Edom in language that recounts material found already in Jeremiah (Jer 49:7–22, especially Obad 1b–4 [Jer 49:14–16]; v 5 [Jer 49:9]; v 6 [Jer 49:10a]). The use of prophetic perfects in the condemnation of Edom for its pride and violating Jerusalem and Judah, presumably during the Babylonian conquest of the southern kingdom (vv 1–9, cf. Ps 137:7; Lam 4:21–22; Ezek 25:12; 33:5, 12), places the emphasis on the certainty of destruction. Edom is accused of participating in the downfall of Jerusalem (vv 11–12), gloating over its collapse (v 12), looting its citizens (v 13), murdering the fugitives or handing them over to the perpetrators of violence (v 14), and acting in ways that violate “brother Jacob” (vv 9–10). The indictment against Edom leads to the announcement of a Day of YHWH (vv 15–21), that is, a day of judgment against the nations and salvation for Jerusalem (vv 15a, 16–18) and Judah (vv 19–21), in an oracle that is often considered to be post-exilic and that verges on apocalyptic. Oracles against foreign nations actually constitute salvation oracles for Judah, and the prophecy of judgment against Edom in Obadiah ends on an almost eschatological note that detaches it from a historical time frame and thus renders it apocalyptic. The memory of Edom’s infractions against the nation of Judah is transformed into a vision of YHWH’s retribution against the nations with themes of a universal judgment, the restoration of a unified Israel, the expansion of the borders of the former united kingdom (v 19), the return of the dispersed (v 20), and the establishment of a divine kingdom (v 21).

In a different way, the book of Daniel draws a prophetic figure into an apocalyptic vision of the end at a time far removed from the actual period of the Exile. Although the book of Daniel is not included among the prophetic books in the Jewish tradition, the Christian Old Testament places it among the Prophets just after the book of Ezekiel, and in Daniel 1–6 the protagonist acts in ways consistent with how prophets act. Daniel is one of the deportees in Babylonia, where he advances as a courtier.⁶ In that capacity, Daniel reveals a number of messages to the kings whom he served (in chs. 1–6) and later reveals visions about the fate of the kingdoms in the final chapters of the book in the form of first-person address (chs. 7–12). Because Daniel is said to be among the deportees at the Babylonian court of Nebuchadnezzar, the stories in the first six chapters have been regarded as containing a kernel of information about the situation of the exiles in the capital. Although this is difficult to substantiate given that the final composition probably stems from Maccabean times and the persecution of Jews under Antiochus Epiphanes, the literature presses that the figure of Daniel be linked to the Babylonian Exile (similar

to Esther, another tale of the Jew in a foreign court; see Middlemas 2012), so that the Exile is again brought into a larger tradition that is clearly apocalyptic. Through the character of Daniel, the literature offers support to Jews to continue to observe pietistic behavior in the face of persecution and suggests that there is a divine plan for history. Rather than focusing on Israel among the nations, the perspective of the book focuses on the nations and only peripherally on Israel. YHWH's purposes for all the nations of the earth will be realized sometime in the eschatological future, at which point the Jews will be vindicated in their faith through the establishment of the kingdom of God.

CONCLUSIONS

Taking a diaspora view of the prophets helps us to see that the innovations typically associated with prophecy in the Exilic period are not unique to the literature interacting with the downfall of Jerusalem and the other monumental circumstances associated with the sixth century B.C.E., but rather are representative of an approach to prophetic tradition that goes back at least to the collections of prophecy generated at the time of the northern kingdom in the eighth century B.C.E. Indeed, the theme of the end and destruction of the northern kingdom found in the eighth-century prophets is related to events of the sixth century such that the prophetic literature that spans the eighth to sixth centuries B.C.E. presents a unified message of judgment (Clements 1977). In addition, the inspiration of prophecy and the generation of a living prophetic tradition attest to the authority granted to the prophets. Prophecy is a tradition in its own right, on par with the Law (Nicholson 2010).

Equally, such a view attests to an emerging corpus of prophetic scripture taken to be authoritative and inspirational for current and future generations. The prophets whose words were maintained and edited were understood to have been right in the sense that their predictions of disaster were proven by the events of history to be true. These were the prophecies that were accepted as scripture and updated in order to draw meaning from them in new circumstances and to suggest that they would continue to be true in the future. It is exactly this future orientation that leads the way for the emergence of apocalyptic literature and thought (e.g., Isa 24–27 or the Isaiah Apocalypse; Isaiah 56–66, known as Third or Trito-Isaiah, Malachi, and Zechariah 9–14 or Second Zechariah). Prophecy much later than the exiles and diasporas that accompanied the fall of the two kingdoms would engage thematically with prophecies of salvation made in the eighth to sixth centuries that failed to materialize—such as a mass return from diaspora, the reunification of the kingdoms of Israel and Judah, the rebuilding of the Temple in its former glory, and the institution of social justice—increasingly in the form of apocalyptic prophecy, but found already in Haggai and Zechariah 1–8, which share more in common with Exilic prophecy than with the literature of the later Persian period. In the end, a diaspora viewpoint affords us the ability to see that the words of the prophets were not collected solely in order to remember important individual figures. Rather,

they represented collections of collections that were read and reinterpreted together as conveying something about the wholeness of the prophetic message as a witness to the overarching purpose of YHWH in and beyond history.

NOTES

1. Analyses of biblical prophecy make use of ANE documentary evidence; see Lindblom 1973; Nissinen 2000.
2. I capitalize Exile to refer to the Babylonian Exile, which interpreters speak of as a historical event (the Babylonian Exile as the time when deportees were relocated from the former southern kingdom of Judah) and a time frame (the time between the conquest of Jerusalem by the Babylonians in 587 B.C.E. and the Persian defeat of Babylon under Cyrus in 539). In these historical constructions, exile means a (re)location with varying degrees of temporality. It also becomes a reference loosed of historical moorings; see Halvorson-Taylor 2012; Middlemas 2012.
3. There are sixteen overt references to the Day of YHWH, appearing in Isa 2:12, 13:16, 22:5, 34:8; Jer 46:10; Ezek 7:10, 13:5, 30:3; Joel 1:15; 2:1, 11; 3:4 [2:31]; 4:14 [3:14]; Amos 5:18–20; Obad 15; Zeph 1:7, 8, 14–18; Zech 14:1.
4. Amos is considered to be the first classical prophet in terms of the time and historical circumstances of his activity, in spite of the canonical order, according to which Hosea is the first of the book of the twelve Minor Prophets.
5. For more on the community that remained in the land after the fall of Jerusalem, see Middlemas 2005.
6. Daniel is said to have been sent into exile at the time of one of the first deportations that occurred in the third year of King Jehoiakim; however, there is no evidence of this deportation. At one time, it was thought that the historical inaccuracies found in the book of Daniel were due to the ignorance of the redactor, but they are now more commonly understood as deliberate signs meant to alert the reader that the stories are far removed from the time in which they are set.

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CHAPTER 4

PROPHECY IN PERSIAN YEHUD

JON L. BERQUIST

TRADITIONAL approaches to Israel's prophetic literature emphasized the monarchic character of the prophetic phenomenon. Prophets appeared alongside Israel's kings, and so the heyday of prophecy occurred during the monarchy, with some prolegomena shortly beforehand and an aftermath in the generation of exile, which saw the end of Israel's monarchy. Although classic scholarship has warned us not to think of post-exilic prophets as "men of the Silver Age" in contradistinction to the prophets of the more valuable "golden" age of the monarchy,¹ the post-exilic age was itself a limitation to prophecy. The rise and fall of the kingdoms of Israel and Judah were epic in scope, empowering grand tales of heroism as well as crushing defeats and vast social problems, all of which monarchic prophets could tackle and, in doing so, aspire to greatness themselves. By contrast, the post-exilic age allowed for no such grandeur; "the period after the return was neither clear nor great."² The prophets of the period were thus inevitably diminished, in comparison to those of the monarchy. These approaches tend to contain other assumptions, and may even portray prophets as "great men" who opposed the kings of their time; as such, prophets rise to greatness only when there are strong (if wicked) kings as antagonists. The murkier politics of the post-exilic age rarely allow such heroic contrasts.

More recent understandings of ancient Israel's development cast the Persian period (538–333 B.C.E.) in a different light, recognizing the formative aspects of this post-exilic period in strongly shaping the religious and cultural character of the subsequent community. Jerusalem and its surrounding territory formed a province called Yehud within the Persian Empire, and local administrators (several of whom appear by name within the corpus of the Hebrew Bible) managed the political and social affairs of the people and the region. Key among the accomplishments of the post-exilic community of Yehud was the development of an Israelite or Judean (and eventually Jewish) identity, based on ancient historical and religious traditions from the previous several centuries, including the monarchies of Israel and Judah. This newly shaped identity served to unite

the cultures and social interests of disparate groups, such as those whose ancestors had remained in the Jerusalem area and those who were moving to Jerusalem from life in Babylonia or Persia. This hybrid group formed a new self-identity, claiming common roots for the entire group and portraying a history that explained why these people had various connections to lands as disparate as Syria-Palestine, Egypt, and Mesopotamia.

This process of building identity influenced strongly the textual tradition that enlarged earlier writings into a more established set of documents. In other words, the Persian period began with conflicting groups in Yehud, some of whom were native to the Jerusalem area and some who had recently immigrated from Babylonia or Persia, and who contested with and among each other how the community should understand itself. By the end of the Persian period, Yehud exists as a relatively unified social entity with better-defined religious practices and social customs, including the operation of a Second Temple for religious life and the presence of a number of Hebrew texts that would eventually form the core of the enduring canon. These changes occurred over the two centuries of Persian imperial control, and the growing communal self-identity in this time registers multiple influences of imperialism.

Prophetic literature retains and communicates for subsequent generations the memory of God's speech to the people, especially in matters of social importance and ethical behavior, but also in concepts of theological understanding and religious practice. As such, prophetic literature has great power to shape the identity of a people, bringing them a sense of being closer to God and rooting their community in an experience of God, both historical and contemporaneous. In the Persian period, the production of prophetic literature, remembering prophets of earlier periods in Israelite and Judean history, occurred at the same time that new prophets were proclaiming oracles and utterances of God relevant to the situations of their time. Prophecy and prophetic literature, although two separate phenomena, both transpired in Yehud, and contributed to the shaping of a new public identity for the Yehudite community.

PERSIAN YEHUD

Scholars use the term "Persian Period" (or "Achaemenid Period," which names the ruling imperial family) to indicate the years of 539–333 B.C.E., during which the Persian Empire ruled a vast territory that reached from Mesopotamia to include, at times, both Egypt to the west and parts of India to the east. It was successor and heir to the Babylonian Empire, but with a geographic extent several times greater. The size, however, was not the most significant difference. Persia varied from Babylonia quite remarkably in administrative policy and practice. Although both empires used military conquest and population redistribution to control and profit from their territories and populaces, the Persian Empire employed a larger non-military governmental structure than previous empires, in order to increase political tribute through a system of provinces and governors, to raise taxes and tariffs (especially on trade throughout the empire), and to

enhance productivity through the management of resources designed to intensify the yield of crops and goods. The net result was an imperial bureaucracy that was less distant from and more visible to average citizens, yet without the fear and threat associated with more strictly military enforcement of imperial goals. Although it would obscure the reality of ancient Persia to depict its empire as benign or peaceful, it probably would have been experienced by most as less conflictual and less often violent. At times, the imperial center sought ways to enhance the autonomy of the peripheral provinces and to govern in a way that would meet the approval of the local populaces, as long as the provinces still met imperial goals.

As a result, the province of Yehud (as the area around Jerusalem was known) responded to the imperial domination of Persia in a very different way than their ancestors had described Egyptian, Assyrian, or Babylonian imperial power. Whereas biblical texts (that is, the extant political, religious, and cultural texts from ancient Israel and Judah) depicted earlier empires as evil or as unwitting divine tools to punish the chosen people, the Yehudite prophetic texts of the Persian period represented the empire as a power with which cooperation would be possible, and at times a power that had Yehud's best interests in mind. God and the Persian Empire could collaborate for the good of the people of Yehud. Within this worldview, prophecy encouraged the community to hold fast to its values without succumbing to fear of the other or despair of the community's future.

The Persian Empire expanded from its previous homeland in Persia through its conquest of the Babylonian Empire, with a decisive victory in 539 B.C.E. The leader of the army, Cyrus, became the first Persian emperor, after twenty years of battle on an ever-increasing scale. His reign until 530 B.C.E. did not experience significant administrative change; the shifts in imperial bureaucratic strategy were not immediate. However, Cyrus relaxed restrictions on travel within the empire, allowing persons and ethnic groups a greater degree of mobility than they had enjoyed under the Babylonian Empire, including the possibility of migration to ancestral homelands. Likewise, the second emperor of Persia, Cambyses, who reigned from 530 to 522 B.C.E., functioned more as a military general than as a political leader. Cambyses' battles included a major campaign against Egypt, and so Persian attention during this decade focused on its southwestern borders, including Yehud, more than in Cyrus's time. Imperial succession after Cambyses was difficult, with most of 522 B.C.E. spent in a dispute before the accession of the third emperor, Darius, who was from a different line within the Achaemenid family.

Darius governed the Persian Empire from 522 to 486 B.C.E., more than twice as long as the first two emperors combined. During Darius's time, a new shape for Persian imperial administration emerged. Darius did not operate predominantly as a military general, but developed a governmental system of provinces, tribute, taxes, and trade. This less direct control (compared to military intervention and conquest) involved significant investment in local rulers within provinces. Whereas Babylonian Jews had been allowed to emigrate to Jerusalem and Yehud during the earlier years of the Persian Empire, now there was an intentional imperial effort to construct and support local rulers in Jerusalem, including persons who would be received by the natives and immigrants

alike, yet would remain loyal to Persian imperial goals for the region. In particular, the empire provided funding for the construction or repair of numerous temples throughout different provinces, and Yehud seems to have followed this pattern. A temple in Jerusalem (known as the Second Temple, after Solomon's temple, which stood from approximately 964 to 586 B.C.E.) had been allowed, and construction seems to have begun in 525 B.C.E. However, delays ensued. Darius's administration provided additional support, with construction recommencing in 521 and completion and dedication in 516/515 B.C.E. The temple provided a center for Yehud's common life, unifying the people and clearly designating Jerusalem as the capital for the province, and the temple also allowed for a locus of political control under the auspices of the Persian Empire.

The emperor Xerxes (486–465 B.C.E.) oversaw a time of centralization of Persian imperial authority. As such, support for more local activities waned, and more of the resources shifted from peripheral provinces to the imperial center. The beginning of wars with Greece moved Persian attention to the northwestern borders instead of the southwestern areas of Yehud and Egypt. This long trend continued under Artaxerxes I (465–423 B.C.E.), the fifth emperor. As the Greek wars escalated, the imperial attitude toward its western reaches bifurcated into military intervention in the northwest and neglect in the southwest, which often resulted in somewhat increased autonomy. Quite possibly, the work of Ezra and Nehemiah should be understood in this context; Yehud's governors and leaders, with a general influence of regional autonomy strengthening their independence, were able to reassert local laws, shift toward tightened social boundaries for the community, and rebuild infrastructure and defense such as the Jerusalem wall.

After Artaxerxes I, the Persian influence on Yehud becomes much less clear. The most likely explanation is that imperial attention declined and the practical effects of increased autonomy resulted in Yehud's disengagement from political affairs at an imperial level. In such a case, a more inward focus could well account for the relative lack of literature to survive the period. For ninety years, a series of four more Persian emperors (Darius II, Artaxerxes II, Artaxerxes III, and Darius III) continued military conflict with the west, together with policies of increasing centralization, creating fewer effects of the imperial power on the southwestern provinces.

PROPHETS DURING THE PERSIAN PERIOD

Several of the prophets of the Hebrew Bible operated during the Persian period, in the province of Yehud or elsewhere. In some cases, such as Haggai and Zechariah 1–8, this context is an explicit claim of the text. For other prophets, scholarly consensus places the prophet within the historical setting of the Achaemenid era; this latter group includes Isaiah 56–66, Zechariah 9–14, and Malachi. These prophets reflect the historical and social setting of the first half of the Persian Empire, between Cyrus and Artaxerxes I.

As with the prophetic texts of any other era within Israelite history, it is difficult to identify broad thematic or stylistic features that would determine a literary period.

However, Persian-period prophecy often sustains its argument through original combinations of earlier motifs, phrases, and concerns. These prophetic texts demonstrate an awareness of and facility with earlier Israelite religious texts, prophetic and otherwise. Deutero-Isaiah combines creation and Exodus motifs to describe God's new action in moving the people from Babylon to Yehud (Isa 43:1–7). Trito-Isaiah integrates earlier Isaianic traditions with language specific to priestly texts. Haggai uses both Exodus terminology and fertility language (Hag 1:9–11; 2:22) to show how YHWH's goals and Persian imperial motivations work together. Zechariah argues for a fused religious/political leadership model (Zech 3–4). Malachi interweaves divergent priestly traditions, and is the first to merge tithes and offerings (Mal 3:8). In these and other ways, each text of prophecy in Yehud shows the mixing of language and text, as well as the shifting alliances possible within a new, post-exilic cultural setting.

Isaiah 40–55

The chapters attributed to the prophet Deutero-Isaiah reflect a historical setting in Babylonia, perhaps shortly before Cyrus's victory in 539 B.C.E. or immediately thereafter. It is best to understand the context as a reflection of the Babylonian Empire's end, with Persia appearing either as Babylonia's challenger or as the new empire in the process of establishing itself. Much of Isaiah's oracles focus on problems specific to life in Babylonia, such as idolatry and the manufacture of idols (Isa 40:19–20; 44:9–20; 45:16; 46:1–2; 48:5). The worship of YHWH demands the rejection of idols, especially those to Babylonian deities such as Bel and Nebo (Isa 46:1). YHWH is described particularly as the only God who can rescue or save (Isa 40:21; 41:22–23; 42:9; 43:9; 44:7–8; 45:21; 46:7; 47:13). This salvation involves the reconstitution of Zion, the mountain of Jerusalem, as a center for religious life (Isa 40:1–2; 41:27; 49:8–14; 52:1–2, 7–10). This is a new thing that only YHWH can perform (Isa 42:9; 43:18–21).

The religious emphasis of Deutero-Isaiah, however, combines with a *Realpolitik*. Three times, these chapters specifically name Cyrus, the first Persian emperor, as God's anointed (or "messiah") who will enact God's salvation for the benefit of the people of Yehud. Cyrus is the "shepherd" of God who will establish Jerusalem, rebuild the temple, and fulfill YHWH's purpose (Isa 44:28). YHWH has grasped Cyrus's right hand and has called him messiah (Isa 45:1). YHWH will support Cyrus in his imperial efforts to free the exiles and build the city of Jerusalem (Isa 45:13). This detailed assistance for a foreign emperor is unparalleled; together, YHWH and Cyrus will work for the good of Yehud.

Haggai

The book of Haggai indicates that the prophet's activity occurred during August through December of 520 B.C.E. This rather brief period focused the prophet's discourse on the issues surrounding the temple construction and other political matters of the time.

Haggai provides substantial support to the Persian-appointed governor, Zerubbabel (Hag 2:23), as well as a series of direct statements that demonstrate the necessity of constructing the temple (Hag 1:2, 8, 12; 2:3, 9, 15, 18). The construction of the temple will allow Yehud to experience peace (Hag 2:9), despite the nearby Persian army (Hag 2:6–7). Likewise, participation in the construction will lead to agricultural fertility and abundance (Hag 2:19). Temple construction is the choice of both YHWH and the Persian Empire, and it is a plan for Yehud's good.

Zechariah 1–8

The next canonical prophet, Zechariah, overlapped slightly with Haggai but continued later, with references in chapters 1–8 dated to 520–518 B.C.E. In these chapters, Zechariah presents visions demonstrating YHWH's devotion to Jerusalem (Zech 1:14–17, 18–21), despite the presence of horses and warriors to the north. Although the army was nearby, prosperity and not destruction would follow for Jerusalem and Yehud (Zech 2:1–5). Zechariah also focuses on issues of leadership in the community of Yehud, especially involving a high priest, Joshua, and a governor, Zerubbabel (Zech 3–4). Both of them appear to be Persian-born Jews now resident in Jerusalem, where religion and politics come together with God's desire and the Persian Empire's support for the protection of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 56–66

The final chapters of Isaiah, Isaiah 56–66, sometimes called Trito-Isaiah or Third Isaiah, are more difficult to place in certain historical context. Some scholars attach these chapters to Deutero-Isaiah, with which these passages share thematic and poetic links. However, these last eleven chapters describe some attitudes that differ from those of Deutero-Isaiah in Cyrus's early years, which argues for a slightly later date. Perhaps it is best to focus on the divergent views about the temple construction in this prophecy. Some voices support the temple project (Isa 60:1–3, 13–15), especially as a reform of the local religious practices that veered too close to idolatry or fertility religion (Isa 57:5–10; 65:1–7). But other voices describe the temple construction as wholly unnecessary; God does not need a humanly constructed dwelling place on earth (Isa 66:1–6). The priests who desire a temple have become evil rather than protecting the interests of the whole people (56:9–57:2; 59:3–15). In harsh terms, Trito-Isaiah reflects a time of social division about the benefits and detractions of a temple in Jerusalem. This conflict perhaps is most understandable if it occurred during the time of the temple's construction itself, in 525–515 B.C.E. Early in Darius's reign, during 520–515 B.C.E., the empire encouraged the completion of the temple construction project. During these years, the temple construction would have required immense resources from the community of Yehud, even though much of the funding would have come from the Persian Empire. The building project

would have been a disruptive daily presence in the city, and the rearrangements of society to complement the new temple as a center of Yehudite life would have been increasingly obvious to all segments of the populace. Trito-Isaiah describes the inevitably conflicted opinions that would attend such construction, and provides a glimpse into social unrest and disagreement that accompanied even such a formative moment in Israelite and Yehudite history. As a whole, the prophecy of Trito-Isaiah encourages intermediation or reconciliation between divided groups and their ideological perspectives, and so the prophetic message charts a delicate course that honors difference while attempting to move the society forward in the direction of a new temple community.

Malachi

The book of Malachi represents the voice of prophecy during Xerxes' reign, quite possibly in its early years (perhaps 485–480 B.C.E.). Such a context for Malachi is contested within scholarship, with opinions ranging from monarchy to late post-exilic dating. Whereas Haggai argues for the construction of the temple and Trito-Isaiah portrays social conflict over its construction, Malachi's interests are in the continued funding of operations for a temple already built. This argues for a context well after the construction project of 525–515 B.C.E., and instead early in Xerxes' time, when imperial support for provincial temples declined substantially throughout the empire as a result of imperial policy changes. The years of Darius's investments in local cultural and political institutions had ended, and the Jerusalem temple began to experience operational difficulties. Malachi responded with a call to raise funds for the temple, but also to improve the standards of priestly functioning. In particular, Malachi requested that the priests follow the covenant of Levi (Mal 2:4), but also envisioned a stronger role for laity, especially in providing the resources needed for correct worship.

LATER PROPHETS

The Hebrew Bible contains other prophetic texts that may reflect a very late Persian time frame but probably suggest a Hellenistic context. For instance, Zechariah 9–14 (sometimes called Deutero-Zechariah) shifts out of prophecy per se and into an apocalyptic genre. Zechariah 9:13 includes a specific reference to Greece, indicating a later time for its composition, even though many parts of the book would fit into late Persian contexts, with echoes of other Yehudite prophetic concerns such as the gathering of the people (Zech 10:6) and a condemnation of bad shepherds (Zech 10:3; 11:4). The book of Jonah is also found in the Book of the Twelve Prophets, but it is not prophetic literature in a technical sense; rather, it is a short story about a prophet. Its maritime setting points toward late Persian or Hellenistic contexts, even though its focus on Assyria is so much earlier that it seems anachronistic. The themes of pluralism fit well within late Persian

or Hellenistic themes as found in the other short stories of the era. The book of Daniel appears in English Bibles as a prophetic book, but the Hebrew canonical tradition places it as one of the writings. It too has more in common with Hellenistic short stories than with Persian prophetic texts, from the perspective of genre. Several elements of Daniel reflect a Hellenistic context, and a Maccabean understanding of the book's topic place it inevitably as one of the latest texts within the Hebrew Bible. Although these three texts cannot be considered prophecy in Yehud, they bear the marks of a literature that has inherited and transformed the interests of Yehudite prophecy.

PROPHETIC LITERATURE IN PERSIAN YEHUD

Not only did the Persian period experience new prophets with original contributions, but the two centuries of Persian rule also set the stage for the production of corpora of prophetic literature. The prophets of earlier eras had left a great heritage of religious and intellectual contributions of speech, even if scholarship has not been able to determine in all cases whether these earlier prophets' initial records were oral traditions, schools of thought, literary fragments, or drafts of larger documents. It is likely that a combination of these existed at the start of the Persian period. However, two centuries later a very different situation had come to pass. Although the major prophetic books of the Hebrew Bible may not have been in finalized canonical form by 333 B.C.E., they had each been assembled, compiled, and edited into large corpuses, each the size of a full scroll. Through the Persian period and beyond, these prophetic books were copied and preserved, although with some continuing changes.

The Hebrew canon recognizes the category of Former Prophets: Joshua, Judges, 1 and 2 Samuel, and 1 and 2 Kings. Although the English and Christian traditions more often consider these as historical books (or as the Deuteronomistic History), the designation as the Former Prophets is a meaningful one. In a sense, this historical writing forms a prophetic corpus as well, in at least two significant regards. First, these books contain stories of prophets such as Elijah, Elisha, Micaiah, Huldah, and others; in some sense, the books form a history of prophecy, showing the paths that the monarchy could have taken if the prophetic impulses had received more attention and political machinations had been more effectively resisted. Prophets are introduced as the true successors of judges and as proper direction for the people. Second, these books cover much of the same historical scope as many of the earlier monarchic prophets (those now in the Book of the Twelve or in the Major Prophets). The Deuteronomistic History forms a companion of sorts for the books more commonly understood as prophetic literature. Third, the prophetic corpuses and the Deuteronomistic History are in some ways competing explanations of the same course of events—the Israelite and Judean monarchies and their collapse. The Former Prophets depict that the evil of apostasy was the cause of the political downfall, and thus the prophets represent a true and better form of worship and religious life.

In addition to the Deuteronomistic History, the Persian period witnessed the collection of the three Major Prophets: the books of Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel. Each of these tomes, of approximately the same length, results from the fusion of older traditions into a coherent corpus (at least, coherent by the standards of ancient literature, even if modern scholarship cannot always ascertain the reading strategies that make the books cohere). Isaiah is not only the first of these in canonical order; it is also the earliest in terms of the setting of its first parts, in the eighth century B.C.E. Isaiah may well represent the longest process of compilation, with new sections added over centuries, as well as sections such as Isaiah 36–39 (similar to 2 Kings 18–20). The eventual book of Isaiah presents a Judah-centered reading of the tradition, with First Isaiah representing a set of Judean prophecies, Second Isaiah providing a Babylonian-based desire to migrate to Jerusalem, and Third Isaiah discussing difficulties between natives and immigrants upon post-exilic settlement in the land.

Jeremiah's intentional arrangement also produces a book with substantial attention to the biography of the prophet, but concluding with many oracles against the nations. The net effect is a book that begins with a very personal recounting, but ends with international scale. In parallel, the prophet himself ends in Egypt, out of the land and representing a pre-exilic diaspora. Jeremiah combines elements of Deuteronomistic thought in ways that differ from the Deuteronomistic History, but that develop other themes of problematic worship and faith in the late days of the temple. The complicated textual history of the Masoretic and Septuagint versions of Jeremiah indicates that the tradition was still under construction in the Persian period, although it likely had settled into separate traditions at some point in the early Hellenistic era.

Likewise, Ezekiel moves from a personal set of narratives about the prophet to a more distant vision about a future new city and new land in Ezekiel 40–48. City and temple issues pervade the book, but the movement begins in Babylonian exile, turning to Jerusalem or Yehud only in the imagination. The return and transformation of the priesthood is shown as more positive than in (Trito-) Isaiah's corpus.

The final prophetic corpus in formation during the Persian period is known now as the Book of the Twelve Prophets, Hosea through Malachi in current canons. These twelve books show the signs of editing into a single collection, and scholars have increasingly recognized the situation of these as individual books reflecting older traditions about distinct periods and yet simultaneously a collection that has intertextual reflections on itself. Historically, the Twelve range from the eighth century (with Hosea and Amos as contemporaries of Isaiah) to the Persian period prophets of Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, thus showing a chronological sweep parallel to the book of Isaiah. As a whole, the Book of the Twelve values diaspora and universalism (or at least internationalism) more so than the other prophetic literatures. All nations are held accountable, and by the end, YHWH is worshiped throughout the world (Mal 1:11).

Through the Persian period, the long and varied prophetic traditions of ancient Israel and Judah had been arranged, along with the more contemporary voices of Persian period prophets, into these five prophetic corpora (the Deuteronomistic History, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Book of the Twelve), offering an array of perspectives and

characters engaged in historical reflection, ethical consideration, the promotion of right worship practices, and the making of meaning. All of them focus on the central issues of identity in the Persian period: how to understand the community's history, how to value the relative contributions of politics and religion, how to build a community that both lives and worships together, and how to understand broad international and imperial context for the local community. Together, these prophetic literatures represent an enduring achievement of Yehud in the Persian period, building upon their experience as well as the traditions they inherited.

THE LINGERING EFFECTS OF PROPHECY IN YEHUD

Earlier generations of scholarship opined about the “end of prophecy” in or after the Persian period. Certainly, large prophetic corpora such as Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel did not continue to be composed after this time, but that hardly indicates that prophecy was at an end. The energies of Yehudite prophecy moved into different directions with great effect.

First, prophecy in Yehud bridged the experiences of monarchic and exilic prophets with the means of preserving their insights and contributions for later generations. Although some of the earlier prophetic texts may well have been written (perhaps in fragmentary forms) by the end of the exile, the two centuries of the Persian Empire provided the foundations for the writing of long-form texts such as the prophetic corpora. The prophets of Yehud existed alongside this canonical (or at least archival) impulse, and surely there were interwoven concerns. The Yehudite prophets demonstrate an awareness of earlier prophetic (and other religious) texts, the themes of which are often brought together by the creative work of these prophets. At the same time, the continuing relevance of older prophetic themes for new cultural reappropriation and meaning matched the need to maintain the older texts as well. In other words, prophecy existed both as developing tradition and as preserved text during this period, and we should not assume that one of these modes existed to the exclusion or without the influence of the other.

Second, the desire to hear and to proclaim a word from God, with close connection to and application for current political settings, in no way dissipated during the Persian period. Indeed, this function of prophecy only expanded. The prophetic word of God formed a basis for the apocalyptic vision of God, which grew as a genre in subsequent eras (and onward into Jewish and Christian expressions such as Merkabah mysticism and the book of Revelation). At the same time, prophecy was also democratized in the teachings of priests and sages (and later midrash and preaching), with applications that were accessible to all people, not directed only to the monarchs, politicians, and elites

who were the audience of older prophetic texts. Christianity and Islam maintained traditions of prophets for centuries after the Persian period, and Jewish traditions of mystics and visionaries should be seen as a very closely related phenomenon. These forms of prophecy did not end in the Persian period; these energies dispersed, continued, and grew.

NOTES

1. Gerhard von Rad, *Old Testament Theology, Volume II: The Theology of Israel's Prophetic Traditions*, OTL (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1965), 278.
2. Von Rad, *Old Testament Theology*, II: 279.

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CHAPTER 5

PROPHECY AND APOCALYPTIC

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BEGINNING in exilic and post-exilic times, a new apocalyptically oriented type of prophecy emerged. Scholars continue to argue over definitions and characterizations, but most researchers of late Israelite prophecy discern in this era significant shifts in genre, world-view, and patterns of prophetic revelation and intermediation. “Proto-apocalyptic” texts reflecting such changes appear in Third Isaiah (Isa 56–66), Ezekiel 38–39, Joel, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, all late sixth- and early to mid-fifth-century B.C.E. scriptural corpora. In a later era, around 165 B.C.E., a full-blown apocalypse appears as the book of Daniel (treated in Chapter 13 of this *Handbook*).

A RADICAL NEW USE OF MYTHOLOGY

Central among the new directions in post-exilic prophecy is a recrudescence of mythic images/archetypes known from across the ancient Near East. (Archetypes are existentially significant symbols or motifs constantly recurring, even cross-culturally, in human myths, dreams, and sacred art.) Behind the end-time chaos-serpent of Isaiah 27:1, for example, lies the wriggling sea-dragon of creation mythology (Ps 74:13–14; Isa 51:9; cf. the seven-headed twisting sea-serpent of Ugaritic myth, CAT 1.3 III 40–42). Another archetype in Isaiah 27:1 is the fantastic animate sword known from Genesis 3:24.

In apocalyptic prophecy, what happened in primordial time (*Urzeit*) repeats itself in the end-time (*Endzeit*). *Protology* becomes *eschatology*. That is, creation mythology is “eschatologized,” so that, as Job Jindo observes, the “mythical framework is believed to unfold in concrete, historical incidents.” The world “becomes an arena where the cosmic struggle of order and chaos occurs according to the pattern predestined at the time of creation. . . . There is only one pattern: chaos is doomed to be defeated” (Jindo 2005: 412).

Mythological thinking posits a fundamental *continuity* of nature and divinity. The chaos-serpent, although subdued by God, cyclically breaks its chains, and earth must repeatedly experience the ripple effects. Apocalypticism, by contrast, expects God's definitive intervention to short-circuit the cycle. The Divine Warrior of yore breaks into history from above the fray of earth's multiverse of immanent powers (Isa 27:1). "In the new world," Hermann Gunkel observes, the timeless "ancient battle shall not occur again."¹

Stepping out from the realm of transcendence, far above, the Divine Warrior wins a new sort of victory, discontinuous with all timeless cycles. God easily puts down the mythic forces of chaos and evil that have manifested outside their atemporal framework. Now incarnate, they are vulnerable to definitive defeat in real time. Realistic and tangible, all wiggling dragons collapse before God's permanent reign—Kingdom Come.

An apocalyptic lens reveals life's contradictions—its foundational oppositions—splitting, polarizing, and coming to a head. The binary dualisms of mythology (life/death, drought/rain, pure/impure, good/evil, light/darkness) become concretized, collide head on, and reach permanent resolution. To take one example, in Persian-era prophecy a hope of resurrection rises to consciousness out of deeply embedded scriptural tensions. Embodied life in earthly community is forever scripture's ideal, but, antithetically, all flesh is cursed with death. Apocalypticism's new "sheltering canopy" resolves the unbearable antithesis by revealing the bodily resurrection of the dead.

Apocalyptic prophecy refuses to give the last word in existence to history, created by humankind, but vests the meaning of existence in Absolute reality, the bailiwick of God. It finds past, present, and future cohering in an overarching divine plan, a forward historical trajectory with its goal achieved via a terrestrial impact of transcendence. The apocalyptic prophets did not lose interest in history, but envisioned history judged definitively by God. They saw the world destined for toppling and rebirth—cosmogony recapitulated. At the eschaton, the vision of Ezekiel 21:26 is fully let loose: "Everything will be changed" (NJB); "nothing will be as it was" (CEB).

The eschaton is at hand; the *end* (קץ) is near (Ezek 21:25)! The intent, however, is constructive. The real point is that God's new *beginning* is near. In the hands of Israel's new visionaries, mythic archetypes become portents signaling a new creation. Such archetypes uniquely express scripture's deepest hopes, its noblest aspirations. They convey all that is forever fervently desirable. Apocalypticism thus envisions the coming to fruition of all the goals of Israel's Torah, classical prophets, and sapiential traditions.

THE END OF PROPHECY?

Apocalypticism's rise does not spell the end of prophecy. The rabbinic corpus, however, reveals at several points a belief that, after Zechariah and Malachi, Israel entered an era when God stopped sending prophets to God's people. Especially relevant rabbinic texts expressing some such conviction include Tosefta Soṭah 13.3; Jerusalem Talmud Soṭah 9.13,

24b; Babylonian Talmud Sanhedrin 11a; Canticles Rabbah 8:9 #3; Seder 'Olam Rabbah 30. Until recently, a scholarly consensus accepted that Judaism from Second Temple times permanently shut down prophecy. For good reasons, the consensus is now questioned.

First, the influential view of Frank M. Cross that Israelite prophecy and monarchy rose and fell together cannot sustain itself. The Hebrew prophets did place checks on Israelite kingship, but this sort of specialized prophetic function should not define what counts as prophecy. The monarchic era simply harbored the necessary social conditions for the *role* of prophecy, but starting after the Exile, many came to believe that prophecy would flourish again only as the final countdown to God's reign began. They understood the community's present task as gathering up the prophets' instructions, teaching new generations the prophetic hope, and awaiting its fulfillment in Kingdom Come.

The New Testament attests that the early Jewish followers of Jesus claimed that prophecy was flourishing once again in precisely such end-time circumstances. New Testament texts celebrating an outpouring of the spirit of prophecy in John the Baptizer, Jesus, and the apostles include Matthew 11:9–14; 14:5; 16:13–14; 21:11, 26, 46; John 1:19–26, 4:19, 6:14, 7:40–52; Acts of the Apostles 11:27–28, 13:1; 1 Corinthians 12–14; Ephesians 4:11; and Revelation 1:3, 18:20.

Second, equally problematic is the view that prophecy ceased in Second Temple times due to the ascendancy of the Torah. Scholars increasingly recognize the Torah's own lively prophetic character, which allows it to stand as a canonical *partner* with prophecy. What is more, a supposed Torah-prophecy dichotomy fits too neatly with the dualistic opposition of priestly and prophetic ideal types (*Idealtypus*) developed by sociologist Max Weber (1864–1920). Scholars can no longer legitimately replay the Weberian typology, which reflected a contemporary bias in German historiography opposing priestly, institutional religion with a lively, vital impulse animating prophecy.

Even if many Jews of the Second Temple era believed that prophecy had now borne its full witness and must patiently await end-time fulfillment, the social role of prophecy did not fully cease with Zechariah, Malachi, and other Persian-era prophets. Evidence to the contrary includes texts such as Daniel 7–11, Qumran Cave 1, Peshier Habakkuk 7:4–5, references in Josephus, and the manner in which Philo likened his own inspiration to genuine prophecy. Individuals also appear in Second Temple times whom the Dead Sea Scrolls, Philo, and Josephus deem to be false prophets. One should distinguish between the closing of the prophetic canon of scripture and any supposed cessation of the social role of prophecy. Jews and Christians may readily affirm a closed canon while simultaneously allowing for modern-era prophets such as Abraham Heschel and Martin Luther King, Jr.

INTERTEXTUALITY AND APOCALYPTICISM

The Persian era saw the emergence of a new medium of revelation that relied on the mantic study and cross-referencing of Scripture. A corpus of authoritative, sacred

writings was in place by post-exilic times, to which Israel's new apocalyptic visionaries made ready reference. Apocalyptic prophecy forged a compelling new imagination from allusions to the corpus. As Marvin A. Sweeney writes, allusions "play a key role in every proto-apocalyptic text."² Consider the intertextual origins of the apocalyptic vision of Isaiah 26.

The authors of the vision of resurrection in Isaiah 26 were steeped in the Isaiah tradition. They were prodigious students of Isaiah's book, immersed in Second Isaiah's hope of new, miracle fecundity on earth. Thus, the vision of resurrection in Isaiah 26 has a demonstrable relationship with an earlier text in Isaiah 54. Isaiah 26 takes up Isaiah 54's image of the barren woman Zion receiving the miracle of offspring. It not only forwards the earlier chapter's images and themes but also repeats several of its keywords.

In Isaiah 54:1, God transforms a barren Zion, devastated by judgment. The joyful shouting (רנן) of resurrected Israelites in Isaiah 26:19 is an intertextual allusion to the earlier Isaian image of Zion shouting for joy as God overcomes her barren state. Joy at effortless fertility in Isaiah 54 becomes joy at apocalyptic victory over sterility in Isaiah 26.

As Isaiah 54 begins, Zion is plagued with sterility, having borne no child (ילד) and having no prospect of labor (חול). Isaiah 26:16–17 repeats the verbs, but gives them an intensive, *apocalyptic* spin. Zion strains toward a reversal of her barrenness, but, at first, languishes in the attempt. Pregnant and ready to deliver (ילד), she writhes (חול) with eschatological labor pangs (Isa 26:17). At first birthing only wind (Isa 26:18), she is in agony as the power of death bears down upon her.

Daughter Zion is not in labor for nothing (Isa 26:17); miracle children will be (re)born (Isa 26:19, 21). The God of history and nature is about to triumph decisively. The miraculous fertility of Isaiah 54 must blossom in mother earth, sprouting verdant, resurrected life. The Isaian vision of intimate reunion with God as husband finds fulfillment in the end-times.

Still more echoes of Isaiah 54 pervade Isaiah 26. Thus, Isaiah 26:13 complains that other lords besides God possess Zion (Isa 26:13, בעל), when God alone should be embracing Israel in marriage (בעל, Isa 54:5). The command in verse 20 to shut the doors and wait for God's judgment to pass appears to take its cue from the reference in Isaiah 54:9 to the Deluge. As Noah's family once did, Israel must now seal themselves off from the effects of God's coming wrath. The note that God's coming wrath will last but a "little while" (v 20) appears to draw on the idea in Isaiah 54:7–8 that outbursts of divine anger last but a moment (both Isa 26:20 and 54:7–8 use the term רגע).

The twice-repeated term טל ("dew") in Isaiah 26:19 also stands out, a poetic encapsulation of divine power to revive life (see esp. Hos 4:5–7 [MT: 6–8]; Ps 110:3; *KTU* 1.19 I 38–46).³ What is more, the repeated reference to the *rephaim* (רפאים; NRSV: "those long dead"; GNB: "those who have long been dead") reinforces chapter 26's emphasis on deliverance as supernatural fertility.

At ancient Ugarit and elsewhere, the *rephaim* were deified royal or heroic living-dead souls who guaranteed dynastic succession and protected their city and its

virility.⁴ To think about group identity and vitality was necessarily to think about the fate after death of these individuals. As the *rephaim* rose from the underworld, the living king of Ugarit was exalted in their gathered assembly and his subjects greatly blessed.

A “democratization” of the term in Hebrew usage allowed it to apply to all the living dead, including those of recent memory. Despite this broadening of the term’s meaning, however, language of *rephaim* continued to conjure thoughts of heroes of yore and of dead, divinized kings, not merely thoughts of the undifferentiated deceased (see 2 Sam 21:15–22; 1 Chr 20:6, 8). Isaiah 26:19 likely speaks of the rising of dead *rephaim* in part to convey nuances of Israel’s ancient founders and patrons leading a stream of rebirths up from the netherworld. Israelite founders and rulers, such as Abraham, Jacob, and Josiah, will lead the deceased children of Zion out from the burial chambers.

Such a belief fits the Persian era of the Isaiah Apocalypse. In Third Isaiah, the community explicitly laments Israel’s alienation from the living-dead souls of its founding ancestors. The people of the early restoration era are in the sorriest of straits, since “Abraham does not know us and Israel does not acknowledge us” (Isa 63:16).⁵

Earlier in Isaiah 26, we find a striking memory of the term’s older, narrower application—an understanding that it refers to the divinized royal dead (Isa 26:14; see also Isa 14:9). Verse 14 insists that God must wipe out all memory of the earthly dynasties that have oppressed Israel. Not only are living enemies slated for death (v 11), but all the deified dead will soon lie beyond the reach of their descendants’ needs. Their invocation names (זכר) will be forever abolished; the normal intervention functions of the royal shades are permanently lost. They will undergo a “death after death.”

The “death after death” of the enemy *rephaim* in verse 14 paves the way for the miracle of verse 15. God’s extermination of the royal dead allows Israel’s population to multiply dramatically and the borders of the land to extend. Just as when Israel destroyed the *rephaim* at the conquest of Canaan, the land’s present owners/occupiers must be disenfranchised. As Francesca Stavrakopoulou writes, “To destroy the dead, as this text suggests, is to replace their continued ‘life after death’ with a permanent ‘death after death’—to wipe out all memory of them. In this way, their hold on their land is released.”⁶

The souls of enemy kings will not rise to the aid of their people (v 14); they are slung away from all relevance to the living as from the hollow of a sling. Israel’s dead, by contrast, continue in remembrance and relevance (v 19). Their ancestral lands, which bind them to the world of flesh and blood, are still claimed by their lineages, and will be restored to rightful “borders” (v 15). What is more, Israel’s dead will rise re-embodied on God’s coming day. They are blessed with the hope of bodily resurrection, of returning to concrete living, breathing, communal life on earth. Scholars should not reduce the language of resurrection in Isaiah 26 to a metaphor of Israel’s political restoration. The Israelite *rephaim* of verse 19 are the remains of real individuals, bundled together with the living in God’s concern and slated for resurrection.

PRIESTLY “SECTS”: AARONIDES, ZADOKITES, AND LEVITES

The rise of early apocalypticism within Israelite religion interconnects with the advent of sectarian Judaism. The post-exilic, Persian era saw the rise of more or less clearly demarcated “parties,” each treasuring a unique group role as God’s end-time remnant within Israel. At this time, varying groups and movements, including sometimes rival priestly houses, began to solidify in new ways, each interacting uniquely with received, scriptural tradition. Each party, or sect, had its own views on key issues, such as openness to foreigners, hierarchical social divisions, the ideal nature of God’s presence with Israel, and continuity with the past, including with past applications of Torah.

The apocalyptic prophecy of the Persian era appears within all three Israelite priestly parties: the sons of Aaron, the sons of Zadok, and the sons of Levi. This tripartite clerical division (Aaronides, Zadokites, Levites) re-emerges later with particular clarity in some of the sectarian literature of Qumran. The Dead Sea Scrolls tend to speak generally of “priests,” that is, sons of Aaron, but they are aware of the Zadokites as an inner-Aaronide lineage. Thus, in the Rule of the Congregation, Zadokites and Aaronides hold priestly authority jointly. Within the Damascus Document, CD 4 understands Ezekiel 44:15 to name three separate groups: the “priests,” the Levites,” and the “sons of Zadok.”⁷

The connection with Ezekiel 44 is natural, since the temple vision in Ezekiel 40–48 attests particularly clearly to Israel’s priestly houses. Its hierarchical thinking was grounded in such distinctions and divisions. Many scholars do not notice the Aaronides in the temple vision, since the Ezekiel school refers to them only generically. Aaronides are simply “priests,” whereas Zadokites are sometimes named (Ezek 40:46; 43:19; 44:15; 48:11). The singling out of the Zadokites is occasional, however, perhaps reflecting junctures when leadership questions arose. A few “vocal” Qumran texts, likewise restricted in number, also appear to stem from times when the Zadokites asserted themselves.⁸

According to Ezekiel 48:8–12, the Aaronide priests have their own living space in God’s utopian land. This space, in turn, contains a Zadokite area (a tract adjoining the Levites’ territory). The text is ambiguous, with other translations possible, but it appears to direct that the Zadokites “shall have [their own, individual] tract out of the total [priestly] reserve of the land—a most holy tract” (see NABR, cf. NJPS).⁹ Verses 11–12, which carve out the tract, may be a gloss from a juncture of Zadokite self-assertion.

The Aaronides also have carefully demarcated areas of operation within the temple precincts. Ezekiel does not specifically name Aaronide and Zadokite subdivisions, but a clear bipartite layout of buildings allows for separate cooking and dining zones for two priestly houses (Ezek 42:13; 46:19–20). The Ezekiel school either assumes separate Aaronide lineages will occupy the two zones, or the group has put a blueprint in place for bifurcating the Aaronides should it need to buttress holiness distinctions in the temple.

Finally, Ezekiel 40:45–46 speaks of two priestly groups guarding the temple’s inner court. The unnamed priestly house, working alongside the Zadokites, must be

Aaronide, since Levites have no access to the inner court. Numbers 18:5, a Zadokite text of the Holiness School (HS), similarly distinguishes priestly altar and sanctuary duties. Unlike Ezekiel, however, HS leaves open whether to apportion the two types of duties among Eleazarites (Zadokites) and Ithamarites (Aaronides). The HS authors elevate the Eleazarites elsewhere, and may assume that altar duties fall naturally to them.¹⁰

The idea that Ezekiel 40:46b, with its Zadokite focus, refers back to both sets of priests in verses 45–46 is strained. As Tuell notes, verse 46b, with its abrupt explanatory pronoun, looks to be an interpretive gloss (in dialogue with Ezek 44) or a vigorous style defending the Zadokites' altar prerogatives.¹¹ The NJPS version rightly reads: "The priests who perform the duties of the altar—they [המה] are the descendants of Zadok." Thus, Eliezer of Beaugency (twelfth century C.E.) had it right. Ezekiel 40:45–46 attests to a middle tier of priests, present in the inner court as the Zadokites are, but with duties like those of the Levites.¹²

In what follows, I probe sample apocalyptic prophecies from each of Israel's three clerical lineages: priests, Levites, and Zadokites. The apocalypticism of the first group, the priestly/Aaronide lineage, emerges with particular clarity in Third Isaiah.

Aaronide Apocalypticism

The texts of Isaiah 56–66 preoccupy themselves both with end-time excitement and with priestly, temple-centered concerns. They revolve around ritual and worship, ceremonial purity, and adherence to priestly *torah*. Indeed, these texts assume the centrality of worship at Jerusalem's shrine atop God's holy mountain (Isa 56:5, 7; 57:13; 60:1–3, 4–9, 10–14; 62:1, 6, 9, 11; 64:10–12; 65:11, 19, 25; 66:6, 8, 10, 13, 20, 23).

Third Isaiah neither singles out the Zadokites for sacral prerogatives, as does Ezekiel's temple vision, nor understands the entire tribe of Levi to be qualified for altar service, as do Deuteronomy 18:1–8 and Malachi 2:4, 8, 10. Although the Isaiah group distinguishes Levites and priests, it ignores divisions within the latter group. Since Aaron unites in his person both Aaronides and Zadokites, the Isaiah group reasons, both lineages may function as altar ministers.

The indifference to hierarchy in Third Isaiah does not stop with Aaronides and Zadokites. Perhaps most surprising, the end-time vision of nations gathering to the temple in Isaiah 66 speaks of God making priests and Levites out of foreigners (66:21). The ambiguous syntax of verse 21 may possibly refer merely to the ordination of returning lay Israelites: "Out of those who return, I will make priests and Levites."¹³ More likely, however, is the more radical understanding in which God opens the priesthood to all nations: "I'll even take some of the foreigners [גֵּוֹיִם-מֵהֶם] and make them priests and Levites" (my paraphrase).

The rhetoric of the Hebrew strains to convince the reader that God will take priests "even from them," that is, even from foreigners.¹⁴ What is more, Isaiah 56:4–7 prepares for this apocalyptic suspension of clerical boundaries by applying to foreigners language limited to Levites in Numbers 18.¹⁵ The verb שָׁרָה in Isaiah 56:6 signals worship of the

Lord and calls to mind acts of temple service (as in Isa 60:7; 61:6). Tellingly, the Dead Sea Scrolls at Qumran Cave 1, Isaiah^a omit this verb, probably due to consternation at any implication that Gentiles might serve as temple priests. Such clerical inclusivity diametrically opposes the Zadokite position of priestly exclusivity in Numbers 18:7 (HS) and Ezekiel 44:8.

Third Isaiah's inclusive perspective here appears to develop organically out of the universalism of Aaronide (Priestly Torah, hereafter PT) portions of the Pentateuch. Texts such as Genesis 28:3 (PT) envision Jacob spawning not only the worship congregation of Israel but an entire cultic communion (קהל) of peoples ("a congregation of peoples," per Eugene H. Peterson's paraphrase¹⁶). Based on the Hebrew here, Gerhard von Rad saw "a universal eschatological cultic community of peoples."¹⁷ Genesis 35:11 (PT) is parallel. The verse foretells Jacob one day convening an international congregation (קהל גוים) of worship.

Openness to the nations correlates with the distinctive intuitions and sensibilities of *reverence* at the center of Isaian theology. Confronted with a "high and lofty one who inhabits eternity" (Isa 57:15; cf. Isa 66:1–2, 18), the Isaiah school eschews hierarchy and embraces profound humility and tolerance. When one is overcome by awe before God's otherness, "You feel . . . that your mind is dwarfed . . . that you had best keep your mouth closed and your mind open," writes Paul Woodruff in his book *Reverence* (2001: 147).

True reverence even proves itself more powerful than sectarian divisions. Woodruff insists that "creeds have come and gone . . . but reverence lives on." To become truly reverent is to affirm others' reverence, even the reverence of those with differing backgrounds and creeds. "Reverence . . . cannot take a stand on fine points of belief" (2001: 132–133).

As noted, such a sensibility of reverence stands in tension with Zadokite ("holiness") views (e.g., Num 18:7; Ezek 44:8). There is even some evidence, at Isaiah 66:5, that the Aaronides' stance of awe provoked opposition from "brothers," perhaps brother priests—the Zadokites. At some point, according to this verse, these brothers came to "hate" and "exclude" the Isaiah group. Isaiah 66:5 appears to quote a rival group taunting the Isaiah group for their hopes for awe, hopes for a coming fearsome manifestation of divine presence. The group's rivals scoff, "Let the LORD manifest His Presence, So that we may look upon your joy" (Isa 66:5 NJPS, cf. NJB, NABR). For the expectation of awe at issue, see, for example, Isaiah 59:19; 60:13; 66:18.

The identification of the Isaiah group as "tremblers" (חרדים) in 66:5 now comes into focus. The Aaronides felt awe before God and proclaimed an apocalyptic message of soul-shaking dread at God's coming manifestation. As Joseph Blenkinsopp has discerned, the book of Ezra reveals more information about the "trembler" group (Ezra 9:4; 10:3). They appear as Ezra's supporters and colleagues in his reforms of post-exilic Judah. Like him, they are oriented toward the priestly *torah* and the temple's sacrificial regimen. In reforming post-exilic society, the group encourages separation from idolatry and making a reparation offering (אשם; Ezra 10:19; cf. Isa 53:10).¹⁸

Isaiah 66:18b–21 does not fit hierarchical Zadokite theology, but neither does it fit with Levitical thinking. We have a clear idea of how Levitical apocalyptic thinking of

the Persian era looked, thanks to the inclusion in the scriptural canon of the book of Malachi (see the discussion later in this chapter). The Levite authors of Malachi certainly proffered no newly inclusive vision of the priesthood in the manner of Isaiah 66. Rather, they upheld God's carefully defined covenant with Levi (Mal 2:4; cf. Deut 18:5; 33:8–11; Jer 33:17–22). The altar priests of Malachi's time (mid-fifth century B.C.E.) seemed to him in violation of this priestly covenant, so he proclaims them in an accursed state (Mal 2:9).

Isaiah 66 appears specifically to engage the presentation of the covenant with Levi in Jeremiah 33.¹⁹ In an apocalyptic suspension of the very foundation of the Levites' priestly house, the Isaian Aaronides overturn the Levitical covenant's permanence and exclusivity (Jer 33:20–21). Tellingly, Isaiah 66:21 uses the terms "priests" and "Levites" found in Jeremiah 33:21 in a notably alternative manner. "Priests" is an individual subject in Isaiah 66:21; priests *and* Levites serve God as distinctive groups.²⁰ In Jeremiah 33:21, by contrast, the "priests" mentioned are merely Levi's descendants in general. Just as David will always have a descendent on the throne, descendants of Levi will always be God's priests.²¹ As the NET translates, "David will by all means always have a descendant to occupy his throne as king and the Levites will by all means always have priests who will minister before me."

Zadokite Apocalypticism

A fine example of a Zadokite apocalyptic text occurs in Zechariah 3, a vision of the cleansing of the Zadokite chief priest Joshua. The text represents an addition to the cycle of apocalyptic visions (Zech 1:7–6:15) forming the bulk of First Zechariah (Zech 1–8). The cycle dates from the early restoration era (520–518 B.C.E.), received by the prophet in the second regnal year of the Persian monarch Darius I (Zech 1:1, 7). It aimed to motivate temple reconstruction work, looking to the apocalyptic return of God's glory, the fostering of a holy land and a holy people, and the dawn of a new age.

Arising in a supportive milieu of international calm, Zechariah's apocalyptic texts cannot be considered a means of coping with geopolitical disruptions or imperial restrictions. His apocalypticism actually arose out of the stability brought by Darius. Interested in maximizing revenues from Yehud, Darius had slated the province for demographic and economic development. His policies allowed Zechariah to implement a temple-oriented apocalyptic action plan. This was an opportunity to get sacral structures in place that could prefigure and launch God's radical epiphany on earth.

Zechariah was a Zadokite priest aligned with the prophecies of Ezekiel and the Holiness School. This literature prioritizes a sacral wholeness of people and land centered in God's indwelling, anthropomorphically conceived. Zechariah was eventually priest-in-charge of an entire priestly household, the clan of his grandfather Iddo (Neh 12:16; cf. Zech 1:1, 7; Ezra 5:1; 6:14; 1 Esdr 6:1), which he probably accompanied home from Exile (cf. Neh 12:4).

The vision of Zechariah 3 may hint that other priestly sects of the restoration era doubted the Zadokites' worthiness. Emerging out of the profanity of foreign exile, were they really fit to resume their temple offices? The filthy garments of verse 4 represent all the exiles' uncleanness (cf. Ezek 4:13–14), but also signify the Zadokites' particular guilt (cf. Ezek 8). Some decades later, Malachi will complain bitterly about the temple's altar priests, imaging them smeared with dung (Mal 2:3). His image diametrically opposes that of Zechariah 3, which relieves Joshua of his filth/excrement [צואים]-covered clothes (vv 3–4).

As Zechariah 3 begins, Chief Priest Joshua is standing before the heavenly council. He has assumed the role of "the Priest" in Ezekiel's vision of God's utopian temple (Ezek 45:18–20), the figure most closely approximating a chief/high priest within Ezekiel 40–48.²² Like this figure, who officiates over national atonement each spring, Joshua stands alone before God to expiate the uncleanness of Israel. His re-clothing symbolizes God's end-time cleansing of both the Zadokite priesthood and the entire community. But it does more. In dialogue with Ezekiel 21:25–27, Zechariah 3 signals the advent of the messianic age.

As Judah crumbled at Babylonia's approach, Ezekiel had proclaimed in 21:25–27 (MT: vv 30–32) that "turban" and "crown" would now vanish from the land: "Remove the turban, take off the crown." Judah would see an inversion of life as everyone had known it. "Nothing shall be as it was!" (NABR). Moving us through and beyond this scenario of inversion, Zechariah brings back both priestly turban and royal crown in twin passages: Zechariah 3 ("turban," v 5) and Zechariah 6:9–15 ("crown," v 14).²³ The prophet depicts an apocalyptic movement through chaos to new, resurrected life.

Realizing the paired status of Zechariah 3 and Zechariah 6:9–15 reinforces a second shared parallelism of the texts. Each of the two passages elevates Priest Joshua while simultaneously announcing the advent of a Davidic leader termed the "Branch" (Zech 3:8; 6:12). The use of the Branch image, rather than the name of a contemporary civic leader (such as Zerubbabel), points ahead to an anticipated, ideal ruler—one who fulfills Ezekiel 17:22–24 (cf. Ezek 29:21; Jer 23:5; 33:15; Ps 132:17).

Ezekiel had employed an archetype of a "tender twig" (17:22) to insist on a messiah who will invert all expectations. His ideal Davidide is no egoistic Machiavellian prince, but a humble, sensitive ruler (77, 17:22). Zechariah adopts this modest messiah.

Ezekiel 21:25–27, where turban and crown are lost, alludes directly to Genesis 49:10–12. Ezekiel redeploys the language in Genesis 49 about waiting a full measure of time until God sets things right (Ezek 21:27). When Zechariah 3 and Zechariah 6 envision turban and crown restored, Genesis 49:10–12 again makes a showing. This time it supports the ideal of a reposed, peaceable Davidide—a fresh sprig. Zechariah's messianic "Branch" is the archetypal instance of Genesis 49's humble king, who rides a foal. He is a fulfillment of Ezekiel 21:26's exaltation of the low and abasement of the high. The Dead Sea Scroll text 4Q252 connects the same dots, understanding Genesis 49:10 to refer to "the Messiah . . . the *Branch*."

Zechariah 3:8–9 cautions Joshua and his priestly colleagues against any aspirations of Zadokite hegemony. God's ideal polity in Zechariah is a diarchic rule, with Davidide/

Branch and Chief Priest holding each other in check. We might have expected such a pattern based on the atonement rite in Ezekiel 45, where “the Priest” works in concert with a Davidic head, a נָשִׂיא (“chieftain”), who provides the needed offerings for the atonement.²⁴ Zechariah 4 epitomizes the book’s diarchic standard with its vision of paired olive trees (4:3, 11–14). Zechariah 6 drives the standard home with its two crowns of authority (עֲטֻרוֹת, v 11; cf. NABR, NJPS), the second reserved for the “Branch” and kept in the temple as a portent (6:14). Dispelling any doubt that Zechariah 6 maintains a diarchic ideal, verse 13 proclaims peace between *two* figures (שְׁנֵיהֶם; cf. NET, NABR, NJB, NJPS).

Verses 8–9 of Zechariah 3 concerning the coming Branch do more than advocate for an ideal diarchic polity. Erhard S. Gerstenberger notes that the mere use of the archetype “Branch” represents a “presentiment” of radical developments; he speaks of a “tense future expectation” in the Branch texts. “Clearly, Yahweh’s rule is to commence soon, and the Judean community will be completely restored” (Gerstenberger 2011: 199).

Like other editorial additions to the vision cycle (Zech 1:14–17; 2:6–13; 4:6–10a; 6:9–15), Zech 3:8–10 puts the emphasis on messianic vigilance. The temple’s inner cabinet must keep focused on the leader to come, the Branch. They must act as “men of portent,” perhaps meaning that their apocalyptic fervor must be a sign to others (cf. Ezek 12:3–15; 24:15–27). Alternatively, the portents at issue may be such symbols as the Branch’s unclaimed crown (Zech 6:14) and God’s hand-engraved endorsement laid within the stone with seven eyes—God’s eyes (Zech 3:9).²⁵

The stone of Zechariah 3:9 appears to be the selfsame object that Zechariah 4:7, 9 envisions used in the temple’s construction. The eyes identify it with God’s real presence, which will indwell the entire temple complex anthropomorphically (the same eyes appear in Zech 4:10; cf. Ezek 1:18; 10:12). As Marko Jauhiainen writes, “The emphasis on the temple-building project in Zechariah and the important antecedent ‘single stone’ texts (e.g., Gen 28:22; Ps 118:22; Isa 8:14; 28:16) probably tip the balance in favour of associating the stone with the future temple that the Branch will build (6:12–13)” (2005: 45 n. 46).

The stone, which God now sets as a portent before Chief Priest Joshua (Zech 3:9), is the temple’s foundation stone, the “first stone” (NABR)—probably the archetypal primeval stone capping earth’s subterranean waters of chaos.²⁶ The stone’s inscription, according to ancient Near Eastern custom, names the building’s royal patron, the messianic Branch. It is likely written on a tin plate for placement in the stone as a dedication. Zechariah 4:10 may thus declare that the stone’s seven eyes “will joyfully look on the tin tablet in Zerubbabel’s hand” when he sets the foundation deposit (NET).

Levitical Apocalypticism

As a final example of Persian-era apocalyptic prophecy, consider a text from the Levitical/Deuteronomic tradition, Malachi 2:10–12. The passage appears among the disputations of Malachi, a prophetic voice of protest from within the Levitical ranks

of Jerusalem's post-exilic temple staff. Malachi picks up and continues the story of the post-exilic temple from Zechariah, but the book's thought diverges markedly from the preceding Zadokite prophecies. The canon rightly presents it as a distinct book.

The ancient Masoretes used paragraph markers to divide Malachi into three major sections plus an appendix. Both the Leningrad Codex (L) and the Aleppo Codex (A) show the same demarcations of structure. The Masoretic scheme makes Malachi 2:10–12 the literary center of the book, a compelling interpretation since these verses echo Israel's core covenantal affirmation (Deut 6:4) and illustrate the current neglect of the covenant: welcoming in the alien gods of foreign wives (Deut 6:14; 7:4).

Catalyzed by the prophesying of Haggai and Zechariah in 520 B.C.E., temple reconstruction was completed by 515. By Malachi's time (some twenty-five to fifty-five years later), however, enthusiasm about the achievement had worn off. The rebuilding had not ushered in an ideal age. Indeed, the governors of Yehud had ceased even to be members of David's line. Everyone seems to have lost any watchfulness about God's coming reign.

Factors contributing to the religious situation excoriated by Malachi include Persian pluralism, a revival of pre-exilic syncretism and occult practices (Isa 57:4–8; 65:3–5; 66:17; Zech 13:2), and failures of civic leadership (Zech 10:2–3; 11:16; Ezra 9:2). A depressed economy (Mal 3:10) and a shaken confidence in Persian stability abetted a mood of cynicism about God's election and care. Darius I had initiated a period of calm and imperial benefaction, but the future was called into question by the Persian defeat at Marathon in 490 B.C.E. and the subsequent revolts against Xerxes in Egypt (485) and Babylon (484 and 482). In all this, Malachi's chief concerns turned on failures, complacency, and corruption associated with temple worship.

Troubles among the altar priests were not unique to Malachi's time. His predecessor Zechariah had struggled to fortify the priests with hope for a new age (Zech 3:8–9; 6:12–14), apparently to no avail (see the priests' language at Isa 66:5, noted earlier). Some years after Malachi's work, Ezra's mission to eliminate false worship in Yehud set him against some of the temple leadership involved in syncretism (Ezra 9:1; 10:18–24; cf. Isa 66:3; Zech 12:13). Nehemiah, too, felt compelled to reform the priesthood (Neh 13:4–9) and to insist on the Levites receiving tithes (Neh 13:10–13; cf. Neh 10:37–39; Mal 3:8–12).

Malachi countered the current malaise of his times with a series of disputations informed by an imagination at once both Levitical and apocalyptic. His was a quarrel between power-sharing factions among Yehud's ruling circles, not a struggle between the fringe and the establishment. From within the ranks of the central temple's staff (see, e.g., Mal 2:4–6), Malachi sounded an alarm about God's imminent advent. God's covenant would triumph suddenly, despite all skepticism (Mal 2:17).

Malachi 2:10–16, his third disputation, confronts his audience with three specific examples of covenantal betrayal. First (v 10), he cites the betrayal of the covenant of Levi (cf. 2:4, 8).

In Malachi 2:10, the prophet holds both sons of Aaron and sons of Levi accountable to a single priestly covenant, “my covenant with Levi” (discussed earlier; see Deut 18:5; 33:8–11; Jer 33:17–22). He finds this perspective natural, since in Deuteronomic thinking the category “Levites” is inclusive of the sons of Aaron and Zadok. These altar-priests share a common vocation with their Levite brothers, precisely the view that Malachi espouses (Mal 3:3; cf. Deut 18:1; 33:10b; Josh 21:4; cf. Deut 17:9, 18; 21:5; etc.).

Malachi demands that his fellow clerics clean up their act and behave like good siblings, mutual sons of “one father” (Mal 2:10). If they do not reform themselves, they will be purged in God’s coming apocalyptic smelting and refinement of all of Levi’s descendants (Mal 3:2–3). A time is imminent when God will scrub all priests clean, making them fit for altar ministry. Cleansing all filth away with the strongest of lye soaps, God will set Judah and Jerusalem right permanently and incontestably.

Levi’s clerical lineage is slated for apocalyptic purging (Mal 3:3–4), not utter termination. Although Malachi is aghast at the altar priests’ profanation of “the covenant with our [Levitical] ancestors” (2:10), he stops short of declaring that covenant void. A Levite himself, Malachi trusts in God’s promise that the covenant with Levi will endure. As we have seen, Jeremiah 33:17–18 specifically guarantees that Levi’s line, along with David’s line, is secure for “all days.” First Samuel 2:35 is parallel, assuring Eli that both lines—Levitical and Davidic—will endure “all days.” “I will raise up for myself a faithful priest,” God declares to Eli; “he shall go in and out before my anointed one forever.”²⁷

In a brilliant intertextual coup, Malachi recapitulates 1 Samuel 2:27–4:1, God’s ancient expulsion of the Elides. He attacks erring contemporary priests armed with an intertextual weapon, a scripture of radical disenfranchisement. Persian-era priests could be purged by God as easily as were the Elides of old, he argues. God has sole prerogative over which Levites are in charge (1 Sam 2:35–36), just as God chooses which prophets succeed Moses (Deut 18:15–19).²⁸

God revealed (גלה) himself to Eli’s father/ancestor (1 Sam 2:27). Later, God abandoned the Elides and revealed (גלה) himself to Samuel (1 Sam 3:21), placing him at the helm as chief Levite (1 Sam 2:35). God’s “faithful priest,” fit for ministry, may be anyone, even an adopted Levite—Samuel (1 Sam 1:1).²⁹

The identity of the “one father” of Malachi 2:10, whose paternity renders all God’s clerics brothers, is ambiguous. At one key level, however, it is certainly Levi.³⁰ First Samuel 2:27 speaks specifically of this “father” in the context of discussing the Elides’ priesthood. Verse 28 then identifies him as the progenitor of the entire Levite tribe, that is, as the eponymous ancestor Levi. Exodus 3:6 speaks of the selfsame “father,” for Moses, like Eli, was a Levite.

Malachi is horror-struck that his fellow priests behave as they do, despite God’s grace to Levi, the ancestor of Aaronides, Zadokites, and Levites alike. God chose Levi “out of all the tribes of Israel to be my priest” (1 Sam 2:28). Given God’s grace, why then do the altar priests of the Persian era behave so faithlessly, selfishly, and vindictively? (cf. 1 Sam 2:29).

NOTES

1. Gunkel 1895: 370. Gunkel stressed the permanence of the new order, cross-referencing Isaiah 66:22. In Third Isaiah the old earth is transitory but God's new world is endless (*ewig*).
2. Sweeney 2005: 240; cf. Polaski 2001: 4–5, 9–12, 22; Hibbard 2006.
3. Hibbard writes, “Dew, often used in parallel with rain, was considered to have powers of renewal, and was, therefore, a great blessing on the land (cf. Deut 33:28; Mic 5:6 [7]; Hag 1:10; Zech 8:12; Ps 133:3; Prov 19:12)” (2006: 148). The resurrecting power of dew is clear in Jewish midrash. Rabbi Tanḥuma of Edrei said that “the dew of the resurrection descends from the head of the Holy One, blessed be he.” “In the future he will shake his head [cf. Cant 5:2–3] and make a life-giving dew descend and the dead live again” (*Pirqe R. El.* 34 [81a]). Jon D. Levenson (personal communication) notes that a quote quite close to this one also appears in the *Midrash on Psalms* (Buber edition) to Psalm 18 (William G. Braude, trans., *The Midrash on Psalms* [2 vols.; YJS, 13; New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1959], 1.241).
4. The publication of a syllabic version of Ugarit's King List has confirmed the divinization of dead kings in Ugaritic religion. Across the ancient Near East, the royal line played the crucial role of supreme officiants in the ancestor cult.
5. On Abraham and Israel as actual living-dead ancestors in Isaiah 63:16, see Tiemeyer 2006: 63; van der Toorn 1988: 216.
6. Stavrakopoulou 2010: 68. For the conquest traditions in mind, see Numbers 21:33–35; Deuteronomy 3:3, 11, 13; Joshua 12:4; 13:12; 17:15; 18:16.
7. For an excellent overview of the evidence, see Hempel 2009.
8. See Hempel 2009: 146, 148, 153.
9. For similar syntax, with an initial *ḥ* meaning “as for,” see Ezekiel 10:13. For discussion, see Ronald J. Williams and John C. Beckman, *Williams' Hebrew Syntax* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2007), sec. 273a; GKC sec. 143e; cf. the Hebrew wording in Numbers 18:8b (see NIV); 1 Samuel 9:20; Psalms 16:3; 17:4; Isaiah 32:1. I understand the text to designate the Zadokites' land as a “most holy” tract (cf. NJPS). The NJB has an alternative understanding in which the entire priestly reserve is “especially holy”: “Their [i.e., the Zadokites'] portion must be taken out of the especially holy portion.”
10. Tuell rightly notes that Numbers 18 neither mentions the Zadokites nor assumes that all Aaronides are automatically Zadokites. It simply addresses itself generally to Aaron and to all priestly lineages stemming from him (1992: 32 n. 37). On HS's elevation of the Eleazarites (among whom number the Zadokites), see Numbers 25:13 (HS). Milgrom helpfully cites Leviticus 21:22 (HS) as evidence that the Holiness School could and did conceive of groups of priests who partake of temple sacrifices but do not approach the altar (Milgrom and Block 2012: 147).
11. Tuell 1992: 32–33, esp. nn. 37, 40.
12. For Eliezer of Beaugency's position, see Milgrom and Block, *Ezekiel's Hope*, 142. The insight of an overlap with Levitical functions is apt, since Ezekiel 44:14a applies language parallel to that in 40:45b to the Levites. Targum Jonathan actually has “Levites” in 40:44 instead of MT's “singers.” The LXX gives the preferable text; 40:44 refers to “two” chambers and has nothing to do with Levites. Numbers 18:5 (HS) insists that priests, not Levites, perform the duties at issue here. The Levites have no access to the inner court (Ezek 44:11, 13).

13. So *The Voice Bible: Step into the Story of Scripture* (Nashville, TN: Ecclesia Bible Society, 2012); cf. NJPS and NABR.
14. See Williams, *Syntax*, sec. 379; Sommer 1998: 148; Weinfeld 1964: 228–242, at 239; Paul 2012: 21.
15. The combination of the verbs לֹוֹה and שָׂרָה occurs only in Numbers 18:2 and Isaiah 56:6. The former verb looks like a wordplay in Isaiah 56:6, suggesting that the foreigners are “Leviting” themselves.
16. See Eugene H. Peterson, *The Message: The Bible in Contemporary Language* (Carol Stream, IL: NavPress, 2010).
17. Cited in Vink 1969: 92. Vink argues for a “non-nationalistic universalistic outlook” at the heart of P (91). He finds that in Genesis 28:3 “we are far away from the generally accepted view of P as narrowly Jerusalemite” (93).
18. For further discussion, see Cook 2008: 15–16; Blenkinsopp 2003: 51–54, 290–301; Blenkinsopp 1995: 392–412.
19. Mark Leuchter argues compellingly for dating Jeremiah 33:19–22 to the Josianic period, when the prophet Jeremiah found himself highly supportive of both king and priests (2008: 77–79).
20. If Third Isaiah were speaking of “Levitical priests” (cf. NJPS), the Hebrew phrasing would probably be לַכֹּהֲנִים הַלֵּוִיִּם as in Deuteronomy 18:1; Jeremiah 33:18. A double datival goal marked by two lameds, as here, is biblically attested elsewhere in Micah 1:6. Note that some Hebrew mss and the Peshitta read “priests *and* Levites” in Isaiah 66:21 (with *waw*); cf. the LXX and Vulgate (also cf. 2 Chr 5:5 LXX).
21. The noun “priests” here stands parallel to “a son” earlier in the verse, and is not appositional. Leuchter correctly observes that the phrase “the Levites, the priests” never occurs in the Levitical literature of the Hebrew Bible or, for that matter, anywhere in Scripture, but understands Jeremiah 33:21 to be using the very phrase as an example of Seidel’s law (2008: 78).
22. Note that Leviticus 4:3, 5, 16 describe the leading cleric carrying out the blood ritual simply as “the anointed priest.” The simple title is sufficient to designate the temple’s chief priestly officer. On “the Priest” in Ezekiel 40–48, see Duguid 1994: 63–64. Ezekiel 44:30 appears also to mention the office of presiding priest.
23. Although Ezekiel 21:26 may have originally conceived of a royal turban, elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible the turban is worn by priests (e.g., see Ex 28:4; 39:28, 31, all HS). Zechariah likely interprets Ezekiel’s turban in the latter, priestly, sense.
24. The temple vision of Ezekiel already presents a notably tempered role for any future high priestly leadership. Ezekiel 40–48 purposely avoids the title “high/chief priest,” probably viewing the presiding priest of the temple as simply its clerics’ lineage head, just as Zadok is the נָגִיד of the Aaronides in 1 Chronicles 27:16–17; cf. 1 Chronicles 9:11; 2 Chronicles 31:13.
25. Most English translations assume the first interpretation, but the second is perhaps more likely. See examples ## 44–49, *IBHS*, p. 153, under the category “genitive of species.”
26. See Tigchelaar 1996: 34–35, 256.
27. For Levites like Malachi, the faithful priest here is emphatically Samuel, not Zadok (as some hold based on 1 Kgs 2:27, although that text does not actually identify Zadok as the “faithful priest”). See further n. 29.
28. The language of God’s “raising up” righteous successors is the same in Deuteronomy 18:18 and 1 Samuel 2:35.

29. Note how 1 Samuel 3:20 certifies Samuel as “faithful” (נאמן, as in 2:35). See Leuchter 2013: 38; Hepner 2010: 365.
30. “Father” points to several figures: Levi (cf. Ex 3:6; 1 Sam 2:27–28), Abraham (cf. Josh 24:3), and God, Israel’s true parent (1:6; cf. Deut 32:6) and creator (Deut 32:6). The allusion to Levi, however, stands out strongly. See Reynolds 1993: 37, 83–84, 150–152.

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*B. Historical Methods
and Textual Representation*

CHAPTER 6

MATERIAL CULTURE, ICONOGRAPHY, AND THE PROPHETS

BRENT A. STRAWN

MATERIAL culture has much to contribute to the study of the prophets and prophecy. At least three areas may be mentioned. At the most general level, material culture casts significant light on larger eras and cultural trends in which the prophets lived, moved, and had their being. It is no exaggeration to say that we know what we know about the Assyrian period, for example—and therefore of this epoch’s pertinence for the prophets active within it—only via careful and extended analysis of the material culture of this region and era: excavation of inhabited sites, investigation of anthropological and faunal remains, interpretation of recovered texts, and the study of human artifacts (artistic and otherwise), to name only the most obvious and important data.

A second, more specific way in which material culture contributes to study of the prophets and prophecy is the assessment of specific cruxes. Consider Amos 7:7–9:

This is what he showed me: the LORD was standing beside a wall built with a plumb line [*ʾānāk*], with a plumb line [*ʾānāk*] in his hand. And the LORD said to me, “Amos, what do you see?” And I said, “A plumb line [*ʾānāk*].” Then the LORD said, “See, I am setting a plumb line [*ʾānāk*] in the midst of my people Israel; I will never again pass them by; the high places of Isaac shall be made desolate, and the sanctuaries of Israel shall be laid waste, and I will rise against the house of Jeroboam with the sword.” (NRSV)

The crux here is the word *ʾānāk*, usually translated as “plumb line” (NRSV, CEB, NJPSV). Though the precise meaning of *ʾānāk* remains elusive (it occurs nowhere else in the Hebrew Bible), its conjunction with “wall” (*ḥōmâ*) and the fact that it is found in Ḳḥwḥ’s hand (*bēyādô*) has convinced many interpreters that building practices are the likely conceptual background.¹ So, with *ʾānāk*, analysis of textual material (especially

via the Akkadian cognate *annaku*, “tin”)² and ancient architecture—both aspects of material culture—combine to inform, even if they do not completely (re)solve, a debated crux.

The third way in which material culture informs study of the prophets is the proper concern of the present chapter: it is the way material culture—and in this particular discussion, iconography—illuminates our understanding of tropes, motifs, and/or themes in the prophets. Iconography, the study of images and the artifacts that (re)present them, is a subset of archaeology writ large and, as such, is concerned with one aspect of material culture.³ The study of ancient Near Eastern iconography in conjunction with the Hebrew Bible has blossomed since the pioneering work of Othmar Keel and the “Fribourg School” that he inspired.⁴ A specialized sub-area in this field uses iconography to better understand metaphors found in the Bible (see, e.g., de Hulster 2009: 105–118; Strawn 2005).

This chapter focuses on one specific image—the lion—to illustrate how ancient Near Eastern iconography may assist with its interpretation. The investigation proceeds within the confines of one specific composition, Amos, with the full realization that, in the case of prophetic books, it is unlikely that every instance of the image dates to the same editorial layer, let alone goes back to the *ipsissima verba* of the prophet. Nevertheless, just as iconographical approaches must avoid *artistic* fragmentation—studying an image-excerpt removed from its larger tableau⁵—so also, when iconographical approaches are applied to the Bible, they must equally avoid *literary* fragmentation, studying just a verse, word, or literary figure without proper attention to the larger literary context(s).⁶ Analysis of an entire prophetic book, then, is an ideal way to proceed, and the fact that Amos is relatively short makes it suitable for a representative probe. Finally, as will be seen, a book-level focus need not be naïve when it comes to compositional issues, even while the material cultural data—here, iconography—may inform compositional discussions.

LION HUNTING IN AMOS

Since the focus of interpretation is the book of Amos—itself a textual artifact as we now have it⁷—the first task is to catalog the lion imagery found therein. There are five instances of three different leonine terms in Amos:⁸

Does a lion [*ʾaryēh*] roar in the forest
without having any prey?
Does a young lion [*kēpîr*] raise its voice from its den⁹
without having captured anything? (Amos 3:4)

A lion [*ʾaryēh*] has roared,
who will not be frightened?
My Lord¹⁰ יהוה has spoken,
who will not prophesy? (Amos 3:8)

Thus says YHWH:

Just as the shepherd rescues from the mouth of the lion [*hā'ārî*]
two legs or a piece of an ear,
thus shall the children of Israel be saved—
those who dwell in Samaria—
with the corner of a couch or part of a bed!¹¹ (Amos 3:12)

Just as when someone flees from the lion [*hā'ārî*]—
and encounters the bear!

Or goes to their house and rests their hand upon the wall—
and the snake bites it! (Amos 5:19)

It is not entirely clear how the three distinct lion terms used in these verses (*'aryēh*, *'ārî*, and *kēpîr*) differ from one another, or from the other words for lions found elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible (*lābî'*, *gûr/gôr*, *layîš*, and *šahāl*), though it seems undeniable that *kēpîr* designates a young(er) lion, perhaps the not yet fully mature adult (Strawn 2005:293–326, especially 304–310). Whatever the case, William Rainey Harper's observation is on target: "Amos's references to lions are not infrequent" (1936: 81). But even five references in a short book like Amos, while impressive, is far from exceptional. Nahum has ten instances of five different lion terms in the space of only three verses (Nah 2:11–13 [Heb 12–14]). For the rest of the prophetic corpus, in decreasing order, Ezekiel has sixteen instances of leonine imagery (Ezek 1:10; 10:14; 19:2 [4x], 3 [2x], 5 [2x], 6 [2x]; 22:25; 32:2; 38:13; 41:19), Isaiah thirteen (Isa 5:29 [2x]; 11:6; 11:7; 15:9; 21:8; 30:6 [2x]; 31:4 [2x]; 35:9; 38:13; 65:25), Jeremiah twelve (Jer 2:5, 30; 4:7; 5:6; 12:8; 25:38; 49:19; 50:17, 44; 51:38 [3x]), Hosea five (Hos 5:14 [2x]; 11:10; 13:7; 13:8), Joel and Micah each have two (Joel 1:6 [2x]; Micah 5:7 [2x]), with Zephaniah and Zechariah both containing one each (Zeph 3:3; Zech 11:3).

This listing—for Amos and for the other prophets—is not exhaustive because the presence of a lion term is not the only way leonine imagery may be present. There is a large semantic domain associated with the lion, comprising the various nouns, verbs, participles, adjectives, and the like that are often, typically, or exclusively used of the animal. These domain elements can be traced to determine if their presence alludes to or evokes leonine imagery even when there is no specific mention of the animal by name (see Strawn 2005: 25–26, 327–356).

When such a search is carried out in Amos, one additional verse is revealed to contain lion imagery by means of the verb *šā'ag* ("to roar"), which is among the most common verbs used for leonine vocalization in the Hebrew Bible:¹²

And he¹³ said:

YHWH roars [*yîš'āg*] from Zion
and raises his voice from Jerusalem.

The pastures of the shepherds dry up,
and the top of Carmel withers. (Amos 1:2)

To summarize the lion hunt in Amos to this point: the book contains a total of five verses across three chapters that explicitly mention or implicitly evoke lion imagery. These verses employ no less than three distinct lion terms, as well as a number of verbs and words that are part of the lion's semantic domain. These include terms relating to the lion's habitat ("forest," "den"), its prey and predation, its effects on others (fear, flight, the need for rescue), even its body ("mouth") and vocalization ("roar," "raising the voice"). Indeed, it is one of the latter items—the verb $\sqrt{\text{šā}}'ag$ —that proves crucial in determining that 1:2 also evokes the image of the lion and not something else like, say, storm imagery.¹⁴

The lion's tracks in Amos are becoming clearer, but more can be said. While the previous discussion gives some sense of Amos's lion (or lions), and casts light on at least some of its ways, habits, even habitats, we have yet to get a full glimpse of the beast. The desire to behold Amos's lion(s) in all its grandeur provides a good segue back to the topic of material culture and the iconography of the lion.

AMOS'S LION(S), MATERIAL CULTURE, AND ICONOGRAPHY

Lion bones in ancient Israel/Palestine date as far back as the Late Pleistocene period (ca. 25,000–10,000 B.C.E.) and have been recovered from archaeological excavations at Jaffa (twelfth century), Tel Miqne/Ekron (IA I and II), and Tel Dan (IA I and mid-ninth century), among others (Strawn 2005: 29). It is likely, then, that lions were prevalent in the land—a conclusion receiving further support from the number of biblical texts referring to lions and the number of archaeological artifacts that witness to the popularity of the lion as an artistic and decorative motif. While the nature, habits, and habitat of real lions in ancient Israel/Palestine are no doubt important (see Strawn 2005: 27–46), it is the confluence of the text and art that is of greatest concern here.

The artistic data are especially important if Martti Nissinen and Charles Carter are correct in their assertion that

[t]he verbal imagery the authors used would have impacted the ancient audiences more deeply than modern readers since it was related to, [and] often drawn from, iconography contemporary to their audience and embedded in their cultural memory. (2009: 7)

And so, they go on to claim,

it is . . . probable that the authors of biblical and Near Eastern texts actually saw visual representations, whether in monumental or miniature form, similar to the metaphors used by their textual tradition. (2009: 13)

This does indeed seem probable in the case of lion imagery, if only given the sheer number of artifacts that employ the animal as a motif. In 2005, I treated over 150 items

from LBA I–IA III/Persian Period (Strawn 2005), but this was only a representative sample, as demonstrated by Jürg Eggler, who has cataloged over 500 items.¹⁵ Given the typical dating of the prophet Amos to the eighth century, it is appropriate to restrict the current discussion to IA II (925–586 B.C.E.) without ignoring altogether later periods given the probability of subsequent redaction(s) in Amos (see further discussion later in this chapter).

Since IA II witnesses a decline of goddess portrayals, instances that associate the lion with the divine realm are not as clear as in some earlier periods (Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 278; Strawn 2005: 97–99). A notable exception is an electron pendant, executed in Assyrian style, that portrays Ishtar on a lion mount before an adorant (Figure 6.1). Other than this depiction, and perhaps the lion mount that carries a caprid-flanked tree from Kuntillet ‘Ajrud (Figure 6.2; Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 217; Strawn 2005: 97–98), direct connections between the lion and the divine realm are limited to artifacts that were apparently used as cult objects or otherwise associated with the cult: lion bowls, for instance, or lion heads used as incense burners (see Strawn 2005: 105–106).¹⁶

Lions are found elsewhere, however, especially in the rise of the guardian lion type, which is especially frequent in IA IIB (Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 278). This type of iconography seems to have served a protective role, but one that alternates according to the lion’s orientation: whichever direction the lion(s) faces is the threatened area, while the area behind the lion is protected and secure.¹⁷ This explains the use of guardian lions in earlier periods at gateways and the like, but it also makes sense of the crudely carved lions found in a ninth-century grave at Tell Eitun (Figure 6.3). These lions face *into* the grave, indicating that “[t]heir function was not to secure the grave and the repose of the deceased, but to keep the spirits of the dead away from the living” (Keel and Uehlinger 1998: 188). Apotropaic use of the lion is also suggested by the existence of IA II lion



FIGURE 6.1 Electron pendant; Tel Miqne-Ekron (Stratum IB); IA II. After Brent A. Strawn, *What Is Stronger than a Lion? Leonine Image and Metaphor in the Hebrew Bible and the Ancient Near East* (OBO 212; Fribourg: Academic Press and Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2005), fig. 3.84 (used with permission).

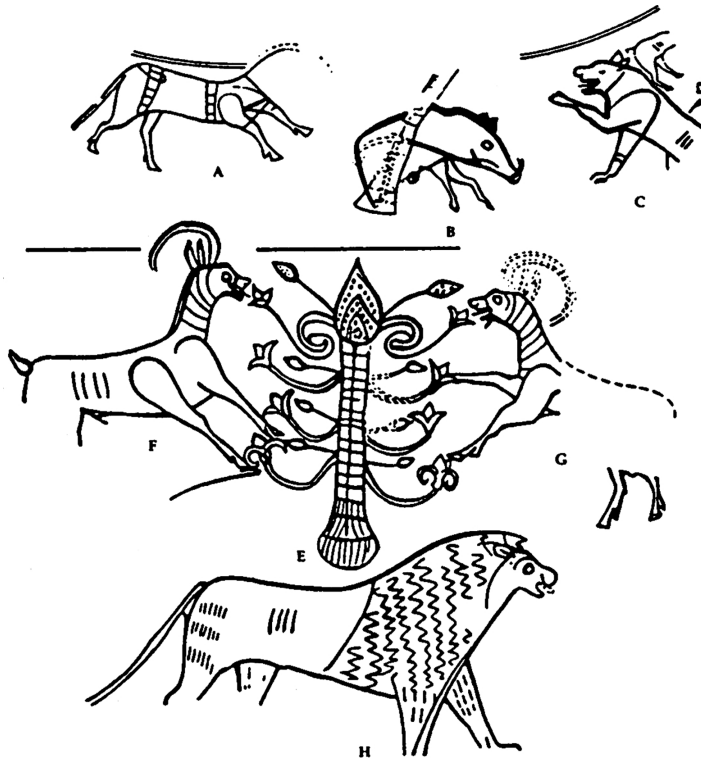


FIGURE 6.2 Pithos A; Kuntillet 'Ajrud; IA II, early 8th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.82 (used with permission).

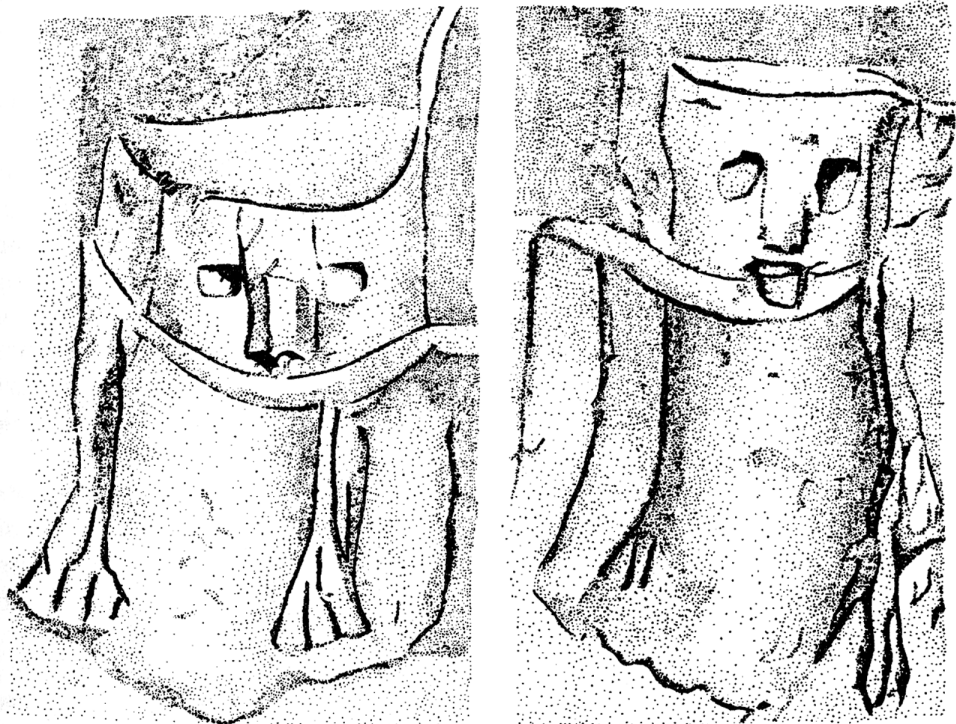


FIGURE 6.3 Stone carving; Tel Eitun; IA II, 9th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.87 (used with permission).



FIGURE 6.4 Seal of Shema, the servant of Jeroboam; Megiddo; IA II, 8th c., but date debated, possibly IA I. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.96 (used with permission).

amulets, if not also by the ivories from Samaria and elsewhere that seem to have been used on furniture (see Strawn 2005: 100–101). But in these cases, too, the apotropaic use is double-edged: threatening to those encountering the lion, benevolent to those protected by its ferocity.

An especially famous find is the seal of Shema, the servant of Jeroboam (*šm' b'd yrb'm*; Figure 6.4), which was recovered from Megiddo. The dating of the seal is debated: Shema is most often thought to have been an official of Jeroboam II (786–746), and so contemporary with Amos (see 1:1; 7:9–11), but others have argued for an earlier, tenth-century date (see the discussion in Strawn 2005: 102–104). While the earlier date is possible—and might make the seal somewhat less important for Amos's time—it is noteworthy that the majority of similar lion seals have been assigned to the eighth century (Strawn 2005: 104). To be sure, such an argument is somewhat circular since most of these lion seals are unprovenanced and so their attribution to the eighth century has relied in part on their similarity to the seal of Shema.

The dating issue aside for the moment, the not insignificant amount of unprovenanced lion seals typically portray the beast striding with open maw, perhaps depicting its roar or a more general aggressive gesture. The threat captured by this type of articulation is further clarified in those seals that show the lion in adversarial encounter (Figure 6.5) or that place a dismembered animal head directly underneath the lion's open mouth (Figure 6.6). The latter type of depiction is quite similar to two Neo-Assyrian seals (probably seventh century) showing lions with dismembered human heads (and, in one case, a hand) (Figures 6.7 and 6.8). Dominique Collon has posited that these were royal administrative seals used to mark booty.¹⁸ A highly similar representation was recovered from Tel Dan, which probably dates to the same period (Figure 6.9) and that may have functioned similarly (Strawn 2005: 105). Whatever the case, the dismembered body parts—whether human or animal—graphically capture the lion's potential for violence.

To return to the dating of the unprovenanced lion seals, there are three objects from controlled excavations that have direct bearing on the issue. The first is the scaraboid of *rpty* recovered from the Palace of Sargon at Khorsabad (Figure 6.10), which dates to



FIGURE 6.5 Limestone scaraboid of *šh*; unprovenanced, 8th c. (?). After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.153 (used with permission).

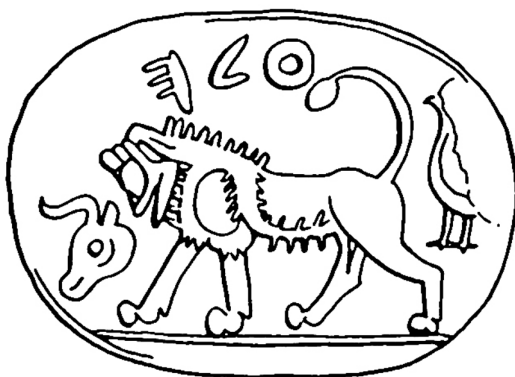


FIGURE 6.6 Agate scaraboid of *lh*; unprovenanced, 8th c. (?). After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.155 (used with permission).

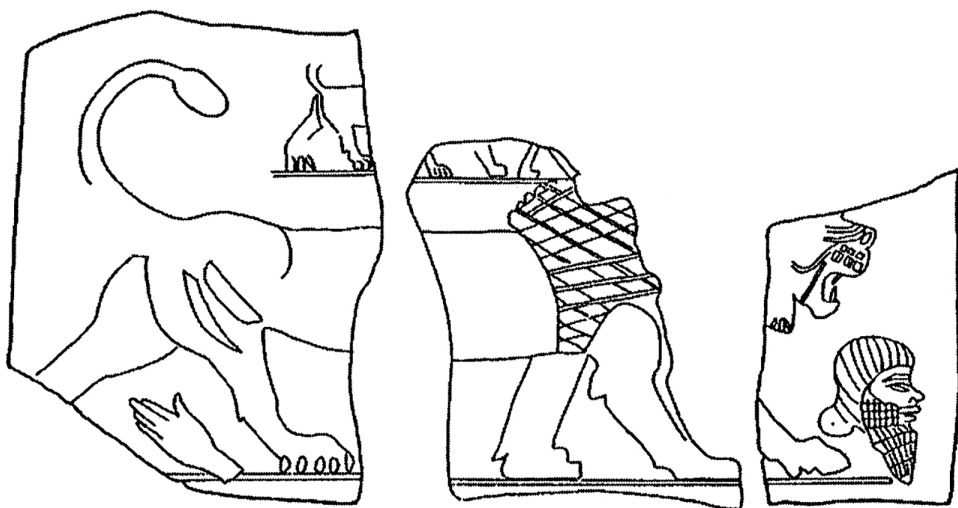


FIGURE 6.7 Stamp seal; probably Nineveh; probably 7th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 4.57 (used with permission).

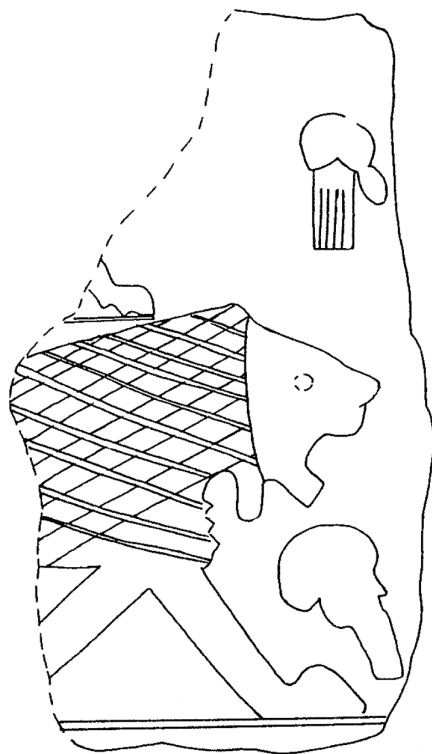


FIGURE 6.8 Stamp seal; probably Nineveh; probably 7th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 4.58 (used with permission).

the second half of the eighth century. The other two come from IA II Jerusalem: a seal inscribed with *lnw'* (or *lnr'*) that was excavated at the Western Wall Plaza (Figure 6.11); and an anepigraphic scaraboid that was discovered in Area E South in the City of David (Figure 6.12). Both of these latter finds are especially noteworthy in terms of find spot and date, and deserve brief discussion.

The reading of the proper name on the first seal (Figure 6.11) is debated. The name *nr'* is well known, but the excavators think the more likely reading is *nw'*. Though *nw'* is otherwise unattested, they believe that it may be “a hypocoristic from *nwy*, ‘DN is my/an abode/pasture,’ or else ‘DN is beauty.’”¹⁹ Interpreting the base word as “abode” is supported by other personal names “composed with *ḥsy*, ‘refuge, shelter,’ principally Hebrew *mḥsyhw* . . . and *ḥl*, ‘tent, shelter, clan.’”²⁰ Quite apart from these connections, the conjunction of the lion with “the pastures of the shepherds” (*nē’ôt hārō’im*) in Amos 1:2 comes immediately to mind.

The iconography of the scaraboid (Figure 6.12) shows a lion striding right on a line, under which is a prone human figure with upraised arm. Baruch Brandl believes the scaraboid should be rotated 90° to the left when “reading” it, in which case the human

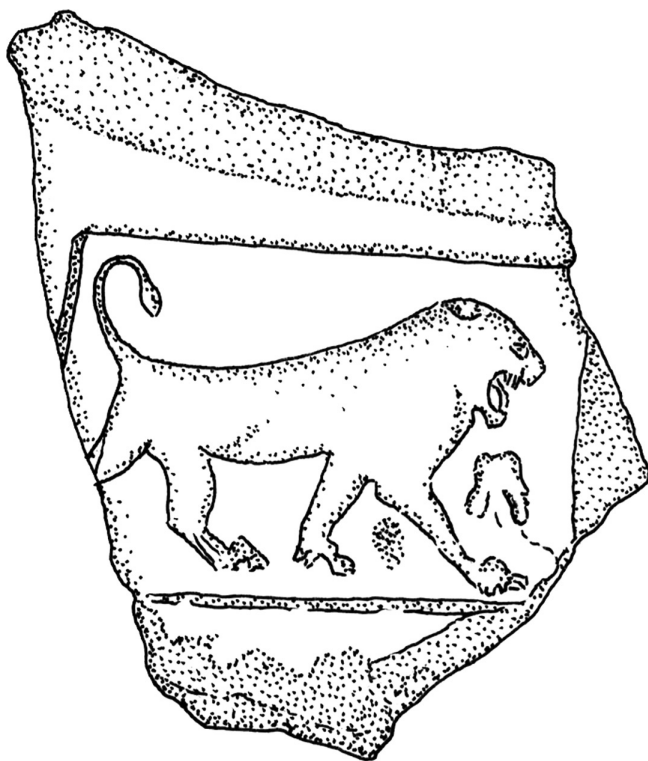


FIGURE 6.9 Seal impression; Tel Dan (Area T); mixed late IA/Persian Period context, after 8th c., perhaps 7th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.102 (used with permission).



FIGURE 6.10 Agate scaraboid (Aramaic) of *rpty*; Krhosabad (Palace of Sargon); second half of 8th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 4.178 (used with permission).

figure is no longer prone but walking forward with the upraised hand.²¹ This is possible, especially since depictions of lions over prone (presumably dead or conquered) human bodies usually portray the latter with both arms lowered alongside the body;²² Brandl also adduces three parallels from Megiddo, Lachish, and Tell Keisan.²³ Even so,

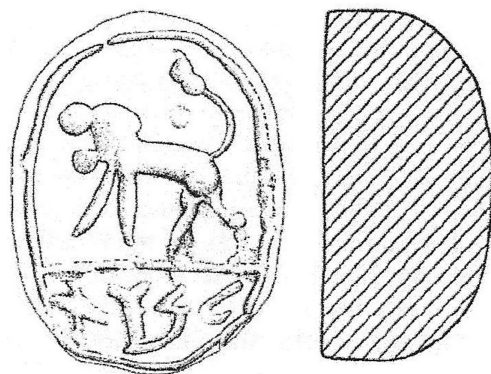


FIGURE 6.11 Limestone scaraboid; Jerusalem; IA II. After Tallay Ornan, Shlmoit Weksler-Bdolah, Shua Kisilevitz, and Benjamin Sass, “‘The Lord Will Roar from Zion’ (Amos 1:2): The Lion as a Divine Attribute on a Jerusalem Seal and Other Hebrew Glyptic Finds from the Western Wall Plaza Excavations,” *’Atiqot* 72 [2012]: 5* fig. 1 (drawing by Dalit Weinblatt Krauz; figure by Benjamin Sass; used with permission, courtesy of the Israel Antiquities Authority).

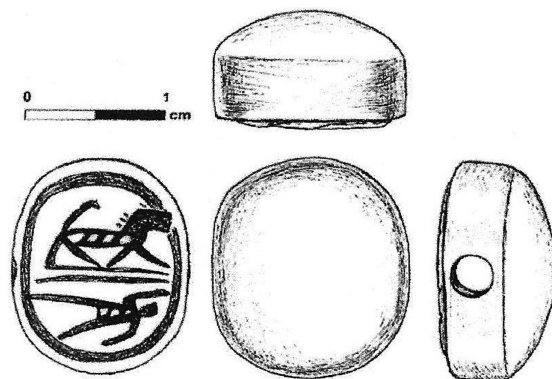


FIGURE 6.12 Bone scaraboid; City of David; 9th-8th c. After Baruch Brandl, “Scarabs, Scraboids, Other Stamp Seals, and Seal Impressions,” in *Excavations at the City of David 1978–1985 Directed by Yigal Shiloh*, Volume VII B: Area E: *The Finds* (eds. Alon De Groot and Hannah Bernick-Greenberg; Qedem 54; Jerusalem: Hebrew University, 2012), 384 fig. 13.7 (used with permission, courtesy of the Institute of Archaeology, the Hebrew University of Jerusalem).

I am not entirely convinced that “it is impossible to identify such a figure as a victim” of the lion.²⁴ The most intriguing point, regardless, is the significance of the upraised arm. In other contexts, this gesture connotes greeting or adoration. If that is operative in this case, the human figure greets or adores the lion, which suggests that this may not be an ordinary lion. If one does not rotate the seal, the proneness of the human figure underscores its subservience to the lion still further, even if the human is not yet dead or otherwise defeated.



FIGURE 6.13 Bulla; Samaria; IA II, probably 8th c. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.93 (used with permission).

In sum, the lion in the scaraboid (Figure 6.12) may be a divine lion, an identification that Ornan, Weksler-Bdolah, Kisilevitz, and Sass also make for the lion in their seal (Figure 6.11):

An iconographical offshoot of the theme “deity on animal or hybrid” is the depiction of the animal/hybrid alone, transformed, as it were, into a stand-in for the deity. . . . This, we suggest, is the case with the lion as a sole motif on our seal.²⁵

They believe such lion seals “typified Judah, and not only Israel,” and, after a consideration of two candidates (YHWH and Asherah or the Queen of Heaven), deem it “preferable to associate the lion in Judah with Yahweh”—indeed, they assert, “lions in both Israelite and Judahite seals symbolize Yahweh.”²⁶

One further observation: the lion image is often associated with royalty in IA II, no less than in other periods (Strawn 200: 101, 104–105). So, for example, the seal of Shema was found in the administrative quarter of Megiddo, suggesting to Keel and Uehlinger that it belonged to “the provincial governor” (1998: 190). Or there is the bulla recovered from Samaria that contained the Assyrian royal seal impression (Figure 6.13). Benjamin Sass has gone so far as to argue that a seal from Ramat Rahel (Figure 6.14), which depicts a lion pouncing on an ibex, was “an official Judahite seal.”²⁷

The lion’s royal profile raises the question of whether or not its depictions might (also) represent the king or officials, and not (or not only), per the earlier discussion, the deity. Of course this may be a false alternative given the extensive connections between the lion and the king, on the one hand, and the lion and the gods, on the other hand—throughout the ancient Near East and across millennia (Strawn 2005: 54–65, 152–217, 236–273). It is possible, then, that in many instances the lion is associated with *both*, in some cases *simultaneously*, and so the association of lion imagery from ancient Israel/Palestine with the monarch does not preclude possible connections to Israel’s God.²⁸ This is an opportune time to return to Amos the prophet and Amos the book. The two are not coterminous but are nevertheless intertwined.

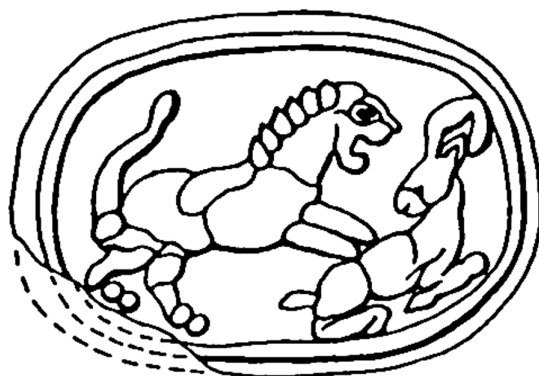


FIGURE 6.14 Seal (from *lmlk* jar); Ramat Rahel; IA II. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.94 (used with permission).

LEONINE ICONOGRAPHY AND/IN RECONSTRUCTED AMOS

Study of Amos, no less than other prophets, has long been occupied with the book's compositional history, which has involved work on its supposed editorial layers or redactions. For well over a century, scholars have argued that not all of the book of Amos can be confidently traced back to the eighth-century prophet by that name, but after that general point all bets are off. Hans Walter Wolff posited six layers in the book (1977: 106–113),²⁹ with Dirk U. Rottzoll arguing for no fewer than twelve.³⁰ Simpler models may be found, but whatever the specifics of the reconstruction, the intractable problem facing any and all redactional-critical approaches remains their entirely speculative nature such that they cannot be replicated and so never command a consensus.³¹ Perhaps this says more about redaction critics proper—that they are a somewhat disagreeable lot!—than it does about the approach per se. Whatever the case, Jörg Jeremias, a leading redaction critic, candidly admits that Amos's message “can be recovered only through complicated, and in many instances only hypothetical, reconstruction” (1998: 5), so that “[a]ny attempt to get back to earlier strata of the book, not to speak of Amos's actual words themselves, is necessarily burdened by a (variously differing) degree of uncertainty” (1998: 9; cf. Andersen and Freedman 1989: 144). Indeed, even so basic but all-important an issue as the proper criteria to be used for delineating editorial seams and compositional layers in the first place is not always agreed upon. Said criteria are sometimes even left completely unspecified. Regardless of this under-theorization, the implementation of whatever criteria are used can be challenged and is always open to alternative interpretations, to say the very least. Most unfortunate of all is the fact that scholars sometimes judge later layers to be somehow less important and pay them less attention, at least in commentary formats. The goal, in any event, in this kind of scholarly endeavor is to reconstruct the

“original” Amos—unencumbered, that is, by later editorial activity—so as to get back to the “authentic” words of the prophet before so many accretions were added, layer upon layer. This nonaccreted form of the book, or of its constituent parts, is typically designated with an asterisk, to signal that this is the original (albeit reconstructed) form: *Amos, for instance, or *1:2.

Despite the problems plaguing redaction criticism writ large, a probe of a number of Amos commentaries (Andersen and Freedman 1989; Harper 1936; Jeremias 1998; Mays 1969; Paul 1991; Snaith 1945–1946; Soggin 1987; Wolff 1977) reveals a relatively uniform opinion on the “authenticity” of Amos 3:4, 8, 12, and 5:19. There is some disagreement, however, about 1:2.

Amos 3:4 and 3:8

Most scholars believe that Amos 3:4 and 3:8 belong to the same rhetorical unit, 3:3–8, with many judging these verses original to Amos,³² with the major exception being verse 7 (Wolff 1977: 181–183), and some minor additions in the lion verses proper—for example, “from its den” in verse 4 and “the Lord” in verse 8 (Jeremias 1998: 47 and nn. 2, 4; Mays 1969: 59 and n. a). The perspective on verse 8 seems idiosyncratic, but that on verse 4 is often related to questions of material culture and zoology—specifically, whether or not lions live in dens (Snaith 1945–1946: 2: 58). Of course they do not, at least not in the wild, and in captivity not for long (Strawn 2005: 38–39). Then again, the word “den” (*mēʾōnâ*) is not highly specific, nor is it restricted only to a certain kind of lair or residence (Strawn 2005: 38). Indeed, *mēʾōnâ* and its by-form *māʾōn* are used of lions elsewhere (Nah 2:11–12 [Heb 12–13]; Song 4:8; cf. also Jer 25:30; Job 38:40; Pss 76:3; 104:22; Jer 21:13; Strawn 2005: 349) and even of YHWH (e.g., Deut 26:14; 2 Chr 30:27; 36:15; Pss 26:8; 68:6; Zech 2:17). “From its den,” then, may mean no more than “from its dwelling-place,” and be no more or less specific than the parallel word, *yaʿar* (“thicket, forest”; used with lions in Jer 5:6; 12:8). Finally, there is no significant text-critical reason to doubt either part of verse 4 or verse 8 (see *BHQ*, 41–42).

Be that as it may, what is the specific force of the lion imagery in 3:4, 8? It seems likely that Amos 3:3–8 as a whole stresses the irrevocable nature of certain events and the cause–effect relationship between them (Wolff 1977: 183). The series of questions appears to expect positive responses: yes, people generally agree before they hold meetings (v 3); yes, traps do not spring unless they have been triggered (v 5); and so forth. In this context, verse 4 suggests that the lion’s vocalization (*yīšʾag* // *yittēn qôlô*) is directly related to its hunt. Lions would not roar without having captured prey (*terep* // *lākād*).

At this point, commentators frequently appeal to zoological reality, though often erroneously (cf. Harper 1936: 68, 74; Paul 1991: 110; Snaith 1945–1946: 2: 11, 58). The problem is simply that the direct connection between the lion’s roar and predation doesn’t seem to be true. Perhaps Amos 3:4 is simply mistaken—either Amos, or “the shepherd’s old maxim” (Wolff 1977: 185) underlying the unit is not aware of real leonine predation³³—or perhaps the verse does not require an interpretation that lions

only roar when they have hunted. Regardless, the Hebrew Bible knows that lions vocalize for a whole host of reasons, a point also made by contemporary zoological researchers.³⁴ What is certain is that lions do *not* roar when they hunt, which is precisely when stealth is required.³⁵ That said, lions can vocalize when they are hungry (cf. Ps 104:21) or when they are eating (Strawn 2005: 35 n. 43; cf. Snaith 1945–1946: 2: 58; Soggin 1987: 58). Either way, the behavior in Amos 3:4 is probably best understood as some type of warning, not one of hunting.

Among other things, the lion's roar announces its presence at a distance to all within earshot, evoking a fear response. The iconography discussed earlier that emphasized the lion's open mouth should be recalled at this point—such images depict the lion's roar or a mouth ready to bite or devour (note references to the lion's mouth in Amos 3:12; Pss 22:14, 22; 58:7; Dan 6:23; cf. 1 Sam 17:35). Indeed, Figures 6.6–6.9 show disarticulated body parts that are best construed as pieces of the lion's prey. An image of a lion devouring a hind leg shank from IA III/Persian Period (Figure 6.15) underscores the gruesome result of the lion's hunt, even as it demonstrates the truth of Jeremias's remark that Amos 3:4 “prompts the reader to think involuntarily of the fear of losing one's life in a situation of extreme danger. No one encountering the lion can escape; its roar is an unmistakable sign for the prey that falls into its clutches” (1998: 52).

What then of Amos 3:8, which serves as “both summary and conclusion” (Andersen and Freedman 1989: 400)? For Jeremias, the culmination of the unit in verse 8 makes the metaphor of verse 4 “transparent for Israel's own position before God, whose ‘lion's roar’ is sounded because Israel is indeed his ‘prey’” (1998: 52; cf. Harper 1936: 68). The two halves of verse 8 exist in a parallelism at once “complete and synonymous,” according to Harper, though he does not believe that the lion and YHWH “have the same reference” (1936: 73). Harper does not offer reasons for the distinction he draws, and yet, quite apart from the most obvious answer—namely, that even “synonymous” parallelism is rarely identical—the iconographical pieces described earlier prompt further reflection. It is not impossible that the lion seals dating to the eighth century may image

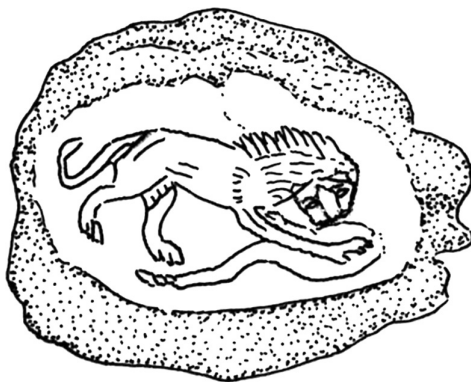


FIGURE 6.15 Bulla; unprovenanced (Samaria?); IA III/Persian Period. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.142 (used with permission).

YHWH. Or, even if they were not originally intended to do such, it is not impossible to imagine that people seeing such images “found” YHWH therein.³⁶ The parallelism of verse 8 surely suggests a close connection between, if not an identification of, YHWH and the lion, but so do 3:12 and 1:2, if not also 5:19 (see later discussion). And this is not yet to invoke the other passages in the Old Testament that connect YHWH with lions, many of which find analogues in the ancient Near Eastern data, both literary and artistic (Strawn 2005: 58–65, 187–217, 250–268). Beyond comparanda, the seals from controlled excavations (especially Figures 6.10–6.12) help to establish a chronological horizon for the similar but unprovenanced lion seals. If so, these seals may be (re)considered with the fairly widespread agreement that 3:4 and 3:8 go back to the eighth century, if not to the eighth-century prophet himself. The result of the close connection between YHWH and the lion in these texts and in these artifacts—and their interrelation—is thus two-fold: (1) that these lion seals are, in fact, images of YHWH, and/or can be read as such; and (2) that YHWH is the lion, and/or lurks behind the lion(s) of Amos.

Amos 3:12

If the point of Amos 3:4, 8 is “inescapable death” (Jeremias 1998: 52), with the vocalization and predation of the lion the primary vehicles of that message, then Amos 3:12 brings that point home with further force. Often treated as an independent oracle (Paul 1991: 119 n. 41; Wolff 1977: 197), it is nevertheless frequently judged to be original to Amos (Mays 1969: 66; Soggin 1987: 61; Wolff 1977: 107, 197). Commentators invariably refer to Exodus 22:10–13 (Heb vv 9–12) as the conceptual background of the verse: shepherds who lost property while it was under their care had to provide proof of the loss—namely, the torn body (*haṭṭēṣpâ*, from *ṭārap*)—in order to avoid paying damages (Harper 1936: 81).

The force of Amos 3:12 is nicely captured in the title given to it by Wolff: “‘Rescue’ as Proof of Death” (1977: 196). As in Exodus 22, what is left over in Amos 3:12 is only evidence that there is no escape from the coming judgment—no escaping alive, at any rate. As Jeremias states, “The ‘rescue’ of a small body part in this context naturally represents nothing more than proof that nothing could have prevented this death” (1998: 59). So, in point of fact, 3:12 completely denies its addressees “any possibility of escaping the announced disaster” (1998: 59).

In this verse, too, material culture proves informative and illustrative. Lions with (pieces of) prey—even human prey like “the children of Israel . . . those who dwell in Samaria”—are depicted in the iconography of ancient Israel/Palestine and beyond (cf. Figures 6.6–6.9, 6.12, 6.14–6.15; Strawn 2005: 35, 382, 394, 396, 434–435, 494), offering a view of what such devastation looks like. Additional illumination is offered by Siegfried Mittmann, who drew attention to ancient beds with lion-shaped feet—an intriguing point since 3:12 mentions not only the torn pieces of the lion’s prey but also “the corner of a bed” for those living in Samaria and “a piece of a couch” for those in Damascus (CEB).³⁷ Such decoration on furniture is not uncommon, and is frequently found on

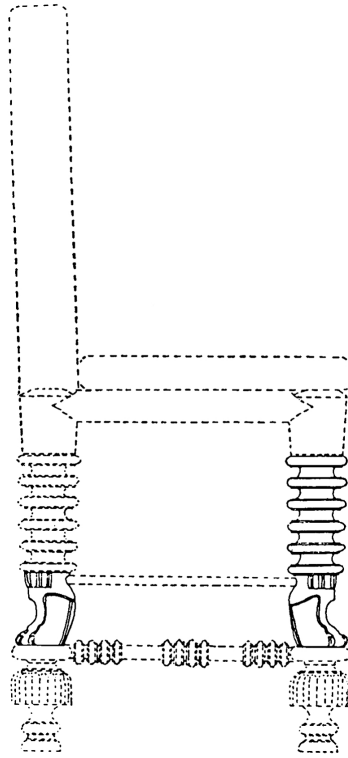


FIGURE 6.16 Throne; Samaria; IA III/Persian Period. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 3.126 (used with permission).

elite items like the Achaemenid throne from IA III/Persian Period Samaria (Figure 6.16). Mittmann presented lion-footed beds from Egypt (Figure 6.17) and Assyria (Figure 6.18).³⁸ Not unlike the furniture decorations discussed earlier—some from Samaria itself (note 3:12!)—the use of lion legs and paws on chairs, tables, and beds likely served an apotropaic function.³⁹

Despite Mittmann's work, Andersen and Freedman have wondered if the combination of imagery—lions with prey, on the one hand, and pieces of furniture, on the other—is somehow “mixed, perhaps incongruous”:

The relations between bones, beds, and people could be two pictures of the remnant of Israelites. The number of Israelites who survive the disaster will be like the few bits of a mutilated sheep left by the lion; or like a few scraps of furniture salvaged from a looted city. All that is left are two pairs of leg bones and a piece of an ear; or the legs of a couch and another small piece. (1989: 410)

But the iconography of lion-footed furniture suggests that the mixture may be ironically intended, especially in light of the typically violent associations of the lion image and its apotropaic employment on elite items. If so, “Amos . . . constructed his so utterly

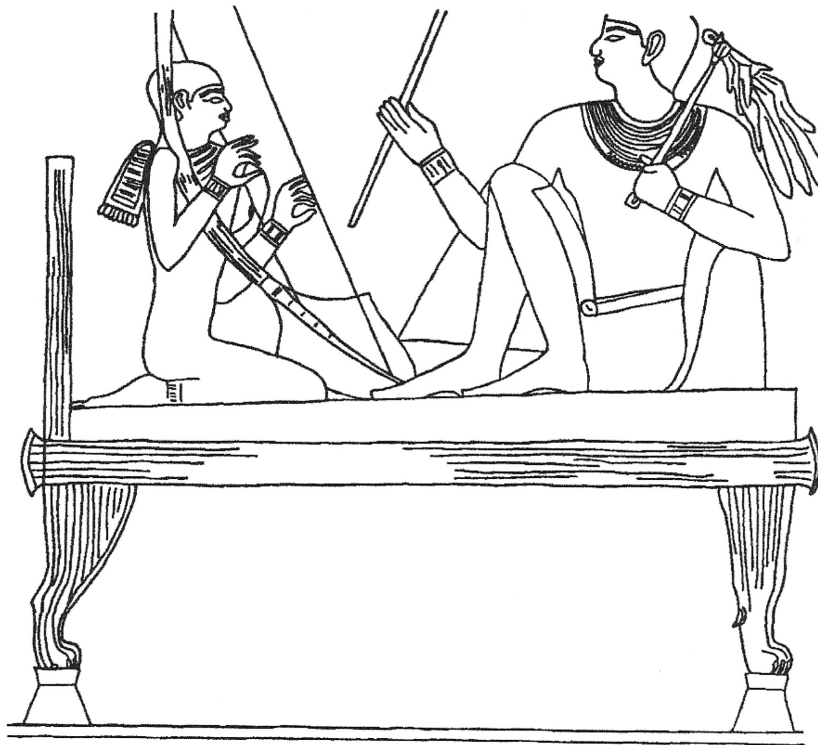


FIGURE 6.17 Relief; Masaba of Mereruka; Saqqara; Dynasty VI. After Siegfried Mittmann, "Amos 3,12–15 und das Bett der Samarier," *ZDPV* 92 (1976): 154 Abb. 1 (used with permission).

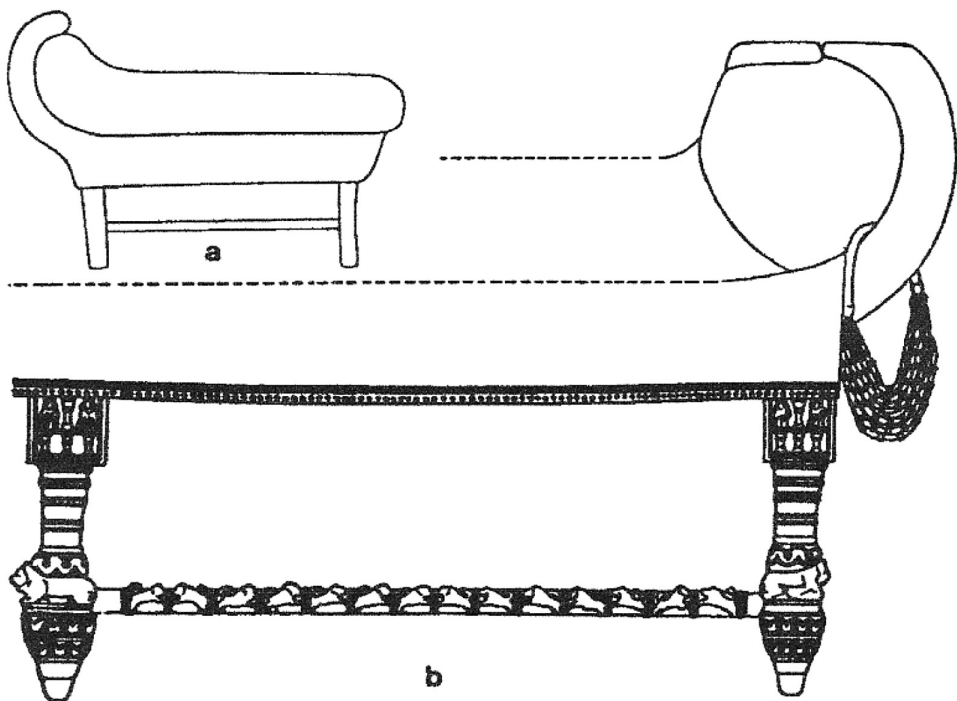


FIGURE 6.18 Assyrian bed of Assurbanipal; 7th c. After Mittmann, "Amos 3,12–15," 158 Abb. 3b (used with permission).

different lion imagery for God in opposition to . . . apotropaic lion representations, which symbolized protection and security” (Jeremias 1998: 60). Once again, this type of lion decoration connoted not only protection but also elite status—wealth, even royalty, if not also divinity. All of that changes, ironically, in the words of the prophet: the Divine Lion is now *against* the wealthy (cf. Amos 3:6–7; 4:1; 6:4; Wolff 1977: 198); they are no longer protected but threatened—better yet, doomed. Hardly anything will be left over when this Lion has finished its meal.

The devastating force of Amos 3:12 has not been lost on commentators; neither has its sarcasm or “ironic thrust” (Mays 1969: 67; cf. Andersen and Freedman 1989: 408; Soggin 1987: 63; Wolff 1977: 198), but both receive additional support, if not final confirmation, by the material culture data offered by iconography.

Amos 5:19

Amos 5:19 and the unit to which it belongs (5:18–20) are deemed by many to be original to Amos, whether that judgment is made on presumed connections to the life of a shepherd (Harper 1936: 132; Jeremias 1998: 100) or simply its content (Barton 2012: 61–66; Mays 1969: 103; Soggin 1987: 94). There is also widespread agreement on the force of the oracle. According to Soggin, it “corresponds to our ‘out of the frying pan into the fire’” (1987: 94; cf. Snaith 1945–1946: 2: 98). The “fire” in question is, ultimately, “sudden death, however it may occur” (Jeremias 1998: 100).

Interpreters disagree on whether the succession of images in Amos 5:19 is somehow progressive. Harper thinks not, believing the thought to be “general,” depicting “a situation from which there is no escape” (1936: 133). Aulikki Nahkola, in contrast, argues that “an escalation in horror is intended by [the] three-fold animal encounter.”⁴⁰ Iconographical remains cannot resolve this debate, but one very early image is notable for placing a human figure, being bitten by a serpent, in the same tableau as a large feline, probably a lion (Figure 6.19). Perhaps the scene might be read narratively such that the lion presents an initial threat, followed by the serpent, as in 5:19.⁴¹ Such an analysis would support Nahkola’s interpretation of this verse. Alternatively, the image need not be read sequentially but simultaneously, which could favor Harper’s perspective. Whatever the case, the iconographical data are clear that, above all else, the lion is a “trope of threat and power” (Strawn 2005: 65; further 134–152, 233–235)—a point also realized in 5:19.

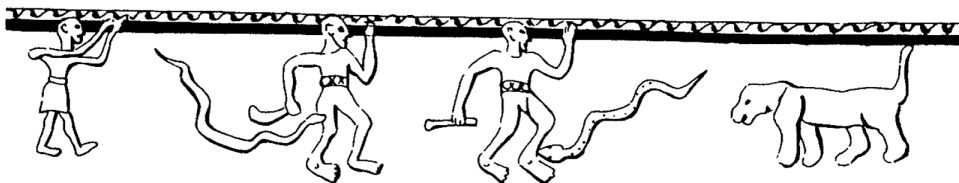


FIGURE 6.19 Ceramic object; Tell Asmar; Isin-Larsa Period. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, fig. 4.64 (used with permission).

Amos 1:2

Thus far, at least for the most part, according to the scholars surveyed here, all of the instances of lion imagery in Amos have been authentic or original to the prophet—*Amos, to use the siglum common in compositional analyses. This changes drastically when we come to the final instance of lion imagery (but the first such instance in the current form of the book): Amos 1:2.

Most commentators believe that this verse is secondary (Jeremias 1998: 13–14; Mays 1969: 21; Soggin 1987: 30; a notable exception is Paul 1991: 36 and n. 42). Indeed, one might say that 1:2 occurs in *first* position in the book largely because it is *last*, or at least later, added at some subsequent point. Wolff places 1:2 in the fourth of his six layers, dated to “the third decade before the end of the seventh century” (1977: 112). According to him, this layer recognized “the new relevance of the words of Amos” for this period (113). Others would place the verse still later: Jeremias, for instance, suggests it is exilic or post-exilic (1998: 14).

Since Wolff’s analysis of 1:2 is more extensive than most, it is worth treating in some detail (cf. also Harper 1936: 9–10). First, Wolff thinks the hymnic style of 1:2 (so also Jeremias 1998: 14; Mays 1969: 21; Paul 1991: 41–42) is different from what *Amos uses elsewhere (Wolff 1977: 118; cf. 121). Although he must admit of obvious connections between 1:2 and 3:4 (which he deems authentic)—especially via the repeated parallelism *yîš’ag // yittēn qôlô*—he argues that 1:2 is secondary: “a metaphor used by Amos to comprehend his auditions [in 3:4] is introduced into the ancient form of the theophany accounts [in 1:2]” (Wolff 1977: 119). He summarizes: “The old form of the hymnic theophany account thus accommodates the announcement of an awesomely effective audition of Yahweh. It seems appropriately to have been placed at the head of the book as a motto summarizing the message of the prophet” (Wolff 1977: 119).

Wolff moves from the verse’s style to its specific content.⁴² Here, too, he must admit of elements in the verse that “demonstrably belong to [*Amos’s] vocabulary,” but asserts that *Amos “never threatens Israel with drought” and argues that “Zion and Jerusalem never figure in [*]Amos’ own utterances as the place from which the voice of Yahweh proceeds” (121; cf. 125, which paints the drought with “eschatological dimensions”). Of course, 1:2 may not be about drought at all—or at least not ultimately⁴³—and Wolff’s point about Zion/Jerusalem is somewhat circular. Note, for example, Andersen and Freedman’s opinion: “the whole nation is in Amos’ view most of the time. . . . To state the point negatively, it is hard to believe that Amos had no views on Judah, or that he never expressed them” (1989: 223; cf. Barton 2012: 42).

The issues, then, for Wolff, boil down to “significant differences of vocabulary and perspective” (1977: 122). To these we might add tone, since Wolff deems 1:2 less accusatory than other *Amos passages. It is possible, however, to challenge each of Wolff’s points about vocabulary, style, tone, and perspective. Is any one of them definitive? Is

not each one of them interpretive, subject to adjudication by those nebulous and far from empirical criteria common to hermeneutics?

It comes as no real surprise, then, to find Wolff somewhat conflicted. Amos 1:2 is somehow less accusatory than *Amos, in his opinion, but is nevertheless “a confession of the devastating force of Yahweh’s terrifying voice” (124). Or, again,

Amos himself, in his extant oracles, never spoke so directly of the “[lion’s] roar” of Yahweh’s voice. He did, however, experience in his own life the irresistible power of Yahweh’s address, and he has indeed compared this to the effect of the lion’s roaring (3:8). (124–125)

To be sure, there can be little doubt that 1:2 is detached from what follows it, if not also from what precedes it (Soggin 1987: 28), and that it functions as a kind of introduction to the book (Harper 1936: cxxxii, 9). But this is only to say that its *present placement* is by design and, as such, perhaps secondary in some fashion; such a judgment does not preclude the originality of the *verse’s sentiment* per se. It is certainly possible, *à la* Wolff, to say that this motto was “formulated in retrospect by the book’s tradents; it establishes the basic tone of the prophet’s message, employing the hymnic style, perhaps as an overture to the liturgical reading of the Amos-traditions” (1977: 126). But, *contra* Wolff, it is hard indeed to know that this is “probably” the case, especially for all that follows his “perhaps.” Once again, the “evidence”—such as it is—can be and has been understood otherwise. So, for example, Shalom Paul argues that

this hymnic verse, which vividly portrays the effects of the wrath of God upon nature and introduces the forthcoming indictments, should be seen as an authentic, alarming, and terrifying overture to the following oracles against the nations. (1991: 41–42)

He makes his argument on the basis of the same verse—its content, style, and so forth—as do those on the other side of the issue of authenticity.⁴⁴

Alternatively, instead of Wolff’s argument, one might consider the recent remarks of John Barton on 1:2 in a somewhat similar vein:

One does not get the impression from the words of Amos that he espoused this idea himself: YHWH for him is a God naturally at home in northern Israel, and indeed the freedom and independence of YHWH makes it doubtful whether Amos really saw him as “residing” anywhere on earth. (2012: 142)

But surely Barton’s remark about Amos’s understanding of YHWH’s freedom (if accurate) makes the bit about the prophet deeming YHWH to be “naturally at home” in the northern kingdom quite dubious. There is, furthermore, no mention of YHWH “residing” (presumably some form of *√yāšab*) anywhere in Amos.

To come full circle: compositional arguments about *Amos and Amos seem to be at something of an impasse.⁴⁵ Appeal to artifactual remains from the material culture of ancient

Israel/Palestine cannot definitively adjudicate such text-based arguments; analysis of the former, no less than the latter, are also interpretive—*inescapably*. Even so, the iconographical materials presented here do comprise another hermeneutically useful data set that biblical scholars can and should draw upon whenever they make hermeneutical arguments. When one does so, it is possible to arrive at a conclusion not unlike that made earlier regarding Amos 3:4, 8. There, I posited that the datable instances of leonine iconography coupled with widely agreed-upon *Amos material connecting YHWH to lions (3:4, 8, 12; perhaps also 5:19) suggested that the unprovenanced seals, too, belonged to the same horizon and that they, too, indexed YHWH in some fashion. Here, in the case of 1:2, these data might be mustered to argue that there is no obvious reason that the prophet Amos, even in the eighth century, did not or could not know of lion imagery associated with YHWH—imagery that often highlighted the animal’s predatory prowess and, even more specifically, its mouth, whether open in roar or attack. Still further, such imagery has been found in the south, in Jerusalem and at Ramat Raḥel, in the general time frame typically ascribed to Amos himself (Figures 6.11–12, 6.14). Such information does not definitively prove that 1:2 is authentically *Amos, but it does tend in that direction—especially since the roar uttered from Zion/Jerusalem by Lion YHWH reaches “as far north as the Carmel (mentioned again in 9:3) [and] is [thus] an extremely fitting prelude to the prophetic message of one who was sent from Judah to northern Israel to announce the Lord’s sovereignty over the entire nation” (Paul 1991: 37).⁴⁶

In sum, the iconographical data considered here seem to put a bit more burden on those who would argue against the originality of Amos 1:2 (whatever the details of its final placement in the book), and even more burden on those who would make such arguments exclusively on the basis of literary (i.e., composition-critical) criteria.

LEONINE ICONOGRAPHY AND/IN CANONICAL AMOS

At the start of this chapter, I stated that material cultural data (viz., iconography) may inform compositional discussions and that a book-level focus need not be naïve regarding compositional issues. The majority of the preceding has been occupied with these points. I also noted at the start the problems that beset iconographical approaches if they are artistically and literarily fragmented. The latter consideration, especially, commends a return to the book level—regardless of any decisions regarding Amos and *Amos—so as to hunt the lion(s) of Amos one more time, across the whole book, armed with both text and art.

Coming between the opening superscription (1:1) and the oracles against the nations (1:3–2:16), Amos 1:2 functions as a kind of motto for the book and for the prophet’s words. The placement of the verse signals its importance; the imagery anticipates the tone of what follows. By means of the verb $\sqrt{\text{šā}}ag$, YHWH is metaphorized as a lion roaring from the south toward the north. Such roaring is no doubt rich with associations, but is clarified as one continues reading. Most immediately, the result of this Lion’s roar is the withering of nature in a merism that moves from most arid to most lush, and that

may also evoke the depopulation of the pastureland.⁴⁷ No one and no thing—one might even add no place—can escape from this Lion and his roar.

The point of Amos 1:2 is well captured in the iconography of the lion, which, especially in IA II, shows the beast a constant threat to its prey. While the lion image can also be deployed in apotropaic ways, the threat the animal poses remains constant. The location that is most threatened lies before and directly underneath the lion. That is the position of prey (Figure 6.20a–b; cf. 6.6–6.9; 6.12; 6.14–6.15). Locating YHWH-as-Lion as somehow in (roaring from) Zion/Jerusalem, then, does not mean that these locales are somehow off-limits—the nice touch of a biased but well-intended Judean redactor. These places *may* be protected space, but may just as likely be threatened by this Lion. Lions, after all, protect their prey solely to devour it (Strawn 2005: 36); they typically vocalize prior to hunting, when hungry, or while eating (Strawn 2005: 35 n. 43); and it only takes a slight change of perspective or position for the protective lion to become a destructive one (Strawn 2005: 61, 63). Indeed, any protective ability the lion has is entirely dependent on its destructive capacity.

This understanding of Amos 1:2 flows directly into the oracles against the nations that immediately follow and that are replete with images of destructive judgment. Paul is right, then, to see 1:2 functioning “as a prologue to the impending and imminent judgment of God against the foreign nations” (1991: 41), but not only against them. Pursuant to the point regarding Zion/Jerusalem vis-à-vis the iconography of the lion-with-prey, it comes as no surprise to find in these oracles a unit against *Judah* (Amos 2:4–5), as well as the climactic oracle against *Israel* (Amos 2:6–16).

Amos 3:1–2 is a second motto to the book. While it introduces language of election and wrongdoing proper, the notion of punishment that is present here is already implicit in Amos 1:2. Following upon this second motto is 3:3–8, which once again highlights the lion. The fear response that one assumes is operative in 1:2 is now made explicit in 3:8, where it is said to be the direct result of the lion’s roar (again $\sqrt{\text{šā}'}ag$). Also made explicit here is the fact that a lion’s vocalization is connected to predation, or at least is an alarm of some sort vis-à-vis prey (3:4). This, too, leads to a reanalysis of 1:2 with regard to the locations threatened by the Divine Lion. They, too, are prey, or potentially if not imminently so! Finally, 3:8 sets the roaring lion in poetic parallelism with the speech of the Lord YHWH. Parallelism, even of the so-called “synonymous” variety, need not be identical, but the connection already established between YHWH and the lion in 1:2, coupled with other texts from the Hebrew Bible (see Strawn 2005: 58–65) and iconographical pieces like those discussed earlier, indicate that this fear-inspiring and roaring Lion is, indeed, the Deity. This is just one, but significant, interpretive result when one “hunts” Amos’s lion(s) at the book level.

Before moving to the next unit of text, it should be stressed that the fearsome roar of the Divine Lion is directly related to divine speech *through* the prophetic word (3:8). Jeremiah is correct, then, when he writes that

[t]his is a commission to deliver a message of destruction. The God who speaks to Amos and whose words Amos cannot keep silent *is* like the lion roaring over its prey (v. 4). . . . Amos *has* heard the roaring of the lion (cf. 1:2); he *must* startle his people. (1998: 54; emphases original)

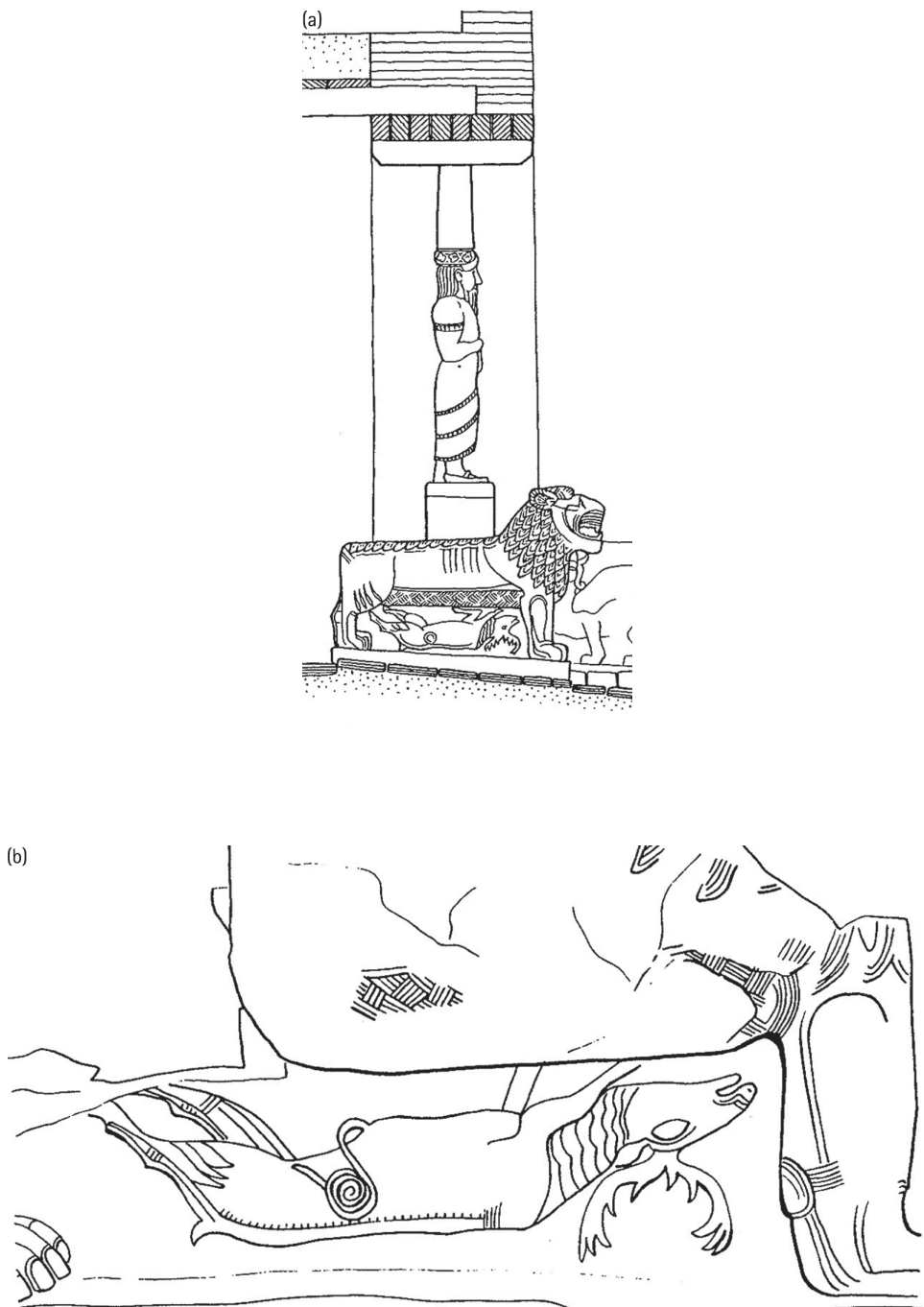


FIGURE 6.20 (a) Reconstruction of portico; Tell Halaf; 9th c.; (b) detail of disemboweled deer under lion mount. After Strawn, *What Is Stronger*, figs. 4.303–304 (used with permission).

Amos 3:9–11 specifies a specific target, Samaria, and indicates that an unidentified enemy will be used as a punitive instrument. The next lion passage follows immediately with an image highlighting the complete devastation wrought by a lion on its prey. As Harper notes, “[t]he force of the comparison lies in the insignificant character of what is rescued . . . the merest remnant, something, indeed, not worthy of mention” (1936: 81). If anything is saved or “snatched away” (*√nāṣal* Hiphil; cf. Paul 1991: 119), it is hardly worth saving, and exists, not to somehow live again, but only to prove death (cf. Ex 22:10–13 [Heb 9–12]; Paul 1991: 119–122). Perhaps the different subjects in Amos 3:12 might be identified with various entities: God, the punishing enemy, the wealthy, the poor, and so on.⁴⁸ When reading Amos as a book, however, and following the tracks of the lion(s) therein, it is hard indeed not to see the lion of 3:12 as the selfsame lion of 3:8 and 1:2. Those two verses indicate that it is none other than YHWH-as-Lion who will devour “the children of Israel” and “those who dwell in Samaria” (3:12). Still further, the connection between this Lion’s roar, this God’s speech, and the divine task of prophecy in 3:8 suggests that one of the ways YHWH executes his judgment, not to mention how the minimalistic salvaging process takes place, is precisely by means of prophetic words exactly like those of Amos.

Much takes place in Amos 3:13–5:17 that cannot be treated here, but the final instance of lion imagery found in 5:18–20 must be considered in this book-level lion hunt.⁴⁹ On first blush, Andersen and Freedman seem correct when they write that “[w]ith such a familiar image, it is unlikely that this lion [in 5:19] has anything to do with the lions in 3:4–8, which represent Yahweh” (1989: 522). Then again, 5:18 introduces the topic at hand as YHWH’s day, which is then immediately described in a succession of images in verse 19 that are chiastically framed by darkness and the absence of light in verses 18 and 20. Verse 19 moves from lion to bear to snake, perhaps in an escalation of horror, or perhaps in a vision meant more synchronously (see earlier discussion). Either way, “[t]he point is very clear: Momentary success is only illusory. . . . Precisely when Israel feels itself secure, more than ever will the deadly ‘bite’ of the ‘Day of the Lord’ take place” (Paul 1991: 186). Paul’s comment here plays on the imagery of verse 19 and YHWH’s *day*, but perhaps the association extends to YHWH *himself*. In contrast to Andersen and Freedman’s opinion to the contrary, tracing the lion across the entire book of Amos suggests that in virtually every instance the lion is YHWH (1:2; 3:4, 8, 12). This lends significant support to seeing YHWH in the lion of 5:19 as well. Indeed, this might make sense of the otherwise unusual use of the definite article in this verse, which speaks of “the lion” (*hā’ārī*), “the bear,” and “the snake.” The use is odd enough that scholars often appeal to an (oxymoronic) indefinite use of the definite article. And yet, the only other instance of this form in Amos is 3:12, where “the lion” (*hā’ārī*) is almost certainly YHWH. So also in 5:19, *the* lion in question may be the Divine Lion, as elsewhere in Amos. Of course such an interpretation would require the same understanding for *the* bear (*haddōb*) and *the* snake (*hannāḥāš*). This is not impossible by any means: Hosea 13:8 likens YHWH to a bear (*dōb*), and while snake imagery is not clearly attested for YHWH in the Old Testament, the serpent has a host of divine connotations in both the comparative data and the archaeological record.⁵⁰

Perhaps, then, YHWH lurks behind the bear and the snake as well as the lion of Amos 5:19. Whatever the case, the placement of the lion in the first position may be definitive in two ways: first, in making the divine connections clear since YHWH has been figured as a lion at several points prior to this verse; and, second, by the specific sentiment insofar as the verse states that even if someone flees from the lion (including the Lion-that-is-YHWH), there is simply no escape. Once again, the coming Day of YHWH is—as the concluding envelope in verse 20 reasserts and re-emphasizes—complete and total darkness, which is to say, devastating.

CONCLUSION

The present chapter has probed just one aspect of material culture and its pertinence for the prophets. In the case of iconography, the artistic remains can contribute to a better understanding of the motifs, images, and metaphors that are found in the prophetic texts. In select cases, attention to the iconographical data may cast light not only on singular instances of an idea in a verse here or there, but also on a host of ideas across a larger textual unit, if not an entire book. Still further, the iconographical data may occasionally prove useful in contributing to, or otherwise chastening, debates about composition and redaction. Material culture, after all, especially if it stems from controlled excavations, does offer a kind of empiricism—though not one divorced from interpretation!—that so many literary approaches, left to their own devices, simply cannot.

NOTES

1. So, e.g., Barton 2012: 76; King 1988: 72–74; Mays 1969: 131–133; Soggin 1987: 114–117; and Wolff 1977: 300–302. Cf. more generally *OEANE* 1: 363–367. A very different understanding, but one that is no less informed by material culture, is found in Jeremias 1998: 130–133.
2. See *CAD* A/2, 127–30; *AHW* 1:49.
3. Manfred Oeming, *Contemporary Biblical Hermeneutics: An Introduction* (Aldershot, UK: Ashgate 2006), 49–54.
4. See Othmar Keel, *The Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms* (New York: Seabury, 1978) for the initial breakthrough; see LeMon 2009, de Hulster 2009, and Ryan P. Bonfiglio, “Reading Images, Seeing Texts: Towards a Visual Hermeneutics for Biblical Studies” (Ph.D. diss., Emory University, 2014) for further discussion.
5. See Othmar Keel, “Iconography and the Bible,” *ABD* 3: 358–374.
6. See LeMon 2009; and LeMon, *Yahweh’s Winged Form in the Psalms: Exploring Congruent Iconography and Texts* (OBO 242; Fribourg: Academic Press, 2010).
7. The artifactual nature of the biblical text is easily forgotten with “the text” often reified in the process. I depend here on the critical edition of *BHQ* (*The Twelve Minor Prophets* [ed. Anthony Gelston; Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2010]), a scholarly product to be sure, but one based on an actual manuscript dating from ca. 1008 C.E. (Codex

- Leningradensis, B19^A). Qumran manuscripts of Amos exist (4QXII^{c-8} and 5QXII), but no variants are attested for Amos 1:2; 3:4, 8, 12; 5:18. Beyond *BHQ*, see also *BHK*, *BHS*, and *HUBP* (the latter based on the Aleppo Codex; ca. 900–925 C.E.), as well as the standard commentaries.
8. Here and elsewhere translations are my own, unless otherwise indicated (cf. Strawn 2005: 367–368).
 9. Some delete “from its den” as extraneous (see *BHS*), but see Soggin 1987: 58; Paul 1991: 110; and further discussion in this chapter.
 10. Some eliminate “My Lord” as an addition. See *BHS*; Soggin 1987: 58; and further discussion in this chapter.
 11. The last line is a notorious crux. See, *inter alia*, Soggin 1987: 61–62; *BHQ*, 80*–81*; and further discussion in this chapter.
 12. It is found with the lion in Amos 3:4, 8. Other lion passages that use this verb include Judges 14:5; Isaiah 5:29; Jeremiah 2:15; 51:38; Ezekiel 22:25; Hosea 11:10; Zephaniah 3:3; Psalms 22:14; 104:21. Nominal forms from the same root are found in Isaiah 5:29; Zechariah 11:3; and Job 4:10 (Strawn 2005: 345–349, especially 345–346).
 13. Probably the prophet himself, given 1:1, and the explicit mention of YHWH in 1:3 (so also Wolff 1977: 122; Andersen and Freedman 1989: 223).
 14. Cf., e.g., the collocation of the verb “to give/set” (*√nātan*) with the noun “voice/sound” (*qôl*) in various theophanic passages (Ps 18:13 = 2 Sam 22:14; Pss 46:6; 68:22). See Jeremias 1998: 13–14; Mays 1969: 22, 62; Paul 1991: 36–37 nn. 39, 44; Soggin 1987: 28–29. Later, Paul unites the meteorological and zoological options: “Thunder was conceived as the roar that issued from the lion’s mouth” (1991: 32 n. 61); but Wolff’s laconic remark is on target: “a thunderstorm would not cause drought” (1977: 119). Andersen and Freedman (1989: 227) concur, but think the imagery is “confused” (225), perhaps even intentionally (cf. 228). Meir Weiss, *The Bible from Within: The Method of Total Interpretation* (Jerusalem: Magnes, 1984), 202–203, deems the verse an instance of catachresis. See further discussion in this chapter.
 15. Jürg Egger, “Iconography of Animals (Mammals),” in *Encyclopedia of Material Culture in the Biblical World* (eds. Angelika Berlejung, P. M. Michèle Daviau, Jens Kamlah, and Gunnar Lehmann; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, forthcoming).
 16. Note also that a lion bone recovered from an altar room complex in ninth-century Tel Dan evidences cut marks consistent with skinning (Strawn 2005: 106).
 17. Cf. Hugh S. Pyper, “The Lion King: Yahweh as Sovereign Beast in Israel’s Imaginary,” in *The Bible and Posthumanism* (ed. Jennifer L. Koosed; SemeiaSt 74; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2014), 59–74, esp. 64, 73.
 18. Dominique Collon in *Art and Empire* (eds. J. E. Curtis and J. E. Reade; New York: Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1995), 189; cf. Strawn 2005: 142.
 19. Tallay Ornan, Shlomit Weksler-Bdolah, Shua Kisilevitz, and Benjamin Sass, “‘The Lord Will Roar from Zion’ (Amos 1:2): The Lion as a Divine Attribute on a Jerusalem Seal and Other Hebrew Glyptic Finds from the Western Wall Plaza Excavations,” *Atiqot* 72 (2012): 1*–13* (10*).
 20. See Ornan, Weksler-Bdolah, Kisilevitz, and Sass, “‘The Lord Will Roar,’” 10*.
 21. Baruch Brandl, “Scarabs, Scaraboids, Other Stamp Seals, and Seal Impressions,” in *Excavations at the City of David 1978–1985 Directed by Yigal Shiloh*, Vol. VIIB: *Area E: The Finds* (eds. Alon De Groot and Hannah Bernick-Greenberg; Qedem 54; Jerusalem: Hebrew University, 2012), 377–396 (383–384).

22. Brandl, "Scarabs," 395 n. 59.
23. Brandl, "Scarabs," 384.
24. Brandl, "Scarabs," 395 n. 57.
25. Ornan, Weksler-Bdolah, Kisilevitz, and Sass, "'The Lord Will Roar,'" 7*.
26. See Ornan, Weksler-Bdolah, Kisilevitz, and Sass, "'The Lord Will Roar,'" 7*.
27. Benjamin Sass, "The Pre-Exilic Hebrew Seals: Iconism vs. Aniconism," in *Studies in the Iconography of Northwest Semitic Inscribed Seals* (eds. Benjamin Sass and Christoph Uehlinger; OBO 125; Fribourg: University Press, 1993), 94–256 (222).
28. Cf. Ornan, Weksler-Bdolah, Kisilevitz, and Sass, "'The Lord Will Roar,'" 8*, who note that the low quality of the Jerusalem seal, coupled with a lack of title for its owner, argues against the owner being of high rank.
29. He placed three of these in the eighth century among Amos and his immediate disciples. Andersen and Freedman believe that the quest to determine which parts "come from Amos himself, or from circles very close to him . . . practically amounts to the same thing" (1989: 143).
30. Dirk U. Rottzoll, *Studien zur Redaktion und Komposition des Amosbuchs* (BZAW 243; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1996).
31. Andersen and Freedman 1989: 141: "Each scholar has his [or her] own list, for there is no surefire technique for distinguishing authentic Amos materials from the additions of later scribes."
32. Not all would agree, of course; see, e.g., Barton 2012: 34 for the possibility that 3:3–6 and 3:8 are later, albeit eighth-century, supplements.
33. This is a matter of some debate. Many commentators directly attribute much of the leonine imagery in Amos, not to mention its accuracy, to the prophet's presumed vocation as shepherd (cf. Wolff 1977: 125; Paul 1991: 185). Harper is especially fond of this (e.g., 1936: 68, 81, and esp. 132 [on 5:19]: "The comparison is singularly appropriate in view of the occupation of Amos, for it was an everyday experience"). Contrast, however, Aulikki Nahkola, "Amos Animalizing: Lion, Bear and Snake in Amos 5.19," in *Aspects of Amos: Exegesis and Interpretation* (eds. Anselm C. Hagedorn and Andrew Mein; LHBOTS 536; New York: T & T Clark, 2011), 83–104, who argues that encounters with such dangerous animals were rare and for this reason memorable and powerful.
34. See, respectively, Strawn 2005: 345–349; and George B. Schaller, *The Serengeti Lion: A Study of Predator-Prey Relations* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972), 103–115.
35. See Edward R. Hope, "Problems of Interpretation in Amos 3.4," *BT* 42 (1991): 201–205; Mays 1969: 60–61; Wolff 1977: 185.
36. Indeed, this latter option may be quite likely. See Bonfiglio, "Reading Images, Seeing Texts"; also Joel M. LeMon and Brent A. Strawn, "Once More, YHWH and Company at Kuntillet 'Ajrud," *Maarav* 20.1 (2013): 83–114 and Pls. VI–VII.
37. Siegfried Mittmann, "Amos 3,12–15 und das Bett der Samarier," *ZDPV* 92 (1976): 149–167.
38. Cf. also Wolff 1977: 198, who referred to images of beds collected in *ANEP* (nos. 451, 658, 660).
39. Cf. Strawn 2005: 107 for the irony of this situation.
40. Nahkola, "Amos Animalizing," 104.
41. Perhaps the bear in Amos 5:19 is a West Semitic or Levantine element. Cf. the discussion of 1 Samuel 17 in Strawn 2005: 236–248.
42. I leave aside here the vexed question of the overlap between Amos 1:2; Joel 3:16 (Heb 4:16) and Jeremiah 25:30. See, *inter alia*, Andersen and Freedman 1989: 219; Barton

- 2012: 35; Paul 1991: 41; Soggin 1987: 28; Weiss, *Bible from Within*, 194–240; and Wolff 1977: 81, 122–123.
43. The primary driver in the verse is zoological—the lion’s roar—not meteorological. See Soggin 1987: 30; Weiss, *Bible from Within*, 208–219.
 44. See also Andersen and Freedman 1989: 144, who take issue with virtually every point raised by Wolff and others of similar opinion: the hymnic material may not be late but “primal . . . quite in tune with Amos’ prophetic outlook as a whole”; eschatological elements could be ancient (cf. 5:18–20); and the non-oracular criterion is insufficient grounds for determining authenticity.
 45. Cf. Andersen and Freedman 1989: 143: the redaction-critical “enterprise seems to have exhausted itself in its conduct along the lines laid down in the nineteenth century.”
 46. See further Weiss, *Bible from Within*, 218–219 on the meaning of Carmel.
 47. See Weiss, *Bible from Within*, 212, 214; cf. Paul 1991: 40.
 48. See D. Matthew Stith, “Whose Lion Is It Anyway?” *Koinonia* 11 (1999): 103–118, for a discussion of possible referents for the lion, *YHWH* being just one of these. Contrast Andersen and Freedman 1989: 408, who argue that the unit is not “a detailed allegory,” and that the focus is “not on the responsibility of the shepherd but on the devastation of the flock.”
 49. I must also leave discussion of Amos 5:21–9:15 for another time.
 50. See Marjo Korpel, *A Rift in the Clouds: Ugaritic and Hebrew Descriptions of the Divine* (UBL 8; Münster: Ugarit-Verlag, 1990), 553–558; and James H. Charlesworth, *The Good and Evil Serpent: How a Universal Symbol Became Christianized* (AYBRL; New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2010).

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CHAPTER 7

TEXTUAL CRITICISM OF THE PROPHETIC CORPUS

EBERHARD BONS

WHOEVER wants to study the prophetic texts of the Hebrew Bible, let alone their translation in a modern language, is faced with a large number of philological and linguistic problems: Hebrew words and phrases might be rare, difficult to understand, even completely enigmatic.* In many cases, problems cannot be easily solved by comparing the extant Hebrew wording with other textual witnesses of the given prophetic quotation, for example other Hebrew sources if available (namely the Qumran scrolls), ancient translations, and quotations in ancient commentaries. On the contrary, problems might become much greater because these documents often exhibit textual variants that diverge considerably from the Hebrew text. In other words, the difficulties of the biblical text often do not diminish but rather increase when textual variants come into play.

INTRODUCTION

The aim of this chapter is to give an introduction to the essential issues, questions, and methods of textual criticism of the prophetic books of the Hebrew Bible (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Twelve Minor Prophets). Particular focus will be placed on their major textual witnesses: the Masoretic Text (MT), the Septuagint as the oldest pre-Christian translation of the biblical text (LXX), the Qumran fragments of the prophetic corpus, and the Vulgate. Needless to say, all these prophetic texts cover several hundreds of pages that display a wide range of textual problems. In fact, every chapter and every verse presents difficulties of its own, each of which requires a careful analysis. Often it turns out that a problematic word or phrase or its textual variant can be explained only against the background of the biblical book in question or of other biblical, or even non-biblical or non-Jewish, texts. Therefore, it is difficult to make general statements about the text-critical situation of each of the prophetic books, at least in an introductory

essay, and at any rate a “one size fits all” approach to text-critical issues ought to be avoided. In addition, it should be highlighted that textual criticism has been in transition since the 1980s. Indeed, methods and procedures used for over a century have become more and more controversial. On the one hand, the number of textual resources has increased since the discovery of the Dead Sea scrolls so that there is much more material to be taken into consideration; on the other hand, text-critical methods have been refined compared to earlier research. Therefore, this chapter confines itself to presenting basic text-critical issues of each of the books of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Twelve Minor prophets. Attention will be paid to new methods and procedures, using a number of selected examples, each of which illustrates a specific category of problems.

THE PROBLEM

Let us start with a simple example. The MT of Amos 3:5a literally reads (see also NRSV): “Does a bird fall in a net on the earth when there is no trap for it?” Obviously, the text quotes an example borrowed from the field of hunting of birds. However, on closer inspection, some questions arise: Why does the bird fall on the earth? Has it been hit by a fowler? And if so, why then is the net *on the earth* necessary? Admittedly, even if the text is not entirely incomprehensible, some details concerning the exact manner of hunting remain open. This leads to the question of whether the MT preserves the original Hebrew wording. Interestingly, in the Qumran fragments, the corresponding Hebrew text is not preserved. However, the LXX, as the oldest ancient translation of the Hebrew biblical text, surprisingly provides no equivalent for the Hebrew noun translated by “net.” Indeed, the LXX reads, “will a bird fall upon the ground without a fowler?” (NETS). In the past, commentators and editors of critical editions of Amos have seen this as an argument to claim that the noun “net” in the MT cannot be original, but must be the result of a mistake or the oversight of an ancient copyist.¹ If this were the case, the LXX could be considered an indirect textual witness of an original Hebrew wording supposed to have gone lost in the process of textual transmission, either by mistake or for other reasons.

Admittedly, this variant has no major consequences for the interpretation of the passage. In other cases, however, theological issues are at stake. In the MT of Hosea 5:2, for example, God announces himself to be “a discipline [*mûsār*] to all of them” (i.e., for Israelites or at least for the sinners in Israel). Many modern translations paraphrase, saying, for example, “I will punish all of them” (NRSV). Nevertheless, the problem remains: God describes himself as a “discipline” for Israelites. In this case, too, the variants are supposed to contribute to solving the problem. In fact, neither the LXX nor the Vulgate has a *nomen actionis* (“discipline”) but a *nomen actoris* (“one that disciplines you” [NETS]): *paideutês* (LXX), *eruditor* (Vulgate). On the assumption that these translations presuppose a corresponding Hebrew word, the graphic difference would be

small: the Hebrew word for “discipline” is *mûsâr*, whereas “one that disciplines” corresponds to the participle *m^eyassêr*. As vowels were not written, the only real difference is between the consonants *yod* and *waw*, two letters that could easily be confused. Be this as it may, the crucial question is whether the MT preserves the older textual tradition—even if the text is somewhat difficult—or whether the form *mûsâr* is erroneous. In this latter hypothesis, the variant readings of the later translations—LXX and Vulgate—would give access, although indirectly, to an allegedly older Hebrew text.² But not only that: the divine title “one that disciplines” or “educator,” which later appears in the New Testament (see Heb 12:9), would not go back to the LXX but already to the Hebrew text of the book of Hosea (see also Deut 8:5). Of course, this variant, which can only be reconstructed, is not attested in the extant Hebrew manuscripts. The Qumran manuscripts cannot help, either, because the verse in question is not preserved. Nevertheless, it can be objected that the reading “I am one that disciplines” would be exceptional in the context of Hosea’s oracles. In fact, rather than identifying God explicitly with an earthly reality, the book of Hosea prefers either comparisons introduced by “like” (e.g., Hos 5:12) or verbal metaphors (e.g., Hos 7:12), instead of nouns.³

These two examples might illustrate the problem: The texts of the Old Testament prophets are not only available in different ancient languages, namely Hebrew, Greek, Latin, Syriac (to mention just the most important ones), but the different versions of the text appear to diverge considerably on various levels—for example, word order, contents, ideas—not always but very often. In each case, the question arises anew: Which variant reading should be given the preference? Which one appears to be older, and which one appears to be the result of a later correction or interpretation? Or vice versa, which more recent variant could be considered a correction of an older text that is incorrect? Finally, what are the arguments in favor of one reading and against the other?

TRADITIONAL APPROACHES OF TEXT CRITICISM

For more than a century, authors and translators aimed at reconstructing a presumably original text, sometimes referred to as “Urtext.” It is obvious that this text is not necessarily identical with the text the biblical author himself has actually written. Moreover, in most cases it is difficult to determine whether such a text reflects a relatively late stage of the development of the biblical book in question (i.e., the alleged source of the LXX), or if it really has much more ancient origins. Be this as it may, even if it is difficult, if not impossible, to gain access to these supposedly earlier stages of the texts of the prophetic books, scholars use different criteria to identify alterations that could have affected their transmission and generated textual variants. To mention just the most important ones,

several factors can be taken into consideration: scribal errors, misreadings, influence of similar or parallel texts, modifications such as additions and omissions, interventions aiming at clarifying the text, theological corrections, and so on.⁴

To return to the examples quoted earlier, several questions arise in light of the aforementioned criteria. As for Amos 3:5a, the crucial word is “net,” which is missing in the LXX. Can we therefore take for granted that the shorter variant (i.e., the LXX text) is the better one, or to say it with a Latin expression frequently used in textual criticism: Is the *lectio brevior* (“the shorter reading”; i.e., without “net”) the *lectio potior* (“the better reading”) in this case as well? As we have seen, this hypothesis has been taken into consideration. However, it has the disadvantage that it cannot explain why the word “net” would have been introduced in the Hebrew text. Interestingly, in his Latin translations of the passage in question, Jerome indirectly confirms the divergence between the two texts insofar as his Latin version of the LXX text has no equivalent of the noun “net” (CCSL 76: 245: *si cadet avis super terram sine aucupe?* Literally, “does a bird fall on the ground without a fowler?”). The ancient Syriac translation, the so-called Peshitta, also reads the word “into a trap.” This means that the divergence between the LXX and the Hebrew text has already originated in antiquity and not in a later epoch. Unfortunately, the words in question are not preserved in the Qumran fragments, the first line of Amos 3:5 being preserved neither in 4QXII^c nor in other manuscripts of the Dead Sea.

In the case of Hosea 5:2, the application of the criteria quoted earlier does not lead to clear-cut results. Is the Greek variant the result of the translator’s confusion of the Hebrew letters *waw* and *yod*, which could actually be very similar? Or is the MT variant the result of an adaption—either erroneous or intentional—to other prophetic texts using the noun *mûsâr* with reference to God (e.g., Jer 5:3; 7:28)? In other words, did the supposed “Urtext” of Hosea 5:2 read, “I am the one that disciplines,” or “I am a discipline”? It seems impossible to rule out either of the two hypotheses and to reach a conclusion as to whether one variant is original while the other is of later date. In the absence of other ancient sources that could be used as criteria, the problem remains open.

For the sake of completeness, it should be mentioned that (at least in the past) biblical scholars felt the need to correct words or phrases supposed to be corrupt, even if the correction was not based on an extant variant. A so-called conjecture or emendation can still be found in the critical apparatus of Hosea 5:2 in the *BHS* where the editor of the volume proposes to read the form *môšêr*, a noun that means “bond, chain” (Isa 52:2). This form has the advantage that its consonants are identical with those of the MT, but it is neither attested in the extant manuscripts, nor can it be considered the Hebrew original of one of the existing ancient translations. In newer text-critical research, scholars tend to avoid such conjectures or emendations because of their hypothetical nature. The most important caveat is that our knowledge of the Hebrew language, of style and rhetoric, is limited,⁵ and this holds true for prophetic texts as well.

FROM TEXTUAL CRITICISM TO THE HISTORY OF THE BIBLICAL TEXT AND ITS INTERPRETATION

In the last three decades, serious doubts have been expressed about whether it is possible to reconstruct an “Urtext” of the Hebrew Bible—even if only the text at some stage prior to the origins of the LXX (third century B.C.E.).⁶ Admittedly, in certain cases it can be argued with some degree of certainty that the MT as it stands is erroneous. An example will be given later in this chapter (Hos 7:13). But on the whole, a Hebrew text to be reconstructed only on the basis of the oldest textual witnesses today appears to be out of reach.

Of course, this situation is due at least partially to the fact that the oldest extant textual documents of the Hebrew Bible date from the last two, perhaps three centuries B.C.E. However, even if older documents were available, the text-critical situation would not change substantially. First of all, it stands to reason that the result of the reconstruction of a supposedly older text always remains hypothetical. But there are two more disadvantages in correcting the MT in the light of other textual witnesses. First, this method risks introducing elements into the MT that belong to other stages of the textual development of the book in question. Second, such a correction consists in replacing a single element of the MT by another one borrowed from a different source, the context and literary features of which are neglected. In fact, even if for a long time other versions of the biblical text have been used like a quarry, the variants of which were deemed more fitting or more appropriate, this method is no longer convincing.⁷ Instead, one has to make sure that the alleged variant is a real variant, that is, that it cannot be explained by other factors, such as a different interpretation of matters dealt with in the text in question, the influence of its immediate or larger context, or elements of the translation technique adopted by the individual translators. In other words, if a variant has arisen from the translation process or from features inherent to its context, it cannot be used for correcting the MT. For this reason, it is crucial to check the context of a given passage carefully: Does it really provide variants like “spare parts” supposed to improve a biblical text considered difficult or enigmatic? Or can these variants be explained against the background of their individual context or by the translation technique? In these latter cases, it cannot serve to correct the MT.

These considerations can contribute to a better understanding of the variants in Amos 3:5a and Hosea 5:2.⁸ In Amos 3:5a, for reasons unknown to us, the LXX renders the Hebrew noun *môqēš* (perhaps a lure that is attached to the trap) by the Greek technical term *ixeutēs*, which occurs nowhere else in biblical literature except here in the book of Amos. As can be illustrated by some ancient texts (e.g., Fable 115, “The

Fowler and the Snake,” attributed to the Greek author Aesopus), this latter word designates a fowler who catches birds by means of birdlime and reeds. That means that this kind of fowler uses neither traps nor nets. Hence, the idea of bird hunting underlying the LXX version of Amos 3:5 is different from that of the MT, and it is probably this understanding of the text which explains why the LXX has no equivalent for the word “net.” The following line of Amos 3:5, however, mentions another procedure: A snare on the ground does not spring up without catching anything. So far so good, but the problem is more complex than that. In the LXX text of Amos 8:1–2, the *ixeutés* appears once more, namely in a prophetic vision, the Greek text of which is quite different from the MT. The use of the noun *ixeutés* in this passage is as difficult to explain as in Amos 3:5. Did the translator have the same procedure in mind, that is, bird hunting as a symbol for the disaster threatening Israel? We cannot rule out this possibility. Nonetheless, it is not surprising that the interpretation of the LXX of Amos has gone its own way since antiquity. Thus, the patristic commentary written by Theodoret of Cyrus (fifth century C.E.), interprets Amos 8:1–2 in the light of Amos 3:5: “Just as birds are easily caught with birdlime, so the people [i.e., Israel] will be caught by the Assyrians” (PG 81: 1700).

As for Hosea 5:2, it is interesting to note that the LXX develops the idea of “discipline” using the verb *paideúō* and other words of this root, even if the Hebrew text does not at all speak of discipline. This is the case in the LXX text of Hosea 7:14, 16; 10:10b. In these passages it is obvious that God is the one who disciplines Israel, or this idea can at least be inferred from the context. The noun *paideutés* in the LXX therefore perfectly fits the context of the LXX version of Hosea. But does it follow that the translators “invented” this variant? Or did they find it in their Hebrew source text? Again, it is impossible to take a clear position because we lack valid criteria, other ancient textual witnesses not being available. Be that as it may, as we have seen earlier, the idea of divine discipline or education has been developed in later Christian texts (see Heb 12:9). Therefore, the variant of the LXX is the source of later Christian reflections about God’s relationship to humans, which cannot be reduced to the denominator “divine punishment” (e.g., Clement of Alexandria, *Paed.* I, 7: 53). That is why the latter example shows that traditional textual criticism, by focusing on the reconstruction of a text prior to the manuscript evidence, overshadows an important reality: The biblical texts have been handed down in various traditions and versions; these date from various epochs and display various features, on the levels of form and content, that have an impact on later theological reflections. Therefore, an important task of recent research consists in tracing the development of biblical texts, especially in antiquity, from the oldest extant sources to all sorts of later ramifications. Obviously, this approach is based on the assumption that the alleged oldest form of the text is not the only one of interest. On the contrary, biblical research interested in the history of the text puts more emphasis on the entire range of later variant readings, insofar as they are witnesses of a wide variety of theological appropriations of the biblical texts in the various Jewish and Christian communities.⁹

TEXTUAL CRITICISM OF THE BOOKS OF ISAIAH, JEREMIAH, EZEKIEL, AND THE TWELVE MINOR PROPHETS: CURRENT DEBATES AND EXAMPLES

One of the goals of this chapter is to present some major debates of current text-critical research of the different prophetic books. In order to illustrate how these problems have been addressed in the past and how they are dealt with in current research, we will provide some selected examples. At the outset, it should be stressed that text-critical research of the prophetic books has fundamentally changed after the discovery and publication of the Qumran biblical manuscripts. However, for each book the situation is different, depending on to what extent these textual witnesses correspond either to the MT or to the LXX, or to neither of the two. Needless to say, the evaluation of these documents and their text-critical value is subject to controversy in current research.

Isaiah

In recent decades, text-critical research on Isaiah has been influenced by two factors. On the one hand, the discovery of the Qumran manuscripts, especially of the almost complete scroll 1QIsa^a, has provided precious material to be compared with the MT and other ancient versions of Isaiah. On the other hand, attention has been focused on the LXX of Isaiah, a rather free translation of its Hebrew source text. To what extent does it reflect the Hebrew Isaiah? To what extent has the translator created a “new” text? To what extent does the LXX translation reflect contemporary Jewish Hellenistic theological ideas or debates?¹⁰ In recent research, debate on these issues continues, and many minor problems and local textual issues are far from being solved. In order to give insight into the problems, we shall present two short examples:

1. In Isaiah 58:6, God asks the rhetorical question of whether a sincere conversion does not consist only in fasting but also in commitment to social justice. At the end of an enumeration of works of charity, the verse speaks of breaking “every yoke” (*kol môtāh*). This wording (except for the vowels) is confirmed by 1QIsa^a. The yoke to be broken evokes the idea of forced labor, namely in the field of agriculture and building projects. The LXX, however, diverges from this idea, rendering the end of the verse as follows: *pâsan suggraphên ádikon díáspa* (“tear up every unjust note”; NETS). This idea is certainly borrowed from another social context, insofar as a *suggraphê* is a written contract (see, e.g., Tob 7:14). The noun is used in numerous papyri dealing with loans (e.g., BGU 6 1278, 215/214 B.C.E.). Consequently, an

“unjust note” is probably a contract the aim of which is to take advantage of poor or defenseless people. In his commentary, Jerome quotes the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible by Symmachus that he renders as follows: *omnem cautionem falsam disrumpe* (“each false guarantee tear up”). Jerome places the contracts in question in the context of widespread usurious practices by which the poor are exploited (CCSL 73A: 665). In conclusion, the LXX translation of the yoke to be broken in Isaiah 58:6 represents a new contextualization of the idea peculiar to the MT and 1QIsa^a. Needless to say, this variant has no consequence for textual criticism of the MT. Nevertheless, it is important for the history of the biblical text and its interpretation.

2. In another case, the LXX provides a very free translation that reflects specific theological ideas unknown to the Hebrew source text. It may suffice to quote one example. In Isaiah 54:16, God declares: “See it is I who have created the smith who blows the fire of coals, and produces a weapon fit for its purpose; I have also created the ravager to destroy” (NRSV). The Qumran scroll 1QIsa^a confirms the MT. The LXX, however, diverges considerably from the Hebrew text: “See, I create *you, not as a* smith who blows the coals, and produces a vessel for work. But I have created *you not for destruction*” (NETS, italics mine). Rather than presenting God as the origin of the smith who creates and the ravager who destroys (for a similar idea, see also Isa 45:7), the LXX completely changes the meaning of the text: God is the creator of Jerusalem (“you”). Unlike the smith who forges an object for everyday use, God does not create a short-lived object. Instead, he creates Jerusalem so as not to be destroyed ever again. It is evident that the LXX translation reinforces ideas of creation theology attested elsewhere in Hellenistic Jewish theology, in particular the idea that God does not create at random or in vain, but that each of his creatures has been created deliberately and for a specific purpose (see, e.g., Hos 13:4^{LXX}; Wis 1:13–14; Sir 39:21). In other words, the LXX translation of Isa 54:16 cannot be used in order to correct the MT, which is understandable. On the contrary, it is the earliest witness of an interpretation of the Hebrew text of Isaiah, a kind of “update” that reflects contemporary theological ideas.

Jeremiah

Text-critical research on the book of Jeremiah is faced with the puzzling problem that the LXX text is about one-seventh shorter than the MT.¹¹ Furthermore, the order of the book is considerably different from Jeremiah 25:14 onward. Interestingly, the pluses of the MT are scattered over many chapters of the book. The divergences between the two versions include omissions of single words, phrases, and sentences, even of longer passages (e.g., Jer 39:4–13). The key question is therefore how to explain this evidence. In principle, different scenarios can be considered: (1) two Hebrew versions were in circulation—a longer and a shorter one—of which the latter was translated into Greek;

(2) the LXX is an abridged version of an underlying Hebrew text; (3) both MT and LXX are independent revisions of a common source text; or (4) the MT as it stands is a revision of the shorter Hebrew source text, which became the *Vorlage* of the LXX.

This latter hypothesis, which is today shared by the majority of scholars, is essentially based on two arguments: (1) two of the Qumran manuscripts of the book of Jeremiah, 4QJer^b and 4QJer^d, provide a text matching—at least partially—the supposed Hebrew source of the Jeremiah-LXX; (2) the numerous pluses of the Jeremiah-MT are characterized by a so-called pre-Masoretic idiolect (i.e., by a large number of words and phrases, many of which are not attested elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible).¹² Certain linguistic features of the pluses of the MT can be attributed to the influence of late Hebrew, attested, for example, in Qumran and in Ben Sira.

Taken together, these arguments make a strong case for concluding that the MT pluses of the book of Jeremiah are the result of a revision of an originally shorter Hebrew text. This pre-Masoretic version probably dates from the late fourth or early third century B.C.E.¹³ Be that as it may, it is certain that in the history of the text of Jeremiah, ways separated, perhaps before the book was translated into Greek. This results, on the one hand, in a textual tradition that is the product of various expansions the Hebrew text underwent in Persian and/or Hellenistic times, and on the other hand, in a shorter text of which the oldest manuscript traces have been found in Qumran and which for about two millennia was known only in its Greek version.

To cite an example that has attracted the attention of scholars since the discovery of the Qumran Jeremiah text, the differences in Jeremiah 10:1–10 require an explanation. In the MT, this passage provides a critique of idols in verses 3–5 and 8–9, whereas verses 6–8, 10 are a kind of hymn to the God of Israel. Of course, the Hebrew text, as it stands, “has an integrity of its own,” as has been claimed by scholars.¹⁴ Nevertheless, it is worth noting that neither the LXX nor 4QJer^b offers the verses in question.

In recent decades, much ink has been spilled over these verses because the divergences require a detailed comparison. First of all, it is obvious that in its Hebrew version the text takes a different turn. Moreover, it is necessary to take into consideration the entire book of Jeremiah in order to shed more light on the pluses. In the context of this chapter, only some remarks can be made. The LXX invites the Israelites not to fear the idols of the nations (v 5). The Hebrew text goes beyond that, saying that the nations must fear YHWH (vv 7, 10). In other words, it did not appear sufficient to claim that the gods of the nations were powerless. On the contrary, the Hebrew text affirms that YHWH is the “king of the nations” (v 7), a divine title that is nowhere else attested in the Hebrew Bible. In conclusion, the pluses of the Hebrew text aim at creating a link between God and the nations, thus reflecting the idea of a universal kingdom of God.

Ezekiel

In recent decades, compared to the book of Jeremiah, the book of Ezekiel has played a less important role in text-critical research. On the whole, it can be stated that the

Dead Sea scrolls do not provide much material of text-critical value.¹⁵ Some fragments closely match the MT, whereas others correspond, here and there, to the Hebrew source of the LXX. The Masada scroll (MasEz) published in the 1990s includes some more fragments that appear to display a close relation to the future MT. As for the LXX, the Greek translation is about 4%–5% shorter than the MT, perhaps reflecting an earlier Hebrew source. On the other hand, it contains a series of pluses not contained in the MT (e.g., in Ezek 18:8 the word *argúrion*, “money”). Text-critical research on the book of Ezekiel has reached a new phase since the Papyrus 967 has been taken into consideration. This Greek papyrus, dating from the third century C.E., is characterized by a great number of variant readings, of which some are hitherto attested only in Codex B (Vaticanus). They are supposed to represent, at least partially, a stage of the text that comes closer to the so-called “Old Greek” (i.e., the earliest stages of the history of the LXX). However, scholars are not unanimous on this question. Furthermore, the situation is complicated by the fact that a critical edition of LXX-Ezekiel, including Papyrus 967, is not yet available (as of 2016). All in all, as in other prophetic books, textual criticism of the book of Ezekiel is faced with a huge number of data that require both overall studies (e.g., of chapters, of translation technique) and in-depth analyses of single verses or phrases. The two following examples chosen from the LXX illustrate that each case is not only different but requires an individual analysis.

1. The text of Ezekiel 18:10–11 contrasts two persons, a father and his son, the first being considered righteous, whereas the son is presented as an evildoer. In the MT, the last words of verse 10 and the first words of verse 11 are obviously corrupt (literally: “and he has done alas! even one of these, and he, he has not done all these”). The LXX, however, offers a text that is entirely understandable: “[a son] committing sins, he did not walk in the way of his righteous father.” It is without doubt that the vocabulary of the LXX, especially the phrase “to walk in someone’s ways,” is somewhat stereotypical and reminiscent of so-called Deuteronomistic language. However, it occurs elsewhere in the book of Ezekiel, both in the Hebrew and the Greek text (Ezek 16:47; 23:31). It is certainly right to conclude that the LXX reading “looks like an attempt to make sense of an uncertain text.”¹⁶ At any rate, the Greek translation is presumably one of the oldest traces not only of the translation of the phrase in question but also of its interpretation. In fact, the problem of the Hebrew text seems to be old, as can be shown by a textual witness that dates from the end of the fourth century C.E. In his commentary on Ezekiel, Jerome quotes a slightly different version of the text in Latin translation: *et fecerit unum de istis* (“and he has made some of these”; CCSL 75: 242). However, once more the question arises of what this text wants to say.
2. In another case, the LXX seems to create a problem, whereas the Hebrew text is perfectly understandable. In Ezekiel 16:3 the MT reads, “There was no one to cut your navel-string” (i.e., of the newborn female child that represents Jerusalem). The immediate context mentions other measures of care, such as wrapping in swaddling clothes. Surprisingly, the LXX reads “you did not bind

your breasts” (Codex B) or “they did not bind your breasts” (Codex A and other LXX manuscripts). Obviously, this reading does not fit the specific context that deals with the care of a newborn child. However, it is possible to explain it, at least in part.¹⁷ It is probably caused by a misreading at the stage of translation: instead of reading the word *šōr* (“navel-cord”), the translator renders a graphically similar word, *šad* (“female breast”), which occurs some verses later in Ezekiel 16:7. Perhaps the translator had in mind that one day the newborn child would be mature, even willing to look for suitors.¹⁸ Nevertheless, even if the LXX variant is the result of a misreading, it has influenced later interpretation, as can be seen in ancient Christian homilies and commentaries on the passage (e.g., Origen, *Hom. Ezech.* 6 [GCS 33]; Jerome, *Comm. Ezech.* [CCSL 75: 162–163]).

The Twelve Minor Prophets

For more than one reason, the text-critical situation of the Twelve Minor Prophets (henceforward XII) has changed very much in recent decades, namely after the discovery of the Dead Sea scrolls.¹⁹ Hebrew fragments of these prophetic books are contained in various Qumran manuscripts of the biblical text (especially in 4Q XII^{a–g}; 5Q Amos) as well as in a scroll found at Wadi Murabbaʿat (Mur XII). Furthermore, in the Qumran Pesharim (especially of the books of Hosea, Nahum, and Habakkuk), single words or verses of the XII are quoted and commented upon. On the one hand, it can be observed that the text of the XII contained in all of these manuscripts to a large part corresponds to the unvocalized MT. On the other, important variants should be noted, some of which match neither the MT nor the extant LXX texts.²⁰ Furthermore, a manuscript was discovered that is of great importance for textual criticism and text history: a scroll found at Naḥal Ḥever that contains parts of the Greek texts of the XII (8ḤevXII gr), namely, fragments of six books: Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, and Zechariah. Where recognizable, this scroll diverges slightly from the LXX text, creating a Greek translation that is closer to the MT than the LXX is. For this reason, the Greek translation of 8ḤevXII gr has been compared with that attributed to Aquila, who about two centuries later had created a very literal Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible. The French scholar Dominique Barthélemy, who was one of the first scholars to analyze 8ḤevXII gr, argued therefore that the “devanciers d’Aquila” (“precursors of Aquila”) can already be recognized in the tendency underlying this manuscript of the Judean Desert.²¹

In the first sections of the present chapter, two examples of textual criticism of the XII have been dealt with in detail (Hos 5:2; Amos 3:5a). In order to complete the panorama of text critical difficulties of the XII, it is useful to present three other examples, each of which shows that simple solutions should be avoided. On the contrary, given the current state of knowledge, it proves necessary to analyze each variant carefully, taking into consideration a range of possible explanations.

1. In Hosea 7:14, the MT reads the verb *yitgôrârû*, the meaning of which in the given context is more than doubtful: “they are sojourners” (?), “they attack” (?). The LXX translates by *katetémnonto* “they were gashing themselves” (NETS). The same Greek verb form occurs in 3 Kingdoms 18:28 (1 Kgs 18:28^{MT}), where it refers to an element of the cult of Baal (i.e., gashing of flesh, presumably a sign of self-abasement). Interestingly, the MT equivalent is *wayyitgôd^edû*, which precisely means “and they cut themselves.” In Hebrew letters, the two forms differ only slightly: instead of the two consonants *resh* in Hosea 7:14, the verbal form of 1 Kings 18:28 twice has the consonant *dalet*. Apparently, these two letters have been confused in the course of the transmission of the Hebrew text. Perhaps in medieval Jewish manuscripts the form with two *dalet* was still known.²² At any rate, not only the LXX but also other ancient translations like the Vulgate and the Peshitta confirm the variant “they cut themselves.” Therefore, it seems legitimate in this case to suggest a correction of the MT that follows the ancient translations.²³
2. In order to gain insight in the evolution of the prophetic texts in the last century B.C.E., a brief look at Jonah 1:14 might be useful. In this verse, the sailors invoke the LORD, saying: “Do not make us guilty of innocent blood” (i.e., in the event that they throw Jonah into the sea). The expression “innocent blood” is attested in the MT (*dām nāqî*). Interestingly, the LXX reads “righteous blood” (*haîma dikaion*), a rendering of *dām nāqî* that can be found also in Joel 4:19 (3:19^{LXX}). The phrase *haîma dikaion* occurs even in the New Testament (Matt 23:35). By contrast, 8HēvXII gr does not read the adjective *dikaion* but the letters *athō* that probably belong to the adjective form *athōon* (“guiltless”). It is interesting to observe that elsewhere in the LXX, the phrase *haîma athōon* (“innocent blood”) is quite frequent (e.g., Deut 27:25; Ps 93:21; 105:38^{LXX}; Jer 7:6; 22:3), and its Hebrew equivalent is always *dām nāqî*. This leads to the conclusion that the LXX translator of the XII, in preferring *haîma dikaion*, appears to opt for a rendering of *dām nāqî* different from that of other LXX books. Perhaps a century later, in the course of the first century B.C.E., the scribal circles responsible for the 8HēvXII gr scroll sought to correct the existing LXX text in order to achieve a more literal translation. Unfortunately, the part of the scroll that included Joel 4:19 is not conserved. Anyway, the variant conserved in 8HēvXII gr is an early indirect textual witness of the future MT that does not read “righteous” but “innocent.” The LXX variant, however, is confirmed by Jerome, who translates the Greek text by *sanguinem iustum* (CCSL 76: 391).
3. In another case the LXX text diverges considerably from the MT for different reasons. Zephaniah 2:11 reads: “The LORD will be terrible [MT: *nôrāh*] against them; he will shrivel [MT: *rāzāh*] all the gods of the earth” (NRSV). The LXX, however, provides the following translation: “The LORD will appear [*epiphanēsetai*] against them, and he will utterly destroy [*exolethreúsei*] all the gods of the nations of the earth” (NETS).
 - (a) To begin with, the rendering of Hebrew *nôrāh* by the future passive of *epiphaînomai* “to appear” might be due to a confusion of two Hebrew roots: *yārē* “to fear” and *ûr* “to become bright.” In fact, the Hebrew verb *ûr* in

some places corresponds to the Greek verb *epiphainō* (e.g., in Num 6:25). Nevertheless, this consideration can only explain why the Greek translator could have opted for the verb *epiphainomai* rather than for the adjective *phoberós* “fearful” (see, e.g., Gen 28:17; MT: *nôrāh*). However, the question remains open of which specific connotation the verb *epiphainomai* carries in this context. On closer inspection, it suits the context perfectly because it can denote, *inter alia*, the apparition of a deity. This connotation is less frequent in biblical literature (see, e.g., Gen 35:7; Jer 36:14^{LXX}; see also Mal 1:14, the adjective *epiphanés* as Greek translation of *nôrāh*), but quite often is attested in non-Jewish Greek literature (e.g., Herodotus, *Histories*, II: 91).

- (b) The verb *rāzāh* is a hapax, the exact meaning of which probably was unknown to the LXX translator of the XII. The choice of the verb *exoletbreúō* is not surprising in the light of other LXX quotations that go in the same direction (e.g., 4 Kgdms 18:4; Zech 13:2). Perhaps it is a kind of *Verlegenheitsübersetzung*, meant to make sense of an enigmatic verb.
- (c) Obviously, the LXX has a plus: “all the gods of the nations of the earth.” Interestingly, the words *tôn ethnôn* have no equivalent in the extant textual witnesses, while in the Mur XII the verse in question is only partially preserved. Admittedly, it is possible that the plus is due to a theological consideration, the translator taking offense at the idea that the earth should have a large number of deities.²⁴ However, the LXX phrase occurs once more in 2 Chronicles 32:17. Hence, it is not totally unknown to the LXX. Perhaps, another explanation of the plus should not be ruled out. In the second half of the verse, the reaction of foreign nations to the destruction of their gods is mentioned: “and to him shall bow down, each in its place, all the coasts and islands of the nations” (NRSV). The insertion of the phrase “of the nations,” as is the case in the LXX, would better link both parts of the verse: The nations whose gods are destroyed will bow down before the LORD. In conclusion, it is possible that the LXX translator inserted two appropriate words, *tôn ethnôn*, in order to create a more fluent text.

CONCLUSION

The examples given in this chapter illustrate that for each book of the prophetic corpus, the text-critical situation is different. Qumran fragments might be available or not, they might differ from the MT or confirm it, they might differ from the MT and confirm the LXX, or they might not match either of these versions. As for the LXX and other ancient translations, the translation technique underlying each of these witnesses has to be reconstructed as far as possible. Last but not least, it should be stressed that each text-critical problem requires a careful analysis of its own, which should include not only grammar, style, and context, but also the specific features of the ancient translations, as well as their social, literary, and political background.

NOTES

- * I wish to express my sincere thanks to my colleagues and collaborators with whom I was able to discuss several aspects of this essay: Jan Joosten (Oxford/Strasbourg), Daniela Scialabba (Strasbourg), and Antonella Bellantuono (Strasbourg).
1. See, e.g., the critical apparatus on Amos 3:5 in the BHS as well as in Hans Walter Wolff, *Joel and Amos: A Commentary on the Books of the Prophets Joel and Amos* (Hermeneia; Philadelphia: Fortress, 1977).
 2. For this hypothesis, see, e.g., Hans Walter Wolff, *Hosea: A Commentary on the Book of the Prophet Hosea* (Hermeneia; Philadelphia: Fortress, 1974), 94, whereas other commentators give preference to the MT, e.g., Andrew Alexander Macintosh, *Hosea* (ICC; Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1997), 180. See also the discussion in Anthony Gelston, *The Twelve Prophets* (BHQ 13; Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 2010), 59*.
 3. See Eberhard Bons, *Textkritik und Textgeschichte: Studien zur Septuaginta und zum hebräischen Alten Testament* (FAT I/93; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2014), 145.
 4. For more details, see Tov 2001, esp. Chapter 6.
 5. See Tov 2001: 356.
 6. See Dominique Barthélemy, *Critique textuelle de l'Ancien Testament*. Volume 1: *Josué, Juges, Ruth, Samuel, Rois, Chroniques, Esdras, Néhémie, Esther* (OBO 50/1; Fribourg/Göttingen: Éditions Universitaires/Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1982), *107.
 7. See Barthélemy, *Critique textuelle*, Volume 1, *111. As for the LXX, Johan Lust claims: "... it should be clear that both versions, the MT and LXX are valuable ones and stand in their own right. The one should not be corrected by the other. This rule should be applied to all cases in which the differences between the MT and the LXX are not to be explained by accidental errors" ("The Old Testament. Textual Criticism—Literary Criticism," *ETL* 60 [1984]: 445–449 [447]).
 8. For a detailed analysis of these passages, see Bons, *Textkritik und Textgeschichte*, 144–147, 169–170.
 9. See also Joosten 2008: 28.
 10. For this approach, see, e.g., Isaac Leo Seeligmann, *The Septuagint Version of Isaiah and Cognate Studies* (FAT I/40. Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2004).
 11. For more details, see Emanuel Tov, *The Text-Critical Use of the Septuagint in Biblical Research* (revised and enlarged 2nd ed.; Jerusalem: Simor, 1997), 191, 243–245.
 12. For these phenomena, see researches carried out by Hermann-Josef Stipp, e.g., his "Linguistic Peculiarities of the Masoretic Edition of the Book of Jeremiah: An Updated Index," *JNSL* 23 (1997): 181–202.
 13. See Armin Lange, *Handbuch der Textfunde vom Toten Meer*. Volume 1: *Die Handschriften biblischer Bücher von Qumran und den anderen Fundorten* (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2009), 318.
 14. So Jack R. Lundbom, *Jeremiah: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary* (AB 21A; New York: Doubleday, 1999), 577.
 15. For more details, see Tov, *Text-Critical Use*, 250; Lange, *Handbuch*, 325–334.
 16. George A. Cooke, *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Book of Ezekiel* (ICC; Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1936), 200.
 17. See Dominique Barthélemy, *Critique textuelle de l'Ancien Testament*. Volume 3: *Ezéchiel, Daniel et les 12 Prophètes* (OBO 50/3; Fribourg/Göttingen: Éditions Universitaires/Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1992), 92; Christina Tuor-Kurth, *Kindessaussetzung und Moral in der Antike*

- (Forschungen zur Kirchen- und Dogmengeschichte 101; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2010), 106–107.
18. John W. Olley, *Ezekiel: A Commentary Based on Iezekiël in Codex Vaticanus* (Septuagint Commentary Series; Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2009), 321.
 19. For more details, see Lange, *Handbuch*, 335–369.
 20. For a synopsis of the MT, the LXX, and the extant manuscripts of the Dead Sea, see *Minor Prophets*, ed. Beate Ego, Armin Lange, Hermann Lichtenberger, and Kristin De Troyer; *Biblia Qumranica* 3B; Leiden/Boston: Brill, 2005.
 21. Dominique Barthélemy, *Les devanciers d'Aquila: première publication intégrale du texte des fragments du Dodécaprophéton trouvés dans le désert de Juda* (VTSup 10; Leiden: Brill, 1963), 163–202.
 22. Barthélemy, *Critique textuelle*, Volume 1, 494.
 23. See, e.g., BHQ, 62^{*}; Macintosh, *Hosea*, 280–281.
 24. See Wilhelm Rudolph, *Micha—Nahum—Habakuk—Zephania* (KAT XIII 3; Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus Gerd Mohn, 1975), 278.

FOR FURTHER READING

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- Tov, Emanuel. 1992. “Textual Criticism.” Pages 393–412 in *ABD*, Vol. 6. New York: Doubleday.
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CHAPTER 8

HISTORY AND MEMORY IN THE PROPHETS

H. G. M. WILLIAMSON

IN the small coastal town of Southwold, Suffolk, United Kingdom, where I live, the parish church is dedicated to Saint Edmund, King and Martyr. The children at the primary school next to the church all know the story well. Every year on November 20, Saint Edmund's Day, they come to the church to meet with the town mayor and other local dignitaries. Doubtless pointing to the four panels in the stained glass east window, the vicar tells them the story of the boy who knew all the Psalms by heart, who became king of East Anglia while only a young teen, who fought the invading Danes but was defeated, then escaped and hid under a bridge at Hoxne. The glint of his spurs was seen by a newly married couple, who betrayed him to the Danes. He was bound to a tree and whipped but refused on pain of death to renounce his Christian faith, whereupon, as Abbo of Fleury later wrote, "this roused the fury of his enemies, who, as if practising at a target, pierced his whole body with arrow-spikes, augmenting the severity of his torment by frequent discharges of their weapons, and inflicting wound upon wound, while one javelin made room for another. And thus, all haggled over by the sharp points of their darts, and scarce able to draw breath, he actually bristled with them, like a prickly hedgehog or a thistle fretted with spines."¹ He was then beheaded. Eventually he was buried at what became Bury St. Edmunds, where the shrine and abbey became one of the wealthiest and most frequently visited pilgrimage sites in medieval England. To help the children remember this, the mayor gives them all a sticky bun at the end of the service (it is always known as "sticky bun day"), and Edmund is paraded as an example of youthful Christian faith, Bible learning, steadfastness against adversity, and so on.

The church and the town are full of features that recall this story. As one enters the church, there is a statue of the bound king above the porch. In addition to the stained glass window, there is also a more modern one of the martyrdom in engraved glass. Over the exterior of the great west window is inscribed *SAnCT EDMUND ORA P: NOBIS* ("Saint Edmund, pray for us"), while on every light fixture there is a representation of the town crest: a crown with crossed arrows through it. There is even a society that is

dedicated to having Edmund restored as England's patron saint, reverting to his position before Edward III replaced him with Saint George. As a community, we are partly shaped by the example and inspiration of this narrative.

There are two problems, however. First, when asked recently by a visitor what Edmund's dates were, I had to confess I did not know and so had to look it up. In other words, the story did not belong to history in the common sense of that word. History involves cause and effect, development in society over time, and the relation of one region to others. An isolated narrative cannot do that. The fact that his reign (c. 855–869) almost overlapped with that of Alfred the Great of Wessex (871–899), for instance, ought to matter in the history of what later became England, but it does not feature in the story and is probably unknown to most. Second, the chances that the story represents an accurate account of his life and death are remote. The oldest account, in the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle from about twenty years after his death, tells us only that “the raiding army rode across Mercia into East Anglia, and took winter-quarters at Thetford; and that winter King Edmund fought against them, and the Danish took the victory, and killed the king and conquered all that land.”² Similarly, twenty-four years after Edmund's death, Asser, Bishop of Sherborne, in his work *Life of King Alfred* wrote, “In the same year [869], Edmund, King of the East Angles, fought fiercely against that army [of Danes]. But alas, he was killed there with a large number of his men, and the Vikings rejoiced triumphantly; the enemy were masters of the battlefield, and they subjected that entire province to their authority.”³ Part of the later story is first recorded about a century later, and is said to have derived ultimately from his armor-bearer; other parts are attested only later still. So it could theoretically be true (after all, coins from only about thirty years after his death indicate that he was by then already sanctified), and harmonization with the Chronicle is not impossible, but reliable opinion denies this.

This situation, which could be multiplied many times and in many places, seems to me admirably to illustrate the nature of the problems we confront when considering history and memory in the prophets. In the light of recent appreciation of cultural memory alongside history and tradition, the language and labels used here need careful definition and analysis.

HISTORY

At the simplest level, it is clear that, with the application of all appropriate critical methods, the prophetic books can be used as evidence in the reconstruction of the history of the times in which they were set. At the political level, for instance, Isaiah 20 is a third-person narrative about the prophet's reaction to the Assyrian campaign against Ashdod in 711 B.C.E.⁴ In form it may be joined with comparable narratives in Isaiah 7 and 36–39. It seems to be written in a style that is similar to aspects of the Deuteronomistic History. It is therefore not a contemporary account of the events, so that analysis will need to include isolation of later authorial or editorial comment and shaping. In this it is similar

to much other historical narrative in the Hebrew Bible. But with all due allowance made for that, it is virtually impossible to deny that it also includes primary evidence that the historian will want to combine with other sources of information, such as Assyrian records of varying type. This is the only place in the Hebrew Bible, for instance, where the Assyrian king Sargon is mentioned by name, and his commander's title of *tartān* is clearly a Hebrew equivalent of the Akkadian *ta/turtānu*. The potential involvement of Egypt, Cush, and Judah as co-conspirators with Ashdod is also noteworthy (see Cook 2011: 125–145, with further bibliography).

For social history, too, the prophets provide much firsthand evidence. Many of them comment on the economic conditions of their contemporaries, and although it is difficult to discern the social realities behind their heavy rhetoric, it would clearly be irresponsible to ignore them on that account alone (see Houston 2008). Equally, it is difficult to think of any source that gives us a closer engagement with the circumstances of the exilic community in Babylon than the writings of the prophet Ezekiel.

Finally, while again allowance must be made for the reformist agenda of most of the prophets, their writings are an indispensable source for the history of Israelite religion. On the one hand, we learn much from their polemic about the state of religion in both the northern and southern kingdoms during the pre-exilic period, and on the other, we can trace many of the developments that led eventually to the various forms of Judaism which emerged by the Hellenistic period in Judah and in the diaspora (see, among many others, Albertz 1994).

At this primary level, therefore, we may apply the principle from my introductory example to conclude that there is raw history to be excavated from the prophets, equivalent to the earliest source we have for Edmund in the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle. It is not to be handled uncritically, and the results are always open to revision in the light of fresh research, but it is not to be jettisoned on that account alone. It was not the reason, however, why the prophetic books were written and preserved; nor is it the factor that most recent readers find interesting. We need to move on, therefore, to a consideration of memory, which may be related to history but which is not to be identified with it. The question is not so much how the prophets contribute to history, but rather what they derive from it.

TRADITION HISTORY

In an earlier phase of research, the focus was not so much on memory as on tradition. During the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, great strides were made both on the critical analysis of the historical books in the Hebrew Bible and on the degree to which they could be related to history itself. While opinions varied considerably, it became clear that one could not assume that all the prophets knew all the Pentateuch, Joshua, Judges and Samuel, for instance, in the form that we now have them. How much of the contents, broadly speaking, may have existed in some shape or form was a subject for debate, but the question, at least, was recognized as a legitimate one. Given that, the further question

could then be asked, and indeed was asked quite forcefully, as to how much in particular the early prophets knew and could assume was known. Were they commentators on a received body of religious beliefs and practices, or were they innovators whose insights were later codified in other texts as well? And to what extent could the progress in prophecy through time be related to the growth in the other authoritative literature?

Into this discussion the work of von Rad and others of his persuasion came as a welcome shaft of new light. In the second volume of his *Old Testament Theology* (1960, ET 1965), together with a range of commentaries in some of both the *Biblischer Kommentar* and the *Old Testament Library* series (for a convenient brief summary, see Clements 1965; see also Childs 1962), von Rad sought to bypass the dilemma of the extent of inherited written historical material by appeal to what he called “tradition,” that is to say, a body of inherited material, comprising both knowledge of past history and the formulation of certain basic and central religious concepts. In the days of the divided monarchy, these would obviously have differed to a considerable degree between the two kingdoms, but following the fall of the northern kingdom they gradually became amalgamated.

Thus for Amos and Hosea, however wide the differences between them, there is a commonality in background tradition. “We have no understanding of Amos’s preaching at all unless we note the way in which he over and over again comes to grips with the election concept, and how it was the nerve of a great part of his message” (von Rad 1965: 133), on the one hand, and “Hosea’s whole preaching is rooted in the saving history. It might almost be said that he only feels safe when he can base his arguments in history” (1965: 140), this being explained in terms of Egypt and Moses, on the other. Both statements vary only by degree. To understand these prophets, we need to be aware of the whole of the Exodus complex in its primitive form with the assurance it gives of God’s special choice and deliverance of his people.

In the south, by contrast, Isaiah of Jerusalem was equally firmly based in the concept of election, but election manifested rather in what has come to be known as the Zion tradition, with its focus on the choice of Jerusalem and its temple, with the Davidic monarch as its divinely appointed head. With this he also amalgamated the old tradition about the holy war with its requirement of faith in God’s self-sufficient saving activity. And here von Rad, who was generous in the extent to which he retained much of the material in Isaiah 1–39 for Isaiah himself, again worked sympathetically with the assumption that Isaiah utilized the entirety of this tradition complex, so that each reference to a part of it subconsciously evoked the whole. Thus the reader of Isaiah needs to appreciate “how the prophet’s whole preaching is permeated from its very beginning by the theme of Zion threatened but finally delivered” (1965: 165–166), even though from Isaiah’s point of view (Isa 22:4) the application of this was so sorely misunderstood by Isaiah’s contemporaries after the events of 701 B.C.E.

The attraction of von Rad’s use of tradition was that it enabled scholars to read the prophets in a manner that was both somewhat more conventional than had become fashionable, and yet to do so with scholarly integrity on critical issues. Conventional did not necessarily equate to familiar, however, for von Rad was in many respects a fine and insightful exegete, so that his reading of the prophetic books within his self-imposed

framework was often fresh and invigorating. Though the tradition-historical method may be in sore need of refinement, we should not allow that to lead to the loss of the many individual insights that it has brought.

Having said that, problems aplenty remain, so that we need to think further about how the prophets related to history as they may have known it. To start with, at the risk of overgeneralizing, I should judge that critical opinion has swung away from the relatively conservative stance that von Rad adopted in regard to the extent of material that may be ascribed to each individual prophet in the book that bears his name. Of course, opinions differ on this question, but that in itself reveals part of the problem. Any reading strategy that ties itself narrowly to the results of literary-critical research is increasingly regarded with suspicion. While there is nothing wrong with a study of the composition history of any given book, it remains vital that interpretation should give equal weight to material that may be judged historically secondary and not to privilege the hypothetical “original.” Second, the results of research on the early history of Israel have also moved in a more negative direction, so that not all, by any means, will be content with the assumptions that von Rad could take for granted, such as a historical kernel to the Exodus narratives, the entry into the land from outside, and the existence of a united monarchy with its capital in Jerusalem and its temple built by Solomon. (As an aside, I might add that I personally take a more conservative stance on some of these questions than many others, but my point is that we cannot leave our interpretation of the prophetic books as a hostage to the fortune of historical research on what their authors may have known.) Third, on von Rad’s own presuppositions (such as an early date for the Yahwist) there remain some curious anomalies. Why, for instance, did none of the eighth-century prophets make any use of the Abraham narratives, with which the doctrine of election may be thought to have started? And how, in the light of the Zion tradition taken as a whole, could Isaiah have pronounced simultaneous defeat and deliverance for his audience?

More important than all these details, however, there arises the question of whether authors in antiquity treated tradition—which in this context effectively means a form of extended history—in the all-embracing manner that von Rad proposed. To revert to my introductory example, was their attitude not rather that of my fellow townspeople, who use the story of Edmund as an inspiring example of bravery and faithfulness that is worth passing on to the children, without any real notion of the extent of his kingdom, of his predecessors or successors, or even his dates? There is a sense among some, but by no means all, that the story may at the least have enjoyed embellishment over time, but that this does not really matter; it shapes the community as it is told, not as some medieval historian may carefully reconstruct it.

MEMORY

At this point, therefore, there may turn out to be much to gain from drawing on more recent study of memory as a social phenomenon. If the pioneering work was done in

the field of sociology by Halbwachs (his most influential work in this regard was published posthumously in 1950; ET 1980; see also Halbwachs 1992; for other introductory studies and surveys, albeit reflecting some differences of opinion in matters of detail, see, for instance, Connerton 1989; Cubitt 2007; Erll and Nünning 2010; Fentress and Wickham 1992; Hobsbawm and Ranger 1983; Jerushalmi 1982; Le Goff 1992; Middleton and Edwards 1990; Olick et al. 2011; Radstone and Schwartz 2010; Wertsch 2002; E. Zerubavel 2003; Y. Zerubavel 1995), it has been applied closer to home by Assmann (ET 2006, 2011; their approaches with regard to history are contrasted by Barstad 2010) and then by many others (see, for instance, Barbour 2012: ch. 3; Ben Zvi and Levin 2012; Carstens et al. 2012; Davies 2008; Edelman and Ben Zvi 2013; Hendel 2005 and 2010; Leveen 2008; Rogerson 2009; Smith 2004). These studies have a greater explanatory power for the way in which “history” works in the social sphere, be that family, religious grouping, or wider community, and they certainly come closer to the manner in which I have experienced the story of Edmund.

But even here two elements need to be distinguished. On the one hand, there is social memory, the account of some person or event that the relevant community finds sufficiently meaningful to preserve and transmit in the public sphere. It is detached from its wider context but has a kind of canonical authority with which the community endows it. On the other hand, there is the individual’s appropriation of that memory; she or he may privately focus on one element or another for a variety of personal reasons, but of course her or his take on it may, in the course of time, influence the transmission of the story if she or he has authority to tell it according to her or his individual appreciation. “Social beliefs, whatever their origin, have a double character. They are collective traditions or recollections, but they are also ideas or conventions that result from a knowledge of the present” (Halbwachs 1992: 188).

An additional division is Assmann’s differentiation between communicative and cultural memory (2011: 34–50). The former is time limited, which has as an inevitable effect that the prophet may well refer to relatively recent history that will have been well known to his audience but to which we now have no independent access. We shall note examples in passing where scholars have probably been misled by trying to locate in the known course of history every event or sequence of events to which some of the prophets refer.

To illustrate from my example once again: the present vicar of Southwold, who of course has had to be inducted into the ritual since his arrival from elsewhere, is much taken with another element in the story that has previously been only occasionally included. After being shot many times, Edmund still refused to renounce his Christian faith, was beheaded, and the head was thrown into the woods. Edmund’s followers had no problem finding his body, but his head was missing. Searching for his remains, they heard a cry of *hic, hic, hic* (“here, here, here”) and traced the voice to a wolf who was protecting Edmund’s severed head. The wolf allowed the followers to take the head, and Edmund’s followers buried him nearby and built a wooden chapel over the spot. The interesting thing about this element of the legend is that according to some sources Edmund came from, and was in fact the last of, the family of Wylfingas or Wuffingas, the

great royal name of East Anglia in previous years. While the philological connection is spurious, it is precisely according to such associations that legends are embellished and attract the individual attention of later narrators.

The case I want to argue for most of the rest of this chapter is that what we find in the prophets in relation to “history” is the individual selection of story elements in isolation, according to the rhetorical needs of the prophet at that point. There is no suggestion that these elements had yet been assembled into a larger narrative whole (though they may have been); rather, as with the story of Edmund, they were elements in the social memory, preserved and valued for a variety of obvious or obscure reasons, on which the prophet could draw. Knowledge of nothing more than the story in question is presupposed, and of course in his appropriation of the story, the prophet may have given it a polemical twist to suit his immediate purpose. This cannot always be determined, since part of the argument is precisely that the story may not have existed in quite the form that we now know it from the narrative records in the Hebrew Bible, though sometimes we can hazard an informed guess about the matter based on the nature of the presentation. Naturally, as we proceed chronologically the material comes closer to the Pentateuchal or historical narrative form. To that extent, von Rad was correct. The following outline should not be seen as a radical corrective of his work, but rather as a refinement that seeks to remain closer to the texts as we have them. Needless to say, the survey cannot be comprehensive, but I hope that the selection of evidence will not be unrepresentative.

COMMUNICATIVE MEMORY

I begin with two examples of what Assmann calls “communicative memory,” which is to say, “living, organic memories, experiences, hearsay, with a time span that cannot exceed three or four generations” (see the chart in Assmann 2011: 41). In these cases the references to history are likely to be beyond our modern recall, and interpretation must work creatively within that limitation. In Amos 4:6–11 (which I here take as an authentic saying by Amos, though my point would not be greatly affected if it were written later), the prophet looks back over a series of natural disasters, by which it was commonly thought that God could speak as a warning (Barton 2012: 101–102). It is unclear whether specific disasters are in mind or whether there is a conscious alignment here with descriptions of divine punishment in some of the law codes (e.g., Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28) as well as more widely in the ancient Near East.⁵ Those who first heard or read these words, however, would doubtless have been able, and been expected, to align these descriptions with aspects of their own experience, so that what appears to be historical becomes more or less paradigmatic.

In the course of this recital, Amos introduces two more specific illustrative examples. In 4:11 he notes that God “overthrew some of you, as when God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah, and you were like a brand snatched from the fire.” This reference is more or

less proverbial, as is shown by the use of closely comparable language elsewhere (e.g., Deut 29:23; Isa 13:19; Jer 49:18, 50:40; Lam 4:6; cf. Isa 1:9; Jer 23:14; Zeph 2:9; see Loader 1990), and this is reinforced in the present instance by the fact that in a first-person speech by God (“I overthrew some of you”) we have the third-person continuation, “as when God overthrew. . . .” In such a case it is meaningless to ask after the literary *Vorlage* of such a saying. However historical the events mentioned may have been thought to be, Amos here simply evokes a commonly understood paradigm of disaster. The contrast with the usage at Ezekiel 16:48–50 underlines the distance between proverbial usage and literary reflection. More allusively, Amos 4:10 refers to “a pestilence after the manner of Egypt,” and this is often referred to as one of the plagues in the Exodus story (Ex 9:3, and cf. 9:15). While this is possible, it is by no means certain. Apart from Soggin’s view that it refers to some independent tradition of an otherwise unattested plague, based on Exodus 5:3,⁶ quite a number of commentators refer to Deuteronomy 28:27 and 60 (as well as Isa 10:24, 26) to suggest that Egypt could be used proverbially or illustratively as the source of plague.⁷ Other exemplary passages in Amos include the references in the oracles against the nations in Amos 1–2 and the allusions in 6:13–14.

From this simple example of communicative memory, I turn to one that may be more controversial, namely Isaiah 9:8–21, to which, in my opinion, 5:25b–29 should be added as a conclusion (see Williamson 2006: 400–403). Rather as with Amos 4, therefore, we have an originally five-stanza poem, of which almost all the fourth stanza was omitted and so lost to us when the last part of the poem was moved to its new, present location at the end of chapter 5; only a fragment remains in the second half of 5:25, enough to suggest that it may have dealt in part, at least, with the disaster of an earthquake.

The basic shape of the poem as a whole is reasonably clear. A series of disasters, whether military (Isa 9:8–12), civil (Isa 9:13–17), relating to social strife (Isa 9:18–21), or possibly natural (Isa 5:25b), have failed to lead to repentance on the part of the nation. Therefore (Isa 5:26–29) God will bring an invincible foreign power to wreak judgment on them.

The identification of the series of disasters has evoked an enormous range of suggestions from the commentators, and Sweeney even suggests that they appear in reverse chronological order.⁸ To give just two lists of examples, first, the onslaught of “the Arameans in the east and the Philistines in the west” (Isa 9:12) has been taken by Kaiser as a reference to Saul’s wars (1 Samuel 13–14; 31),⁹ though the collaboration with Aram reminds him of the period of the Judean king Joash. Wildberger suggests that the reference is to events in the relatively distant past (he mentions the ninth century in particular),¹⁰ and Donner (1964: 71–72) finds here a general reference to incursions in the ninth and the first half of the eighth centuries, whereas most commentators think of the more recent past. Blenkinsopp, for instance, thinks of the reign of Jeroboam II or just after, mainly by association with the implications of Amos 1:3–5 and 6:13–14 (see also 2 Kgs 14:22–29).¹¹ Procksch makes a strong case for the last years of the reign of Menahem.¹² Unlike his successor Pekah, who adopted an anti-Assyrian stance and so allied with Aram to invade Judah, Menahem appears to have been a loyal vassal, in which case he could well have roused the ire of Aram and the Philistines at the time when they were

beginning to put together an anti-Assyrian coalition. There is no independent evidence that they invaded Israel at this time, however, as Gray observes,¹³ though that is not a fatal argument, as there are other significant campaigns, especially involving the northern kingdom, which for whatever reason the books of Kings do not include (the reign of Ahab is the classic example). Those who retain the MT's "Rezin" in verse 11 are, of course, obliged to date these events later, following the Assyrian conquest of Aram and Israel, though most delete the reference as a later gloss (see NRSV); Beuken, for instance, refers specifically to the first Assyrian conquest in 732 B.C.E.¹⁴

The wide diversity of opinions on these matters suggests that it will be difficult to reach any firm conclusion. The most satisfying result rhetorically would be to find here a reference to the closing years of Menahem's reign, as something within the memory of the audience would be probable; it furnishes the only possible scenario where Aram and the Philistines might have acted jointly against Israel. No such action is actually known to us from those years, however, so that we are left with the quandary of whether to eliminate the possibility from consideration or simply to acknowledge that it might not have been recorded in our extant sources. An alternative approach therefore deserves mention, namely that there is no specific historical reference here at all, but that the two foreign nations are mentioned simply as examples of traditional enemies in general.¹⁵ Strongly in favor of this approach is the observation that the same two nations also feature twice elsewhere as stereotypical and classic neighboring enemies: Amos 9:7 and Ezekiel 16:57. In that case, virtually all the suggested historical occasions will be involved generally, but none specifically. The virtue of this last position is that the focus of attention in the poem as a whole is not so much on the acts of judgment as on the spread of sins, which evokes them as developed systematically from one stanza to the next.

Second, in relation to the breakdown of civil society in verses 13–17, suggested references have included the revolution of Jehu (2 Kgs 9–10), which was still vividly remembered shortly before Isaiah's day (Hos 1:4),¹⁶ the aftermath of Tiglath-Pileser III's invasion in 732 B.C.E. after the Syro-Ephraimite war, and the general descent into anarchy in the final years of the northern kingdom's existence, as attested especially in Hosea.¹⁷

If verses 8–12 should be dated to Menahem's reign, and if these stanzas refer to chronologically sequential events (as seems clearly to be implied here by v 13), then a reference to the chaotic aftermath of Tiglath-Pileser III's invasion would seem to be the most plausible referent. Again, however, the question may be raised of whether we should be looking for any specific historical occurrence in the first place. As is clear from 3:1–9, Isaiah envisaged the collapse of society as the inevitable consequence of destructive judgment, and it is interesting that there, too, he begins by referring to the removal of "support and staff," which could be compared rhetorically with the "head and tail" of 9:14 here. With general memories of past disasters, he is concerned mainly to show how the failure to heed warnings has only one inevitable result: the total collapse of civilized society.

A final matter that should give us pause relates to the likely audience of this poem. The introduction in 9:8 refers to Jacob and Israel, whereas the following verse speaks of Ephraim and Samaria. Since the latter clearly refers to the northern kingdom (see Isa

7:1–9; 8:4; 17:3; 28:1, 3), it is tempting to suppose that the more generalized opening verse has in view the people of God as a whole, which will therefore also have included Judah, as, for instance, at 5:7 (see Williamson 2006: 342–343) and 8:14. If that is true, then we should not necessarily restrict our exegesis to the northern kingdom alone, even if it is the primary referent. The broader phraseology that Isaiah uses speaks in a manner that allows each reader to evoke his or her own memories of all-too-common events of which these will have been stereotypical examples.

I conclude that communicative memory is well attested in the prophets and that it serves as a warning against advancing interpretations that rest on what is historically unknown to us from other sources. As exegetes we must respect the fact that the prophets were closely involved with their contemporaries' current perceptions of reality and engaged with them at a close level of communication. The fact that this material was then preserved because it was found valuable by later generations suggests that these in turn were able to apply such memories in different ways according to their own later experiences. They open up the text for reapplication in ways that far outstrip the narrower confines of historical-critical reconstruction alone.

CULTURAL MEMORY: NORTHERN KINGDOM

I move next to the broader topic of cultural memory with particular attention to the ways in which individual prophets drew on that for their own purposes. I shall restrict my survey to the eighth-century prophets not only because of space constraints but more particularly because they predate the period when the Pentateuch and the Former Prophets were beginning to take their recognizable shape. They therefore illustrate the use of social memory in the sharpest manner available to us.

It is clear, as all commentators have recognized, that Amos was familiar with some form of the Exodus, wilderness, and entry-into-the-land stories. On a relatively generous allowance of what may be ascribed to him, we find references in at least 2:9–10; 3:1–2; 5:25; and 9:7. In what form he knew these stories is less clear, however. Older commentators used to argue or to assume that he knew them in the form that they take in the earlier sources available to him, though in the current turmoil of Pentateuchal criticism many would question whether that is still a safe assumption. The polemic at 5:25 heightens our difficulty: “Did you bring to me sacrifices and offerings the forty years in the wilderness, O house of Israel?” In material conventionally ascribed to the early sources, there are references to altars and offerings of some sort in connection with the Exodus and Sinai at Exodus 12:21–27; 17:15; 24:4–8; 32:5–6. To separate these from the wilderness period of forty years¹⁸ looks like special pleading. For reasons that need not detain us now (see the careful discussion of Barton 2005), it is therefore clear that Amos has worked independently with the narrative for purposes of his own (and see Jer 7:22). In the words of Jeremias, who includes Hosea also in his comment, “It is not their intention to instruct their contemporaries about history—the discussion of some ‘age of Moses

without sacrifices' is looking past the text itself—but rather to guide them away from their trust in automated 'righteousness.'"¹⁹

A striking feature about the other three passages listed earlier is that they all refer to the Exodus by way of the use of the *hiph'il* of *'lh* ("brought up"); the standpoint is therefore that of coming to and being in the land, rather than on the redemptive or liberationist aspect of the Exodus. We may link that observation to the fact that the main emphasis in Amos 2:9–10 is that they were brought up "to possess the land of the Amorites," that in 3:1–2 the rhetoric is directed toward present culpability based on past favor, and that at 9:7 the point is that being brought up to one's land is far from a unique experience. It therefore looks as though Amos is trying to use the Exodus complex only as a backdrop to his current invective. There is no element of salvation history about this. The usage is highly selective and individualistic, giving no real hint as to the full outline of the story that he knew. He makes use of social memory of a canonical event in a more or less historically decontextualized manner for separate purposes of his own.

When we turn to Hosea, the other prophet who was principally concerned with the northern kingdom, we find two features that deserve comment. First, and most striking, he has a habit of referring to incidents from the past referred to by little more than a significant geographical name (for comparison, see Jonker 1995; on a broader canvass, Schama 1996). Sometimes we know the story that may lie behind them, but not always—again, we have to reckon with the better knowledge of his first audience. At 1:4 "the blood of Jezreel" in relation to Jehu is sufficient even for us to recall the revolt described in 2 Kings 9–10, though we note that Hosea condemns what the historical narrative clearly applauds, the revolt having even been put in hand by prophetic encouragement. In 2:14–15, as well as a reference to the wilderness as a place of renewal, we even find that God will "make the valley of Achor a door of hope," quite the contrary to its previous setting for the stoning of Achan (Josh 7:24–26). At 8:5–6 and 10:5 there are probable references to the calf at Bethel; Beth-aven in the latter verse seems to have become a standard pejorative way of referring to the cult at Bethel, based on Amos 5:5 (and see also Hos 4:15; 10:8; Macintosh 1997: 162–164, 302–306, 401), and thus "Samaria" at 8:5–6 is best understood as a way of referring to the northern kingdom as a whole. This being so, without any further elaboration "the calf of Samaria" is sufficient as an allusion to the whole narrative of the establishment by Jeroboam I of the official nature of Yahwism in the north.

The section of the book which begins at 9:10 "repeatedly alludes to the traditions about the divine initiative in choosing and delivering Israel in the patriarchal age, the Exodus and conquest and the institution of the monarchy. . . . Yet the historical traditions contribute little or nothing to the substance of this hope" (Davies 1992: 224; for a differing emphasis, see Hoffman 1989). At 9:10 a mention of Baal-peor is sufficient to evoke the story known to us from the start of Numbers 25. At 9:15, "every evil of theirs began at Gilgal" is usually thought to refer to either or both of the initial entry into the land (Joshua 3–5) or the origins of the monarchy (1 Sam 11:14–15); Hosea elsewhere warns against the dangers of the cult there (e.g., 4:15; 12:11), so that a general reference is possible. Macintosh (1997: 376–377), however, thinks that the reference is to some recent event otherwise unknown to us, in which case it should be included rather in the list

of comparable allusions that follows. A mention of Gibeah at 9:9 and 10:9 is enough to make probable a reference to the story in Judges 19–21, though a few commentators favor alternative references. A rare reference to the Exodus itself in 11:1 recasts the nature of the account in a striking pre-Deuteronomic portrayal of love and sonship, which Wolff suggests may be due to his concern to offer a contrast with Canaanite notions of deity as family.²⁰ Why Admah and Zeboiim should be mentioned in 11:8 rather than the stereotypical Sodom and Gomorrah with which they are otherwise always associated (cf. Gen 10:19; 14: 2, 8, and especially Deut 29:23) is unknown to us. Finally, there are references to place names that certainly refer to events otherwise unknown to us (e.g., 6:7 and 10:14). I conclude from this lengthy catalog that Hosea reckoned very much on the social memories both recent and remote that he shared with his audience, but that he turned and reused them for his own polemical purposes.

The other feature of Hosea to which reference should be made is the more extended treatment of Jacob in chapter 12. Such a full reference to the patriarchal narratives is unprecedented among the eighth-century prophets and it raises many questions of a critical nature. A survey of the commentaries indicates that in many respects the references are close to the form of the story that we know in Genesis, but that there are some distinctive features (such as the reference to weeping in v 4) and that the order of events is jumbled in Hosea (see Day 1988: 43–44). An interesting suggestion to help explain these features is that the most immediate source may not be literary at all but rather liturgical, “a parody on a piece of liturgical poetry used at the Bethel sanctuary” (McKenzie 1986: 319), itself based on some form of early epic rather than the literary form of the narrative that we now know. While it is difficult to establish such a suggestion with any certainty, the use of liturgy as a vehicle for the transmission of social memory has probably been undervalued in the study of ancient Israel. In my opinion, references to Jacob and to Israel in many of the Psalms look as though they preserve ancient memories precisely because of the unexpected nature of their preservation in the southern kingdom, and this suggestion in regard to Jacob in Hosea might well fit closely with that observation. In any event, the character of this use of the Jacob story is similar to that in the story of Edmund that was outlined earlier.

CULTURAL MEMORY: SOUTHERN KINGDOM

In turning now from the prophets who primarily addressed the northern kingdom to those whose message was directed to a southern, Judean audience, we must obviously look in particular at what can reasonably be recovered of the oracles of Isaiah of Jerusalem now included in Isaiah 1–39. Here (against occasional claims to the contrary) there are no references to the Exodus or, indeed, any other of the major pentateuchal narratives. Instead, we note first that there are several references to David in a manner which suggests that his reign was regarded as an ideal. They cannot all, however, be easily aligned with other written sources known to us. The problems encircling

the interpretation of Isaiah 29:1–8 are too dense to be unraveled here, but we should note the striking fact that nowhere in the David narratives is there any precedent for talk of Jerusalem as “the city (*qryh*) where David encamped” (v 1). Based on verse 3, “encamped” is usually taken to be a reference to “besiege,” but the account of 2 Samuel 5:6–10 does not envisage any such siege. Less plausibly, a few have taken the word to be a simple equivalent of “dwell,” but again this seems completely out of keeping with the immediate reference in 2 Samuel 5:9 and 11, as well as elsewhere, to David immediately building parts of the city as well as a house for himself. It seems likely, then, that Isaiah is alluding to the older story entirely in the light of the expected siege of Jerusalem by Sennacherib. The older titles “house of David” and “city of David” occur at 7:2, 13; 22:9, 22 (though it is difficult to be sure how many of these reach back to Isaiah himself); with the exception of the last mentioned verse, however, they all refer to a decline from the ideal, so that the name of David evokes a sense of wistful regret. The same is probably true also of the apparent references to David’s military victories mentioned (without naming him directly) in 28:21, as Mount Perazim clearly indicates (see 2 Sam 5:20). This leaves a question about the following reference to the valley of Gibeon. Either it refers to Joshua’s famous exploits there in Joshua 10:6–14 (in which case it is out of chronological order and is merely snatched out of the air for rhetorical effect), or more likely it refers to the continuation of David’s campaign (Geba in 2 Samuel 5:25 being emended to Gibeon with LXX and 1 Chr 14:18; Vollmer 1971: 163–165). Either way, rhetorically Isaiah reverses the force of the memory by comparing these scenes now to God’s strange and alien work.

A similar sense of disappointed recollection also surrounds references to Jerusalem/Zion as it once was. This comes clearly to the fore in Isaiah 1:21, which describes a once faithful, just, and righteous city (*qryh*, as at 29:1) where now injustice of all sorts is the norm. A similar sense of loss pervades 3:1–8, where the honored leaders in society will soon be lost (see also 5:14). It is in this light that we should approach Isaiah’s understanding of the so-called Zion tradition. The fact that he not infrequently refers to elements of which it is comprised makes clear that he was aware of it, and no doubt there was a good deal that was fundamental to his beliefs; God’s royal sovereignty and his choice of Zion with its temple and Davidic monarch lie deep within Isaiah’s fundamental convictions. This should not be confused, however, with any suggestion that he therefore subscribed to the notion that Zion could never suffer punitive judgment by God through foreign enemies on account of the faithlessness of her citizens. From early times (8:6–8) to late (22:4, 12–14), Isaiah confronted this misplaced confidence.

The picture is admittedly complex, as he could equally use the same elements to construct hopes for a better future, 9:1–7 (assuming it to be Isaianic) being a clear case in point. In the dense skein of imagery in that passage, it is interesting to note in passing how alongside much that is clearly Davidic there is also an otherwise unexplained reference to “the day of Midian” (v 4), which a later writer (10:26), with his addition of “the rock of Oreb,” evidently understood as a reference to the story of Gideon in Judges 6–8 (see especially 7:25). Interestingly, this same triumph was celebrated in the liturgy (see Ps 83:9–12), so that we need not be surprised to find that a story which was set in the

territory of the northern kingdom of Israel was also celebrated in Judah. Once again, we see how the simple mention of a name is sufficient to recall a popular tale.

The challenge to the popular misconceptions about the Zion tradition finds a striking parallel in the other eighth-century prophet to Judah, Micah. On the usual assumption that most of Micah's own words are included in chapters 1–3, we find not only the bleak but powerful poetic description of defeat in the second half of the first chapter, but in particular a direct reference to a central tenet of Zion theology at the end of chapter 3. To the financially induced priests and prophets who declare, "Surely the LORD is with us! No harm shall come upon us" (Mic 3:11), thus echoing the sentiments of such Psalms as 46 and 48, Micah retorts, "Therefore because of you Zion shall be ploughed as a field; Jerusalem shall become a heap of ruins, and the mountain of the house a wooded height."

As we move from the eighth to the sixth and the fifth centuries, we find that the prophets' use of social memory comes to be more and more closely aligned with the written forms of the Pentateuch and the Former Prophets with which we are now familiar, so that it becomes more appropriate to undertake more immediately literary comparison and analysis. It therefore goes beyond my present purpose to survey all that in detail, though fortunately I can refer to the thorough study of the matter by Day (1988), which still retains its value. That is not to say that otherwise unparalleled versions of narratives do not sometimes appear, perhaps especially in Ezekiel. Reference is necessary only to his distinctive version of the Garden of Eden story in Ezekiel 28:11–19 and to his unparalleled history of Jerusalem in chapters 16 and 23 (which also includes Samaria) to make the point.

Little would be added to my main point by pursuing this, however. What I hope the present chapter has shown is that what used to be known technically as tradition history has enormously amplified our understanding of how the prophets interacted with the story of Israel as they inherited it. More recent work based on a more social-scientific approach to history has refined that appreciation. We now know that in ancient times, as often in modern too, history is not regarded as a single, connected thread of narrative. Rather, it is learned and passed on as separate and often even isolated stories with which self-understanding of the present community resonates either by way of identity or of shared moral and social values. In my opinion, the prophets often (though admittedly not always) refer or allude to these stories in just such a way, evoking a memory of inherited history in order to illustrate or reinforce their argument. If that is right, then it allows the reader to start with the text we have, rather than believing that she or he must start with some ulterior agenda, whether known or unknown, that may lie behind the text.

NOTES

1. Francis Hervey, *Corolla Sancti Eadmundi: the Garland of Saint Edmund King and Martyr* (London: John Murray, 1907), 35.
2. *The Anglo-Saxon Chronicles*, ed. and trans. Michael Swanton (London: JM Dent, 1996), 70.

3. *Alfred the Great: Asser's Life of Alfred and other Contemporary Sources*, ed. and trans. Simon Keynes and Michael Lapidge (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1983), 78.
4. In this chapter all translations are from the New Revised Standard Version of the Bible and all verse references are to the English version.
5. See Hans Walter Wolff, *Joel and Amos* (Hermeneia; Philadelphia: Fortress, 1977), 213.
6. See J. Alberto Soggin, *The Prophet Amos: A Translation and Commentary* (London: SCM, 1987), 75.
7. See, among recent commentators, John H. Hayes (*Amos, the Eighth-Century Prophet: His Times and His Preaching*; Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1988, 147); Francis I. Andersen and David Noel Freedman ("popular wisdom held that it was endemic in that land," *Amos: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*; AB 24A; New York: Doubleday 1989, 442–443); and Jörg Jeremias ("probably a proverbial expression," *The Book of Amos: A Commentary*; OTL; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1998, 66).
8. See Marvin A. Sweeney, *Isaiah 1–39 with an Introduction to Prophetic Literature* (FOTL 16; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), 195–196.
9. Otto Kaiser, *Isaiah 1–12: A Commentary* (OTL; London: SCM, 1983), 222.
10. See Hans Wildberger, *Isaiah 1–12: A Commentary* (CC; Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1991), 228.
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PART II

INTERPRETING
THE PROPHETS

C. Literary Criticism

CHAPTER 9

ISAIAH

Structure, Themes, and Contested Issues

ULRICH BERGES

OVER recent decades, exegetical research on Old Testament prophecy in general and on the book of Isaiah in particular (see the overview by Höffken 2004) has been characterized by a notable paradigm change. While older studies concentrated mainly on the various stages of textual development, its redactions, additions, and glosses (diachronic analysis), recent research increasingly examines the composition and structure of the prophetic books (synchronic analysis). The former main interest was directed toward the oldest prophetic words. In order to be able to hear the voice of the divinely inspired men of God, the original *logia* had to be excavated from the secondary literary material like a treasure from debris.

THE NEW PARADIGM: THE PROPHET'S BOOK PRECEDES THE PROPHET'S WORD

In contemporary approaches, a quite different understanding prevails: the word of God does not correspond to the allegedly earliest stratum of the literary account but is to be perceived only *within* the prophetic book as a whole. Whoever wishes to discover the prophet cannot bypass the book. This is the motto of the new paradigm. The word of God has been preserved, extended, and thereby actualized by the tradents of the prophetic accounts. Thus, later additions are not to be considered as products of theologically insignificant epigones. Rather, these passages are the vivid result of the maintenance of tradition (*Traditionspflege*) over centuries, which intensively pondered the divine will for Israel and the Gentiles.

Apart from a few exceptions, such as the pioneering commentary by Muilenburg (1956: 381–773), the synchronic analysis of the book of Isaiah started to break ground

in the mid-1980s (cf. Rendtorff 1984; Watts 1985, 1987). Due to their exegetical tradition, Anglophone scholars pursued this approach very intensively (cf. Blenkinsopp 2000, 2002, 2003; Brueggemann, 1998a, 1998b; Childs 2001), whereas their German colleagues still employed predominantly diachronic methods. But over the years a significant change can be observed: The once heated debate about the prevalence of synchronic *or* diachronic methods gave way to the understanding that the validity and legitimacy of both approaches derive from the nature of the biblical books themselves. In the interpretation of the book of Isaiah, scholars have to take into account both the final form as well as the history of its development. As a result of this vivid discussion, the limits of either approach became apparent: On the one hand, no exegesis of the final form is able to integrate every single aspect into one overall concept. On the other hand, no diachronic model satisfactorily displays all the stages of development of the book. Both approaches have their proper legitimacy, but likewise each one has its limited validity. Thus, only a combined application meets the requirements of the biblical text. This methodological combination is the aim of the “diachronically reflected synchrony” (*diachron reflektierte Synchronie*). The approach principally examines the final form, in a synchronic way, without disregarding the historical background of the textual development (see Berges 2012a).

ON THE HISTORY OF RESEARCH ON THE BOOK OF ISAIAH

The history of research can be summarized as follows: from the prophet Isaiah to the three books to the one book of Isaiah. According to the pre-critical past, but also for a continuing conservative branch of research, the prophet Isaiah himself is the author of the entire scroll.¹ This view is mainly based on the superscription (Isa 1:1), which labels the entire body of text as the prophetic vision of Isaiah ben Amoz living in the days of the Judean kings Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, the prophet’s contemporaries in the second half of the eighth century B.C.E. The fact that Isaiah is considered to be a visionary constitutes an important detail: the superscription does not deal with authorship in the modern sense of the word, but with the prophetic authority that underlies the entire book. Therefore, it does not come as a surprise that the book of Isaiah has been passed on and interpreted as a coherent text (LXX, Qumran, NT, Patristic Literature; cf. Sir 48:22–25). The praise of the fathers in the book of Sirach (chapters 44–55) already understands Isaiah as a renowned and reliable visionary who lengthened King Hezekiah’s life by healing his illness (cf. Isaiah 39) and comforted the mourning inhabitants of Zion (cf. Isaiah 40): “He revealed what was to occur to the end of time and the hidden things before they happened” (Sir 48:25).

But anyone who still asserts the “one-prophet interpretation” is burdened with the dogma of verbal inspiration and ignores a 200-year-old tradition of Isaiah exegesis.

Given the fact that Isaiah ben Amoz was commissioned during the reign of King Ahaz (around 734 B.C.E.) and remained politically active until the end of King Hezekiah's reign (around 700 B.C.E.), he cannot possibly have predicted the calling of Cyrus, the king of Persia (around 550 B.C.E.), by name (cf. Isa 44:28; 45:1). No contemporary would have understood him. Yet not only chapters 40ff, but also a whole range of prophecies within Isaiah 1–39, cannot be ascribed to the historical prophet living in the post-exilic times. An analytically sound exegesis liberated from the dogmatic coercion of verbal inspiration has to reckon with a multitude of authors of the book of Isaiah.

An important step in this direction was set by Duhm in 1892² with his Isaiah commentary, in which he replaced the traditional “one-prophet interpretation” by a “three-book interpretation” (Isaiah 1–39; 40–55; 56–66). For the author of Isaiah 40–55, Duhm postulates an anonymous prophet whom he names “Deutero-Isaiah.” Since this individual is regarded as the author neither of the *‘ebed*-YHWH Songs (42:1–4; 49:1–6; 50:4–9; 52:13–53:12) nor the polemical texts against idols (esp. 44:9–20), only about three-quarters of the text is classified as the product of Deutero-Isaiah. With regard to Isaiah 56–66 dating from the times of Nehemiah, another anonymous prophet is brought into play, whom Duhm names “Trito-Isaiah.” In most cases, scholars who adopt Duhm’s position overlook the fact that even though Duhm spoke of three books, he did not restrict authorship simply to Proto-, Deutero- and Trito-Isaiah. To the contrary, he understood the book of Isaiah as a product of various anonymous authors who, among other texts, wrote the Babylon oracles (Isaiah 13; 14; 21) and all the other prophecies that could not be ascribed to Isaiah ben Amoz. Thus, contrary to popular belief, in Duhm’s view the three books do not go hand in hand with three authors. In consequence, he ought to have called the author of Isaiah 13–14 “Quarto-” and the author of the *‘ebed*-YHWH Songs “Quinto-Isaiah.” If he had done so, the success of his “three-book interpretation,” in scholarship as well as in church, would have been much lessened. Especially the Christian churches were not interested in three books. But once the theory of single authorship was no longer tenable, Duhm’s concept of Deutero- and Trito-Isaiah allowed them to maintain anonymous but inspired men of God as authors of the crucial texts in Isaiah 40ff.

Currently the “three-book interpretation” has been strongly criticized as well since more and more literary connections between the main parts of the book come to the fore (especially between 1–39 and 56–66). The current state of research has been accurately described by Sheppard: “our problem is no longer that there are so few obvious connections between parts of the book, but there are so many and they seem so independent and disparately related.”³ Neither the hypothesis of an Isaianic school existing over hundreds of years nor the “accident-theory” is able to explain adequately the connections and disparities of the different compositional units. The situation is quite paradoxical: the book of Isaiah is too disparate to be regarded as unified, and too unified to be regarded as purely disparate.

In recent times, Duhm’s “three-book interpretation” has been superseded by the “one-book interpretation.” This new paradigm emphasizes that the different parts have never existed as independent written accounts. Yet, this correct approach courts the

danger of falling behind Duhm and the historical criticism of the past 200 years. It would be a fallacy to claim that the issue of unity is sufficiently clarified by referring to the writing down in one single scroll. As a consequence, unlike Duhm and other scholarship up to the 1980s, all exegetical studies—even those on smaller units—have to address the question about the position and function of these passages in the overall context of the book.

OVERVIEW OF APPROACHES TO THE FINAL STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK OF ISAIAH

One of the most important attempts to get hold of the final structure of the book of Isaiah came from Brownlee.⁴ Following the methodological approach of Liebreich, he chooses the Great Isaiah Scroll of Qumran (1QIsa^a) as a starting point. There one finds an obvious break of three lines between chapters 33 and 34,⁵ and *plene* writing increases from Isaiah 34 onward. Nevertheless, both parts of the scroll were certainly copied by the same hand. From this literary evidence, Brownlee deduces a deliberate two-part composition (1–33//34–66), each one comprising seven sections. As a central theme of the entire composition, he suggests the dialectic between “ruin and future blessedness,”⁶ which he sees already prefigured in the contrast between Isaiah 1:24–25 and 1:26–27. Nevertheless, important themes seem to find no appropriate consideration in his schema, as, for example, that of the polemic against foreign gods (40–48). In addition, Brownlee himself admits that the *ʿebed* of the second series lacks a counterpart in 1–33.⁷

Brownlee’s two-part composition is taken over by Sweeney in his commentary on Isaiah 1–39; Sweeney underlines that “the first part of the book projects judgment and subsequent restoration whereas the second part announces that the judgment has ended and restoration is beginning” (1996: 41). Additionally, Sweeney puts greater emphasis on “the transitional functions of chs. 32–33; 34–35 and 36–39,” indicating “that the structure of the book of Isaiah falls into two basic parts: chs. 1–33 and chs. 34–66” (1996: 43). By emphasizing the bridging function of these texts, Sweeney simultaneously argues for the two-part composition.

In search of a transitional passage between the two main parts, the first text in question has been Isaiah 33, which Beuken labeled as “mirror text.” According to him, the entire book of Isaiah is refracted in this chapter like a ray of light passing through a prism. Yet, he concedes that the references to the preceding texts are clearly fewer than those to the subsequent chapters.⁸

In contrast, Steck (1985) considers Isaiah 35 to be the compositional bridge between the first and the second half of the book. Together with 34, this chapter may form a “diptych.” Yet the strong literary connections between 35 and 40:1–11 show that 35 is more than just the counter-image to 34. In consequence, chapter 35 performs a double

function: on the one hand, it sketches out the radiant future of Zion against the dark background of the judgment upon Edom, and, on the other hand, it re-establishes the bridge from 1–33* to 40–66 disrupted by Isaiah 34. Certainly, this “bridging character” of Isaiah 35 has to be underlined, albeit with the modification that it constitutes the second, not the first bridge (Isaiah 33) between the two main parts.

In addition to Isaiah 33 and 35, chapters 36–39 are considered to be the third editorial bridge connecting the bipartite book of Isaiah. Strikingly, the narrative about Zion’s miraculous deliverance (36–37) and Isaiah’s announcement that the royal house will once be deported to Babylon (39) has an almost verbatim parallel in 2 Kings 18–20. The importance of Isaiah 36–39 for the interpretation of the entire book has been impressively demonstrated by Ackroyd. According to his reading, the story of the Babylonian delegation has been deliberately placed at the end of these narratives in order to lead the reader to chapters 40–55 (cf. Ackroyd 1974: 338). The omission of the tribute payment to Sennacherib (cf. 2 Kgs. 18:1–16), the insertion of the Hezekiah psalm (Isa 38:9–20), and the emphasis on the pious prayer rather than the miracle (cf. vv 8–9) give rise to the assumption that these changes, as compared to the version in 2 Kings 18–20, were made by those who were responsible for including these narratives in the middle of the Isaiah Scroll. But following Isaiah 33 and 35, chapters 36–39 do not simply provide an additional connecting link for the two major parts. Rather, they constitute the theological center of the final form of the book. The fact that the oracles against Assyria and in favor of Zion/Jerusalem have been fulfilled in the humiliating defeat of the invader and the death of the blasphemer underpins the expectation that the message of comfort in Isaiah 40–55 will come true as well.

Once the key position and function of Isaiah 36–39 is recognized, the remaining units can easily be arranged around this center. As a result, the book of Isaiah can be regarded as a literary cathedral in which the reader is invited to witness Zion’s past history and future destiny (cf. Berges 2012b: 23–24).

- Act I, Isaiah 1–12: Zion and Jerusalem between judgment and salvation;
- Act II, Isaiah 13–27: Zion’s enemies and friends—YHWH’s kingship;
- Act III, Isaiah 28–35: The divine king and the congregation of Zion;
- Act IV, Isaiah 36–39: The threat to and deliverance of Zion and Jerusalem;
- Act V, Isaiah 40–48: The *‘ebed* Jacob/Israel in Babylon and his liberation by Cyrus;
- Act VI, Isaiah 49–54: The restoration of Zion and the work of the *‘ebed*;
- Act VII, Isaiah 55–66: The division in Israel and the fate of the *‘abadim*.

The term “act” as used here refers to a compositional unit of a literary, not a theatrical, nature. Asserting the latter would require the assumption that there has been a tradition of such performances within biblical Israel. For this, however, there is no evidence (*contra* Baltzer 1999). The book of Isaiah is the literary “Drama of Zion” in which the readers or hearers witness the transformation of Jerusalem from a place of judgment into a place of eschatological salvation for both the righteous in Israel and the just ones from the nations.

DIACHRONIC MODELS

Diachronic theories concerning the book as a whole can be divided into two categories. Scholars belonging to the first group advocate a model of combination (among others, Vermeylen and Steck). According to them, the final form of the book has been compiled from larger units, which at first developed relatively independently. Proponents of the second group argue in favor of a model of continuity: In their view, Deutero-Isaiah deliberately perpetuates Proto-Isaiah, edits the first corpus of texts, and uses it as an introduction to his own chapters (Williamson). Subsequently, Trito-Isaiah resumes the process of literary reception and redaction in continuity with Deutero-Isaiah (Stromberg). Vermeylen reckons with a Proto-Isaianic collection that, around the year 480 B.C.E., had a structure comparable to that of the book of Ezekiel and that of Jeremiah in their Septuagint version: judgment oracles against Judah and Jerusalem (Isaiah 1–12), judgment oracles against the nations (13–27), and promises for the people of God (28–35), with 36–39 as a historical supplement concluding the collection.⁹ Regarding chapters 40–55, Vermeylen assumes a core of oracles composed by the anonymous exilic prophet, “Deutero-Isaiah,” which all dealt with the appearance of Cyrus. According to Vermeylen, the two originally independent collections were joined after 480 B.C.E. He considers the core of chapters 60–62 as the basis of the Trito-Isaianic collection. Instead of dealing with the building of the second temple, this post-exilic oracle rather is concerned with the city walls of Jerusalem (cf. 60:10; 62:6). Yet, he rejects the idea of “Trito-Isaiah” being an anonymous prophet of the post-exilic period, since 56:9–62:12 are purely literary productions related point by point to 1:2–2:5. Following the time of Nehemiah, a final redaction brought the whole book together and highlighted the fate of the paganized sinners and of those from the nations who turned to YHWH.

In agreement with Vermeylen and based on extensive and detailed literary observations, Steck advocates the deletion of the notion of “Trito-Isaiah” referring to an anonymous prophet from the exegetical vocabulary. Consequently, he regards Isaiah 60–62 as a purely literary continuation of 40–55. The amalgamation between Proto-Isaiah’s collection of 1–39 and Isaiah 40ff has been realized by Steck’s “homecoming redaction” in the period of the early wars of the Diadochi. In this process, Isaiah 35 served as decisive bridge-text (cf. 11:11–16; 27:[12], 13; 62:10–12; see the summary in Steck 1985: 80). For the consolidated period of the Ptolemies (approximately 270 B.C.E.), Steck reckons with smaller additions such as 19:18–25 and 25:6–8.

In contrast, Williamson supports a model of continuity, according to which Isaiah 40ff evidently were created in knowledge of the proto-Isaianic chapters, as can be observed by the strong impact of Isaiah 6 on 40:1–8. Given these close relations, Williamson draws the conclusion “that he [Deutero-Isaiah] regarded his own work as an integral continuation of the work of Isaiah, or, which comes to the same thing, that he bound the version of Isaiah’s book into his own as the necessary precursor to what he was now announcing to his compatriots in exile” (1994: 113). But this deduction raises the serious question of whether Deutero-Isaiah would not have modified the text of Proto-Isaiah more

profoundly if he actually did use it as a prolegomenon to his own prophecies. Following Williamson, his academic teacher, Stromberg (2011) focuses on the influence of Trito-Isaiah (Isaiah 56–66) on the preceding chapters 1–55. According to him, Trito-Isaiah cannot be reduced to the role of reader. Rather, he has to be considered as the redactor of these chapters—an assumption that Stromberg tries to verify with reference to Isaiah 1:27–31; 4:2–6; 6:13; 11:10; 36–39; 48:22; 54:17b. Since in antiquity revisions and supplements were not inserted into the text of existing scrolls, Trito-Isaiah added his own work (chapters 56–66), as well as his revision of Isaiah 1–55, while making a new copy of the Isaiah Scroll (cf. Stromberg 2011: 144).

The decision in favor of one model heavily depends on the degree to which scholars evaluate the differences (model of combination) and the similarities (model of continuity), respectively. Nevertheless, one cannot exclude the possibility that the similarities affecting the entire book of Isaiah were not created by those scribes who joined the two main parts in the first place, but were produced by later redactions that sought to match the already combined parts even more homogeneously.

KEY PERIODS OF LITERARY DEVELOPMENT

Despite all differences regarding the diachronic models, the majority of scholars agree on several main periods in which the literary development of the book of Isaiah took place. First of all, there is the initiator Isaiah ben Amoz and his circle of disciples, which he most likely gathered during the Syro-Ephraimite crisis (734–732 B.C.E.). At least the first-person report in the so-called Isaiah Memoir (Isa 6:1–8, 18) is generally ascribed to the historical prophet himself. Subsequently, the Philistine revolt in 713–711 B.C.E. and Assyria's severe reaction seem to have influenced the collection of oracles against the nations in Isaiah 13–23, including the symbolic prophetic act in chapter 20. The historical background of chapters 28–39 corresponds with the political situation in 705–701 B.C.E. when Judah continuously attempted to infringe her duty of loyalty to Assyria by seeking an alliance with Egypt (cf. Isa 31:1–3). In the end, this hazardous maneuver led to the siege of Jerusalem by Sennacherib (cf. Isaiah 36–37). While the majority of scholars agree on a substantial number of Isaianic prophecies in Isaiah 1–39 (e.g., Beuken 2003, 2007, 2010), Kaiser is very skeptical regarding this issue. According to him, one can attribute to the historical prophet only those texts that cannot be satisfactorily explained as dating from a later period of literary development. “In view of the fact that alterations were made to the Isaiah roll down to the Hellenistic period, there is bound to be a demand to deny on principle that any saying derives from the prophet himself, if it can be explained on the basis of a different period.”¹⁰

Radicalizing the position of his academic teacher, Becker¹¹ concludes that the historical Isaiah has been a prophet of doom against the foreign nations and, by consequence, a prophet of salvation for his own people. In his view, all oracles of doom against Israel date from exilic–post-exilic times. *Post eventum*, the prophet of salvation was rendered

a prophet of doom in order to demonstrate that Isaiah had all along warned about the catastrophe. Against this position, it has been argued that it is hardly likely that Isaiah's prophecies remained in their original state for over 150 years and had not been adopted and reinterpreted prior to the Exile and post-exilic times. Additionally, *contra* Becker's assertion, the core of Isaiah 7 cannot simply be dated to proto-chronistic times.¹² Why should anybody living around 400 B.C.E. haphazardly invent a story about Isaiah and King Ahaz as protagonists in the Syro-Ephraimite crisis, which took place more than 300 years earlier? The stimulating dissertation of de Jong, *Isaiah among the Ancient Near Eastern Prophets*, seems at first glance to approve the position of those who consider Isaiah a prophet of pure salvation. Indeed, the Dutch exegete points out that the core of the Isaiah-tradition (Isaiah 6–9; 10–11; 28–32) had a “basically pro-state” impetus (2007: 283). Such an allegiance to the state was also the characteristic feature of the Neo-Assyrian prophecy under Esarhaddon (681–669) and Ashurbanipal (669–631). Given this content-related parallel, there are good reasons to count Isaiah “among the ancient Near Eastern prophets” (2007: 463). Nevertheless, de Jong does not withhold the differences from Mesopotamian prophecy: in this prophetic tradition, woe-oracles seem to be unknown and Isaiah appears to have played a more important role by far in the public sphere than his Neo-Assyrian colleagues (2007: 354–355). These specific traits notwithstanding, de Jong convincingly demonstrates that the perception of Isaiah as a charismatic figure in rigorous opposition to the dominant self-justification of the monarchy can no longer be maintained. Nevertheless, de Jong ascribes more texts to the historical prophet than other exegetes who hold a more rigid concept of redaction criticism.

The second core period of the Isaiah tradition was the second third of the seventh century B.C.E., a time when the end of the Neo-Assyrian Empire became more and more apparent¹³ and the young King Josiah ascended David's throne in Jerusalem, eager to regain Judah's former strength and splendor. According to Barth, whose dissertation, *Die Jesaja-Worte in der Josiazeit*,¹⁴ deeply influenced the interpretation of the book of Isaiah, texts such as Isaiah 8:23b–9:6; 10:16–19; 14:4b–21; 14:24–27; 30:27–33; and 31:5, 8b–9 belong to the so-called “Assyria redaction.” At about the same time, Vermeylen likewise argued in favor of a redaction related to King Josiah (i.a. Isa 2:2–4; 7:15; 8:23b–9:6a; 11:1–5; 22:19–23).¹⁵ In Anglophone biblical research, the thesis has been taken up particularly by Sweeney (1996: 57–59), who expanded the redaction to further passages of the book (Isa 7:11; 27; 32; 36–39), as well as to texts dealing with the return of exiles (11:11–16; 19:18–25; 27:6–13). In the time of King Josiah, the latter were written in order to propagate the repatriation of the Northern Kingdom by those exiled Israelites who had been deported by Assyria in 722/721 B.C.E. The enthusiasm for Josiah displayed by some scholars must not hide the fact that his name is not once mentioned in the entire book. Moreover, he died what would have been perceived as a disgraceful death when he was fatally wounded by the Egyptian Pharaoh Necho II in Megiddo (cf. 2 Kgs. 23: 28–30). How little Josiah's political impact eventually became is apparent given the fact that his son Jehoahaz was dethroned and deported to Egypt by Necho after only three months of reign. His replacement by Jehoikim as new tributary king in Jerusalem underlines Josiah's political inefficacy. After Josiah's death in 609 B.C.E., Judah's and Jerusalem's

political fate quickly took a turn for the worse, culminating in the first (597 B.C.E.) and second (586 B.C.E.) deportation by the Neo-Babylonians. Is it really probable that the redactors of Proto-Isaiah did not take notice of this profound political decline? This critical question does not render the assumption of an "Assyria redaction" contemporaneous with Josiah's accession completely obsolete. But it reveals the limits of an exegetical approach that overemphasizes the figure of King Josiah and his time in order to reconstruct the pre-exilic development of the book of Isaiah. The monofocal concentration on Josiah and his reign (640–609 B.C.E.) in some scholars' interpretation has even led to the conclusion that all parts of the so-called messianic triptych (Isaiah 7; 9; 11) deal with this king.¹⁶ In the final form of the book, these texts are deliberately put in close proximity. As a result, they can be read as a sequence of a prophetic promise of a Davidic heir to the throne (Isaiah 7), the announcement of his birth with the proclamation of his throne names (Isaiah 9), and a prophetic oracle at the moment of his accession to power (Isaiah 11). But do all these passages really date from the same period, and do they all allude to the same person?

Given the historical scenery of Isaiah 7:10–17 in the context of the Syro-Ephraimite war, as well as the retrospective narrative (in contrast to Isaiah 9 and 11), it is likely that this text goes back to the time of Isaiah.¹⁷ If that is the case, the strongest candidate for the announcement of birth is one of King Ahaz's sons, most probably Hezekiah. This interpretation is in line with the Jewish tradition. By the sign of Immanuel, Isaiah promised to King Ahaz that the house of David would not perish if only he trusted in יהוה. The identification of the Immanuel in Isaiah 7:14 with Hezekiah is supported by the fact that during the Assyrian siege (701 B.C.E.) the king meets Isaiah at exactly the same location as did his father during the Syro-Ephraimite crisis (Isa 7:3; 36:2; cf. 2 Kgs 20:20).¹⁸ As to the trust in God, Hezekiah exhibits more confidence than his father. He is, however, not steadfast enough, as can be seen by Isaiah's harsh criticism, which culminates in the announcement of the deportation of the royal house to Babylon (Isaiah 39). Scholars who advocate for Isaiah 7:10–17 as part of the Josianic redaction weight the argument inversely: Hezekiah is not only depicted more positively than his father, but Ahaz should increasingly become the negative contrast for the favorable portrayal of his son.

Regarding Isaiah 9:1–6, the announcement most probably alludes to Josiah, although Hezekiah remains a good alternative. The emphasis on a child (!) ascending David's throne (v 5) perfectly corresponds to the eight-year-old Josiah succeeding his father. Furthermore, the introduction to the oracle (8:23b) seems to raise hope for a restoration of the Davidic Empire under Josiah by announcing a glorious future for Zebulun and Naphtali denoting the territories once lost to the Assyrians under Tiglath-Pileser III.

Although Isaiah 11 might as well date from the time of Josiah's accession to the throne, the hope for eternal peace on God's holy mountain, which exceeds all reality and is radically future-oriented, rather points to an eschatological Davidic ruler.¹⁹ No Judean king—not even Hezekiah or Josiah—was able completely to satisfy the requirements as David's successor. Moreover, it is striking that the shoot does not grow out of David's root but of the stump of his father Jesse. Furthermore, terms such as "king" (7:1) or "throne of David" (9:6) are entirely absent in the chapter. These literary observations

lead to the assumption that Isaiah 11 no longer cherishes political aspirations but awaits a new form of reign based on the knowledge of God (11:9). It is not a coincidence that the vision of a future peaceable kingdom (Isa 11:6) is adopted by the servants in Isaiah 65:25: according to them, the vision of a just order should be accomplished on Zion as they conceive it in post-exilic times.

During the exilic period, the book of Isaiah underwent its third core phase of development. In the textual world of the book, this crucial epoch is introduced with the proclamation of comfort in Isaiah 40:1–11. It has frequently been emphasized that chapters 40–48 and 49–55 are distinct entities. While the former deal with Israel's destiny in Babylon, the latter focus on the destiny of Jerusalem and Zion.

Additionally, after Isaiah 48 important topics are no longer raised: "Babylon–Cyrus" (i.a. 41:1–5, 25; 43:14; 44:24–45:7; 45:13; 46:11; 48:12–16a), "former and latter/new things" (41:21–9; 42:6–9; 43:8–13; 44:6–8; 45:21; 46:8–11; 48:3–8, 14–16), "polemic against idols" (40:19–20; 41:6–7; 42:17; 44:9–20; 45:20; 46:1–7; 47:9b–15), and the discussion about the "incomparability of YHWH" (40:12–18, 21–31; 41:21–28; 42:14–17; 45:9–13; 46:3–5; 48:1–11). In Isaiah 49–55 and beyond, these issues are no longer addressed. Mainly, this is because the setting has changed from the land of exile to the homeland. Another crucial feature of these chapters is the imperative to flee from Babylon (48:20–21) and to go out "from there" (52:11–12), underlining the movement from exile back home. The first scene of the new section (Isaiah 49–54) is dominated by the servant, the literary representation of that Israel through which God will show his glory (49:3). He presents himself as witness sent to Jerusalem and the nations in order to announce God's renewed power of salvation. In the past, Jacob/Israel (i.e., the Golah) was skeptical about this new activity of YHWH (40:27). Now Jerusalem/Zion (i.e., the non-exiled part of the people of God) deeply questions God's power and intention to secure the future of his people (49:14). A special feature of chapters 49–54 (not including Isaiah 55) is the alternation of passages dealing with the servant on the one hand (49:1–13; 50:4–11; 52:13–53:12) and Zion/Jerusalem on the other hand (49:14–50:3; 51:1–52:12; 54:1–17a). From 54:17b onward, the figure of the servant (singular) is consistently replaced by the servants (plural; cf. 54:17b; 56:6; 63:17; 65:8, 9, 13, 14, 15; 66:14), that is, his offspring (cf. 53:10).

The *opinio communis* stating that at least parts of Isaiah 40–55 were written in the Babylonian Exile has been vehemently questioned by Barstad²⁰ and subsequently by Tiemeyer.²¹ They both argue that the chapters have been composed in Jerusalem after 539 B.C.E. and before the reconstruction of the Second Temple (520–515 B.C.E.). According to them, Akkadian loanwords such as those in 40:20 and 41:25 do not corroborate the argument for Babylonia as historical context of Isaiah 40–55 since there is little knowledge about the languages spoken at that time, and Biblical Hebrew is generally full of *hapax legomena*. In addition, most if not all texts of Isaiah 40–55 that deal with a wandering through the wilderness have to be understood metaphorically and do not imply an actual journey through the *terra intermedia* between Babylon and Jerusalem.²² Quite rightly, they both emphasize that the Babylonian conquest did not leave Judah totally destroyed and depopulated. Settlements such as Mizpah, Gibeah, Bethel, and Gibeon persisted as enclaves where literary activity might have continued.

These important considerations notwithstanding, it still remains salient that topics like Cyrus, foreign deities, or Babylon are confined to chapters 40–48, whereas from Isaiah 49 onward the perspective shifts to Zion/Jerusalem. Hardly any scholar still advocates Babylon as the historical context for Isaiah 49–55. It remains the most probable assumption that the core of Isaiah 40–48 indicates a Babylonian origin, while Isaiah 49–55 were written in Jerusalem or its close vicinity. In the current state of research, this view is shared by the majority of scholars. In this regard, it seems noteworthy that with the exception of Isaiah 42:1–4, all Servant Songs isolated by Duhm are located after Isaiah 49 (49:1–6; 50:4–9; 52:13–53:12). While in Isaiah 41:8–9; 44:1, 2, 21; 45:4; 48:20 the *‘ebed* is equated with Jacob/Israel, the Servant Songs lack such identification (except for 49:3). Duhm’s assumption that the four songs were secondarily inserted into Isaiah 40–55 and thus can be interpreted separately from their literary context in the final form of the book has proved to be incorrect. Due to the strong connections between references to the servant within and outside the songs, Duhm’s position is no longer held. The passages in which the *‘ebed* is mentioned for the first time have almost a parallel structure: Jacob/Israel is called servant (41:8, 9; 42:1), YHWH has chosen him (41:9; 42:1) and upholds him (41:10; 42:1). Despite Duhm’s erroneous position that the Servant Songs (better, Servant Poems) originally were not related to Isaiah 40–55, the extraordinary character of these passages is not automatically disproved (*contra* Mettinger 1983). The interpretation has to take into account the close interrelation between those texts in which the honorary title “servant” is used in reference to Jacob/Israel and those passages without such identification. For this understanding, two texts play a significant role: In Isaiah 42:19–21, YHWH asks who is as blind as his servant and deaf like his messenger. In Isaiah 43:10, he announces to those who abandon their blindness and deafness: “you are my witnesses and my servant whom I have chosen.” In other words: everybody who testifies to YHWH’s renewed salvation, initiated by the calling of Cyrus as his shepherd and anointed one, is in fact a servant of YHWH. Especially in the Golah, the vital question arose as to who was still willing to hold on to YHWH and the salvation of Israel at a time when all promises seemed to have been broken. Yet, the true servant is constituted of every Israelite who confesses that YHWH is the only true God and savior, and who does not stay as a blind and deaf servant in Babylon, the land of worship of foreign deities (Isaiah 48), but returns to his homeland. Arriving in Zion/Jerusalem, this servant of God presents himself in front of all peoples (Isa 49:1–4) since—in contrast to the first Exodus from Egypt—the deliverance takes place in plain view of all nations. Consequently, they should acknowledge YHWH as the only God. But if the blind and deaf servant does not leave Babylon (48:20) and bears the name Israel/Jacob only superficially, ignoring the consequences of this call (48:1), YHWH is unable to prove his uniqueness in front of the nations and their deities. Thus, it is only consequent that in Isaiah 49:3 the returned servant is identified with that kind of Israel in whom YHWH wants to glorify himself.

The longer the servant bears witness to YHWH’s plan of salvation, the more he is confronted with massive opposition since the situation in post-exilic Zion/Jerusalem by no means corresponded to the servant’s claim. This is the background of the fourth Servant Song (Isa 52:13–53:12). Admittedly, the majority of exegetes still interpret the text as

testimony of Deutero-Isaiah's suffering and martyrdom (cf. i.a. Blenkinsopp 2002: 79 on this passage as "a kind of panegyric or funeral oration soon after the prophet's death"). But considering the vagueness of identification of Deutero-Isaiah as individual prophet, this reading becomes more and more unlikely. What is meant by the reference to the deceased servant seeing his offspring (cf. Isa 53:10), given the fact that the hope for individual resurrection hardly occurs in Second Temple literature prior to the second century B.C.E.? On the other hand, a collective understanding of resurrection implying the hope for the restoration of exilic-post-exilic Israel is well documented by Ezekiel 37. Against this backdrop, Isaiah 53 possibly constitutes a literary reflection of the conflict between the returnees from the Golah and the residents who had not been deported in 586 B.C.E. (cf. "Abraham" in Isa 51:2 and Ezek 33:24). And yet, the homecoming servant expresses his fervent hope that the Judeans who spared deportation accept the suffering as redemption for the sins of the "many" (i.e., the whole people of God).²³

The fourth key period refers to the time of the advanced restoration of Jerusalem after the reconstitution of the temple cult (515 B.C.E.). Probably, it is related to Nehemiah's program of reconstruction in the mid-fifth century B.C.E. This dating corresponds with the *opinio communis* of redaction criticism affirming that the core of the last main part of the book is located in Isaiah 60–62. The terms and topoi "sacrifice" (cf. Isa 60:7), "walls/gates" (60:10–11, 18; 62:6), "place of my sanctuary" (60:13; cf. 62:9), and "priests" point to the period when the sacrificial cult was reactivated in Jerusalem and people expected that the nations would contribute opulent gifts to the reconstruction project. At the same time, the vision of the divine light coming over Zion/Jerusalem is closely connected to the hope for a just order (60:17b, 21; 61:1–3, 8, 10–11; 62:1–2). This core passage is surrounded by three successively added frames that are concerned with (a) the admittance of proselytes, even eunuchs and the mission to the nations (56:1–8; 66:18–24), (b) the separation between the wicked and the righteous (56:9–58:14; 65:1–66:17), and (c) communal complaints that deal with the non-arrival of salvation (59; 63:1–64:11). The pragmatics of this concentric structure is twofold: First, the salvific event of God's coming to Zion/Jerusalem is open to people from all the nations; second, the wicked within the people of God have to convert before the light can come. The inclusion of the righteous from the nations and the exclusion of the wicked within Israel are two sides of the same coin.

According to Hanson,²⁴ the schism between the righteous and the wicked in the post-exilic community was created by eschatologically oriented groups who combated the temple aristocracy and found themselves more and more marginalized. This clear-cut opposition of "priestly establishment vs. prophetic visionaries in the battle for the temple" is certainly too unnuanced, as Schramm has shown.²⁵ He rightly asks how a Trito-Isaianic redaction, close to the final redaction of the entire book, could have been so successful in merging the traditions and the parts of the book if it had been realized by a marginal group. Regardless of this discussion, it is one of the unanimous assertions of these chapters that by practicing "justice and righteousness" (*mišpāt/šēdāqâ*), God's "salvation and righteousness" (*yēšū'ā/šēdāqâ*) will finally come (56:1). The first word pair appears frequently in Isaiah 1–35 (e.g. 1:21, 27; 5:7, 16; 9:6). The second occurs regularly in

Isaiah 40–55 (45:8; 46:13; 51:5, 6, 8). The fact that the expressions are combined in Isaiah 56:1 indicates that the previously distinct sections of the Isaiah scroll start to be merged from Isaiah 56 onward. There is much to be said for the hypothesis that the scroll was finished in its substantial form around 400 B.C.E. According to Steck (1985: 69–71), the last redactions are to be placed a hundred years later, in the time of the Ptolemaic dynasty. Against such a late dating might speak the fact that the fall of the Persian Empire has left no visible traces in the book of Isaiah.

SCRIBAL PROPHECY IN THE BOOK OF ISAIAH

As has been shown earlier, the idea that literary prophecy was exclusively or predominantly drafted by charismatic individuals or by the literary activity of their circle of disciples did not turn out to be a viable concept. The possibility of a basic Isaianic layer for chapters such as Isaiah 6–8 and 28–31, however, is by no means ruled out. If critically and modestly applied, it is even a necessary assumption since every literary tradition needs an initial core from which to develop. Why would scholars doubt that Isaiah ben Amoz gathered a circle of disciples (cf. Isa 8:16–18)? But is it reasonable to reckon with an Isaianic school that is believed to have persisted over centuries?²⁶ The fundamental question is easy and complicated at the same time: How did a biblical book with a literary development that took at least three centuries (approx. 700–400 B.C.E.) precisely come into existence? More and more, it has become apparent that the assumption of prophetic individuals working in isolation—whether known by name (Isaiah ben Amoz) or anonymous—does not suffice. In consequence, the development of prophetic books is most adequately explained by the assumption of trained *literati* who passed on the word of God by reworking, expanding, and creatively adapting the existing tradition in view of their particular time. As to Isaiah 56–66, scholarship for a long time has tended to perceive these chapters as scribal prophecy (*Fortschreibungsprophetie*), which at first was oriented mainly toward Isaiah 40–55 but increasingly came to refer to Isaiah 1–39 as well. The position that the last main part of the book was composed by an individual prophet rather than by a group of *literati* cannot be vindicated with reference to the statements of Isaiah 61:1–3 in the first-person singular, since already in Isaiah 40:1–11 the first-person singular suddenly switches to plural (v 6). Similar literary observations can be made in Isaiah 43:10 (“you are my witnesses and my servant”) as well as in 50:4–5 (“YHWH gave me a tongue of disciples; to hear as disciples”). The phenomenon becomes particularly apparent in 59:21 as divine introductory speech to Isaiah 60–62: “This is my covenant with *them* . . . my spirit that is upon *you* [singular].” Undoubtedly, this verse interprets the individual figure of Isaiah 61:1–3 endowed with the divine spirit (“the spirit of the LORD is upon me”) in a collective way. It applies to all those of Jacob/Israel who turn away from their sins and turn to the redeemer of Zion (Isa 59:20). Thus, Isaiah 59:21 constitutes the oldest interpretation of Isaiah 61 and unmistakably shows collective orientation. Equally evident is the transition from the servant (singular) to the servants

(plural) from 54:17b onward. With good reason, these servants are identified with those who applied the endowment of the divine spirit in Isaiah 61:1—as overture to the central chapter of the core composition Isaiah 60–62—to themselves, and simultaneously presented themselves in continuity with the servant of Isaiah 40–55.

In contrast to “Trito-Isaiah,” many scholars still contend that there was an individual prophetic author behind Isaiah 40–55.²⁷ But even with reference to “Deutero-Isaiah,” more and more exegetes argue for a group identity. In the first half of the twentieth century, this view had already been held by Caspari against Duhm.²⁸ Unfortunately, it did not gain much attention in the research on the book of Isaiah.²⁹ In recent times, the situation has significantly changed (i.a. Werlitz 1999: 285–293).³⁰ It has become more and more apparent that there is no prophetic individual entering the literary stage in chapters 40–55 and that the Servant Songs are unable to fill the “biographical vacuum.”³¹ Moreover, recent studies on the redaction history of the chapters attribute fewer and fewer passages to the Deutero-Isaianic core. As a consequence, the literary habitat of the exilic prophet (i.e., the chapters in which he is supposed to be found) is reduced to some portions in Isaiah 41–45. In contrast to the references to Ezekiel’s life in Babylon (cf. Ezek 1:1; 24:1; 26:1; 29:1), the presumed prophet behind Isaiah 40–55 lacks such literary descriptions of his personal situation. In contrast to the repeated formula “the word of YHWH came to me” in Ezekiel (6:1; 7:1; 12:1, 8, etc.), no comparable example is found in Isaiah 40–55. Even those scholars who still maintain the hypothesis of an individual exilic author implicitly recognize the alternative of an authorial group. The most probable candidates are exiled temple singers who initially were active in Babylon and remained literarily productive after their return to Jerusalem. Some scholars consider the possibility that “Deutero-Isaiah” was their *spiritus rector*, a kind of *chef du groupe*.³² But the central problem, his anonymity, still remains unresolved. If the prophet behind the modern eponym “Deutero-Isaiah” had been the leading figure of such a group, his namelessness is even more puzzling: Why should his disciples not have preserved his name and identity?

One of the main arguments for the assumption of Levitical singers as the authorial group behind these chapters is the closeness of the hymnic passages in Isaiah 40–55 to Psalms 96 and 98 with their praise of God’s universal kingship. Additionally, the divine fight against the forces of chaos in Isaiah 51:9–10 to re-establish security for Jerusalem and the cosmic order has many parallels in the Psalms of Korah (Psalms 42–49; 84; 85; 87; 88). The affinities of Isaiah 40–55, however, are not restricted to the book of Psalms. They cover a whole range of important traditions of the Hebrew Bible: the patriarchal narratives and the Exodus, the prophetic judgment tradition, some elements of the Jerusalem Isaiah composition (such as “the Holy One of Israel”), influences from Jeremiah (especially the so-called confessions; see Jer 31:35 in Isa 51:15) and from Ezekiel (profanation of the name in Isa 48:11, cf. Ezek 20:9, 14, 22³³), Deuteronomistic elements,³⁴ Jerusalem cult traditions with the central motifs of Zion, the nations, and the refashioned David tradition (Isa 55:3–5), as well as the intimate connection of creation and history in analogy to the priestly stratum of the Pentateuch. The combination and amalgamation of all these traditions cannot be explained merely as a late phenomenon in the development of

prophetic writings. Rather, it points to a collective authorship by professional *literati* who had access and fundamental knowledge of these traditions in ancient Israel. All those who question the possibility of collective authorship in Isaiah 40–55 should take a look at some later compositions in the first part of the book. With regard, for example, to Isaiah 24–27, the hypothesis of collective authorship is commonly accepted (cf. Hibbard 2006). Why continue to search for an individual as the author of Isaiah 40–55 if such an endeavor is completely out of question for the traditions of the Pentateuch or the Historical Books?

Furthermore, the assumption of collective authorship could illuminate the smooth transition between Isaiah 55 and 56 more plausibly. Already Duhm (1968: 419) held the view that Isaiah 56:1–8 is only superficially linked with Deutero-Isaiah and that it appears to be rather an *addendum* or an insertion by a foreign hand. It is somewhat surprising that the founding father of the Trito-Isaiah hypothesis was apparently not very convinced about the beginning of the last main part of the book. So it is not surprising that other divisions were proposed by modern scholars. Seitz, for example, defines Isaiah 54:1–66:24 as the last main part of the book and heads it “Vindication of the Servant by God” (2001: 481). Watts interprets Isaiah 54:17c–56:8 as a separate section and considers 54:17c to be “a kind of title beginning this new section” (1987: 244). According to Vermeylen,³⁵ Isaiah 56:9 constitutes the starting point of Trito-Isaiah. Other scholars like Wegner³⁶ assume that 48:22 and 57:21 are the most important watersheds creating the divisions Isaiah 40–48; 49–57; 58–66. To date, little attention has been drawn to the concluding verse of Isaiah 54: “This is the heritage of the servants of YHWH, and their righteousness from me, says YHWH” (v 17b). This is astonishing since the Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIs^a) highlights this line with no fewer than three scribal features (*vacat*, *paragraphos*, *spatium*). From this line onward, the transition of the servant to the servants in Isaiah 40–66 is completed.

If Isaiah 54:17b is interpreted as a superscription to what follows, the “Woe” (הוי) in 55:1 regains rhetorical force as it points to the growing gulf and impending separation between the servants and their opponents, which reaches its peak in chapters 65–66.³⁷ Although these servants were related to the cult, they seemed not to be of priestly descent (cf. Isa 56:1–8; 66:1–6). Rather, the group consisted of descendants of Levitical singers who returned to their homeland. This understanding supports the assumption that in post-exilic times these servants connected Isaiah 40–66 with 1–32*, the venerable Isaiah tradition preserved in Jerusalem. As a result, this scripture became Zion’s prophetic book for Israel and the nations, and Isaiah ben Amoz was made the visionary of the entire book that has borne his name ever since.

NOTES

1. Cf. John N. Oswalt, *Isaiah 1–39* (NICOT; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 25; J. Alec Motyer, *The Prophecy of Isaiah: An Introduction and Commentary* (Downers Grove, IL: Inter-Varsity, 1993); Oswald T. Allis, *The Unity of Isaiah: A Study in Prophecy* (Philadelphia: Presbyterian and Reformed Publishing, 1950); Edward J. Young, *Studies in Isaiah* (London: Tyndale, 1955).

2. Unfortunately, this standard reference in German-speaking scholarship has not been translated for over a hundred years.
3. Gerald T. Sheppard, "The Book of Isaiah: Competing Structures according to a Late Modern Description of Its Shape and Scope," in *SBL Seminar Papers 1992* (ed. Eugene H. Lovering, Jr.; Atlanta, GA: Scholars, 1992), 549–582 (575).
4. William H. Brownlee, "The Manuscripts of Isaiah from Which DSIa Was Copied," *BASOR* 127 (1952): 16–21.
5. Cf. Brownlee, "Manuscripts of Isaiah"; Brownlee, *The Meaning of the Qumrân Scrolls for the Bible: With Special Attention to the Book of Isaiah* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1964).
6. Brownlee, *Meaning of the Qumran Scrolls*, 255.
7. Cf. Brownlee, *Meaning of the Qumran Scrolls*, 249.
8. Cf. Willem A. M. Beuken, "Jesaja 33 als Spiegeltext," *ETL* 67 (1991): 5–35 (28).
9. Cf. Jacques Vermeylen, "L'Unité du livre d'Isaïe," in *The Book of Isaiah* (ed. Jacques Vermeylen; BETL 81; Leuven: Leuven University Press, 1989), 11–53 (28–34).
10. Otto Kaiser, *Isaiah 1–39: A Commentary* (OTL; London: SCM, 1980 [2nd ed.; orig. publ. 1974; Germ. orig.: *Der Prophet Jesaja Kap. 1–39*; ATD 18; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1973]), xii.
11. Uwe Becker, *Jesaja: von der Botschaft zum Buch* (FRLANT 178; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1997).
12. Cf. Becker, *Jesaja*, 59.
13. Sigmund Mowinckel, *Jesaja disipline: Profetien fra Jesaja til Jeremia* (Oslo: Aschehoug, 1926); *idem*, "Komposition des Jesajabuches 1–39," *AcOr* 11 (1933): 267–292.
14. Hermann Barth, *Die Jesaja-Worte in der Josiazeit: Israel und Assur als Thema einer produktiven Neuinterpretation der Jesajaüberlieferung* (WMANT 48; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1977).
15. Cf. Jacques Vermeylen, *Du Prophète Isaïe à l'apocalyptique: Isaïe, I–XXXV, miroir d'un demi-millénaire d'expérience religieuse en Israël*, Vol. 2 (Paris: Gabalda, 1978), 688–692.
16. Cf. Antti Laato, *Josiah and David Redivivus: The Historical Josiah and the Messianic Expectations of Exilic and Postexilic Times* (CBOTS 33; Stockholm: Almqvist & Wiksell, 1992); Marvin A. Sweeney, *King Josiah of Judah: The Lost Messiah of Israel* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001).
17. Cf. Hugh G. M. Williamson, *Variations on a Theme: King, Messiah and Servant in the Book of Isaiah* (Carlisle: Paternoster, 1998), who even dates the entire triptych to this period.
18. Despite considerable chronological problems: according to 2 Kings 18:1, Hezekiah was twenty-five years old when acceding the throne in Jerusalem; according to 2 Kings 18:13, Sennacherib's campaign against Judah took place in Hezekiah's fourteenth regnal year (701 B.C.E.). Thus, by the time of the Syro-Ephraimite crisis (734–732 B.C.E.), Hezekiah would already have been born.
19. *Inter alia* Joseph Blenkinsopp, *David Remembered: Kingship and National Identity in Ancient Israel* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2013), 135–137.
20. Hans M. Barstad, *A Way in the Wilderness: The "Second Exodus" in the Message of Second Isaiah* (JSSM 12; Manchester: University of Manchester, 1989).
21. Lena-Sofia Tiemeyer, *For the Comfort of Zion: The Geographical and Theological Location of Isaiah 40–55* (VTSup 139; Leiden: Brill, 2001).
22. Øystein Lund, *Way Metaphors and Way Topics in Isaiah 40–55* (FAT II/28; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2007).

23. Cf. Ulrich Berges, *Jesaja 49–54* (HThKAT; Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 2015).
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25. Cf. Brooks Schramm, *The Opponents of Third Isaiah: Reconstructing the Cultic History of the Restoration* (JSOTSup 193; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1995), 81–111.
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30. Cf. also Rainer Albertz, *Die Exilszeit: 6. Jahrhundert v. Chr.* (Biblische Enzyklopädie 7; Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 2001), 283–286.
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32. Michel, “Deuterocesaja,” 521; Albertz, *Exilszeit*, 285–286; cf. earlier Hans-Christoph Schmitt, “Prophetie und Schultheologie im Deuterocesajabuch: Beobachtungen zur Redaktionsgeschichte von Jes 40–55,” *ZAW* 91 (1979): 43–61 (59).
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CHAPTER 10

JEREMIAH

Structure, Themes, and Contested Issues

MARK LEUCHTER

THE book of Jeremiah remains at the forefront of scholarly inquiry into the formation of the Hebrew Bible, in no small part due to its points of contact with so many other pivotal texts. The book of Jeremiah countenances Deuteronomy, the Priestly literature of the Pentateuch, prophetic materials in the book of the Twelve, historiographic material in the book of Kings (or for many, the Deuteronomistic History more generally), the restoration narratives in Ezra-Nehemiah, the closing chapters in the book of Chronicles, and even the discourses in the record of the “other” prophet of the early exilic era, the book of Ezekiel. In this maelstrom of literature, the book of Jeremiah often functions as a point of reference against which shifting ideologies and theological positions are measured. By the end of the exilic era and the outset of the Persian period, it was already regarded as an authoritative body of prophetic teaching to which one might refer to secure legitimacy or to which one might affix ideas in need of support. The book of Jeremiah was a socio-religious anchor *and* palimpsest from a very early period in its development, which speaks to not only the towering stature of its namesake in public memory, but also the potency of the arrangement and categories of its contents.

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK

The book of Jeremiah possesses three major structural blocks: a collection of oracles presented as the prophet’s pre-exilic words to Israel/Judah (“Unit A”), a scribal anthology containing historiographic narratives and oracles addressing the fall of Judah and the beginning of the Babylonian Exile (“Unit B”), and an assortment of oracles against foreign nations (OAN), similar to those found in other prophetic books (“Unit C”). A fourth unit, Jeremiah 52, completes the book, but most scholars recognize that this was added to the work at a very late stage and that it is simply a copy of 2 Kings 25 (with

only very minor variations). For this reason, scholars generally look to only the first three structural blocks as the fundamental units of discourse within the book. Indeed, one major version of the book of Jeremiah (see the following discussion) appears to have been canonized well before the addition of Jeremiah 52, ending with the phrase “here are ended the words of Jeremiah,” with Jeremiah 52 appended afterward at a much later time.

However, it is essential to note that two major ancient versions of the book evolved in antiquity, one preserved in the Masoretic Text of the Hebrew Scriptures (MT), and another preserved in a version that was eventually translated into Greek in the third century B.C.E., known as the Septuagint (LXX), that derived from a very different Hebrew Vorlage than what we encounter in the MT. The manuscript evidence from Qumran further reveals that other versions existed as well, but none of these seems to have survived in substantial form beyond Qumran. The MT and LXX thus represent the best witnesses to the dominant ancient versions of Jeremiah, and while each possesses the aforementioned three major structural blocks, they appear in a very different order in each version. The differences and commonalities are summarized in Table 10.1.

In the MT, the book opens with chapters 1–25, the prophet’s oracles to Israel and Judah (Unit A). The “call narrative” in Jeremiah 1 provides the lens through which the ensuing material may be understood; the closing oracle (Jeremiah 25) looks back to the beginning and provides a discourse on Judah’s final judgment from *YHWH* and the form it will take through the figure of Babylon. Though this last oracle is dated to the reign of Jehoiakim (605 B.C.E. according to Jer 25:1),¹ there are solid grounds for dating several passages in Jeremiah 1–25 to periods post-dating 587 B.C.E. All of the Bible’s prophetic literature passed through the hands of later scribes at some point, and it is impossible to divorce these subsequent literati and their ideological biases from the textualization of the oracles they received and transmitted. Nevertheless, many of these oracles may indeed have roots in the late monarchic period in which Jeremiah was active, and set the thematic and rhetorical terms by which later materials could be added. The overall structuring of this block of material presents the oracles to Israel and Judah as a body of teaching for later audiences in relation to the final and turbulent years of the Judahite monarchy, reflecting on the theological underpinnings of events that transpired in that era.

Table 10.1 The Sequence of Major Units in the Masoretic (MT) and Septuagint (LXX) Versions

Jeremiah MT Tradition	Jeremiah LXX Tradition
Unit A: Oracles to Israel/Judah (Jer 1–25)	Unit A: Oracles to Israel/Judah (Jer 1–25:13)
Unit B: The scribal anthology (Jer 26–45)	Unit C: OAN (Jer 25:14–32:34)
Unit C: OAN (Jer 46–51)	Unit B: The scribal anthology (Jer 33–51)

The second unit of material in the MT of Jeremiah, the scribal anthology, is found in chapters 26–45 (Unit B). These chapters are often described as historiographic narratives, but this is a somewhat misleading description; while they contain important historiographic information, Jeremiah 26–45 is strategically punctuated by assortments of oracles, some of which have very early origins and were revised either by the prophet himself or the scribes who set them within their anthology. The centerpiece of this anthological unit is actually a collection of oracles identified by scholars as “the Book of Consolation” (Jeremiah 30–33), a book-within-a-book that contains oracles of hope, forgiveness, and restoration addressed to different audiences. The structure of the scribal anthology, then, places the concept of redemption at its core; the surrounding materials, which contain troubling and violent features, are somehow qualified by this material at their core. The anthology emerges as a companion piece to the material in Unit A, with a didactic message for audiences regarding how the actions of the prophet and his peers held relevance for post-monarchic Judahite communities.

The final major structural unit in the MT version of the book is the OAN, spanning chapters 46–51 (Unit C). The origins of the OAN collection are difficult to assign to any single period for various reasons, not the least of which is that the various oracles it contains seem to date from diverse points in time, and show signs of extensive secondary expansions and elaboration. The matter is further complicated by the fact that while the LXX also contains an OAN collection, it is quite different in content and arrangement than the version preserved in the MT. Scholars have endeavored—with questionable success—to determine which of these collections is more “authentic.” It is perhaps more useful to see each as a testament to an ancient tradition of the prophet’s oracles to foreign nations, which was always associated with and read alongside the collection of his oracles against Israel and Judah (as suggested, we should note, in Jer 36:2), and which obtained a variety of iterations as the Jeremianic literary collections proliferated.

The MT version of the OAN does show some signs of its original purpose, however, as well as the conditions under which it was redacted. The scribal anthology ends with Jeremiah’s condemnation of the Judahite refugees in Egypt, which leads directly into the oracle against Egypt in the OAN (Jeremiah 45–46), and the final oracle in the collection is the oracle against Babylon, to which the colophon of Seraiah ben Neriah (a Jerusalemite scribe) remained appended, thereby closing the MT sequence of the book. The MT version of the OAN was thus probably shaped by the same scribes who created the anthology, who lived in Babylon during the exilic period, and who saw the prophet’s message as one applicable to Judahites now living among the nations under Babylon’s control (see further under “Contested Issues”). It is these scribes who are responsible for the notice in MT Jeremiah 51:64b that “here end the words of Jeremiah,” providing a closing frame to the opening “words of Jeremiah” at the outset of MT Jeremiah 1:1 and demarcating the extent of the authoritative corpus (chapter 52 was thus subsequently appended).

The structure of the LXX version of Jeremiah is in some respects similar to that of the MT, insofar as it contains the same three structural blocks, but as noted in Table 10.1,

their arrangement is dramatically different. The opening chapters of the LXX (Unit A, Jeremiah 1–25) roughly parallel those of the MT, but the second unit of material in the LXX is the OAN (Unit C), which span LXX Jeremiah 25:14–32:34. Unlike the MT version of these oracles, the OAN in the LXX does not possess a discernible political or geographic “logic”; that is, the order of the oracles appears to be somewhat random. The final structural block is the scribal anthology (Unit B), which runs from LXX Jeremiah 33–51 and which is very similar to the scribal anthology in MT Jeremiah 26–45, though somewhat more truncated. In fact, the LXX version of the book is roughly 13% shorter than the MT, which suggests that the sources used in the construction of the former were expanded and embellished by the scribes who produced the latter (see further under “Contested Issues”).

The overall contents of these blocks loosely resemble what we find in the MT, but the alternate sequence of the blocks is of great significance. The sequence in the LXX more closely matches the books of Ezekiel and Isaiah, where oracles directed to foreign nations are placed in the middle of these prophetic works. This helps align Jeremiah’s prophetic book with Israel’s larger prophetic tradition, and suggests that the fate of nations is literally wrapped up within *YHWH*’s message to Israel. Furthermore, the closing of the LXX with the scribal anthology allows for the book to come to an end with a blessing offered to Baruch ben Neriah (LXX Jeremiah 51), the brother of Seraiah; the scribe appears to eclipse the prophet. If, as many scholars have argued, the development of the LXX should be dated to the Persian or early Hellenistic period, such a literary suggestion is reinforced by the social reality, for Israelite prophecy had by then dwindled, and scribes associated with the Jerusalem temple carried the mantle of intellectual authority.

The different structures of the MT and LXX versions of the book of Jeremiah point not only to different circles of tradents, but to vastly different audiences. The mature forms of each version developed throughout eras when Jews lived under foreign imperialism (Babylonian, Persian, Hellenistic) and in dispersed communities. The MT sequence, initiated in an early form by scribes living in Babylon, was developed by later scribes who returned to Jerusalem in the Persian period who maintained communal allegiances to the memory of that earlier experience; the text they shaped over time preserved strong traces of that allegiance and experience. The LXX, on the other hand, is often regarded as having developed among Jewish scribes living in Egypt from a time as early as the beginning decades of the Babylonian Exile. The founders of that community thus had a very different experience than those who were carried captive into Babylon, and valued different traditions of expression (textual or otherwise) that were preserved in their version of the Jeremianic corpus. The persistence of both ancient versions in antiquity points to the needs of their respective audiences who still bore the marks of their earlier cultural experiences, with each text serving as a sort of anchor or baseline for communal identity formation. Yet while the structural differences point to divergent concepts of identity and views of history, the material shared between the MT and LXX of the book reveal that these different communities and textual collections possessed a common point of origin in the distant past.

MAJOR THEMES

Transgression and Punishment

Most of the book of Jeremiah revolves around the notion that Israel has transgressed against YHWH, and the deity will thus execute judgment against them and inflict punishment. While the theme is consistent, different oracles apply this theme to different parties and even individuals. For example, the oracles spanning Jeremiah 2–4 are often viewed as directed (in part) to the populations of the former northern kingdom, who are said to have transgressed against YHWH by virtue of their fidelity to illegitimate deities and allegiances with illicit foreign forces; for this reason, YHWH will visit his wrath upon them, since they have turned their back upon him despite his fidelity to them. These oracles probably stem from very early in the prophet's career, but they have been worked into a larger literary structure (Jeremiah 1–25) that transforms them into an invective against Judah, transferring the sins of the former group onto the latter. In some cases, the concept of transgression and punishment is directed to specific groups: Jeremiah 7:16–20 directs YHWH's ire against common families engaged in prohibited praxes, Jeremiah 8:4–9:25 addresses the elites of Jerusalem (especially the royal officers, sages, and official priests), and Jeremiah 22 indicts the entire royal Davidic line subsequent to the death of King Josiah (609 B.C.E.). Rarer but still prominent are oracles addressing the transgression and punishment related to individuals: Jeremiah 20:16 addresses the prophet's adversary Pashhur, Jeremiah 21:7 spells doom for King Zedekiah, and Jeremiah 36:29–30 condemns King Jehoiakim for his repudiation of the prophet's written words of warning. All levels of society, from the plenary to the personal, are subject to the same standards of punishment for abdication of their fidelity to divine will.

Repentance and Redemption

Despite all of the “gloom and doom” associated with Jeremiah's oracles of woe and judgment, many of these oracles also contain provisos for redemption and restoration. As noted earlier, the “Book of Comfort” in Jeremiah 30–33 plays a central role in the book, but other oracles possess similar features that highlight the possibility of divine forgiveness following sincere repentance. A major example of this can be found in Jeremiah's famous “Temple Sermon” (Jer 7:1–15), delivered following the death of King Josiah. In this oracle, YHWH claims that if the people “emend their ways and doings” and follow the principles of covenant law (see later discussion), they will be able to continue to live in safety. Similarly, the early oracles to the north in Jeremiah 2–4 contain a call to “return” (*šwb* in Hebrew) to YHWH, who calls them out on their sins but who is willing to take them back as his people. Even the narrative material in the scribal anthology carries forward this theme: the survivors of the destruction of Jerusalem are given the opportunity to continue living in the

land under conditions of relative safety (Jeremiah 40), and the prophet's own proclamations to this remnant group provide them with repeated chances to reaffirm their fidelity to YHWH even as they abandon earlier conditions (Jeremiah 42; 44). The most famous moment dealing with this theme is that of Jeremiah 34:31–34, which specifies that the people who have been taken captive can eventually look forward to a time when YHWH will rebuild the covenant bond with them and forgive them their earlier trespasses.

Law and Covenant

Throughout the book of Jeremiah, Israel's covenant relationship with YHWH remains a central focus. At all levels, the book presupposes that the people of Israel are YHWH's people and that he is their deity, and no other. At various points, this is expressed via marital metaphors (especially in Jer 3:1–5), but also through the metaphor of parent/child (Jer 31:8) and, especially, of suzerain to vassal (Jeremiah 2; 11:1–17; 22:8–9). The suzerain/vassal relationship in the book of Jeremiah may be assigned to the writers' awareness of common political power structures in the ancient Near East where these relationships were the norm, but is also very likely inspired by the strong presence of this motif in the book of Deuteronomy and the function of law in that work. As scholars have recognized for a long time, Deuteronomy is founded in large part upon the standards of neo-Assyrian and Hittite treaty literature, where the suzerain overlord lays down the terms by which the vassal must swear allegiance. The dynamic of Israel as YHWH's vassal is fixed in the book of Deuteronomy, and this accounts for its presence in the book of Jeremiah, since there is broad agreement among scholars that the latter is strongly influenced by Deuteronomy's thought, language, and law.

The book of Jeremiah regularly characterizes the covenant according to legal concepts found in Deuteronomy. The Temple Sermon, for example, alludes to Deuteronomy's legislation in its call for obedience (Jer 7:6, 9), the covenant "lawsuit" in Jeremiah 11:1–17 utilizes the same type of language found throughout Deuteronomy 5–11, and the prophet's confrontation with Zedekiah in Jeremiah 34:8–22 begins with an invocation of both Deuteronomy's legislation regarding slavery and the call to proclaim the law publicly every seven years (Jer 34:14; cf. Deut 31:10). In addition, the destruction wrought by Babylon—YHWH's punishment for the people's abrogation of the covenant—is identified as a result of their rejection of the Deuteronomic law (Jer 9:11–12). Finally, Jeremiah 31:31–34 speaks of a new covenant being "written" on the hearts of Israel, following Deuteronomy's understanding of law as a written text from Israel's earliest period of residency in the land (Deut 27:2–3).

Baal and Falsehood

Certain keywords recur throughout the book of Jeremiah that carry heavy thematic resonance, and two of the most prominent and frequent are "falsehood" (*šqr* in Hebrew)

and “baal.” When viewed in the aggregate, the oracles containing these two motifs associate them as reflections of each other. Within the rhetoric of Jeremiah, the term “baal” appears at first to refer to the Canaanite deity of the same name (Baal), that is, a deity that Israel is prohibited from worshiping. However, the book also makes reference to “baal” in other contexts, identifying the term with the ancestral cult (the worship of “the baals” in Jer 8:2; 19:13) and indeed with devotion or fetishizing of any icon or principle that displaces or challenges exclusive fidelity to YHWH and his law. So, for instance, even the understanding of YHWH himself could be fetishized and thus be rendered a “baal” (Jer 31:32). By the same token, blind faith in the edifice of the Jerusalem temple or the sanctity of the Davidic covenant may qualify as Baalism and thus displace the role of YHWH as the “living god” in Israel’s consciousness.

All of this constitutes “falsehood” in the book of Jeremiah—words, doctrines, actions, politics, social institutions, and even people manifest falsehood at various points, set against the truths conveyed by the prophet to his audience and by the book to its readers. The issue of falsehood is most powerfully voiced in relation to social and physical institutions and edifices that an ancient Israelite (or Jewish) audience would have known and considered both familiar and infallible. The Temple Sermon brazenly refers to the words “the sanctuary of YHWH” (i.e., the Jerusalem temple itself) as “words of falsehood” (7:4, 8). The oracles similarly impugn the priesthood and state-sponsored prophets for falling prey to falsehood as well (5:31; 6:13; 8:13). The recurrence of these charges suggest strongly that Jeremiah himself was charged with false prophecy during his activity, a charge that appears to be confirmed in the account of Jeremiah 26 and the “showdown” between Jeremiah and Hananiah in Jeremiah 28. The book ultimately vindicates Jeremiah (as did history), but intensifies the charge and the theme in relation to prophets who promoted contrary messages (Jer 27:9–10, 14; 29:21–32).

The Divine Word

Equally as frequent and pervasive as the motif of falsehood/baal, but standing in complete opposition to it, is the theme of the divine Word (*ḏbr* in Hebrew) of YHWH. This Word is presented not simply as the locution of the prophet’s oracles, but as a force that empowers history into being and which carries the very presence of YHWH into the social lives of his people. The idea of the divine Word as connected to the prophetic office is presupposed in the quotation of Jeremiah 18:18, where Jeremiah’s adversaries affirm that “the Word shall not depart from the mouth of the prophet.” Though the nature of that Word is obviously contested between Jeremiah and his adversaries, both recognize that prophets are charged with conveying it and that it carries tremendous power. This concept is spelled out at the very beginning of the book: Jeremiah 1:9–10 informs us that the divine Word placed in Jeremiah’s mouth—one charged with Mosaic-Deuteronomic authority (cf. Deut 18:18)—will change the political landscape not simply within Israel (and Judah) but throughout the entire world. Thus when Jeremiah begins an oracle with the phrase “hear this word!” the oracle is not simply a human warning but a blueprint

for divine will and the resulting shape of history; to deny hearing it is to deny one's part in it and thus to deny one's accountability to YHWH.

It is this very same Word that migrates from the prophet's mouth to the scroll containing written prophecy, and it is the prophet himself who serves as the bridge between the two forms of communication. Jeremiah is repeatedly presented as personally organizing his oracles into literary collections (30:2; 36:2; 51:60), and then goes on to interact closely with scribes who do the same (Jer 32:6–15; 36:4–8, 32; 45:1; 51:59–64a). These written works carry the same degree of numinous power as the oracles the prophet pronounces out loud: Jeremiah 36:17–18 spells out that written prophecy is not simply records of revelation but the very substance of revelation, containing the exact same divine Word that lives in the mouth of the prophet. The very textual materiality of the book is highlighted as the way that the divine Word continues to be revealed (Jer 36:32). With the fading of the prophet from view, the divine Word eventually only resides in these written oracles, turning them into cosmic texts that sustain covenant and community, that provide order for the cosmos, and that can be consulted to discern the voice and will of the deity.

The Prominence of Scribes

More than any other prophetic book, the book of Jeremiah promotes the importance of scribes in the religious and social life of Israel. Most scholars recognize that all of the Bible's prophetic books passed through the hands of various scribal groups, but no other prophetic book explicitly emphasizes the role of scribal processes and methods, as well as the names of individual scribes, in the same manner as the book of Jeremiah. Most of the overt references to scribes and scribalism are found, not surprisingly, in the scribal anthology of (MT) Jeremiah 26–45, where figures such as Baruch ben Neriah, Ahikam ben Shaphan, Elasah ben Shaphan, and the other scribes named in Jeremiah 36 take center stage as protectors of the prophet, agents of his message, and trustees of his message. But scribes and scribalism play important roles beyond these chapters as well: Seraiah ben Neriah is charged with enacting an important ritual involving the reading of Jeremiah's anti-Babylon oracle in Jeremiah 51:59–64a, and the prophet himself is subtly characterized in scribal terms throughout the book. The very fact that so many of the prophet's oracles are assembled and organized into "books" throughout the larger Jeremianic corpus is suggestive of this, but so is the presence of rhetorical designs in the oracles that point to scribal training and enculturation. The line between prophecy and scribalism is blurred, if not ultimately removed, throughout the book of Jeremiah.

Homeland, Exile, and "a Prophet to the Nations"

Much of the book of Jeremiah focuses on the threat of exile into foreign lands and the status of the ancestral homeland. This was a pressing concern even before Jeremiah's lifetime, since the fall of the northern kingdom of Israel in 721 B.C.E. had introduced into

Israelite consciousness the possibility of dislocation and detachment from the sacred landscape upon which ethnic and religious self-concepts were founded. Questions and anxieties surrounding this issue are found in many of the early oracles in the book (i.e., those that seem to pre-date the rise of Babylon in 605 B.C.E.), with the connection between the land and national social/political conduct set in binary relation to each other (Jer 2:7; 7:1–15; 16:18). The old agrarian ideal that factored Israel's land tenure into the covenantal relationship with YHWH is central to these oracles, where social ethics and religious fidelity ensure secure residence in a fertile land, while transgression led to the threat of expulsion, following the Deuteronomic ideology (Jer 7:12–15; cf. Deuteronomy 28; 2 Kgs 17:7–23). The pitch of this discourse increases in oracles postdating the rise of Babylon, and especially following the exile of Jehoiachin and a small community of Jerusalem's elites in 597 B.C.E. Various oracles in the book of Jeremiah (some probably added or significantly adjusted by later scribes) favor those carried into exile as having paid the price for earlier transgression and thus fit for eventual redemption (e.g., Jer 24:2–7; Jeremiah 27–29).

Many oracles and narrative units, however, seem more inclined to favor those who remained in the land, positioning them as fit for redemption as well and emphasizing their connection to agrarian covenantal concepts (Jer 7:7b is one good example). Ultimately the themes play out in the larger macrostructures of the MT and LXX: the former ends with a declaration that Babylon (the place of exile) will fall, implying a return to the land in Seraiah's colophon (MT Jer 51:59–64a), and the latter ends in Baruch's colophon (LXX Jeremiah 51) with a declaration that blessing will be obtained "in all the places" where the scribe Baruch finds himself (i.e., exile/Diaspora). If the MT was shaped primarily among the elites of the Jerusalem scribal establishment during the Persian period while the LXX took shape among the Jews living in Egypt during that same time frame, the ending of each version with these opposing thematic emphases makes sense. However, there is an irony in this, insofar as the MT tradition was developed by a community that strongly connected its identity to the experience of the Babylonian Exile, while the scribal anthology ending with Baruch's colophon was originally composed (in part) to make a case for those who had remained in the homeland after the captivity of 597 B.C.E.

In all of this, Jeremiah's oracles take on an increased significance when we recall that in the call narrative, YHWH designates him "a prophet to the nations" (Jer 1:5) and indeed to both "nations and kingdoms" (1:10). Though the prophet's early career is presented in the book as directed to various social groups within Israel (and, in particular, within the kingdom of Judah), the prophet's role evolves as the book continues, especially in the anthology of chapters 26–45 and, of course, the OAN. Jeremiah becomes a pivotal figure not only in conveying the terms of Israel's life in the homeland and various states of exile/dispersion, but also in the development of a theology that began to see Israel's fate as connected to the fate of the world and its ruling empires (Assyria and Babylon; later, Persia). YHWH, Israel's god, fully emerges as a universal deity with hegemony over all the nations into which Israel has been cast and within which they fight for survival. His will and intentions for Israel have international and indeed cosmic ramifications; this was

certainly a going concern among those Jews living in the mid-sixth century B.C.E. who preserved powerful memories of Jeremiah's words and deeds (see the following section, "Contested Issues"). As such, the shaping of his oracles into a definitive literary collection became the basis for an understanding of world events and a curriculum for understanding the nature of the cosmos far beyond the boundaries of the small West Semitic territory whence Israel came.

CONTESTED ISSUES

Several consistent problems, debates, and conundrums have characterized research into the history, composition, redaction, and reception of the book of Jeremiah over the last two centuries of critical scholarship, and characterize discussion about the book even in earlier periods. Questions abound regarding the extent of the prophet's hand in the shaping of the book bearing his name, the sociological presuppositions standing behind the book's rhetorical choices, the question of gendered language and its political/theological manipulation within the book's oracles, the manifold dimensions of Israelite religion and mythology presupposed at various points in the book—the list could go on. We will limit our attention to four matters that are perhaps the most hotly contested:

1. The Jeremiah corpus as a source for historical reconstruction;
2. The relationship between the Jeremiah corpus and the Deuteronomistic tradition;
3. The poetry versus the prose oracles;
4. The text-critical study of the Jeremiah corpora.

This is of course a very limited set of topics, but each intersects with many of those noted earlier, and each has held a place at the forefront of research into the book and its formation.

History, Memory, and the Prophet Jeremiah

For much of the twentieth century, scholarship was divided on how the book of Jeremiah could be used to reconstruct dimensions of the titular prophet's life and the historical setting in which the contents of the book appear to take place. Many scholars viewed the dates, events, arguments, and institutions reported in the book as transparent barometers of Israelite religion and life in late monarchic Judah and the outset of the Babylonian Exile. It is still common for commentators to draw direct conclusions about this period from the book's contents in this regard. On the opposite end of the spectrum are those scholars who have looked to the Jeremiah tradition as possessing a fair degree of artifice, assigning its contents to a period far removed from the events they profess to relate and

thus too temporally distant to preserve any historically reliable information. For these scholars, the individuals and institutions are projections of only an imagined past.

A different approach has been supported through new archaeological evidence and advances in the study of cultural memory in ancient literature. As regards the former, excavations over the last two decades have provided a clearer picture of the sequence of events in the closing years of the Judahite monarchy, many of which correspond very well to the information preserved in the book of Jeremiah. Moreover, many bullae/seals have been recovered that contain the actual names of individuals mentioned prominently in the book, corroborating much of the book's basis in genuine historical circumstances. As regards the latter, it is clear that these historical circumstances have been preserved and transmitted by communities that emphasized certain events and figures as more important than others, retrofitting earlier details to conform to living theologies and social constructs and thus moving away from a purely uninflected account of the past. While *how* something is remembered may intervene between historical actuality and constructed meaning, *what* is remembered emanates from important and broadly recognized events. It is a real, experienced past that is made meaningful to the present of a given tradent or audience; textual details cannot be taken at face value, but should not be rejected as entirely dislodged from historical moorings.

Applying this understanding to the book of Jeremiah, there is much that can be said, at least in broad strokes, about the historicity of the figures and events depicted therein, particularly the prophet Jeremiah himself. The confluence of discourses in the book point to him as a Levite of northern-Ephraimite heritage (Jer 1:1; 11:21–23; 32:6–15), evident especially from the consistent attitudes in his oracles that would emerge from such a background (criticism of the monarchy, the emphasis on YHWH's Torah, the motif of the Exodus, and the repeated references to northern geonyms and events). The characterization of Jeremiah as immersed in a scribal/textual culture is also supported by his connection to a northern Levite heritage. Evidence from the biblical record reveals that Levites are repeatedly presupposed to be literate figures, and indeed literacy is a hallmark of sacerdotal authority throughout the ancient Near East. Texts in antiquity were objects of numinous power and ritual function, both of which would have fallen within the province of Levitical tradition. This by no means constitutes proof that Jeremiah wrote all of his oracles, but it is at least suggestive of his literary facility and explains why he is remembered as having written his oracles. Finally, the linguistic profile of Jeremiah's oracles evidences a northern dialect, despite the fact that the prophet was active in Judah a century after the fall of the north.

Thus it is problematic and precipitous to adopt the perspective that virtually nothing in the book tells us about the historical Jeremiah or the era in which he lived. At the same time, this figure and that era have been subjected to the perceptions of later scribes and audiences. Most scholars recognize that even if the book of Jeremiah is "set" in the late monarchic and early exilic periods, its primary shape reflects the experience of communities living in exile and, later, returning from exile to a difficult life in Persian Yehud (538–332 B.C.E.). The late monarchic period and Babylonian conquest took on vastly different meaning to Jewish groups living in Mesopotamia and those who remained in the

ancestral homeland toward the end of the exilic era, and the prophet's oracles would thus be remembered, transmitted, and interpreted differently as well.

Traces of these cultural claims over the memory of Jeremiah's oracles are preserved in the corpus itself. One can imagine, for example, that a homeland community would interpret the oracle in Jeremiah 7:3–7 regarding ongoing life in "this place" not simply as the Jerusalem temple but as the entire ancestral homeland, and this concept has been grafted into the extant conclusion of that verse; some scribe or tradent with homeland affinities or sensitivities added a closing note to Jeremiah 7:7 specifying that the "place" in question was indeed "the land that I [YHWH] gave to your fathers forever." At the same time, it is clear that the exilic communities regarded their existence in Mesopotamia as sanctified by the prophet's words to them in Jeremiah 29:5–7, so much so that the text preserving Seraiah's colophon in Jeremiah 51:59–64a took on a ritual dimension in their own evolving geo-mythology. The colophon and the text to which it was affixed have been shaped to emulate a foundation deposit ceremony typical of Mesopotamian traditions, turning the Euphrates into a sacred boundary marker and thus claiming the adjacent territory for YHWH and his people.² That these oracles began with Jeremiah in some form does not offset the fact that they were remembered, shaped, and made meaningful according to the needs of those who preserved them.

Jeremiah and the Deuteronomistic Movement

The memory of Jeremiah's northern-Levitical heritage leads to another important aspect of the presentation of the prophet, namely, his connection to Deuteronomistic thought, that is, the ideas enshrined in the book of Deuteronomy and the work commonly known as the Deuteronomistic History (the books of Joshua–2 Kings). Scholarship into the origins of the Deuteronomistic scribal circle and the composition of Deuteronomy has generally recognized that this scribal group first emerged in late monarchic Judah sometime during the reign of Josiah (627–609 B.C.E.), and engaged Levitical ideologies in constructing its works; the Deuteronomists were probably composed largely of northern Levites living in Judah, who had obtained some measure of social and political influence by the late seventh century B.C.E. Their literature was conceived in part to mediate between royal and rural interests, which is consistent with the intermediary role Levites traditionally played in Israelite society, but also to present a theoretical system affirming a very old agrarian social ethic recalling a time before kingship had emerged in Israel. The language used to convey this ideology, however, was highly learned, sophisticated, and influenced by the Akkadian traditions that permeated Israelite society during its time under the auspices of the Assyrian empire (ca. 734–627 B.C.E.).

While Jeremiah's oracles appear to have been substantially redacted by later Deuteronomistic scribes, there is good reason to accept that the prophet was himself at least somewhat familiar with Deuteronomistic thought in its early instantiations. Scholars continue to debate whether Jeremiah should be counted among the ranks of the Deuteronomists or if his (apparent) engagement of their discourse tradition

evidences a counterpoint. But the issue should not be cast in black and white terms. Because Deuteronomy and the Deuteronomistic History mediate between traditions, it seems more likely that Deuteronomism contained space for variation and adjustment in the pursuit of maintaining that goal. The prophet's ostensible disagreement with specific passages in Deuteronomy or the Deuteronomistic History does not necessarily constitute a rejection of the entire thought enterprise. Moreover, the biographical information tying Jeremiah to elite, learned circles in Jerusalem on one hand and Levitical tradition on the other situates him in conceptual, historical, and social proximity to the Deuteronomists themselves who possessed the same characteristics. If later Deuteronomistic scribes set about reshaping and transmitting his oracles and teachings, their agenda was informed by the memory of Jeremiah's connection to their own forebears.

All of this bears upon the question of Deuteronomistic redaction within the book. The classical source-critical theories of the early twentieth century promoted the view that the poetry represented the prophet's authentic oracles, the narrative material was Deuteronomistic historiography, and the prose sermons were either Deuteronomistic summaries of the prophet's teachings or Deuteronomistic exegeses of earlier oracular material in the book. This model for understanding the development of the book's contents is still accepted by many scholars, who quite reasonably see the poetic material as standing in the tradition of Israel's earlier prophetic literature of the eighth–seventh centuries B.C.E. This may well be the case; the poetic oracles very often engage a trove of expressions and concepts found in those earlier works and periodically develop or extend them. But if Jeremiah was enculturated in Deuteronomistic thought (as discussed earlier), then it remains entirely possible that at least some of the prose oracles derive substantially from him or clearly reflect his teaching activity, even during the years preceding the Babylonian Exile.

Finally, the matter of the relationship between the Deuteronomistic historiography in the book of Kings and in that of Jeremiah remains contested. That the narratives in Jeremiah are Deuteronomistic in style and ethos is widely accepted, but the direction of dependence (if such a direction can actually be determined) is not. Many scholars see the Jeremiah historiography as dependent upon a largely completed book of Kings, and thus date the composition of units such as Jeremiah 37–44 to the late exilic or early post-exilic periods. Others see different camps of Deuteronomists working on different corpora, one working on the Jeremiah corpus while another generated the book of Kings. Differences in detail and perspective would thereby result from the different allegiances and theological interests of these related but distinct groups, with stylistic and linguistic similarities resulting from both working at roughly the same point in time and the same general location (Babylon or exilic-era Judah).

A mediating position is one that accepts a late monarchic version of Kings that narrates events down to Josiah's reign or slightly thereafter and therefore makes no mention of Jeremiah's activity. The historiographic material within the book of Jeremiah was then composed to address events subsequent to what was included in the late monarchic version of Kings, and the historiography regarding the prophet and his times

likely went through a few stages of development in the first half of the Babylonian Exile. The subsequent development of the book of Kings thus continues its own narrative but would have also been composed with an eye to the Jeremiah historiography, and various flourishes from the post-monarchic scribes who expanded Kings demonstrate such an awareness and influence (see, e.g., the impact of Jer 15:4 on the discourses in 2 Kgs 21:12–15; 23:26–27).

The merit of this proposal is that it accounts for what we now know about the scribal process in antiquity, especially in the late seventh–sixth centuries B.C.E. At this time, scribes transmitted documents both from textual copies and from memory, and the memorization of one document invariably had an effect on the transmission of another. A fluid and dynamic oral-textual curriculum governed scribal processes as much as theological agenda and deliberate literary design; the Deuteronomistic scribes who developed the Jeremiah historiography knew the oral traditions connected to the prophet as much as the textual traditions in the monarchic edition of the book of Kings, resulting in narratives that possessed unique features not found in the latter. By the same token, the Deuteronomistic scribes who added to the post-monarchic edition of Kings would have been equally versed in these traditions, as well as the more recently composed historiography associated with Jeremiah. The unique features of the Deuteronomistic language that some scholars identify in Jeremiah may be the result of earlier lexical factors that were filtered through the intellectual sieve of scribes enculturated in the Deuteronomistic tradition. In any case, it is problematic to relegate the Deuteronomistic character of the Jeremiah narratives to a category distinct from what we encounter in Kings and the Deuteronomistic History in general—the relationship is far more symbiotic.

Poetry and Prose in Jeremiah's Oracles

The variation of poetic and prose forms in Jeremiah's oracles is closely related to the question of the Deuteronomistic valences in the book. Critical scholarship on the book in the first half of the twentieth century identified the poetry as an independent source reflecting the prophet's own words, while the prose oracles derived from a different source. Scholars disagreed, though, on how to further qualify these formal categories. For example, Jeremiah 30–31 are largely poetic, but were periodically set aside from the other poetic oracles in the book and placed in their own source-critical category. More complicated still was the view regarding the provenance and purpose of the prose oracles, as scholars disagreed on whether or not these prose oracles reflect any of the prophet's teachings even if they derive from a secondary scribal hand, and one probably associated with the Deuteronomistic scribal tradition. Two basic positions still characterize much scholarly presupposition. In one direction are scholars who argue that the prose oracles were cultivated among scribal groups preserving the prophet's basic teachings and are not far (in spirit) from his original words. In the other direction are scholars who see the oracles as entirely secondary to Jeremiah's prophetic ministry or the circles

associated with it, viewing these oracles as an attempt to redact the poetic oracles into a Deuteronomistic ideological matrix.

Several scholars have challenged these positions for different reasons. First, a strict division between the poetry and prose in terms of compositional origins assumes that an author was not able to use both forms of expression, which is obviously problematic. Prose interruptions of the poetry may well point to the redaction of different sources, but this does not mean that the prose unit in question came from a separate author. Rather, it may be that oracles deriving from the prophet in both poetry and prose were preserved and later arranged according to a specific rhetorical design or intention. Supporting this also is the fact that much of the poetry in the book of Jeremiah uses Deuteronomistic terms and develops Deuteronomistic themes (e.g., Jer 3:1; cf. Deut 24:1–4). This has led some scholars simply to conclude that the poetic and prose oracles equally derive from Jeremiah himself, who lived at a time when prophetic poetry and legal/parenetic prose had become part of Israel's culture of letters in which he—as a Levite with close ties to the scribal groups of Jerusalem—certainly took part.

As noted earlier, research into scribal methods and culture over the last two decades, however, has presented some difficulties for theories ascribing most of the oracular material to Jeremiah personally. Comparative analysis of scribal groups across the ancient world (inclusive of Israel) reveals that scribes internalized a tremendous amount of curricular material, and terms/style from one curricular source could affect the reproduction of another. While this may still be applied to Jeremiah himself (i.e., a prophet who knew the Deuteronomistic prose idiom would be able to voice his own oracles in that idiom), it also opens the door to the possibility—and for many researchers, the likelihood—that a more complicated network of authors and redactors is responsible for the various oracles in poetic and prose form. The poetry in Jeremiah containing Deuteronomistic language could have derived from a later scribe who memorized the poetic oracles that derived from Jeremiah (or which were believed to have derived from him) but reproduced them under the influence of the Deuteronomistic curriculum he also memorized. Conversely, doctrines that did originate with Jeremiah could have been reproduced in the Deuteronomistic prose idiom as well; in this case, the prose oracles would be a combination of Jeremiah's genuine teachings and a later scribe's intellectual and stylistic predilections and impulses.

The issue, in short, cannot be conclusively resolved. The poetry may be the result of scribal shaping, and the ideas encoded into the prose may have originated with Jeremiah's prophetic teachings. But given what is known of scribal methods and text production alongside the evidence for historically authentic features of the prophet's characterization in the book, it seems reasonable to see some poetic and prose discourses beginning in the prophet's own day (with him and scribal figures like Baruch associated with him), with different forms deployed to address different audiences or to be performed or studied in different contexts. Later scribes could certainly continue to develop these works in both prose and poetic forms, sometimes for specific purposes such as to address exilic audiences or to account for later developments in the early Persian period. The book of Jeremiah became a long-duration sacred text transmitted by many

generations of scribes; even though many discourses may be assigned to the late monarchic and exilic periods (and to Deuteronomistic circles), later scribes must have added to it accordingly, following its extant rhetorical modalities.

Text Criticism and the Book of Jeremiah

The Dead Sea Scrolls, discovered and first examined in the mid-twentieth century, revealed four distinct versions of the book of Jeremiah, which points to a variety of Jeremiah corpora circulating in antiquity. But even in light of the Qumran manuscript evidence, text-critical scholars still focus on the relationship between the MT/LXX versions of the book. Over against the fragmentary nature of the Qumran manuscripts, the MT and LXX are complete works and derive from antiquity, making them central to the matter of the textual growth of Jeremiah's oracles and the Jeremiah historiography, and both obtained canonical status for large communities in a way that the Qumran material did not (or at least in a way that the extant Qumran material does not demonstrate). The central text-critical questions for much of the last several decades have asked which version represents an older (and thus "better") collection, and where the histories of these versions should be traced.

These related questions are problematic because they presume that one collection in a mature form predates the other. This presumption fueled many studies throughout the twentieth century, with the majority of text critics pointing to features in the LXX, such as its relative brevity and the position of the OAN in the second structural block, as evidence that it was the earlier/better collection, with the MT expanding and rearranging a previously authoritative corpus. Any comparison of parallel materials shared by the MT and LXX reveals that most of the time, the LXX preserves an older version; the MT is clearly expansionistic in nature, which matches the scribal predilection for expansion in the transmission of texts over time. This does not, however, mean that an entire canonical corpus predates another canonical corpus in a linear manner; for instance, the somewhat later material in MT Jeremiah 25 does not mean that its authors drew from a version of that chapter as it appeared in an ossified LXX corpus. The matter is more complicated and is connected to the history of the communities that preserved and developed each version, the politics of the sixth–fourth centuries B.C.E., and the scribal culture of the ancient world.

The fragmentation of the Judahite communities following the fall of Jerusalem in 587 B.C.E. meant that a common Jeremiah tradition—probably a version of Jeremiah 1–25 + OAN—was inherited by different groups. The scribal anthology (MT Jeremiah 26–45 // LXX Jeremiah 33–51) was probably first introduced into this collection by Judahite scribes in Babylon who sought to legitimize themselves in the eyes of those who were exiled a decade earlier with Jehoiachin, and was inserted between Jeremiah 1–25 and the OAN for hermeneutical purposes (subsuming the anthology within the authoritative "words of Jeremiah" spanning Jer 1:1 and 51:64b). This newer, larger corpus subsequently underwent scribal expansion over time, leading to what would become the MT and building upon the older, common material that survived in the LXX of Jeremiah 1–25 +

OAN. But this also means that the community which preserved the older material preserved in the LXX (identified by many scholars as the Jewish community that took root in Egypt during the sixth century B.C.E.) did not possess a mature “book of Jeremiah” that included the scribal anthology created in Babylon. It would only be during the Persian period that this other community would eventually have gained access to the scribal anthology through the place of the proto-MT version of the book in the official library and liturgy of the Jerusalem temple.³

The development of the MT sequence/structure (though not the specific content of what is currently found within each structural unit) very likely predates the development of the LXX sequence, even if the individual textual units in Jeremiah 1–25 + OAN in the LXX more closely resemble the earlier common tradition deriving from 587 B.C.E. The appending of the scribal anthology to this material and its place in the final structural position in the LXX sequence demonstrates not only the commitment of the community to the integrity of the material they had long possessed, but also their deference to the “official” version of the Jeremiah tradition in Jerusalem. Indeed, the fact that many of the parallels shared between the MT and LXX versions of the scribal anthology block show shorter versions in the LXX may suggest the conservative predilections of the community that maintained the LXX version and the ongoing expansionistic ethos of the trustees of the MT version in Jerusalem. In passages such as MT Jeremiah 33:14–26, which probably entered the MT in the late sixth century B.C.E., this is clearly the case. Alternatively, however, some of the plusses in the MT that do not appear in the LXX may point to inadvertent (or even deliberate) deletions in the copying of LXX-type manuscripts containing this material.

A confluence of factors account for the differences between the MT and the LXX, but it seems clear from the foregoing that it is precipitous to conclude that the LXX was earlier, let alone a better witness to the formative stages of the book’s structural blocks, than the MT. If this is borne in mind, it becomes clear that text-critical considerations should not be utilized to draw generalized conclusions about which textual corpora should be mined for more “authentic” indications of social and historical conditions in antiquity. Considering scribal convention in antiquity, it is inevitably the case that extant oral-textual curricula beyond the book of Jeremiah must have affected how these different textual versions grew over time. Perhaps that makes all the more remarkable what these textual versions retain in common with each other. Beyond the common textual material, both versions attest to the degree to which their scribal shapers and their intended audiences regarded these works both as relics of a distant past and as forums for contemporizing their particular relationship to it.

NOTES

1. This was probably worked into the chapter’s superscription to align its contents, and indeed the contents of Jeremiah 1–25 in general, with the report in Jeremiah 36:1–8 of the creation of an early written collection of the prophet’s oracles in the same year.

2. For more on this textual episode as reflecting a Mesopotamian foundation deposit ceremony, see my essay, "Sacred Space and Communal Legitimacy in Exile: The Contribution of Seraiah's Colophon (Jer 51:59–64a)," in *The Prophets Speak on Forced Migration* (ed. Mark J. Boda, Frank Ritche Ames, John Ahn, and Mark Leuchter; AIL; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2015), 77–99.
3. The Elephantine "letter to Bagohi" (TAD A4.7–4.8) suggests the deference shown among the Jews of Egypt to the theological authority of the Jerusalem temple and its priesthood; scribal interchange between these communities would have provided opportunities throughout the late sixth–fifth centuries B.C.E. for the scribal anthology preserved in Jerusalem to reach the communities that introduced it into the proto-LXX tradition.

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CHAPTER 11

EZEKIEL

Structure, Themes, and Contested Issues

ANDREW MEIN

THE book of Ezekiel is undoubtedly a challenging read, “full of majesty, obscurity, and difficulty,” as one seventeenth-century commentator put it.¹ It plunges the reader into a world of extraordinary visions, bizarre symbolic actions, and grotesque metaphors. It contains vivid images and prosaic legal arguments, ferocious condemnations and extravagant promises. Ezekiel has always provoked strong reactions, and, as early as the rabbinic period, commentators agreed that it is among the most difficult of biblical books to comprehend.

The book’s setting is the tumultuous period of the early sixth century B.C.E. This was a time of extreme crisis, as successive Babylonian invasions devastated Judah and Jerusalem, leaving city and Temple in ruins, the Davidic monarchy at an end, and many people exiled to distant Mesopotamia. The book presents the prophet Ezekiel as one of the first wave of exiles, a member of a priestly family, whom Nebuchadnezzar deported along with Jehoiachin in 597 B.C.E. Ezekiel’s prophecies act as a kind of commentary on unfolding events, reminding his hearers of YHWH’s continuing power, explaining the disaster as the result of Judah’s sin, and, once the worst has come, imagining the shape of a new future.

THE SHAPE OF EZEKIEL

Ezekiel is unusual among prophetic books for the relative clarity of its basic structure, and commentators typically divide it into three main sections:

- 1–24: Judgment on Jerusalem;
- 25–32: Oracles concerning the nations;
- 33–48: The restoration of Israel.

This threefold framework conforms to the rabbinic view that Ezekiel “begins with destruction but ends up with consolation” (Baba Bathra 1.6), and corresponds broadly to the book’s contents, but is rather a blunt instrument to understand its structure. It may therefore be helpful to outline Ezekiel’s contents in a little more detail.

Chapters 1–3 describe Ezekiel’s vision of YHWH’s glory by the river Chebar, and move on to the prophet’s commissioning. Chapters 4–7 press home a message of judgment through sign actions and oracles. Chapters 8–11 take Ezekiel on a visionary tour of the defiled Temple, where he sees YHWH’s glory withdraw by stages from the sanctuary and abandon the city to destruction. Chapters 12–24 largely continue the message of judgment, painting a vivid picture of Jerusalem’s past and present sins and her impending punishment. The focus shifts in chapters 25–32 to condemn the surrounding nations, especially Tyre (26–28) and Egypt (29–32). Chapter 33 recapitulates some of the earlier themes of judgment, and leads into a series of oracles in 34–37 that promise Israel’s restoration to the land to live in obedience and prosperity. In chapters 38–39 YHWH raises up one last threat to restored Israel, the monstrous Gog, and defeats him in a final battle. Finally, in 40–48 Ezekiel makes another visionary journey to the land, where he is shown the detailed plan of a new Temple, and sees the divine glory return to its rightful place in the sanctuary.

This narrative outline is inevitably an oversimplification, not least because a few hopeful threads are woven in among the generally doom-laden prophecies of 1–24, and notes of judgment remain even in 33–48. Nevertheless, it does suggest that the present shape of the book is the result of purposeful arrangement, and this impression is confirmed by a number of other structural features of the book.

The most explicit of these is a series of fourteen dates, which count from Jehoiachin’s exile in 597 B.C.E. These introduce the prophet’s oracles and visions, beginning with the opening vision “in the fifth year” (Ezek 1:2) and running in more or less chronological order to the vision of the new Temple in the “twenty-fifth year” (Ezek 40:1). As well as moving the narrative on, they locate the prophet in the period of the early exile, suggesting a ministry that lasted from 593 to 573. They also relate closely to the experience of the Jehoiachin exiles and the ultimate fall of Jerusalem. Particularly striking are the notes in 24:1–2 of the beginning of the siege of Jerusalem and in 33:21 that on this day Ezekiel learned of the city’s fall. As well as dates and other introductory formulae, the book is bound together by significant patterns of repetition and recapitulation, such as the sentinel passages (Ezek 3:16–21; 33:10–20), which serve as “bookends” for the initial stage of Ezekiel’s ministry (Joyce 2007: 42). And absolutely fundamental to the forward momentum of the book are the three major visions of YHWH’s glory: first by the river Chebar (1–3), later departing from the defiled Temple (8–11), and finally returning to the new Temple (40–48).

Whatever precise divisions scholars propose, it is clear that the book of Ezekiel has a narrative shape that holds its contents together, and points squarely at the crisis of exile. Whether this structure is the work of the original prophet or of later editors remains a source of considerable debate.

QUESTIONS OF COMPOSITION

Ezekiel's strong structural and stylistic unity left the traditional view of its composition unchallenged rather longer than with the other major prophets. S. R. Driver wrote in 1891 that "[n]o critical question arises in connexion with the authorship of the book, the whole from beginning to end bearing unmistakably the stamp of a single mind" (Driver 1891: 261). But even this most homogeneous of prophetic books contains significant unevennesses, and as early as 1900 Richard Kraetschmar had noted the prevalence of duplicate passages, concluding that a later editor had assembled two different recensions of the prophet's words.² By 1924 Gustav Hölscher had gone much further, arguing that the original poetry of the exilic prophet had been obscured by the priestly prose of a fifth-century Zadokite editor. Since the book is very substantially prose, this left an original stratum of fewer than 150 verses.³

In the 1930s scholars noted the contradiction between the book's exilic setting and its intense focus on Jerusalem, and proposed that Ezekiel's ministry took place there rather than in Babylonia,⁴ or as well as in Babylonia.⁵ Perhaps the most radical solution was Torrey's suggestion that Ezekiel was a late pseudepigraphal work written in the Jerusalem of the third century B.C.E. to evoke the Jerusalem of Manasseh (cf. 2 Kings 21).⁶ These and other theories left a strong mark on Ezekiel scholarship for many years: Arguments about the location of the prophet raged, and redactional theories developed further, showing a particular reluctance to attribute salvation oracles to the exilic prophet (and especially all or part of 38–39 and 40–48).⁷

Some consensus emerged in the 1950s and 1960s under the influence of Georg Fohrer and Walther Zimmerli, who drew back from the most radical solutions to Ezekiel's composition, and argued that a substantial core of the book goes back to Ezekiel in exile (Zimmerli 1979, 1983).⁸ Zimmerli, in his massive commentary and numerous studies, traced the majority of the book to the sixth-century prophet, but also allowed for a considerable degree of secondary elaboration at the hands of an "Ezekiel school," which transmitted the text and expanded it in a style very similar to that of the original. A more thoroughgoing approach to the stratification of the entire book has become typical of German-speaking scholarship, as seen in the work of Karl-Friedrich Pohlmann (1996, 2001, 2008), who finds the approach of Zimmerli and his followers far too conservative. Pohlmann himself proposes a small original collection, which was overworked by two successive redactions during the Persian period. He distinguishes an earlier *golaorientierte Redaktion*, which emphasizes the special status of the 597 deportees, and a later *diasporaorientierte Redaktion*, which has a broader conception of Israel. Although the book may have a small exilic core, it really reflects the debates and concerns of a much later period.

The oldest surviving Greek manuscript of Ezekiel, Papyrus 967 (late second/early third century C.E.) also raises an interesting challenge. It contains several significant omissions from MT, most notably 36:23c–38 (including the "new heart" material). Moreover, its salvation oracles have a different order: 36:1–23b is followed by MT 38–39,

then 37 leads into the Temple vision of 40–48. While commentators have often dismissed these differences as due to scribal error and a later reordering of the Greek text (cf. Joyce 2007: 47–48), more recent voices assert that p967 represents a genuinely early textual tradition, and that the present arrangement of 33–48 is the result of a rather late editorial process. However hard it is to determine when the component sections were originally produced, at the very least it appears that two variant editions of Ezekiel were in circulation in the late Second Temple period.⁹

The most prominent defender of Ezekiel's unity and early date has been Moshe Greenberg, who finds none of the criteria for determining redactional layers acceptable on literary grounds. Rather, he argues that through a process of "holistic interpretation," we can understand the entire book as the work of the early sixth century, and receive the "impression of an individual mind of powerful and passionate proclivities," who has imposed a coherent shape on the entire book (1983: 26–27). Yet Greenberg almost certainly goes too far in denying any substantial redactional activity in the book. The question is made more complex because of the homogeneity of the Ezekiel tradition. Paul Joyce points out that the book is "particularly resistant to any straightforward division into primary and secondary material," since by contrast with other prophetic books, "secondary material bears an unusually close 'family resemblance' to primary" (2007: 12). Ezekiel's oracles have undoubtedly undergone some process of redaction, but it is possible, and even likely, that the process began with the prophet himself.

The majority of English-speaking Ezekiel scholarship currently works somewhere on a spectrum between Zimmerli's cautious redaction criticism and Greenberg's holistic approach, recognizing that although much of its contents may go back to the heat of the crisis, the book as a whole must belong to a slightly later period. The latest oracle is dated to 570 B.C.E., and it is likely that any "first edition" of the whole was produced sometime after that, but probably before the exiles returned to Jerusalem and the rebuilding of the Temple in 515, not least because the book makes no explicit reference to Persian-period conditions.¹⁰ We are, I believe, justified in reading the book of Ezekiel as largely the work of the prophet himself and of his exilic editors, who share a social context not radically dissimilar to Ezekiel's. Even if parts of it were reworked in Jerusalem after the return, the book contains a genuine contemporary attempt to make sense of the events of the early sixth century, and reflects the perspective and interests of Judean exiles in Babylon.

THE CHALLENGE OF EXILE

Nebuchadnezzar's first siege of Jerusalem in 598–597 B.C.E. ended with the surrender of the young King Jehoiachin (2 Kgs 24:12). Kings goes on to report the exile of the king and his family, along with his officials of state, "men of valor," artisans, and smiths (24:12, 14), that is to say, a good proportion of the upper strata of Jerusalem society. This proved only the beginning of the crisis for Judah, as Zedekiah, the "king of his own choice" with whom Nebuchadnezzar replaced Jehoiachin, soon rebelled against his overlord

(588–587). The Babylonian response was more severe: city and Temple were sacked and yet more people deported (2 Kgs 25:8–21). Judah was taken under direct Babylonian control and ceased to exist as an independent political entity.

While Jehoiachin and his immediate circle were kept in Babylon, the majority of Judean deportees were most likely settled in agricultural communities to work on the land and the canals of rural Mesopotamia: Ezekiel's "Tel Abib" (3:15) is probably one of these.¹¹ It was clearly possible for these exiles to continue some sort of communal life, but we must not ignore the degree to which their whole world had been turned upside down. Ezekiel's community will have suffered the shame and trauma of military defeat and the rigors of a long forced march. They will have been faced with unfamiliar work in a new and strange environment, and a profound sense of loss and dislocation. It is little surprise that Ezekiel quotes them as saying, "Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost; we are cut off completely" (37:11).¹²

Ezekiel often puts words into the mouths of his opponents that reflect the deep anxieties the crisis provoked. The elders of Israel in the Temple complain that "the LORD has forsaken his land, the LORD does not see" (Ezek 8:12), while the inhabitants of Jerusalem claim that the exiles "have gone far from the LORD" (11:15). In addition to the cry of despair in 37:11, Ezekiel faces challenges that prophecy is not to be trusted (12:22, 26), that people are suffering for their parents' sins (18:2), and that "the way of the LORD is unfair" (18:25). The events of the 590s and 580s clearly provoked deep theological questions about the responsibility for the disaster, the power and justice of YHWH, and the value of holding on to Judean identity and traditions away from the land and its institutions. In the aftermath of such unparalleled disaster, the questions Ezekiel addressed were no mere intellectual exercise, but were crucial to the exiles' sense of identity both as individuals and a community.

EZEKIEL AS PROPHET AND PRIEST

The book's opening vision is the Hebrew Bible's most detailed and yet obscure depiction of the God of Israel. It draws on both Temple themes and wider ancient Near Eastern iconography to create an image of unparalleled divine power and mystery. Ezekiel sees a figure enthroned above strange living creatures and accompanied by storm and fire; he identifies this figure with both precision and reticence as "the appearance of the likeness of the glory of YHWH" (1:28). As does Isaiah 6, Ezekiel 1–3 moves from a vision of the enthroned YHWH into a commissioning to speak on YHWH's behalf, and helps establish Ezekiel's credentials as a prophet among the exiles. If Jeremiah is told, "I will put my words in your mouth" (1:9), Ezekiel goes one better, being given the divine word as a scroll to eat, written on both sides with "lamentation and mourning and woe" (Ezek 2:10). Like Jeremiah, Ezekiel too learns that he will meet resistance in his prophetic task (Ezek 2:1–7; 3:4–11; cf. Jer 2:19); his role is to be a sentinel (Ezek 3:16–21; cf. 33:10–20; Jer 6:17), who will warn the community of the impending danger their rebellion has brought about.

Ezekiel is in some respects a textbook prophet, employing the full repertoire of prophetic forms. His symbolic actions portray the imminent siege of Jerusalem and its dire outcome. His oracles proclaim the word of YHWH, adopting and adapting a dazzling range of literary models. His words will be a reliable guide to the future, a point made with some force in 12:21–28 (cf. Deut 18:15–22). He has something of the ecstatic visionary about him, gripped by “the hand of the LORD” and lifted up by the spirit. Yet the reader is also immediately struck by how very wordy the book is, how excessive its use of language. It has often been suggested that Ezekiel is the first truly literary prophet, the book more written than oral in its composition. One effect of this is that we encounter Ezekiel primarily as a character in a narrative, who performs the prophetic role given him by YHWH: as Ellen Davis puts it, “the prophet who swallowed the scroll becomes (to our eyes at least) virtually indistinguishable from what he ate.”¹³

Even for a prophet, Ezekiel’s persona is awkward and unsympathetic. His behavior and voice are wholly subordinated to YHWH’s word, and are characterized by physical afflictions, bizarre actions, and violent rhetoric. Perhaps most poignant is Ezekiel’s refusal or inability to mourn the death of his own wife (Ezek 24:15–27), who becomes merely a sign of Jerusalem’s justified punishment. Unsurprisingly, modern commentators have questioned the prophet’s mental health and have offered a variety of psychiatric diagnoses.¹⁴ These are, of course, extremely difficult to substantiate, given our vast temporal and cultural distance from the prophet and the literary nature of Ezekiel’s portrait. Smith-Christopher nevertheless makes an intriguing proposal when he notes parallels between Ezekiel’s sign actions and the symptoms of post-traumatic stress disorder, a syndrome common among modern refugees across a range of cultures.¹⁵ Whether the prophet himself was a sufferer is probably beside the point: Ezekiel’s bizarre behavior becomes a literary representation of the exiles’ own psychological dislocation, modeling the devastating trauma that they have experienced. As a prophet to the exiles, then, Ezekiel offers an authoritative voice, able to explain events from the divine perspective, but one that is shaped by and responds to the circumstances in which they find themselves.

If Ezekiel is unquestionably a prophet, it is impossible to understand or appreciate this prophetic book without taking serious account of its relationship with priestly tradition. Ezekiel is immediately identified as a priest (Ezek 1:3), and one of the most plausible explanations of the mysterious “thirtieth year” (1:1) is that it is Ezekiel’s age, an age at which he might have expected to begin his priestly service. The key term of Ezekiel’s visions of YHWH, כבוד (“glory”), is drawn from priestly theology, where it is a technical term for the presence of God (e.g., Ex 24:16–17, Lev 9:23; Num 16:19; 1 Kgs 8:11).¹⁶ The living creatures of the opening vision (Ezek 1:5–13), upon which the כבוד rests, are later identified as the cherubim, which formed YHWH’s throne in the Temple (Ezek 10:20; cf. 1 Kgs 6:23–28). The defilement of that Temple is the primary reason that the glory of YHWH abandons his dwelling place to destruction, and Sweeney suggests that “insofar as even the Temple has become a place of profanation in Ezekiel’s understanding, so the Temple and Jerusalem themselves must be purged in order to bring about their

purification and restoration.”¹⁷ The account of YHWH’s return to the Temple is followed not only by detailed regulations for the performance of sacrifices and festivals (e.g., Ezek 43:18–27; 45:13–25), but also by a reordering of priestly hierarchies that gives only the Zadokites privileged access to the sanctuary and the responsibility of sacrifice (Ezek 40:46; 42:19; 44:15–16).

Priestly theology provides Ezekiel’s primary conceptual framework, and Ezekiel’s moral language is deeply dependent on this tradition. The form of his arguments often resembles that of priestly case law (Ezek 14:1–11, 12–20; 18:1–32; cf. Leviticus 17, 19), and the prophet shares a great deal of language in common with pentateuchal priestly texts, especially the Holiness Code (Leviticus 17–26).¹⁸ Blood, central to the symbolic world of the priesthood, provides a crucial metaphor for his analysis of guilt and injustice (e.g. Ezek 22:2–4; 24:1–14). He analyzes the entirety of Israel’s behavior through the ritual categories of holy and profane, clean and unclean, as here in the summary of 36:17: “Mortal, when the house of Israel lived on their own soil, they defiled it with their ways and their deeds; their conduct in my sight was like the uncleanness of a woman in her menstrual period.” This “ritualization of ethics” extends the symbolic language of the Temple beyond the strictly priestly sphere. From the perspective of exile, where all Judah’s old certainties are crumbling, Ezekiel succeeds in keeping the Temple as a focal point for communal values and aspirations (Mein 2001: 137–76).

That Ezekiel is both prophet and priest is a commonplace of modern scholarship, but this presents an intriguing paradox, since he has no access to the Jerusalem Temple, where he might actually exercise a priestly ministry. Margaret Odell has argued persuasively that Ezekiel’s opening chapters present a transformation from priest to prophet. She draws detailed parallels with the priestly ordination rites of Leviticus 8–9, which culminate in the priest’s sacrifice to make atonement for the people (Lev 9:1–21). By contrast, Ezekiel’s symbolic acts to “bear the iniquity” of Israel and Judah (Ezek 4:4–8) do not restore the divine relationship with the people but underline Jerusalem’s inevitable punishment. He can no longer fulfill a priest’s primary role, and his eating of impure siege rations (Ezek 4:9–15) and shaving of his head (5:1–5) is even “explicitly anti-priestly behavior.”¹⁹

Odell acknowledges that Ezekiel does not wholly lose his priestly identity, and aspects of the priestly role may yet remain open to him in exile. He is certainly unable to undertake a sacrificial function, but the book does suggest that priests are more than merely ritual performers within the sanctuary. They are also shown as teachers of ritual law, and Ezekiel can still impress upon his hearers “the difference between the holy and the common, and show them how to distinguish between the unclean and the clean” (44:23; cf. 22:26). The priest’s role becomes one of theorist and teacher, adapting and transforming the tradition for changed circumstances.²⁰ Ezekiel uses the language of a *מקדש מעט*, a “sanctuary in small measure” (11:16), to affirm YHWH’s continuing relationship with the exiles. The prophet’s own situation may be analogous: as YHWH’s presence is available in a limited but nevertheless real way, so Ezekiel’s priesthood in exile is no sham, but a genuine form of mediation.

THE SINS OF JERUSALEM

Ezekiel's response to the crisis of exile is uncompromising. The prophet's oracles of judgment lay out a sustained and furious case against Jerusalem and its leaders, shattering any misplaced confidence that the exiles might have in the security of a divinely sponsored dynasty or the inviolability of YHWH's Temple. In broad terms, Ezekiel reiterates the concerns of his prophetic predecessors: cultic apostasy, political faithlessness, and social injustice have brought Jerusalem to unavoidable judgment. Impending defeat and destruction are therefore not the result of YHWH's weakness, but the deity's appropriate response to his people's persistent rebelliousness.

Ezekiel's symbolic actions introduce the coming disaster, but the explanation only begins to take shape in Ezekiel's first programmatic oracle of judgment (Ezek 5:5–17). This oracle condemns Jerusalem for disobedience: "she has rebelled against my statutes and my ordinances, becoming more wicked than the nations and the countries all around her" (5:6). It clarifies the nature of this rebellion as the defilement of idolatry: "because you defiled my sanctuary with all your detestable things and with all your abominations—therefore I will cut you down" (5:11). A lengthy diatribe against the "mountains of Israel and their idols" follows in Ezekiel 6, and idolatry is never far from the prophet's view. Not only a problem of the present generation, it deeply scars Israel's past relationship with YHWH. It is one of the chief sins of the woman Jerusalem (16 and 23), and is central to the lengthy historical retrospect of 20:1–32, where Israel would not forsake the "idols of Egypt" (20:7–8). By contrast with Deuteronomistic tradition, Ezekiel never dignifies these false objects of worship with the name "other gods." His characteristic terms for idols, תועבות ("abominations"), שקצים ("detestable things"), and גלילים (perhaps "dung balls"), are themselves part of the polemic, undermining any claim to power made on behalf of divine images.²¹

The centerpiece of Ezekiel's critique appears in the prophet's visionary journey to Jerusalem, where he is shown a sequence of idolatrous activities within the Temple precincts (Ezek 8:1–18). This grisly tour begins with the "image of jealousy" at the gates of the Temple (8:3, 5), perhaps an image of the goddess Asherah. It moves on to show seventy elders offering incense to images of "creeping things" on the walls of their chambers (8:7–13), and women weeping for Tammuz, the Mesopotamian fertility god (8:14–15). Each scene contains the refrain, "you shall see greater abominations than these," until the climax of sun worship in the Temple itself (8:16). There is a deep irony in the elders' complaint that "the LORD does not see us, the LORD has forsaken the land" (8:12), since YHWH abandons his Temple to its destruction (9:1–11:25) precisely because he sees what is happening there.

The location of all these horrors is important not only because the Temple is YHWH's dwelling place, but also because of the fine line between religion and politics in a society like ancient Judah. Ezekiel's polemic against idols focuses not primarily on the "popular religion" of the Judean peasantry, but the proper maintenance of the state cult. The

Jerusalem Temple is inescapably political, and other political concerns are also high on his agenda. While the traditional prophetic condemnation of injustice is more muted in Ezekiel than some other prophets, it is nevertheless present, and is directed sharply at Jerusalem's leaders (e.g., 11:1–13; 22:23–31; 34:1–6, 17–22). More prominent are the high politics of Judah's international relations. Ezekiel is fundamentally opposed to Zedekiah's government in Jerusalem, and condemns his attempts to assert Judah's independence from Babylon and to engage in alliances with Egypt.²² He singles out the “vile, wicked prince of Israel” for punishment (21:25, cf. 12:8–16), and the allegorical oracle of the eagles and the vine in chapter 17 asserts that YHWH has rejected him because of his rebellion against Babylon. Astonishingly, it even equates the oath of obedience that Nebuchadnezzar forced upon Zedekiah with YHWH's own covenant (17:16). Zedekiah is the primary target of Ezekiel's critique, but the rest of the Jerusalem elite are also implicated in the king's rebellion (Mein 2001: 87–90).

Ezekiel's invective against Jerusalem is most shocking when the prophet uses the metaphor of betrayed husband and faithless wife to reflect on the city's persistent sin and justified punishment. Although the stories of chapters 16 and 23 are not identical, there are many points of contact. Jerusalem is the abandoned child of Canaanite parents, adopted and then married by YHWH (16:1–14); or she is one of two sisters (Oholah and Oholibah—Samaria and Jerusalem), already promiscuous in Egypt before their marriage to YHWH (23:2–3; cf. 20:8). The prophet graphically displays the city's sinfulness as sexual license: the woman's “lovers” are both the idols she has made (16:15–22; 23:36–39) and the foreign nations with which she allies herself (16:26–29; 23:11–21). Explicit images of sexual violence and mutilation represent the trauma of invasion, military defeat, and deportation, as YHWH sends Jerusalem's former lovers to carry out her punishment (16:35–43; 23:23–35, 46–47). There is a hopeful coda to the first version of the story (16:53–63), but no equivalent for Oholibah.

Modern commentators have been disturbed by the extreme violence of these oracles, and by the near-pornographic techniques the prophet uses; the naked and brutalized Jerusalem is “the defiled and defiling other, the constant object of the objectifying gaze” (Galambush 1992: 125). The rhetoric depends on deeply held hierarchical assumptions about relations between the sexes, and works by putting the (presumably male) Jerusalem elite in the position of the debased female figure of the metaphor. The brutal images quite possibly draw upon the humiliating and emasculating trauma of defeat and deportation, which Ezekiel's own community has experienced. This in turn may force the audience of Ezekiel 23 to see that “the theological ‘answer’ to the scandal of defeat comes only through embracing their identification with Oholah and Oholibah, whores and adulterers whose shame is theirs alone.”²³ But it is equally possible that the oracle expects its readers to identify primarily with the male character YHWH, the humiliated husband who must act to restore his lost honor, and thereby to distance themselves from incorrigible Jerusalem and “avoid blame for the nation's fall by concealing themselves behind the bodies of women” (Yee 2003: 134). That both responses to these oracles seem plausible brings us back to the old conundrum of an exilic prophet addressing oracles to Jerusalem. There is an inevitable duality to the experience of exile, and there are, in

effect, two different “moral worlds” that Ezekiel’s community inhabits. The first is the old world of home, with its relative wealth, privilege, and prestige; the second is the new and harsher world of a disempowered minority at the service of the Babylonian state. Both of these worlds will have exerted pressure on the identity of the Judean exiles, who needed to define themselves not only against the threat of assimilation into the local Babylonian culture but also against a potentially paralyzing identification with the community still at home.

Despite their overwhelmingly negative tone, Ezekiel’s oracles of judgment form a crucial part of the prophet’s survival strategy for the community of exiles in Babylon. In particular, they take advantage of the exiles’ natural identification with Jerusalem to explain events in terms that make sense to them. When Ezekiel blames a poisonous cocktail of idolatrous worship in high places and perverse foreign policy for the disasters of the present, he is working within an established framework of moral and political discourse, which would have been familiar to his audience, who were themselves drawn from Judah’s former elite.

It is often argued that the purpose of all the oracles of judgment is to force Ezekiel’s hearers to take responsibility for the disaster that has befallen them, “exposing delusions of innocence and offering a divine understanding of reality” (Block 1997: 14). But the dual world that Ezekiel’s audience in exile inhabits makes this something of an oversimplification. Insofar as they still identify with Jerusalem, they are the targets of Ezekiel’s invective. But if Ezekiel’s audience is in exile, however much they are tempted to identify with the fate of their former home, the sustained nature of the polemic cannot but establish a degree of distance between Jerusalem and exile.

Dalit Rom-Shiloni has developed this idea, arguing that Ezekiel is the primary source of an exclusive exilic ideology, which sees the Jehoiachin exiles as the only true continuation of the pre-exilic community. Ezekiel establishes the distinction through his constant invective against Jerusalem, and especially in two passages that address the question “who inherits?” (11:14–21; 33:23–29). In both cases the inhabitants of Judah attempt to disinherit the exiles by claiming that only those still in the land are the heirs of the divine promise to possess it (11:15; 33:24). Ezekiel’s response is unequivocal. In 33:23–29 he asserts that those who remain are so wicked that YHWH will utterly destroy them, leaving the land “a desolation and a waste.” In 11:14–21 the exiles may be far from the land but retain a relationship with God and will be restored to the land to live in obedience. Through arguments like these, Ezekiel becomes “the voice of extreme exclusivity, the voice that declares the Jehoiachin exiles to be the prestigious, one-and-only legitimate community of Judeans.”²⁴

The exiles may indeed be the community to be restored, but we should not push the distinction too far. The book does not offer an absolutely black and white categorization: “exiles good, Jerusalem bad.” Ezekiel’s view of human nature is too bleak for this, and the prophet severely criticizes the exiles themselves for “taking their idols into their hearts” (14:6). The book is also not as consistent in its use of terminology as we might like: in particular, the term “house of Israel” is a rather slippery one: it often refers to the community surrounding Ezekiel in exile (e.g., 11:14; 14:1–11) or to the community

to be restored (36:22; 37:11), but at other points is directed to the community back in Jerusalem (e.g., 8:6, 10–12, 11:5). Ezekiel's rhetoric works in seemingly contradictory ways, at some points seeking to bring exile and Jerusalem closer together, at other times further apart. But again the dual focus of life in exile may help explain this, if the prophet's aim is both to encourage a sense of continuity with Judean tradition over against the Babylonian environment, and to establish the Judean exiles as a community in distinction from failed Jerusalem.

RESPONSIBILITY, REPENTANCE, AND EZEKIEL'S ETHICS

Ezekiel's own community of exiles does not exist in a moral vacuum: they must also take responsibility for their own actions. Past scholarship saw the prophet as a great ethical innovator, moving beyond more "primitive" notions of corporate responsibility and punishment visible in the Decalogue and the historical books to introduce a new doctrine of "individual responsibility." This view drew largely on Ezekiel 18:1–24, which overturns the exiles' claim that "the fathers have eaten sour grapes and the children's teeth are set on edge" (i.e., their current troubles are not their fault but their parents'). By setting out a test case in which three related individuals, a wicked father, righteous son, and wicked grandson, are judged, each on the basis of his own sins, Ezekiel challenges his hearers to take responsibility for their own situation. Ezekiel's contribution is probably more modest than a wholesale ethical revolution: instead, he takes ideas of individual responsibility that had long prevailed in legal practice (cf. Deut 24:16) and applies them fresh to the matter of divine judgment. Paul Joyce (1989) has argued that the true focus of the chapter is the collective crisis facing Israel and hence not the moral independence of individuals but of *generations*. By contrast with the Deuteronomistic History, which blames the long-dead Manasseh for Judah's downfall (2 Kgs 21:10–15; 23:26–27; 24:3), Ezekiel charges that if this generation is suffering, it must be the result of its own sin.

It is nevertheless hard to deny that there are strong individualistic elements running through Ezekiel: the sentinel material (3:16–21; 33:10–20) implies that individuals who attend to the prophet's message will thrive, and the account of Noah, Daniel, and Job (14:12–20) suggests that under severe judgment three such righteous men would save themselves, even if no others. Even Ezekiel 18 retains a degree of individual emphasis that must be accounted for. Here too the exilic context is important. As members of a dominated minority within the Babylonian empire, the exiles had no more access to the political and religious life of Jerusalem's elite, those areas upon which Ezekiel focuses in his oracles against Jerusalem. Instead, they could really only make moral choices in the more limited sphere of their immediate community. Two key oracles addressed to the exiles, 14:1–11 and 18:1–32, demonstrate this reduction of scope, or "domestication" of

ethics. In both cases the prophet adopts forms of speech that had their origin in priestly case law to the theological and moral issues facing the exiles. This not only preserved the legal traditions, but also the sense of responsibility that the exercise of those traditions allowed. Moreover, in both cases the content of the oracles seems adapted to the conditions of exile. In 14:1–11 the exiles have no temple to defile, and their sin takes place on a different scale: they have “taken their idols into their hearts, and set the stumbling block of their iniquity before their faces.” Equally, the test cases of chapter 18 have a more domestic flavor, dealing not with the grand themes of Jerusalem politics but with sexual ethics and just relationships between neighbors in a small community (Mein 2001: 178–202).

It is also no coincidence that the two most unequivocal calls to repent within the book of Ezekiel occur in 14:1–11 and 18. Repentance is a contested topic in Ezekiel, since the book often appears to equivocate about the possibility or even the value of a response to the prophet’s preaching. On the one hand, there are clear calls to repent (14:6; 18:30; cf. 18:21–32; 33:10–20). On the other, it seems that repentance would have little effect: Jerusalem’s fate is sealed, and in the salvation material YHWH seems determined to restore his people almost regardless of their moral and religious condition. If there is a benefit to the exiles in repentance, it must lie somewhere else.

The call to repent in Ezekiel 18:21–32 has often been seen as the climax to which the chapter is leading, and closely connected with the doctrine of individual repentance. But there is undoubtedly a communal dimension to the passage, which repeatedly addresses the “house of Israel” (cf. Zimmerli 1979: 386). Here too we may find evidence of the moral rescaling that reflects the exiles’ changed circumstances. As with the more limited content of sin and virtue in 14:1–11 and 18, repentance works at the level of day-to-day domestic existence more than that of national institutions. National repentance is not possible, perhaps because the key communal institutions are no longer accessible. But at the more reduced scale of relations between individuals and families, repentance remains an option. Ezekiel is not neutral about the moral behavior open to the exiles: he clearly distinguishes what is acceptable from what is not, and the calls to repent are directed toward the present experience of exile, showing YHWH ’s ongoing concern that his people should act rightly (Mein 2001: 202–213).

RESTORATION AND DIVINE SOVEREIGNTY

If there is one thing that holds the whole book of Ezekiel together, it is the central figure of YHWH , and Joyce correctly writes of the “radical theocentricity” of the book (1989: 89–107). YHWH ’s powerful action drives both the destruction of Jerusalem and the restoration of Israel, and over and over again we encounter the so-called recognition formula: “that you/he/they shall know that I am YHWH .” Closely related to this is YHWH ’s concern for the holiness of his name, which is prominent in chapter 20’s extended critique of Israel, and especially the context of restoration (36:20, 22; 39:7, 25;

43:7; cf. 20:39). Here YHWH exerts his power by restoring the nation that has shamed him, first by its sins and then by the military defeat that he himself imposed on it. He acts at last on behalf of his people, gathering the scattered exiles, and returning them to the land of Israel.

YHWH will now revitalize Israel's lost communal institutions in ways that make it impossible to repeat the mistakes of the past. He will reinstate some form of monarchy (17:22–24; 34:23–24; 37:24–25; 40–48), but without delegating too many royal prerogatives to the Davidic figure, who appears more of a middle manager than a vigorous messiah (cf. Mein 2001: 249–251). YHWH will reunite North and South (37:15–28), putting an end to dangerous divisions among his people. Most substantially he will provide a new Temple and cultic regulations to ensure his permanent presence for Israel (chs. 40–48). Under these new and transformed circumstances, both land and people will flourish, and Israel will be able to live in obedience, security, and prosperity.

Ezekiel is most famous for his vision of a valley full of dry bones, which represent the current tragedy of the people of Israel (37:1–14). In response to Ezekiel's prophecy, the bones come together, the corpses are clothed in flesh, and they receive the breath of life. This is not, as some Christian commentators took it, a prediction of the resurrection of individuals from the dead, but a vivid metaphor for the restoration of the people of Israel to the land: "I am going to open your graves, O my people, and I will bring you back to the land of Israel, and you shall know that I am the LORD, when I open your graves, and bring you up from your graves, O my people. I will put my spirit in you and you shall live, and I will place you on your own soil, and then you shall know that I, the LORD, have spoken and will act" (37:12–14). Such extravagant promises of a communal future respond to the powerlessness of the exilic situation by offering shared hopes and aspirations, and are a source of strength and common purpose in difficult circumstances.

Despite all the positive images, the restoration of Israel is by no means an end in itself, as Ezekiel 36:22 makes clear: "It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act, but for the sake of my holy name, which you have profaned among the nations to which you came" (36:22). YHWH's love and tenderness toward Israel are conspicuous by their absence, and Israel's appropriate response to restoration is often not joy or gladness but shame and self-loathing (e.g., 16:61–63; 20:43; 36:31–32). Baruch Schwartz points out that Ezekiel lacks any of the reflection on penitence, covenant faithfulness, or love that motivates restoration in the Torah and the other exilic prophets. He argues controversially that for Ezekiel the oracles of restoration are more or less of a piece with the oracles of judgment. Everything is subordinated to YHWH's majesty, wounded as much by his own punishment of Israel as he was by the sin that provoked it. His only option is a "most ungracious project of forced rehabilitation," through which divine honor will finally be satisfied.²⁵

This "dim view of restoration" in Ezekiel is strong meat, but it is striking that Ezekiel's movement from judgment to salvation is paralleled by a shift from responsibility to passivity on the part of the people of Israel, who become less and less responsible for what happens to them at a communal and national level. Not only do these oracles promise

Israel's restoration unconditionally, they also make it clear that even the people's ability to respond to the gift is something that YHWH himself will enable. This comes over powerfully in 36:18–38, where after their return YHWH will cleanse the people from what has defiled them, and provide for them a new heart and a new spirit: a “heart of flesh” to replace the “heart of stone,” the result of which will be a “renewed capacity to respond to Yahweh in obedience” (Joyce 1989: 111). Even in the vision of chapters 40–48, which demands a good deal of human action in its detailed ritual instructions, obedience follows restoration rather than precedes it. The vision presents Ezekiel with the restored Temple less as a blueprint for action than as a divine *fait accompli*.

Jacqueline Lapsley highlights a tension in the book between different understandings of the moral self. The calls to repentance (Ezek 18:32; 14:6) take for granted that people have the capacity to change their ways and to do good, whereas the promise of the new heart (11:19; 36:26) is both more deterministic and more pessimistic about the possibility of human virtue.²⁶ The shift from Jerusalem's responsibility for judgment to Israel's passivity in the face of restoration is evidence that the pessimistic view is the one that wins out in the end for Ezekiel. Moreover, it is possible to see this theological shift as also reflecting the social experience of Ezekiel's hearers, who have moved from positions of power and responsibility in Jerusalem to live with the much more limited moral possibilities of life in exile (Mein 2001: 216–256).

Ezekiel's radical theocentricity also expresses itself powerfully in the book's reflection on divine kingship. YHWH is only named explicitly as king once (20:33), where he is the royal shepherd who brings his people in a new Exodus out of exile and into the “bond of the covenant” (20:37). However, the theme is deeply embedded in the book, which “tells the story of God's final attempt as their only legitimate king to claim the loyalty of his subjects, the rebellious and recalcitrant house of Israel” (Odell 2005: 1). The enthroned God of the opening vision has a royal aspect: Odell goes on to suggest that the details of the vision evoke the design and iconography of Assyrian throne rooms in order to claim that only YHWH is the great king who controls the universe (2005: 13–37). Ezekiel certainly has little time for human kings, whether the Judean Zedekiah or the unnamed kings of Tyre and Egypt in chapters 26–32, whose royal hubris is no match for the power of YHWH. The portrayal of Pharaoh as the defeated sea monster (29:1–16; 32:1–10) and other *Chaoskampf* motifs establish YHWH as victorious king, and this may be part of a wider “move to dismantle royal legitimacy” in favor of YHWH's sole kingship.²⁷

The one human king who is never explicitly challenged in the book is Nebuchadnezzar, but the overthrow of Babylonian power must at least be implicit in Ezekiel's oracles of restoration, which from the outset establish YHWH's kingship with the royal claim that “I myself will be the shepherd of my sheep” (34:15). Kingship must also be at the heart of the book's final vision, since in the ancient Near East, temple building is a royal task. Ezekiel's temple has no human builder, and thus the vision with its extensive reimagining of the geography of the land both re-establishes YHWH on his throne and reasserts “YHWH's territorial claim as the only king of Israel.”²⁸ Susan Niditch has made the suggestive claim that the current shape of chapters 38–48, which moves from the conflict

with Gog into the temple vision, replicates an ancient mythic pattern in which the building of a palace or temple is the seal of a deity's victory over chaos.²⁹ If so, YHWH's temple building confirms his royal and divine dominance.

Ezekiel's assertion of YHWH's sovereignty is an astonishingly bold one, given the unenviable position of his community as a powerless minority within the vast Babylonian Empire. But this boldness is typical of a book that so often takes the old world of the Jerusalem elite, breaks it apart, and reinvents that world with YHWH at its absolute center. In doing so, it gives an uncompromising reminder to the house of Israel that, despite all appearances and willing or not, they have a future.

NOTES

1. William Greenhill, *An Exposition of Ezekiel* (Edinburgh: Banner of Truth, 1994), 5.
2. Richard Kraetzschmar, *Das Buch Ezechiel* (HKAT; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1900).
3. Gustav Hölscher, *Hesekiel, der Dichter und das Buch: eine literarkritische Untersuchung* (BZAW 39; Giessen: Töpelmann, 1924).
4. Volkmar Hertrich, *Ezechielprobleme* (BZAW 61; Giessen: Töpelmann, 1932).
5. Alfred Bertholet (with Kurt Galling), *Hesekiel* (HAT 13; Tübingen: Mohr, 1936).
6. Charles C. Torrey, *Pseudo-Ezekiel and the Original Prophecy* (YOSR 18; New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1930; repr. New York: Ktav, 1970).
7. Fuller accounts of the development of Ezekiel criticism are available in McKeating 1993, Darr 1994, Levitt Kohn 2003, and Pohlmann 2008.
8. Also Georg Fohrer, *Die Hauptprobleme des Buches Ezechiel* (BZAW 72; Berlin: Töpelmann, 1952).
9. For an up-to-date and thorough examination of the issues, see Ingrid E. Lilly, *Two Books of Ezekiel: Papyrus 967 and the Masoretic Text as Variant Literary Editions* (VTSup 150; Leiden: Brill, 2012).
10. Ronald E. Clements, "The Chronology of Redaction in Ezekiel 1–24," in *Ezekiel and His Book* (ed. J. Lust; BETL 74; Leuven: Peeters, 1983), 283–294; Moshe Greenberg, "The Design and Themes of Ezekiel's Program of Restoration," *Int* 38 (1984): 181–208 (2008).
11. The "river Chebar" is hard to identify, but is probably a canal that connected with the Euphrates, perhaps near Nippur in southern Babylonia. On the presence of Jewish communities in the agricultural hinterland of Babylonian cities, see Matthew W. Stolper, "Murashu, Archive of," *ABD* IV: 927–928; Laurie E. Pearce, "New Evidence for Judeans in Babylonia," in *Judah and the Judeans in the Persian Period* (ed. Oded Lipschitz and Manfred Oeming; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2006), 399–411.
12. On the harshness of exile, see Daniel L. Smith-Christopher, *A Biblical Theology of Exile* (OBT; Minneapolis: Fortress, 2002), 49–73.
13. Ellen F. Davis, *Swallowing the Scroll: Textuality and the Dynamics of Discourse in Ezekiel's Prophecy* (JSOTSup 78; Sheffield: Almond, 1989), 135.
14. The most substantial recent example is David J. Halperin, *Seeking Ezekiel: Text and Psychology* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1993).
15. Smith-Christopher, *Biblical Theology of Exile*, 75–104.

16. See, e.g., John F. Kutsko, *Between Heaven and Earth: Divine Presence and Absence in the Book of Ezekiel* (BJSUCSD 7; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2000), 77–100.
17. Marvin A. Sweeney, “Ezekiel: Zadokite Priest and Visionary Prophet of the Exile,” in his *Form and Intertextuality in Prophetic and Apocalyptic Literature* (FAT 45; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2005), 125–143 (137).
18. The precise direction of influence remains stubbornly difficult to determine, although recent work tends to argue that Ezekiel draws on the present text of H or something very like it. For a review of scholarship and detailed proposals along these lines, see Michael A. Lyons, *From Law to Prophecy: Ezekiel’s Use of the Holiness Code* (LHBOTS 508; New York: T & T Clark, 2009).
19. Margaret S. Odell, “You Are What You Eat: Ezekiel and the Scroll,” *JBL* 117 (1998): 229–248 (247); cf. Baruch J. Schwartz, “A Priest Out of Place: Reconsidering Ezekiel’s Role in the History of the Israelite Priesthood,” in *Ezekiel’s Hierarchical World: Wrestling with a Tiered Reality* (ed. Stephen L. Cook and Corrine L. Carvalho; SBLSymS 31; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2004), 61–71.
20. Andrew Mein, “Ezekiel as a Priest in Exile,” in *The Elusive Prophet: The Prophet as a Historical Person, Literary Character, and Anonymous Artist* (ed. J. C. de Moor; OtSt 45; Leiden: Brill, 2001), 199–213; Corrine L. Carvalho, “Priest, Prophet and Exile: Ezekiel as a Literary Construct,” in Cook and Carvalho 2004: 73–89; Sweeney 2005.
21. Kutsko, *Between Heaven and Earth*, 25–42.
22. See Bernhard Lang, *Kein Aufstand in Jerusalem: Die Politik des Propheten Ezechiel* (SBB; Stuttgart: Katholisches Bibelwerk, 1978).
23. Corrine L. Patton, “‘Should Our Sister Be Treated like a Whore?’ A Response to Feminist Critiques of Ezekiel 23,” in *The Book of Ezekiel: Theological and Anthropological Perspectives* (ed. Margaret S. Odell and John T. Strong; SBLSymS 9; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2000), 221–238 (237–238).
24. Dalit Rom-Shiloni, *Exclusive Inclusivity: Identity Conflicts between the Exiles and the People Who Remained (6th–5th Centuries BCE)* (LHBOTS 543; London: T & T Clark, 2013), 196; for Rom-Shiloni, Ezekiel’s editors soften the approach in chapters 34–37, which imagine a wider restoration than just the Jehoiachin exiles, but nevertheless assume that Israel will reoccupy an empty land.
25. Baruch J. Schwartz, “Ezekiel’s Dim View of Israel’s Restoration,” in *The Book of Ezekiel: Theological and Anthropological Perspectives* (ed. Margaret S. Odell and John T. Strong; SBLSymS 9; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2000), 43–67. See also Andrew Mein, “Profitable and Unprofitable Shepherds: Economic and Theological Perspectives on Ezekiel 34,” *JSOT* 31 (2007): 493–504.
26. Jacqueline E. Lapsley, *Can These Bones Live? The Problem of the Moral Self in the Book of Ezekiel* (BZAW 301; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2000).
27. Madhavi Nevader, “YHWH and the Kings of Middle Earth: Royal Polemic in Ezekiel’s Oracles against the Nations,” in *Concerning the Nations: Essays on the Oracles against the Nations in Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel* (ed. Else K. Holt, Hyun Chul Paul Kim, and Andrew Mein; LHBOTS 612; London: T & T Clark, 2015), 161–178 (163).
28. Kalinda Rose Stevenson, *The Vision of Transformation: The Territorial Rhetoric of Ezekiel 40–48* (SBLDS 154; Atlanta, GA: Scholars, 1996), 163.
29. Cf. both the *Enuma Elish* and the Ugaritic Baal Cycle; Susan Niditch, “Ezekiel 40–48 in Visionary Context,” *CBQ* 48 (1986): 208–224.

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CHAPTER 12

THE TWELVE

Structure, Themes, and Contested Issues

RAINER KESSLER

THE traditional name for the book in Hebrew or Aramaic is “The Twelve.” As early as the second century B.C.E., Ben Sira speaks of “the twelve prophets” (49:10). Jerome in his prologue to the Latin translation explains that though each book has its specialty in style and diction and its own time of composition, they form one book. Augustine calls them “the minor prophets,” simply because of their length compared to the books of Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel (civ. XVIII 29). Hebrew manuscripts sometimes have a short final masorah at the end of every individual book, and a full final masorah appears at the end of the Twelve, indicating the number of verses and the central verse of the book as a whole (cf. BHS). Traditional enumerations of the number of the books of the Hebrew Bible, which differ between twenty-two (Josephus, *Contra Apionem* I,8 = 1,38) and twenty-four books (4 Ezra 14:45), always count the Twelve as one book.

The Twelve were written on one scroll. This scroll has about the same length as the scrolls of the so-called major prophets: Isaiah has 1,291 verses, Jeremiah 1,364, Ezekiel 1,273, and the Twelve have 1,050 verses.

THE INDIVIDUAL BOOKS AND THEIR ORDER

The *individual books* within the Book of the Twelve are quite different in length, literary character, and date.

Characterization of the Individual Books

Eleven of the twelve books are compositions of prophetic oracles. The only exception is Jonah, which is a pure narration, with only very few prophetic words embedded, as

well as one prayer (Jonah 2). Besides Jonah, there is only one more narrative pericope, the short story about the confrontation between Amos and the priest Amaziah at Bethel (Amos 9:10–17). Furthermore, the beginning of Hosea has narrative elements (Hosea's marriage) in close combination with prophetic oracles.

Though most of the individual books consist of prophetic oracles, each one has its own specific profile. In Hosea, the oracles form a close composition, running through from chapter 4 to its finale in chapter 11. The composition is framed by the “biographical” narrative in chapters 1–3 and three longer chapters at the end (chs. 12–14). Amos has a similar structure. Here the words of the prophet in chapters 3–6 are framed by oracles against the nations in chapters 1–2 and a collection of visions (including more oracles) at the end (chs. 7–9). The book of Micah is characterized by a sequence of shifts from oracles of judgment to oracles of salvation. Nahum and Habakkuk are bound together by two psalms, one at the beginning of Nahum, the other at the end of Habakkuk. A system of precise dates (days and months in the second and fourth years of the Persian king Darius) runs through Haggai and Zechariah 1–8. The long book of Zechariah has two parts; the first is marked by a composition of eight night visions (chs. 1–6), the second has elements that approach those of apocalyptic texts. The last book of the Twelve, Malachi, has the unique form of disputation speeches; these are discussions between *YHWH* and the people (or groups, such as the priests) presented by the prophet with, however, only few remarks by himself.

Most of the shorter books have only one subject: in Joel it is the day of *YHWH*, in Obadiah doom for Edom and the nations, in Jonah and Nahum the fate of Nineveh (with Nineveh's salvation in Jonah and her destruction in Nahum). Haggai is about the reconstruction of the Second Temple.

Each of the books is ascribed to a prophetic individual. Most of the prophets are situated in specific historical situations. Hosea and Amos are prophets who prophesy in the northern kingdom of Israel in the years preceding the conquest of Samaria and the end of the state of Israel (i.e., in the second half of the eighth century B.C.E.). The protagonist of the book of Jonah probably is the prophet Jonah ben Amittai mentioned in 2 Kings 14:25 as prophesying in the days of king Jeroboam II. He then would be contemporary with Amos. Micah is a prophet from Judah at the end of the eighth century B.C.E. Nahum and Habakkuk have no exact date, but mention the Assyrians (whose capital is Nineveh) and the (Neo-)Babylonians (Hab 1:6). This locates them no earlier than the end of the seventh and the beginning of the sixth centuries. Zephaniah is said to be contemporary with King Josiah, who reigned in the last third of the seventh century. Obadiah, which is not dated, presupposes the fall of Jerusalem in 586 B.C.E. Haggai and Zechariah are prophesying in the days of Darius I (i.e., at the end of the sixth century B.C.E.).

Books without any date include Joel and Malachi. The superscription to the book of Joel does not mention any king. The content of the book is about locusts and the day of *YHWH*, but has no historical allusions. Malachi has no date either. However, the position after the Persian period prophets Haggai and Zechariah and the passing mention of the—probably Persian—“governor” (Mal 1:8) locate it in the time of the Persian Empire.

All in all, the twelve books present a sort of compendium of Israelite prophecy from the times of the Israelite and Judahite kingdoms through to the epoch of Persian rule.

Order of the Books

The *order of the books* differs in the Hebrew and Greek traditions in that the first six books have a different order (see Table 12.1). In both traditions, the order is *more or less chronological*. This is evident for Hosea and Amos, the eighth-century prophets from the northern kingdom, at the beginning, as well as for the last six prophets from the epoch of Assyrian, Babylonian, and Persian dominance, at the end. In the Hebrew order, Obadiah comes too early, because his oracles are later than the fall of Jerusalem and, consequently, later than Micah. In the Greek order, Jonah is too late if the prophet for whom the book is named is thought to be identical with the northern prophet from the times of Jeroboam II.

This may be a hint that chronology is only one principle for stringing the books together. In the Greek tradition, this principle might be superseded by the principle of putting longer books before the shorter ones (cf. the three major prophets before the twelve minor in the Hebrew tradition, or the sequence of the suras in the Qur'an). So Hosea, Amos, and Micah, with fourteen, nine, and seven chapters, are put before Joel, Obadiah, and Jonah, with three (so the Greek book of Joel), one, and four chapters, respectively.

In the Hebrew tradition, chronology might be combined with linking books together by *catchwords*.¹ Some of these links are obvious and significant. Joel as No. 2 is linked with Amos as No. 3 by the words “יְהוָה roars from Zion, and utters his voice from Jerusalem” (Joel 4:16a; Engl. 3:16a; and Amos 1:2a) and “the mountains shall drip sweet wine, and (all the) the hills shall flow with milk/with it” (Joel 4:18a; Engl. 3:18a; and Amos 9:13b). No. 3 Amos has in his last chapter, “in order that they may possess the remnant of Edom and all the nations . . .” (9:12a). The next book (Obadiah, No. 4),

Table 12.1 The Order of the Twelve in the Hebrew and Greek Traditions

	<i>Hebrew</i>	<i>Greek</i>	<i>Hebrew = Greek</i>
1	Hosea	Hosea	7 Nahum
2	Joel	Amos	8 Habakkuk
3	Amos	Micah	9 Zephaniah
4	Obadiah	Joel	10 Haggai
5	Jonah	Obadiah	11 Zechariah
6	Micah	Jonah	12 Malachi

first is directed against Edom and then turns to “all the nations” (Obad 15) announcing that the house of Jacob “shall possess their possessions” (Obad 17, cf. v 19). Micah as No. 6 and Nahum as No. 7 are linked together not by identical catchwords, but by the so-called grace formula of Exodus 34:6–7 by which the nature of God is portrayed. The formula is split up between the two books. Micah ends with its first part: “Who is a God like you, forgiving iniquity and passing by transgression for the remnant of his inheritance? He does not retain his anger forever, for he is a God who delights in steadfast love” (Mic 7:18). The first verse of Nahum continues with at least the theology of the second part of the formula: “A jealous and avenging God is YHWH, YHWH is avenging and wrathful; YHWH takes vengeance on his adversaries and rages against his enemies. YHWH is slow to anger and great in power, yet by no means clearing the guilty” (Nah 1:2–3).

Although some of the catchwords are indeed significant, it must be underlined that the principle of catchwords as presented in the preceding text works only within the Hebrew tradition. The Hebrew sequence of Joel-Amos-Obadiah so clearly linked together by identical words or nearly literal allusions is broken in the Greek tradition, where Amos is separated from both Joel and Obadiah.² On the other hand, the Greek composition has its own catchwords linking books together, which are separated in the Hebrew tradition. The most significant case is that of Micah and Joel, who follow each other in the Septuagint. Micah 4:3 has the famous vision that “they shall beat their swords into ploughshares, and their spears into pruning-hooks.” In the Greek tradition, the vision is immediately questioned by the proclamation to the nations in the book of Joel: “Beat your ploughshares into swords, and your pruning-hooks into spears” (Joel 4:10, Engl. 3:10).

UNIFYING ELEMENTS

Besides their roughly chronological order, the Twelve are bound together by some additional *unifying elements*.

The Superscriptions

Among the unifying elements, in the first place one has to mention the *superscriptions*. In general, they do not follow an identical scheme. Some books do not have a superscription at all but begin as a narrative. This is obvious in the case of Jonah, but also true for the books of Haggai and Zechariah, both of which begin with a full sentence. The rest of the beginnings are true superscriptions. They can be divided into two types. The first type has the word of YHWH as its subject: “The word of YHWH that came to [Hosea/Joel/Micah/Zephaniah].” The second type has different forms, which are, however, united by the fact that the prophet is the subject of his words: “The words

of Amos”/“The vision of Obadiah”/“Oracle (literally: burden) of Nineveh; book of the vision of Nahum”/“The oracle (burden) which Habakkuk the prophet saw.” Malachi has a combination of both forms: “Oracle (burden) of the word of YHWH to Israel, by the hand of Malachi.” In all cases, even in the narrative beginnings, appears the name of the prophet, so that the beginnings unequivocally separate the twelve books from each other.

However clear this separation is, the system of superscriptions does not fully coincide with the borders of the individual books. Habakkuk has a second superscription within the book; chapter 3 begins with the words: “A prayer of the prophet Habakkuk.” Zechariah also has two superscriptions within the book, which not only subdivide the book but also connect it with the following book (Malachi): Zechariah 9:1: “Oracle (burden) of the word of YHWH”; Zechariah 12:1 “Oracle (burden) of the word of YHWH to Israel”; and Malachi 1:1 “Oracle (burden) of the word of YHWH to Israel, by the hand of Malachi.” We will have to come back to these observations when we discuss theories about the redaction history of the Twelve later in the chapter.

The Dates and the Theology of the Word of YHWH

Within the superscriptions, there are two elements that have a uniting effect. The first element is the *dates* given within the different types of headings and in different forms. Hosea is dated “in the days of Kings Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah of Judah, and in the days of King Jeroboam ben Joash of Israel.” Amos has a different type of superscription, but the book is dated in the days of two of these kings, Uzziah of Judah and Jeroboam ben Joash of Israel. Micah, the next book with a date, is linked to Hosea in that it is dated “in the days of Kings Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah of Judah.” The next dated prophet, Zephaniah, according to the superscription prophesied about a century later, “in the days of King Josiah ben Amon of Judah.” As we have already seen, Haggai and Zechariah are not dated after Judean or Israelite kings, but after the Persian ruler Darius I. Though only six out of the twelve books have precise dates, the unifying idea behind the dates is that Israel’s history from the time of the monarchy down to the Persian epoch is accompanied by the word of authorized prophets.

This immediately leads to the second element of unity given by the superscriptions. In particular, those that have “the word of YHWH” as their subject represent a special *theology of the word of YHWH*. According to these headings, there exists only one word of YHWH, which is addressed to individual prophets at different times in Israel’s history and then is handed on to Israel by the prophets. Other superscriptions have “the oracle (burden) of the word of YHWH” as their subject (Zech 9:1; 12:1; Mal 1:1). Though it is not clear what “burden” (*maśśā*) really means, in combination with “the word of YHWH” it is a form of oracle coming from God. In the light of these superscriptions, all the prophets of the book are seen as speakers of YHWH’s word. They have individual messages in different historical, social, and religious circumstances. But behind these lies one word of YHWH.

UNIFYING THEMES

The superscriptions with their historical interest and theological idea of the word of YHWH are not the only unifying element in the book of the Twelve. There are several *themes* that run through the Twelve and provide a certain unity for them. Scholarly research has identified some themes that are especially significant: the day of YHWH, the role of the nations, the use of Exodus 34:6–7, and others.

The Day of YHWH in the Book of the Twelve

The most prominent theme in the list probably is *the day of YHWH*.³ Joel is dominated by this theme. The book begins with the call to a mourning ritual, which is to be held on the occasion of a catastrophe caused by locusts. Their invasion is interpreted as a sign for the day of YHWH. Joel 1:15 sets up the equation: “Alas for the day! For the day of YHWH is near, and as destruction from the Almighty it comes.” Joel 2:1 nearly repeats the words of 1:15: “The day of YHWH is coming, it is near.” Joel 2:11 adds: “Great is the day of YHWH.” Then repentance of Israel leads to change. Israel will be saved, and the nations that threatened Israel will be punished. The theme of the day of YHWH is still present in the last chapters (3:4; Engl. 2:31). The exclamation of 1:15 and 2:1 is even repeated in 4:14 (Engl. 3:14): “The day of YHWH is near.” But now its significance is turned into the opposite: the nations who gather in the valley of Jehoshaphat, “in the valley of decision” (4:14; Engl. 3:14), will be destroyed. “But YHWH is a refuge for his people, a stronghold for the people of Israel” (4:16; Engl. 3:16).

Does this mean that the day of YHWH is light for Israel and not darkness? The book of Amos, following directly after Joel (in the Hebrew tradition), gives the answer: “Alas for you, who desire the day of YHWH! . . . It is darkness, not light. . . . Is not the day of YHWH darkness, not light, gloom with no brightness in it?” (Amos 5:18, 20). Amos’s oracle is the rejection of a false estimate of the day of YHWH that could be deduced from the book of Joel.

The next book, Obadiah, repeats the words of Joel 1:14; 2:1; and 4:14 (Engl. 3:14): “The day of YHWH is near.” Again, however, as in Joel, the day is not darkness but light for Israel. Obadiah 15 continues: “The day of YHWH is near against all the nations.” It means punishment for the nations and salvation for Israel.

The following books from Jonah through Habakkuk have no explicit reference to the day of YHWH. This changes drastically in Zephaniah. The first chapter of this book is a long poem about the day of YHWH. Again we read: “The day of YHWH is near” (Zeph 1:7). All the authorities of Judah and all her wealthy people are threatened: the priests, the royal court, the traders, and the noble landowners in the old town of Jerusalem. Then verse 14 repeats: “The day of YHWH is near.” What follows is a poem on the day, “a day of wrath, a day of distress and anguish, a day of ruin and devastation, a day of darkness and

gloom, a day of clouds and thick darkness” (Zeph 1:15). Unlike the references in Joel and Obadiah, and as in Amos, the day is a day of darkness, not light.

The next allusion to the day of YHWH is met in the last chapter of the book of Zechariah. The first verse of the chapter announces a day that “is coming” or “is about to come” for YHWH. On this day, God will act against Jerusalem and then against the nations. YHWH will reveal his power in a theophany. The chapter ends with the vision of a pilgrimage of the nations to Jerusalem to observe the feast of Tabernacles. Amos’s question whether the day of YHWH is light or darkness is answered in an unexpected way. The day will be darkness for those of the nations who will not go up to Jerusalem and worship the king YHWH there. But it will be light for all who celebrate the feast of Tabernacles in Jerusalem together with YHWH’s people. The nations will be divided between those who become part of YHWH’s kingdom and those who decline to follow him.

Zechariah offers a future for the nations but leaves open the question of whether Israel as a whole will be saved. This question is answered only by the last book of the Twelve, in the last chapter of Malachi. Even within Israel there will be a separation “between a righteous person and a wicked one, between one who serves God, and one who has not served him” (Mal 3:18). It will be on the day which is coming that the evildoers will be destroyed and the righteous will rejoice under the “sun of righteousness” (Mal 3:19–20; Engl. 4:1–2).

An appendix forms the conclusion to the book of Malachi and, at the same time, to the book of the Twelve and even to the entire prophetic canon (Mal 3:22–24; Engl. 4:4–6). This last unit again deals with the theme of the day of YHWH. The coming of Elijah the prophet is announced before the coming of the day of YHWH. Elijah will reconcile parents and children so that the land will not be annihilated with a ban. The author of the verse probably hints at Micah 7:6, where the conflict between the generations is the prominent sign of the (eschatological) time of confusion and judgment (v 4). The reconciliation between sons and fathers, daughters and mothers is the prerequisite for the coming of the day of YHWH as a day of salvation and not of destruction.

Six of the twelve books have explicit references to the theme of the day of YHWH. In the first books, two possibilities are presented: the day could be salvation for Israel and judgment for the nations, or it could be doom for Israel. It could be, metaphorically said, light or darkness. In two books (Joel and Obadiah), the day is described as bringing destruction to the nations who are hostile toward Israel; in two other books (Amos and Zephaniah), the day is directed against Israel herself. The last two books (Zechariah and Malachi) give up the simple opposition between Israel and the Gentiles. For them, the day of YHWH is a day of separation, a separation within the nations as well as within Israel. At the very end, the reconciliation brought by Elijah before the coming of the day will prevent God’s striking of the land. The six books not only offer a veritable theology of the day of YHWH,⁴ but also shed light on the other books. As noted earlier, these books do not explicitly mention the day of YHWH. Many of them, however, speak of “this day” (Mic 2:4; 4:6; 5:9; etc.), of “days to come” (Amos 4:2; 8:11; 9:13), or a time “at the end of the days” (Hos 3:5; Mic 4:1). Read in the context of the neighboring books, the day or days

of these oracles can be understood as identical with the day of YHWH (“this day”), or as a time-span before (“day to come”) or even after YHWH’s day (“at the end of the days”).

This possibility leads to the question of whether it is justified to read the Twelve as a unit. It is a hermeneutical problem of fundamental importance for the understanding of the so-called minor prophets. Before I turn to it, I shall mention some other themes that span the entire book of the Twelve, or at least a relevant number of books.

Israel and the Nations

One theme, already alluded to in the discussion of the day of YHWH, is the relationship between *Israel and the nations*. In some books, it is closely linked to the vision of the future “day” (Joel, Obadiah, Zechariah 14). But the theme of the nations also appears in contexts other than the day of YHWH. Amos begins with a composition of oracles against foreign nations, but the eventual emphasis is on God’s judgment on his own people, Judah and Israel (Amos 1:3–2:16). In the center of the Twelve, we find a composition of three books: Jonah, Micah, and Nahum. Two of them have their only concern in the fate of Nineveh, the capital of Israel’s archenemy, Assyria. According to Jonah, Nineveh will repent and consequently be saved. For Nahum, on the other side, the fate of Nineveh is decided; it will be annihilated. Micah, in between the two, seems to explain the leap from salvation to judgment. The nations who “listen” (Mic 1:2) and “stream to the mountain of YHWH’s house” (4:1) can be saved, but YHWH will “execute vengeance on the nations that did not obey” (Mic 5:14; Engl. 5:15). Zephaniah, like Amos, has a composition of oracles against foreign nations, eventually ending in the announcement of judgment on Jerusalem (Zeph 2:4–3:5). As we have seen, according to Zechariah 14 there will be a separation between the nations who follow the God of Israel and those who still try to fight him.

According to the theme of the day of YHWH, it would be possible to develop a theology of the relation of Israel to the nations from the book of the Twelve. Some of its elements would be that Israel is not better than the nations (Amos 1–2; Zeph 2:4–3:5), that the fate of the nations depends on their attitude toward Israel and her God, and that eventually “at the end of the days” (Mic 4:1) the nations will be saved because they are going to Zion to receive “instruction” (*torah*) from there. However, the hermeneutical question remains: Is it justified to read the Twelve in this way?

The Grace Formula of Exodus 34:6–7 within the Book of the Twelve

Another thread running through the Twelve is the *reception of the words of Exodus 34:6–7*: “YHWH, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness, . . . forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, yet by no means clearing the guilty, but visiting the iniquity of the parents upon the children and the children’s

children, to the third and the fourth generation” (Scoralick 2002). Numerous are the allusions to and even quotations of these words within the Twelve. In Joel 2:13, the first part of the formula is quoted nearly literally. To motivate the call to repentance, the prophet adds the words of Exodus 34:6, introduced by the quotation marker *ki* (“for”): “for he is merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love.” Then, however, the text differs. While Exodus 34:6 has “abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness,” Joel 2:13 changes the phrase into “abounding in steadfast love and repenting from evil.” God’s “faithfulness” is replaced by his disposition to “repent.” God’s “faithfulness” is not characterized by immutability, but is interpreted as including his willingness to change his mind. The formula is thus adapted to the special situation of Joel, in which the people are called to “return” (*šûb*), which is motivated by the allusion to God as being himself ready to repent and return. The next verse continues: “Who knows whether he will not return and repent . . . ?” (2:14).

Jonah 4:2, like Joel 2:13, introduces the first part of the formula of Exodus 34:6 as a quote. Jonah says, “I knew that you are a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and repenting from evil.” Jonah makes the same change as Joel does, replacing God’s faithfulness with the deity’s repentance from evil. Again, the formula is adapted to the context. The context, however, is different from that of Joel. In Joel, the change aims at motivating the people’s hope. In Jonah, the prophet accuses God of not being faithful. God gave him the order to announce the end of Nineveh (Jon 3:4). Then the king of Nineveh and all the people repented, using the same hopeful words as in Joel: “Who knows whether God will not return and repent?” (Jon 3:9). And indeed, God repents (v 10). Jonah feels that he has been turned into a “false prophet” by God’s repentance because his words against Nineveh will not be fulfilled (cf. Deut 18:22). So he accuses God of not being faithful but willing to repent. He is a God on whom the prophet cannot rely.

Whereas Joel 2:13 and Jonah 4:2 are direct quotations of the formula, Micah 7:18–20 is more or less an allusion to it. Several expressions of the formula are used: “to forgive iniquity,” “transgression,” “steadfast love,” “to be merciful,” “sins,” and “faithfulness.” Unlike in Joel and Jonah, nothing is said about God’s inclination to repent. However, the prophet (or his late redactors) hopes that God will “return” (*šûb*) and open the future for his people as in the “days of old.”

Discussing the catchword links between the individual books of the Twelve, I have already mentioned that the negative part of the formula of Exodus 34:6–7 follows in the next book, namely Nahum. Some parts of the formula are quoted nearly literally. The phrase “YHWH is slow to anger . . . , yet by no means clearing the guilty” (Nah 1:3) is almost identical with Exodus 34:6–7: “YHWH . . . [is] slow to anger . . . , yet by no means clearing the guilty.” The first part of the allusion to Exodus 34 in Nahum 1:2 strengthens the formula’s theology, adding the divine qualities of jealousy and vengeance.

As in the case of the day of YHWH, the explicit reference to the formula of Exodus 34:6–7 also sheds light on the other books where the formula is not quoted directly. One of the key words of the formula is God’s *hesed*, his “steadfast love.” Another important characterization of God is his being “merciful” (*raḥûm*). Both roots, together with other

attributes of the formula, are quoted in Joel 2:13, Jonah 4:2, and Micah 7:18, 20. God's steadfast love and his "mercy," however, are also mentioned in Hosea (Hos 2:21; Engl. 2:19). But mainly *hesed* ("steadfast love") appears not as God's attitude, but as something the Israelites are missing (4:1; 6:4) or should be practicing (6:6; 10:12; 12:7). Hosea 4:1 is close to the formula of Exodus 34:6. There it is said that God is "abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness," while the people, according to Hosea 4:1, have "no faithfulness, no steadfast love." Do all these allusions to the formula and their special use in Hosea mean that, read in context, the behavior of the Israelites in Hosea is mirrored in the formula about God known and quoted from Exodus 34:6–7? The composition of the Twelve makes it possible to read the formula about God as an invitation to the people to imitate God.

The formula of Exodus 34:6–7 is quoted in the Twelve only with its positive part as far as Israel is concerned. The negative part, God's will to punish, appears together with Nineveh only in the book of Nahum. But every reader of the book, then and now, knows that the formula has two parts. Reading the Twelve as a unity in the light of the formula, he or she will soon become aware that the negative part of the formula also plays an important role within the Twelve. Especially the word "to visit" (Hebr. *pāqad*) with an object (iniquity, guilt, transgression), as part of the Exodus formula ("but visiting the iniquity of the parents upon the children"), appears throughout the Twelve, especially in Hosea (1:4; 2:15; 4:9, 14; 8:13; 9:9; 12:3), Amos (3:2, 14), and Zephaniah (1:8, 9, 12). In all cases, the text speaks of Israelites who are threatened by YHWH's punishing "visit." For an attentive reader of the Twelve, both parts of the formula are present. The book as a whole can be read as a commentary to the formula: there will be punishment, but in the end God's mercy and steadfast love shall prevail.

THE HERMENEUTICAL QUESTION

The question must now be posed: On what grounds is it possible to read the book of the Twelve as a unity? And what are the hermeneutical implications?

Intentional Allusions within the Twelve

The answer to these questions has to be given on different levels. The first is formed by *intentional allusions in individual texts*. My first example of an intentional allusion to other books of the Twelve is taken from Micah. The first pericope in Micah 1:2–7 is closely linked to the books of Hosea and Amos. Micah 1:3 is literally identical with Amos 4:13 ("YHWH will tread/treads on the heights of the earth"). The reasons given in Micah 1:7 for the total destruction of Samaria are all taken from Hosea. Accusations because of "images" (Hos 11:2), "wages" (Hos 2:14; 9:1), and "idols" (Hos 4:17; 8:4; 13:2; 14:9) are repeated in Hosea, and the metaphor of the "prostitute" runs through the entire book (Hos

1:2; 2:6–7; 3:3; 4:10–15, 18; 5:3–4; 6:10; 9:1). It is nearly impossible to understand Micah 1:7 without having read Hosea first. Israel's transgressions (Mic 1:5) leading to the destruction of Samaria are a summary of the accusations in Hosea. The beginning of the book of Micah is intentionally linked to Amos and Hosea to indicate that the destruction of Samaria announced in these books has come and shall be definitive ("her foundations are laid bare"; Mic 1:6).

Another example of intentional allusions between two books is found in Micah 4:6–7 and Zephaniah 3:19, respectively. Both texts share the same theological interest. Micah 4:6–7 speaks about the gathering of those in diaspora (cf. Mic 4:9–10; 5:2, 6–7; 7:12) and at the same time about the healing of those whose "skin was torn off" and whose "bones were broken in pieces"—that is, those who had been oppressed and exploited—by "the heads of Israel and the rulers of the house of Jacob" (Mic 3:1–3). Zephaniah also binds together the two themes of Judah being threatened by the nations (cf. Zeph 3:6–10) and social injustice within Judean society (3:1–5, 11–13). Zephaniah 3:19 brings both themes together using nearly the same words as Micah 4:6–7. Micah 4:6–7 reads: "*On that day, says YHWH, I will assemble the lame and will gather the scattered. . . . The lame I will make the remnant. . . .*" Zephaniah 3:19 says: "*. . . at that time, I will save the lame and will gather the scattered, and I will make their shame into praise . . .*" (identical vocabulary in italics). The language is highly metaphorical. The adjective "the lame," in Hebrew a feminine form, in the Hebrew Bible appears only in our two verses (the masculine form also in Gen 32:32). This must be seen as a sign that we here have an example of an intentional allusion. It is difficult or even impossible to decide the direction of literary influence in this case. Be that as it may, the nearly identical formulation presupposes the connection of the two books of Micah and Zephaniah.

In the discussion of the catchwords that link books together, I have already given more examples, such as Joel 4:16a (Engl. 3:16a): "YHWH roars from Zion, and utters his voice from Jerusalem," which is repeated in Amos 1:2a, or the vision of Micah 4:3: "They shall beat their swords into ploughshares, and their spears into pruning-hooks," which is turned into its opposite in Joel 4:10 (Engl. 3:10): "Beat your ploughshares into swords, and your pruning-hooks into spears."

Whereas in all these cases we find individual phrases intentionally binding two or more books together, the last example is of a different character. It is the book of Malachi, the last of the Twelve. Malachi certainly knows other books from the Twelve and alludes to them. Malachi 2:7 expects "the priest" to guard "knowledge" and to give "torah," whereas Hosea 4:6 accuses "the priest" of rejecting "knowledge" and forgetting "torah." The opposition of "evil" and "good" and the quest for "justice" in Malachi 2:17 have their closest parallel in Amos 5:14–15 and Micah 3:1–2. The question concerning the day of the messenger's coming, "and who can stand when he appears?" (3:2), echoes Joel 2:11 ("the day of YHWH is great—who can stand it?") and Nahum 1:6 ("Who can stand before his indignation?"). The combination of the coming of the LORD with his "temple" and the idea of YHWH being a witness (Mal 3:1, 5) is also found in Micah 1:2.⁵ Malachi 3:7 repeats the words of Zechariah 1:3 almost literally: "Return to me, and I will return to you, says YHWH of Hosts." The catchword "my statutes" and "your ancestors" in Malachi 3:7 are

taken from Zechariah 1:6. The theme of God's blessing, which will only come when the tithes and offerings are brought to the Temple, connects Malachi 3:8–10 with Haggai 1:2–11. In Malachi 3:10–11, the catchwords "blessing," rainfall from "heaven," "vine," and "fruit" (of the soil) are identical with Zechariah 8:12–13. Finally, the last unit in Malachi, which speaks of "the day to come" and "the day when I act" (Mal 3:19, 21; Engl. 4:1, 3), alludes to the concept of the day of YHWH, which is so prominent in the book of the Twelve. In sum, Malachi displays a rich intertextuality with a great number of the books forming the collection of the Twelve. The author of Malachi writes his book with the other books of the Twelve in his mind or perhaps even in front of him.

Juxtaposition of Books

These intentional allusions between individual books or, as in the case of Malachi (and probably also Joel), between a whole book and (almost) the rest of the Twelve, form one level on which it is possible or even necessary to read the Twelve as a unity. The second level is quite different in character. It is formed by the *mere juxtaposition of the books*. A significant example is Micah's vision of the nations streaming to Mount Zion (Mic 4:1–4). Though the text does not mention the theme of the day of YHWH, by the introductory formula "at the end of the days" (Mic 4:1) it is connected with this theme treated in several other books of the Twelve. I have mentioned this in the discussion of the theme of YHWH's day.

There is yet another theme within Micah's vision, making new sense when the books of the Twelve are read together. According to Micah 4:2, "out of Zion shall go forth torah." This torah, in parallelism with "the word of YHWH," is the instruction for the nations, enabling them to settle their conflicts and live in peace. The word "torah" is used without the definite article, so it is definitely not meant to be the Torah from Mount Sinai, the "Torah of Moses." It is an actual instruction for the nations.

But what happens when we read Micah 4:1–4 in the context of the Twelve? The word "torah" appears in eight of the twelve books of the collection. In some texts, it hints at the priestly torah in a technical sense, either in the strict sense of regulations given in response to cultic questions (Hagg 2:11) or in the broader sense of priestly teaching (Hos 4:6; Zeph 3:4; Mal 2:6, 9). Other texts speak of God's torah, "my torah" (Hos 8:1, 12), the "torah of YHWH" (Amos 2:4), or simply "the torah" (Hab 1:4; Zech 7:12). Here "torah" means God's universal will, revealed not only to the priests but to all members of the people of God. At the very end of the Twelve, "the torah" is identified with "the Torah of Moses that God commanded him at Horeb for all Israel" (Mal 3:22; Engl. 4:4). Whether priestly torah, the torah of YHWH, or the Torah of Moses, in all these texts God's will is directed only to Israel. And in all places except Malachi 3:22 (Engl. 4:4), Israel (or the priests) reject the torah. The only text where "torah" is connected with the nations and where it is accepted by its addressees is Micah 4:1–4. As we have seen, torah here is not the Torah from Sinai (or Horeb) but actual instruction for the nations. Read in the context of the Twelve and at the same time in an eschatological perspective, however, we

get the vision of universal peace. The nations receive “torah” as actual instruction that enables them to keep peace. And Israel has “the Torah of Moses” (Mal 3:22; Engl. 4:4). Remembering it, Israel (or better, the righteous within Israel) shall be prevented from experiencing God’s punishment at the day that comes, “burning like an oven” (Mal 3:19; Engl. 4:1). Both the nations and Israel have a promising future.

What should be underlined is that this understanding does not emerge from the reading of only one of the books of the Twelve. Neither are there redactional texts that intentionally suggest this reading. It is only the juxtaposition of the texts that makes this understanding possible (or even necessary).

The differentiation between redactional texts that intentionally link individual texts together and an interpretation that emerges from the reading of the texts as a unity leads to the much discussed question of how the book of the Twelve came into being. The first part of this question is whether we can detect redactional steps that lead from the individual books to the final composition. The other part of the question is whether the books should be read as a unity, or whether the intention of the final redaction is only to present an anthology of twelve individual books.

THE FORMATION OF THE BOOK OF THE TWELVE

The observations made earlier about unifying elements within the Twelve remained at the level of the final text. However, we can draw some conclusions from them concerning the formation of the book of the Twelve.

Precursors to the Collection of the Twelve Books

It is very probable that before the composition of the Twelve as a whole, there were smaller compositions. Redactional texts within Hosea and Amos suggest that the two books once formed a composition of its own. In Hosea, we find nearly literal quotations from Amos. Hosea 4:15b combines Amos 4:4; 5:5, and 8:14. Hosea 8:14b is a citation of the formula of punishment from Amos’s oracles against the nations (Amos 1:4, 7, 10, 14; 2:2, 5): “I will send fire against his cities, and it shall consume his strongholds.” On the other hand, Amos has mainly semantic allusions to Hosea. The word “to visit” (Hebr. *pāqad*) in the sense of punishment in Amos 3:2, 14 is probably taken from Hosea (1:4; 2:15; 4:9, 14; 8:13; 9:9; 12:3). The Hebrew word *’āwôn* for “iniquity” is a keyword in Hosea’s accusations (Hos 4:8; 5:5; 7:1; 8:13; 9:7, 9; 12:9; 13:12; 14:2–3). In Amos it is found only in 3:2, which might be influenced by Hosea’s language. The conclusion drawn from these observations could be that in an early stage Hosea and Amos formed a small unity of two books (Jeremias 1996).

A widespread but not unanimous consensus says that Hosea and Amos, together with Micah and Zephaniah, once formed a “book of the Four.” The main evidence for the hypothesis is the similarity of the superscriptions. We can add the observations made earlier in the context of intentional allusions between the books: Micah 1:2–7 relies on the text of Hosea as well as Amos, and that Micah 4:6–7 and Zephaniah 3:19 use nearly the same words to proclaim a peaceful future for Judah. Furthermore, it is evident that Haggai and Zechariah 1–8 form a unit held together by a system of dates (Hagg 1:1; 2:1, 10, 20; Zech 1:1, 7; 7:1). Zechariah 9–14 and Malachi are bound together by a system of headings that all begin with “Oracle (burden) of the word of YHWH” (Zech 9:1; 12:1; Mal 1:1). Nahum and Habakkuk display a certain symmetry, having psalms at the beginning (Nahum 1) and at the end (Habakkuk 3), with many semantic similarities and oracles against Nineveh (Nahum 2–3) and the Chaldeans (Habakkuk 1–2) in the center. They once could have formed a diptych before they were inserted into the emerging book of the Twelve (Kessler 2006).

Consequently, it is widely accepted that the Twelve were not put together as twelve individual books in one redactional act, but that there must have been smaller collections of two, four, or more books, which successively were combined to eventually form “the Twelve.” However, there is no consensus of what these smaller collections looked like and how they were brought together. According to James Nogalski, two multivolume corpora form the starting point of the collection, the Haggai-Zechariah corpus (Haggai and Zechariah 1–8) and the book of the Four, which he labels as “the Deuteronomistic corpus” (Nogalski 1993a: 278–280). The so-called Joel-related layer combined these two preexisting corpora and merged Joel, Obadiah, Nahum, Habakkuk, and Malachi into them. In a final step, Jonah and Zechariah 9–14 entered the corpus to complete the Book of the Twelve (Nogalski 1993b: 274–279). Aaron Schar (1998) proposes different steps: a book of Two (Hosea and Amos), a book of Four (plus Micah and Zephaniah), a book of Six (plus Nahum and Habakkuk), a book of Eight (plus the Haggai-Zechariah-Corpus), a book of Ten (plus Joel and Obadiah), and eventually the Twelve by the addition of Jonah and Malachi. Jakob Wöhrle accepts some of the results of his predecessors, especially those concerning the beginning of the process of collection.⁶ For the later stages, however, he proposes a model that relies less on the idea of the addition of preexisting books or small corpora and more on the postulation of redactional work that added verses and thus formed different layers. Wöhrle (2008) labels them, among others, as foreign-nations corpus I, foreign-nations corpus II, salvation-for-the-nations corpus, and grace corpus.

Redactional Layers

Even more contested than the identification of precursors to the Twelve is the question of how the redactors worked. Mere juxtaposition is not probable because there are too many unifying elements within the texts. Catchwords are a means of redaction. However, the question is left unanswered of whether these catchwords were already

in the texts before they were brought together, or whether they were formulated for their new context to link books together. Even more difficult to answer is the question of whether we can identify redactional layers running through several books to form a unity.

A possible example of such a layer is the so-called “futility curse” of the natural order being reversed as punishment. It appears in all of the four books of “the Four” (Hos 4:10; Amos 5:11; Mic 6:14–15; Zeph 1:13), and the formulations have certain similarities. “They shall eat, but not be satisfied” (Hos 4:10) is nearly identical with Micah 6:14: “You [m. sg.] shall eat, but not be satisfied.” “You have built houses of hewn stone, but shall not live in them” (Amos 5:11) is repeated in Zephaniah 1:13: “They build houses, but shall not live in them.” These similarities in concept and semantics could indeed be the result of intentional redactional activity to unite the four individual books on a certain level (Schart 1998: 218). However, there is no proof beyond all doubt of intentional activity. Futility curses are well known in ancient Near Eastern literature, and they also appear in Leviticus 26:26 (“though you eat, you shall not be satisfied”) and Deuteronomy 28:30 (“you shall build a house, but not live in it”). The formulations within the Four could be taken from the curses in Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 28, but they could also be part of a shared concept known to the authors of Hosea, Amos, Micah, and Zephaniah without mutual influence.

Methodological difficulties are even greater when we consider not only a few isolated sentences but elaborated concepts. Wöhrle (2008: 173–189), who defends a sophisticated concept of redactional layers running through the book of the Twelve, proposes, among others, a layer of Davidic promises consisting of Amos 9:11, 12b; Micah 4:8; 5:1, 3*; Zechariah 9:9–10. The first problem with the alleged layer is that there are almost no similarities between these verses, either in semantics or in content. Furthermore, other prophetic books outside the Twelve also contain Davidic promises (Isa 9:1–6; 11:1–5; Jer 23:5–6; 33:15–16; Ezek 34:23–24; 37:24–25). Some of the texts from the Twelve display closer similarities with these texts outside the Twelve than among themselves. So the word *mæmlākāh* (“kingdom”) is used exclusively in Isaiah 9:6 (Engl. 9:7) and Micah 4:8. The idea of going back to the very beginnings of the house of David, namely to the “stock of Jesse,” David’s father, or to David’s hometown, Bethlehem, is shared by Isaiah 11:1 and Micah 5:1 only. The root *ts-d-q* “righteous/righteousness,” which within the Twelve is unique in Zechariah 9:9, is very prominent outside the Twelve, namely in Jeremiah 23:5–6 and 33:15–16. Wöhrle himself is aware of the problem and admits that the promises within the Twelve could be independent insertions, rather than a redaction covering the whole book.

A look at the book of Malachi can illustrate the problem. Earlier I have mentioned that Malachi is written in the knowledge of (most of) the other books of the Twelve. This is true. However, Malachi also relies on a bulk of other texts from the Torah (compare Mal 1:6–2:9 with Ex 34:6; Lev 22:17–25; Num 6:23–27; Deut 15:21; 28) and other prophets (compare the Edom oracle in Mal 1:2–5 with Isa 34; Jer 49:13–22; Ezek 25; 35; Joel 4:19 [Engl. 3:19]; and Obadiah). Examples could be multiplied.⁷ They demonstrate that Malachi’s allusions are not restricted to the Twelve but cover the canon of Torah and

prophets. The same is true for the majority of the layers that allegedly link the Twelve together: they are not exclusively restricted to the Twelve.

To summarize, it is obvious that there are redactions which cover more than one prophetic book. In later texts, also, clear allusions to texts from the Torah can be found. However, it is methodologically very difficult and often impossible to identify a redaction that exclusively covers only the Twelve. The possibility to read the Twelve as a unity in a reader-oriented approach does not imply the proof of a redaction that intentionally brought the twelve books together.

READING STRATEGIES

This leads to the question of how the Twelve should be read. Scholars discuss whether they should be read as “Twelve Prophetic Books or The Twelve,”⁸ that is, whether they form a unity or instead are to be considered as a mere anthology. In my view, the alternatives are not as polarized as they may seem. Every book of the Twelve can be read as an individual unit that makes sense in itself. But when read in context, it is possible to accumulate more sense. Even the different sequences of the books in the Masoretic and Greek traditions offer the chance to generate a variety of meaningful readings.

Like the book of Isaiah, the Twelve cover a period of prophecy from the monarchical period through the Hellenistic era. However, the methodological challenge is different. In the case of Isaiah, readers have to understand the unity of history that covers some centuries, but is revealed by God through a “vision” seen by a prophet of the eighth century B.C.E. (Isa 1:1). The Twelve, on the other hand, are a compendium of twelve individual books that cover nearly the same time span. Like Isaiah, the twelve prophets speak in the name of one God, the God of Israel. In their case, however, it is the reader’s task to discern the unity of God’s message within different individual voices at different times and in different places. Reading the Twelve demands holding together unity *and* variety, or better, holding together unity *in* variety and plurality.

NOTES

1. Cf. Nogalski 1993a: 20–57 (“The Catchword Phenomenon”).
2. Nogalski (1993a: 57) notes that “the [Greek] translators exhibit no cognizance of these words as a unifying technique in the compilation of the Book of the Twelve.”
3. For Beck 2005, it is the only theme that really holds the Twelve together; cf. 318–322.
4. For a short outline of this theology, cf. Rendtorff 2000.
5. The last examples are quoted from Kessler 2012: 232.
6. Wöhrle (2006) accepts as first collections the Book of the Four and the Haggai-Zechariah-corpus, while his conception of the Joel-corpus differs from Nogalski’s “Joel-related layer.”
7. Cf. Weyde 2000.
8. To quote the title of the contribution of Ben Zvi 1996.

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CHAPTER 13

DANIEL AND APOCALYPTIC IMAGINATION

ANATHEA E. PORTIER-YOUNG

COMBINING story, vision, prayer, and discourse, the book of Daniel forms a bridge between Israel's classical prophetic literature and two characteristic genres of Hellenistic Jewish literature: apocalypse and novella. While the ancient Greek versions of Daniel more closely approximate the genre of novella, the Hebrew and Aramaic version preserved in the Hebrew Bible is more properly classified as an apocalypse and represents one of the earliest extant examples of this literary genre. In each version, the book is deeply rooted in Israel's prophetic tradition and consciously sets out to interpret earlier prophetic texts, including the scroll of Jeremiah. At the same time, Daniel testifies to the influence of, and offers a response to, Mesopotamian culture and mantic arts. It also offers a challenge to the Hellenistic empires that inherited these and similar forms of knowledge. For the book of Daniel, interpretation, vision, and literary creation are acts of resistance, encouragement, and hope. The Hebrew and Aramaic book of Daniel consciously reshapes earlier literary forms in a new political moment to transform the imaginations of its readers and hearers. The book's prophetic and apocalyptic dimensions make specific claims about knowledge and power that aim to disrupt and deny the hegemony of empire, affirm the sovereign providence of the God of the Jews, and empower the book's audience for the work of teaching and witness. The Greek versions transpose the book's apocalyptic elements into yet another key. The attention is turned inward toward the reading community. In the process, older prophetic traditions and mantic wisdom provide a resource to guide the reading community, shaping its leadership in the face of internal conflict and offering models of wise discernment, courage, virtue, and piety in ever new cultural settings.

This chapter does not provide an overview of the book of Daniel. Rather, in keeping with the theme of this volume and the title of the chapter, it first addresses the relationship between Daniel and prophetic literature, then explores the nature and function of Daniel's apocalyptic imagination. The chapter focuses mainly on the Hebrew and Aramaic version of Daniel.

DANIEL AND PROPHETIC LITERATURE

Is Daniel Prophetic Literature?

Some ancient sources named Daniel among the prophets. At Qumran, a fragmentary text known as 4QFlorilegium, commonly dated to the late first century B.C.E., introduces quotations from Daniel 12:10 (cf. 11:35) and 11:32 as “written in the scroll of Daniel the prophet” (4Q174 II.3–4). The portion of commentary in which these quotations appear is given the label “midrash”; it interprets the prophecies it contains according to their significance for its contemporary audience. That is, for the author of 4QFlorilegium, the prophetic-apocalyptic discourse in Daniel 11–12 describes events that are happening or are about to happen in the author’s own time. Daniel spoke true prophecy for the author’s own generation and community.

The first-century C.E. Jewish historian Josephus also calls Daniel a prophet, on three occasions. Josephus’s lengthy retelling of the Hebrew Scriptures weaves Daniel’s story into a longer account of Judean history. Here Daniel’s story follows closely upon that of the prophet Jeremiah. In retelling Daniel 4, Josephus hints at Daniel’s status as prophet: “as he foretold, so it came to pass” (*Antiquities* 10.217). His retelling of Daniel 5, meanwhile, highlights the convergence in Daniel of two sources of knowledge: wisdom and divine revelation (10.241). In this episode, the Babylonian king Belshazzar considers Daniel a “foreteller of misfortune” and “prophet” after Daniel has interpreted the writing on the wall as foretelling the end of his own kingdom and life (10.246). In narrating the scene that follows, Josephus himself refers to “Daniel the prophet,” marking a subtle shift in the narrative presentation of Daniel. Later Josephus praises Daniel’s gift of prophecy in effusive terms, stating that Daniel “was so happy as to have strange revelations made to him, and those as to one of the greatest of the prophets” (10.266),

for the various books that he wrote and left behind him are still read by us till this time; and from them we believe that Daniel conversed with God; for he did not only prophesy of future events, as did the other prophets, but he also determined the time of their accomplishment; and while prophets used to foretell misfortunes, and on that account were disagreeable both to the kings and to the multitude, Daniel was to them a prophet of good things, and this to such a degree, that, by the agreeable nature of his predictions, he procured the goodwill of all men; and by the accomplishment of them, he procured the belief of their truth, and the opinion of [a sort of] divinity for himself among the multitude. (10.267–268; trans. Whiston)

For Josephus, the vision Daniel receives in Daniel 10 guarantees the accuracy and truth of Daniel’s prophetic predictions (10.269). Here Josephus considers the angelic mediation that is characteristic of apocalyptic literature to be a marker of prophetic authenticity: Daniel’s apocalyptic discourse is more easily recognized as true prophecy because of its angelic source (cf. Maimonides, *Guide to the Perplexed* II. 41, 1963: 386).

Finally, in the Gospel of Matthew, Jesus calls Daniel a prophet. Jesus's "apocalyptic" discourse in Matthew's gospel, like its parallel in Mark 13, contains numerous allusions to the book of Daniel (e.g., Dan 7:13–14; 12:1, 12). Through these allusions, the language and imagery of Daniel are recast and reinterpreted as applying to a future time whose date is not yet known (Matt 24:36). One of the signs that the time of crisis has arrived will be the appearance of the "desolating sacrilege standing in the holy place, as was spoken of by the prophet Daniel (let the reader understand)" (Matt 24:15). Daniel's predictions thus hold a key to discerning the dawning of the messianic kingdom.

The testimonies of 4Q174, Josephus, and Matthew notwithstanding, within the modern Jewish Bible, or TaNaK, Daniel holds a place not among the *Nevi'im*, or "Prophets," but within the canonical division traditionally called *Ketuvim*, or "Writings." This classification follows the shape of the canon preserved in the medieval Masoretic text of the Hebrew Bible that is canonical for Jews today, and is similarly reflected in the declaration of Maimonides that "our people have registered a unanimous consensus that Daniel belongs among the books of the writings and not among the true prophetic books" (II. 45, author's translation). Although Maimonides calls Daniel a prophet (II. 41; 1963: 385), he clarifies that Daniel is not a prophet like Isaiah, Jeremiah, or Nathan, but is a prophet of the same order as Solomon, with whom God also communicated in a dream (II. 45; 1963: 399–400). For Maimonides, the distinction is one of degree.

When such a consensus may have been reached remains a matter of debate. Some have argued that Daniel's exclusion from the prophetic corpus within rabbinic Judaism may owe to the book's second-century B.C.E. date. Evidence from the book of Sirach, while not definitive, has been interpreted to signal that a "closed" canonical list of prophetic books was already known by the beginning of the second century B.C.E. (Sir 49:9). By this reasoning, a work written after that date would not be added to the existing list of Prophets, regardless of perceived continuity with that literary corpus, but would instead be included in the still developing collection of Writings.

Klaus Koch, by contrast, argues that within rabbinic Judaism, Daniel was originally part of the prophetic corpus, but was reassigned from the Prophets to the Writings following the second Jewish revolt against Rome (1985: 123). Koch's argument highlights the starkly political nature of Daniel's apocalyptic prophecies and their close link with Judean resistance to imperial rule. According to this hypothesis, transferring Daniel from the prophetic books to the Writings would have tempered its call to resistance and, within Jewish tradition, discouraged ongoing reinterpretation and application of Daniel's prophecy to new historical moments. At the same time, the book's inclusion among the Writings within Jewish tradition further highlights the distinctive character of Daniel, for its apocalyptic literary form and emphases render it both like and unlike the major prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel and the so-called minor prophets collected in the Book of the Twelve.

Contemporary Christian Bibles, by contrast, follow in varying degrees the canonical shape preserved in ancient witnesses to the Septuagint, a longer and more porous collection of Greek scriptures that included works translated from Hebrew as well as original Greek compositions. In the ancient period, Septuagint scriptures were

authoritative for many Greek-speaking Jews and Christians. Although the Septuagint is not considered authoritative for modern Jews, the Septuagint has provided the basis for the canonical lists and ordering of books in later Catholic and Greek Orthodox Bibles and, to an extent, those in other Orthodox Christian Bibles (e.g., Ethiopian and Russian Orthodox). Although canonical ordering and divisions among the major witnesses to the Septuagint vary, four ancient canonical divisions became standard in Christian Bibles, namely Laws, Histories, Poetic Books, and Prophets or Prophecies. Among these canonical divisions, Daniel was included in the Prophets or Prophecies. In Codices Alexandrinus and Vaticanus, Daniel follows Ezekiel and is the final book of the Prophets; in Codex Vaticanus, it is also the final book of the Old Testament. This placement highlights Daniel's function as a bridge or portal between genres, testaments, and imagined worlds. In most English Christian Bibles today, Daniel is likewise included among the prophets, where it follows the book of Ezekiel. This close canonical pairing of Daniel and Ezekiel recognizes their common sixth-century B.C.E. Babylonian setting as well as shared visionary elements, which I explore further later in the chapter.

To the question of whether Daniel is prophetic literature, the answer of tradition is thus mixed: yes and no. It is not simply a question of literary form. As noted earlier, Daniel is distinctive for its balance of stories, visions, and discourse and its creative use and shaping of new apocalyptic forms. Yet, among other prophetic books, no one literary form defines the corpus. Some prophetic books are predominantly poetry, others balance poetry with narrative; one is predominantly story, others use an elevated prose style. Proto-apocalyptic features, such as vision reports and expectations of dramatic divine intervention that transforms the known world, emerge within the books of Isaiah, Ezekiel, Joel, and Zechariah. Daniel demonstrates continuity and discontinuity with these earlier prophetic books, making them both familiar and radically new.

Revelation, Knowing, and Textual Authority in Daniel

The book of Daniel is set in Babylonia in the sixth century B.C.E., spanning the reign of four kings, three Babylonian and one Persian. In the book, the exiled Judean Daniel is the protagonist of several stories narrated in the third person and a set of visions narrated in first person. In the stories, Daniel is portrayed as possessing uncommon knowledge and understanding. In the tale that introduces the Hebrew and Aramaic version of the book, the young captive Daniel and his three friends submit to three years of training within the Babylonian educational system, where they learn the language and literature of the Babylonian culture (Daniel 1). This narrative portrayal of acculturation paints a picture in which Judean and Babylonian traditions meet in the formation of Daniel and his friends. The tale does not further specify the content of the curriculum they learn. Nonetheless, Daniel's engagement and competition with the Babylonian practitioners of mantic arts in chapters 2 and 4 suggest that the curriculum includes some introduction to the Babylonian divinatory tradition.

In the course of their study and owing to their embodied commitment to their native traditions, Daniel and his three friends receive a divinely granted gift of “knowledge and skill in every aspect of literature (*sēpher*) and wisdom; Daniel also had insight into all visions and dreams” (1:17). The knowledge they receive sets them apart, both from their Judean companions and from other (presumably Babylonian as well as more broadly international) students in their peer group (Dan 1:17). Daniel’s knowledge and wisdom impress his king and prison guard, setting the stage for subsequent tales in which Daniel’s knowledge will enable him to interpret dreams and writing, save the lives of other mantic practitioners, and foretell the humbling of Babylon’s king and the end of the kingdom itself (Dan 2, 4, and 5).

In chapters 7–12, Daniel is no longer the interpreter, but is instead the seer. He does not understand the visions he sees or the text he reads; he relies instead on the interpretation and revelation provided by angelic interlocutors. The pairing of revealed wisdom and dream interpretation in the court tales of Daniel 1–6 in some ways prepares the reader for Daniel’s apocalyptic visions and the angelic interpretations and discourses that accompany them in chapters 7–12. Yet Daniel’s shift from interpreter to recipient of interpretation heralds a new epistemology: Heavenly knowledge must be conveyed by heavenly agents.

The book’s distinctive revelatory forms have features in common with classical Israelite prophecy and reports of theophanies and angelophanies. They also share features with Babylonian divinatory wisdom (such as dream interpretation) and even Persian traditions preserved in later literature. Is Daniel’s knowledge the same kind of knowledge that Israel’s prophets had? Does it reflect a new synthesis of Israelite and Babylonian forms? Daniel 2:21, 23, and 5:14 emphasize the divine origin of the wisdom that enables Daniel to interpret dreams and writing, and portray Daniel as a divinely authorized messenger of revelation to the kings of Babylon. Attention to references to writing in the book of Daniel clarifies the book’s understanding of the relationships among earlier prophetic literature, the knowledge revealed to Daniel, and Mesopotamian divinatory traditions.

After its initial use in 1:17, the Hebrew noun *sēpher*, properly a scroll but frequently translated as “book” or “literature,” occurs three other times in Daniel (9:2; 12:1, 4). In 9:2, speaking in the first person, Daniel reports that he “understood” or “discerned” (*bînōti*; OG *dienoēthēn*; TH *sunēken*; based upon the narrative that follows, NAB construes the verb as conative, “tried to understand”) “in the scrolls the number of years that was the word of the LORD to Jeremiah the prophet to fulfill the desolation of Jerusalem—seventy years” (9:2). Jeremiah had decreed seventy years for Judah’s desolation and exile in Babylon, followed by restoration (Jer 25:11–12; 29:10). Daniel’s confusion results from cognitive dissonance as he tries to reconcile what he has read in Jeremiah’s scroll with what he has seen in the visions reported in chapters 7 and 8. Jeremiah prophesied a limited period of foreign domination, followed by restoration and independence. Daniel has already experienced the first desolation of Jerusalem. Now he sees a future of repeated subjugation, stretching long past Jeremiah’s seventy years and culminating in a second desolation exceeding the first. The conflict between prophetic tradition and visionary experience requires new interpretation.

In the narrative that follows, Daniel engages in prayer, fasting, and mourning for a period of three weeks (9:3–21; cf. 10:2–3). This activity may have been a form of mantic or mystical preparation for seeking a revelation or vision. Daniel then reports that the “man” Gabriel appeared to him “to give wisdom and understanding” (*lěhaskilēka bināh* 9:21). Specifically, Gabriel offers a new interpretation of Jeremiah’s seventy years as “weeks” of years (9:24) divided into periods. The angel’s revelation predicts the rebuilding of Jerusalem, the cutting off of an anointed one, a second destruction of Jerusalem and its sanctuary, war, and desolation (9:25–27). In this case, “wisdom and understanding” are tantamount to revealed interpretation of an earlier prophetic text, imparted by an angelic mediator.

Four details illuminate the relation between Daniel’s apocalyptic imagination, the book’s portrait of divinely granted knowledge, and the earlier prophetic tradition in chapter 9:

1. The prophetic text is treated as an authoritative source of revealed knowledge.
2. New revelation in the form of visions creates cognitive dissonance that precipitates a need for the reinterpretation of earlier prophecy.
3. The new interpretation, or “understanding,” arises through angelic revelation.
4. The angelic revelation is precipitated through study of the prophetic text, ascetic practice, and prayer.

The date of composition is important for understanding what kind of “wisdom and understanding” this revelation offers to the *audience* of Daniel. Scholarly consensus locates the composition of the final form of the Hebrew and Aramaic book of Daniel around the year 165 B.C.E. At this time, Judeans were victims of state terror, military occupation, and religious persecution at the hands of the Seleucid empire (Portier-Young 2011). The temple had again been assaulted and profaned and its sacrifices had ceased. The revealed reinterpretation of Jeremiah’s seventy years allows Jeremiah’s text to speak to the fears and suffering of Daniel’s second-century Judean audience. In actualizing this earlier prophetic text through new revelation, the book of Daniel thus asserts that earlier prophecy remains relevant to new circumstances and addresses them directly, but angelic interpretation is required to understand its meaning in the new context. The wisdom and understanding granted to Daniel include knowledge for the audience about the events they are experiencing and their imminent resolution. This new understanding of Jeremiah’s prophecy provides a wider frame for current events, revealing God’s plan to deliver God’s people and the activity of holy angels who fight against the oppressing Seleucid king and his armies.

Written texts also hold special authority in chapters 10 and 12, but here they are not earlier prophetic scrolls but heavenly writings (Baynes 2011). At the beginning of chapter 10, the narrator reports that Daniel received a true word and understanding of the word in “the vision” (*mar’eh* 10:1). Daniel then reports that a man (*ish*; in 10:18 he is “one that appears [*kěmar’eh*] human”) appears to him. The man explains his mission to Daniel by reference to a “book (*kětab*) of truth” (10:21). The truth that the man then reveals to Daniel includes predictions regarding battles to come, the fate of empires, the persecution that

will befall his people, deliverance at the hands of Michael, and the resurrection, reward, and punishment of some of those who have died. Leslie Baynes categorizes this “book of truth” as a book of fate (2011: 127, 131). She notes that Daniel has no direct access to it, and thus cannot read it himself. Instead, its contents are revealed to him in his vision of the man. Thus, apocalyptic visionary experience provides access to knowledge contained in a heavenly book. At the conclusion of this speech, the man refers to those among Daniel’s people who are “written in the book” (*sēpher* 12:1). According to Baynes, this is yet another book, not the book of truth, but a book of life, similar to those in Exodus 32:32–33 and Isaiah 4:3, each “a metaphorical application of a citizenship list” that confers heavenly citizenship (2011: 71–73). At the end of his discourse, the man instructs Daniel to “keep the words secret and the book sealed” until the end-time (12:4). Here the man refers to yet another book: the book of Daniel. While each writing referred to in the man’s discourse is distinct, they partake of a common authority: the angel conveys the contents of the book of truth to Daniel, and Daniel records them in his own book. Knowledge of the book of life is similarly guaranteed by the man’s truthful testimony and conveyed through Daniel’s book.

The close connection between the prophecy of Jeremiah in 9:2 and the man’s interpreting revelation in chapters 10–12 establishes continuity and difference between Daniel’s apocalyptic visions and the existing record of prophetic revelation. It also authorizes a new scripture that takes up, transposes, and supplements the earlier prophetic text. On its own, Jeremiah’s text is opaque to even the most devout reader. It can be understood only in the light of the scroll of truth, the contents of which the man reveals to Daniel. The contents of the book of truth, and by extension of Daniel’s final vision, also go far beyond the scope of Jeremiah’s prediction, culminating not only in the restoration of a battered people but in the resurrection of their dead. Without the angelic visitation, Daniel would not have access to the contents of this heavenly scroll or to the meaning of the earthly one. Inquiry into the prophetic text precipitates the vision, while the vision provides the hermeneutical key for understanding and extending the prophetic text.

The Aramaic cognate to *sēpher* is found in Daniel 7:10, providing one additional reference to “scrolls” (*sīphrîn*). At the hour of judgment against the beasts, or empires, scrolls are opened before the throne of the one like an ancient of days. These scrolls likely hold a record of the deeds, judgment, and fate of the four kingdoms.

By contrast with these scrolls and books, the “literature” of the Chaldeans is not mentioned again after Daniel 1:4. The reader is thus invited to perceive a superficial similarity but a difference in kind—only the knowledge revealed by God and God’s heavenly agents is authoritative and true.

The Relation between “Mantic,” “Divinatory,” or “Revealed” Wisdom, Biblical Prophecy, and Apocalyptic Literature

Scholars have attempted to map the relationship between the modes of knowing in Daniel and those of prophetic and wisdom traditions in ancient Israel and Judah. The strong influence of earlier prophetic traditions on the book of Daniel and the book’s

emphasis on revealed knowledge suggest that Daniel grows in part from a prophetic seedbed. Yet Gerhard von Rad pointed out that in the book of Daniel, the protagonist is not called a prophet but is repeatedly characterized as possessing wisdom. Von Rad argued instead that Daniel represented an eschatological shift within Israel's wisdom tradition (Von Rad 1965: 2.303–307; Goff 2014: 58). Hans-Peter Müller offered a more nuanced hypothesis that characterized the understanding of “wisdom” and its synonyms (such as “knowledge” and “understanding”) in the book of Daniel as “mantic” or “divinatory” wisdom (Müller 1972). For Müller, this theory accounted for key features of apocalyptic imagination, including apocalyptic determinism and symbolism.

For James VanderKam, however, Daniel's emphasis on revealed or divinatory wisdom did not distance the book from prophetic traditions (VanderKam 2000a, originally published 1986). VanderKam emphasized the link between mantic or divinatory wisdom and prophecy, and cautioned against distinguishing them too sharply. VanderKam pointed out that Akkadian prophetic texts that have been compared to Jewish apocalypses may have been influenced by both divinatory wisdom and prophetic traditions (2000a: 247–248). Biblical literature similarly reveals a close link between divination and prophecy (Deut 13:1–6; 18:15–22; Num 12:6; Mic 3:5–6; Jer 14:14; 27:9–10; 29:8–9; Ezek 13:1–9, 17–23; analyzed in VanderKam 2002a: 252–253). While these biblical passages uniformly condemn the activity they call divination, including divination through dreams and visions, they nonetheless attribute this activity to individuals called “prophets” and/or list this activity as a close parallel to authorized prophecy. VanderKam argued that, in exploring the connection between prophecy and apocalyptic literature or between prophecy and divination,

the term prophecy should not be limited to what the few great literary prophets taught or did. Israelite or Judean prophecy was a far broader phenomenon that included not only their efforts but also late prophecy, of course, and an unavoidable mantic element. Prophecy in this wider sense was probably the decisive stimulus in the evolution of apocalyptic thought. (2000a: 254)

More recently, Andreas Bedenbender has rejected the label “mantic wisdom” for Daniel and the more or less contemporary apocalyptic text, *1 Enoch*, arguing that the books' heroes do not engage in the type of ritualized activities, such as haruspicy, that are characteristic of Mesopotamian mantic arts. Bedenbender proposes instead a designation used earlier by Randall Argall, namely “revealed wisdom.” This designation aims to distinguish the book of Daniel from both Mesopotamian forms and classical Israelite wisdom traditions. Instead, through an emphasis on revealed knowledge, the link between the book of Daniel and Israel's prophetic traditions becomes more readily apparent (Bedenbender 2008).

Lester Grabbe introduces cross-cultural social-scientific evidence into the debate. Grabbe observes a close connection between “prophecy, apocalyptic, and mantic wisdom” within ancient and modern pre-industrial societies, and notes that one practitioner may engage in all three (2003: 118–119). Grabbe locates all three phenomena

under the wider umbrella of divination. Grabbe's proposal has been challenged by Collins, who argues that, with respect to the literary evidence, the more appropriate broader category is not divination but revelatory literature, while the corresponding activities would best be grouped together under the broader category of "intermediation," as proposed by Robert Wilson. Among forms of revelatory literature, Israelite prophecy and apocalypse are distinguished in part by their eschatology. Apocalyptic eschatology expects individual judgment after death; Daniel 12 exemplifies this distinctive feature (Collins 2003: 50; cf. Flannery-Dailey 2004: 276–277).

This survey highlights that the categories of prophecy, mantic or revealed wisdom, divination, and apocalyptic revelation are closely associated, permeable to one another, and therefore difficult to distinguish in absolute terms. Precision in terminology and categories is important. At the same time, perceiving the nexus of relationships may be equally important to locating Daniel within one or another category.

The Relation between Apocalyptic Visionary Experience and Symbolic Visions to Classical Prophecy

In light of this chapter's focus on apocalyptic imagination, the relationships between Daniel's apocalyptic visionary experience and symbolic visions, on the one hand, and classical prophecy, on the other, merit further attention here. Frances Flannery emphasizes the role of genuine visionary experience in the development of apocalyptic literature and imagination (Flannery-Dailey 2004: 153–164). As Christopher Rowland has argued, apocalyptic visionary experience is not idiosyncratic or entirely novel, but is shaped by shared practices, including habitual reading of scripture. Earlier prophetic vision reports such as Isaiah 6 and Ezekiel 1 help the seer to imagine the heavenly realm and its inhabitants, providing detail regarding visual, auditory, and other embodied sensations (e.g., strength or weakness, shaking) that may provide a basis for the seer's own experience (Rowland 2006: 47–48).

For example, the throne vision in Daniel 7 builds on earlier throne visions experienced by Isaiah and Ezekiel. While neither of the earlier visions provides a precise template for Daniel's experience, they provide a visual, sensory, and symbolic lexicon for experiencing and narrating such a vision. Isaiah beholds the LORD of hosts seated in glory on a high throne and surrounded by heavenly creatures who lift their voices in worship. Isaiah describes sights and sounds, shaking architecture, air filled with smoke, the touch of a heavenly creature, and his own vocal response (Isa 6:1–8). Ezekiel describes cloud, brightness, and flashing fire, a mysterious throne, its movement, roaring sound, a voice, and one like a human. Ezekiel further describes his response to the vision, not with speech, like Isaiah, but in his body: he falls on his face, until a spirit enters him and places him on his feet (Ezekiel 1). A comparison between these visions and Daniel 7 suggests that the seer(s) who penned the latter vision had meditated on the earlier biblical throne vision reports, finding in them prompts for their own visionary experience and prophetic-apocalyptic imagination. The report of Daniel's embodied experiences later

in the book (e.g., 10:15–17) highlights further ways in which Ezekiel's vision report may have shaped the visionary experience described in Daniel.

It is also frequently noted that the symbolic visions of Daniel have partial roots in the symbolic visions of earlier prophets, including those found in Amos, Jeremiah, and Zechariah. In the book of Amos, the Lord GOD shows Amos three visions. The first two are “moving pictures” portraying God's activity: in one, God forms a swarm of locusts that then eat the land's vegetation, and in the other, God summons a fire that rains upon the earth, devouring the deep and eating the land (Amos 7:1–4). Neither vision requires interpretation. Amos understands them as visions of imminent divine judgment against God's people and responds by interceding on their behalf (7:2–3; 7:5–6). The third vision—a plumb line in the LORD's hand—is more static, and marks a point at which the prophet is no longer able to intervene. Instead, the LORD follows this vision with an oracle of destruction against Israel's high places and the house of its king (7:8–9).

In Jeremiah, the LORD asks the prophet what he sees. When Jeremiah responds that he sees first an almond branch (1:11), and second a “boiling pot, tilted away from the North” (1:13), the LORD responds in each case with an oracle. In the first case, a shared consonantal root facilitates wordplay between the object in the vision and the corresponding oracle. Through this wordplay, the branch's capacity to flower and bear fruit is made to symbolize the LORD's vigilance in performing the word that the LORD has declared (Jer 1:11–16). The oracular interpretation of the second vision relies on a mixture of metaphor and visual detail to portray the armies of tribes from the north pouring forth in tumult to wage war on the cities of Judah.

In some of these early symbolic visions, an oracle is made memorable and given emotive force, both positive and negative, through a single image. These demonstrate the capacity of a divine interlocutor to make future events visible to the seer or prophet in symbolic form and represent an early stage in the development of a visionary imagination among Israel's prophets. Other visions dramatize imminent events, allowing the seer to witness their unfolding. Like Daniel, Amos experiences significant distress when he is shown the events to come.

In Zechariah's symbolic visions, the prophet has multiple interlocutors, first an angel, then the LORD, and listens while they speak to one another as well as to him. In one case, as in Jeremiah 1:11, the “word of the LORD” precipitates the vision (Zech 1:7). At times the angel asks Zechariah, “What do you see?” (4:2; 5:1); at other times Zechariah asks the angel to explain to him what he has seen (1:9, 18; 4:4; 6:4). Zechariah's visions are more complex and numerous than those of Amos or Jeremiah, though not yet as complex or lengthy as those in Daniel. Like Daniel, Zechariah does not hesitate to confess that he does not understand what he sees (4:5). This comparison reveals continuity between the symbolic visions of earlier prophets and those in the book of Daniel, while also testifying to a development from simple to complex visions and more transparent symbolism to more obscure. The role of the interpreting angel in Zechariah 1–6 marks an important development in the progression from prophetic to apocalyptic modes of knowing.

Apocalyptic Prophecy

These visions in Zechariah are commonly included among prophetic passages regarded as “proto-apocalyptic” texts, so called because they share features with early Jewish apocalypses such as Daniel. These shared features variously include eschatological visions and discourses, mythical cosmic imagery, angelic mediation, and temporal and moral dualism. At the same time, these prophetic texts do not properly fit the literary genre of apocalypse and likely precede the book of Daniel and other early Jewish apocalypses. Imagery, motifs, and even language from several of these texts are taken up in later apocalyptic literature. For this reason, proto-apocalyptic texts are seen as a bridge between classical biblical prophecy and apocalyptic literature and illuminate the history of ideas and forms that leads from one to the other.

Prophetic texts commonly identified as proto-apocalyptic include portions of the book of Ezekiel (esp. 37–38), Isaiah 24–27, Joel, and Zechariah (Cook 1995). One early example, Ezekiel 37–38, employs earlier, mythical divine-warrior traditions to portray a future battle (it will take place in “the latter years” or “the latter days” [38:8, 16]) in which supernatural divine forces defeat the assembled enemy, who is identified as Gog. As Stephen Cook notes, the battle is portrayed as a decisive cosmic event that “inaugurates a future age” (1995: 88–90). It is distinguished from earlier prophetic texts by its universal emphasis, expectation of a radical temporal juncture, and portrayal of a “moral dualism” in which the embattled cosmic forces represent good and evil, order and chaos (1995: 90–94). Cook argues that these chapters are integral to the book as a whole, illuminating the (partial) origins of apocalyptic literature and thought within the priestly-prophetic traditions and social settings of mainstream Judaism. Cook’s analysis helps locate Daniel’s own apocalypticism not at the fringes of Judean culture of the second century B.C.E., as had previously been argued, but much closer to its heart.

APOCALYPTIC IMAGINATION

The inclusion of a chapter on Daniel’s apocalyptic imagination in a volume on prophetic literature owes in no small measure to the influence of two scholars, Walter Brueggemann and John J. Collins. In 1978, Brueggemann published a concise but important book entitled *The Prophetic Imagination* (Brueggemann 2001). Here Brueggemann recognized the political nature of Israel’s prophetic literature. But he also distanced Israel’s prophecy from calls for social action. Instead, he highlighted the role of imagination. Linguistic and epistemological dimensions of Israel’s prophetic literature were a key to establishing or awakening consciousness (2001: 21). Brueggemann characterized two competing modes of consciousness: the royal and the prophetic. In this schema, the royal consciousness funds the dominant culture. It underwrites and is supported by exploitation, control, and stasis. It colonizes the imagination of royal subjects so that it becomes difficult to conceive of an alternative. Prophetic imagination counters royal

consciousness. Lament names the distance between royal narrative and collective experience and allows the people to feel again. New language, song, and imagery of hope make it possible to envision an alternative way. Absurd obedience embodies this new reality and brings attention to a power greater than the ruling state (Brueggemann 2001: xv).

In the preface to the revised edition of *Prophetic Imagination*, Brueggemann quotes the work of Frederick Asals on Flannery O'Connor's "Imagination of Extremity" (2001: xiv–xv). For Asals, the "prophetic mind" enables a return to reality, a reawakening of the senses to contingency, suffering, and God (Asals 2007: 221). Brueggemann further characterizes communities that are likely to generate prophecy as ones with a deep fund of memory, public consciousness of pain, communal practices of hope, and a distinctive, coded mode of discourse (Brueggemann 2001: xvi). These characteristics of a community might equally generate apocalyptic imagination, discourse, and literature. While many features distinguish apocalyptic from prophetic imagination and literature, they also hold much in common.

Six years later, John J. Collins's influential book *The Apocalyptic Imagination: An Introduction to Jewish Apocalyptic Literature* prompted a new generation of scholars to take more seriously the logic and aims of a much-maligned literary corpus. Building on his earlier work, Collins's book focused on "apocalypse" as a literary genre. For Collins, the genre's formal features signaled an intensified concern with epistemology, while also expanding the horizon of earlier prophetic literature to encompass cosmic geography, the sweep of history, a future beyond empires, and life beyond death. While Collins did not define apocalyptic imagination as such, from the extant examples of the genre apocalypse, Collins derived characteristics of a distinctive apocalyptic worldview or "conceptual framework." This worldview, according to Collins, entails

basic presuppositions about the way the world works, which are shared by all apocalypses. Specifically, the world is mysterious and revelation must be transmitted from a supernatural source, through the mediation of angels; there is a hidden world of angels and demons that is directly relevant to human destiny; and this destiny is finally determined by a definitive eschatological judgment. (1998: 8)

Among the apocalypses from which Collins derives this worldview, Daniel holds a special place, as it is the only example within the Hebrew Bible and one of the oldest exemplars of the genre. The features identified by Collins are especially prominent in chapters 7–12. Yet they are adumbrated in Daniel's divinely granted gift of wisdom and understanding in literature and dream interpretation in chapter 1, the revelation of the king's dream in chapter 2, the watcher's decree of judgment in chapter 4, and the mysterious writing that spells the end of an empire in chapter 5.

In addition to identifying the key features of an apocalyptic conceptual framework, Collins also explores the expressive character of apocalyptic language and symbolism, which may also be considered central components of the apocalyptic imagination (1998: 282). By pushing the limits of language, apocalyptic writers are able to stretch the

imagination beyond what is ordinarily visible and sensible. They push readers to see, hear, taste, smell, and touch a transcendent reality and a future world order radically different from that of the present. This perception of a world beyond and a world transformed conditions actions and choices in the present.

Developing Collins's insights further, Jin Hee Han's study of Daniel's apocalyptic language describes an "alternative literacy" that summons readers to "dream of a world radically different from the status quo" in order to "revise the way of life, the way of perception, and the way of existence" (Han 2008: 7, 113). That is, the seer invites the reading community not only to dream this alternative world, but to inhabit it (86). Han argues that Daniel offers its readers a *paideia*—education, formation—that counters the *paid-eia* of the dominant Hellenistic culture (39–48).

The comparison with Hellenistic *paideia* emphasizes that apocalyptic imagination was shaped not only by the revelation of heavenly mysteries but also by bodily disciplines, including, for some, practices like those described in Daniel 1 and 9. As biblical scholars increasingly attend to religious experience behind, within, and in front of the texts we study (see, for example, Stone 1974; Flannery, Shantz, and Werline 2008; Shantz and Werline 2012; the Society of Biblical Literature unit on Religious Experience in Antiquity) and simultaneously engage with emerging studies of embodied cognition (Shapiro 2010, 2014; see three SBL units: Bible and Emotion; Mind, Society, and Religion in the Biblical World; and Senses and Culture in the Biblical World), it becomes clear that apocalyptic imagination is not simply an activity of the mind. It is shaped through social interactions, religious practices, and activities of reading. And it shapes in turn the embodied experience of the world and events that transpire within it.

In the wake of the influential studies by Brueggemann and Collins, it has become commonplace to speak of prophetic or apocalyptic imagination. "Imagination," like its frequent synonym "worldview," is not a term that is used in biblical literature. As should already be evident, that does not preclude its usefulness in discussing Daniel and the perspective and experiences of those who wrote and read this text. But it may be helpful to gain some clarity regarding what this term entails and how other contemporary studies of imagination may shed light on Daniel's apocalyptic imagination.

Closely linked with creativity, imagination is a faculty that posits a reality—or possibility—beyond the dimensions of mundane reality that are immediately perceptible to the senses. Imagination may posit hidden or alternative realms, roles, or structures. It plays a key role in memory, decision-making, and planning for the future. It aids in problem-solving, and makes it possible to envision alternatives to existing constraints or the way things are currently done. Imagination can thus be a powerful catalyst for change. For poet Margaret Avison, the "optic heart" sees beyond what the world presents to us: "Nobody stuffs the world in at your eyes. / The optic heart must venture: a jail-break / and re-creation." Avison's "optic heart" insists on the relationship between sensory perception, intellect, emotion, embodied memory, and the faculty of imagination. This optic heart risks leaving behind familiar constraints, even bondage, so that self, other, and world may be reconstituted in the light of newly perceived possibility (Quinsey 2009: 348). Similarly, in analyzing poet Emily Dickinson's figure

of imagination's "slow fuse," Michael Gallagher writes that "imagination carries us to thresholds of possibility but it becomes transformative when its fuse catches fire and causes an explosion of new perception" (Gallagher 2015: 53).

In practical terms, imagination is a faculty we frequently associate with children at play, visionary leaders, and those who create and appreciate literature, visual art, theater, film, and music. Northrop Frye argues that listening to stories, for example, is a "training for the imagination" (Frye 1964: 116). This insight helps us to understand the close linking of narrative and visionary forms in the literary genre of apocalypse, in which stories typically set the scene for apocalyptic visions and discourses. In the case of Daniel, the stories contained in chapters 1–6 are believed by scholars to have circulated independently as a cherished and frequently told collection of tales (Newsom 2014: 9–10). The relationship between storytelling and imagination suggests that these very stories—precisely *as* stories—played a critical role in shaping an apocalyptic imagination within ancient Judaism.

Though, culturally speaking, imagination is less frequently associated with religion, numerous scholars have recently explored the role of imagination in religion, theology, and religious experience (Green 1989). Nonetheless, as Garrett Green notes, despite their shared emphasis on imagination, "recent users of the term employ it so variously that it would be misleading to say that they share a common concept." What they do share, for Green, is an underlying assumption that religion offers an alternate construction of the world to that of empirical science (1989: 9–10). While the validity of such epistemic dualism is debated, the idea that religious imagination can provide an alternative epistemology to other dominant cultural frames is important for understanding apocalyptic imagination. Apocalyptic imagination is funded by belief in revealed knowledge; as an apocalypse, the book of Daniel aims to share that knowledge by recording the seer's revealed visions and their divinely authorized interpretations. Such knowledge offers an alternative to imperial modes of knowing. In Daniel, this is especially highlighted in the tales of contest between Daniel and the Babylonian diviners (Daniel 2, 4, and 5). In these stories, Daniel alone, not the Babylonian dream interpreters, is able to interpret Nebuchadnezzar's dreams and the mysterious writing on the wall. For Daniel's audience, the book's alternative epistemic claims and evocative symbols make it possible to imagine a world radically different from that of the Hellenistic empires that ruled Judea. They can imagine a world governed wisely and justly by God in heaven, permeable to the movements of angels who would rise up to fight for Judah and deliver its people.

Paula Cooley (1994) further explores the capacity of religious imagination to challenge existing structures and frames of knowing by examining its embodied dimensions. Body is site, subject, and resource for human imagination; its lived experiences can enable or hinder the recognition of another as subject or provide resources for challenging other modes of cultural authority. The book of Daniel repeatedly links vision and body, highlighting the embodied nature of apocalyptic imagination. In Daniel 1 and 9, prolonged fasting (chs. 1 and 9) and humbling in sackcloth and ashes (ch. 9) precipitate Daniel's gift of wisdom, his ability to interpret dreams, and Gabriel's visitation and interpretation of Jeremiah's scroll. In the court tales, Nebuchadnezzar and

Belshazzar are physically distressed by the visions they see. In the apocalyptic chapters, the narrator focuses our attention on Daniel's embodied response to his visions (7:14, 29; 8:17–18, 27; 10:8, 15–18): his breath becomes ragged, his face blanches, he falls to the ground, he experiences prolonged weakness and bodily sickness. In Daniel 8, after Daniel has fallen, an angel touches him, conveying strength and lifting him to his feet (8:18). Daniel experiences similar bodily distress in response to his vision of a man clothed in linen (10:8, 15, 17); the man's touch helps him to stand (10:10–11) and speak (10:15) and gives him strength (10:18). Details regarding Daniel's embodied experience develop those found in earlier prophetic traditions and provide readers a point of entry into Daniel's apocalyptic imagination. Daniel's weakness and trembling may resonate with what the reader already feels or may prescribe a response to the vision. The physical strength and ability the angel confers on Daniel can similarly become a part of the reader's experience.

The valuing of imagination as such has been traced to the Enlightenment, Romanticism, and British imperialism (Engell 1999). Enlightenment and Romantic understandings of imagination located the faculty of imagination primarily within the individual, without giving adequate attention to the role of cultural and historical forces in shaping imagination or to the shared imagination of a community. Other studies have documented the ways in which empires, ancient and modern, colonized the imaginations of their colonial subjects through propaganda, violence, and other practices of subjugation (Pieterse and Parekh 1995b). Conversely, by decolonizing the imagination, a community may take away from the colonizer the power to define its world and identity, reclaiming the power to name its own identity and to imagine and shape a radically different reality. Reappropriating familiar images and symbols and creating new ones are critical to this process. Imperial imaginaries continue to leave their print within the postcolonial imagination. Thus, for Jan Nederveen Pieterse and Bhikhu Parekh, "decolonization . . . requires not the restoration of a historically continuous and allegedly pure precolonial heritage, but an imaginative creation of a new form of consciousness and way of life" (1995a: 3).

Seen in this light, Daniel's apocalyptic visions can be understood to play a key role in decolonizing the imaginations of their Judean audiences, allowing them to interact with the legacies of the Mesopotamian and Hellenistic empires while simultaneously rejecting their totalizing narratives. Drawing upon the prophetic, legal, historical, and wisdom traditions of Israel and Judah and the shared embodied practices of worship and piety, and combining these with the power of story and with newer literary forms, alternative, apocalyptic discourse, and visionary experience, the Danielic seers sought to forge a shared apocalyptic imagination, a new consciousness that perceived a hidden reality on heaven and earth. By igniting this fuse of changed perception, they sought to empower their audiences to venture, to break out of the prison of the imperial imaginary, and to imagine in its place an alternative structure of governance, a path to religious and national freedom, and heavenly existence beyond death.

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CHAPTER 14

METAPHORIZATION AND OTHER TROPES IN THE PROPHETS

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PROPHETIC literature utilizes a wide range of literary tropes, including metaphor, simile, alliteration, assonance, hyperbole, irony, repetition, parallelism, and wordplay. Because many of these features also appear in the poetry of Wisdom literature and the Psalms, analysis of prophetic style often draws upon general studies of Hebrew poetry. The poetics of the prophets, however, is distinctive—traversing prose, poetry, and rhetoric, and complicating as well as advancing meaning.

Far from simple ornamentation, prophetic style raises key questions. To what extent should these texts be analyzed as speech and to what extent as literature? Do complex wordplay and bold comparisons signal editorial artifice or divine inspiration? Do the culturally saturated prophetic tropes mechanically replicate the dynamics of power from which they emerge, or does the reader's ideology inform (and even overwrite) the prophetic imagination? Most important, what should readers *do* with not only the words of the prophets but also the thoughts and feelings that prophetic style evokes?

PROPHETS, POETS, OR PRODUCERS?

English translations regularly distinguish between poetry and prose within the prophets. The NRSV of Jeremiah, for example, formats some chapters exclusively as poetry (ch. 6), some as exclusively prose (ch. 19), and most as a mixture of the two (chs. 3, 8). The NRSV casts Obadiah, Micah, Habakkuk, and Zephaniah as exclusively poetry; Haggai, Zechariah 1–8, and Malachi as exclusively prose; and Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Jonah, Nahum, and Zechariah 9–14 as a mixture of prose and poetry.

This separation of prophetic poetry and prose, however, appears neither in Qumran texts nor Masoretic manuscripts. In the great Isaiah scroll from Qumran (1QIsa) and in the Westminster Leningrad Codex, for example, the fourth Servant Song (Isa 52:13–53:12) is indistinguishable from prose. Modern formatting derives instead from discernment of “poetic” features such as parallelism, terseness, repetition, patterning, and other elements outlined by Adele Berlin.¹ Comparing English translations, however, underscores the subjectivity of these judgments. The NAS, for example, differs from the NRSV in formatting Hosea 1:10–11 as poetry and Ezekiel 1–18 and Amos 8:1–4 as prose.

Throughout the history of interpretation, the identification of prophetic poetry has been based on stylistic elements—and interwoven with particular understandings of prophecy’s origins. In the late eleventh and early twelfth centuries C.E., the Jewish poet and linguist Moses ben Jacob Ibn Ezra (related to the more famous Abraham Ibn Ezra) deemed biblical prophecy as poetry. By comparing Hebrew poetry to its Arabic analogues in Muslim Spain, he developed an “aesthetic exegesis” that treated the “literary ornaments of poetry (Arabic *badi*)” as the human prophet’s embellishment of the divine message. In contrast to the earlier rabbinic tradition that treated apparent repetitions in biblical literature as exegetically significant, Moses Ibn Ezra claimed that the style of the prophets was just that—style.²

In the eighteenth century, however, Robert Lowth argued that the poetic style of the prophetic books indicates prophecy’s liturgical origins. In lectures 18–21 of his *Lectures on the Sacred Poetry of the Hebrews*, Lowth identified aspects of parallelism and meter within the prophetic books and attributed them to the “college of prophets,” whose task it was to sing hymns. “Many of the prophecies are in reality hymns or poems” (Lowth 1815: 249). Some poetic features (such as parallelism), he claimed, run throughout the prophetic corpus, but each prophet exhibits a distinctive poetic style:

Isaiah . . . is at once elegant and sublime, forcible and ornamented; he unites energy with copiousness and dignity with variety. In his sentiments there is uncommon elevation and majesty; in his imagery the utmost propriety, elegance, dignity, and diversity; in his language uncommon beauty and energy; and, notwithstanding the obscurity of his subjects, a surprising degree of clearness and simplicity. . . [Ezekiel] is deep, vehement, tragical; the only sensation he affects to excite is the terrible. (Lowth 1815: 288; 291–292)

Lowth lavished particular praise on Nahum, whose descriptions of the downfall of Nineveh “are expressed in the most vivid colours, and are bold and luminous in the highest degree” (Lowth 1815: 297).

In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Bernhard Duhm viewed the poetic style of the prophets as proof of their divine inspiration. Linking inspiration with poetry, Duhm denied that prophetic prose was “genuine prophecy.” As Robert Wilson explains, in the mid- to late twentieth century, Graeme Auld and Robert Carroll inverted Duhm’s evaluation (Wilson 2004). Like Duhm, they identified the authors

of prophetic language as poets but, in contrast, they insisted that the artfulness of the poetry indicates human authorship. According to Auld and Carroll, prophetic books are the products of scribes and not divine intermediaries; the writers are “poets not prophets” (Carroll 1983).

A current trend in prophetic study underscores the scribal origin of written prophecy even more boldly. Ehud Ben Zvi’s extensive work on prophetic texts insists that they are the work of elite scribes, *literati*, working within the Persian period,³ and O’Brien’s commentary on Micah (2015) explores the real-life consequences of this work of a Persian-period scribe. Similarly, Martti Nissinen discerns within Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Chronicles the development from *prophecy as divination* to *prophecy as authoritative writing*. While non-biblical ancient Near Eastern sources do not link prophecy to literacy, he argues that the description of writing in the book of Jeremiah testifies to “the transition from written to literary prophecy and, implicitly, highlights the role of scribes in the *Fortschreibung* (expansion/redaction) of prophetic words.”⁴ In Ezekiel, “the text itself becomes an authority related to the authority of the Torah. In Chronicles, finally, the scribalization of prophecy has reached the point where visions and prophecies are referred to as scribal products, and prophets have become their authors.”⁵

While metaphorization and literary tropes are not limited to those portions of the prophetic books recognized as poetic, this brief discussion has underscored that identifying prophetic poetry intertwines with other dimensions of studying the prophets. Style bears upon not only intermediation and orality/writtenness but also upon the very purposes of prophetic language, to which this discussion now turns.

POETRY OR RHETORIC?

Interpreters commonly equate prophetic literature with rhetoric, analyzing the ways in which its literary devices seek to persuade an audience. Such an approach is sometimes named explicitly, as in the work of Yehoshua Gitay (2008), who applies the categories of classical rhetoric to the biblical prophets (“The Reasonable Appeal”; “The Ethical Appeal”) and underscores the persuasive power of stylistic devices such as rhetorical questions, imperatives, alliteration, and contrasts. Even when not named, however, the approach is commonly implicitly assumed, reflected in the language scholars use to describe what imagery “means,” how it seeks to “persuade” its audience, and what politics and theology shape the author’s “intentions.” It echoes in the contemporary language of “prophetic preaching” within progressive/liberal Christianity, reflected in Leonora Tubbs Tisdale’s title⁶ and in the rhetoric of Jeremiah Wright.⁷ In this light, prophets appear as preachers, social critics, or even pamphleteers, seeking to alter the perceptions and the behavior of an audience by utilizing rhetorical devices that reconfigure the imagination and/or grant existential force to the message.

Several key voices have challenged the assumption that prophetic poetry aims to clarify and persuade. In *Prophecy, Poetry, and Hosea*, Gerald Morris underscores the difference between poetry and rhetoric, particularly the way in which each employs literary style. To meet its goal of persuasion, rhetoric aims for clarity. The goal of poetry, however, is to call attention to itself: it succeeds by “complicating sense with sound, by using incongruous words or expressions, by deforming expected emphases or by deliberately obscuring or even contradicting itself” (Morris 1996: 42).

Morris explicates how the book of Hosea uses literary features—particularly repetition and wordplay—in a poetic way. While in Aristotelian rhetoric repetition emphasizes meaning, repetition in Hosea continually changes and complicates meaning. As Morris notes, “Many repetitions are notable for appearing in one kind of speech first, then surprisingly in an utterly different sort of speech later” (1996: 62), and rather than limit repetition to neat parallel lines, Hosea reiterates language within and across lines. Pointing to examples given by Harold Fisch in his study of Hosea’s puns in *Poetry with a Purpose* (1988), Morris shows that the writer of Hosea plays with phonemes to create level after level of ambiguity. “Pun after pun hints at a secondary level of meaning”; based not in logic but on incantation, “the words themselves bear the power” (Morris 1996: 90, 93–94).

Similarly, Yvonne Sherwood underscores the complexity and obscurity of prophetic language, which is more like Donne than Wordsworth, more Baroque than Romantic, more disturbing than beautiful (Sherwood 2002, 2009, 2010). Sherwood sees this rawness, of course, in the content of prophetic literature: prophetic poetry is filled with images of excrement, sexual assault, and dead bodies, as well as other images that offend polite sensibility. Her primary argument, however, is that the style of prophetic poetry is itself violent—disruptive, fragmentary, jarring. Rather than enlighten the reader, prophetic language serves to confound sense. According to Sherwood, Morris, and Fisch, prophetic poetry does not attempt to aid understanding. The author constructs a metaphor only to subvert it, turn it on its head, disassemble its pieces, and make something new. Every time the reader “grasps” meaning, it changes. Prophetic poetry “enlivens rather than enlightens” (Morris 1996: 74).

This poetry-versus-rhetoric distinction has been made by those outside biblical studies as well. Barbara Caruso, for example, contrasts rhetoric, which imposes one’s will on others, and poetry, which shares one’s truth: “Rhetoric is a pronouncement; poetry is a conversation.”⁸ The beginning of Audre Lorde’s poem “Power” provokes such a conversation:

The difference between poetry and rhetoric
is being ready to kill
yourself
instead of your children.⁹

The questions raised here affect all aspects of prophetic interpretation. Is prophetic literature expressive or instrumental? Does it seek to evoke and spur, or clarify and mobilize? Should readers approach prophetic poetry and prose differently? Should a translator aim for making sense of the prophets, or for replicating their sounds?

PROPHETIC POETIC STYLE

Close attention to the specific features of prophetic poetic style highlights these interpretive quandaries. The following discussion seeks not to be comprehensive but to demonstrate ways in which style not only decorates meaning but also obscures sense.

Parallelism

At least since the work of Lowth, parallelism has been considered the key marker of Hebrew poetry. In this device, two lines are paired to reinforce or extend meaning¹⁰ and are often classified as synonymous, antithetical, or synthetic parallelism. Indentation in translations such as the NRSV seeks to underscore the parallel style, as seen in its presentation of Micah 3:9–10:

⁹ Hear this, you rulers of the house of Jacob
 and chiefs of the house of Israel,
 who abhor justice
 and pervert all equity,
¹⁰ who build Zion with blood
 and Jerusalem with wrong!
¹¹ Its rulers give judgment for a bribe,
 its priests teach for a price,
 its prophets give oracles for money;
 yet they lean upon the LORD and say,
 “Surely the LORD is with us!
 No harm shall come upon us.”
¹² Therefore because of you
 Zion shall be plowed as a field;
 Jerusalem shall become a heap of ruins,
 and the mountain of the house a wooded height.

This passage exhibits obvious synonymous parallelisms: rulers of house of Jacob/chiefs of house of Israel; justice/equity; blood/wrong; bribe/price/money; field/ruins/ wooded height; and Zion/Jerusalem/mountain of the house. In verses 11 and 12, however, three rather than two synonymous lines are joined.

Other prophetic texts also demonstrate—and break from—the standard parallelism of two lines. Joel 2:7–9 offers numerous two-line parallels:

⁷ Like warriors they charge,
 like soldiers they scale the wall.
 Each keeps to its own course,
 they do not swerve from their paths.

- ⁸ They do not jostle one another,
 each keeps to its own track;
 they burst through the weapons
 and are not halted.
- ⁹ They leap upon the city,
 they run upon the walls;
 they climb up into the houses,
 they enter through the windows like a thief.

The third line of 2:8, however, interrupts the neat parallelism, adding new information and adding an element of chaos to the orderly march of the locusts/army.

Morris explores at length the ways in which Hosea refuses to follow the rules of parallelism. Hosea 2:11 (Heb 2:13) throws multiple word pairs into a single line (“festivals” appears twice) and *hishbati* (“I will end”) rhymes with *shabbatah* (“her sabbath”) within a single line. In Hosea 9:1–2, the expected patterns of word pairs are shuffled around, so that the pairs threshing floor/wine press and grain/new wine are split over two verses (Morris 1996: 67). As the examples of Micah and Joel reveal, however, this counterformulaic use of parallelism is not limited to Hosea but runs throughout the prophets.

Repetition/Wordplay/Paronomasia

While parallelism is itself a form of repetition, the prophets also utilize repetition within and across lines. The word “day,” for example, appears fourteen times in Zephaniah 1 (fifteen, if one includes the “days” of King Josiah in 1:1), driving home the terror of the coming Day of the LORD. “Sweep away” appears three times in Zephaniah 1:2–3, intensified in the Hebrew of 1:2 with an infinite absolute of the same verb. In Micah, the verdict against Samaria in 1:6 is repeated for Jerusalem in 3:11 (both will be made into a “heap”), and words and verbal roots repeat throughout Micah 2: “evil,” “field,” “preach,” “house.”¹¹ Isaiah 52:13–53:12 repeats *ns* (“bear/lifted up”) three times; *rb* (“many”) five times; and *ph* (“mouth”) four times. In Amos 5, “seek!” intends to shape the people’s behavior four times. These repetitions not only create coherence and build extensity, but also help develop theological concepts: In Isaiah 52–53, the servant’s willingness to “bear” his “burden” compels YHWH to “lift him up” (all from the root *ns*).

Words that repeat from the end of one textual unit to the beginning of the next unit are often understood by redaction critics as catchword linkages between once-disparate oracles. In Amos 1, the oracles against Damascus and Gaza are linked by “exile,” and those between Gaza and Tyre are linked by “entire communities.” According to James Nogalski, catchwords also link the individual books of the Minor Prophets into a coherent Book of the Twelve, though Ben Zvi has questioned such a conclusion.¹²

Other forms of repetition include puns, alliteration, assonance, and onomatopoeia, in which the sound of words rather than their meaning is reiterated. Such wordplay is rife in the prophets. In Micah 1:8–16, the names of various locales indicate their fate: Beth-le‘aphrah (“house of dust”) should roll itself in the dust (‘*aphar*, 1:10), and

Achzib is “deception” (*‘achzab*) (1:14). Some scholars “repair” other verses in Micah 1 so that every town name is treated as a pun: in *The Message*, for example, Lachish becomes “Chariotville” and Adullam becomes “Glorytown.”¹³ The first three words of Nahum 2:10 sound alike (*buqah umbuqah umbulaqah*), as the NRSV translation attempts to capture (“devastation, desolation, and destruction!”). At times, the sound of words reflects their meaning: in Nahum 2:7 handmaids moan (*m^enahāgôt*) and beat their breasts (*m^etoph^ephot*), and the opening interjection of Micah 7:1 (NRSV “woe”) reproduces the sound of wailing (*‘alelay*), as does the modern term “ululation.”

Puns often appear when YHWH instructs the prophet. In Amos 8:2, the prophet’s vision of a piece of fruit (*qayitz*) is interpreted by the deity as a sign of Israel’s end (*qetz*), and in Jeremiah 1:11–12 an almond tree (*shaqed*) confirms that the deity is a watcher (*shoqed*). In Amos 5:5, the deity declares that Gilgal will surely go into exile (*hagilgal gala yigleh*).

Interpreters tend to understand prophetic wordplay as underscoring the proportionality of divine punishment, its “poetic justice”: “The wordplays [in Micah 2] show up the folly of wickedness—sinners will receive their ‘just desserts.’ . . . readers of the book are prompted to visualize a causal relationship between negative social behavior, namely, sin and divine punishment.”¹⁴ Challenging this interpretation, however, is the observation that punishment based on sound may appear more arbitrary than just. Sherwood insists on the capricious nature of the fruit/end example in Amos 8: the connection between the two cannot be logically anticipated (Sherwood 2002: 61). She also notes that in the case of Gilgal going to exile (Amos 5), the city’s fate is sealed by the unfortunate resonances of its name. The same case may be made for Micah 1: the poetry of Micah does not seek justice for the towns of the Shephelah but attempts to evoke pathos for Jerusalem’s exiles; the names of the towns become not the basis for punishment, but rather a set of sounds with which the poet can play.

Similarly, repetition does not always illuminate. As Morris notes, the repetition of “dew” throughout the book of Hosea may be artful but also obfuscating. In Hosea 6:4 the affections of Ephraim and Judah are compared to dew that evaporates; but the evaporation of dew in 13:3 symbolizes pending destruction, while in 14:6 the Holy One is like life-giving dew (Morris 1996: 63–69). In Hosea, dew symbolizes sin, punishment, and salvation.

Reversals, Irony, and Satire

Prophetic literature is especially fond of reversals. Those who expect good things will suffer instead:

Alas for you who desire the day of the LORD!
 Why do you want the day of the LORD?
 It is darkness, not light;
 as if someone fled from a lion, and was met by a bear;
 or went into the house and rested a hand against the wall,
 and was bitten by a snake. (Amos 5:18–19)

Instead of perfume there will be a stench;
 and instead of a sash, a rope;
 and instead of well-set hair, baldness;
 and instead of a rich robe, a binding of sackcloth;
 instead of beauty, shame. (Isa 3:24)

Those who now suffer are promised good things in the future:

Instead of the thorn shall come up the cypress;
 instead of the brier shall come up the myrtle;
 and it shall be to the LORD for a memorial,
 for an everlasting sign that shall not be cut off. (Isa 55:13)

Micah 4–5 contrasts Jerusalem's current humiliation (enemies gaze upon Daughter Jerusalem, who writhes in pain) with her future exaltation (she will become a heifer who tramples her enemies). In Micah 7, Daughter Jerusalem who now suffers at the hands of her enemy anticipates a reversal in fortunes, described with pairs of opposites: though she now falls, she will soon rise; though she now dwells in darkness, light will soon come; though others once threatened to make Daughter Jerusalem into a public spectacle (4:11), she now threatens her feminine enemy with the same fate. Because she accepts her current dire straits as YHWH's just punishment for her sins, she can trust that when YHWH's anger subsides she will be redeemed.

Some prophetic reversals proceed in a relatively straightforward fashion: good becomes bad, bad becomes good. As explored extensively by Carolyn Sharp, others develop in a more complex way, veering into the realm of satire or irony. While in Ezekiel 34 YHWH initially behaves like the Good Shepherd, he then turns to judge between the sheep and the sheep (34:17–22) (Sharp 2009: 131–132); YHWH does not simply reverse course, but destabilizes the assumptions of the reader. The reader of Micah 2:12–13 remains as ignorant of the divine intention of gathering sheep into the pen (is this salvation or punishment?) as the animals themselves (Sharp 2009: 172). The doxologies in Amos (4:13; 5:8–9; 9:5–6) serve less to praise the deity, as in the Psalms, than to underscore the inevitability of divine punishment (Sharp 2009: 153). Jonah not only parodies the prophetic role but even more the character's theological affirmation: contrary to Jonah's claim to know that "you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and ready to relent from punishing" (4:2), and contrary to YHWH's claim that he will "spare" Nineveh (4:11, NRSV "be concerned about"), "God has never been a God of mercy" (Sharp 2009: 184). A post-exilic reader of the book would have known well that Nineveh was not ultimately spared, nor were Israel and Judah. Parodied in Jonah, suggests Sharp, is not the prophet, but all who depend upon divine mercy.

Irony and satire, suggest Sharp and Jemielity, are key rhetorical strategies of prophetic condemnation. "Prophecy and satire," says Jemielity, "deliberately equate suffering and its attendant disgrace with punishment" (1992: 40). The poetic aspects of this language, however, unsettle its rhetorical success. Sharp acknowledges that "one critic's ironizing

hyperbole may be another critic's passionate truth claim" (2009: 6) and that while interpreters may agree that Jonah is satire, they disagree about who—or what—is being satirized (2009: 130). Indeed, determining that expectations have been contravened presupposes a firm grasp of ancient (and modern) expectations and a clarity of language that the prophets rarely provide.

Exaggeration/Hyperbole

A related analysis can be offered for identifications of prophetic hyperbole. Interpreters often praise exaggeration as an effective rhetorical device: by overstating the case, one drives home the point. By depicting the rich as those who "trample the head of the poor into the dust of the earth" (Amos 2:7), Amos intensifies their critique; by comparing land-robbers to those "who eat the flesh of my people, flay their skin off them, break their bones in pieces, and chop them up like meat in a kettle, like flesh in a caldron" (Mic 3:3), Micah depicts their behavior as scandalous. When Ezekiel is depicted as eating a scroll (3:1–3) and lying on one side for 390 days and another for 40 days (4:1–17), the writer's use of the fantastic creates a mental universe in which the prophet embodies the scandal and extremity of Jerusalem's punishment.

As with satire, however, the hyperbole may be in the eyes of the beholder. YHWH's rejection of sacrifices in Amos 5:21–25, for example, was understood by late nineteenth-century German scholars and some social activists in the twentieth century as straightforward evidence that the prophets stood in opposition to the Temple cult, but the same passage is read by many post-Holocaust scholars as hyperbole, an overstatement of the need for ethics to accompany ritual. Similarly, the claim of Jeremiah 1:5 that YHWH knew the prophet while he was still in the womb is treated by some readers as prophetic hyperbole for the conviction of one's call, but by others as the very clear factual basis for opposing abortion.

Other Features

Other features of prophetic poetry similarly communicate and complicate meaning. *Symbolic names* such as Isaiah's *Shear-jashub* ("a remnant shall return," 7:3), *Immanuel* ("God with us," 7:14), and *Maher-shalal-hash-baz* ("the spoil speeds, the prey hastens," 8:1, 3), and Hosea's *Lo Ammi* ("not my people"), *Lo Ruḥamah* ("not pitied"), and Jezreel (Hosea 1) concretize the prophetic message but also remain fluid. Between Isaiah 7 and Isaiah 8, for example, *Immanuel* shifts from a sign of promise to a witness to judgment. At the beginning of Hosea 2 the prophet denies the very children whom he was instructed to name in chapter 1, and by the end of chapter 2 the names of the children are undone.

Context-specific vocabulary often evokes particular settings but is also destabilized by them. "Thus says the LORD," the marker of "divine messenger speech" in the ancient Near East, *explicitly* conflates the word of the prophet with the divine word yet *implicitly* distinguishes the two; when the voices of YHWH and the prophet blur, the prophet may

be divinized but the divine is humanized (Sharp 2009: 126). The language of the lawsuit ("contend!" "hear!") underscores the justice of YHWH's charges against the people but also casts doubt on the likelihood of an impartial jury: who will convict a deity who functions as plaintiff, witness, and judge? The conflation of lawsuit language with the language of the Divine Warrior's march (e.g., Micah 1) further indicates that none can resist YHWH's charges: if this plaintiff does not get justice in court, he will go to war. Throughout, Micah uses vocabulary to mark the implied prophet's words as lament, but the speeches lack the raw emotional power of those that appear in Jeremiah 8, 9, 20; the book of Lamentations; and the psalms of lament. The disputation speech of Malachi, Isaiah 28, Jeremiah 8, and elsewhere claims to report the words of the prophet's opponents, but those voices never actually are heard. The speech imputed to them becomes suspect because of its universally unsympathetic tone.

Metaphor and Simile

The most distinctive feature of prophetic style, however, is comparison.¹⁵ Through episodic similes and extended metaphors, the prophets cast one thing as another, not only provoking new insight but also solidly rooting prophetic language in culture and ideology.

The difference between simile and metaphor is often made on strictly stylistic grounds—simile includes "like" or "as" (Hebrew *ki*), while metaphor does not—but the two forms differ also in the nature of the comparisons made. Simile tends to compare a single characteristic of one thing with another: Israel will take root like a tree of Lebanon takes root (Hos 14:5) and will flourish as a garden flourishes (Hos 14:7). *Metaphor* extends further into what George Lakoff and others have termed "cross-domain mapping"¹⁶—the transference of one realm of existence onto another. Not focused on a single characteristic, metaphor allows a wide range of associations and provides a conceptual frame for thought; not simply a literary device, these forms are "metaphors we live by" (Lakoff and Johnson 1980). When we "travel on the freeway of love," for example, lovers are like travelers, love itself is like a vehicle, and while the relationship may chart a particular destination, the ride itself is part of the thrill. This metaphor precludes other ways of thinking about love: that it might be organic, grounded in promises or responsibility, cloistered, or contentious. Likewise, when YHWH is a Warrior, divine power and divine destruction take precedence over divine vulnerability, divine mercy, and divine-human intimacy.

The prophets draw from the broad array of life for their comparisons. Deity, people, and places are compared to animals (bear, maggot, locust, lion, sheep); to food and eating utensils (grapes, wine, cup, bowl, egg); to tools (ax, staff, rod); and to elements of what modern readers would characterize as "nature" (fire, water, chaff). Human occupations appear frequently (arborist, pruner, sentinel, messenger, midwife, warrior), as do the vicissitudes of human living (blindness, thirst, pain in childbirth, mourning). YHWH's relationship with Israel is compared to the bond between shepherd and sheep

and vinedresser and vineyard, imputing particular characteristics to both the divine and the human tenor of the equation. These vehicles of metaphor offer glimpses of the lives of ancient Israelites—their foodstuffs, their predators, and their concerns.

Through the use of familial metaphors, they also reflect the patriarchal structure and ideology of the ancient Israelite family. Just as sons owe strict obedience to their fathers and justifiably may be beaten for failure to adhere to the father's rules, so too Israel and Judah deserve punishment by YHWH for rebellion (Isaiah 1; Malachi 1; Jeremiah 3). Just as sexual access to a woman is "owned" first by her father and then by her husband (a right enforceable by stripping, beating, and even execution), so too Israel and Judah may be physically punished for "whoring" after other gods (Hos 2:5 [Engl. 2:3]; Ezekiel 16; 23). This latter comparison is often dubbed "the marriage metaphor," though it clearly does not describe the romantically tinged partnership of equals that many in the modern world associate with the institution of "marriage."

Other metaphors resonate with the ancient Israelite family in less obvious ways. The frequent comparison of nations and cities to "whores" (Hebrew *zonah*) points to a figure outside the patriarchal family but nonetheless relies upon patriarchal ideology to function: their sexuality uncontrolled by males, prostitutes are the dangerous but alluring threat to the system.¹⁷ The common prophetic image of Daughter Jerusalem/Zion suggests a familial frame, but most often evokes a military setting. According to Cynthia Chapman, every occurrence of the "Daughter Zion" metaphor appears in a military context: "Daughter Zion is always the pawn or prize in a military battle between men and Yahweh."¹⁸ The vulnerability of a daughter in the patriarchal family, it seems, allows the transfer of the image to another register (O'Brien 2008, 125–151).

Alongside Daughter Zion, other prophetic images draw from the military domain. YHWH appears as a warrior not only in extended passages such as Habakkuk 3 and Isaiah 63, but also in short references throughout the prophets. The Divine Warrior marches fully armed with bow, arrows, spear, and rod (Habakkuk 3), each element able to take on metaphorical significance of its own: in Zechariah 9, YHWH lifts up Judah as his bow, Ephraim as his arrow, and Zion's sons as his sword (9:13) before sounding the trumpet and marching forth to protect Jerusalem from enemies (9:14–15). In Isaiah 10, the "rod" (Hebrew *shebet*) functions in various ways. Metaphorically, Assyria is the "rod" used by the Divine Warrior to smite Judah (10:5) but which should not vaunt itself over the one who lifts it (10:15). More literally, it is the rod with which Assyria beats Judah (10:24): When the Assyrians beat the Judahites, they should understand that YHWH himself directs the violence against them. The "club" (Hebrew *matteh*) often accompanies the rod: in Isaiah 30:30–32, YHWH promises to strike the Assyrians with his rod (*shebet*) and the staff (*matteh*) of punishment raised by his "brandished arm" (NRSV). Both implements can serve non-military functions as well. While in Isaiah 10:5 the *matteh* is the "club" in YHWH's hand, in Isaiah 10:26 it is the "staff" that YHWH once lifted up against the Sea of Reeds. The *shebet* is YHWH's rod of discipline in Ezekiel 21:15, 18 and the staff with which YHWH shepherds in Micah 7:14.

Many scholars have underscored the ways in which these description of the Divine Warrior draw upon common ancient Near Eastern cosmological motifs. YHWH's career

as a Warrior follows that of Ba'al and Marduk; the "radiance" of his weapons reflects the light of weapons brandished by Assyrian kings; and his hyper-masculine military prowess seeks to out-man Assyrian and Persian rulers.¹⁹ The human experience of military conquest, however, also echoes throughout this language. The swords, clubs, rods, and arrows of Assyrian, Babylonian, and Persian soldiers would have not been mere abstractions for the first readers of the prophetic books.

READERLY ENGAGEMENTS OF PROPHETIC TROPES

Readers have responded in very different ways to the dynamics of power embedded in prophetic metaphor. Some have attempted to understand and appreciate the rhetorical effectiveness of the comparisons. Walter Brueggemann, for example, has repeatedly underscored the pathos evoked by Hosea's imputation of familial bonds to Israel and YHWH. By portraying YHWH as a "resilient and determined lover" who will not give up Wife Israel (Hos 2:14–23) and as an anguished father who cannot abandon the son whom he once loved, the biblical author allows readers to hope that "YHWH's commitment goes beyond formal obligation to the irrationality of emotional attachment."²⁰

Second-wave feminists, however, have insisted that the pathos of the comparisons constitutes perhaps their greatest danger, tapping into and insidiously reinforcing culturally bound gender hierarchies. Not only does comparing the deity to a particular class of humans grant those humans greater, even quasi-divine, status ("If God is male, then the male is God"²¹) but also oppressive patterns of human behavior become normalized. "Thinking with" prophetic metaphor, matters of love and honor are resolved by violence, humans must be either male or female, desire is heteronormative, men dominate, children obey, and women submit. Feminist resistance to prophetic metaphor has been prolific, generating numerous monographs on Hosea, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah and pervading all three editions of the *Women's Bible Commentary* and both editions of the *Feminist Companion to the Prophets*.²²

Other feminists have attempted to retrieve from prophetic metaphor a more hopeful word for women. Juliana Claassens, for example, finds in the metaphors of YHWH as mourner, mother, and midwife constructive feminine imagery for the divine.²³ Peggy Day challenges such gyno-friendly readings of the prophets by noting that such correlations of YHWH with female experience appear in simile and are not constitutive of divine character: although "a mother comforting her child is clearly maternal/gynomorphic, Yahweh is not thereby envisaged by the author as being a comforting mother."²⁴ In response to those who claim that the similarity between the Hebrew words for "compassion" and "womb" (both from the root *rḥm*) feminize divine mercy, she insists that "etymology does not entail shared meaning in the mind of the speaker of a language" such that the word "compassion" does not necessarily evoke uterine imagery.

Third-wave feminist studies and queer studies have countered that much of the gender ideology perceived by second-wave feminist scholars of the Prophets presupposes an essentialism of gender and heteronormative desire. Stuart Macwilliam, for example, contends that Jeremiah's use of the marriage metaphor is far from patriarchal: by asking the male readers of the book to resume their status as good wives, the book undermines, rather than reinforces, gender expectations.²⁵ While Macwilliam underestimates the degree to which gender must be normalized in order to be subverted, he and others appropriately highlight the role that readers play in the reception of prophetic metaphor.

Trauma studies has proven a useful conversation partner for those seeking to understand the pervasive violence of the prophets. For example, Kathleen O'Connor reads Jeremiah's violent language as a provisional attempt at meaning-making in the aftermath of the Babylonian destruction of Judah. By mirroring the disjointed and horrific experiences of those surviving trauma, the book tells truth "slant"²⁶ for the sake of healing: "God as Punisher offers one way, among many in Jeremiah, to integrate the disaster into the long stream of the nation's existence, its long narrative memory."²⁷ Carole Fontaine, too, recognizes the existential situations from which prophetic metaphor emerged: "The writers of the Bible most certainly 'got the message' of their own vulnerability . . . A violent god is preferable to an impotent or non-existent one."²⁸ Steed Davidson, instead, turns to post-colonial studies to explore the way in which prophetic tropes, especially gendered ones, reflect and process the anxieties of the colonialized subject.²⁹

And yet, even these attempts to respond to the gendered violence of prophetic tropes often overestimate the stability of prophetic comparisons. The fact that scholars can debate whether in Joel armies are being compared to locusts or locusts to armies; which parts of Hosea 2 reflect the human register and which reflect divine character; and whether Micah 1:7 casts Samaria as a prostitute or a pimp³⁰ underscores the point that prophetic literature cannot be simply equated with rhetoric or paraphrased in simple prose. Is *YHWH* a masculine warrior in Isaiah 63 or a failed one? Is the dissociation that O'Connor discerns in Jeremiah a symptom of trauma and/or the nature of prophetic language? When are stereotypes being subverted and when are they being reinforced? Should interpreters mine every trope for meaning, or might they occasionally face a dead metaphor rather than a dead body?

THEOLOGICAL IMPLICATIONS

Patrick Miller has suggested that biblical poetry invites a particular mode of theology: based on his study of the Psalms, he suggests that poetry invites speech about God that is figurative and open, and bridges the human and divine realms.³¹ What mode of theology might the distinctive poetic style of the prophets engender?

Over the centuries, interpreters have disagreed about what the prophets teach: whether they predict the future, rail against the cult, or preach a message of social justice. Despite their differences, however, almost all have assumed that the prophetic message was intended to be coherent. They have treated metaphor, allusion, alliteration, and other poetic features as the means to an end: a message that, once deciphered, can be explicated in discursive, even homiletical, style.

Taking seriously the disruptive, counterintuitive character of prophetic language challenges not only the practice of translators who attempt to smooth out the incoherence of prophetic language, especially through emendation, but also those who derive from prophetic literature rigidly bounded theological systems. Prophetic poetry does not clarify who God is, but instead subverts understanding at every turn. If the poetic style of the Psalms creates a bridge between the human and the divine, then the style of prophetic poetry destroys existing bridges. Poetic style seems to offer safe passage over the void but actually unravels when solid ground disappears.

Treating prophetic literature as poetry rather than rhetoric necessarily questions any discussion of the “message” of the prophets. It problematizes not only much of the history of the interpretation of the prophets but also contemporary attempts to read prophetic books as Persian-period literary productions crafted to “explain” the lessons of the past. How can prophetic literature provide a coherent explanation of the nation’s fate if the literature itself is not coherent? If the only connection these books make between sin and punishment is that of sound, then perhaps the only real lesson to learn from the past is the wisdom of changing one’s name. When modern readers tame prophetic words into a neat message, they undo the very aim of prophetic language: to complicate meaning. Reflecting on the theological implications of her work, Sherwood suggests that

[p]rophecy . . . uses violent distortions of language as a testimony to the power of Yahweh: as in the prophetic theophanies, in which the presence of God touches the earth, causing the “foundations” and the thresholds to shake (Ezek. 1.28; Isa. 6.1–6; Amos 9.1) or the earth to melt (Amos 9.5), so linguistic convulsion creates a sense of words intervened in, and subjected by God. It uses violence to represent the radical otherness of a Yahweh’s-eye view of the world and the strangeness of God’s language. (Sherwood 2002: 73)

Prophetic language, she suggests, underscores divine sovereignty and transcendence.

Andrew Mein comes to similar conclusions about Ezekiel’s language. He suggests that the repugnant God portrayed by Ezekiel might propel us not to look for better divine images elsewhere but instead to face the reality “that ultimately all of our language about God will fail”—including the language about God in biblical texts: “biblical texts are not just sometimes idolatrous, but perhaps inevitably idolatrous” (Mein 2013: 275). In these affirmations, Mein finds support in the apophatic theological tradition, which insists on the importance of “unknowing” God (quoting from Meister Eckhart) for the sake of “God beyond God.” For both Mein and Sherwood, prophetic

poetry is a form of negative theology, a shattering of the idols into which humans have made their images of God.

If all speech about God is false, including that of the prophets, should all speech end? Mein stresses that the apophatic mystical theologians did not draw this conclusion: their writings “are regularly characterised by a superabundance of theological affirmation and an extravagant wordiness” (2013: 275). Just as the book of Ezekiel does not limit speech but instead engorges itself with language, swallowing it whole and spewing it forth in all directions, Mein suggests that negative theology invites humans not to silence speech but to heap it up, since none of it is adequate in itself.

The fractures of prophetic wordplay and repetition caution against any single authoritative meaning and yet invite a diversity of reader response. Perhaps the goal of theological commentary on the prophets is to explore the ways in which the disorienting language of the prophets leads readers in many different directions, all at once. Just as there is no single right way to read prophetic poetry, perhaps the disturbing poetry of the prophets propels its readers not toward less speech about God and the world, but toward much, much more.

NOTES

1. Adele Berlin, “Introduction to Hebrew Poetry,” in *The New Interpreter’s Bible*, ed. Leander Keck (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2005), 167–181.
2. Barry D. Walfish, “Medieval Jewish Interpretation,” in *The Jewish Study Bible*, ed. Adele Berlin; Marc Zvi Brettler; Michael Fishbane (New York: Oxford University Press, 2003), 1876–1900.
3. For example, Ehud Ben Zvi, *Micah* (FOTL 21B; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2000).
4. Martti Nissinen, “Since When Do Prophets Write?,” in *In the Footsteps of Sherlock Holmes: Studies in the Biblical Text in Honour of Anneli Aejmelaesus*, ed. Kristin de Troyer, T. Michael Law, and Marketta Liljestrom (Leuven; Paris; Walpole, MA: Peeters, 2014), 605.
5. Nissinen, “Since When Do Prophets Write,” 606.
6. Leonora Tubbs Tisdale, *Prophetic Preaching: A Pastoral Approach* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2010).
7. For a comparison of Dr. Wright’s rhetoric and that of Hosea, see Carolyn J. Sharp, “Hewn by the Prophet: An Analysis of Violence and Sexual Transgression in Hosea with Reference to the Homiletical Aesthetic of Jeremiah Wright,” in *The Aesthetics of Violence in the Prophets*, ed. Julia M. O’Brien and Chris Franke (LHBOTS 517; New York and London: T & T Clark, 2010), 50–71.
8. Barbara Caruso, “The Difference between Poetry and Rhetoric,” *The Earlhamite* (1983). <https://www.earlham.edu/media/445758/1983address.pdf>.
9. Audre Lorde, “Power,” in *The Collected Poems of Audre Lorde* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1978).
10. James Kugel argues that parallelism does not simply duplicate ideas but heightens them. See his *The Idea of Biblical Poetry: Parallelism and Its History* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998).
11. Carol J. Dempsey, “Micah 2–3: Literary Artistry, Ethical Message, and Some Considerations about the Image of Yahweh and Micah,” *JSOT* 85 (1999): 117–128.

12. James Nogalski, *Literary Precursors to the Book of the Twelve* (BZAW 217; Berlin and New York: de Gruyter, 1993); Ehud Ben Zvi, "Twelve Prophetic Books or 'the Twelve': A Few Preliminary Considerations," in *Forming Prophetic Literature: Essays on Isaiah and the Twelve in Honor of John D. W. Watts* (ed. Paul R. House and James W. Watts; LHBOTS 235; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1996), 125–156.
13. Eugene Peterson, *The Message: The Bible in Contemporary Language* (Colorado Springs: NAV Press, 2002).
14. Dempsey, "Micah 2–3," 19, 21.
15. In Hosea 14, nine comparisons appear; there are five in Hosea 13:7.
16. George Lakoff, "The Contemporary Theory of Metaphor," in *Metaphor and Thought* (ed. Andrew Ortony; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 202–251.
17. Phyllis Bird, "'To Play the Harlot': An Inquiry into an Old Testament Metaphor," in *Gender and Difference in Ancient Israel* (ed. Peggy L. Day; Minneapolis: Augsburg-Fortress, 1989), 75–94.
18. Cynthia Chapman, *The Gendered Language of Warfare in the Israelite-Assyrian Encounter* (Winona Lakes, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2004), 93.
19. See, for example, Cynthia R. Chapman, "Sculpted Warriors: Sexuality and the Sacred in the Depiction of Warfare in the Assyrian Palace Reliefs and in Ezekiel 23:14–17," in *Aesthetics of Violence in the Prophets*, 1–17.
20. Walter Brueggemann, "The Recovering God of Hosea," *HBT* 30 (2008): 5–20 (14–16).
21. Mary Daly, *Beyond God the Father: Toward a Philosophy of Women's Liberation* (rev. ed.; Boston: Beacon Press, 1993), 19.
22. For an overview, see Susanne Scholz, "Feminism: Second Wave Feminism," in *The Oxford Encyclopedia of the Bible and Gender Studies*, Volume 1 (ed. Julia M. O'Brien; New York: Oxford University Press, 2014), 242–251; also Julia M. O'Brien, "Imagery, Gendered: Prophetic Literature," 355–360, in the same volume.
23. L. Juliana M. Claassens, *Mourner, Mother, Midwife: Reimagining God's Delivering Presence in the Old Testament* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2012).
24. Peggy L. Day, "Deity: Hebrew Bible," in *The Oxford Encyclopedia of the Bible and Gender Studies*, Volume 1, 74–80.
25. Stuart Macwilliam, "Queering Jeremiah," *BibInt* 10 (2002): 384–404.
26. The allusion is to the opening line of the 1872 poem by Emily Dickinson catalogued as #1263: "Tell all the truth but tell it slant" (*The Poems of Emily Dickinson* [ed. R. W. Franklin; Cambridge, MA, and London: Belknap, 1998], 494).
27. Kathleen M. O'Connor, "Reclaiming Jeremiah's Violence," in *Aesthetics of Violence in the Prophets*, 37–49 (47).
28. Carole R. Fontaine, *With Eyes of Flesh: The Bible, Gender, and Human Rights* (The Bible in the Modern World 10; Sheffield: Sheffield Phoenix, 2008), 76.
29. Steed Davidson, "Prophets Postcolonially: Initial Insights for a Postcolonial Reading of Prophetic Literature," *BCT* 6/2 (2010): 24.1–24.13.
30. Erin Runions, *Changing Subjects: Gender, Nation, and Future in Micah* (Playing the Texts 7; London and New York: Sheffield Academic Press, 2001).
31. Patrick D. Miller, "The Theological Significance of Biblical Poetry," in *Language, Theology, and the Bible: Essays in Honour of James Barr* (ed. Samuel E. Balentine and John Barton; Oxford: Clarendon, 1994), 213–230.

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CHAPTER 15

GENRE CRITICISM AND THE PROPHETS

BARBARA GREEN

To understand genre is not a simple matter. A challenge to meet initially is the appropriate sorting of the relationship between form and genre. Were it simply a matter of consistency in terminology, a decision could readily be made. But since the matter is more complex than it appears and presents roots useful to understand, the first task here is to make practical and productive order from a snarl.

Let me begin with two analogies. First, imagine that you are visiting a military museum with your grandfather, looking at uniforms. You spot one that catches the eye, and say, “That soldier must have felt cold in the winter during the US Civil War!” Your companion says, “Soldier! That’s an admiral’s uniform from World War II!” Your grandfather is able to identify the uniform by specific characteristics and to place it precisely in its historical context, leaving no room for dissent. Later that same day, you prepare to appear for your part-time job as guard in the university library. You don’t work for a company, and so have needed to compose a uniform suitable to your responsibilities. You have assembled something that looks official, but you’ve skipped some of the detail (stripes down the pants leg, medals on the jacket breast). You decided to wear a utility belt but stocked it with a flashlight and cell phone, not with a gun or a Taser, certainly not with a sword. You have dispensed with a hat as being more trouble than it is likely worth. When pressed, you explain that your choices were based primarily on authority and function: who you need to be perceived to be and what you need to do. If someone takes your picture and you end up in a museum, it will not be immediately obvious just who hired you, to do what, or when you did it. But you are clearly “in uniform” and will be afforded a certain status, almost automatically, by library patrons and, you hope, by any troublemakers.

The first situation (military uniform) will help us understand form criticism adequately enough to move to our second venue (your self-styled guard uniform), genre study, which is where we need to be for the remainder of this chapter. To ask a lot of precise historical questions about your guard outfit will miss the point of whether your choices will enable you to do your job effectively.

The question of how prophets talked (or wrote) emerged in the late part of the nineteenth century in Anglo-European biblical study as part of the huge effort to bring historical questions, issues, and implications into the field of inquiry. The early form-critics, as they were called, operated on the assumption that what is extant in written form needed examination in terms of oral forebears. These scholars assumed, as well, that speech-forms were likely to be particular to discernible and specific social contexts. Their quest, generally speaking, was to isolate and identify oral templates and social situations that lay behind and that helped generate the written material we now possess. Terminology was slippery, if not sloppy: the word “form” could be used to denote a sort of Platonic template, a particular instance of one, a genre, even a structure. But the aim and interest were inherently historical and were fraught with what we can see now were the weaknesses of the early quests for historical precision in biblical matters.

More recently, a similar-seeming quest has gained popularity, sharing some aims and terminology: genre study. Here the interest is not necessarily or fundamentally historical (and certainly not operating under the old assumptions of form-criticism) but primarily literary. The quest here is for the understanding of literary genre: What was likely assumed as prophets spoke or wrote, and how can contemporary readers be assisted to anticipate what the ancients may have been aiming to suggest by their words as we have them? What particular shapes did those sets of words take, and why? How shall we construe them? If we do not key into genre conventions and explore their features the best we can, we will likely misunderstand the communication. So the two projects (form and genre) emerged from somewhat different projects, and scholars trained in them will likely act according to the norms and presuppositions of their disciplinary training. But we, now, need to be clear about which conversation we are entering, and we need especially to appreciate that the contemporary quest is usually not for historical precision or facticity. Since terminology often overlaps, with the terms “form” and “genre” being used somewhat interchangeably, we need to be as clear as possible about what we are seeking. It is a century too late to urge writers to clarity and consistency in terminology, so we “users” must be the ones to adapt. There is some thought to simply meld the two strands, but it seems best to leave them distinct, though overlapped, and to challenge us to proceed well-informed.

One quick return to the analogy before summarizing: The museum visit with an expert was analogous to an exercise in form-criticism: Grandfather’s single clear, correct identification of the admiral’s uniform at mid-twentieth century, deduced by its formal features and able to be tagged with historical accuracy. The second situation involving what to wear to your guard job is more open, less constrained, closely related to how you see yourself proceeding at a particular event: recognizable as staff, comfortable enough to survive your shift, hatless and weaponless. You may choose to wear one thing for one set of reasons, while another person on another shift may decide something else, though likely none will wear evening attire or a bathing suit to work. So we can see the differences: an admiral cannot vary his colors and will have to wear his uniform no matter what, though presumably it was designed with naval functions in mind. But you are much freer to make sartorial decisions than he will have been and can be more pragmatic, creative.

Genre, in the efficient words of one who has provided a discussion of various ancient as well as contemporary understandings, is “. . . a socially defined constellation of typified formal and thematic features in a group of literary works, which authors use in individualized ways to accomplish specific communicative purposes.”¹ Since genre bears on the matter of function, it will also be related to rhetoric, the artistic (and somewhat historically conditioned) choices of a speaker/writer to influence reception of language. We will be thinking of it more as a literary quest than as a historical one; more as a matter of function and communication than as cleanly classificatory; more as hybrid and complex than as agreed upon and simplex. We can anticipate that small genres collaborate to compose a larger and more obvious one. Carol Newsom (2010: 272–276) usefully characterizes a set of genre projects, related but distinct and in fact changing significantly as one moves along them as across a spectrum: Genre may be a matter of reliable containers into which words may be cast; or it may be a matter of shared family resemblances; genres may be modes of comprehension, formally or more socially conceived; or genres may be cues for receivers, to assist construction.² There is overlap of various sorts.³ A theorist like Brian Paltridge reminds us to anticipate flexibility between ideal types and actual occurrences, between classification and communication. He urges us to consider formal features but also thematic domains and social uses, to note differences between conceptual and pragmatic, oral and written. Some genres may be small, precise, clear (such as *haiku*), while some are larger, heterogeneous, comprising many subgenres (for example, the novel). Genres can be studied at various levels of abstraction and can be expected to clump with their fellows, the better to effect their communication.

My aim in this chapter is to offer a suitable sample of genres that work well and to draw them from a representative list of prophetic material. For each, I will name the genre, and characterize it briefly in terms of both its classic shape and also its likely or plausible function and effect. I will then choose a particular and representative example from a prophet and discuss that particular text in greater detail.

ALLEGORY

In allegory, the features of one more literal and familiar matter are considered and discussed in terms of the specific characteristics of another more allusive or implied entity to provide reader access to meaning, with the speaker’s challenge being to establish and build coherence in the elaboration of details. The use of the genre is not so much to surprise the hearer into insight as to intensify agreement comprehensively and compellingly, point by point, as the allegory develops. In Ezekiel 16, the prophet uses the life-journey of a dependent female and her male patron to suggest the relationship between God and Judah/Israel: The more literal description is of an infant born wild, neither bathed nor swaddled, seen but allowed to roam on her own until taken into marriage, at which time some special care (bathing and clothing) took place. But the fine adornment enjoyed by the new bride, as well as other gifts bestowed, became occasions of rebellion

and disloyalty, the bride taking up with lovers to the disgust of the husband/patron. The referent or match is to the indigenous and thus irregular origins of Judah/Israel, needing to fend for “herself” until such time as YHWH entered into covenant relationship with “her,” bestowing the privileges and obligations of being God’s unique people, gifts that God charges the people misused and abused. The characteristics of the life experience of a dependent woman are thus detailed to show and suit the life trajectory of God’s people as the relationship deteriorates. The impact of some sixty verses of description is to suggest overwhelmingly the thankless and intransigent guilt and wantonness of the bride/people and the righteousness of the husband/deity. For many moderns, at least, there may emerge as well an impression of overkill in blame, an overexposure of the cruelty of the husband as well as an outrage at the massive shaming of the wife.

ARGUMENT A *MINORI AD MAIUS*

In this small genre rooted in logic, the speaker promises that, on the basis of lesser evidence, worse (or greater) things can in fact be expected. Also called *qal veḥomer* or *a fortiori*, the structure names the lesser situation—often outsized already—and promises that something even more extreme can be anticipated. The speaker moves from the terrible to the unthinkable (or from good to better) to make the point. Obadiah 5–8 develops one of these. The prophet promises Edom repayment for unworthy deeds, arguing that if thieves or robbers approached you, they’d not take everything; or if gleaners passed hands over your vines, they’d leave a few grapes. But—how much the worse—the divinely authorized ransacking and pillaging of Edom, with your erstwhile allies forcing you out of your homes, having deceived and trapped you, without your anticipating or suspecting it. The progression aims to shock and insult, even torment the hearer/opponent to imagine what can be worse than bad. It likely has the additional impact of consoling the speaker’s partisans that they can anticipate satisfaction.

CALL/COMMISSION

A prophet occasionally provides a narrative sharing the circumstances of an initial call or commission, detailing the way in which God gained his attention, gave him a task to fulfill, and promised sponsorship. Typically the prophet initially demurs, indicating either that the task is too formidable or the prophet unsuited. But typically, the deity presses an override, either promising to help or explaining in more detail what is needed, eventually ordering that the charge must be taken up, with some sort of sign provided for reassurance. Scholars assume that, given the lack of official and recognizable credentials authorizing the prophet (no bloodline, no crown, no wisdom training), the call narratives functioned as proofs to opponents that, indeed, the prophet had been called

by God and had tried unsuccessfully to avoid the controversial life that the call entailed. If not convincing opponents, the call/commission form may have come to console the prophet himself and sustain hearers. Isaiah's call in chapter 6 is classic, though also creative in its use of the standard motifs: He reports seeing a vision of God, seated on a high throne, divine garment sweeping into and heavenly smoke filling the temple. The prophet registers unworthiness, both his own and that of his people, but an angel cauterizes his lips with a heavenly coal. Attended by angels as might be a king in a room of advisors, the deity is heard to wonder whom to send on a commission needing fulfillment. At once Isaiah volunteers, is accepted, and is assured that he will indeed be charged with the task but can expect to fail at it. The genre elaborates some of the classic themes of the prophetic book: glory and highness of the deity, the low condition of humans; the urgency of the work to be done but the short-range futility of the effort to do it.

DAY OF THE LORD SAYING

A theme as well as a genre, the promise or threat that a time is looming to change realities and surprise those who experience it is frequent in the prophets. It can come as a rider on many kinds of sayings, offering either hope to those afflicted by suffering or stimulating alarm among those inflicting trouble on others from disregard for what God wants accomplished. The genre, collaboratively intensifying the other genres it attends, assumes that, temporary appearances notwithstanding, God is powerful and will intervene effectively on the day, manifesting divine power to friend and foe alike. The simple expression can be elaborated with threatening details of many sorts: war, devastation, or catastrophic weather. Undoubtedly the genre began as a reassurance that God's own suffering people would be granted relief as the day comes upon opponents, a case visible in Obadiah 15, where the people of Edom are promised a sudden unpleasant experience of God's anger. Conversely, the prophet Joel promises his own addressees, YHWH's own people, that they will be shocked and shamed when the day of the LORD comes to them (1:15; 2:1, 11, 31; 3:14). At some point, the idea that the day bodes ill for YHWH's own people must have come as a shock, but our familiarity with the double-edged day blunts the surprise and may render the feature banal.

DIALOGUE

Dialogue (or discourse utterance) involves speech between two parties, where engaged listening occurs, as suggested by the responsive nature of the replies, common subject matter, vocabulary, and imagery. Distinguishable from the many instances in which God gives orders and the prophet remains silent, dialogue allows for agreement or disagreement, for fresh understanding and compromise. The genre often exposes

the anguish or anger of the prophet, and the difficulty of his understanding or accepting what is being communicated. The dialogues allow reader/hearers the opportunity to ponder the challenge of the human prophet's actually learning the will of the deity as well as the difficulty in understanding it and carrying it out. The prophet Jeremiah features some rich examples of this genre, notably in chapter 14, though the context and order of the material are not immediately clear. But Jeremiah 14:10–16 introduces a resolution by God addressed to the prophet, bidding him not to intercede for the people because, God claims, the deity is resolved not to listen to prayer or regard sacrifice. The prophet speaks up nonetheless, contravening exactly what has just been said, offering as an excuse that the people have been lied to by prophets who reassure them of peace and security in Jerusalem—not their fault, the prophet seems to suggest. God takes up the prophet's exact point, that indeed many are speaking who have been neither sent nor commissioned, but avers that lying prophets do not excuse misled listeners, and that those who mishear those who misspeak will suffer the consequences of the transaction. That they were lied to, the prophet learns, does not change the outcome, which will be famine, sword, disease, and defeat in the streets of Jerusalem, felling prophet and people alike. But liars must beware.

DIRGE

A dirge is a (mock) funeral song, often in distinctive meter in the Hebrew, bewailing the death of someone, recalling and extolling his or her merits, inviting further expressions of grief and outrage. Contrastive language builds up distinctions between one phase of life and another, valorizing earlier times while regretting their loss. Ezekiel 19:1–14 expresses the prophet's intense feelings at the demise of the royal house, with language contrasting early splendor with the shock of later and unexpected collapse. The point looms that, despite a promising start, kings and even the ruled nation are doomed to destruction. Tone is difficult to discern and must be gathered from wider context: genuine grief or implicit satisfaction.

DISCOURSE ASCRIBED

Ascribed discourse comprises the quoting of one character by another, the representation of another's speech into the discourse of the main speaker, whether accurately or re-stressed in some way in order to make a particular point. Clearly not a form in the sense referred to at the opening of this chapter, it is a useful device in terms of cuing the reader to an interpretive choice. To read ascribed genre as non-ascribed will be to miss a key facet of its communication. The impact of the genre is to position the words of the original speaker in the mouth of the borrower, usually to undermine credibility and

erode respect. In the early chapters of Jeremiah (e.g., 2–6), God testifies to the persistent wrong of Lady Zion and the men of Judah, simulating their own speech against them pervasively to characterize the males as malevolently defiant and the female as guilty but more placatory. Smaller instances of the genre occur elsewhere, for example, at 15:5–14, where God addresses Jerusalem, urging her that no one will pity her, even when the most dread suffering comes upon her. The language and imagery develop the theme of a grieving woman whose sons have been taken away untimely, and whose sun has set at noon, again suggesting “untimely.” In the midst of the description of the bereft woman comes ascribed speech, plausibly the claim of the sons taken away in the midst of the catastrophe. The son chides explicitly the woman who bore him and implicitly the deity who has abandoned him, maintaining his innocence as though being one who neither lent nor borrowed. And yet, the attributed speech suggests, since he is beset on every side, a man of conflict and cursing, his claim is specious. The ascribed speech flies in the face of all that the deity has testified about Jerusalem’s sons, making this one sound denying and defiant about what is happening, and certainly all the more guilty.

DISPUTATION

The genre of disputation is most fundamentally a case presented by one speaker against another who may or may not actually respond but whose participation is dialogically imagined as contesting. The speaker, affronted by implied claims, offers both a defense and a countercharge against the opponent. The prophet typically represents the side of divine justice and charges the people with violations of norms well known to them, with the result that the accused are both wrong and culpable. The disputation can be brief or more developed, with the opponent’s viewpoint suggested or sketched, only to be refuted. The advocate for the deity becomes judge as well, blending two roles that modern Westerners assume are split. The point is not so much to provide a fair and unbiased hearing as to demonstrate how the accused are at fault and why they are judged guilty. Micah represents this genre in 2:6–11, where the main speaker (the prophet) accuses others—present or imagined, spoken to or about—of trying to silence the testimony being offered as God’s. “Stop preaching,” they say. “That’s no way to preach! Shame shall not overtake us . . . the house of Jacob be condemned!” We fill in: “You can’t make those claims about *us*!” Two additional questions, posed indignantly and still by the prophet quoting his opponents’ presumptions, query whether the LORD’s patience is typically so short as the prophet’s preaching implies, and whether it is the divine practice to foreclose in the way the prophet suggests. The speaker quotes opponents so as to refute them, pointing out the interlocutors’ deficient attitude and reasoning. The prophet resumes his own persona and voice to suggest that the virtuous do not need to take offense at his words, whereas those who take offense are rightly charged with deeds of violence and injustice, showing themselves guilty and at cross-purposes with God’s project of justice, and hence in need of judicial rebuke before they bring destruction on the land. The prophet closes by suggesting that windy words about wine would be acceptable to such people, implying that

he is not about to argue in that mode. The guilt is thus made clear and underlined by the unwillingness of the targeted group to allow such words to reach their ears. Malachi 2:10–16 offers another sample of the genre: The prophet, speaking for conversation partners, inquires and in fact states interrogatively a point that all should be able to acknowledge, and then moves on to dispute that his interlocutors (opponents) have grasped it, attesting to contrary behaviors. He invokes divine punishment on such people before noting other behaviors, as well, that seem to flout the fatherhood of God, which presumably all accept. Adding now a rejoinder from those with whom he is disputing, the prophet concludes the unit by reinforcing his point with a divine quotation, effectively silencing his opponents. Prominent in this particular disputation are questions, which stress both the responsibility of other disputants to know pertinent reality and also their clear deficiency. As the genre anticipates, the party disputing the prophet is rendered mute.

DOXOLOGY/HYMN

Occasionally into the midst of primarily minatory language burst short poems of praise to God, stylized and lyrical, brief and unexpected, where the prophet seems to break off from warning and denunciation to speak in another register, resembling psalms more closely than prophetic speech. Though redactors puzzle over them, wondering how they got there and what might be their place in the rhetorical plan, we can appreciate these short sets of praise as a relief to some of the more standard harshness of prophetic discourse. Amos has three of these, 4:13, 5:8–9, 9:5–6, addressing God as shaper of mountains and summoner of winds, as treacher on high places of the seas, as creator of the heavenly planets, manager of the changing of day to night, designer of cosmic waters. God is also described as powerfully touching earth so that it trembles, causing the Nile to swell and overflow its accustomed place, indeed as constructing the divine dwelling with its chambers in the heavens while establishing the earth as well. The poems, coming amid the struggles of deity and prophet to gain the attention of the elites whose lavish lifestyles are impoverishing their fellows, remind those shaken by the poetry that God's power and authority are not minor, not to be dismissed.

EXHORTATION (AND ITS NEGATIVE PARTNER, ADMONITION)

This genre pair features an address to another, urging that a behavior be undertaken or, conversely, that it be avoided. Bolstered by reasons for the prophet's imploring language, the genre is aimed to be more persuasive than are some other instances that rely on authority. We are invited to ponder why a prophet who can command seeks to persuade. Haggai 2:6–13 employs the genre in the midst of visions aimed to conduce to temple rebuilding after

return from exile. Addressing first those witnesses who grieve that the Second Temple is a feeble replacement for the First, the prophet promises that, appearances notwithstanding, God is about to shake the cosmos with the result that the nations will pour wealth into the humble new temple, bringing prosperity to all. Isaiah 58:1–12 addresses the same general post-exilic community, warning them about the abuses of cult in the new (Second) Temple. Though people approach with offerings and mouth the prescribed sentiments, the prophet (speaking for the deity) explains that social injustice and liturgical participation are incompatible. Warning them against the futility of denying their sinfulness while imploring God's help, warning against stressing their cultic righteousness while refusing to acknowledge their deeds of oppression, the prophet urges new behaviors that suit better: deeds of justice and liberation as liturgical rubrics welcomed at the temple. The exhortations are presumably persuasive in their capacity to refigure ethics as worship.

LAMENT

This genre, found in psalms as well as in prophetic literature, expresses in vivid poetry the speaker's grief and anger at his and/or the people's present fate, contrasting it with happier times, elaborating the present distress, typically blaming opponents and exculpating God. Jeremiah most famously has several of these striated throughout chapters 11–20. His first two (11:18–23 and 12:1–6) use sheep and shepherd imagery to develop their point. The prophet cries out to the deity, here admitting that he went toward the slaughter like an innocent lamb, little suspecting, until informed by God, that those guiding him were indeed planning his silencing and slaughter. But now that he is in the know, the prophet begs God to punish them for what they had planned for him, indeed one of their kin. His second lament (or confession) also calls on God as vindicator of the righteous and innocent sufferer, begs God to drive to the slaughter the sheep that Jeremiah characterized as trying to shepherd him toward death in the previous poem. In both cases, the anguish and anger at the suffering provoked by his opponents is intense, and though the prophet prefaces his second lament by saying that he does not necessarily expect God to take his side, he belies that point by asking nonetheless. Somewhat atypically, Jeremiah's second lament receives a response from the deity—whether heard or ascribed by the prophet is unclear. But the divine utterance (12:5–6) challenges rather than consoles, offering a pair of proverbs by which the lamenter might assess his situation and act more shrewdly.

METAPHOR

A metaphor is an utterance in which a set of understandings belonging to one reality is asked to shed light upon another realm. This ancient trope was once more commonly classified as imagery or figural speech, but insofar as genres are reader strategies, we do well to

consider them as collaborative genres as well. To miss a metaphor cue can result in great confusion. Metaphor was understood classically (after Aristotle) as based on resemblance. More recently (in the twentieth century) and most recently (in cognitive metaphor theory), the suggestion is that the terms of the metaphor need not be—even *are* not—based on similarity. Rather, the likeness that the metaphor seeks to show arises as the unusual comparing is done. To use a metaphor can be to screen one set of traits through another to see what catches, to provoke new and diverse insight, beginning a chain of possibilities, some of which will be more fruitful than others. A famous metaphor occurring in Hosea is that of human family relations (marrying, having children) to suggest the relationship between the deity and the chosen people. Sketched with some variation of detail in his first three chapters, the prophet, speaking for the deity, urges that patriarchal marriage between a male and a female is helpful in exploring the more arcane bond between deity and people. The husband, seen as the controlling and righteous partner, engages with a woman who has been or may continue to be unfaithful in some way, whether relying on another patron for gifts, bearing his children, or the like. Unlike Ezekiel, who detailed allegorically a set of relations in which one realm matched the other, Hosea offers more metaphorically a series of quick images, and the hearer/reader is invited to probe specifically how the family metaphor illumines the YHWH/Israel bond (usefully or not). The metaphor that once seemed insightful and compelling to an ancient audience strikes many moderns as abusive. The prophet Nahum (2:12–13) is also instructive for his complex and multivalent use of the lion metaphor: We can, again, think of one domain (a frightening predator beast) as able to illumine another (here, Assyria, known both from Assyrian non-epigraphic data and from the text as emblemized as a lion) as hunted by YHWH, the successful lion-hunter. The prophet elaborates the Assyria-as-lion image by speculating about what has become of the lion's den, the broader land where lions dwell and pace proudly and fearlessly, shepherding their cubs. The lion is described as tearing its victims to provide for its young, filling its lair with savaged animals in order to provide for its family. Not least is the notion that if the powerful and dreaded Assyrian lion, just described in six aspects, is claimed to be vanquished, the agent of that deed is shown to be very powerful indeed. When we allow a metaphor to be intertextually enriched (e.g., think of Amos's use of YHWH as lion), we draw a much more complex and ambivalent figure, prompting us to contemplate the notion that the lion is both our helper and our opponent. The prophet Joel, famously detailing the havoc wrought by locusts (2:1–11), prompts us to wonder about whether locusts are the literal foe of the land, or whether they are a metaphor for a human opponent. The question is not able to be answered definitively and may not need to be answered here, but the sorting of it is productive of considerable insight: How do foraging locusts offer insight into an invading army?

METONYMY

Metonymy, related to though distinguishable from metaphor, can be seen as a special instance of some of the metaphoric processes by which the language of one reality is used

to suggest unexpected insight into another. Like metaphor, metonymy is both a figure of speech and a tiny genre, typically helping a larger utterance to make its effect. Metonymy involves using a small portion or detail of something to suggest the presence of the fuller element. The understatement and the phantom detail tease the mind to speculate on the fuller implication below the surface of what is said. Nahum, for example (1:13), when envisioning the reversal of the long oppressive hold Assyria maintained over Israel and Judah, talks in terms of snapping the Assyrian yoke off the neck and shoulders of Judah, breaking the controlling cords; here, the means by which a farmer guides a plow animal suggests the vast and abusive power the Assyrians maintained over the economic and eventually the political fortunes of Judah. The image of guidance apparatus for plowing both represents and understates the complex relation between Assyria and Judah: There is more to an animal's power than the task a farmer can conduce it to do with reins and yoke, and yet the guide apparatus indeed reduces the animal to obeying the plowman. The single moment of breaking the control apparatus of the animal makes suggestively vivid what is about to happen.

PARABLE

A parable is a brief narrative, setting a scene of some sort, with an implied address to a character and surely as well to a reader. Though often simple at the surface, the parable genre poses a situation in which the addressee is challenged to situate something familiar in terms of something else less obvious, with the characteristics of the clearer, simpler, and perhaps disarming situation able to circumvent the challenges of examining the less obvious thing. It has been suggested fruitfully that a parable is a narrative metaphor (i.e., having a metaphoric core developed in a story, rather than remaining a kernel). The Greek word from which "parable" comes suggests that two things are thrown together, while the Hebrew word (*mashal*) that covers riddling speech cues us to the enigmatic nature of the utterance. Though parables are common and distinctive in the New Testament, there are few like them in the Hebrew Bible. The function of a parable is to induce reflection and insight, often to get an audience to contemplate something unpalatable with a story that seems innocuous. A wonderful example of the parable genre is Isaiah 5:1–7, a vineyard story. The prophetic narrator introduces the piece as a song, sung for a friend about his vineyard. It starts simply enough, with sensible details about owning and developing such a piece of property, then moves quickly with parallel lines to emphasize the construction of the place and, eventually, the destruction of it. There is no struggle to understand the basic storyline. But in the middle of the song the singer/speaker reveals by pronoun choice that the vineyard is his own and has become quasi-personified. He poses two pointed, challenging, and virtually unanswerable questions to listeners/readers, inviting them to take sides between players: What more could I have done that I failed to do? How did good grapes produce a bad vintage? It is evident that the genre uses the prosaic and familiar details of agriculture to pose deeper and

more difficult ones of refusal and failure in the divine/human relationship. The challenge is for all hearers (within the text and outside it) to find selves and roles described, to be confronted with the appraisal of a serious other (prophet speaking for deity), and to respond in a salutary way. The unthinkable detail of the owner working to destroy a beloved heritage by reversing the building process is shocking and sad, and the silence of those addressed is not a surprise in the genre, suggesting that the owner/singer has indeed posed a difficult problem, in this instance about how God's project with Judah can have gone so wrong.

PARODIC SPEECH

A speaker may choose to imitate the discourse of another, with a mind to inverting it or even ridiculing it, perhaps appearing to share its assumptions and to use its particular phrases to a group that will recognize them, but then signaling at some point (to readers, if not to textual addressees) that the conventions are being imitated, questioned, critiqued, undermined, ridiculed, or dismissed as foolish, with a clear alternative implied. The strategy behind such a genre is to evidence both that the speaker is alert to what addressees know and value, and has passed judgment against it, such that it is discredited. Parody is powerful in that once one has heard something mocked skillfully, it is difficult to accept it as respectfully as before. The matter is more serious if the parody has been performed in the presence of others, so that the object of the parody has been shamed publicly. The challenge is to discern the parodic edge, the precise place or way in which "straight" language goes slant. Isaiah 36:13–22 features a particularly brilliant example of parody, in which the Assyrian official (called the Rabshakeh) is delegated by the military commander to appeal to the citizens of Jerusalem to surrender peacefully, rather than risk siege and attack against their city with the likely result that it will be taken, the fate of many other settlements in the region. The Rabshakeh mocks and inverts language of what can be identified as Isaian discourse and theology/ideology to catch the attention of all listening: Thus says the great king: "On whom are you relying? If on the LORD God, will God have been pleased at the destruction of altars recently by your king? . . . Don't say, 'The LORD will surely save us.' . . . I promise you security under your own vine and fig tree. . . . Have any gods saved their people yet?" The impact of the speech can be estimated by the fact that the Judean officials beg the Rabshakeh to converse with them in Aramaic, lest the people hear the shocking nature of what is being proposed.

PERSONIFICATION

Personification is a genre ubiquitous in the prophets, offered in various sizes, from a brief reference to a more extended and developed trope. The choice is to name as a single

person a group that is more diffuse, and of course more complex. The genre can be reductive and may seem unfair, the characterizing of a larger set under a particular name. But it can also be richly suggestive in many ways, the naming of a whole set of people under one name. Personification enables a quick instance of intertextuality, as a character like Daughter Zion in one place can easily be explored as the persona occurs elsewhere. To personify involves making an attribution of gender and likely of class, risks caricaturing in order to be vivid and clear. Daughter Zion appears in prophets set in contexts from the eighth century on, and a few quick instances can demonstrate the genre and its several impacts. Micah calls Jerusalem Daughter Zion, referencing the hill on which Jerusalem is set, signaling her (and it) as threatened and vulnerable, needing rescue (4:8), as crying out in labor and hence pained and vulnerable (4:9–13) and in need of help, likely and typically from a male savior, such as a king. She may be empowered by another in order to undergo an ordeal (4:14). Jeremiah uses the feminine singular attribution of Zion pervasively in chapters 2–3 and is able to suggest some attitudes and behaviors that are typical of her (e.g., speaking one thing and then contradicting it: 2:23, 25). Daughter Zion laments and grieves throughout Lamentations (e.g., ch. 1); she is proud and haughty when the prophet describes her attire (Isaiah 3:16–24); she is threatened with physical abuse (in Jer 6:24–25). Finally, in Isaiah 37:22 she is characterized differently still, as able to see and hear through the rhetorical posturing of the Assyrian Rabshakeh and to despise and ridicule him behind his back, shaking her head in derision at his inflated and intemperate assertions. These few samples of a ubiquitous genre suggest the vast range of points that prophets are able to suggest about both “the Zion project” (e.g., from inviolable to shattered) and to offer non-intended readers multiple possibilities for response. That Daughter Zion is characterized in primarily patriarchal terms seems undeniable, and yet functioning from within the fullness available from the metaphor, to reduce it to simply one valence or reception would be unfortunate. In a genre so malleable and open to nuance as this one, multiple insights ought to be able to emerge.

PRAYER

A genre most familiar from Psalms, prayer also occurs occasionally in the prophetic literature, when the prophet addresses and invokes the deity directly, pouring out diverse feelings, asking for certain things and begging to be spared others. Inevitably, sub-genres compose the main one: questions, comparisons, metaphors, and ascribed speech all abound. Typically, as the prayer ends, the petitioner gives thanks to God for gifts anticipated. A useful example comes in Jonah 2, as the prophet cries to God from the belly of the large fish, where he had been stored for three days after rescue from stormy waters encountered after boarding a boat to avoid his assignment. The prayer, a mix of second-person and third-person appeals, may seem borrowed, trite, and stale, ill-suited to its context, and yet some parts are most relevant to the circumstances described in the

events leading up to the prophet's being dropped overboard: vivid references to water troubles. The prayer is also suitable in that it seems to work on the pray-er as well as the prayed-to: Jonah, emerging from the fish, has experienced not only mercy from God but now finds it in himself to reverse direction and go to preach in Assyria. Within the short book where it is found, the prayer seems to achieve its intended effect and to offer readers a window into an intimate relationship between deity and prophet.

PRONOUNCEMENT

Prophets are often asked for advice, but also provide it unsolicited to those whose behavior requires it. In some instances the pronouncement is positive (salvation), though frequently the words promise a negative outcome (punishment). Haggai 2:10–19 offers such a piece: Set amid the apparently pervasive unwillingness to rebuild the temple after their return from exile and thus to be able to worship appropriately, deity and prophet press the people to reflect on their own behavior and its outcomes. God directs Haggai to seek a pair of rulings from the priests about the contagion of ritual uncleanness, queries that are answered correctly by those consulted. But the prophet supplements what has been given correctly (and with no apparent struggle) with a pronouncement neither asked nor evidently anticipated: A dearth of results from what might be anticipated (a quest for fifty units of wine finding only twenty) will reverse when the temple rebuilding begins, and blessings will become abundantly available, appearances notwithstanding. Those who have not asked a question are provided with a response and are urged to trust it, though it looks unlikely. A pronouncement, unbidden, both rebukes and consoles the people (or warns them, in the case of a negative word).

QUESTION

A tiny genre, again frequently used as a building block in larger genres, is the question—often called rhetorical. In common usage, to label a question rhetorical implies that it is somewhat false and has no real function, that the answer is obvious and known to all. In the context of genres, however, the term “rhetorical” modifying the noun “question” queries the effect upon the reader/hearer and is far from meaningless. Such questions are aimed to flush out the unwilling or reluctant participation of the addressee, and are designed so as to coerce or conduce participation in the point the prophet is aiming to make or the picture he is attempting to sketch. As the audience is not able to avoid the pitch of the questions and can be led, query by query, closer to the main point the prophet is establishing, the insight will be available to all but the most resistant. The imagery of the questions is typically massively involved in the strategy of the larger point. Amos has a set of these in 3:3–7: Each is framed to be answered with a negative; each

is drawn from nature, each more frightening than the previous, each set up in terms of cause and effect. Questions build, from more innocuous (two not likely to meet unless by appointment) to the more ominous (misfortune not falling on a town without God's willing it). And they home in on the point that God has acted, has roared, and not without effect; the prophet asks as well how, given the roar of the divine lion, can he *not* prophesy. The main themes from Amos emerge in the set of questions hurled at his silent hearers, and even without their response, the seriousness and inevitability of minatory prophecy is established. Whether his words give offense or not, Amos makes his case that he must communicate what he has heard from God.

ROOT METAPHOR

Clearly akin to metaphor, a root metaphor ramifies and complexifies the pair of realities that construct the piece, neither in the linear and consistent way of the allegory nor in the narrative way of the parable, but more randomly and cumulatively, so that the various detailed features intersect and prompt even more reflective insight than happens with the other related genres. Isaiah 40–55 develops the root metaphor of the journey back from Exile in terms of the Exodus from Egypt, drawing out diverse features, such as the invitation to depart, the transformed nature of the terrain, the wondrous experience of the journeyers, and the reality of liberation. He also juxtaposes imagery from God's creation of the world, the fashioning of creatures, habitats, and cosmic realities, with the effect that the return from Babylon/Persia is not simply a new exodus but is in fact a new creation, a fresh in-breaking of God's creative favor into the lives of God's people. Root metaphors are virtually inexhaustible and almost ineffable in the panoply of language they offer for consideration.

SATIRE/TAUNT

A satire or taunt is a genre designed to insult and demean its addressee, whether that personage is actually addressed or spoken about, naming plausible issues or situations and constructing them in detail to inflict damage on the addressees or referents. Habakkuk 2:6–20 offers such a taunt, addressed to an oppressor of his people, presumably some local elite (though the specific target of the taunt remains vague). Having characterized this figure generally as dishonest and unjust in 2:4–5, the prophet moves to detail the ways in which victims have suffered. Punctuated or marked with the exclamation of “Woe,” the language promises apt retribution, condemning the malefactor on several counts: First, for plundering others, he may expect creditors to take his possessions from him; second, for extortion that has built his house, he may expect his ill-gotten home's stones and rafters to condemn him; third, for harmful crimes that built

cities, the accused must anticipate that testimony to God's glory will fill the earth; and finally, he that forced drunkenness on others and took shameful advantage of them will be forced to drink the cup, stagger, and be shamed. Summatively, he who invested in falsehood will be let down by and disappointed in it at a moment of calling for help. The powerful one will be forced to confront and be victimized by his own crimes. We can, perhaps, hear the wish of the speaker as driving the taunts, but the impact may be a sort of reminder that reversal comes to the powerful, imaginatively if not always in actuality. The German word *Schadenfreude* conveys the complex and conflicted notion that one can rejoice over the harm befalling others and be glad to do so. Assisting and nuancing the taunt, this concept conveys an additional prompt to an alert reader. Oracles against (or about) the nations are filled with examples of this sentiment, and we can sample it in Nahum 3:18–19, a moment bringing to a conclusion the entire account of the collapse of Assyrian power that had so long dominated all in the region. As the Assyrian shepherds whose responsibility it has been to guard the sheep are caught sleeping, and their sheep have been scattered and even savaged as their keepers have nodded off, so all who have suffered at the hands of those same shepherds clap their hands over their heads. The feeling is perhaps less conflicted for the intended readers than for moderns, who may flinch at the call to rejoice at bad fortune befalling even an opponent—or who may feel ashamed if they do not flinch.

SYMBOLIC ACTION (REPORTED)

The prophetic corpus abounds with symbolic actions assigned and performed, often presented in terms of directions to the prophet or the description of compliance (often both). The impact of the action is also provided, even if the result is no apparent response at all, a refusal of the action. The prophet Ezekiel has many of these, not least as he falls silent in the midst of his ministry and must mime to any watching. Typically, the actions are absurd or grotesque at the surface, perhaps to catch the attention and provoke the query of a jaded or unwilling community, but also, presumably, to suit the pedagogical point that needs to be made. So in 5:1–4 we hear the prophet instructed by God to barber his head with a sword or a knife and weigh the trimmings, so as to divide them prominently, carefully. When the prophet comes to learn that the siege of Jerusalem is ended and Zion breached, he is to take one-third of the hair and destroy it (to suggest those who die in the battle itself), to distribute another third around the city (for those who do not survive the fall of the city), and to watch the last third be blown into exile and pursued by the sword or knife (suggesting those harried into exilic captivity). The time between the shaving and the dispersal of the hair invites speculation on the part of witnesses, with the inexorable choices already made ready before they come to accomplishment. The symbolic actions are doubly instructive: for those who witness them before they come to pass, and for later interpreters who search them for insight about God's ways with humans, and human ways with God.

THEOPHANY REPORT

This genre describes the manifestation of God as witnessed by a human being, detailing both the actions and characteristics of the deity and the corresponding effect on the witness. The language is richly elaborated and dramatic, even exaggerated, both frightening and consoling. Habakkuk, who had complained earlier in the text (1:2–4 and 13–17) that God was dilatory, shortly thereafter (in 3:3–15) offers a description of the arrival of the deity, attended by pestilence and plague, shaking the earth, shattering the mountains, the effects of the divine arrival larger than local, more momentous than physical. The prophet himself suffers cosmically at what he experiences: loose bowels, quivering lips, weakened bones—and yet he maintains faith in the ultimate good that the theophanic presence has done before and will do in the prophet's own day.

UNCREATION SAYING

A small and distinctive genre, assisting its host setting by adding a totalizing urgency to something already dire (perhaps more familiar from Job 3, where it is detailed in many more verses), it is used as well by prophets who call for the reversal of creation. An invocation for uncreation is not simply to be equated with destruction. The reversal of creation itself is more foundational and frightening. The prophet Zephaniah (1:2–3) announces God as reversing the three fundamental spheres familiar as God's creation: the solid surface of earth where humans and animals live, the sky where birds spend much time, and the sea where fish live. The creator who reverses the beneficence of creation is dread indeed, and fear intensifies as God's primal act is undone. Used in war imagery where the obvious foes are human, the small genre underlines the notion common in the prophets that the destruction of the enemy is God's deed, not the action of humans. The genre thus manages to stress divine omnipotence as discernible behind fallible human deeds.

VISION (REPORT)

Prophets characteristically have visions from God and then report them to those who need to consider or understand such things but rely on prophets for intermediation. The slippage between participants (God to prophet, prophet to people) reminds us of the fragility of prophetic intermediation: the difficulty of hearing God well and discerning how such communication is suited to what is being experienced, and the frequent unwillingness or refusal of people to accept what they are told as though it were indeed

of God. Zechariah 1–6 comprises some eight visions, where the prophet must struggle to make tangible and authoritative what has been experienced by the one and must be somehow accepted by others. Zechariah's first vision (1:7–17) is instructive: Carefully dated by the book narrator, the narrative is soon taken over by the prophet himself to describe what he saw and to relate the question to his interpreting angel, thus alerting hearers/readers know what the issue is: Seeing multicolored horses, the prophet asks what they are and learns that their role is to patrol and that their report suggests that the earth is tranquil. Oddly but usefully, the angel signals not relief but frustration at that news, begging God for an end to the curse of exile. God speaks consolingly to the angel, who repeats the words to the prophet: God's use of the nations as a tool to punish Judah has gone awry, and God will now intervene to restrain them and rebuild Jerusalem and bring to it the bounty of the nations. In a third vision (2:5–9) the prophet, seeing a man with a measuring line, learns from an angel what is pertinent: that the line is not needed. The city will not be requiring or tolerating measurement, will overflow with people and animals, and will be surrounded by God's protective fire. If we recall that both Amos and Ezekiel have used the measuring motif, we are additionally encouraged to see that the return from exile will be blessed beyond previous times. The visions need explanation, and only an otherworldly being can provide it. The prophet in this case knows the question but not the answer; nevertheless, he knows that help is available to him and to the people to whom he speaks.

NOTES

1. Brown 2008: 122.
2. See Newsom 2010.
3. The volume edited by Marvin A. Sweeney and Ehud Ben Zvi (2003) demonstrates scholars' blending and shifting perceptions or moving from one set of assumptions to another.

FOR FURTHER READING

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CHAPTER 16

REDACTION CRITICISM AND THE PROPHETS

JAMES D. NOGALSKI

THE *Nevi'im* constitute the canonical designation for eight scrolls, four comprising the so-called Former Prophets (Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings) and four comprising the Latter Prophets (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Twelve). A sea change has occurred in the last thirty years in the study of prophetic literature. Scholarship in the early part of the twentieth century set aside the work of the redactors because the focus was on finding the *ipsissima verba* (the actual words) spoken by the prophet for whom the book was named. By the end of the century, two things had changed. General skepticism reigned with regard to finding, with any degree of confidence, the original speeches of the historical prophets, and scholars came to have a much higher regard for the work of the scribes and tradents who collected, shaped, and transmitted the scrolls. The creative shaping of the scrolls by persons who transmitted the materials, combined with actualizations for later generations, exerted far more influence on the final form of the collection than did the prophet for whom the writings are named. Interpreting the whole, not merely the parts, is the task of redaction criticism. Despite some inherent limitations with the method, redaction criticism has opened up new vistas for interpreting prophetic literature.

QUESTIONS OF METHOD

Early History of Redaction

Early redactional studies of prophetic writings showed little concern for the work of the redactors. Instead, the goal of redactional studies in the early part of the twentieth century focused heavily on the task of isolating prophetic speeches, unfortunately labeled

as “genuine” source material, from material that had been added as “secondary” to the authentic words of a prophet. Commentators generally showed far less interest in this secondary material, for as the name implied, it was not deemed to be as important as that material that came from the actual mouth of the prophet. As criteria for determining secondary material became more refined, questions were raised about more and more passages, concerning whether or not they represented “genuine” material from the prophet or not. James Muilenburg (1969), Walther Zimmerli (1979), and Brevard Childs (1979) raised serious questions about the inadequacy of ignoring the rhetorical function of the prophetic material and the role that the shaping of prophetic writings played in conveying a theological message. The books as we have them are not transcriptions of speeches. They represent literary products, each of which was generations in the making, that resulted from theological reflection on what to include, where to include it, how to shape it, and how to change it. See the cautionary arguments against isolating the genuine words of the prophets themselves, as opposed to the character of the prophet, in Jeremiah by Karl-Friedrich Pohlmann (1996: 40–41).

Redaction History

More recent redactional work on the prophetic corpus has taken to heart critiques about the need to take the final form of the text seriously, including both its homogeneous and heterogeneous features, as part of any model for reconstructing the history of a prophetic scroll. In many ways, redaction criticism functions as an extension of literary criticism (*Literarkritik*, a term inaccurately translated as “source criticism” in many English language works). *Literarkritik* analyzes the entire literary form of a text, including the task of identifying characteristics that support a text’s homogeneity or heterogeneity. If and when a text exhibits signs that more than one person had a hand in the creation of the text as it stands, the intrusive material is set aside *temporarily* in order to focus on the “earliest written form” of the text that can be described using these analytical processes. The difficulty of getting behind the earliest written form to postulate about oral transmission of prophetic material cannot be discussed here. It remains a necessary but much more complicated part of the exegetical process (see Odil Hannes Steck 1998: 63–74 and Uwe Becker 2011: 65–78). At this point, newer redactional studies differ from those literary-critical analyses of the early twentieth century. Those early endeavors, with a few exceptions, showed little interest in understanding the “secondary” material. The newer studies, by and large, take into account the need to explain the text in its entirety, up to and including its final form. Redaction criticism seeks to evaluate this heterogeneous material in order to ascertain when and why it may have entered the corpus.

If *Literarkritik* represents the analytical process of separating the heterogeneous material to determine the earliest written form of the text at hand, redaction history represents the return trip: the classification of the “secondary” material and putting the pieces back together again. For example, whereas literary criticism may have isolated

an insertion into an existing text, redaction history asks whether that insertion belongs with another portion of the writing, whether it merely comments on the immediate context, whether it evidences an even broader literary horizon, or whether it represents an isolated gloss.

Reasons for associating editorial activity in one place with editorial activity elsewhere in the corpus can vary. The role of editors can range from the compilation and placement of independent oracles in collections (a role widely recognized in early sections of Amos 3–6 and Hosea 4–10) to the creation and/or incorporation of compositions of varying sizes (e.g., Isaiah 36–39, a parallel to 2 Kings 18–20, that is now largely recognized as a block of material adapted and included to create a transition from the eighth-century orientation of most of Isaiah 1–33 to the clearly Persian-period materials of 40–66). Redactional studies evaluate the supplemental material to ascertain whether there are literary, theological, or other characteristics in these texts that would suggest they share a common purpose with texts elsewhere in the writing, and to describe as far as possible the points at which this material would have been added to the earlier written material. On this, see the discussion of Leslie Allen on Jeremiah (2008: 10–11). Before continuing, one must recognize the important role that text criticism has come to play in understanding the development of parts of the prophetic corpus.

Text Criticism and Redaction Criticism

At times, text criticism and redaction criticism overlap. With the publication of the Dead Sea Scrolls and other texts from the Judean desert, the portrait of the textual history of prophetic scrolls has been complicated immensely. The pluriformity of texts circulating in Qumran and elsewhere irrefutably demonstrates that the road to the Masoretic Text (MT), which forms the basis for most modern translations, was not a straight one. At the same time, these (often fragmentary) texts and translations also delimit the time frame during which the prophetic corpora were shaped. In many instances, difficult texts that scholars once presumed to have experienced scribal corruption have had to be re-evaluated because the textual difficulties were already present in these early manuscripts. Thus, these manuscripts create a significant paradox in that while they document a multiplicity of textual traditions, they also testify to the general stability of the prophetic texts from the second and third century B.C.E. when compared to Codex Leningradensis, the eleventh-century C.E. text that forms the basis of the critical editions of *BHK*, *BHS*, and *BHQ*. See the definitions of diplomatic editions versus eclectic versions of critical editions in Tov (2012: 418).

Of the four scrolls comprising the prophetic corpus, two of them (Jeremiah and Ezekiel) display a significantly different size in the *Vorlage* of the Greek translation in comparison to the MT, while the texts of Isaiah and the Twelve are essentially the same length. The MT of Jeremiah is roughly one-eighth longer than the Hebrew text of the Old Greek version when it is retroverted into Hebrew. The most common explanation for this difference is that the LXX translators worked from a shorter Hebrew

text. Consequently, the longer Hebrew text of the proto-MT continued to develop, while the Hebrew *Vorlage* of the LXX represents, for the most part, an earlier version of Jeremiah, though it also shows some development. The fact that two of the four fragments at Qumran containing portions of Jeremiah in Hebrew, 4QXII^b and 4QXII^d, coincide more closely to the LXX than to the MT significantly increases the odds that the differences in these two traditions do not result from the Greek translators. Rather, the changes happened as a result of the transmission of the Hebrew text. Emanuel Tov (1981) has classified this supplementary material into six types: text arrangement, addition of headings to prophecies, repetitions of sections, addition of new verses and sections, addition of new details, and changes in content. Despite this evidence, at least two recent commentaries (Lundbom 1999 and Fischer 2005) reject the idea that the growth of the MT is the best explanation. While they succeed in making the important point that each case of variant readings needs to be evaluated separately, the case for the omission of text from the LXX *Vorlage* seems, on the whole, far less likely than the continued growth of the Hebrew tradition. This is especially the case for Lundbom's arguments for numerous cases of haplography.

The other major difference between the LXX and the MT of Jeremiah is the location of the oracles against the nations. In the MT, these oracles appear almost at the end of the corpus (Jeremiah 46–51), whereas in the earlier *Vorlage* of the Greek version, the same oracles appear in a different order after Jeremiah 25:13, or in the middle of the scroll. The fact that the sequence of the nations in the MT shows a more deliberate movement from west to east suggests that the MT order is later than the order in the LXX.

The issues are similar in Ezekiel, though differences are smaller in number, and while the Qumran parallels are not as clear, the evidence of Papyrus 967 aligns closely with that of the shorter LXX. Three longer minuses appear in the LXX at Ezekiel 12:26–28, 32:25–26, 36:23b–38. Additionally, Ezekiel 7 evidences a number of pluses (7:5b, 6b–7a, 10b, 11c) and transpositions of verses in the MT when compared with the LXX. Some work has been done comparing the additional material for redactional tendencies based upon the later Hebrew developments (Lust 2003: 83–92). As with Jeremiah, the evidence strongly suggests that the MT continued to develop *after* the *Vorlage* of the LXX was copied, if not after the text was translated into Greek.

The issues in the Twelve and Isaiah are not, by and large, questions of a different text. The variant readings are much more open to interpretation, and generally reflect an attempt to make sense of difficult texts, usually on the part of the translator (though some can also be the result of changes by Hebrew scribes). For example, in the Book of the Twelve, the biggest differences between the MT, the early manuscripts from the Judean desert, and the Greek translations known elsewhere comprise the different orders of the writings in the first half of the Twelve. The most common order for the Greek tradition moves Amos and Micah after Hosea, with Joel, Obadiah, and Jonah remaining in the same order as in the MT. This rearrangement of the writings reflects a hermeneutical decision, but it implies a redactional decision that results in highlighting different thematic connections (Sweeney 2000). Additionally, one Hebrew manuscript (4QXII^a)

likely, but not with certainty, preserved Jonah after Malachi; see Fuller (1996; 1997: 221–222); Steck (1996); Guillaume (2007); Brooke (2006).

The large Isaiah scroll from Qumran does not contain major sections that have been rearranged, nor does it demonstrate a substantially different text that has continued to develop after the Old Greek was translated. It does, however, show a significant number of variant readings (Ulrich 2013), suggesting that scribes often attempted to clarify obscurities in the text. The scroll also contains a number of marginal glosses that are not part of the text itself.

Cumulatively, the state of textual analysis provides a complicated picture of texts in flux (especially Jeremiah and Ezekiel), yet since some of the early Qumran manuscripts come from the third century, they also provide physical documentation of the existence of the prophetic collections (even if they do not reflect the MT tradition exclusively) by the beginning of the second century B.C.E.

COMPOSITION, COMPILATION, AND SHAPING

Shaping and Actualizing the Scrolls

The label “secondary” is no longer a prominent term in redactional studies. Rather, scholars attempt to classify and sequence the material to explain its relationship to the foundational layer (*Grundschrift*) of the recorded text. Insertions, additions, *Fortschreibungen*, editorial frames, and isolated glosses represent terms that one will more likely find in recent redactional studies. When supplemental material appears in more than one location in a writing, and a strong case can be made that the similarity is tied to an editor’s agenda, that material may be grouped together and labeled to help classify the redactional agenda. See, for example, the names of Jakob Wöhrle’s layers for the Book of the Twelve, such as foreign nations oracles I, foreign nations oracles II, and grace layer (*Fremdvölkerschicht* I, *Fremdvölkerschicht* II, and *Gnadenschicht*). Frequently, however, especially in Jeremiah and Ezekiel, the supplementary material may relate to a specific passage without necessarily commenting on the entire scroll. Such material may be classified as a *Fortschreibung*, an actualization of a text for a later audience, or an isolated gloss, a (usually) brief insertion to clarify or comment upon something in a verse that cannot be clearly identified as part of a redactional agenda. Such supplemental material may or may not be associated with a specific redactional layer.

Scribal Prophecy

Recognition of the phenomenon of scribal or written prophecy (*Schriftprophetie*) has continued to grow. This phenomenon takes seriously the growth of a corpus as the work

of scribal tradents (groups and individuals) who were much more than mere copyists. These scribal prophets were well versed in the texts on which they worked, and in the developing canon as well. Some prophetic writings owe their existence to scribal prophets. Siegfried Bergler's work (1988) on Joel, Helmut Utzschneider's treatment (1989) of Malachi, and quite a number of the more recent redactional models now work on the assumption that educated scribes had a major impact on the formation of the prophetic scrolls.

Small Collections

Analysis suggests that most of the books involve the gradual accretion of small collections and compositions, along with various means of linking these texts. Amos illustrates how the shape of a prophetic writing developed by combining several existing compositions that were not necessarily joined with one another originally. Amos 1–2 represents a composition of eight oracles against the nations that have a similar form and opening refrains ("For three transgressions and for four, I will not take it back"). Nevertheless, numerous scholars have argued that a core group of these oracles was updated in the exilic period by a redactor who mimicked the style of the original collection to include a broader array of nations by adding oracles against Tyre (1:9–10), Edom (1:11–12), and Judah (2:4–5) to this collection. The placement of these three presumes knowledge of the geographical flow and the style of the original composition.

Similarly, the five visions of Amos (7:1–3, 4–6, 7–9; 8:1–3; 9:1–4) represent a longer composition of similarly patterned accounts that heighten the threat of divine punishment with each vision in the cycle. Debate exists about whether the final vision was part of the original composition. Regardless, this composition has been interrupted by the incorporation of a prophetic narrative (7:10–17) and a rehearsal of key themes from Amos 1–7 that functions as a concluding reflection (8:4–14) before the final vision (9:1–4).

By contrast, the center and largest section of Amos (chapters 3–6) reflects the character of an anthology, with each chapter beginning with a new introduction to the subsequent oracles (3:1; 4:1; 5:1; 6:1). Most recent models assume that these sections of Amos were independently transmitted for some time before being joined with one another.

Jeremiah's oracles against the nations (OAN) provide another example of how recognizable blocks of material were handled differently by earlier and later tradents. The early form of these oracles represented in the Old Greek tradition was re-sequenced and moved from the middle (appearing originally after 25:13) to near the end of the scroll (chapters 46–51), probably in order to heighten their eschatological function. The later version of Jeremiah thus concludes with the OAN and suggests that the nations will be punished after Jerusalem is punished; note especially the drinking of the cup imagery used of Edom (49:12) and Babylon (51:7). These OAN in the MT lead directly to a description of Jerusalem's destruction (Jeremiah 52), a text that is a parallel to 2 Kings 25, and which ends with the narrative of Jehoiachin's release from prison. In its current

location, it provides a more hopeful ending because it implies the nearness of the punishment for the nations.

Cultic Source Blocks

Cultic source blocks illustrate another type of source used in the redaction of prophetic books. Scholarship has indicated that preexisting compositions (often with editorial adaptations) were incorporated into prophetic writings for which they were not originally composed. These thanksgiving songs, theophanic hymns, and calls to lament may appear within a prophetic work, but they likely belonged originally in a cultic setting. Their placement may reflect a redactional agenda in their current setting. Such cultic source blocks are particularly prominent in the Book of the Twelve, though they also appear in the other scrolls. In the Twelve, one can point to the thanksgiving song in Jonah 2, the theophanies at the beginning of Nahum and the end of Habakkuk, the disputations of Malachi, the core laments of Joel 1–2, and other texts (Nogalski 2009: 30–39).

Rolling Corpus versus Larger Compositional Blocks

One of the major differences concerning the models of how prophetic scrolls developed into the texts as we now have them concerns the extent to which stylistic variations are explained. A number of redactional models on individual writings presume that changes in style within a text should generally be attributed to the hand of the new writer. The resulting models thus assume that redactors by and large added comments, inserted commentary, or otherwise offered additions to texts that stand out stylistically, but often do not represent independent sources. The additions often do not have the larger corpus in view, but react to something in the immediate context. As a result, the growth of the corpus is sporadic and unsystematic. Sometimes these editorial additions may relate to one another thematically or lexically, and in these cases one can speak of redactional layers across a larger context.

By contrast, other models focus more on the conceptual framework of a prophetic writing, and assume that larger sections were compiled from preexisting sources. In these cases, the use of these existing sources, along with editorial frames and larger literary horizons, may account for a significant number of the stylistic variations. As a result, the same literary tensions are explained by a smaller number of editors and scribal intrusions.

Take, for example, the case of Joel. A number of commentators in the last two decades, working with the presupposition of a rolling corpus, have evaluated stylistic variations in Joel as one marker for three to five redactional layers (Wöhrle, Jeremias). Other commentators interpret the book as the work of one, or at most two, stages of growth because they see Joel as a conceptually unified writing compiled from a number

of preexisting sources (Wolff, Nogalski, Schart, Bergler, Sweeney). Barton, who distinguishes between an “inherent unity” and an “imposed unity,” sees the first half of Joel as a fairly cohesive composition, while chapters 3–4 (MT) represent a much looser collection of sources and fragments.

Changes for Readers

In several cases, evidence of growth arises from text critical analysis that also provides insight into how scribes worked with prophetic scrolls. One type of scribal reflection, in particular, shows that scribes inserted markers for the reader. In Jeremiah 7:1–2a (MT), a text missing from the LXX, a scribe has inserted a new heading (“The word that came to Jeremiah from YHWH”) and a command (“Stand in the gate of the house of YHWH and proclaim there this word”). What makes this insertion notable is that it uses an introductory formula typical for Jeremiah heading (cf. 7:1; 11:1; 18:1; 21:1; 25:1; 30:1; 32:1; 34:1, 8; 35:1; 40:1; 44:1), and the command picks up the command given to the people in 6:16 (“Stand in the crossroads”). The scribe made these insertions because the speech that follows in 7:2b clearly represents a new unit that presupposes a new location. Rather than taking place at the crossroads, it presumes the prophet is at the temple (see 7:4). This insertion merely makes explicit that which was implicit in the text, but it demonstrates a keen awareness of the immediate context and the broader tendencies of Jeremiah.

Editorial Threads

Numerous examples in the prophetic corpora could be cited to illustrate types of scribal activity that create movement between various parts of the books, but three examples are noted here. First, the dated superscriptions in Ezekiel and the Twelve provide those scrolls with a chronological progression, though the superscriptions are quite different from one another. Isaiah does not have this character beyond 1:1. Jeremiah contains numerous dating formulas, but they do not appear in a clear sequence. The chronology in the Book of the Twelve and Ezekiel should be taken seriously as part of the overall design of the book.

A second example indicating a sense of a literary whole spanning the corpus can be noted in the departing and returning of the Glory of YHWH in Ezekiel. The dramatic judgment scene in Ezekiel 11:22–23 depicts the departure of YHWH’s protective glory from the temple to a place east of the city in response to the people’s behavior. More than thirty chapters later, Ezekiel 43:1–3 alludes back to the vision of 8–11 and articulates the return of YHWH’s glory. When one recognizes these allusions, they clearly imply a conceptualization of the whole that links these chapters, despite the fact that the chronological headings in Ezekiel imply that the prophet receives the two visions nearly twenty years apart (compare the dates of 592 B.C.E. in Ezek 8:1 and 573 B.C.E. in 40:1). Clearly, the writer of 43:1–3 assumes that the reader has read the earlier portions of the scroll.

A third example appears in the repeated use of Exodus 34:6–7 in the Twelve to create a “conversation” of sorts regarding the compassion and justice of YHWH. These links are not univocal, but do appear to be deliberate. Joel 2:13 draws upon Exodus 34:6 to emphasize YHWH’s compassion in the face of repentance; then Joel 4:21 (Engl. 3:21) draws upon Exodus 34:7 to assert YHWH’s ultimate justice on the nations who take advantage of Judah. Later in the Book of the Twelve, Micah 7:18–20 draws upon Exodus 34:6 to pronounce compassion on YHWH’s people, while the opening of the next writing (Nah 1:3) cites Exodus 34:7 to emphasize YHWH’s justice against his enemies, interpreted there as Assyria (cf. Nah 1:1). By contrast, Jonah problematizes the theological perspective of Joel by citing Joel’s version of Exodus 34:6–7 in Jonah’s final confrontation of YHWH (see Jon 4:2), which satirically challenges the character Jonah’s (= Joel’s) affirmation of YHWH’s punishment of the nations, opting instead to affirm YHWH’s compassion toward the nations as much as YHWH’s own people.

Limitations

Open problems remain in how best to articulate the redactional profile of the prophetic corpus. As noted earlier, the role of the interplay between text criticism and redaction criticism continues to require scrutiny. The overlap is especially prominent in Jeremiah and Ezekiel, but Isaiah and the Twelve also require examination. The publication of the *Biblia Qumranica* series (Ego et al. 2005) can provide a great help in this respect. This series publishes biblical manuscripts from the Judean Desert and Qumran in parallel columns, marking the variations with shaded boxes. As well, recent publication of transcriptions of the prophetic materials in a more affordable (paperback) format is quite welcome and will help involve broader consideration of the variants (Ulrich 2013).

The question of composition with existing sources versus rolling corpus is complex and differs from writing to writing. The rolling corpus model works better in some books than others, especially Jeremiah and Ezekiel given the overlap of text criticism and scribal activity, though it is certainly present in Isaiah (note especially Isa 16:13–14). The redactional use of existing sources offers better explanations in other writings (e.g., the theophanic hymns at the beginning of Nahum and the end of Habakkuk, which help to periodize the Assyrian and Babylonian domination of Judah for the Book of the Twelve).

SHAPING THE FOUR SCROLLS OF THE LATTER PROPHETS

Isaiah

The scroll of Isaiah presents material related to a lengthy span of time, from the time of the prophet Isaiah in the eighth century to the Persian period (note the mention of

Cyrus in 44:28; 45:1, 13). This book mentions only one named prophet, though critical scholars have long recognized the need to assume that a number of anonymous authors actually contributed the bulk of the book.

No longer does critical scholarship on Isaiah assume that the book of Isaiah consists of the writings of three prophets, which were simply appended to one another. For much of the twentieth century, critical scholars treated Isaiah as essentially three independent collections from three prophetic figures: the eighth-century Proto-Isaiah (chapters 1–39), the late exilic work of Deutero-Isaiah that presumes knowledge of Cyrus of Persia (chapters 40–55), and the early post-exilic collection of Trito-Isaiah that assumes a functioning temple back in the land (chapters 56–66).

The major redactional models now recognize that redactional shaping has accompanied major developments of the Isaiah scroll. The redactional models now circulating conclude that material was often added to existing portions of Isaiah 1–39 to anticipate themes from later collections. Sustained arguments for eighth-century material are now generally limited to the foundational material in portions of chapters 1–11 and 28–32, though significant portions of these chapters are often treated as coming from a major updating of the Isaiah materials in the time of Josiah. Newer models that treat the entire scroll find that quite a number of passages in chapters 1–39 have been composed after Jerusalem's destruction and suggest that many were incorporated when chapters 40–55 and 56–66 were attached to the Isaiah materials.

Redactional shaping has been particularly heavy at the beginning and middle sections of the collection (especially Isaiah 33–35 and 36–39). While debate exists, most see Isaiah 36–39 as derivative of (or otherwise related to) the parallel accounts in 2 Kings 18–20, a text composed during the reign of Babylon in the first half of the sixth century B.C.E.

Most redactional models treat the OAN (Isaiah 13–23) as heavily influenced by Persian period datings, if not origins. Similarly, most scholars date Isaiah 24–27 as a late Persian or Hellenistic period text designed largely to conclude the OAN. Isaiah 12 reflects an eschatological thanksgiving hymn from the postexilic period.

Debates concerning Isaiah 40–55 do not center on the date(s) of composition as much as they focus upon how and when these chapters were joined with the larger corpus of Isaiah. One group of redactional studies tends to argue that 40–55 had a literary history of some duration prior to being joined to Isaiah 1–39 (see Steck, Blenkinsopp, Schmid, and Berges). Some in this group see an early core of the collection, mostly in 40–48, though the conclusion of this early version could be found in 52:7–10. This core arose around the time of Cyrus and has an utterly optimistic outlook regarding the imminent return of YHWH to Jerusalem, but under the kingship of Cyrus, not a Davidide. Additions to this material include a major emphasis on Zion (in 49:14–26; 51:9–10, 17, 19–23; 52:1–2; 54:1). A second group maintains that Isaiah 40–55 never existed apart from chapters 1–39 in some form (Williamson, 1994). Rather, chapters 40–55 constitute a continuation of the tradition of Isaiah of Jerusalem updated in the Persian period, though Williamson ascribes more engagement in 1–39 by the author of 40–55.

Very few redaction historians consider Isaiah 56–66 to have come from a single hand. The idea that these chapters were the composition of a single anonymous prophet

(Trito-Isaiah) has been generally abandoned in favor of three or four subsequent additions to the larger scroll (though see Berges 2012: 501). Most recognize the center section (Isaiah 60–62) as the earliest portion of 56–66, with a number arguing that it represents the redactional agenda of articulating a Zion theology without a king. See the illustration of the use of Isaiah 9:1 in Isaiah 60:1–12 noted by Schmid (2012: 168). Chapters 56–59 were placed at the beginning of the new material (60–62) and combined with chapters 63–64 (along with the bridge text of Isaiah 34). The final addition of chapters 65–66 created an *inclusio* with the first chapters of the corpus. Among other correspondences, Isaiah 66:24 picks up Isaiah 1:31, and Isaiah 65:25 picks up the eschatological text of Isaiah 11:6 (see discussions in Berges 2012: 497). While recent redactional studies have created a scenario of complex portraits of the development of Isaiah, they agree that its constituent parts can no longer be treated in complete isolation from one another if one wishes to account for *both* the unifying elements *and* the diverse elements within Isaiah 1–66 as a whole.

The Book of the Twelve

Like Isaiah, the Book of the Twelve also presents prophetic messages from the eighth century to the Persian period, but unlike Isaiah, under the authority of twelve named prophets. Old Testament scholars gave very little consideration to the ancient Jewish and Christian tradition that the Twelve prophets were written on a single scroll and counted as a single book until the last twenty years of the twentieth century, but a great deal of work has looked at the redactional implications since then. Much of this work has attempted to distinguish the redactional work on the prophetic writings within the Twelve before and after they enter the corpus, on the assumption that most writings were not composed originally for their current location in the Twelve. The results of these investigations have not compelled absolute consensus, but a number of scholars reach similar conclusions concerning how the corpus came together. The unifying features of the Book of the Twelve derive from a set of recurring themes, specific motifs, recognizable allusions, catchwords, and other forms of citations.

The earliest collection of more than one writing resulted in the joint transmission of Hosea and Amos (Jeremias 1996; Schart 1998). In the exilic period, first Micah and then Zephaniah were added to form a Book of the Four Prophets whose message was intertwined to highlight God's judgment on the northern and southern kingdoms (Nogalski, Schart, Albertz, Wöhrle). These four writings received editorial additions indicating that they were read together into the Persian period. This editorial work included the linking of the superscriptions through a patterned presentation of the kings mentioned in the superscriptions that gave the collection a chronological framework covering the eighth and seventh centuries. In the early post-exilic period, a separate collection of Haggai and Zechariah 1–8 was published together to document the involvement of these prophetic figures with the rebuilding of the Temple and the reorganization of the community after 520 B.C.E.

Debate continues on the sequence in which the remaining writings were combined into the scroll, but there is general agreement that Obadiah, Nahum, and Habakkuk expanded the Book of the Four with judgment upon the foreign peoples of Edom, Assyria, and Babylon, respectively, thereby expanding the message of judgment on Israel and Judah (Nogalski, Schart, Wöhrle, Steck, Bosshard-Nepustil). The role of Joel is pivotal in these models. Some see Joel as the literary anchor of the Book of the Twelve, meaning that it owes its current shape in no small measure to its position between Hosea and Amos (Nogalski, Schart), since all of the recurring motifs in the Twelve play a significant role in the structure of Joel. This group sees Joel as a compilation from preexisting sources that were combined redactionally in a major compositional move. Others see Joel as a prophetic writing that grew over time (beginning in the exilic period in conjunction with the Book of the Four Prophets), or argue that it was attached to the Twelve only at a relatively late stage in its development (see Wöhrle 2006: 387–460). In the fourth century, a number of writings (including Nahum, Habakkuk, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi) received editorial insertions that take up the language of Joel to refer to the onslaught of the nations as locusts who will attack Judah before they themselves are punished (Nah 3:15*; cf. Hab 1:9; Mal 3:7, 11), or the fertility of the land as restoration of the grain, wine, and oil (Hos 2:24 [MT; Engl. 2:22]; Joel 2:19; Hag 2:18; Zech 8:12; Mal 3:11). The latest book to enter the corpus, Jonah, likely did so during the Hellenistic period. Jonah's parody of the theology of Joel makes it unlikely that Jonah entered the corpus at the same time as Joel. Jonah's late date of composition (late Persian or early Hellenistic period) also makes it unlikely that it entered at the same time as Joel.

The recurring themes that help to unify the Book of the Twelve include the Day of YHWH, the use of agricultural fertility language to signify covenant blessings and curses, the theodicy problem, and the fate of Judah and Israel in the past and the future. A number of Day of YHWH texts appear in the Book of the Twelve, where thirteen of the seventeen uses of the specific term appear. The prominence of the phrase, however, does not mean that these passages present a consistent, singular pattern. One has to evaluate each text to figure out the target, the time frame, and the means by which YHWH will intervene in order to understand what each text intends by the phrase. Joel, in fact, presents three different paradigms for the Day of YHWH.

The combination of wine, grain, and oil frequently appears in texts as ciphers for covenant blessings or curses. The trope can appear in texts of judgment (e.g., Hos 2:10–15 [Engl. 2:8–13]; Joel 1:8–10; Hab 3:16–17; Hag 1:10–11) or promise (e.g., Hos 2:23–25 [Engl. 2:21–23]; Joel 2:18–19, 24–25; Hag 2:19; Zech 8:12; Mal 3:10–11), depending on the rhetorical aims of the passage. Threats to this fertility are portrayed as locusts (Joel 1:4; 2:25; Nah 3:15; Hab 1:9; Mal 3:11). On the macro level, this theme intertwines with several Day of YHWH texts.

The theodicy problem deals with the issue of YHWH's long-standing compassion toward and punishment of YHWH's people, YHWH's use of foreign nations to punish Judah and Israel, and YHWH's punishment of those nations when they overstep the role YHWH has assigned them (see Nogalski 2009: 30–39).

The fate of Judah, Israel, and the nations changes as one progresses through the Book of the Twelve, depending upon the presumed chronology of the Twelve's superscriptions in Hosea, Amos, Micah, Zephaniah, Haggai, and Zechariah.

Jeremiah

The book of Jeremiah covers a much more limited time frame in terms of its portrayal of the prophet than does Isaiah and the Book of the Twelve. Jeremiah's oracles are set within the time frame from Josiah (Jer 1:2) through Jehoiachin (Jer 52:31) and Gedaliah (Jeremiah 40–41) in Judah in the late seventh and early sixth centuries. A number of superscriptions throughout the book provide chronological settings for the material they introduce by referring to these rulers, to Jehoiakim (1:3; 25:1; 26:1; 35:1; 36:1, 9; 45:1; 46:2), and to Zedekiah (1:3; 24:1; 27:1; 28:1; 32:1; 34:2; 37:1; 39:1; 49:34; 51:59), but unlike the Book of the Twelve or Ezekiel, the sequence of these superscriptions shows no interest in a strict chronological arrangement. Much more prominent in the structure of the book is the long noted presence of poetic oracles as the dominant character of chapters 1–25, while prophetic narratives dominate chapters 26–45 and 52. The OAN of Jeremiah (46–51) contain mostly poetic texts.

When it comes to theories about the redaction of Jeremiah, Duhm (1901) and Mowinckel (1914) cast a long shadow over the discussion. For much of the twentieth century, their four-source theory played a major role in the discussion of the book's origin. In the end, these four sources (A, B, C, D) did more to characterize the type of literature than actual sources as such, so that even those who reject these sources often still make use of these groupings. Source A, according to Mowinckel, consisted of sayings of the prophet and first-person accounts. This group of texts covers most of the material in chapters 1–25. Source B comprises third-person narratives about Jeremiah, which Mowinckel calls the biography of Jeremiah. Source B texts include 19:1–20:6; 26–29; 36–44; and 51:59–64. Source C texts comprise prose discourses with Deuteronomistic revisions, which include 7:1–8:3; 11:1–14; 18:1–12; 21:1–10; 22:1–5; 25:1–11; 34:8–22; 35:1–19; and so on. Source D texts comprise the salvific materials in chapters 30–31. The first two-thirds of the twentieth century saw much discussion about these sources, with a goodly consensus that chapters 1–25 contained much of the early preaching of Jeremiah that may even have constituted the core of the so-called first scroll recopied by Baruch in 605 B.C.E. (Jeremiah 36). See Eissfeldt (1974) for a fuller rehearsal of the discussions through the 1960s.

By the end of the 1970s, discussions of the redactional development of Jeremiah took a major turn based upon several critiques of the shortcomings of the four-source theory. Specifically, the "Deuteronomistic language" could not be limited merely to source C (see especially Thiel 1975, 1981). Rather, linguistic markers suggesting connections to or awareness of Deuteronomistic outlooks also appear in the so-called early material, some of which represents later editing, but some of which appears to be part of the core material. Consequently, the impossibility of isolating purely "Jeremianic" speeches is now

taken for granted. Nevertheless, the editorial work that can be isolated often appears to be fragmented or only executed over portions of the scroll, though two exceptions to this tendency have been noted: the *golah*-oriented and the diaspora-oriented redactions, especially as put forward by Pohlmann (1978).

American and Israeli scholarship on Jeremiah tends, on the whole, to shrink the time frame into which the editorial work on Jeremiah took place into the time of the exile. Allen (2008: 7–11), for example, avers that Jeremiah essentially became a book by the end of the exilic period, and he believes it was intended *for* those in the Babylonian Exile. He believes the expansions to the Hebrew text still address those in exile. Consequently, for Allen the two Jeremiah textual traditions circulated independent of one another for three centuries or so until the LXX translated the shorter one around 200 B.C.E. (Allen 2008: 11). A similar divide holds generally for the book of Ezekiel between European scholars on the one hand and American and Israeli scholars on the other. Even when both these groups make similar observations regarding the relative development of composite texts, they tend to fit these developments into smaller or larger time frames.

Ezekiel

Formally, the superscriptions of Ezekiel portray a setting for the book that begins with the prophet's call narrative during the fifth year of the first deportation (1:1–3) and ends some twenty years later, anticipating a return to Jerusalem (40:1). In between, almost all of the dated superscriptions appear in chronological order (cf. 1:1–3; 3:16; 8:1; 20:1; 24:1; 26:1; 29:1; 29:17; 30:20; 31:1; 32:1; 32:17; 33:21; 40:1). Additionally, references in one part of the book refer back to a text in the preceding chapters (e.g., the departure of the glory of YHWH from the Temple in 11:22 and the vision of its return in 43:1–4). Further, the thematic focus changes from judgment against Israel (1–24) to oracles against the nations (25–32) to restoration of Israel (33–48). These structuring elements provide a framework for the book that, especially in comparison to Jeremiah, imbue Ezekiel with a sense of coherence that has given rise to theories of prophetic composition by a single author or to a small group. These theories ascribe much of the book to Ezekiel himself, or at least to Ezekiel and his students. Others treat Ezekiel as a late pseudepigraphical work of the fourth or third centuries B.C.E. (see the extensive history of interpretation in Zimmerli 1979: 3–8). Nevertheless, redaction-critical investigations by Zimmerli and Pohlmann in particular have shown the likelihood that these structuring elements are insufficient to explain the totality of the material in Ezekiel as the result of a single compositional stage. For example, in between these dated superscriptions one finds undated introductions to units, and these units often contain a core text and updated material that takes a different tack on the topics covered in the unit.

While by no means the first to recognize the diachronic character of Ezekiel, Zimmerli's two-volume commentary (1969; ET, 1979, 1983) took a major step forward in delineating the character of the supplementary material as redactional updating (*Fortschreibung*) of existing written units. He considered much of this updating to be the

work of the disciples of Ezekiel, so that the vast majority of the book was completed in the sixth century (1979: 68–74).

Zimmerli's model portrays a lengthy process of reflection on individual written units that are updated with later material and expanded perspectives. In this way, Zimmerli accounts for the non-dated introductions to units that are relatively self-contained and for the updated material that accompanies these more independent units by providing a perspective after the fall of Jerusalem and subsequent events. In places, Zimmerli also thinks that smaller collections were inserted into the existing larger collection. Notably, chapters 25–32 (containing Ezekiel's OAN) interrupts an existing transitional unit (24:25–27) connecting chapter 24 with 33:21. Similarly, he sees chapter 18 as an insertion between two chapters (17 and 19) with a more integral connection. He also notes that chapters 20–22 constitute a block, so that the two blocks (17/19 + 20–22) were framed by two related chapters (16 and 23) that provide a certain editorial cohesion of their own. Chapter 24 concludes the part of the collection that overwhelmingly focuses on judgment against Israel. By contrast, the themes of 33–39 are overwhelmingly positive. He sees chapters 40–48 as a later composition that also represents the final phase of redaction. Zimmerli notes that the date that opens this section represents the midway point between the book's beginning and the year of Israel's release from captivity. He argues that this redactional updating represents the work of a school of Ezekiel that likely was located at the prophet's own home for much of its history. While Zimmerli advanced the study of Ezekiel by focusing on the *means* by which the book grew, Pohlmann proposes a significant advance for the *motives* for the major updates to the corpus.

Pohlmann argues that a number of the speeches have settings in Jerusalem prior to the first exile (Pohlmann 1996: 36–39). Pohlmann goes so far as to postulate an early prophetic book of such speeches conceptualized and formulated in Judah before the time of the opening vision mentioned in 1:1–3 (594 B.C.E.). Pohlmann identifies several passages of this older book (19*; 31*; 15:2–4) that anticipate this destruction, and he argues that it was even updated before the first exile. The biggest change to the collection comes, however, with the material that Pohlmann assigns to a second formative stage that he calls the *golah*-oriented redaction. These redactors privileged the exiled community that was taken from Jerusalem in 597 with Jehoiachin. This redactional work was responsible for most of the dating elements—including the decision to date the speeches to the years of Jehoiachin's exile, not Jerusalem's destruction. Pohlmann labels a third stage of the work on Ezekiel as the diaspora-oriented redaction, by which he means a series of later reflections that broaden the scope of the anticipated return to include more than the first exiles associated with the group taken with Jehoiachin.

Even though Pohlmann's theory about an early prophetic book conceptualized in Judah attempts to account for long problematic passages that seem to address the people in Judah prior to the first deportation, it is not clear that Pohlmann has won many followers on this point. See his own recent assessment—though he continues to advocate for his position—in Pohlmann (2009: 325–328).

Pohlmann appears on much stronger ground when distinguishing between the *golah*-oriented redaction and the diaspora-oriented redaction of Ezekiel. *Golah* is the

Hebrew word for exile and refers to the ideological orientation of a significant number of texts and *Fortschreibungen* that limit (or at least privilege) those whom YHWH will restore to those who were exiled in 597, but the land must lay desolate first because of the great evil perpetrated upon it. Significant texts reflecting this ideology include the core of 1–3* (not 1:4–28; 2:1–2; 2:3–7; 3:4–9); 7; 11; 12; 14:21–23; 17:22–24; 19*; 24:25–27; 33:21–29; 36:1–15; 37:1–14. These texts presuppose that the end of the period of judgment will come only with the return of the exiles to Jerusalem, while no space is made in the restoration ideology for those exiled after Jerusalem's destruction or for those who remained in the land because these groups were responsible for the judgment that YHWH brought against Jerusalem. The early date formulas also represent the work of this redaction, giving preference in its dates tied to Jehoiachin's exile (1:1–2; 8:1; 33:21). Pohlmann thinks that this work addresses the descendants of those exiled with the first *golah* in 597.

The third stage of the development concerns texts that reflect a series of revisions that reflect theologically on the diaspora situation. The main lines of this theological reflection concern texts that speak more generally about the scattering and collecting of Israel and attempt to come to terms with the long-standing nature of the wrath of YHWH. YHWH's decision to deliver Israel for the sake of his name, as he did to the people in the wilderness, requires a new commitment to YHWH that avoids idolatry. These texts do not anticipate a return to a new land so much as they deal with the continuing punishment after 538. Texts focusing on these issues do not all come from the same hand, so this final stage is not a singular revision, but a series of diaspora reflections. Key texts include Ezekiel 20; 36:23b–32*; 38, and 39. Pohlmann leaves open the possibility that the insertion of 25–32 and the addition of 40–48 could be part of this revisionary work.

Pohlmann dates the work of the *golah*-oriented redaction toward the end of the fifth century B.C.E., while he sees the diaspora-oriented updatings as the work of tradents from the fourth century B.C.E. Pohlmann finds similar redactional agendas in Jeremiah as well.

Both Zimmerli and Pohlmann have followers, so that real differences exist in the dates assumed by commentators for the majority of the book. These debates show no signs of resolution currently. It is probably fair to say that a majority of American and Israeli scholars tend to come much closer to Zimmerli by dating the majority of the book to the sixth century (cf. Lundbom, Allen), while recent European scholarship, with Pohlmann, tends to accentuate the development of the corpus as having a longer history into the fourth century (see Schmid 2012: 169–174). Those emphasizing the differences between the LXX *Vorlage* and the MT, along with the material differences documented by Pohlmann and others that point to significant changes in assumptions in the *Fortschreibungen*, will continue to describe the growth of the corpus in more elongated terms, while those assuming a more active role for the prophet because of the autobiographical character of the book will look for ways to explain the vast majority of the material in Ezekiel as material that could have been composed in the lifetime of the prophet.

CONCLUSION

Work on the redaction of the prophetic scrolls as edited literary works in their own right, complex though they may be, has seen a considerable investment of time and energy in the last thirty years. On the one hand, one would be hard pressed to find much in the way of a consensus on the major issues. On the other hand, several broad trajectories have begun to emerge. Gone are the days when editorial material was set aside. Scholars have a much healthier, albeit a much more complex, picture of the creative work of shaping the scrolls that gave rise to the prophetic collection we now have. Likely none of the four prophetic collections reached their final forms until well into the Persian period, and in the case of the Twelve and Isaiah, perhaps not until the Hellenistic period.

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D. Topical Studies

CHAPTER 17

THE PROPHET AS PERSONA

ELSE K. HOLT

The Oxford Dictionary of Literary Terms defines *persona* as

[t]he assumed identity or fictional “I” (literally a “mask”) assumed by a writer in a literary work; thus the speaker in a lyric poem, or the narrator in a fictional narrative. In a dramatic monologue, the speaker is evidently not the real author but an invented or historical character. Many modern critics, though, insist further that the speaker in any poem should be referred to as the persona, to avoid the unreliable assumption that we are listening to the true voice of the poet. One reason for this is that a given poet may write different poems in which the speakers are of distinct kinds: another is that our identification of the speaking voice with that of the real poet would confuse imaginative composition with autobiography. Some theorists of narrative fiction have preferred to distinguish between the narrator and the persona, making the persona equivalent to the implied author.

When it comes to Old Testament prophecy, a traditional exegetical approach would deem this determination inappropriate. Until the advent of modern historical-critical scholarship—and in many ways, also within modern historical-critical scholarship—the prophet whose name was applied to the book and whose identity was attached to the book in its first verses was indisputably the author of the book. This indisputability was thoroughly challenged around the turn of the twentieth century, notably by scholars such as Bernhard Duhm, Rudolf Kittel, John Skinner, and Sigmund Mowinckel. On the other hand, there was no doubt within this critical scholarship that a historical prophet was the author of the prophetic books of the Old Testament and that with the help of critical methodologies, most notably literary criticism and form criticism, the exegete would be able to reach the prophet’s *ipsissima vox* and thus his spirituality. As late as in the 1980s, the scholarly society would go into rages over minimalist commentaries, most notably Robert P. Carroll’s commentary on Jeremiah, which put a serious question mark by the historicity of the prophet as author. The historical-biographical approach

to prophetic books, so common even in the twentieth century, can be substantiated by looking into the introductions to commentaries from both sides of the Atlantic.

Since the 1980s, however, an increasing number of exegetes go beyond the historical-critical quest for the original prophet and the literary deposits of traditions and redactions motivated by the obvious fact that the only material we have is the text in its final forms, including variant forms in the translated versions. Moreover, there has been a growing understanding of the reading process as a dialogue between the text and its reader, rather than as a monologue. This quest does not, of course, call for neglecting historical-critical work. Rather, reader-response criticism and other contextual analyses should be informed by historical-critical caveats against forgetting Lessing's hermeneutical "garstige Graben" ("ugly ditch") between us and the biblical texts, and in my experience, this methodological reticence is acknowledged in most scholarly literature. This notwithstanding, the quest for the biography of the historical prophet, say Hosea, Amos, or Jeremiah, has turned into a literary and theological quest for the prophetic persona, the character that serves as the first-person narrator or the implied author of the prophetic book.

THE MEANING OF PERSONA

The word "persona" is borrowed from the theatrical world of Greco-Roman antiquity, where actors concealed their faces behind masks. Traditional etymology of the word linked persona with Greek πρόσωπον ("mask"), or Latin *personare* ("to sound through"), understanding the mask as something the actor spoke through in order to intensify the sound of the voice, a "megaphone." Currently, philologists derive the Latin word from Etruscan *Phersu*, the name of a masked gladiator, depicted in the so-called Tomb of the Augurs in Tarquinii (sixth century B.C.E.).

Throughout history, the word "persona" has increased its number of meanings, from the original understanding of persona as a mask, a "device of transformation and concealment on the theatrical stage" to Immanuel Kant's definition: "Rational beings are designated 'persons' [*Personen*] because their nature indicates that they are ends in themselves."¹ From a device of concealment, the antique understanding of *persona* has changed into the innermost sincere center of the human being, the person, also in everyday use. More important in the present connection, though, is the understanding of persona by Carl Gustav Jung, who regarded the persona as a mask of the collective psyche and as nothing real. According to Jung, "[t]he persona is always identical with a *typical* attitude, in which *one* psychological function dominates, e.g. feeling, or thought, or intuition." As augmented by Fabian Gudas: "Jung opposes the persona, the self a person assumes in order to play a social role, to the anima, a person's true inner being."²

In his monograph *The Literary Persona*, Robert C. Elliott discussed the use of persona in drama, literature, and religion through history. The questions, of course, were the following: Who is the first-person speaker of any given text—and what degree of

importance should be applied to the significance of the author? Are proponents of New Criticism right in their neglect of the significance of the author for understanding a literary work? Or should we follow those who refute the claim that we can possibly “hope to understand a writer’s art and mind apart from his personality” and who “regard the concept of the persona when used as a critical tool as at best an unfortunate mistake”? (Elliott 1982: 13–14).

And applied to prophetic studies: Is it important for understanding, for example, the so-called Confessions in the book of Jeremiah to know the prophetic author and the story of his life? Do we need to know whether Ezekiel was psychotic in order to make sense of his message (see later discussion in the chapter)? And would the message of the book of Jonah be more vivid to us if we knew the author of the story of Jonah?

A related question discussed by Elliott and others is the “sincerity” of the author who communicates through a persona, whether expressed in first-person discourse or concealed behind a literary character. How will the reader be able to tell if the (alleged) author is sincere in his presentation of acts or sentiments? Will the author—like Søren Kierkegaard, T. S. Eliot, or Ezra Pound—disguise himself behind various literary personae, as discussed by Elliott (1982: 35–62)? When applied to Old Testament prophetic writing, the question is which connection exists between the name of the book and its author(s) and redactors. As an example, are Jeremiah’s Confessions or Hosea’s first-person narrative about his marriage to “a woman who has a lover” sincere or authentic expressions of turmoil in the prophetic mind, or are they meant as theological communication? And furthermore, what difference does it make to the theological communication of the Old Testament text?

Elliott includes another discussion that might be illuminating in our context of religious literature: the use of the mask for ritual purposes. “From the beginning of recorded history,” Elliott writes, “and far back beyond that in cultural time, people have donned masks in the service of various transformative activities—for purposes of entertainment, certainly, including ‘play-acting’—but also in their efforts to communicate with the spirits and with their gods, even to partake of godhood” (Elliott 1982: 21). With reference to the American ethnologist Raymond D. Fogelson, Elliott argues that masks are of transcendent importance, not only to the North American Iroquois but to many other peoples.

When an Iroquois puts on the mask . . . he *becomes* the spirit, he is assimilated into the being of the spirit, a phenomenon of participation of a kind that the French philosopher Lucien Lévy-Bruhl described many years ago. Thus among the Iroquois (and many others) to don the mask in the appropriate ceremonial circumstances and settings is not to enact a role, to make believe, but temporarily to incarnate cosmic reality. Clearly this reverses our normal categories: instead of the mask as a bogus front, hiding the real person behind it, for the Iroquois and the others the mask mediates the highest reality of all.³

From all we know, the prophets of the Old Testament did not don masks, and under every circumstance we have no access to masks in our Old Testament texts as we have them, as mere texts. Nevertheless, what we do have are transmitted narratives of

prophetic sign-acts, which would almost never be practicable and which would best be understood as performance art, as a kind of street theater,⁴ and prophets like Hosea and Jeremiah impersonate the divine in their speech (cf. Hosea 1; Jeremiah 8–9). The focus on the prophet as a historical person—as opposed to a literary persona, a character that might or might not represent an ancient Israelite or Judean prophet and his message—tends to cover up the understanding of these prophetic books themselves: that they mediate “the highest reality of all,” the word of YHWH, God of Israel.

THE PROPHET AS A HISTORICAL PERSON IN TWENTIETH-CENTURY SCHOLARSHIP

As indicated in the preceding section, twentieth-century scholarship, especially before the impact of dialectical theology on particularly European Old Testament theology from the 1930s and onward, displayed a huge interest in the prophet as a person in Kant’s understanding (not as a persona!). The influence of books such as Bernhard Duhm’s commentary on Jeremiah and his *Israels Propheten* or John Skinner’s *Prophecy and Religion* cannot be overestimated. In *Israels Propheten*, Duhm presents the prophets in the context of Israel’s political and religious evolution in three steps. The first step is the *dämonistische*, to be understood as the primitive and unsophisticated, popular religion of the tribes. Duhm names the second period *die dynamistische*; here, YHWH was presented as the leader of the people who uses the prophets as his “human tools”—YHWH *bedient sich menschlicher Werkszeuges*. In this period of joint leadership between God, prophet, and people, the people and the “men of God” unfortunately were degraded into a nation of peasants who wanted no more than monarchic rulers and no progress, and definitely no leadership in a higher, more spiritual sense. Fortunately, precisely at this point a new kind of men emerged, the prophets “who did not proclaim salvation and victory, but judgment and doom.” These prophets did not care much about worldly leadership; they were called to assume leadership in humanity’s inner history (*in der inneren Geschichte der Menschheit*). By this began the third and highest level in the life of Israel, a level of the chosen few, the prophets of YHWH, who remained isolated from common Israelites. The prophets were, even the irreligious reader must understand, “the beginning of the spiritual world history,” far more important than “the philosophers of Greece or India’s sages.”⁵

Against this background, Duhm presents the individual prophets in their historical setting. Amos is the “reasonable, rational citizen and workman” and would have remained an average dresser of sycamore trees and a herdsman, had he not had visions that forced him with “moral necessity” to proclaim what he saw and heard. His proclamation takes the form of divinely inspired poetry. Hosea is much softer than Amos, an emotional person. His marriage to no fewer than two adulterous women (Hosea 1–3) is surprisingly old-fashioned, but “the religious sentiment is more outstanding than by

Amos, the man of moral clarity and power, and his poetry is filled with beautiful images, although they carry a certain touch of being produced at the desk.” Isaiah is presumably of royal decent; his message is that of doom, intended to draw the destruction close and lead to the people’s moral death. Ezekiel is a desktop writer more than a poet, a visionary more than a prophet, a man of the cult more than of spirituality (Duhm 1922: 98–101; 144–147; 227–241). It is a relief for Duhm finally to be allowed to return to the authentic prophet, Jeremiah, one of the greatest prophets and poets in Israel, the true descendant of Amos, Hosea, Isaiah, and Micah, and thus a totally independent soul. Duhm writes more than forty pages on Jeremiah (Duhm 1922: 242–284).

Already fifteen years before *Israels Propheten*, Duhm published his most influential book, the commentary on Jeremiah (Duhm 1901). Joe Henderson and Mary Chilton Callaway have recently discussed the hermeneutics and theology of early twentieth-century approaches to Jeremiah, and both Henderson and Callaway point to the importance of liberal theology and its focus on personal faith in the presentation of Jeremiah the prophet.⁶ In the end, the portraits of the prophets by the fathers of historical-critical scholarship seem to be closer to the perceived persona than to historical referentiality. In the words of Henderson (2014: 14): “The biography of Jeremiah that resulted from the historical-critical method has a strong resemblance to the lives of the nineteenth-century theologians and biblical scholars who broke with traditional Christianity.” Duhm’s and Skinner’s emphasis on spirituality and personality continued throughout the twentieth century with John Bright’s and Wilhelm Rudolph’s commentaries as the most important examples in the English- and German-speaking worlds, respectively.

For Bright (1965: xv), Jeremiah was

... both one of the great figures of Israel’s history and a person whom one can readily admire. He was a man of great spiritual insight and depth, a man of driving eloquence who was possessed of unusual poetic gifts; he was, moreover, in the profoundest sense of the word a brave man, a passionate and exceedingly human man who captures our sympathies as few figures from ancient times do.

This is not far from John Skinner’s famous portrait of Jeremiah as a man of profound religious emotions, driven by an inner psychological compulsion, which leads to the prophet’s “perception of a new spiritual truth or a fresh impression of the reality of things divine.”⁷

Rudolph opens his commentary with an extensive introduction to the life and work of Jeremiah, followed by a paragraph on Jeremiah’s theology (Rudolph, 1968). Here, he does not abstain from referring to the sentiments of the prophet vis-à-vis political and personal challenges, or from combining information from the three sources of the book (Rudolph adopts Mowinckel’s four sources with the modification that the texts outside the sources A, B, and C are not part of a source but simply *unechte Stücke* [false pieces]). The reader gets the impression of a passionate man who struggles with both humans and God—the Confessions, *inter alia*, are treated as testimonies of his courage to discuss the meaningfulness of God’s work. Rudolph constructs a prophetic biography from

the information available in the book, including descriptions of emotions; one example must suffice:

We realize how hard this preaching was for him in that he probed again and again whether things really were so bad that a divine oracle of annihilation was justified (5:4f; 6:9; 5:26ff); eagerly, he reached for any sign of improvement (3:21ff), interceding, he leaped into the breach (14:11), and yet, when he took stock of his work after the first couple of years under Josiah, the result was bleak (6:27ff): *massa perditionis* (Rudolph 1968: III).

Unlike Bright, however, Rudolph abstains from overt religious or psychological panegyric in his biographical effort.

It is interesting to note, then, the shift of emphasis only twenty years later in William L. Holladay's influential two-volume commentary on Jeremiah (Holladay 1986–1989). Although Holladay maintains the historicity of Jeremiah's oracles, he does not offer an introduction to Jeremiah, the man; instead, Holladay is focused on the historical context of Jeremiah's proclamations, which he claims to be able to date more or less precisely in the period between Jeremiah's call as a twelve-year-old boy in 615 B.C.E. and his last prophetic words as a man of forty, late in the year 587 B.C.E. (Holladay 1986: 1–10). In Holladay's work, the interest in the biography of the prophet has changed from an interest in the prophetic person to the influence of historical events and the message of the prophetic book. The prophet as a man of religion has disappeared from the major critical commentaries.

This is even more the case in the contemporaneous commentary on Jeremiah by Robert P. Carroll (1986). Holladay and Carroll differ profoundly in their view of the historicity of the book of Jeremiah, but they agree in their—in the case of Holladay implied—refusal to paint a portrait of Jeremiah the man. In Carroll's words, "Presented at certain points in the book as a prophet, Jeremiah emerges as a counterpoint to the collapse of Judean culture. The few details of his life which appear in the text are tantalizingly incomplete and open to a variety of interpretations. . . . the book cannot be considered to be a biography of Jeremiah" (Carroll 1986: 33).

Thus from the 1980s and onward, prophetic studies have been more and more focused on the message of each prophetic book, the mode of its communication, its redaction, its historical and cultural background, and its intertextuality, and less on the prophet as a person. An illustrative example is the introduction to Jörg Jeremias's commentary on Amos (Jeremias 1995). Here, in the introduction, the importance lies not with the religious emotions or the personal life of the prophet but in the message in its historical context. As a parallel, some twenty years later, with the approach of New Criticism in the study of literature, the author has disappeared, so to speak, and has been replaced by redactors.⁸ In the midst of this deliberate scholarly ignoring of, for example, the historical Jeremiah, however, the prophet has re-emerged in new garments as the prophetic persona.

Of course, it can be debated whether the concept of persona is applicable to prophetic literature at all, and from the point of view of a historicist approach as sketched earlier, it

isn't. Interestingly, Carroll, who—as we saw earlier—refutes our access to any historical Jeremiah, raises the question of whether “the presentation of Jeremiah as prophetic *persona* [. . .] may be too modern an approach to the text. The *figure* of Jeremiah may only be an editorial link between different elements in the tradition . . .” (Carroll 1986: 58, emphasis added). Moreover, *persona* has been used in different and even opposing ways in exegetical literature, and this calls for caution and precision.⁹ In what follows I shall use *persona* as a reference to the presentation of a prophet, directly through (self-)biography and/or indirectly through the message of the prophetic book. Thus, the prophetic *persona* is the literary figure that emerges to the reader during his or her reading of the book, whether this *persona* has any historical background as a “real” person or not.

PROPHETIC LITERATURE AND THE GENRE OF BIOGRAPHY

The development sketched in the preceding text parallels the development in New Testament studies through the twentieth century. From the middle of the nineteenth century, the unquestioned belief in the gospels as telling the “true” story of the life of Jesus was problematized by historical-critical scholarship, which in its turn inspired the quest for the historical Jesus of the early twentieth century. This project was challenged by the early form critics, not least those who shared the opinion of dialectical theologians, who blamed their *Leben-Jesu* colleagues for painting a picture of Jesus that was unduly influenced by the religious ideals of liberal Protestantism. These scholars replaced the biographical focus with a focus on the message of the gospels, the *kerygma*. Since the 1970s, however, the literary turn of the research of the gospels has created an interest in biography, understood as an antique genre.

In the article on biography in the *Anchor Bible Dictionary*, Charles H. Talbert defines the genre of ancient biography with special emphasis on its importance for the study of early gospels, canonical as well as apocryphal. Talbert does not consider Old Testament literature, and it is not the aim of this chapter to advocate possible historical relation between the Greco-Roman genre and the prophetic books. Nevertheless, it might be heuristically useful to apply Talbert's definitions to prophetic literature. This is suggested by the circumstance that Satyrus's *Life of Euripides* is dated in the third century B.C.E. (Talbert 1992: 746) and thus is contemporaneous with the later editions of some of the prophetic books, such as the book of Jeremiah. Later, the genre of biography became popular in ancient Jewish writings such as Philo's *Life of Moses* (ca. 25 B.C.E.) and the anonymous collection *The Lives of the Prophets* (first century C.E.). Thus, a demand for biography must have existed in antique Judaism, which shaped the backdrop for the final versions of the prophetic books.

Talbert distinguishes between what is essential (or constitutive) and what is accidental to ancient biography. According to Talbert, it is *constitutive* to the genre that the subject

“be a distinguished or notorious figure (kings, generals, philosophers, literary figures, lawgivers, prophets, or saints) and that the aim be to expose the essence of the person” (746). The relevance of this for prophetic literature is hardly disputable. Talbert lists several *accidental* characteristics, of which the most applicable in the present context seem to be (1) that there is no interest in tracing personality or character development; (2) that some biographies have as their aim to affect the behavior or opinion of their readers;¹⁰ (3) that the life of a subject may be set within a mythical framework; and (4) that ancient biographies hold a multiplicity of social functions, among which the most important in an Old Testament context would be as propaganda and to “indicate where the true tradition is in the present” (747). These accidental characteristics also seem to pertain to at least some of the prophetic books.

Leben-Jesu scholars from the beginning of the twentieth century have rightly been accused of anachronism when searching for modern-type biographical information in the gospels, and the same applies to the biographical approach to the Old Testament prophets. What these books communicate is theology, not biography, but in some cases it is theology in the form of ancient biographical discourse. Later, we shall trace some of these cases, with Hosea, Amos, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah as prominent examples. Before that, however, we will ask: Why did the authors behind these prophetic books use biography as their discursive tool?

THE NEED FOR BIOGRAPHY

In the cultural environment of writing, so important to the axial age in Israel,¹¹ the period of the finalizing of the prophetic books as well as the other parts of the Old Testament, it seems to be important to authorize the message by way of an authorized messenger. A telling example is the scribe Ezra’s public reading of the Torah in Nehemiah 8. Here, the reading of the written word of God is emphasized as a legitimization of the Torah in the post-exilic Judean community. All the people gather in Jerusalem at a named location, the Water Gate, at a precise date and time, and listen to the Law of Moses, which, so it is emphasized time and time again, is written in a book. The circumstances are meticulously unfolded, and the most important witnesses are mentioned by name and their place on the wooden podium from which Ezra reads the Law. Thus, the authorization of the Torah for the post-exilic community is framed in a narrative of a certain historical setting and certain historical persons who serve as guarantors of the legitimacy of the message. Even the Torah needs reaffirmation by biography and history.

This need of authentication and authorization also pertains to prophecy. In the words of Knud Jeppesen,

Collections of oracles came into being, applied to the prophet; the past had no means of verifying their authenticity but this was not conclusive. There seems to have been an aspiration, not least in post-exilic time, to break off the anonymity of the prophetic

words and connect them to certain, known prophets. This seems to be the point of putting headlines to the collections of oracles. Then, as well as now, there might not be much distance from “Wasn’t it Isaiah who once said . . .” to “Isaiah once said. . .”¹²

Writing in 1987, Jeppesen did not deny the historicity of the prophets, who in his perspective were historical persons; but he urged an exilic setting of the prophetic books, in his case the book of Micah, the biographical parts of the books thus being legendary. From a current exegetical perspective, Jeppesen’s and his contemporaries’ trust in scholarship’s ability to locate a historical prophet or his *ipsissima vox* is overly optimistic—and also superfluous for understanding the meaning of the message in context. But that does not change the importance of his emphasis on the authorization process through the inclusion of legendary (written) material.

From a cognitive perspective, biography and “history”—also in the shape of invented history and biography—seem to be part of our inherent proclivity as social beings. We need, cognitively, to “know” the source of the message and “know” the “person behind it” in order to add to the credibility and significance of the message.¹³ thus, the narrative of Ezra reading the Torah out loud for Israel; thus, the biographical material in the prophetic books; thus, the addition of David’s name and the references to his life in the rubrics of the Psalms.

BIOGRAPHIES OF PROPHETIC PERSONAE

The quantity of biographic information—and accordingly the immediate impression of a prophetic persona—varies tremendously in the prophetic books. Some of them, such as Joel, Obadiah, and Malachi, are only briefly associated with their eponymous authors through the word-event formula in the rubric or through a few editorial formulae as discussed, for example, by Jill Middlemas in relation to Haggai and Zechariah 1–8.¹⁴ Middlemas labels four categories of edited material that identify the prophet as the sender or intermediary of the divine word: (1) the intermediary formula; (2) historical dating; (3) the word-event formula; and (4) interpretive detail, providing “indication of the efficacy of the prophet’s words” (e.g., Zech 1:12). She suggests five chief reasons for this kind of editorial activity, of which two are especially suggestive for our purpose: (1) to preserve a historical context (or to provide one, given your viewpoint), and (2) to give legitimacy to the prophet and to lend authority to the tradition of the prophet, especially the written record (Middlemas 2011: 145–149).

Other prophetic books offered more detailed “biographic” information, but it is important to recall that this information was not solely, and maybe not even primarily, given in order to identify the prophet. Rather, the authorization was double-sided: through the presentation of the prophetic persona, the prophetic “biography” authorized the message as a divine message; but at the same time, the messenger- and word-event formulae authorized the prophetic persona as a divine messenger. Some

books, such as the book of Jeremiah, cover large periods of the life of the prophet. In the case of Jonah, the narrative of the man *is* the message. In any case, none of the prophetic books goes without a sender and a date, probably redactional additions. Thus, one could tentatively conclude that by the time of the redaction of the prophetic books in the Persian period, the need for authentication was so deeply felt that the collection of (maybe) previously anonymous oracles were prefixed with rubrics that attached the oracles to a certain person, and often also to certain times and locations.

Some of the most telling examples of “biography” are the books of Hosea, Amos, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah, with the third one of the major prophets, the book of Isaiah, as a notable exception. In what follows, we shall not go into the discussion of the historicity of these biographies, and the reflections presented do not in any way intend to refer to the historicity of the prophets. Neither shall we consider the textual history through tradition or redaction. The prophetic biographies in question are understood as adhering to the conventions of a literary genre, the prophetic biography, although this genre comes in different rhetorical forms. The question is this: What is the impact and the function of the presentation of a prophetic persona on the message of the book?

Hosea

Set in Northern Israel of the eighth century B.C.E. (Hos 1:1; 5:1), the book of Hosea offers enough “biographical” material to create the impression of a prophetic persona. The introductory third-person narrative of Hosea 1–2 tells how Hosea marries a “wife of whoredom” (אִשָּׁת זִנוּנִים) and has children of whoredom (יְלִדֵי זִנוּנִים, Hos 1:2).¹⁵ Both the prophet himself and the woman are presented with their patronyms, which lend an impression of “reality” to this prophetic sign-act. In Hosea 3 we find a parallel presentation of the same motif in the first-person narrative of YHWH instructing the prophet to marry “a woman who has a lover and is an adulteress” (אִשָּׁה אֹהֶבֶת רֵעַ וּמִנָּאֶפֶת, Hos 3:1). The two presentations are different in relation to genre, third-person narrative and first-person memoir, respectively, and to a certain degree also in their message, though in the end the outcomes seem to be alike.

Hosea 1 serves as the biography proper, telling the story of the prophetic sign-act, while the so-called *RîB* (lawsuit) in Hosea 2 frames the divine exposition of the narrative. Interestingly, the transition from Hosea 1 to 2 is far from smooth. There is no word-event formula to present the divine speaker, and the addressee of the discourse is far from well-defined. In Hosea 2:3 (MT) the addressees seem to be the children, who are requested to plead with (רִיב) their mother, while only two verses later the addressee might be a member (or members) of the audience. From Hosea 2:18 (MT), the discourse is addressed to the woman who will be reinstated in her role as divine spouse while the children will be forgiven (Hos 2:23–25 [MT]). Thus, the addressees seem blurred while the sender is uniform, the prophetic persona representing the deity. When read as a unity, Hosea 1–2 presents the message of Israel’s sins and YHWH’s purging acts, which lead to her redemption through divine mercy.

The much shorter “memoir” in Hosea 3 presents the sign-act in verses 1–3 and its exposition in verses 4–5: After a period of waiting and cleansing, the Israelites will return to YHWH and his chosen king. Again, the message is a message of return to God, this time not due to his mercy but to the conversion (שוב) of the people. In both cases, the prophet disappears from the picture and is replaced by YHWH, for whom the prophet obviously serves as a stand-in. After chapter 3 the prophetic persona disappears completely from the text, and so does YHWH. The proclamation formula, “Hear the word of YHWH, O people of Israel,” is only used in Hosea 4:1. In the rest of the book the speaker is anonymous; there are no proclamation formulae, no messenger- or word-event formulae. Nevertheless, it goes without saying that the speaker is YHWH, not the prophet who through the sign-acts has been converted to a representation of the deity. Thus, in Hosea 1–3 we get a first premonition that the prophetic persona, as presented in the introductory chapters, serves as a personification of YHWH. The prophet carries the mask through which, so the text implies, YHWH speaks and the deity becomes more than a voice from above. YHWH is presented as being involved with the human condition. Through the presentation of the troubles of a flesh-and-blood prophet, the implied author generates identification between his audience and YHWH. Then, as the drama unfolds and the message is explained, the whore and her children of whoredom are identified as the people, and the audience is forced to acknowledge their sin against him. On this backdrop, the book can continue its narrative of Israel’s apostasy and YHWH’s cathartic punishment, his mercy and loyalty (חסד and רחמה).

Amos

Amos’s persona is different from Hosea’s; nevertheless, the book of Amos also presents an identification between message and person that calls for consideration. A first indication comes in the introductory oracle, which is governed by the verb שאג (“to roar”), with YHWH as the subject. The verb returns in Amos 3:4, 8, with a lion as the subject in the simile:

Does a lion roar in the forest, when it has no prey?
Does a young lion cry out from its den, if it has caught nothing? (Amos 3:4)¹⁶
The lion has roared; who will not fear?
The LORD GOD has spoken; who can but prophesy? (Amos 3:8)

The roaring lion is obviously YHWH himself; nevertheless, he who roars is also the prophet (cf. Amos 3:8bβ). This is indicated in the introduction to Amos. The book is labeled דברי עמוס (“words of Amos”), a most unusual reference, since the average introductory formula in the prophetic books is דבר יהוה אשר היה אל, “The Word of YHWH which came to. . .” The introduction, “words of PN,” is known only from Jeremiah and Amos. From the outset, then, the book is labeled a book of words spoken by a prophet, not by God; nevertheless, the first words by the prophet concern words, roared by YHWH himself from

Zion, the temple mountain in Judah (not in Samaria). Moreover, and differently from Hosea, the book of Amos is rich with formulae that identify the oracles as words of YHWH. The words in the book of Amos are not the words of the prophet who speaks them but the words of YHWH; note also the repeated use of emphasized first-person YHWH speech in Amos 4. Only in the visions in Amos 7–9 is the prophet separated from YHWH as an independent person who enters a conversation with YHWH and sides with Israel, pledging for mercy. This pledge, however, is canceled after the interference of Amaziah, the priest of Bethel who tries to expel Amos to Judah (Amos 7:10–17). Amos answers by claiming that he is not a professional prophet (נביא) but a farmer and that he was called to prophesy (הנבא) to God's people, Israel, by YHWH himself.¹⁷ As opposed to Moses in the desert, Amos seeks to intercede for the people, and thus the prophet is moved from Israel's party to YHWH's. After the fourth and final vision, the prophet is quieted, חשׁה ("Hush!"), and the only remaining speaker is YHWH. This is authenticated by prophet's identification with his message, the doom over Samaria's social injustice. Obviously, Amos as a prophetic persona is dissociated from the upper classes of the society to which he prophesies, since he is an outsider, a herdsman coming from Tekoa in Judah (Amos 1:1).

The presentation of the prophet Amos offers the impression of a literary persona, rather than the outline of a living person. The biographic information is closely linked to his prophetic vocation, and time and again the prophet fades away and is overwritten by the divine word. Oracle, prophet, and persona merge and become indissoluble.

Isaiah

The historical person of Isaiah is concealed by the fact that the book obviously consists of three parts and that these parts do not originate with one prophet. But also the literary persona of Isaiah is an elusive figure in the book that bears his name. There are a few (Deuteronomistic) narratives with oracles that connect him to the royal house in pre-exilic times, most emphatically the Immanuel prophecy in chapter 7, the sign-act in 20:1–7, and the events during the Assyrian siege of Jerusalem, Isaiah 36–39 (= 2 Kgs 18:13–20:19).¹⁸ The call narrative in Isaiah 6, on the other hand, connects him to the Temple, suggesting that he might be a priest—a perception supported by the extant references to Zion and intertextual and theological links to the book of Psalms. This notwithstanding, Isaiah the prophet has not invited nearly as much interest in biography or identification as especially Jeremiah (see discussion later in this chapter).

One group of texts, however, has fostered intense work concerning their referentiality to a person, the so-called servant songs, Isaiah 42:1–4; 49:1–6; 50:4–9, and 52:13–53:12. It was Bernhard Duhm who, in his 1892 commentary on Isaiah, identified the four servant songs, which he argued were composed by a member of the Jewish community during the first half of the fifth century B.C.E. Since that, a multitude of proposals for the identification of the servant has been presented; Klaus Baltzer, for example, has proposed that the servant songs form a prophetic biography, which was secondarily added to Isaiah

40–55. Tryggve Mettinger, on the other hand, in his *Farewell to the Servant Songs*, argues for an inclusion of more ‘*ebed*’ passages (i.e., “sections in Isa 40–55 in which the term ‘*ebed*’ figures”),¹⁹ and ends up with a collective interpretation as a result of “democratization” during the exile (Mettinger 1983: 44). Blenkinsopp (2002: 76–81) calls for a cumulative editorial process of the servant songs within Isaiah 40–55, and argues that “we must take seriously the possibility that these passages have in the course of time been assigned to several individuals or groups,” beginning with Cyrus.

The implied ongoing discussion shows us that even the Servant Songs cannot be seen as an indisputable attempt of creating a prophetic persona in the book of Isaiah. The messages of this book are not subsumed under any attempted personification, and the persona of any of the “Isaiahs” evaporates at second glance. This, however, is rather unusual, something that will be further demonstrated in the cases of Ezekiel and Jeremiah.

Ezekiel

The sheer size of the book of Ezekiel makes generalizations about it hazardous;²⁰ it offers a few “biographical” narratives, lengthy parables, venomous diatribes, and a blueprint for the post-catastrophe temple in Jerusalem. Ezekiel has been read through the lens of psychopathology,²¹ post-traumatic stress disorder (Smith-Christopher 2002: 89–96), and disaster studies (Stulman and Kim 2010: 145–181), the collective parallel to the individual phenomenon of post-traumatic stress disorder. The book of Ezekiel as a book with its “surplus of violence and unrelenting blame” seems to be in need of scholarly redemption. In the expression of Stulman and Kim, “The Book of Ezekiel . . . opens a dark shadowy window into the pain of displaced people” (2010: 145).

If we read the “biographical” material as non-historical discourse, it consists by and large of narratives about sign-acts. The eating of the scroll, Ezekiel 3:1–3; the death of the prophet’s wife remaining un-mourned, both emotionally and by acts of rites, 24:16–18; Ezekiel prophesying for the bones in the valley, 37:1–10; and the subsequent sign-act of the unification of two sticks of wood, 37:16–17—all these sign-acts receive expositions within the text that make the prophet a representation of the divine message. They are not—or at least not primarily—narratives about what has happened; the sign-acts are not only signs, but enact performances of the divine will and intent. The act and the message are one, and the prophet becomes a personification of theology, a mask representing the divine. The sign-acts are at the same time speech-acts. The same can be argued concerning the visions (e.g., Ezekiel’s two visits to the Jerusalem temple in chapter 8²² and chapters 40–48). Through the presentation of the visionary experiences, the literary prophetic persona transforms into a persona in the imbedded narrative, a persona narrated by a persona, so to speak. This later persona is the representation of the message.²³

In his major commentary on Ezekiel, Walther Zimmerli referred to B. Baentsch, who in 1908 came to this conclusion: “These actions, in all their details, are so precisely calculated, and directed to their purpose, that we cannot speak here of a mental disturbance” (Zimmerli 1979: 17). Zimmerli comments (1979: 18):

It is certainly not appropriate to regard and read it [the book of Ezekiel] as a description of a biographical situation. The visions and symbolic actions are undoubtedly set out in regard to the message to be heard and seen in them. [. . .] The biographical element is repeatedly integrated into kerygmatic considerations and by this estranged from its customary context.

Zimmerli, however, is not ready to skip the historicity of the acts and sign-acts of Ezekiel: “Yet, for all this, it is still not said that in Ezekiel’s visions and symbolic acts we have to do with a pure literary fiction” (18). The first step toward hermeneutical minimalism and the literary turn of exegesis was yet to be taken. Nevertheless, taking Baentsch and Zimmerli as a point of departure, it is worthwhile to consider whether this “calculation” (Baentsch) is part of the literary presentation of the prophetic persona. Do the weirder sides of Ezekiel mirror the close connection between act and proclamation?

The book of Ezekiel is especially dense on references to traditions appearing elsewhere in the Old Testament. Exegetes have understood this referentiality in terms of authentication of the prophet, necessitated by his lack of authority as speaking in Babylon.²⁴ However, considering the highly literate form of Ezekiel both in the presentation of his sign-acts and in terms of the overall use of intertextual references as building blocks of the book proper—as shown by, for example, Anja Klein in a 2010 article²⁵—I prefer this referentiality to be understood as a part of the creation of the prophetic persona.²⁶ The presentation of Ezekiel the *prophet* (by means of autobiography, as shown by, for example, D. Nathan Phinney) can be understood as a literary act that presents Ezekiel the *prophetic persona* (*pace* Phinney). The narratives of highly unrealistic visions and acts—most of which are only reported as instructed by YHWH but never as performed by Ezekiel—serve to present and authenticate the book of Ezekiel as a prophetic book about a prophetic persona who hears, sees, and experiences divine intervention in his life. Thus, he can serve as a prophet, a role model, and an inspiration to conversion and transformation for his reading audience, be it contemporaneous to the book or later. Moreover, being directly connected to historical data and geographical locations, Ezekiel’s literary biography can also serve as survival literature for the exiles in Babylon, as shown by Stulman and Kim (2010: 161): “In broad strokes Ezekiel makes the paradoxical claim that life’s greatest gifts emerge in the most unlikely places. Who would have ever expected Babylon to become a fulcrum of hope and newness?” The impressive narratives of the prophet’s experiences serve as a medium of hope.

Jeremiah

The same holds true when it comes to the book of Jeremiah, which since the beginning of the twenty-first century—rightly, in my opinion—has been analyzed as trauma literature, and thus as survival literature for exilic and post-exilic Judaism.²⁷ In Jeremiah we find the most expressed identification between man and message in the Old Testament, as already inferred by the approach of Skinner and Duhm.²⁸ Moreover, Jeremiah is the

prophet with the most complete “biography” in his book, from information about his birthdate and birthplace via his showdowns with the ruling classes in Jerusalem before and during the Babylonian siege until his disappearance in Egypt, where he was brought by Judean refugees after the fall of Jerusalem.²⁹ This notwithstanding, more and more scholars raise the question as to whether we have any chance of reaching information about the “historical Jeremiah” or even the core of his message. In his book *The Prophetic Persona: Jeremiah and the Language of the Self*, Timothy Polk has shown that Jeremiah’s so-called Confessions are best understood as “features of the persona rendered by the text.” In opposition to the approach of the dialectical theology of the mid-century twentieth century,³⁰ Polk reads the Confessions as models of both personal piety and theological *kerygma*: The concern of the interpretation of the Confessions is “to limn the features of the persona rendered by the text as a model of obediential suffering,” and “. . . since Jeremiah’s person is inextricably bound up with his proclamation, the piety is really part of the kerygma, not something extrinsic to it” (Polk 1984: 129).

Polk’s study is based primarily on the first-person language texts in the book of Jeremiah, also outside the Confessions, covering various form-critical genres. These texts he calls “language of the heart.” Based on his synchronic approach, Polk reaches the understanding that the book of Jeremiah offers a theology of imitation. His results, however, point to other parts of the book of Jeremiah than the first-person texts. The imitation not only comprises the prophetic persona and the audience of the book; the imitation also includes the prophetic persona, imitating the deity. The word of God and the prophet merge into one persona, and the prophet’s *vita* serves as an authorization of the divine word-become-flesh.³¹ The association of God and prophet is positively established, for example, in the call narrative, Jeremiah 1:4–10, with its exposition in 1:11–14, 15–19; in the divine-prophetic dirge over Jerusalem in Jeremiah 8–9; and in the prophetic sign-acts, Jeremiah 13:1–14; 19:1–15. Moreover, as shown by Martin Kessler already in 1968, the overall fate of the prophet images the fate of the word of God in the composition of the book of Jeremiah. Prophet, word, and deity become one.

Negatively, the identification of God and prophet is corroborated by the prophet’s dissociation from the people: he is not allowed to intercede for the people, Jeremiah 14:11–16 (cf. 21:1–10); instead, from the outset God makes him

a fortified city,
an iron pillar,
and a bronze wall,
against the whole land—
against the kings of Judah,
its princes, its priests, and the people of the land. (1:18)

In the book of Jeremiah we find the most clearly expressed example of the merging of God and prophet, the prophetic persona representing and incarnating the divine persona. By analogy to the Iroquois—and ancient Greek—thinking, mentioned earlier: The

prophet bears the mask of the divine in order to assimilate into and identify with the deity and to participate in the divine project.

AUXILIARY, CONCLUDING REFLECTIONS

In his concluding remarks, Polk clarifies his understanding of persona in the book of Jeremiah:

The poetic, metaphoric qualities of our material are clear evidence that the book of Jeremiah is a work of the imagination. This is not to say that it is fanciful, unreal, or untrue. Nor is it even to say that it is dominated by an aesthetic interest. Quite to the contrary, the aesthetic labors in the service of the religious, and the book is clearly engaged in making truth-claims—about the world, about the prophet, and about God—though scarcely in propositional form. The point is that the kind of truth claimed . . . is of a special sort, one that cannot be expressed apart from the imaginatively charged language it employs (Polk 1984: 166).

This understanding goes hand in hand with John Barton's considerations in his *Ethics and the Old Testament*.³² Inspired by the works of Martha C. Nussbaum, Barton opts for understanding Old Testament ethics through narrative. Nussbaum has shown how Aristotle and the Greek tragedians convey ethical consideration through drama and narrative, not through first principles (like Plato).³³ As in the work of Aristotle, Barton claims, in the Old Testament ethics are not communicated as universal rules and as principles detached from human interaction (*pace* Kant), but as narratives that help us think about ethical matters. "To put it in modern terms, ethics is not a science but an art" (Barton 2003: 57). This approach allows for redrawing some of the lines of demarcation between the various things biblical scholars do, historical-criticism in one trench, literary readings in the other. Nussbaum's hermeneutics inspire to a fuller understanding of the meanings of the text. Barton concludes:

What unites us with the text is not a decision to read it as if it had just been written, but the conviction that it and we are both exercised by certain fundamental questions about human beings and the world they inhabit, chief among which is 'How ought we to live?' . . . One gets from her [Nussbaum's] writing a sense that the great texts matter because they ask what is good for humankind and never rest till they have found an answer (Barton 2003: 64).

In my opinion, Barton's proposal is applicable to Old Testament prophecy as well as to narrative. The prophetic personae, as masks and megaphones of God, carry the *theology*—God's talk—on their bodies and via their performances and speeches to the readers of prophetic literature. The prophetic books, understood as literature like the works of Aristotle or Euripides, are intent to impress on their audiences imitation and

consideration of religious thought, leading to understanding, conversion, and action. What is true for ethics is true for religious understanding, conversion, and action, too: Religious persuasion is not a science but an art.

NOTES

1. Immanuel Kant, *Foundations of the Metaphysics of Morals* in *Critique of Practical Reason and Other Writings in Moral Philosophy* (trans. and ed. Lewis White Beck; Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1949), 86–87; cf. Elliott 1982: 19.
2. Carl G. Jung, [*Collected papers on*] *analytical psychology* (authorized translation ed. Constance E. Long; 2nd ed. New York: Moffat Yard, 1917), 466; emphases original. See Fabian Gudas, “Persona,” in *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics* (ed. Alex Preminger et al.; Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1993), 900–902 [901]. The use of persona in the Christian theological discussion of the divine personae is of no relevance to our topic.
3. Elliot 1982: 21; emphasis original.
4. See Louis Stulman, “Prophetic Words and Acts as Survival Literature,” Chapter 18 of the present volume. For prophetic sign-acts and street theater, see Johanna Erzberger, “Prophetic Sign Acts as Performances,” in Holt and Sharp 2015: 104–116.
5. Duhm 1922: 3–8. All translations made by the author. The connection between the contempt of Duhm and his contemporaries for antique Judaism as a mediocre, legalistic cult religion and emerging anti-Semitism in Europe is painfully recognizable.
6. In Holt and Sharp 2015, see Joe Henderson, “Duhm and Skinner’s Invention of Jeremiah,” 1–15; Mary Chilton Callaway, “Seduced by Method: History and Jeremiah 20,” 16–33.
7. Skinner 1922: 12. It is illuminating in this connection to see how Skinner separates himself from the view of his contemporaries, that “they [the later prophets] are simply using the traditional form of prophetic experience to express ideas which they had apprehended otherwise, either by pure spiritual intuition or by the exercise of their reasoning and reflective powers,” and emphasizes the achievements of “recent psychological research.” “The so-called irrational part of a man’s nature has assumed a new importance under the name of the ‘sub-conscious’; and, uncertain as the ultimate nature of the sub-conscious self may be, there are facts enough to dispel the notion that everything of value in the spiritual life of man must come by way of conscious intellectual effort” (11–12).
8. Cf. also William McKane’s two-volume commentary: *Jeremiah I* and *II* (ICC; Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1986 and 1996). McKane’s idiosyncratic approach to the book of Jeremiah as a “rolling corpus” is purely redactional, and he is expressly reluctant about finding the historical Jeremiah in the book. Thus he does not offer any introduction to the historical prophet Jeremiah from Anathoth.
9. See the discussion in David Nathan Phinney, *The Prophetic Persona in the Book of Ezekiel: Autobiography and Portrayal* (unpublished dissertation, Yale University, 2004), 38–47.
10. “The imitation of noble examples . . . is not to be regarded as a blind and unthinking repetition of acts performed by some great man in the past. It meant learning from a great exemplar the way to order one’s life and then . . . to emulate what sort of person he was” (Talbert 1992: 747).

11. On Israel and the axial age, see Robert N. Bellah, *Religion in Human Evolution: From the Paleolithic to the Axial Age* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2011), esp. Chapter 6: "The Axial Age I: Introduction and Ancient Israel," 265–323.
12. Knud Jeppesen, *Græder ikke saa saare. Studier i Mikabogens sigte*. Volume I (Aarhus: Aarhus University Press, 1987), 99, with reference to Peter R. Ackroyd (author's translation from Danish).
13. Jesper Sørensen from the *Interacting Minds Centre*, Aarhus University, in a private conversation. The current interest among biblical scholars in "inventing" biographies might have its cause in the circumstance that we as scholars, with our minimalist hermeneutics of suspicion, miss traditional historiography and/or our former historical naïveté.
14. Jill Middlemas, "The Shape of Things to Come: Redaction and the Early Second Temple Period Prophetic Tradition," in *Constructs of Prophecy in the Former and Latter Prophets and Other Texts* (ed. Lester L. Grabbe and Martti Nissinen; ANEM 4; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2011), 141–155.
15. The meaning of זמרים is thoroughly discussed in feminist exegesis, but the question is without significance in this context.
16. Translations are from the NRSV unless otherwise indicated.
17. The meaning of this remains enigmatic, since we do not possess verifiable information about the social location of herdsmen and dressers of sycamore trees and the association to the information in Amos 1:1 that Amos was a shepherd. The varied information about Amos's trade indicates indirectly that the information given is not about what he did for a living but about his calling as God's chosen prophet and adversary of the people.
18. According to Joseph Blenkinsopp, these chapters result from "a move to reconstrue the prophet Isaiah as a 'man of God' who interceded, worked miracles, healed, and was supportive of the ruler" (2002: 54).
19. Trygve N. D. Mettinger, *A Farewell to the Servant Songs: A Critical Examination of an Exegetical Axiom* (Scripta Minora 1982–1983; 3; Lund: CWK Gleerup, 1983), 13.
20. Bernhard Duhm labeled Ezekiel a *Schriftsteller*, a prosaist and desktop writer with no sense of poetry (1922: xx), while his contemporary, Gustav Hölscher, by the means of radical *Literarkritik*, freed Ezekiel from "the dry prosaic pattern in which the redaction ha[d] woven his poems," making the poet Ezekiel reappear "in a clear light, with his brilliant, imaginative and passionate rhetoric" (Gustav Hölscher, *Hesekiel, der Dichter und das Buch* [BZAW 39; Gießen: Töpelmann, 1924; English trans. in Zimmerli 1979], 5).
21. B. Baentsch, "Pathologische Züge in Israels Prophetentum," *ZWT* 50 (1908): 52–81; David J. Halperin, *Seeking Ezekiel: Text and Psychology* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1993).
22. With reference to Edwin C. Broome, "Ezekiel's Abnormal Personality," *JBL* 65 (1946): 277–292, Halperin understands Ezekiel digging a hole in the Temple wall, Ezek 8:7–8, as "a symbolic representation of sexual intercourse" (*Seeking Ezekiel*, 2, cf. 82–140). This is the point of departure for his psychoanalytic reading of Ezekiel.
23. My considerations are inspired by the Danish genre theorist Sune Auken, who studies the phenomenon of "genre within a genre," e.g., of biographical elements in fiction, as a rhetorical and literary device. See Sune Auken, "Genre as Fictional Action: On the Use of Rhetorical Genres in Fiction," *Nordisk Tidsskrift for Informationsvidenskab og Kulturformidling* 2, Vol. 3 (2013): 19–28.

24. Cf., e.g., D. Nathan Phinney, "Portraying Prophetic Experience and Tradition in Ezekiel," in *Thus Says the Lord: Essays on the Former and Latter Prophets in Honor of Robert R. Wilson* (ed. John J. Ahn and Stephen L. Cook; LHBOTS 502; New York: T & T Clark, 2009), 234–243 (243).
25. Anja Klein, "Prophecy Continued: Reflections on Innerbiblical Exegesis in the Book of Ezekiel," *VT* 60 (2010): 571–582.
26. Cf. Margaret S. Odell, "Genre and Persona in Ezekiel 24:15–24," in *The Book of Ezekiel: Theological and Anthropological Perspectives* (ed. Margaret S. Odell and John T. Strong; SBLSymS 9; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2000), 195–219.
27. See O'Connor 2011; Stulman and Kim 2010: 97–141; Else K. Holt. "Daughter Zion: Trauma, Cultural Memory and Gender in OT Poetics," in *Trauma and Traumatization in Individual and Collective Dimensions: Insights from Biblical Studies and Beyond* (ed. Eve-Marie Becker, Jan Dochhorn, and Else K. Holt; SaNT 2; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2014), 161–175. On the concept of survival literature, see Linafelt 2000.
28. Thus, the scholarly literature abounds with titles referring to the suffering of the prophet. See, on the biographical approach to Jeremiah, Holt and Sharp 2015.
29. The extant biographic interest in Jeremiah continued in a vast extra-scriptural literature affiliated with Jeremiah and his secretary, Baruch, especially from the second temple period, as in, e.g., the so-called pseudepigraphical books of Baruch, 1–4 Baruch.
30. Against A. H. J. Gunneweg's assertion: "The prophecy as well as its subsequent interpretation contains less piety to be explicated psychologically but for that all the more kerygma to be explicated theologically," Polk raises the heuristic objection that "[a]nalytic in the concept 'exemplar,' one would think, is the concept 'imitation,' and it is precisely the prophetic persona's piety, i.e. his obediential faith, that configuration of beliefs, trust, praise, and anguish expressed in the Confessions, which is to be imitated by the reader—and explicated by the exegete" (Polk 1984: 129).
31. Cf., e.g., Else K. Holt, "Communication of Authority: The 'Prophet' in the Book of Jeremiah," in *The Discursive Fight over Religious Texts in Antiquity: Religion and Normativity* (ed. Anders-Christian Jacobsen; Aarhus: Aarhus University Press, 2009), 110–118; Else K. Holt, "Narrative Normativity in Diasporic Jeremiah—and Today," in *Jeremiah (Dis)placed: New Directions in Writing/Reading Jeremiah* (ed. A. R. Pete Diamond and Louis Stulman; LHBOTS 529; New York: T & T Clark, 2011), 125–135.
32. The following is based on Barton 2003, Chapter 4: "Reading for Life," 55–64.
33. "To put the contrast crudely, Plato works on ethical problems from first principles, whereas Aristotle's method is empirical, based on the minute observation of particular cases and of what commends itself to the average person" (Barton 2003: 57).

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CHAPTER 18

PROPHETIC WORDS AND ACTS AS SURVIVAL LITERATURE

LOUIS STULMAN

JEREMIAH 18:18 introduces the fourth of Jeremiah's so-called confessions by alluding to three forms of authoritative speech in Judean life: "instruction" (תורה) by the priest, "counsel" (עצה) from the sage, and the "word" (דבר) of the prophet (cf. Ezek 7:26). Interestingly, the repositories of these sources of divine knowledge correspond in broad strokes to the tripartite division of the Hebrew Bible. The duty of the priest is to teach the *torah*, that is, to instruct people in holy living and liturgical practice in the presence of a holy God. The prophet communicates the "word" of God to the people of God, a task that involves challenging the dominant power structures of the day and imploring Judeans and Israelites to practice social justice and righteous living. The sage, whose written legacy is preserved in part in Job, Qoheleth, and Proverbs, offers "counsel" on behavior, values, and dispositions that support prudent professional interactions and that help people negotiate life's many ethical quandaries. All three—priest, prophet, and sage—play key roles in community formation. All give expression to Israel's enduring religious traditions. All function as intermediaries, but only prophets were entrusted with receiving and delivering the divine word. And only prophets bridge the chasm between the divine and human worlds by "the word of God/YHWH."

GOD'S SPOKESPERSONS

The word *prophet* derives from the Greek term προφήτης, which is a translation of the common Hebrew term נביא, likely meaning "to call" or "to speak" (Petersen 2002: 5–8). As God's spokespersons, prophets are commissioned and empowered to declare the divine message, regardless of its acceptance. Whether speaking out against social injustices or

economic improprieties, or confronting a nation's idolatry and rebellion, their oracles are customarily introduced as "the *word* of YHWH," "the *word* that came [to the prophet] from YHWH," "the *word* that YHWH spoke," "the *word* of YHWH that came to me," "hear the *word* of YHWH," and most often, "this is what YHWH says/said." God puts the divine word in the mouth of prophets when authorizing them (Num 23:5; Deut 18:15–22; Jer 1:4–10) and prophets "ingest" it in order to fulfill their mission (Ezek 3:1–27; Jer 15:16). The word that prophets utter is therefore not their own: it derives neither from the dominant power structures of the community nor from the force of their personality. It is the word of God and thus conveys a marked sense of import and urgency.

At the prompting of YHWH, prophets declare the divine word to kings, governors, priests, military personnel, and international dignitaries, as well as ordinary citizens. On occasion, prophets respond to particular inquiries (Isa 38:1–8; Jer 37:1–21; 45:1–5), although inquirers do not always (often) heed their words (e.g., Jer 42:1–43:7), and at least in one instance attempt to destroy them (Jeremiah 36). In a striking story of the rejection of the prophetic word, Judah's King Jehoiakim orders one of his court officers, Jehudi, to bring a prophetic scroll to him, after which he has the scroll cut into pieces and burned (Jeremiah 36). This brazen act of political muscle is thwarted by God's instruction to Jeremiah to produce another scroll with the same words, as well as additional ones.

At times, prophets convey oracles that conflict with, and even contradict, other prophets, creating extreme circumstances for listening communities (Deut 13:1–5; 18:15–22; and 1 Kgs 22). A dispute between the prophet Jeremiah and his rival Hananiah sheds light on these extremities bubbling beneath the text (Jeremiah 27–28). In the most detailed narrative on prophetic conflict in the Hebrew Bible, the two prophets offer irreconcilable interpretations of Judah's pressing political predicament. Hananiah insists that Babylon's domination of Syria-Palestine will come to an end in the immediate future, resulting in the restoration of the Judean deportees of 598/7 B.C.E.—a buoyant interpretation likely fueled by Isaiah's earlier oracles concerning Jerusalem's indomitability. In stark contrast, Jeremiah contends that Judah must brace itself for a long and arduous season of exile. Accommodation and patient hope, not insurrection, will best serve the community's welfare. That both prophetic messages are rooted in venerable theological traditions makes community discernment problematic. That both messengers employ a surplus of conventional forms and practices makes the dilemma all the more daunting. Both Jeremiah and Hananiah introduce their message as the word of YHWH; both use traditional prophetic language and corroborate the divine message with symbolic actions. Both utter their words within the temple precincts, apparently as recognized professional functionaries. Such conditions draw attention to the formidable task of distinguishing true from false prophecy, as well as to the importance of prophecy as verbal communication rather than as mantic power, personal charisma, or ecstasy. Indeed, the entire enterprise is subsumed under the heading of דבר, the Word—in oral or written form.

One of the more confident results of twentieth- and early twenty-first-century Near Eastern scholarship is that prophecy in its earliest form was predominantly an oral phenomenon; prophets were primarily spokespersons and not writers. Although prophets

in ancient Israel and elsewhere in the Levant were likely capable of writing down their oracles or even delivering them in written form (that is to say, the transcription of oracular discourse was not the sole responsibility of scribal communities), the essence of their intermediary work was the dissemination of the *spoken word*, perhaps even in brief poetic utterances.

It is difficult to map out a chronology of the growth and development of prophecy in ancient Israel. The Hebrew Bible depicts Israel's earliest prophets/seers, including Nathan and Gad, Elijah and Elisha, as speakers, performers, miracle workers, and those with special abilities to discern what others cannot see.¹ Even at the start of the "classical period" of prophecy, when the so-called writing prophets emerge, Amos, Hosea, and Micah appear as spokespersons and visionaries, not as writers. The complex book of Jeremiah bears witness to a transition from oral prophecy to written prophecy: Jeremiah first appears as a spokesman of repentance who morphs into a Deuteronomic preacher, whose words are eventually written down in authoritative texts or scrolls (e.g., Jer 25:1–14; 36:1–32; 45:1–5; 51:59–64). No earlier than the sixth century, with Ezekiel, do we likely encounter prophecy in written form from inception. The dilemma facing those seeking to analyze the earliest spoken words of the prophets or to reconstruct their growth and development is that prophetic speech is preserved only in written sources. We have no access to the oral prophecy apart from its literary representation.

WRITTEN PROPHECY

Contemporary studies of language have demonstrated that the shift from oral to written speech involves more than mimetic changes. When the spoken word is transcribed, significant alterations occur. Ronald E. Clements observes that "written prophecy is necessarily different from oral prophecy precisely because it is written and is thereby made subject to the gains and losses that written fixation entails" (1996: 204). The literarization of prophecy involves the restructuring of meaning and reconfiguring of thought. Put differently, when the spoken word becomes the written word, realignments in setting and audience, as well as intentionality and meaning, take place.²

At the outset, written prophecy has fewer spatial and temporal limitations than its oral counterpart. When communicating the divine word, the prophet addresses a particular audience at a particular time and place, often in response to particular networks of domestic or geopolitical concerns. The proclaimed word is therefore culture- and crisis-specific; it is rooted deeply in the contingencies of local contexts. When the oral word is written down, it is to some extent freed from these constraints and can move about freely in diaspora, both figuratively and literally, as when Jeremiah sent a prophetic message by carrier to Judean refugees in Babylon (Jer 29:1–14). Written prophecy can therefore *do* what prophets cannot, and can *go* where prophets are banned. Moreover, prophetic scrolls (i.e., oral prophecy preserved in writing) are more resilient than prophets themselves, who are subject to physical attack and even death. The prophet

Micaiah, for example, is assaulted after he predicts Israel's military loss (1 Kings 22); Jeremiah is struck by Pashhur, thrown into a cistern, and forcibly taken to Egypt (e.g., Jeremiah 20, 38, 43). Amos is harassed and threatened with extradition by Amaziah, a priest at Bethel who represents the interests of King Jeroboam. Scrolls can survive such brazen acts of political force, and even if they are destroyed, others can be produced, however arduously. Consequently, written prophecy compensates for the vanquished prophet, whose words are essentially subject to a range of human limitations. It is the written word, now in its various iterations, that endures forever (Isa 40:8).

The written word, however, is far more than a surrogate of the spoken word or an anthology of loosely connected oracles.³ Prophetic writing in ancient Israel represents a distinct, though related, rhetorical expression. Unlike its oral counterpoint, it takes shape *after* the ravages of war and attends to the survivors. This written expression, in large measure, functions as a complex human response to the massive collapse of long-standing cultural and symbolic arrangements, a collapse that is chiefly the result of war, forced relocation, and captivity. Put differently, the prophetic corpus is essentially meaning-making literature for postwar communities. It pulsates with pain and danger. It practices candor about fallen worlds and moves beyond candor to critique. It destabilizes and dismantles trusted traditions. It demands covenant loyalty and calls the community to action. Consequently, this literary tradition enjoys its own distinctive character, with its own concerns and values. Biblical prophecy is *ancient Israel's disaster literature*, its literature of loss and liminality.

WRITTEN PROPHECY AS DISASTER LITERATURE

Written prophecy's multiplicity of voices bears witness to the end of Israel's symbolic, cultural, and political structures, principally as a result of two national disasters: the fall of Samaria in the late eighth century B.C.E., and the sixth-century destruction of Jerusalem, events that scholars have long identified as the focal points of the prophetic corpus. Even a superficial reading of the corpus cannot obscure the central role played by these devastating events and the concerted effort to survive them. This disaster literature, or "anti-poetry," to use Tadeusz Różewicz's term, is beset with violence and deep ruptures in life.⁴

Hosea opens the Book of the Twelve, for example, with an ominous allusion to the brutality of Jehu's house (Hos 1:4–5) and proceeds to map out the utter destruction of northern Israel. Joel's metaphorical world is consumed by invading armies, envisioned as "cutting locust," "swarming locust," "hopping locust," and "destroying locust" (Joel 1:4). In Amos, abuses in war unify the initial oracles against the nations; and the threat of military invasion is a focal concern throughout the book. Obadiah is an expression of rage against Edom for "the slaughter and violence done to your brother Jacob" (Obadiah

10). Jonah, in contrast, elicits a more amenable response to life within the empire. Assyria's menacing military machine is never far from the purview of Isaiah, which bristles with divine violence and human cruelty. Jeremiah speaks of a dreaded northern foe descending on Judah. The beleaguered prophet, as depicted in the Deuteronomistic tradition, dares to consider the destruction of the grand Temple (Jer 7:1–8:3), the end of the covenant (11:1–17), the election tradition turned on its head (18:1–12), the enduring Davidic dynasty under assault (21:1–10), and the loss of land, forcing the people into normalizing life in diaspora (25:1–14). Ezekiel, “a theological manifesto for exiles,”⁵ is replete with the language of siege and captivity.

Written prophecy invites its readers to imagine the unthinkable, not unlike Thornton Wilder's *The Bridge of San Luis Rey*, which begins, “On Friday noon, July the 20th, 1714, the finest bridge in all Peru broke and precipitated five travelers into the gulf below. This bridge was on the highroad between Lima and Cuzco and hundreds of persons passed over it every day. . . . The bridge seemed to be among the things that last forever; it was unthinkable that it should break.” Prophets dare to imagine the loss of order and beauty in the world, even the end of culture, and the return to primeval chaos.

The earth is breaking, breaking;
The earth is crumbling, crumbling.
The earth is tottering, tottering;
The earth is swaying like a drunkard;
It is rocking to and fro like a hut.
Its iniquity shall weigh it down,
And it shall fall, to rise no more. (Isa 24:19–20; Tanakh translation)

I looked at the earth, and it was without shape or form;
at the heavens and there was no light.
I looked at the mountains and they were quaking;
all the hills were rocking back and forth.
I looked and there was no one left;
every bird in the sky had taken flight.
I looked and the fertile land was a desert;
all its towns were in ruins before the LORD, before his fury. (Jer 4:23–26, CEB)

The horrors of war no doubt serve as the subtext to these and other prophetic expressions of cosmic crumbling. The text bears witness to the end and dares to re-enact it. Written prophecy shifts the wreckage of war from ground zero, the historical datum, to the symbolic world of language, affording readers the opportunity to name their ordeal, mourn it, and survive it.

Equally remarkable, the literarization of prophecy seeks to generate hope in people whose worlds have collapsed and whose cherished forms of faith and culture have been broken seemingly beyond repair. In this capacity, written prophecy functions not only as disaster literature but as *ancient Israel's literature of survival*. It imagines a future for the historical losers in the world to come—that is, in the dangerous postwar world of diaspora.

WRITTEN PROPHECY AS LITERATURE OF SURVIVAL

How does literature so laden with loss operate as an artistic expression of hope? In the first place, it translates lived chaos into language and so creates a bearable distance between traumatic events and their symbolic representations. It refuses to indulge in denials about the nation's monstrous losses, generating space for the work of grief, a prerequisite to the work of hope. This trauma corpus puts virtually every facet of community life under a microscope and calls for action, transforming victims of violence into active meaning-makers. It creates alternatives to the old world, alternatives that contour a future for a people seemingly without one. Moreover, it makes a stunning claim that raw historical power is subservient to the power and purposes of God. This polyphonic corpus speaks with clarion voice that God's purposes are not thwarted by geopolitics or cosmic forces.

Even the surplus of judgment oracles can be read through the prism of hope. To speak of war, military occupation, and confinement as divine judgment is to place the worst of human conditions within a context of meaning. God's messengers garner an array of tropes to manage death and destruction and to construct symbolic order in times of social convulsion. Foremost, the prophets place the community's traumatic violence and disaster within a sin–punishment schema. Israel's fractured world, the prophets insist, is chiefly a consequence of its own idolatry and disobedience. Although this morally exacting world to an extent blames the victims and not the perpetrators of violence, in effect assaulting the people's sense of integrity, it also sets gratuitous suffering within a context of meaning. As such, it reflects a focal concern for community and individual survival.

Equally compelling, when written prophecy displaces the earliest settings of oral prophecy (*Sitze im Leben*) with its own literary settings (*Sitze im Buch*), it reconfigures the prophetic persona itself: prophets emerge in the text as harbingers of judgment as well as heralds of hope. This metamorphosis, or bifurcation, takes place in large part by punctuating the preponderance of judgment oracles with glimpses of a bright future, or to use the particularly apt words of Christian Wiman's language, a bright abyss.⁶

The book of Amos concludes with words of political and ecological restoration after the prophet's concentrate of harsh indictments against Israel (Amos 9:11–15). Obadiah indicts the Edomites for inhumane acts, yet ends with an oracle of hope, not for the perpetrators of violence but for their victims: in spite of the wickedness of foreign kings, the sovereign God will one day establish justice on earth (Obad 1:21). Joel speaks of the terrible Day of YHWH and yet concludes with a promise of renewal and restoration: "In that day the mountains shall drip sweet wine, the hill shall flow with milk, and all the stream beds of Judah shall flow with water; a fountain shall come forth from the house of the LORD and water the Wadi Shittim" (Joel 3:18) . . . "for YHWH will dwell in Zion" (3:21b).

Despite misgivings regarding God's plan for God's people, Habakkuk gives voice to hope against all odds: "though the fig tree does not blossom and no fruit is on the vine,

though the produce of the olives fails and the fields yield no food . . . yet I will still rejoice in YHWH; I will exult in the God of my salvation" (Hab 3:17–18). Even Zephaniah, a prophet who has virtually nothing but scathing words for Judah, envisions warrior YHWH renewing God's people "in his love" (Zeph 3:14–20). The often searing oracles of Micah are mitigated by words of forgiveness and love (Mic 7:18–20). Zechariah concludes with a vision of holiness and economic propriety (Zech 14:20–21). Malachi closes with a promise that the prophet Elijah will come, turning the hearts of the parents to their children and the hearts of children to their parents (Mal 4:5–6). The final chapter of Isaiah invites readers to "rejoice with Jerusalem, and be glad for her" (Isa 66:10), even though the book's final words are dreary. Jeremiah offers a hint of hope within the royal court of Babylon (52:31–34). The book of Ezekiel ends with the triumphant note that God is present even in the most unexpected places: "The LORD is There" (Ezek 48:35).

The putative effect of this rhetorical move is a judgment–salvation schema that characterizes written prophecy as a whole. Walter Brueggemann has observed that "the Latter Prophets have been more or less programmatically shaped and edited into a two-fold assertion of *God's judgment* that brings Israel to exile and death, and *God's promise* that brings Israel to a future that it cannot envision or sense for itself."⁷ Likewise, Marvin A. Sweeney suggests that "prophetic books tend to focus on the punishment and restoration of Israel/Judah, with the emphasis on the latter."⁸ This literary and theological propensity to bring written prophecy to a close with buoyant words of salvation subverts the corpus's internal construction of a causal and morally coherent world; that is to say, the finality of mercy ultimately deconstructs moral exactitude. Perhaps this *Tendenz* contributes to prophets being remembered in Jewish and Christian tradition as messengers of coming salvation. Sirach, for instance, could speak of the "Twelve Prophets" as comforting the people of Jacob and delivering them with confident hope (49:10; see also Tob 14:5; 2 Macc 15:9). The earliest Christian communities would speak of God's spokespersons as prognosticators and forerunners of messianic hope (e.g., Luke 4:16–21; Acts 2:14–21).

Embedded in this overarching judgment–salvation framework are voices that problematize both the bifurcation of written prophecy and a prophetic universe governed by sin, punishment, and salvation. In his confessions, for instance, Jeremiah, the quintessential sufferer, gives voice to grave doubts about God's management of the world (e.g., Jer 12:1–4; 20:7–18). Jeremiah represents all those who suffer the ravages of violence as a result of honorable deeds. Amos pleads with God that Israel "is too small" to endure the coming judgment. Isaiah of the Exile (Isaiah 40–55) speaks of suffering as redemptive rather than punitive, which is another way of placing radical suffering within a context of meaning (e.g., 52:13–53:12).

Whether constructing a symmetrical moral universe (with the aid of a sin–punishment schema) or entertaining doubts about its reliability, prophetic meaning-making addresses survivors at inchoate moments and envisions their fractured world as penultimate: it affirms that the world in which they live is not governed by arbitrary world-historical forces, but by a God whose wisdom and power are penultimate to none.

Even expressions of doubt about the moral workings of the universe do not approach anything approximating a denial of God.

The literarization of prophecy, in all, reconfigures setting and audience, as well as intentionality and meaning. Written prophecy converts prewar *oracles* into postwar *texts* and attends to the survivors, perhaps the victims of intergenerational trauma. It transforms prophets of doom into prophets of salvation.⁹ It marches to the beat of *Jetztzeit* (the ever-present now), rather than to the directives of chronological time and linear logic. It is governed by a *Sitz im Buch* rather than a *Sitz im Leben*. It displaces vanquished spokespersons for God with resilient and authoritative prophetic texts. It functions as trauma literature for communities that have suffered the assault of three world powers: Assyria, Babylon, and Persia. Although interpreters often assume a direct correspondence between literary and social reality and so construe the words of the prophets as windows into Israel's struggle with idolatry and immorality, reading through the prism of trauma suggests a far more primal concern for survival—the survival of the community, the survival of faith, the survival of God. Even accusations of sin and judgment oracles, with their surplus of guilt, can be seen through this interpretive lens.

WRITTEN PROPHECY AS PERFORMANCE

As trauma literature, written/biblical prophecy is not merely a compendium of poetic and prose utterances, or even a master narrative of divine judgment and promise. Such renderings reduce the prophetic meaning-making to what prophets say (i.e., to cognitive and verbal discourse). God's messengers, however, are more than mouthpieces (Abraham Heschel), and they do more than make the invisible God *audible*. Prophets also function as performers engaged in a kind of "street theater."¹⁰ In this capacity, they enact the acts of God by the force of artistic expression, especially their body art; they sculpt new configurations of justice and hope by the force of their imagination.

Readers today enjoy no more immediate access to prophetic street/temple theater than they do to the oral messages of the prophets. We have only *literary accounts* of sign-acts, with all the benefits and limitations inherent in the shift from speech/action/vision to writing. Not unlike oral prophecy, prophetic symbolic actions now belong to a literary world that attends to survivors of war and forced migration. As literary discourse, for instance, they are organized by *Jetztzeit* rather than by ordinary spatial and temporal categories. They are also governed by a *Sitz im Buch* rather than a *Sitz im Leben* and thus are no more extraneous to their literary context than, for instance, the Deutero-Jeremianic prose is to its poetic milieu. In their extant form—their *only* form—narratives of "non-verbal" prophecy ironically inform "verbal" (oracular) prophecy and play an integral role in the construction of *literary* meaning.

Hosea, for example, opens with prose reports of sign-acts (Petersen 2002: 176–181) that set the stage for the entire book. Specifically, the names given to Hosea and Gomer's children symbolize the end of Israel, the book's major motif (Hos 1:2–9). The names of

these children are then transformed (inverted) to symbolize the survival of Israel (2:1–3), another dominant motif in Hosea. Amos sees a “plumb-line” which in effect represents the exacting justice of God and the resulting end of Israel, two of the book’s major themes.¹¹ In the book of Isaiah, we encounter the prophet walking naked for three years at God’s command “as a sign (אֵימָה) and an omen (מוֹפֵת) against Egypt and Nubia” (Isa 20:1–6; cf. Mic 1:8). This daring act of resistance brings to light the futility of Judah’s reliance upon Egypt’s military machine. In another sign-act, Isaiah’s son Shear-jashub (“a few will survive”) imagines the destruction and eventual survival of the nation (Isa 7:2–9), another dominant literary motif in the book. At the command of YHWH, Isaiah writes on a tablet the words “Maher-shalal-hash-baz” (“Quick to the Plunder–Swift to the Spoil”) and gives this ominous name to another child he fathers, exposing the reader to the horror of military siege and invasion (Isa 8:1–4). These sign-acts not only reinforce Isaianic motifs; they also perform them through the lens of nonverbal art. The tradition employs drama in consort with speech as a means of broaching the unspeakable horror of war. This confluence of aesthetic forms—verbal and nonverbal, theater and verse—makes survival all the more possible.

In an act of prophetic theater, God commands Jeremiah to bury his “loincloth” under a rock near the Euphrates and dig it up later when it is spoiled, apparently to symbolize the ruin/devastation of the nation (Jer 13:1–11). Elsewhere in the book, Jeremiah shatters a clay jar to break any denial of Judah’s wholesale destruction (19:1–15). In another act of prophetic theater, God commands Jeremiah to refrain from the most basic forms of community life: weddings and funerals. Counter to ancient Near Eastern norms, Jeremiah is prohibited from marrying and having children, apparently to symbolize the collapse of the order of creation, or put locally, the end of Judean culture (16:1–13). And in still another, Jeremiah renames the priest Pashhur (“panic lurks all around”) to make palpable the disaster to befall the Jerusalemite establishment. These sign-acts “represent” disturbing facets of the end of the life that Judeans had long known (1:10).

In the second half of the book, chapters 26–52, Jeremiah’s symbolic acts pivot around dismantling and rebuilding, life and death, which are the text’s center of interest. In one instance, Jeremiah puts an ox-yoke on his neck to enact long-term regional subjugation to Babylonian hegemony (27:1–22). In another, when the land is already under enemy occupation, he reclaims family property in Anathoth to create hope in God’s resolve to restore displaced Judeans to their homeland (32:6–44). In Egypt, Jeremiah buries stones in front of Pharaoh’s palace in Tahpanhes to symbolize the approaching reign of Nebuchadrezzar (43:8–13). Near the end of the book, following a diatribe against Babylonian hegemony, Jeremiah records on a scroll all the disasters that would befall Babylon. The prophet entrusts the chief quartermaster Seraiah, Baruch’s brother, with the task of reading the words of the scroll and afterward throwing it into the Euphrates to mark Babylon’s demise. This subversive political act is a form of liturgical theater that reimagines power structures inside the borders of the empire.

The book of Ezekiel is replete with prophetic acts (and vision reports) that signify facets of identity erasure, military occupation, forced relocation, and prolonged captivity. It is not surprising that Ezekiel’s sign-acts often reflect symptoms of post-traumatic

stress disorder and victimization (Stulman and Kim 2010: 148–153). After his inaugural visions and commission report, Ezekiel is instructed to perform several symbolic acts that re-enact the terrifying realities of war for the historical losers (3:22–7:27). Ezekiel is bound and silenced to convey his solidarity with the refugee community with which he lives. The prophet lies on his left side for 390 days and on his right side for 40 days to embody Israel's guilt and suffering (Ezek 4:4–8). At God's instruction, he shaves his head and beard with a sword, representing national captivity (Ezek 5:1; cf. Isa 7:20). When Ezekiel's wife dies, he is instructed not to mourn or weep, or perform the conventional mourning rites. In Ezekiel 12:1–16, God tells Ezekiel to prepare a backpack for going into exile and to carry it through a hole in the city wall with his face covered. The sign-act, performed in darkness, provokes queries that the prophet answers: the act anticipates the capture of the Jerusalemite king (Zedekiah) and those in league with him. It also draws attention to God's power and honor, in contrast to the ubiquitous brutality of the empire.

Ezekiel the refugee not only performs these sign-acts, he *becomes* a "sign" of the unspeakable horrors of war and its aftermath (אִוֶּר or מוֹתָה; e.g., 12:11; 24:24; cf. Isa 8:18). Only once does one of Ezekiel's sign-acts convey hope (24:15–27). The prophet writes on sticks and joins them to each other to make a single stick, imagining the restoration and unification of the diasporic Judeans and Israelites: one nation, one shepherd, one people, one sanctuary, one God (37:15–23). All other symbolic actions performed by Ezekiel are riddled with pain, suffering, and alterity. They convey a visceral sense of national loss and hybridity.¹² Ezekiel is betwixt and between social and symbolic worlds: land and exile, privilege and pariah, hope and despair, trauma and recovery. He is haunted by memories of Jerusalem's temple and disconcerting realities of a templeless life in Babylon.

While we cannot speak of an anatomy of sign-acts, we can describe distinguishing characteristics. For example, sign-acts often assume a tripartite form: a divine command to act, a prophetic response/action, and a verbal interpretation of the action, which conveys God's will (Fohrer 1968: 18–19). These diverse dramatic expressions, moreover, inform the logic and intentionality of written prophecy and appear within various biographical and autobiographical landscapes. At the same time, they represent a mode of operation that cannot readily be reduced to prophetic speech. Whereas prophetic utterances are principally cognitive and cerebral, rational and discursive, prophetic sign-acts appeal to the visual and visceral, the affective and tactile. They belong to the world of performance and physicality. They come to life in the body, not merely the mouth, of the prophet and serve as witness, liturgy, reparation, provocation, re-enactment, and protest, as well as disaster and survival theater.

These savage illocutionary acts are therefore not merely "*verbum visibile*, a visible word"¹³ or "enacted words,"¹⁴ or even actions that "drive home" or accentuate prophetic oracles.¹⁵ That is to say, they do more than embellish or clarify "the message"¹⁶ or "illustrate words with gestures."¹⁷ Sign-acts, in written form, represent a distinct form of artistic expression and meaning-making for communities that have endured the trauma of war and political captivity. For a contemporary example of the power of political theater, one might think of Nelson Mandela's donning of the Springboks' jersey, specifically the

number of the Springbok captain, François Pienaar, at the 1995 rugby World Cup at Ellis Park. That singular symbolic act united a country in ways that words, even Mandela's words, could never have done.

Prophetic sign-acts, often embodied in the prophetic persona, bring to light haunting memories of community pain that cannot be subsumed under the heading of speech. At times, prophets perform in silence (Petersen 2002: 147–149), seemingly in conflict with their *raison d'être* as God's spokespersons. Their nonverbal tropes shatter a myriad of social (and symbolic) conventions, even those that sustain the very order of creation. They are forbidden to mourn, marry, or bury their dead—all signs of the end of life, total and complete devastation. They shave their heads and beards and burn their hair. They mutilate their bodies, remain motionless for extended periods, bury artifacts, shatter objects, howl like jackals, and screech like ostriches. They subject themselves to dimensions of community pain and marginality that resist ordinary categories of speech, even poetic speech. Such silent actions re-enact the collapse of “first principles,” when cherished social and symbolic structures are dealt a deathblow and new arrangements are not yet realized. In the direst of circumstances, whether in lived-time or text-time, *words are inadequate*.¹⁸

Kathleen M. O'Connor suggests that silence takes seriously the haunting experiences of survivors. In moments of “unspeakable” suffering, she maintains, the presence of words, even God's words, “diminish . . . voices of pain, wash over them, and crowd them out.”¹⁹ Mystics have long recognized the limitations of language, especially propositional discourse, and so have created a “non-language”: “*sunder warumbe*,” “*via negativa*,” or apophatic theology, the paradox, and the language of silence.²⁰

The prophet's “non-language” not only honors the memory of survivors, it also haunts traumatized communities back to life. It breaks various forms of denial. It transforms tormenting sensory memories into expressions of divine pathos. It normalizes the bizarre by representing visceral dimensions of traumatic violence, including pervasive loss and the annulment of hope, as divine drama. And it fosters resilience by shocking victims of war into brooding reflection and potential action. “Won't you tell us what your actions mean for us?” (Ezek 24:19). “Tell us what these sticks mean . . .” (Ezek 37:18).

It is noteworthy that therapists rely on expressive/creative arts in the healing of trauma survivors when psychotherapeutic mechanisms are inadequate.²¹ In such cases, affective and aesthetic interventions (e.g., trauma-informed art therapy)²² serve as modicums of healing for those laden with deep emotional (and subconscious) wounds, including the unseen scars of war. Relatedly, communities under siege have long looked to nonverbal art forms as coping mechanisms. Consider, for example, the graffiti on the walls of prisons in El Salvador or the recycled glasswork and embroidery by Palestinian women. Or note the telling relics of US hegemony in Yong Suk Kang's untitled photography.²³ In her 2005 book *The Art of Gaman*,²⁴ Delphine Hirasuna highlights the efficacy of art as a form of survival, and resistance, in the face of terrible human suffering. This literary work, together with the exhibition at the Renwick Gallery in Washington, D.C., celebrates the arts and crafts of Japanese Americans in “relocation” camps in the

western United States during World War II. These artistic expressions of *gaman*, she argues, helped interns endure their abject humiliation with patience and dignity. Music, poetry, drama, and nonverbal artistic expressions, including simple arts and crafts, have long sustained victims of unspeakable suffering when language falters. And nonverbal sign-acts operate with comparable power and healing force in the prophetic corpus of the Hebrew Bible.²⁵

SUMMATION

Inspired speech and inspired sign-acts, or performance art, differ in fundamental respects. One is verbal, cognitive, auditory, and rational, albeit not propositional; the other is more visceral, dramatic, and kinesthetic. Lines of distinction should not be blurred between these forms of communication, nor should the latter be subsumed under the heading of the former. In fact, non-cognitive forms of meaning-making art, including prophetic sign-acts, may appreciate radical human suffering in ways not fully accessible to linear arrangements inherent in speech. Beauty and pain cannot be readily reduced to cognitive modes of operation.

At the same time, verbal prophecy and prophetic performance are undoubtedly related in their present form. Both are tropes employed to convey the divine will. Both are thick with meaning and are woven together in the prophetic re-presentation of the purposes of God. Both are expressions of textual art, not art for art's sake, but art for the sake of communal survival. Both engage in reimagining a world under assault. Both seek to inspire action and dispel indifference. And both conspire to create a meaning-making map of judgment and salvation in which prophets appear as harbingers of doom and heralds of hope. To a degree, prophetic words and acts have more in common than differences, especially since both testify to the horror of war, exile, and confinement, as well as the dissolution of core beliefs, cultural identity, and symbolic worlds. Their stringent testimony to the truth shatters various forms of denial. The raw language of divine and human violence, in tandem with penetrating images of cultural ruin, assists in the hard work of grief and community building. Moreover, a textual performance of death and destruction, which includes mourning women, silent and stoic prophets, menacing armies, defiant kings, insolent people, and a world returning to primeval chaos, refuses to shut down the senses and banish memory.

Such deathscapes give form to inchoate spaces of national life, particularly to memories of unprovoked violence, war, military occupation, deportation, and captivity—traumatic experiences in ancient and contemporary times.²⁶ In this capacity, prophetic speech and sign-acts function in concert as a survival map for conquered societies. Together, they not only bear witness to but re-enact the chaos of identity erasure and symbolic disjunction. They organize this maelstrom in ways that “make sense” of gratuitous suffering—a palpable concern of survivors. Prophetic acts and words often give

warning of imminent disaster and so dispel the fear of a moral universe spiraling out of control. They employ blame to bring a level of coherence to the randomness of unprovoked violence. They claim that geopolitical force is not ultimate power—indeed, that God's will is realized in and through the exigencies of history. Overall, prophetic utterances and sign-acts construct new trajectories of meaning and identity for post-war communities. This complex alchemy ultimately serves survivors in their struggle to cope with the massive debris of war and prolonged captivity in the land of their oppressors.

NOTES

1. Moses is an exception.
2. For a full delineation of distinctions between oral and written discourse, see Paul Ricoeur, *Interpretation Theory: Discourse and the Surplus of Meaning* (Fort Worth: Texas Christian University Press, 1976). See also Walther Zimmerli, "From Prophetic Word to Prophetic Book," in *"This Place Is Too Small for Us": The Israelite Prophets in Recent Scholarship*, ed. Robert P. Gordon (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 1995), 419–442.
3. The past two decades of scholarship have focused on the "structures and structuring elements which give coherence to the text, sectionally or as a whole" (p. 108 in Gordon, ed., *"The Place Is Too Small for Us"*).
4. See Gregory Orr, *Poetry as Survival* (Athens, GA: University of Georgia Press, 2002), 127–132.
5. Margaret S. Odell, *Ezekiel* (SHBC; Macon: Smyth & Helwys, 2005), 10.
6. Christian Wiman, *My Bright Abyss: Meditation of a Modern Believer* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2013). Prophetic expressions of hope are rarely divorced from the harsh geopolitical realities of hegemony.
7. Walter Brueggemann and Tod Linafelt, *An Introduction to the Old Testament: The Canon and Christian Imagination* (2nd ed.; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2012), 135; emphasis in original.
8. Marvin A. Sweeney, *Isaiah 1–39* (FOTL 16; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), 17.
9. Clements, *Old Testament Prophecy*, 191–202. Of course, (pre-exilic) prophets were capable of speaking words of hope, but they spoke predominantly of coming judgment.
10. Sharp 2009: 10. For a detailed analysis of prophetic acts as street theater, see B. Lang, "Street Theater, Raising the Dead, and the Zoroastrian Connection in Ezekiel's Prophecy," in *Ezekiel and His Book: Textual and Literary Criticism and Their Interrelation* (BETL 74; Leuven: Peeters, 1986), 297–316. Prophets also function as visionaries or seers who see that to which others are not privy. In the Hebrew Bible, their visions transmit a certain kind of communicative act through the medium of prose and sometimes poetry.
11. Amos sees locusts, fire, and a basket of summer fruit as well (Amos 7:1–9; 8:1–3; cf. Jer 1:11–19), which re-enact the death and destruction of the northern state. Technically, these "acts" are visions and not sign-acts. That is to say, they are not enacted by the prophet himself but are narratives of what the prophet "sees." Nonetheless, "seeing" and "acting" are often woven together in the prophetic re-presentation of the purposes of God.
12. The preceding allusions are clearly not the only sign-acts or symbolic acts in the Latter Prophets. For a full list, see Viberg 2007: 43–54.

13. Johannes Lindblom, *Prophecy in Ancient Israel* (Philadelphia: Muhlenburg Press, 1962), 172.
14. Stephen F. Winward, *A Guide to the Prophets* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1968), 24.
15. Lindblom, *Prophecy in Ancient Israel*, 165.
16. Douglas A. Knight and Amy-Jill Levine, *The Meaning of the Bible: What the Jewish Scriptures and Christian Old Testament Can Teach Us* (New York: HarperOne, 2011), 417.
17. Robert P. Carroll, *Jeremiah* (OTL; London: SCM Press, 1986), 295.
18. Street drama flourished in the United States in the 1960s, often to protest the war in Vietnam, when words had seemingly been exhausted, when the number of dead was growing exponentially, and when conventional societal channels of remonstrance had broken down.
19. Kathleen M. O'Connor, *Lamentations and the Tears of the World* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2002), 86.
20. Dorothee Soelle, *The Silent Cry: Mysticism and Resistance* (trans. from *Mystik und Widerstand* by Barbara Rumscheidt and Martin Rumscheidt; Minneapolis: Fortress, 2001), esp. 55–76.
21. Lois Carey, ed., *Expressive and Creative Arts Methods for Trauma Survivors* (London and Philadelphia: Jessica Kingsley Publishers, 2006).
22. "In general, this approach takes into consideration, but is not limited to, the following: 1) how the mind and body respond to traumatic events; 2) recognition that symptoms are adaptive coping strategies rather than pathologies; 3) cultural sensitivity and empowerment; and 4) helping to move individuals from being not only survivors, but 'thrivers' through skill building, support networks, and resilience enhancement" (Cathy A. Malchiodi, "Trauma-Informed Expressive Arts Therapy: Tapping the Arts' Powers as Trauma Intervention," published online in the *Psychology Today* blog on March 6, 2012 and accessible at <http://www.psychologytoday.com/blog/the-healing-arts/201203/trauma-informed-expressive-arts-therapy>; see also Malchiodi, *Expressive Therapies* (New York: Guilford Press, 2005).
23. See several photographs in *The American Effect: Global Perspectives on the United States, 1990–2003* (New York: Whitney Museum of American Art, 2003), 122–123.
24. Delphine Hirasuna, *The Art of Gaman: Arts and Crafts from the Japanese American Internment Camps 1942–1946* (Berkeley and Toronto: Ten Speed Press, 2005).
25. For a fuller treatment, see Louis Stulman, "Reading the Bible through the Lens of Trauma and Art," in *Trauma and Traumatization in Individual and Collective Dimensions: Insights from Biblical Studies and Beyond* (ed. Eve-Marie Becker, Jan Dochhorn, and Else K. Holt; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2014), 176–191.
26. See Mary E. Mills, *Alterity, Pain and Suffering in Isaiah, Jeremiah and Ezekiel* (LHBOTS 479; London and New York: T & T Clark International, 2007).

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CHAPTER 19

GOD AND VIOLENCE IN THE PROPHETS

L. JULIANA CLAASSENS

We are living in a violent world. Whether it be the violence on the Big Screen that increasingly simulates the violent video games our children play, or the violence of war that has entered our living rooms (as evident in the 2003 war in Iraq, which became the first war to be televised in real time, showing live pictures of the “shock and awe” battle for Baghdad albeit from a safe distance), it is clear that violence has permeated our world today. Indeed, the world as we know it has never been the same after the violent terrorist attacks of 9/11, which saw airplanes flying into the Twin Towers in New York and the Pentagon in Washington, D.C., so becoming a symbol of the globalized nature of terror and violence. Add to this the rape statistics worldwide that document in essence a war of another kind, the terrifying accounts of genocide in Rwanda and Sudan, and the shootings at schools, movie theaters, and shopping malls that in the past decades have shocked the world out of its comfort zone; we are bound to conclude that for far too many contemporary readers, violence has become a way of life.

VIOLENT TEXTS AND VIOLENT READERS

Mirroring the violence in society, the rhetoric in the biblical prophets is steeped in violence. Containing graphic descriptions of war as experienced by both Israel and her enemies, large portions of the prophetic books are surely not meant for sensitive readers. For instance, in Nahum 3:1–3, one reads the following re-enactment of war in which Israel is taking pleasure in envisioning the violent destruction of their Assyrian enemies.

Ah! City of bloodshed, utterly deceitful, full of booty—no end to the plunder!
The crack of whip and rumble of wheel, galloping horse and bounding chariot!
Horsemen charging, flashing sword and glittering spear, piles of dead, heaps of
corpses, dead bodies without end—they stumble over the bodies!

These violent texts are even more disturbing when one realizes that God is depicted with blood on his hands. For instance, in Isaiah 63:1–6, even the most desensitized reader might be shocked when encountering the vivid image of God treading the winepress only to realize that the grapes that are staining God's robe red are the heads of Israel's enemies. And texts like Ezekiel 16 and 23, which portray God as an abusive spouse or, even more troubling, as a rapist when the violation of war is imaged in terms of sexual violence (cf. e.g., Jer 13:21–22 and Nah 3:4–5), beg for explanation, particularly in light of the fact that the gender stereotypes underlying these violent portrayals continue to shape a world in which women are considered less than fully human.

So what does one do with these violent texts that, as several scholars have shown, do not stay on the pages of the Bible? Even though Eric Seibert (2012: 10) is right that “violent texts do not kill people any more than violent movies do,” words create worlds, so that textual violence may play a part after all in forging violent readers. In this regard, Seibert outlines the violent legacy of biblical texts that in the past has caused much harm. Entire groups of peoples have been annihilated in the name of God by military campaigns whose justifications were specifically grounded in biblical texts. For instance, in an example that directly pertains to the topic of violence in prophetic rhetoric, Pope Gregory VII, who played a prominent role in the garnering of support for the First Crusade, which was responsible for the violent slaughter of thousands of Muslims in the name of God, is said to have been particularly fond of Jeremiah 48:10, which says, “Accursed is the one who keeps back the sword from bloodshed” (Seibert 2012: 17). And the “Battle Hymn of the Republic,”¹ whose first stanza contains a reference to the image of “God treading the vintage where the grapes of wrath are stored” (inspired by the image of God as divine warrior in Isaiah 63), has become a song of war, used in virtually every war in which the United States has been involved.²

Given this violent legacy of the prophetic books, it is important to formulate a hermeneutical framework for making sense of these violent texts. In the next section, I will approach the problem of violence in the prophetic rhetoric by introducing six recent proposals that have been greatly helpful in my own thinking in constructing a hermeneutical framework for interpreting the violence that is so central in the prophetic rhetoric. And in the final section, some suggestions will be made as to how to overcome the legacy of violence in the prophetic rhetoric.

UNDERSTANDING VIOLENCE IN PROPHETIC RHETORIC

Prophetic Violence in Canonical Context

A first proposal that is important for understanding the way that violence functions in the prophetic rhetoric is that the violence in the prophetic books is to be understood in terms of the broader context of the biblical traditions as a whole. So there is continuity

between the portrayal of violence in the prophetic books and the way that violence is represented in the Deuteronomistic traditions. For instance, in Deuteronomy 7:1–2, one finds a reference to the divine command that Israel is to annihilate (“smite” and “utterly destroy” in the Hebrew), in what has come to be known as the *herem*, all the inhabitants of the Promised Land (the Hittites, Girgashites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites; cf. also Deut 20:16–18). The Deuteronomistic justification of genocide is associated with the threat posed by the Canaanites, whose religious practices were thought by the Deuteronomist to lead the Israelites astray. Also in the priestly tradition (as reflected in, e.g., Leviticus 18), the justification for divinely ordained violence is depicted in terms of holiness concerns when the lewd sexual practices of the Canaanites are thought to have polluted the land—the proposed violence construed as an act of purging the evil from the land (cf. also Lev 18:25, according to which the land would vomit them out).

It may well be that there exists a close link between the *herem* as portrayed in the Deuteronomistic traditions and the experience of violence that underlies the prophetic books. Ziony Zevit notes that the idea of Israel’s *herem* may have been inspired by the violent attacks experienced by the Assyrians during the eighth century. In several texts in the prophetic corpus, we see evidence of the violent devastation that Israel experienced at the hands of the Assyrians. For instance, in Isaiah 10:28–32 and Micah 1:10–16, the reader witnesses a systematic march of the Assyrian army that destroys one city after the other. However, in the prophetic traditions, it seems that the actual practice of the *herem* is transformed into metaphor when, after 586 B.C.E., the prophets conjured up violent fantasies of revenge with their greatest enemies meeting a violent end. This metaphorization of the *herem* is also at work in Israel’s historiographic tradition, in which the complete annihilation of the Canaanites as portrayed in, for example, the stories of the destruction of Jericho and Ai (Joshua 6, 9) are construed by scholars of Israelite history as evidence of Israel re-creating in the seventh/sixth centuries B.C.E. a past in which their ancestors, as Zevit suggests, “had engaged in genocide, but did not pursue any mimetic activities to re-enact that past against current enemies.”³

We furthermore see how, in these traditions, there exists continuity in the way in which God is associated with violence. In both the Deuteronomistic traditions as well as in the Prophets, God is considered to be responsible for the violence in the form of enemy attacks and war. This is evident in light of, for example, the book of Isaiah, in which the Assyrians and Babylonians are considered to be God’s instruments sent to humble God’s people. For instance, in Isaiah 10:5–6, we read:

Ah, Assyria, the rod of my anger—
the club in their hands is my fury!
Against a godless nation I send him,
and against the people of my wrath I command him,
to take spoil and seize plunder,
and to tread them down like the mire of the streets.

This link between God and violence, as found in both the Prophets and the Deuteronomistic traditions, relates to the widespread belief that disaster was related to divine judgment: that Israel's disobedience was responsible for the violence that had befallen them in the form of the Assyrian onslaught. So we see within the Divine Warrior motif how in a reinterpretation of the "Day of the LORD" tradition, God is said to fight against the sinful Israelites. However, in the oracles against the nations that are found in more than one of the prophetic books (Jeremiah 46–51; Amos 1–2), the theme of violence against the nations that had a prominent role in the Deuteronomistic traditions is picked up again and intensified when, on an eschatological level, Israel directs its hopes to a future in which God will save God's people from their enemies. In this regard, John Collins proposes that the intention of the graphic violence in prophetic literature that exhibits apocalyptic features was actually to prevent further violence. With regard to Isaiah 63, Collins notes that the expectation of divine judgment on an eschatological level precluded human action. For instance, in Isaiah 63:5 it is said that God's violent destruction of the enemy forces occurs without any human involvement:

I looked, but there was no helper;
I stared, but there was no one to sustain me;
So my own arm brought me victory and my wrath sustained me.

According to Collins, this attitude of leaving vengeance to God when the Day of Vengeance is at hand is encapsulated well with the following quote: "Why walk around with a shot gun if the atomic blast is imminent?"⁴

Traumatic Memories

A particularly productive means for understanding violence in the prophetic rhetoric comes from recent developments in using trauma theory as a hermeneutical lens for understanding the biblical literature that emerged out of the aftermath of the violent attacks of, for example, the Babylonian Empire. For instance, scholars such as Kathleen O'Connor have helped us see the ways in which a book like Jeremiah constitutes trauma literature, on the one hand reflecting the wounds the community suffered due to the devastating effects of a world come undone, while on the other hand also constituting the attempts of the community to deal with the effects of the trauma.⁵

Employing insights from trauma theory, O'Connor explains how disasters destroy everything that gives meaning to life, and how they overwhelm the senses, leading to numbness, loss of language, and amnesia. The violence that is found in, for instance, the book of Jeremiah could thus be understood as traumatic memories—a vitally important step for the survivors to find language again, to express the horrors of war. For O'Connor, the elaborate metaphors employed by the war poems in Jeremiah seek to

draw the fragmented memories of the Judean survivors into a singular narrative, so restoring the survivors' ability to put into words the unspeakable. As she formulates it, "Jeremiah's violent poetry creates a vocabulary of experience, builds a common language among survivors to name what happened, gives shape to disaster, and helps Judeans face it in small portions" (2010: 49).

This approach also helps one to understand the rape language used in Jeremiah 13. According to O'Connor, the language of rape serves as a means to capture the extreme trauma Judah had experienced, the horrors of war imaged in the form of the sexual assault of an abandoned woman. O'Connor points out that "the fact that rape is appalling, unbearable, unspeakable and unacceptable is surely the point. . . . Rape is what happened to them."⁶ To be able to put these traumatic events into words is the first step on the way toward healing.

Trauma theory also serves as a means of explaining God's association with violence. Marvin Sweeney describes how various parts of the Hebrew Bible attempt to make sense of God's involvement with suffering, as most clearly evident in the Babylonian invasion that saw the destruction of Jerusalem. Sweeney argues that "Isaiah is indeed a work of theodicy that attempts to defend YHWH from charges of impotence and immorality" (2008: 103). Also Kathleen O'Connor construes the violent imagery in Jeremiah as a means of holding fast to God in the midst of the terror all around. She notes, "I see in God's violence a potent stammering toward meaning, a poetic offering that begins the work of interpretation, of making sense of the senseless" (2010: 47).

And yet, to comprehend this prophetic understanding of God and violence does not mean that the last word on sin and suffering has been uttered. An uncritical application of the prophetic viewpoint that God is responsible for violence and the ensuing suffering may actually cause more harm than good in a contemporary society in which believers, in an analogous attempt to make sense of suffering, may view, for example, the terror attacks of 9/11 as God's punishment (cf. especially the unfortunate remarks of Jerry Falwell, who blamed the gays and lesbians of New York for incurring God's wrath). Rather, divine violence in the prophetic rhetoric is a theological problem that challenges contemporary believers to continued contemplation in light of our best theological and hermeneutical skills.

Violence and Identity Formation

A third approach that is helpful in explaining violence in prophetic literature is that the violence in the prophetic rhetoric is less a matter of actual violence, but rather a rhetorical strategy for drawing boundaries between "us" and "them" as an integral process of identity formation. This process of identity formation may occur on different levels. In the first instance, using imagined violence to draw boundaries is a particularly productive means for explaining the violence found in the oracles against the nations, which, as mentioned earlier, is a continuation of a similar rhetorical strategy found in the Deuteronomistic traditions.

For instance, in Zephaniah 2, the cities of the Philistines, Moab, Ammon, the Ethiopians, and the Assyrians are said to be violently destroyed by God. For instance, in Zephaniah 2:8–10, we hear God speak:

I have heard the taunts of Moab
and the revilings of the Ammonites,
how they have taunted my people
and made boasts against their territory.
Therefore, as I live, says the LORD of hosts,
the God of Israel,
Moab shall become like Sodom
and the Ammonites like Gomorrah,
a land possessed by nettles and salt pits,
and a waste forever.
The remnant of my people shall plunder them,
and the survivors of my nation shall possess them.
This shall be their lot in return for their pride,
because they scoffed and boasted
against the people of the LORD of hosts.

In this regard, the work of Sara Ahmed regarding emotions is helpful. Ahmed shows how hatred and disgust work together in order to create boundaries between individuals and others, and between communities, where “others” constituted a threat to the individual or the group’s existence. This feeling of hate is moreover coupled with disgust, when what she calls “sticky signs” come to be attached to the bodies of others. In her context of London, Ahmed explains how the word “Paki” has become an insult by means of its association with other words of disdain, such as “immigrant,” “outsider,” and “filthy”—a slur becoming so dominant that new meanings are blocked. Ahmed points out that by means of the repeated performance of disgust and hatred, sharp boundaries between “us” and “them” are drawn that in their most severe manifestation may lead to violence.⁷

With regard to the Ammonites and Moabites who in Zephaniah 2 are said to meet a violent end, Ahmed’s notion of “sticky signs” is a helpful means for explaining the stark boundaries between these nations and Israel that underlie the expression of violence in the prophetic rhetoric. In Genesis 18–19, we see, for instance, how the story of the origins of these two groups of people go back to the lewd story told regarding Lot’s two daughters who, after having escaped from the doomed Sodom and Gomorra that are considered to be the epitome of wickedness, slept with their father after getting him drunk. The two sons who were born out of this sexual encounter were named Ammon and Moab. This slanderous narrative tracing the origins of Israel’s most revered enemies is a good example of how disgust and hatred work together to create boundaries; as in the case of Zephaniah cited earlier, these boundaries culminate in an expression of violence in which the real or imagined destruction of these two groups of people are justified.

The literary portrayal of violence in the prophetic rhetoric is also used to draw internal boundaries of class. Daniel Smith-Christopher likens the violent rhetoric employed by the prophet Micah to the anger expressed by the “black power” activist Stokely Carmichael. Smith-Christopher notes that Carmichael’s use of violent rhetoric in the early 1960s in the United States had the function of rousing up in African Americans a yearning for “self-determination, self-sufficiency, [and] self-protection.” The function of this act of “self-assertion and release of angry aggressive feelings” offered blacks “a sense of psychological emancipation from racism” (2010: 75–76). According to Smith-Christopher, Carmichael’s use of violent rhetoric offers a helpful hermeneutical framework for understanding the violent rhetoric in the following two parallel texts from Micah:

Therefore I will make Samaria a heap in the open country,
a place for planting vineyards.
I will pour down her stones into the valley,
and uncover her foundations (Mic 1:6).

Therefore because of you
Zion shall be plowed as a field;
Jerusalem shall become a heap of ruins,
and the mountain of the house a wooded height. (Mic 3:12)

Smith-Christopher reads these two texts against the backdrop of the internal societal struggles in eighth- to seventh-century Israel and Judah as a means of forging an identity for the exploited peasant farmers against the rich city owners who have systemically violated the rights of the poor and needy. Instead of ascribing the destruction to the invasion of the Assyrians, as many scholars typically have done, Smith-Christopher proposes that this violent rhetoric reflected in Micah constitutes “threats of a God-inspired uprising against elite monopolies of land and power,” which, like the rhetoric employed by Stokely Carmichael, “are words intended to empower a disempowered Israelite/Judean social class.”⁸

Rhetoric of Resistance

Fourth, the violence in the prophetic texts also can be understood in the context of resisting the hold of the various empires that overshadowed Israel’s history. The actual violence Judah had experienced at the hands of one empire after another gave way to imagined violence that found expression in fantasies of revenge. In books such as Nahum and Jeremiah, one finds graphic visions of the once mighty Babylon or Assyria in a vulnerable, violated position, often employing sexual violation in order to describe the downfall of the once mighty city. For instance, with reference to Nahum 3 cited earlier, Julia O’Brien, drawing upon insights from contemporary film theory, describes Nahum’s dream of revenge in terms of a rhetoric of resistance:

The readers are the ones who truly see Nineveh's shame. Ancient readers were allowed to gaze on assaulted Nineveh; they saw the feminization of Assyrian troops. Like a darkened theatre, the reading event allowed readers to experience something to which they would not have had access in the light of day. No longer the oppressed with their eyes downcast or diverted, the readers looked directly at Nineveh; they become not the downtrodden but equals with nations and kingdoms who got to see the spectacle of Assyria's defeat. (2010: 118)

Within this understanding, the violent imagery in the prophetic rhetoric may thus actually fulfill a positive function. For Israel to stand clapping their hands over the dead bodies of their enemies, as portrayed in Nahum 3:19, could in psychological terms be considered a healthy expression of coming to terms with trauma.⁹ Moreover, citing the interpretation of South African interpreter Willie Wessels, who has read the book of Nahum as "resistance literature" in line with the protest songs that were employed in the struggle against apartheid in South Africa, O'Brien proposes that these prophetic visions of the enemy's downfall may serve the function of reminding people that the power of the mighty empire (then and now) is limited.

O'Brien further argues that the visions of Assyria's downfall do not necessarily pertain to Assyria *per se*. Citing the difficulties of dating prophetic books, O'Brien points out that "the violent images and anti-Assyrian language" in Nahum actually could be understood as cultural stock images that have become part of Israel's vocabulary.¹⁰ In this way, the rhetoric of resistance in a book like Nahum may speak a word of comfort to a later audience who were traumatized by the Babylonian and/or the Persian Empire. Rooted in the firm conviction that God is in control, these visions hold up an image of a mighty Warrior-God before whom enemy empires are crushed.

A fascinating example of the use of violent prophetic rhetoric in order to resist injustice is evident in the reception history of the "Battle Hymn of the Republic." For instance, this hymn was often used by Martin Luther King, Jr., in the struggle for civil rights for African Americans in the United States. Drawing on the original intention of the hymn (i.e., the fight to free the African American slaves), the civil rights activists were engaged in a new battle (i.e., a battle for freedom and equality). It is significant, though, that Martin Luther King, who throughout his life was committed to nonviolence, himself reflected on the violent imagery of the "Battle Hymn" that so often marked his speeches in the battle for civil rights. He is recorded as having said, "We did not hesitate to call our movement an army. . . . But it was a special army . . . that would sing but not slay."¹¹

Feminist Challenges

Fifth, feminist scholars have been particularly skilled in helping us make sense of the graphic images of sexual violation used in the prophetic books. For instance, the metaphor of God as a scorned husband who acts violently due to his wife's unfaithfulness is first found in the book of Hosea, is elaborated upon in Jeremiah 1–2, and reaches a nadir

in Ezekiel 16 and 23. This metaphor, according to which the husband-deity is justified in using violence in order to punish his wayward wife (i.e., the city of Jerusalem, whose act of worshiping other gods is imaged in terms of prostitution [cf. the Hebrew term *zōnāh*]), reflects deep-seated gender stereotypes, for example, that women are sexually lascivious and that husbands are justified in using violence as a means of controlling their wives.¹²

Quite often, one would hear the defense “It is just a metaphor!” in an attempt to make sense of this violent portrayal of the deity. However, feminist scholars have shown that not only are these metaphors shaped by society, but they also have a shaping function. This is nowhere more evident than in Ezekiel 23:46–48, in which the metaphor is said to serve as a warning for all women:

For thus says the Lord GOD: Bring up an assembly against them, and make them an object of terror and of plunder. The assembly shall stone them and with their swords they shall cut them down; they shall kill their sons and their daughters, and burn up their houses. Thus will I put an end to lewdness in the land, so that all women may take warning and not commit lewdness as you have done.

Similar to the approaches cited earlier, feminist interpreters employ various strategies in order to explain the gender-based violence found in the prophetic rhetoric. For instance, with reference to the violent portrayal of a male, abusive God in Ezekiel 16, Gale Yee employs postcolonial criticism, arguing that the representation of gender violence emerges out of the prophet Ezekiel’s attempt to make sense of the personal and collective trauma caused by the colonization, conquest, and exile of Israel by the hand of the Babylonian invaders in the early sixth century. The violent acts of the enemy forces invading the land and destroying the property and the people in it are couched in terms of sexualized violence and rape, which are reminiscent of the real acts of violence that accompany war. However, Israel is also portrayed in gendered terms to reflect the humiliation as well as the metaphorical (and perhaps even literal) emasculation/castration of the priestly class by the victorious colonizer. The prophet portrays Israel as a female because after the humiliating attacks by the Babylonian invaders, the people of Israel feel quite similar to a violated woman. Moreover, the prophet’s act of scapegoating that places blame, metaphorically speaking, on the bodies of women also explains the use of gender violence to narrate the nation’s trauma. Yee argues (2003: 132–134) that in order to explain the humiliation of his people, Ezekiel transposes “the political dealings of the Judean male elite with foreign nations onto the fractured, beaten, and sexually ravaged body of a woman,” thus explaining the trauma of the Babylonian invasion in terms of the punishment an adulterous woman would have received.

A Culture of Violence

Finally, Tamar Kamionkowski proposes that one should understand the violence reflected in biblical prophets in broader terms than direct violence that is associated

with times of war. Drawing on the work of John Galtung, she proposes that it is also important to identify structural violence, such as racism, classism, sexism, and oppression in the prophetic books, in addition to cultural violence, which can be described as those aspects of culture such as religion, ideology, language, art, and science that are responsible for justifying instances of direct or structural violence as important. As Galtung explains, “Cultural violence makes direct and structural violence look, even feel, right—or at least not wrong.”¹³ For instance, even in a prophetic text such as Isaiah 2:2–4 that typically has been held up as a text of peace, cultural violence is embedded in the prophet’s rhetoric. So one should keep in mind that the prophets were no peace activists. As Kamionkowski rightly points out, the prophets were convinced that “order and stability would come about through acts of divinely orchestrated violence.” Thus the idyllic situation of peace is brought about by force, leading Kamionkowski to argue that “the problem with divine violence in prophetic literature is a problem of deeply embedded cultural violence. Power, submission, war and acts of direct violence were deeply imbued into the societies the produced the Hebrew Bible” (2007: 46).

Moreover, the reference that all the nations will stream to Israel and its God in order to learn his ways and to walk in his paths (v 3) is, according to Kamionkowski, an example of cultural violence according to which “the total submission to the divine will and by extension to a particular leadership group” assumes certain hegemonizing tendencies where there is little room for others to express their own subjectivity and where others are coerced to follow the one God of Israel (2007: 45).

With this broader definition of violence in mind, the biblical interpreter needs to be sensitive to the way in which institutions such as slavery and patriarchy were seen in Israel as the “natural” order of things, according to which subtle and more overt forms of violence were tolerated as “just the way things are.” With regard to the prophetic rhetoric, moreover, it is important to keep in mind that the prophets were children of their time, and that the cultural violence that was responsible for structural and direct violence was so entrenched in their world that they were unable to step outside it—a reality that challenges us to be mindful of those instances of cultural violence in our own societies that have caused us to think that various forms of structural and direct violence could be considered to be “normal.”

RESISTING VIOLENCE

The six proposals outlined in the preceding sections have in common that they seek to understand the violence that forms an integral part of the prophetic rhetoric. But to understand is but a first step. For those interpreters who are committed to the ethical task of biblical interpretation, it is also important to come up with strategies that resist the violence that is held up in the biblical traditions. In light of the fact that violence begets violence, I propose that it is vitally important that we as readers seek to find a way beyond violence.

One way to deal with the violent rhetorical strategies of the prophets would be similar to what some feminists have proposed: that these texts cannot be saved and should (literally or figuratively) be torn from the pages of the canon. However, other scholars have proposed that such “texts of terror” should be kept in the canon in order to help readers see the continuing reality of gender-based violence, which is not only found in the biblical traditions but also threatens the well-being of our respective communities today.¹⁴ Also, Robert Haak proposes that violent metaphors as used by the prophets may have a conscientizing function. He writes:

[A]s long as we continue to live in a society which sees war as one option for settling disputes, we must use the words of war clearly to make real the destruction of war to those sitting safely at home, far from the violence they only see on the nightly news. It may be ironic that the best way to decrease the amount of actual violence in our world is to increase the vitality of the metaphors which are used to the point that the actual violence becomes “real” to the society. Only when the reality of violence is understood and felt in a society can responsible use of violence be claimed. It may be that in a given case, when confronted with the reality of violence, a society may decide against its actual use. (2010: 30)

Or it may not. In her revealing article, “The Beauty of the Bloody God: The Divine Warrior in Prophetic Literature,” Corrine Carvalho admits that she, together with many other Americans, loves going to violent movies. Citing the example of Neo from *The Matrix*, who can be likened to the American cowboys of old as well as recent futuristic “sci-fi” warriors, she argues that “American audiences, at least, like our messiahs to have rippling muscles, sweat-dripped arms, and a well-stocked arsenal.”¹⁵ Carvalho builds her argument on the assumption that “humans crave creative violence and often utilize it.” According to her, “violent images can be used to resist, recover, entertain, inflame or inspire.”¹⁶

As we have seen in the various proposals for understanding the violence that forms an integral part of the prophetic rhetoric, the violent imagery indeed may have fulfilled a valuable function for the original audience, and conceivably, as in the example of Martin Luther King, could also function positively as a means to resist injustice. Nevertheless, precisely because we are living in a world where the culture of violence has become a normal state of being, it is crucially important to resist the violence portrayed in the biblical text. The most important reason that scholars feel the need to “overcome” or “transcend” the problem of violence in the prophetic rhetoric is the very real possibility that violent rhetoric, even though intended to be metaphorical, could be taken literally. As several scholars, including Jonathan Klawans, have pointed out, once these violent fantasies of the prophets became part of the canon, “they may find their way into the hands of groups who accept without question their own self-righteousness and their enemies’ evil nature.”¹⁷

This fear is corroborated by the many instances in which violent rhetoric has indeed crossed over into real life. For instance, in a fascinating book outlining the reception history of the “Battle Hymn of the Republic,” John Stauffer and Benjamin Soskis rightly point

out that this hymn, which had its origin in the struggle to free the African American slaves during the Civil War, in subsequent generations was used to inspire future generations of Americans to fight whatever was considered to be a noble cause at the time. So it is told, for instance, how Brigadier General Theodore Roosevelt, Jr. (eldest son of former president Teddy Roosevelt) started singing the “Battle Hymn” as he walked among the troops who were approaching the coast of Normandy on what would become D-Day, urging the soldiers to sing along, as they embarked on the war against Nazism and fascism.¹⁸

The application of the “Battle Hymn” in times of war is open for abuse, though. Stauffer and Soskis tell a chilling story that comes from America’s involvement in Vietnam. On March 29, 1971, Second Lieutenant William L. Calley was found guilty and sentenced to life in prison for masterminding the My Lai massacre, which saw Calley convicted for the premeditated murder of twenty-two unarmed Vietnamese non-combatants.¹⁹ All across the American South, radio stations played a parody of the “Battle Hymn” called the “Battle Hymn of Lt. Calley,” in which an aggrieved Calley proclaimed to the tune of the “Battle Hymn” that he and his men simply were doing their duty when they “took the jungle village exactly like they said. . . .” When Calley is said to enter the “final campground” and the “great commander” asks of him: “Did you fight or did you run?” Calley answers in the words of the final stanza: “Count me only as a soldier who never left his gun.”²⁰

So what is the solution? In his book *The Violence of Scripture: Overcoming the Old Testament’s Troubling Legacy*, Eric Seibert has suggested various strategies that may help the reader in resisting violence. Seibert proposes that one should name and analyze the violence that occurs in the biblical text, before proceeding to critique the violence. He proposes, for instance, that one may look for internal critiques of violence within violent texts, or use alternative (nonviolent) voices to deconstruct the dominant (violent) discourse. One strategy he proposes that is particularly helpful in challenging the impact of violent texts is to read with the victims in the text (i.e., the ones “named or unnamed, seen or unseen—who are abused, oppressed, or killed”). Seibert argues that by “reading with those who have been marginalized, silenced and erased by the text,” one may “read with different questions in mind,” contemplating how differently the story would sound if it were to be told by the victims (2012: 81). In order to illustrate this particular reading strategy, Seibert introduces a fascinating article in which Chris Heard engages in a deconstructive reading of Habakkuk by reading from the perspective of the children of Judah and Babylon affected by divine violence. Heard argues that a deconstructive reading of the violent rhetoric of the prophet Habakkuk may draw our attention to the plight of the children of both Judah and Babylon who have been affected by the violent attacks by the Babylonians in 587 B.C.E. and then the Persians in 539 B.C.E. Using Psalm 109 as intertext, in which God’s judgment against Judah by the hand of the Babylonians is captured in the curse “May his children be orphans. . . . May his children wander from their hovels, begging in search of bread” (vv 9a, 10), Heard writes in ironic fashion about the plight of the Judahite children:

What was that? Who mentioned children? Nobody said anything about children! The text didn’t say anything about the oppressors having children! But now that the

psalmist mentions it—now that this intertext exposes the heartfelt desires of the vengeful—I see them there. Right over there, just outside the margins of the text. Punished for the sins of their fathers. Branded. Outcast. Homeless. Naked. Starving. If, that is—and what a big “if” this is!—if the Chaldeans didn’t just kill them outright. Curse the Chaldeans! The idea was to punish the guilty. The idea was justice. But this is not justice. The suffering of Judahite children for their fathers’ sins is not justice. (1997: 86)

Heard furthermore continues to imagine the plight of the Babylonian children who emerge as the victims of Judah’s dreams of revenge. Drawing on the heartfelt wish in Psalm 137:9 that God will bring down the Babylonians (“A blessing on him who seizes your babies and dashes them against the rocks!”), Heard says the following regarding the Babylonian children:

What was that? Who mentioned babies? Nobody said anything about babies! The text didn’t say anything about the Chaldeans having babies! But now that you mention it, I see them there. Right over there, just outside the margins of the text. Punished for the sins of their fathers. Maimed. Broken. Bleeding. Brain damaged. If, that is—and what a big “if” this is!—if being smashed against the rocks didn’t just kill them outright. (1997: 86)

Heard argues that such a deconstructive reading of the violent rhetoric reflected in a prophet like Habakkuk may, in the first instance, help one to remember the real cost of war, to be mindful of the innocent victims of war. In the second instance, though, such a deconstructive reading may also help the reader to resist the violence that continues to destroy the lives of men, women, and children across the world.

Finally, my own work has been dedicated to resisting the violent rhetoric used by the prophets by highlighting some of the alternative metaphors for God that are also found in the prophetic books. For instance, in my book *Mourner, Mother, Midwife: Reimagining God’s Liberating Presence* (2012), I seek to develop alternative ways of speaking of God’s delivering presence in terms of the non-traditional female metaphors of God as Wailing Woman (Jeremiah 8–9), God as Mother (Isaiah 42, 45, 49, 66), and God as Divine Midwife (Psalm 22, 71) that are in contrast with the portrayal of the more common Liberator-Warrior metaphor that traditionally has been used for God.

These divine metaphors that, like some of the prophetic texts cited in this chapter, grew out of Israel’s experience of trauma during the Babylonian exile employ acts of tears and lament in the instance of the wailing women, the acts of giving birth and nurturing new life closely associated with mothers, and acts of wisdom, skill, and healing performed by professional midwives to talk about God’s liberative action. However, instead of the violence and abuse that permeated the divine portrayal of God in many of the prophetic texts, the metaphors of God as Wailing Woman, Mother, and Midwife, which view God’s deliverance in terms of God’s liberating presence, offer us language to speak about a God who is present in the midst of pain and who is consistently on the side of life.

NOTES

1. "The Battle Hymn of the Republic." Composer (attributed to): William Steffe (1852); composer: T. Brigham Bishop (1858). Author of Lyrics: Julia Ward Howe. Howe's lyrics to the old folk song "John Brown's Hymn" were first published in *The Atlantic Monthly*, volume 9/52 in February 1862.
2. John Stauffer and Benjamin Soskis, *The Battle Hymn of the Republic: A Biography of the Song That Marches On* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 12. Cf. also my article on the journey of this hymn, "'Trampling out the Vintage where the Grapes of Wrath are Stored': Assessing the Legacy of 'The Battle Hymn of the Republic,'" *NGTT* 55/3.4 (2014) <http://ngtt.journals.ac.za/pub/article/view/653>
3. Zevit 2007: 36–37. Cf. also pp. 26–27.
4. Collins 2003: 15–17. The quote cited here comes from a classic article by Krister Stendahl, "Hate, Non-Retaliatio, and Love: 1QS X, 17–20 and Rom 12:19–21," *HTR* 55 (1962): 344–345. Cf. also Geller 2007: 51.
5. Cf. the pioneering work done in this regard by Daniel L. Smith-Christopher, *A Biblical Theology of Exile* (OBT; Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2001), and see O'Connor 2011. Cf. also the newly constituted "Biblical Literature and the Hermeneutics of Trauma" section of the Society of Biblical Literature.
6. O'Connor 2010: 46. Cf. also O'Connor 2011: 55.
7. Sara Ahmed, *The Cultural Politics of Emotion* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2004), 51, 92. Cf. also the work of Hector Avalos that outlines the phenomenon of group privileging in the Hebrew Bible and the ensuing violence that results from group privileging, *Fighting Words: The Origins of Religious Violence* (New York: Prometheus Books, 2005), 137–144.
8. Smith-Christopher 2010: 80–87. A similar line of thinking is found in Carolyn J. Sharp's insightful argument regarding the way in which Hosea employs violent rhetoric reminiscent of the infamous "God Damn America" sermon given by the African American pastor Jeremiah Wright during the 2008 presidential election in the United States. Sharp proposes that Rev. Wright's rhetoric of subverting the official narrative of America's history, particularly in terms of its racist past, can be likened to the prophet Hosea's use of violent images that serve the purpose of dismembering people's identity in order to reconstitute a new self-understanding. See Sharp 2010: 68–69.
9. Hand-clapping in the ancient Israelite context was not considered a mere celebratory gesture, as it is today in the Western world. Nili S. Fox makes some helpful suggestions as to how the clapping of hands functioned in the ancient Near East as an expression of anger and anguish. In terms of Nahum 3, Fox shows how the clapping of hands occurs in a context of triumph or approval as a sign of "malicious glee." See Fox, "Clapping Hands as a Gesture of Anguish and Anger in Mesopotamia and in Israel," *JANES* 23 (1995): 49–60 (54–55).
10. O'Brien 2010: 125. Cf. also Julia O'Brien's chapter on "God as (Angry) Warrior," in *Challenging Prophetic Metaphor: Theology and Ideology in the Prophets* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2008), 101–124.
11. Cited in Stauffer and Soskis, *Battle Hymn of the Republic*, 259.
12. Cf., e.g., the classic essay by J. Cheryl Exum (1995). Cf. also the important essay by Linda Day (2000).
13. Galtung 1990: 291, cited in Kamionkowski 2007: 46.

14. Katheryn Pfisterer Darr, "Ezekiel." In *Women's Bible Commentary* (ed. Carol A Newsom and Sharon H. Ringe; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1998), 199. Cf. also Exum 1995: 264.
15. Cf. Carvalho 2010: 135.
16. Carvalho 2010: 151. Carvalho maintains that she wants a violent God who enters the fray, who punishes the wicked. As she says, "I want a God who cares enough to be angry, involved enough to do something and divine enough to accomplish what humans shouldn't even try."
17. Klawans 2007: 14. Cf. also Geller 2007: 51.
18. Stauffer and Soskis, *Battle Hymn of the Republic*, 274–275.
19. Even though Lt. Calley was convicted of the murder of only 22 My Lai victims, the actual number of civilians slain was much higher. William Thomas Allison notes in his book *My Lai: An American Atrocity in the Vietnam War* (Witness to History; Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2012) that hundreds of innocent civilians were brutally murdered, in addition to many women being raped and corpses mutilated (38).
20. "Battle Hymn of Lt. Calley" (From C Company featuring Terry Nelson with Julian Wilson, James M. Smith, Plantation Records, 1971). Cited in Stauffer and Soskis, *Battle Hymn of the Republic*, 300–302. Cf. also 279–280.

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E. Reception History

CHAPTER 20

THE PROPHETS IN THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS

ALEX P. JASSEN

THE Dead Sea Scrolls are witness to several important snapshots in the history of the reception of the prophets in Second Temple Judaism. The Dead Sea Scrolls come from a time when the canonization of the Hebrew Bible was only beginning to take shape. As such, the nature of what books constitute scripture was still an open question for many Jews in the Second Temple period. And even when specific books were universally regarded as scriptural, these books often display a remarkable degree of textual fluidity. Thus, the Dead Sea Scrolls offer a glimpse into the very world that shaped the authority of the prophetic books and gathered together these books into a broader collection of prophetic literature.

The Dead Sea Scrolls attest to the growing centrality of the interpretation of prophetic texts for Jews in the Second Temple period. The words of the prophets were regarded as a repository of the ancient revealed word of God. These books therefore became the object of both veneration and intense study as Jews in the Second Temple period searched in the ancient prophetic texts for guidance and direction in order to enliven the word of God in their own time. Indeed, the constellation of sectarian communities associated with the Dead Sea Scrolls saw their very identity as bound up with the utterances of the ancient prophets. In the Pesharim, for example, the sectarians interpreted the ancient prophetic books as hidden literary ciphers. When these texts are decoded through the sectarians' inspired exegesis, the ancient prophetic word reveals the origins, unfolding history, and eschatological future of the sectarian communities. As in other segments of Second Temple Judaism, the assumption of the contemporary significance of the prophetic books is widespread throughout other sectarian writings and informs nearly all exegetical engagement with the prophetic writings.

The Dead Sea Scrolls also point to the ongoing activity of crafting prophetic texts as a form of interpretation. Jews in the Second Temple period appropriated the voice of the ancient prophets to create new compositions that either rewrote the words of the ancient prophet or recast the prophetic identity in a new literary setting. In addition

to texts that would later be included in the Hebrew Bible, the Dead Sea Scrolls contain several compositions associated with Jeremiah, Ezekiel, David, and Daniel. These compositions were cast aside in the later Jewish and Christian canon of the prophets. In the pre-canonical stage of the Second Temple period, however, these additional compositions gave form to a much more expansive set of prophetic texts.

For the Dead Sea Scrolls sectarians, prophets and prophecy were not merely vestiges of ancient Israel preserved in book form. Rather, the sectarians regarded themselves as recipients of ongoing revelation and therefore saw themselves in continuity with the prophets of old. To be sure, the sectarians recognized the disjunctive nature of their relationship with the ancient prophets. The particulars of revelation had changed over time, and the sectarians deliberately refrained from referring to their leaders as prophets. Yet, similar to other segments of the Second Temple Judaism represented in wisdom and apocalyptic texts, the sectarians stake claim to the enduring legacy of ancient prophets and prophecy.

PROPHETS AND PROPHETIC BOOKS IN THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS

The Prophets as a Collection

The writings of ancient Israelite prophets formed a large portion of the scriptural literature of Judaism in the Second Temple period. The Dead Sea Scrolls preserve some of the earliest evidence for seeing the ancient prophets as representing a unified literary collection—the precursor to the later canonical category of the “Prophets” (see VanderKam 2012: 61–67). In most cases, this literary collection is presented as standing alongside Moses and the Torah (Pentateuch). Thus, for example, the *Rule of the Community* (1QS) exhorts its audience “to do what is good and upright before him, just as he commanded through Moses and all his servants the prophets” (1QS 1:2–3). Similarly, the Torah is described as having been revealed to Moses and the prophets (1QS 8:15–16). To be sure, the *Rule of the Community* does not explicitly refer to the *books* of the prophets. But, this is surely the intended meaning, as the prophetic books represented the only way for the sectarians to access the ancient prophetic word.

The literary character of the interaction with the ancient prophets is well illustrated by two passages in the *Damascus Document* (CD) and *Miqṣat Ma’ase ha-Torah* (4QMMT). CD 7:14–19 (parallel 4Q266 3 iii 18–19) contains an elaborate interpretation of Amos 5:26–27. The two scriptural expressions “tents of your king” and “*kiyyun* of your images” are understood as “the books of the Law” and “the books of the Prophets.” These two divisions are also found in *Miqṣat Ma’ase Ha-Torah*. The core of this text is a series of laws regarding temple ritual and purity concerning which the author of the text excoriates the addressee for advocating the incorrect position and insists on the correctness

of his approach to the laws. In the final hortatory section, the author insists that the addressee will come to the correct understanding of the law after careful study of “the book of Moses, the books of the Prophets, and (the writings of) Davi[d and the annals] of each generation” (4QMMT C 10–11 = 4Q397 14–21 iv 10–11). Later in the same passage, the end-time scenario envisioned by the author is presumed to be “[written in the book] of Moses and in the b[ooks of the prophet]s” (4QMMT C 17 = 4Q397 14–21 iv 15). *Miqṣat Ma’ase Ha-Torah* presumes that there is a group of prophetic writings that the addressee could readily consult. Moreover, the author of *Miqṣat Ma’ase Ha-Torah* deems these books to be authoritative guides for Jewish practice and end-time speculation. While the term “book of Moses” likely refers to the Pentateuch, *Miqṣat Ma’ase Ha-Torah* provides little guidance on what its author presumes falls under the rubric “books of the prophets” (or “David” or “annals of each generation”). Indeed, it is likely that the author and the addressee would have disagreed on what constitutes authoritative prophetic texts.

The literary grouping presumed by the *Rule of the Community* and *Miqṣat Ma’ase Ha-Torah* comports with other evidence from the late second century B.C.E. The Prologue to the Greek translation of Ben Sira identifies the sage Ben Sira as having studied the “law and the prophets and the other books of our fathers.” And 2 Maccabees 2:13–14 anachronistically portrays Nehemiah as collecting together “the books about the kings and prophets, and the writings of David, and letters of kings about votive offerings.” Nehemiah’s imagined literary grouping becomes the template for similar activity attributed to Judah Maccabee. These categories likely reflect several different approaches to the division of sacred texts advocated by Jews in the second century B.C.E. (for later evidence, see Luke 24:44; Josephus, *Ag. Ap.* 1.37–43; *b. B. Bat.* 14b–15a).

Scholars debate the significance of all these passages for the development of the tripartite canon. But, across all the passages, the categories of Law/Torah and Prophets are well attested. Thus, by the second century B.C.E., Jews were beginning to think not just about individual books but about how those books cohere with others in order to generate larger bodies of authoritative writings. The stability of the term “prophets” in these passages points at least to a core of generally agreed-upon books contained therein. Yet, none of these passages provides any sense of what specific books were regarded as part of the prophetic collection. Indeed, the lack of clarity regarding what is contained in these categories likely points to the still fluid nature of their identification.

Prophetic Books in the Dead Sea Scrolls

Neither 2 Maccabees nor the Prologue to Ben Sira provide additional direction on what its authors would have regarded as constituting the prophetic books. In the case of the Dead Sea Scrolls, however, we have a unique opportunity to examine the broader literary collection preserved by the constellation of sectarian communities associated with scrolls. The approximately 930 manuscripts found in the Qumran caves yielded numerous copies of prophetic books, sectarian writings that cite prophetic books in various

ways, explicit commentaries on prophetic books, and expansive compositions attributed to ancient prophets. Taken together, this evidence provides a window into what the sectarians of the Dead Sea Scrolls regarded as the ancient prophets.

Manuscript Inventory of Prophetic Books

In what follows, I approach this question by examining the evidence from several angles. Table 20.1 presents a manuscript inventory of books that were likely regarded as scriptural prophetic books for the Dead Sea Scrolls community: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, the Twelve (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi), and Psalms (the manuscripts are all found in Ulrich 2010). This list represents an attempt to work backward from the later biblical canon of the “Prophets” to determine the shape of these books in the Dead Sea Scrolls and their reception in Second Temple Judaism. The inclusion of Daniel and Psalms in this list reflects an attempt to assess the status of these books in the pre-canonical stage of the Second Temple period.

It is almost certain that Daniel and the Psalms were regarded as part of the same broader collection of scriptural prophetic texts. In the case of Daniel, later Jewish tradition places the book of Daniel in the “Writings” section of the Hebrew Bible and identifies him as a visionary rather than a bona fide prophet (*b. Meg.* 3a; *B. Bat.* 14b). In the Christian Old Testament, Daniel is placed alongside the other prophetic books. The abundance of evidence indicates that Jews in the Second Temple period regarded Daniel as a prophet and therefore would have included the book of Daniel in any collection of prophetic writings. The sectarian text *4QFlorilegium*, for example, explicitly cites Daniel as a prophet (4Q174 1–3 ii 3; cf. 11Q13 2:18), and Josephus prominently identifies him as a prophet (*Ant.* 9.267–269; 10.245–246, 249, 267–276).

The book of Psalms presents a more complex situation (see Lim 2009). The later Jewish canon locates the book of Psalms in the “Writings” section, while in the Christian Old Testament it is placed alongside other poetic texts. The Cave 11 *Psalms Scroll*, however, contains a prose addition that asserts that the book of Psalms was composed through prophecy bestowed upon David: “All these he composed through prophecy, which was given to him from before the Most High” (11QPs^a 27:11). While the *Psalms Scroll* never explicitly refers to David as a prophet, this identification is found in Josephus (*Ant.* 6.166) and the New Testament (Acts 1:16; 2:25–35). Moreover, as we shall see, the Psalms are the object of pesher interpretation in the same way as explicitly prophetic books.

The identification of the Psalms as prophetic highlights an intriguing curiosity regarding the literary groupings discussed in the previous section. Most scholars regard the reference to “David” in *Miqṣat Ma’ase Ha-Torah* and 2 Maccabees as, at the very least, referring to the book of Psalms. In each case, this literary unit is distinguished from the books of the prophets. Yet, the evidence surveyed here indicates that David too was regarded as a prophet and the book of Psalms as a prophetic book. The multiple identities for the book of Psalms suggest that we should not presume the same rigidity that one finds in later canonical lists and categories. The Psalms was clearly a popular book in the Second Temple period and as such garnered its own unit when discussing broader

Table 20.1 Scriptural Prophetic Manuscripts

	Cave 1	Cave 2	Cave 3	Cave 4	Cave 5	Cave 6	Cave 8	Cave 11	Other	Total
Isaiah	1QIsa ^a –Isa ^b (2)			4QIsa ^{a–r} (18)	5QIsa					21
Jeremiah		2QJer		4QJer ^{a–e}						6
Ezekiel	1QEzek		3QEzek	4QEzek ^{a–c} (3)				11QEzek		6
Daniel	1QDan ^{a–b} (2)			4QDan ^{a–e} (5)		6QDan				8
The Twelve				4QXII ^{a–g} (7)						9–12
Hosea				4QXII ^{a–b, g}						
Joel				4QXII ^{c, g}					MS 4612	
Amos				4QXII ^{c, g}	5QAmos					
Obadiah				4QXII ^g						
Jonah				4QXII ^{a, f–g}						
Micah				4QXII ^{f–g} 4QXII ^g 5; 4QpMic(?)						
Nahum				4QXII ^g						
Habakkuk				4QXII ^g						
Zephaniah				4QXII ^{b–c, g}						
Haggai				4QXII ^{b, e}						
Zechariah				4QXII ^{a, e, g}						
Malachi				4QXII ^{a, c, g} ; 4QXII ^c 35						
Psalms	1QPs ^{a–c} (3)	2QPs	3QPs	4QPs ^{a–x} (23)	5QPs	6QPs	8QPs	11QPs ^{a–e} (5)		36

literary groupings. Thus, while it was likely not regarded as among the “books of the Prophets,” it was equally considered part of the prophetic heritage of ancient Israel.

The overwhelming majority of the prophetic manuscripts—as with the Dead Sea Scrolls as a whole—are paleographically dated to the first century B.C.E. A smaller number were copied in the second century B.C.E. and the first century C.E. (Fuller 2009). Two copies of Daniel (4QDan^{a,c}) date to the second century B.C.E. and therefore were copied within a half-century of the final composition of the book of Daniel.

All of the books that constitute the later collection of Jewish and Christian canonical prophets are preserved, and in relatively high numbers. There is a clear preference for certain books. Indeed, Isaiah (21) and the book of Psalms (36) represent two of the three best-represented scriptural books in the entire Dead Sea Scrolls (there are 30 Deuteronomy manuscripts). These two books (along with Deuteronomy) are also the most frequently cited books in the New Testament. At the same time, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, and the Twelve are relatively well represented. The calculation of the Twelve is somewhat complicated. In addition to the eight distinct manuscripts from Caves 4–5, several scholars have argued that 4QXII^f 5 (Micah) and 4QXII^c 35 (Malachi) should no longer be classified as parts of the manuscript with which they were originally identified. Rather, they represent independent manuscripts. MS 4612 (Joel) is part of the Schøyen Collection and its provenance is therefore uncertain, although it is claimed to be from Cave 4 (though not part of the seven preserved Cave 4 scrolls). 4QpMic(?) clearly contains material from Micah, though it is too fragmentary to determine if this is a scriptural text of Micah or a pesher text (see further von Weissenberg 2011: 359–361). Because of these uncertainties, the manuscript number for the Twelve ranges from nine to twelve.

To put these numbers in perspective, the only other non-sectarian writings preserved in such high numbers are the books attributed to Moses (Genesis: 19–20; Exodus: 17; Leviticus: 13; Numbers: 7; Deuteronomy: 30; Jubilees: 12) and the various Enochic writings (12–13). In contrast, many of the later canonical historical books are poorly represented and most likely enjoyed little prestige among the Dead Sea Scrolls sectarians. While the extant manuscript inventory is itself the result of the accident of preservation, the numbers do seem to represent to some extent the relative degree of interest in the various books. The high numbers for Isaiah and Psalms in particular suggest that these books served an important function for the Dead Sea Scrolls sectarians, likely as the object of communal study.

The manuscript evidence for the Twelve offers the earliest evidence for multiple prophetic books being copied together on a single scroll (see von Weissenberg 2011). The reference to “the twelve prophets” in Sirach 49:10 indicates that already by the early second century B.C.E., the Twelve were regarded as a unified collection. It is not clear, however, whether the books were always copied on the same scroll and in what order they appeared. The Dead Sea Scrolls manuscripts provide some direction, albeit equivocal. Five of the Cave 4 manuscripts—including the oldest copy (4QXII^a)—preserve material from multiple books. Though no manuscript contains all twelve books, all of the books are preserved in at least one of the manuscripts. 4QXII^g in particular contains

eight (possibly nine) of the twelve books on a single scroll. This evidence suggests that these five manuscripts would have contained the entire twelve books. Seven other manuscripts preserve remnants of a single book and are too fragmentary to determine whether they were once part of a larger manuscript that included the entire Twelve (4QXII^c 35; 4QXII^d; 4QXII^f; 4QXII^f 5; 4QpMic[?]; 5QAmos; MS 4612). Among the manuscripts containing multiple books, all but one follow the same order as the Masoretic Text. 4QXII^a places Jonah toward the end of the collection after Malachi. Thus, 4QXII^a, the Septuagint, and the Masoretic Text preserve three distinct orders for the books of the Twelve.

The data summarized here points to a core group of scriptural prophetic writings in the Dead Sea Scrolls. At the same time, the fluid nature of scripture in the Second Temple period extends to these prophetic books. The book of Jeremiah provides a good example. Prior to the discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls, scholars were aware of two distinct versions of the book of Jeremiah—one found in the Hebrew Masoretic Text and one contained in the Greek Septuagint. The Dead Sea Scrolls yielded six Hebrew Jeremiah manuscripts. Four of these manuscripts preserve enough text to determine their textual character. Two Jeremiah manuscripts align with the longer version of Jeremiah as found in the Masoretic Text (4QJer^{a,c}), while two others correspond with the shorter version of Jeremiah otherwise only known in Greek translation (4QJer^{b,d}). Although each version of Jeremiah overlaps enough to be considered the book of Jeremiah, their literary divergence clearly marks them as distinct “versions” of Jeremiah from antiquity. In the Dead Sea Scrolls, both versions stand alongside each other as authoritative versions of the prophetic word of Jeremiah. The situation with the Jeremiah scrolls can likewise be found for nearly every book that would later be considered part of the Hebrew Bible. This phenomenon is no small matter in the broader social landscape. If Jeremiah, for example, was considered as the prophetic word of God, then Jews in the Second Temple period regarded the very word of God as still fluid and dynamic.

Citations of Prophetic Books

Alongside the manuscript evidence, the citation and interpretation of a particular scriptural book serves as an important measure of its prestige. A full catalog of citations and interpretations of prophetic books in the Dead Sea Scrolls is beyond the scope of this study. Table 20.2 provides a more limited attempt to examine the contribution of prophetic citations. The scriptural passages found in Table 20.2 all contain an introductory formula that specifically associates the cited passage with a named prophet. I also point out instances where the individual is explicitly identified as a prophet or the composition is described as “the book (*sefer*) of. . .”

The passages identified here constitute a small fraction of the many times that verses from the prophetic books are cited or alluded to in the Dead Sea Scrolls. These particular passages provide a unique subset of prophetic citations because they explicitly identify the name of the prophet to whom the citation is ascribed. Moreover, in fourteen out of the twenty-one cases, the text further identifies the individual as a “prophet.” The prophetic books that appear in this list are frequently cited throughout the Dead Sea

Table 20.2 Citations of Prophetic Books with Introductory Formula Referring to Prophet

	DSS Text	Citation Introduced with "PN the prophet"	Citation Introduced with "the Book (<i>sefer</i>) of PN"
Isaiah			
7:17	CD 8:10–12	√	
8:11	4Q174 1–2 i, 21 15–16	√	√
10:34–11:1	4Q285 7 1–3	√	reconstructed
24:17	CD 4:13	√	
32:7	4Q177 5–6 5–6	√	√
40:1–5	4Q176 1–2 i 4–9		√
52:7	11Q13 2:15–16	√	
54:1	4Q265 1 3–6	√	√
54:16	CD 6:8–9		
65:22–23	4Q174 15 1–3	√	reconstructed
Jeremiah			
5:7	4Q182 1 4–5	√	
?	4Q163 1 4		
Ezekiel			
9:4	CD 19:12		
39:3	4Q285 3–4 (reconstructed)	reconstructed	reconstructed
37:23	4Q174 1–2 i, 21 16–17	√	√
44:15	CD 3:21–4:2	√	
?	4Q177 7 3	√	√
Daniel			
9:25	11Q13 2:18		
12:10 + 11:32	4Q174 1 ii 3–4a	√	√
Zechariah			
13:7	CD 19:7–9	√	√
Psalms			
6:2–5	4Q177 12–13 i 2–3		

Scrolls without any introductory formula referring to the prophetic author. These particular passages do not seem to indicate what would have motivated an author to attach the name and prophetic identity to a particular scriptural citation. I would like to offer some tentative suggestions based on the cumulative evidence.

The list attests to the oversized influence of Isaiah within the prophetic heritage of ancient Israel in the Second Temple period. Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Daniel have a modest presence here as well. In most cases, there is a certain degree of proportionality to the number of scriptural manuscripts for each particular prophet. The obvious inconsistency in this regard is the evidence for the Twelve and the book of Psalms. From the Twelve, only Zechariah is explicitly cited by name. To be sure, several other books from the Twelve are cited prominently in the Dead Sea Scrolls. But, if there is something unique about a book being closely associated with a named prophet, the near absence of the Twelve here is suggestive. In the case of the Psalms, the evidence may be related to the ambiguous status of David as a prophet. As I noted earlier, while Josephus and the New Testament refer to David as a prophet, the most explicit identification of the Psalms as prophetic in the Cave 11 *Psalms Scroll* seems to avoid ascribing to David the label “prophet.”

The subset of prophetic citations that I have identified here are more than merely another example of the widespread use of prophetic scripture in Second Temple Judaism. The cluster of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Daniel as *named* prophets suggests that Jews in the Second Temple period placed a much higher premium on their identity as the preeminent prophets from Israel’s past—with special attention lavished on Isaiah. The Twelve and Psalms were equally authoritative as repositories of the divine word. They are widely cited as eschatological proof texts, and several Pesharim are devoted to the Psalms and the Twelve. At the same time, however, I am suggesting here that the Dead Sea Scrolls attest to an inner core of prophets whose identity loomed large in the Second Temple period. These books therefore enjoyed a deep and lasting resonance for Second Temple period Jews as they sought to enliven the word of God through the written words of the prophets.

INTERPRETATION AND EXPANSION OF PROPHETIC BOOKS

The interpretation and expansion of certain scriptural books represent another marker of their prophetic character and ongoing significance in the Second Temple period. The Dead Sea Scrolls preserve a unique form of scriptural interpretation found in the Pesharim. The words of the ancient prophets are regarded as predictive of the origins and eschatological future of the Dead Sea Scrolls community. Another set of manuscripts rewrite and expand prophetic texts in varying degrees. The particular prophetic character serves as the inspiration for a new composition. The Pesharim and the

expanded prophetic texts are both interpretive in nature. Both take the older prophetic text as their point of departure and employ a variety of exegetical techniques to amplify the prophetic content. These two corpora, however, differ considerably in their form. The Pesharim are explicit commentaries. The prophetic text is cited explicitly and then interpreted through a sequence of comments that do not intrude into the cited scriptural passage. Even as they claim to represent the single true interpretation of the prophetic scripture, the Pesharim are unmistakably distinct from the prophetic literature they interpret. In contrast, the expanded prophetic narratives often blur the lines between the older prophetic text and the expanded prophetic narratives. Some of these texts employ the exegetical technique of “rewriting,” whereby the older prophetic text is reformulated to fit the desired context of the new text. In other cases, the expanded prophetic narrative merely adopts the identity or voice of the ancient prophet. All of these settings make no formal distinction between the older scriptural content and the newer expanded material.

The Pesharim

The Pesharim represent a collection of previously unknown Hebrew commentaries on scriptural prophetic books and, more broadly, the method of scriptural interpretation contained in these and other scrolls found in the Qumran caves (for the texts, see Horgan 1979; see further Brooke 2005, 2012). As a genre, Pesharim share a set of common assumptions and characteristics. Pesharim presume that the ancient prophetic words do not refer only to the specific points in time in which they were uttered. Rather, they are hidden ciphers that allude to the origins, historical circumstances, and eschatological expectations of the communities of the Dead Sea Scrolls and other Jews and foreigners within their orbit. While the ancient prophets did not understand the full meaning of their words, the Pesharim envision inspired individuals in their own time who possess the ability to uncover the hidden meaning in the scriptural text.

The ideological basis of the Pesharim is well articulated in *Pesher Habakkuk* (1QpHab). The ancient prophets are conceptualized as pronouncing oracles concerning “everything that is to come upon his people and [his] com[munity]” (1QpHab 2:9–10). The text describes an inspired exegete imbued with the ability to interpret the meaning of these very words that signify “everything that is to co[me up]on the last generation” (1QpHab 2:7). *Pesher Habakkuk* claims that the hidden future meaning of the prophecy was not known, even to the prophet: “God told Habakkuk to write down the things that are going to come upon the last generation, but when that period would be complete, he did not make known to him” (1QpHab 7:1–2). The full meaning of the ancient prophetic pronouncements is known only to the Teacher of Righteousness, “to whom God made known all the mysteries of the words of his servants the prophets” (1QpHab 7:4–5).

The end of days envisioned in *Pesher Habakkuk* and throughout the Pesharim is not some distant eschatological age. These texts bear evidence that the Dead Sea Scrolls sectarians envisioned the unfolding of the eschatological age in their own time. Only

when its eschatological expectations failed to materialize did they assert that “the Last Days will be long, much longer than the prophets had said; for God’s revelations are truly mysterious” (1QpHab 7:7–8), yet “all the times fixed by God will come about in due course” (1QpHab 7:13). The Pesharim give voice both to the expectation of an imminent eschatology and a reconstituted set of eschatological ambitions. Through a variety of exegetical techniques applied to the scriptural lemmata, the ancient prophetic words are provided a new set of meanings and applications. One of the most distinctive elements of the Pesharim is their attempt to “contemporize” the words of the ancient prophets, thereby infusing them with eschatological import.

Formally, Pesharim are marked by the citation of a lemma from a scriptural verse that is then provided with a unique interpretation. In most cases, a distinct technical formula intervenes between the lemma and interpretation—most commonly, one finds some iteration of “the interpretation of the passage is . . .” or “its interpretation is. . .” The recurring Hebrew technical term for “interpretation” (*peshar*; pl. *pesharim*) provides the name for the broader set of texts exhibiting these formal characteristics and the interpretive activity. Pesharim are commonly classified in three distinct categories: (1) continuous Pesharim; (2) thematic Pesharim; and (3) isolated Pesharim.

Continuous Pesharim represent sustained interpretations of entire prophetic books or sections of books. In these texts, a lemma from the scriptural book (of varying length) is cited, followed by the technical *peshar* formula and then the interpretation (also of varying length). This entire structure is repeated for the next lemma in the scriptural text, thus producing a series of similar units in the continuous *Peshar*. The Dead Sea Scrolls have preserved 17 *Peshar* manuscripts containing continuous commentaries on scriptural books: six Pesharim on Isaiah (3Q4, 4Q161–165); two Pesharim on Hosea (4Q166–167); two Pesharim on Micah (1Q14, 4Q168); one *Peshar* on Nahum (4Q169); one *Peshar* on Habakkuk (1QpHab); two Pesharim on Zephaniah (1Q15, 4Q170); three Pesharim on the Psalms (1Q16, 4Q171, 4Q173).

Thematic Pesharim are characterized by the appearance of *peshar* exegesis of disparate scriptural passages, clustered around a focused eschatological theme: *4QFlorilegium*—4Q174; *4QMidrash Eschatology*—4Q177; *11QMelchizedek*—11Q13. Isolated Pesharim denote individual examples of *peshar*-type exegesis embedded in larger literary works of clearly different genres. In both thematic and isolated Pesharim, the same general prophetic texts predominate. Passages from Isaiah and Psalms are the most frequently cited and interpreted: Isaiah: CD 4:13; 4Q265 1 3–6 (recons.); 4Q177 5–6 1–2; 11Q13 2:17, 20 (recons.); Psalms: 4Q174 1–2 i, 21 10, 18–19; 10–11 9; 11Q13 2:11–12.

The thematic and isolated Pesharim are unique in that they incorporate interpretation of the Pentateuch. *4QFlorilegium*, for example, applies an eschatological understanding to the blessing of Moses in Deuteronomy 33. In several places, the *Damascus Document* applies *peshar*-type interpretation to Pentateuchal passages (Num 21:18 in CD 6:3–11; Num 24:7 in CD 7:18–21; Deut 32:33 in CD 19:21–24). Nearly all the examples of *peshar* interpretation on the Pentateuch involve poetic passages. In some cases, for example Deuteronomy 32, there is already a predictive nature to the text that lays the foundation for the eschatological *peshar* interpretation. The evidence therefore suggests

that the Dead Sea Scrolls sectarians regarded specific poetic passages in the Pentateuch as prophetic. These poetic-prophetic passages were then regarded as a basis for eschatological interpretation in the same way as the prophetic books that are the basis of the continuous pesharim.

Expanded Prophetic Narratives

If the preserved manuscripts represent an accurate sampling of the once complete Qumran library, not all prophetic books were treated the same way with regard to exegetical engagement. Based on the preserved manuscripts, Isaiah, Psalms, the Twelve, and poetic passages from the Pentateuch are the objects of peshar interpretation. A small number of isolated passages apply peshar exegesis to verses from Jeremiah (4Q163 1 4; 4Q182 1 4–5) and Ezekiel (CD 3:21–4:4). No continuous peshar manuscripts exist for Jeremiah, Ezekiel, or Daniel. Rather, these books are interpreted in new compositions that rewrite or expand upon the prophetic books in varying degrees (Brooke 1998, 2012; Jassen 2007: 225–234).

Alongside the eight copies of the later canonical book of Daniel, the Dead Sea Scrolls preserve several compositions related to some degree to the character of Daniel. These texts include *4QPrayer of Nabonidus* (4Q242); *4QPseudo-Daniel*^{a-b} (4Q243–244), *4QPseudo-Daniel*^c (4Q245), *4QApocryphon of Daniel* (4Q246), *4QFour Kingdoms*^{a-b} (4Q552–553), *4QDaniel-Susanna?* (4Q551). The fragmentary nature of each of these texts often makes it difficult to reconstruct their precise relationship to the canonical book of Daniel. Indeed, in some cases, these compositions may pre-date the second century B.C.E. date for the final form of Daniel. Even accounting for this possibility, it seems clear that the prophetic character of Daniel served as the primary inspiration for most of these texts. For example, the reconstructed text of 4Q243–244 contains the *ex eventu* prophecy of Daniel, encompassing a review of history from the time of the flood all the way through the Hellenistic period and into the eschatological age. Daniel dictates this review in the presence of a foreign king, most likely identified as Belshazzar (see 4Q243 2 2).

The author of *4QPseudo-Daniel*, writing sometime in the late Second Temple period, appropriates the prophetic voice of Daniel in order to authenticate his review of history. The Second Temple period author casts the review of history into the prophetic voice of the sixth century B.C.E. prophet Daniel. With the benefit of the author's historical hindsight, the prophet of *4QPseudo-Daniel* accurately predicts the future course of history. This technique matches closely the compositional technique of the author of the canonical book of Daniel. In both cases, the accurate review of history validates the prophetic voice. This in turn lends a high degree of authority when the author speaks through the prophet in order to outline future events that have not yet transpired from the historical vantage point of the author and his readers.

The *4QApocryphon of Jeremiah* texts are loosely related to the book of Jeremiah through the reuse of the character of Jeremiah. Scholars have argued for the existence of

three distinct texts: A (4Q383); B (4Q384); C (4Q385a, 387, 387a, 388a, 389, 390) (Dimant 2001). The connections to the book of Jeremiah are in allusion and style. *4QApocryphon of Jeremiah C*, for example, employs the character of Jeremiah in a way consistent with his portrait in the book of Jeremiah. 4Q385a 18 i–ii follows the book of Jeremiah (esp. Jer 40–44; 52:12–13) in narrating several details regarding the fall of Jerusalem and Jeremiah's relationship with the exiles. Contrary to the biblical text (Jer 39:14; 40:6), 4Q385a 18 i 6 recounts that Jeremiah accompanied the exiles to Babylon (a tradition also found in other extra-biblical texts about Jeremiah). The text introduces Jeremiah as a prophet communicating with the exiles in Babylon and exhorting them to remain faithful to the covenant while in captivity. *4QApocryphon of Jeremiah C* places special emphasis on Jeremiah's admonition to the exiles to refrain from idolatry. Jeremiah is presented as a new Moses delivering a Torah for the exiles. The following section locates Jeremiah among the exiles in Egypt. As in the previous section, he delivers an oracle exhorting the exiles to follow the covenant and renounce idolatry. Unlike the Babylonian exiles, the Egyptian exiles are resistant to Jeremiah's words (as in Jer 43:1–3; 44:15–19).

Other manuscripts of the *Apocryphon of Jeremiah C* are only tenuously related to the biblical character and story of Jeremiah. In these settings, Jeremiah acts as a prophet conveying *ex eventu* prophecy for the history of Israel; 4Q389 1 5–7 locates Jeremiah in Egypt, though it describes a document read to the exiles in Babylon. Devorah Dimant has proposed that this letter contained a review of Israelite history from early biblical times through the eschatological age. Dimant reconstructs the scope of this review of history from the extant fragmentary manuscripts (see Dimant 2001: 99–100). The review of history in this text is similar to the historical reviews in the *Damascus Document*, the book of Jubilees, and the Animal Apocalypse. The *Apocryphon of Jeremiah C* draws on Jeremiah's prophetic identity to affirm the validity of the historical review for the Second Temple period and the eschatological age. Thus, Jeremiah functions in this text first and foremost as a prophet of God divulging privileged information about the future.

The *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* texts are similarly inspired by the character of Ezekiel (4Q385, 385b, 385c, 386, 388, 391; Dimant 2001). Unlike the Daniel and Jeremiah texts, *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* more closely appropriates the prophetic voice of Ezekiel in rewriting language and content from the book of Ezekiel. For example, Ezekiel appears as the first-person speaker in several instances (e.g., 4Q385 2 9, 3 3, 4 2; 4Q386 1 ii 2; 4Q391 65 4–5) and is also identified as the recipient of direct divine speech (e.g., 4Q385 4 4). In using these formal features, the author of *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* claims that the text is the authentic word of Ezekiel and his prophetic communication with God (Zahn 2014: 341–342). Within this framework, *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* expands or modifies content from the book of Ezekiel and introduces entirely new content that becomes equally identifiable as the prophetic word of Ezekiel. For example, Ezekiel 37:1–14, the Vision of the Dry Bones, is generally understood as a prophetic metaphor for the future restoration of Israel. The author of *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* transforms this prophetic metaphor into an explicit theological statement affirming the bodily resurrection of the righteous of Israel (4Q385 2+3, 4Q386 1 i, 4Q388 7; see Zahn 2014: 344–350). Another fragment (4Q384 4) describes Ezekiel's hope for the hastening of the end of days. The text harnesses Ezekiel's prophetic voice by

tracing this eschatological expectation to a direct divine speech to Ezekiel. In so doing, the author of *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* introduces new content entirely unknown in older Ezekiel traditions and paints it with the patina of Ezekiel's prophetic authority.

The expanded prophetic narratives discussed here were each composed outside the sectarian communities of the Dead Sea Scrolls. They therefore represent a snapshot of how wider segments of Second Temple Judaism interpreted and expanded the words of the prophets. The ancient prophets of Daniel, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel became literary ciphers through which Second Temple period writers could claim to transmit the word of God. The resulting compositions stood alongside the other books attributed to these prophets and collectively represented the prophetic heritage of ancient Israel. We do not know the degree to which the authors and readers made a distinction between the word of Ezekiel, for example, as represented in the book of Ezekiel and the *4QPseudo-Ezekiel* texts. The expanded prophetic narratives represent another example of the still fluid and dynamic approach to the prophets in the Second Temple period.

PROPHECY IN THE SECOND TEMPLE PERIOD

On the “Decline” of Prophecy

For many Jews in antiquity, prophecy was an institution that had ceased to exist in the early post-exilic period (see, e.g., Ps 74:9; 1 Mac 9:27; 4:46; 14:41; *m. Sot.* 9:13; *t. Sot.* 13:2–3; Jassen 2007: 11–19). Other Jews asserted that prophecy continued to exist in their own time, but its character and modes of revelation had changed. The evidence from Josephus provides a good example of the latter position. Whenever Josephus discusses prophets from ancient Israel, he introduces them with the designation *prophētēs* (“prophet”). When Josephus treats individuals in the Second Temple period who he believes possess oracular abilities, he identifies them with the title *mantis* (“mantic”). For example, Josephus describes Judah the Essene's prediction of the murder of Antigonus (*War* 1.78–80) not as prophecy, but rather as *prorrēthentōn* (“predictions”) and *man-teuma* (“oracles”). Similarly, Judah is a *mantis*, not a *prophētēs*. The activity of Judah the Essene comports with Josephus's more general understanding of the predictive role of prophets and prophecy. While Judah's actions are prophetic, Josephus carefully refrains from identifying him as a prophet.

The terminological distinction that Josephus draws when referring to prophets and prophecy brings into sharper focus his claim in *Against Apion* (1.41) that the “exact succession of prophets” had ended during the period of Artaxerxes. Scholars often point to this passage as evidence that Josephus argued for the decline of prophecy in the early post-exilic period (see Jassen 2007: 17–18). In this passage, however, Josephus is asserting that only prophetic books composed before the early post-exilic period are worthy

of inclusion in the sacred scriptures. His explanation is not that prophecy *ended*, but rather than it *changed*. Prophecy as it was performed and perceived in the pre-exilic period had come to an end at some point in the early post-exilic period. At the same time, new prophetic models emerged that performed similar mediating functions. For Josephus, this prophetic rupture renders any writings of the later set of prophets unfit for inclusion in the sacred history.

The recognition of the changing nature of prophecy must be viewed alongside a general suspicion in the Second Temple period of false prophets (Jassen 2014: 179–182). Zechariah 13:2–6, for example, casts aspersions on all individuals claiming to be prophets by contrasting the true prophets of old with the illegitimate prophets of the present. While Zechariah 13:2–6 refers to the condemned individuals with the technical term “prophet,” later Second Temple literature unequivocally identifies such individuals as *false* prophets. The Septuagint, for example, translates the Hebrew *nābi* (“prophet”) as *pseudoprophētēs* (“false prophet”) in all cases where the individual is deemed to be a false prophet (e.g., Zech 13:2). Josephus uses similar terminology to deny any prophetic identity for several individuals in the Second Temple period claiming to be prophets. For example, Josephus denies any truth to the prophetic claims of the “Egyptian” by introducing him simply as a “false prophet” (*War* 2.261). Josephus similarly traces the roots of the failed zealotry against Rome to a first century C.E. “false prophet” (*War* 6.285; cf. 2.258). In all these cases, Josephus employs the designation “false prophet” alongside terms such as “imposter” and “deceiver” (e.g., *War* 2.259; *Ant.* 20.167) to reject the very notion that these individuals have any access to God.

The broader evidence from the Second Temple period provides a context for the examination of ongoing prophetic activity in the Dead Sea Scrolls. Several texts among the Dead Sea Scrolls evince a concern for false prophets. The *Temple Scroll* (11QT^a 54:8–18) and the *Moses Apocryphon* (4Q375) both contain a set of laws based on Deuteronomic principles for identifying and prosecuting a false prophet. Similarly, *4QList of False Prophets* (4Q339) preserves a register of false prophets in Israel’s history. These texts indicate that the sectarians were sensitive to the widespread suspicions regarding contemporary prophetic claims. This evidence likewise explains why the sectarian communities of the Dead Sea Scrolls never refer to their own leaders as prophets. The sectarian opponents are the only contemporary individuals in the Dead Sea Scrolls explicitly identified as prophets. One of the *Thanksgiving Hymns* (1QH^a), for example, employs prophetic terminology colored with the accusation of false prophecy to condemn the opponents as “mediators of deceit” (1QH^a 12:6–7), “mediators of a lie” (1QH^a 12:9–10), “seers of deceit” (1QH^a 12:10), and “seers of error” (1QH^a 12:20). Most significantly, the sectarian opponents are condemned for attempting to seek God with the aid of “lying prophets” (1QH^a 12:16). Throughout the hymn, however, the hymnist uses non-prophetic language to claim to have unfettered access the God. The point of the hymn is clear: the prophetic claims of the enemies are unfounded and should not be trusted. In contrast, the hymnist is a recipient of true revelation (see further Jassen, 2007: 280–290; 2008b: 311–318).

Modified Modes of Revelation

The rhetoric of the hymn in 1QH^a 12 is guided in part by the ongoing suspicion regarding false prophecy and the concomitant currency attached to the accusation of false prophecy to one's enemies. The avoidance of explicit terminology also reflects the sectarian assumption that the nature of revelation and prophecy had changed to such an extent that the classical language for identifying prophecy was no longer appropriate—similar to the evidence found in Josephus. Despite the absence of explicit prophetic terminology, the Dead Sea Scrolls point to several modified modes of revelation that the sectarians regarded as representing the contemporary realization of the phenomenon of prophecy. These modified modes of revelation reflect a shift from the oracular nature of prophecy to a textualized and sapiential setting (see also Brooke 2006; Nissinen 2008).

The most prominent modified mode of revelation found in the Dead Sea Scrolls is what I have previously identified as “revelatory exegesis” (Jassen 2007: 203–207). This term applies to the reading, interpretation, and reconfiguration of ancient prophetic scripture as a prophetic experience. Examples of this phenomenon can be detected throughout Second Temple literature. In Daniel 9, for example, Daniel's interpretation of Jeremiah's written word is treated as commensurate with the prophetic visions and dreams that he experiences in other chapters (Jassen 2007: 221–225). In Daniel 9 and similar examples from the Second Temple period, revelation occurs through the process of reading and reformulating earlier prophetic scripture. The older prophecies serve as ancient divine communiqués now preserved in literary form. Guided by divine inspiration, readers reawaken the divine speech and decipher the contemporary application of the ancient prophetic word. This experience is identified as equivalent to classical modes of prophetic communication, and its practitioners are singled out for their prophetic capabilities.

I discussed two examples of revelatory exegesis in the previous section: expanded prophetic narratives and Pesharim. As observed by George Brooke (2012), the identification of these examples as prophetic interpretation is doubly significant. These texts have as their goal the interpretation and amplification of older prophetic literature. Yet, as Brooke further observes, the claim—whether implicit or explicit—that the later exegete is uncovering the deeper hidden meaning of the older prophetic text is equally a claim to be continuing the prophetic voice of the earlier text. In the expanded prophetic narratives, the later exegete appropriates the prophetic identity of the older prophet along with that prophet's mode of prophetic discourse. The ancient prophets were regarded as forward-thinking. Accordingly, the authors of the expanded prophetic narratives utilized the ancient prophetic voice to outline a vision of future circumstances. The exegetes, however, did not invent anew the content of their message. Rather, they subtly reworked the older material. In so doing, they are making the implicit claim that what they are now articulating has already been revealed to the ancient prophet. What is being said in the expanded narrative is merely a repackaging of the original prophetic message.

In many ways, these processes mimic the history of the formation of biblical prophetic literature through a succession of prophetic schools and scribes. Deutero-Isaiah appropriates the voice and identity of Isaiah and expands the Isaianic prophetic discourse. An unknown scribe expanded the prophetic message of Jeremiah and created a new, longer version of Jeremiah's prophetic voice. In these two cases, the expanded prophetic narrative is bestowed an imprimatur of prophecy on account of the incorporation of the expanded Isaiah and Jeremiah into what becomes the canonical version of these prophets. It is likely that the authors of *Pseudo-Daniel*, the *Apocryphon of Jeremiah*, and *Pseudo-Ezekiel* saw themselves as doing much the same thing.

The Pesharim similarly reflect the belief that the interpretation of prophetic scripture is itself a prophetic experience (see Jassen 2007: 343–353; Brooke 2012). As noted earlier, the Pesharim assume that the words of ancient prophets predicted the circumstances surrounding the origins and eschatological history of the sectarian communities and their opponents. Like Daniel 9 and other examples of revelatory exegesis, pesher literature is predicated upon the assumption that the word of God is now transmitted through the scriptural text. The process of reading and interpreting the text is therefore conceptualized as a viable realization of the prophetic experience.

While the authors of the expanded prophetic narratives stake their claim of prophetic continuity in their anonymity, the Pesharim are more forthcoming regarding the revelatory basis of their exegetical technique. *Pesher Habakkuk* explicitly claims that the Teacher of Righteousness's ability to interpret prophetic scripture is because "God placed into [his heart discernme]nt to interpret all the words of his servants the prophets [whom] through them God enumerated all that is going to come upon his people and [his] com[munity]" (1QpHab 2:9–10). This passage outlines one of the fundamental assumptions of pesher exegesis: In the past, God told the ancient prophets special knowledge regarding future events. In the present, God has bestowed upon the Teacher of Righteousness the intellectual capabilities to access this prophetic message through the medium of inspired exegesis. This same passage earlier refers to the Teacher of Righteousness as speaking "from the mouth of God" (1QpHab 2:2–3). Column seven makes a similar claim regarding the Teacher's divinely bestowed knowledge: "God made known all the mysteries of the words of his servants the prophets" (1QpHab 7:4–5). The Teacher of Righteousness and other inspired pesher exegetes become partners with the ancient prophets in the process of discerning the full meaning of their words. The three passages highlighted here indicate that this process is about more than exegetical acumen. Rather, the Teacher of Righteousness's inspired exegesis of scripture was understood as an application of one of the new rubrics of prophecy.

The Dead Sea Scrolls indicate that the sectarians also saw the process of lawgiving as a revelatory experience (Jassen 2008a). The sectarians advocated a model of progressive revelation of the law. For the sectarians, two types of law exist (1QS 5:7–13). There is the "revealed" law, which is known to all Jews through the medium of scripture. In addition, there is the "hidden" law, which was only revealed to the community and elect people in history. The hidden law contains amplifications of biblical law, new legal concepts, and other legal content not otherwise accessible through scripture. According to the *Rule of*

the *Community*, proper observance of the law requires knowledge of “everything that has been revealed (from) time to time and according to that which the prophets have revealed by his holy spirit” (1QS 8:15–16). The hidden law was first revealed to Moses. The next recipients were the Israelite prophets. This portrait of the ancient lawgiving prophets differs considerably from their presentation in biblical literature and as understood by most Jews in antiquity.

Several other Dead Sea Scrolls texts rework the role of the classical prophets in biblical literature and refashion them as mediators of divinely revealed law (see, e.g., 1QS 1:2–3; CD 5:21–6:1; 4Q166 2:1–6; 4Q381 69 4; 4Q390 2 i 4–5; full treatment in Jassen 2008a). At the same time, the sectarians fashion their own identity as recipients of progressive revelation of law as a prophetic encounter in continuity with that with which they believed the ancient prophets had been similarly engaged. The *Rule of the Community*, for example, describes the sectarians’ receipt of law in language very similar to that of the ancient prophets: “According to everything that has been revealed from it [i.e., the Torah] to the Sons of Zadok (1QS 5:9; 4QS^{b,d}: “to [the multitude of] the council of the me[n] of the Community”). The sectarians recontextualized the activity of the classical prophets as an earlier stage of the process upon which they now base their entire legal system. The constant and consistent portrait of the ancient prophets as mediators of divinely revealed law authorizes the identical sectarian pursuit.

The Dead Sea Scrolls contain evidence for an additional modified mode of revelation that was viewed as commensurate with prophecy. In this model, the gap between the divine and human realms is bridged by the transmission of knowledge from God to certain humans—what I term “sapiential revelation” (Jassen 2007: 241–278). While the cultivation of wisdom is common in the biblical tradition, it is rarely associated with Israelite prophets. In the Second Temple period, sapiential revelation and wisdom instruction are removed from their exclusive wisdom context and provided with a new prophetic framework. Ben Sira, for example, identifies the process of teaching wisdom as “pouring out instruction like prophecy” (Sir 24:33). The receipt of divine knowledge and the divulging of divine mysteries are conceptualized as a prophetic process and its practitioners as prophetic figures (see Nissinen 2008, esp. 528–531).

I noted earlier that the Cave 11 *Psalms Scroll* introduces David’s composition of the Psalms as the product of prophetic inspiration: “All these he composed through prophecy (*binvū’ah*), which was given (*nitān*) to him from before the Most High” (11QPs^a 27:11). This passage forms an *inclusio* with the clause that immediately precedes the list of psalms that David composed: “The Lord gave (*wa-yyittēn*) him a brilliant (*nevōnā*) and discerning spirit” (11QPs^a 27:3–4). Both passages claim some divine gift to David using similar language (“to give”—*ntn*). Line eleven asserts that David composed the psalms with prophetic guidance. This notice is intended to qualify and be qualified by the description of David as a sage in lines 2–3. This correspondence is reinforced by the apparent word play between *nevū’ah* and *nevōnā*. David’s prophetic capabilities as identified in line 11 are the direct result of the sapiential revelation granted to him in line three (for further examples, see Jassen 2007: 366–375).

CONCLUSIONS

The Dead Sea Scrolls provide a sharp lens through which to view the reception of the prophets in Second Temple Judaism. The scrolls evince an ongoing conversation regarding which ancient writings would be regarded as prophetic and the degree of prestige and authority attached to each of these books. The majority of the books that would later be considered part of the Jewish and Christian prophetic scripture were already regarded as such in the Dead Sea Scrolls. The manuscript evidence, however, suggests that Jews in the Second Temple clearly had a higher predilection for specific prophets and prophetic books. As with most scriptural books in the Second Temple period, the prophetic writings reflect the still fluid textual nature of scripture. While Jeremiah, for example, was universally regarded as prophetic scripture, readers accessed the precise prophetic words through two equally authoritative versions of the book of Jeremiah.

The evidence from the scrolls further indicates that Jews in the Second Temple period had a wider understanding of what constitutes prophetic scripture than later Jews and Christians. The books of Daniel and Psalms were regarded as prophetic scripture. Moreover, the boundaries of what were considered prophetic writings were extended by the inclusion of expanded prophetic narratives. The best preserved of these are associated with Daniel, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel. Taken as a whole, the evidence from the Dead Sea Scrolls indicates that Jews in the Second Temple period regarded the divine word as accessible through multiple prophetic literary sources.

The Dead Sea Scrolls further point to shifting conceptualizations of the meaning of prophecy. The expanded prophetic narratives and the Pesharim give voice to the blurred lines between composition and interpretation. The authors of these texts interpret ancient prophetic writings while simultaneously claiming to extend the compositional and revelatory setting of the older texts. For the sectarians behind the Dead Sea Scrolls, prophecy was not an institution solely associated with the prophets of ancient Israel. Rather, they regarded their own exegetical, juridical, and sapiential activity as extending the oracular and revelatory activities of the ancient prophets. The sectarians, like other Jews in the Second Temple period, recognized the changing nature of revelation and the language of prophecy. Accordingly, the Dead Sea Scrolls often utilize new terminological markers for prophecy and presume a disjunctive nature between ancient and contemporary modes of revelation. Notwithstanding this acknowledged rupture, the sectarian communities of the Dead Sea Scrolls fashioned their self-identity to reflect the belief that they represented the contemporary heirs of the ancient prophets.

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CHAPTER 21

THE PROPHETS IN THE NEW TESTAMENT

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FOR the earliest Christians, prophecy was by no means a relic of the past. The line of the prophets, stretching back beyond Moses, had reached its culmination in Jesus; in his name, men and women empowered by God's Spirit continued to prophesy and perform signs and wonders. Contemporary experiences colored perceptions of the prophets of old, even as the ancient prophets and their writings shaped early Christian interpretations of God's mighty acts through Christ and the Spirit in their own day.

The nature and role of prophecy in early Christianity is a vast subject encompassing numerous fields of research.¹ Even the narrower topic indicated by the title of this chapter has spawned a substantial body of literature. Thus, the goals of the present essay are rather modest: first, to consider to whom the New Testament writers are referring when they speak of "the prophets"; second, to open a window onto the rich and variegated reception of the prophets in the New Testament writings through three case studies. These will show that prophetic texts play a significant role in shaping early Christian convictions about the significance of Jesus' life (Matthew's Gospel), the distinctive character of the community's ethics (1 Peter), and the divine plan for Israel and the nations (Romans 9–11).

"THE PROPHETS" IN THE WRITINGS OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

A Living Tradition

Like other Second Temple Jews, the authors of the New Testament writings regard the prophets as charismatic figures of Israel's past through whom God spoke and acted in

exceptional ways.² The Evangelists refer in broad terms to the “prophets and righteous people” of former generations (Matt 13:17//Luke 10:24), to “the patriarchs and all the prophets” (Luke 13:28; cf. John 8:52–53) or, simply, to “(all) the prophets” (Mark 6:15; Mark 8:28//Matt 16:14//Luke 9:19; Luke 24:27; Acts 3:18, 24; 10:43). Luke and John also speak of “Moses and (all) the prophets” (Luke 16:29, 31; 24:27; Acts 26:22; John 1:45). Reflecting the central place the Mosaic Law has assumed in Second Temple Judaism, this latter expression both associates Moses with, and grants the lawgiver primacy among, the prophets.³ Others named as prophets in the New Testament include “Samuel and his successors” (Acts 3:24), Elijah, Elisha, Hosea, Joel, Jonah, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Daniel, and David.⁴ In two instances, figures thought to predates Moses are also regarded as prophets: Enoch (Jude 14–15) and Job (Jas 5:10–11; cf. *Test. Job*).

The prophets belong not only to Israel’s past, but also to its future. The Gospels allude to the popular expectation of Elijah’s return in the last days (e.g., Matt 11:14; 17:11; see Mal 4:5–6). Moses himself is remembered as having prophesied that God would one day raise up “a prophet like me” in Israel (Deut 18:15) whose divinely authorized word would command unquestioned obedience (Luke 9:35; Acts 3:22–23; 7:37; cf. John 6:14; 7:40).⁵

In the meantime, prophetic gifts continue to be manifested among God’s people. Matthew’s infancy narrative assigns a prominent role to Joseph, who like his ancient namesake receives foreknowledge and instruction through heaven-sent visions and dreams. Luke’s Gospel opens with the Holy Spirit filling, guiding, and inspiring the prophetic speech of godly Israelites like Elizabeth and her husband, Zechariah the priest, the devout Simeon, and Anna the “prophetess” (Luke 1:41, 67; 2:25–27, 36). And in a classic example of Johannine irony, Caiaphas “prophesies” in his office as high priest that Jesus will die for the nation (John 11:51).⁶

With John the Baptist and Jesus, figures resembling the ancient prophets in stature once more stride onto the stage (cf. Luke 9:8). Traditions about the prophets of old—their message, their miracles, and their martyrdom—profoundly shape the Gospels’ portrayals of John and Jesus.⁷ In turn, New Testament portraits of these contemporary prophets offer invaluable perspectives on how the classical prophets themselves were remembered at the time of the Second Temple.

The characterization of John and Jesus as prophets receives particular emphasis and elaboration in Matthew’s Gospel and, above all, in Luke-Acts. Filled with the Holy Spirit from his mother’s womb, John goes forth “in the spirit and power of Elijah” to prepare the way for the Lord’s coming (Luke 1:13–17; cf. Matt 11:14). As the forerunner of God’s Messiah, he is “a prophet, and more than a prophet” (Luke 7:26//Matt 11:14). Like the prophets of old, John boldly exposes sin and injustice among God’s people, especially their religious and political leaders; he calls Israel to repent and to practice justice in the face of impending divine judgment; and he announces the good news of God’s coming reign (Luke 3:1–20; Matt 3:1–12).

Jesus, too, appears in Luke’s Gospel as “a prophet mighty in deed and in word in the sight of the Lord and all the people” (Luke 24:19). Empowered by the Holy Spirit, he embodies God’s reign in his prophetic concern for the poor, the prisoners, the foreigner, and the outcast (Luke 4:14–30). Jesus’ ministry evokes the powerful deeds of

Elijah and Elisha, as those who witness him bring a widow's only son back from the dead recognize that "a great prophet has arisen among us" (Luke 7:16). Like Matthew, Luke presents Jesus as a prophetic interpreter of Torah, though one who exercises a sovereign authority over the Law far beyond what tradition had attributed to any prophet (Luke 6:17–49; Matt 5:17–48).⁸ The story of Jesus' meeting with Moses and Elijah on the mount of Transfiguration, recounted in all three synoptic Gospels, vividly portrays the Messiah's continuity with, and yet superiority to, both lawgiver and prophet (Mark 9:2–8//Matt 17:1–8//Luke 9:28–36). Even as the heavenly voice identifies him with the long-anticipated "prophet like Moses," to whom Israel must hearken,⁹ Jesus is revealed to be far more than a prophet: he is God's own son, the chosen one. In Luke's Gospel, as in the other Synoptics, Jesus is remembered as prophesying the impending destruction of Jerusalem and the coming of the Son of Man to usher in God's reign. His oracles employ traditional prophetic forms such as metaphor (Luke 23:31), parable (Luke 21:29–31), and lament (Luke 19:41–44), weaving imagery from earlier prophetic texts into new constellations (Luke 21:5–36). Finally, Jesus, like John, shares the fate of the prophets before him. In likening the unjust executions of Jesus and John to the rejection and murder of the ancient prophets, the early Christians both draw from and further develop Israel's martyrdom traditions.¹⁰

The prophetic activity of Jesus continues in the early church. Luke's second volume interprets the outpouring of the Holy Spirit on the community at Pentecost as fulfilling not only Joel's prophecy concerning the last days (Acts 2:16–21, citing Joel 3:1–5) but also John's prediction that the one to come after him would baptize with the Holy Spirit (Luke 3:16). Appealing to prophecies of David (Acts 2:25–28/Ps 16:8–11; Acts 2:34–35/Ps 110:1) Peter identifies the Spirit as the gift of the risen Jesus, now exalted to God's right hand as Lord and Messiah (Acts 2:33–36). In addition, Luke carefully crafts his narrative so that the stories of the apostles replicate the patterns of Jesus' own prophetic ministry. Acts depicts the apostles and other Spirit-driven followers of Jesus carrying on the work of the prophets within and beyond the bounds of Israel: proclaiming judgment and salvation, calling for repentance, performing signs and wonders, receiving God's word in visions and dreams, promulgating inspired interpretations of scripture, forecasting the future, and, in some cases, sharing the prophets' fate. Forms of prophetic activity among the early Christians find abundant attestation throughout the rest of the New Testament as well.¹¹ Fittingly, then, the canon of apostolic scriptures of the Western Church culminates in a "scroll of prophecy" (Rev. 22:19) that weaves a rich and complex tapestry of visions, exhortations, and warnings out of innumerable threads culled from Israel's prophetic writings.¹²

Prophetic Writings

Just as the practice of telling Jesus' story reflects—and in turn shapes—how the earliest Christians conceptualized the activity and message of "the prophets," so Jesus likewise provides the writers of the New Testament with the hermeneutical key to interpret the writings the ancient prophets left behind.

In the New Testament, the ancient prophets are not simply individuals who spoke and acted for God in the past; the divine voice continues to address God's people through the scriptures that traditionally bear the prophets' names. Indeed, when New Testament authors speak of the prophets, it is most often with reference to a body of texts. "Isaiah" and "the prophets" are read aloud publicly in the synagogue (Luke 4:16; Acts 13:16, 27) and privately by individuals (Acts 8:28, 30, 32).¹³ Luke twice makes reference to a "scroll of (the words of) Isaiah the prophet" (Luke 3:4; 4:17), once to a "passage of scripture" containing Isaiah's words (Acts 8:32), and once to the "scroll of psalms" (Acts 1:20; cf. 13:33). In addition, Mark identifies a conflated quotation of Exodus 23:20, Malachi 3:1, and Isaiah 40:3 as "written in Isaiah the prophet," and Paul refers to what "[God] says in Hosea" (Rom 9:25). The single mention of a "scroll of the prophets" may well refer to the Book of the Twelve (Acts 7:42–43, citing Amos 5:25–27).¹⁴ Elsewhere one encounters "the writings of the prophets" (Matt 26:56), words "written *through* the prophet(s)" (Matt 2:5; Luke 18:31; cf. John 1:45; Rom 1:2), or sayings "written *in* the prophet(s)" (Mark 1:2; Luke 24:44; John 6:45; Acts 24:14).¹⁵ Not infrequently, a scriptural quotation is attributed to a particular prophet: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Daniel, Hosea, Joel, David, Enoch. Of these named individuals, however, only Isaiah emerges with anything like a distinctive persona.¹⁶

Citation formulas introducing prophetic texts frequently refer to speech. In about a third of these, the prophet is the subject of the verb of speaking; in the remainder, the prophet is the instrument through whom God or the Holy Spirit speaks (e.g., Matt 1:22; Acts 3:21; Heb 1:1). As divine discourse, prophetic texts are believed to harmonize perfectly with one another. For this reason, New Testament authors do not hesitate to make blanket appeals to the unified testimony of "(all) the prophets" of God (e.g., Matt 26:56; Acts 10:43; Rom 1:2; 1 Pet 1:10). They conjoin, combine, and conflate prophetic texts with a degree of freedom that strikes a modern interpreter as nothing short of astonishing. Because God is understood to be the primary author of sacred scripture, New Testament writers also assume the congruity of "the prophets" with the books of Moses. Thus, phrases like "the Law and the prophets" or "Moses and the prophets" can serve as comprehensive designations for "all the scriptures" (Luke 24:27; cf. Matt 5:17; Acts 24:14; Rom 3:21).¹⁷ This usage finds parallels elsewhere in Second Temple Judaism, of course.¹⁸ What is distinctive about the writers of the New Testament is their conviction that the unity of the Law and the prophets consists in the witness of these ancient texts to God's saving actions in the present time through Jesus the Messiah.¹⁹ Thus, even the Law can be read as prophecy; for Moses, too, wrote about Jesus (Luke 24:27; John 1:45; 5:46; Acts 26:22; 28:23; Rom 3:21).

THE WRITINGS OF THE PROPHETS IN THE NEW TESTAMENT

While they share the fundamental conviction that Jesus himself is the hermeneutical key to the scriptures, New Testament authors appropriate prophetic texts in a wide variety

of ways.²⁰ The three brief case studies that follow seek to display something of the range and sophistication of the reception of the prophets in the New Testament writings.

Matthew: The Prophets and the Story of Jesus

In Matthew's programmatic Sermon on the Mount, Jesus claims that he has come to "fulfill" the Law and the prophets (Matt 5:17). Just what "fulfillment" entails, the evangelist discloses by telling the story of Jesus as the culmination of God's providential care for Israel. In the narrative and prophetic texts of scripture, Matthew discerns the patterns of the divine purpose for the ages. By mapping the story of Jesus onto these patterns, he captures the climactic significance of the Messiah's life, death, and resurrection for Israel and, ultimately, for all nations.²¹

Matthew's Gospel opens with Jesus' genealogy, whose singular structure locates the birth of the Messiah at the divinely determined turning point of Israel's story. Three sets of fourteen generations—the numerical value of "David" in Hebrew—lead from Abraham to David the king, from David to the Babylonian Exile, and from the Exile to the Messiah. The outworking of the divine plan becomes evident in the specific circumstances surrounding Jesus' birth. The prophet's assurance that "God is with us" (Matt 1:23/Isa 7:14) finds narrative fulfillment as God steers the course of world events to bring the ancient prophecies to pass. When Joseph, a descendant of David, discovers that his betrothed has conceived, the angel of the Lord informs him in a dream that Mary has remained chaste, for the child she carries is from the Holy Spirit. The angel instructs Joseph to name the child "Jesus," foretelling that "he will save his people from their sins" (Matt 1:18–21). The evangelist subtly reinforces the claim that "all of this happened so that what the Lord had said through the prophet would be fulfilled" (Matt 1:22) by weaving into his own narrative (Matt 1:18, 21, 25) the words of Isaiah 7:14, which he quotes explicitly in the center of the pericope: "See, the virgin will conceive and bear a son, and they will call his name 'Emmanuel'" (Matt 1:23).

Without doubt, the designation of the woman as a "virgin" in the Greek version of Isaiah 7:14 helps to explain the evangelist's attraction to this prophecy. But given Matthew's focus on the centrality of David and his family in the divine plan, it is clear that what he sees being "fulfilled" in the birth of David's descendant Jesus involves far more than a virginal conception. In Isaiah's confrontation with Ahaz, the prophecy of Isaiah 7:14 is given as a sign of hope to the Davidic dynasty, a gracious confirmation of the promise that David's line will not fail and that God will not abandon Israel to their enemies (cf. 2 Sam 7:8–16).²² Within the Book of Isaiah, moreover, 7:14 anticipates the oracle in 9:1–7 celebrating the birth of a righteous king whose just and peaceful reign on David's throne will have no end. Just as the angel's promise that Jesus "will save his people from their sins" (Matt 1:21) finds its fulfillment in the narrative of the Messiah's self-offering in obedience to God on the cross ("the blood of the covenant poured out for many, for the forgiveness of sins," Matt 26:28), so Isaiah's prophecies of the son of David come to fruition in the resurrection of Jesus. Risen from the grave, Emmanuel, "God

with us" (Matt 1:23), assures his worshiping, doubtful disciples: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. . . . See, I am with you always, even to the end of the age" (Matt 28:18–20).

As the story of Jesus' birth unfolds, the ancient prophets continue to bear witness to God's providential ordering of history. That a ruler and shepherd for Israel would be born in Bethlehem was prophesied ages ago, as the high priests and scribes of the people attest (Matt 2:1–6/Mic 5:1–3). Similarly, the angel's admonition to Joseph to seek refuge for his family in Egypt fulfills the word spoken long before by the Lord through the prophet: "Out of Egypt I called my son" (Matt 2:15/Hos 11:1). Even Herod's brutal murder of the young boys of Bethlehem had been foretold by the Lord through Jeremiah the prophet, who centuries earlier offered a vivid poetic depiction of Rachel grieving inconsolably over her vanished children (Matt 2:17–18/Jer 31:15). And when the angel directs Joseph to move his family to Galilee, his decision to settle in Nazareth likewise fulfills what had been said "through the prophets" (Matt 2:23).

Not a few interpreters have found the evangelist's appeal to these prophecies arbitrary and contrived. Attention to the wider settings of these particular oracles in the prophetic writings, however, uncovers a deeper logic at work.²³ Each of the prophets Matthew cites here addresses Israel in exile, assuring them of God's unshakable faithfulness despite the chastisement they are presently enduring. Micah juxtaposes images of kingless, captive Zion's anguish (Mic 4:9–10, 14) with the promise that her birth pangs will bring forth a ruler to shepherd the regathered people of Israel (Mic 5:1–4a). Hosea contrasts God's tenacious love for "Israel . . . my son," whom God called out of Egypt and nurtured in the wilderness, with the inveterate idolatry of the covenant people (Hos 11:1–4). Because of their flagrant rebellion, they will soon return to Egypt, Hosea prophesies, and Assyria will rule over them (Hos 11:5–7). But God will not abandon his beloved forever. Once again, God's children will hear the divine summons and will come forth from Egypt in a new exodus. The LORD will restore them to their homes and "dwell in [their] midst" (Hos 11:8–11; cf. Matt 1:23, "God with us"). Jeremiah depicts the matriarch Rachel (associated by Matthew with Bethlehem via Gen 35:19–20) weeping over her exiled children (Jer 31:15). Yet in the very next breath, the LORD calls this bereft mother to cease her weeping, promising that her scattered children will return. Furthermore, the larger section of Jeremiah 30–31 is framed by divine discourses declaring God's firm purpose "in days to come" to restore Israel and Judah to their land, where "they shall serve the LORD their God and David their king, whom I will raise up for them" (Jer 30:9). The Lord vows to make a new covenant with Israel, to write the Law upon their hearts, and to remember their sin no more (Jer 31:31–34). Even Matthew's cryptic comment, "He will be called a *nazoraïos*," evokes Isaiah's promise that a *nezer* will one day sprout from Jesse's roots. Endowed with the Spirit, he will rule justly over God's regathered people (Isa 11:1).

The evangelist's appropriation of these prophetic oracles, then, is governed by a logic of "fulfillment" that might be termed "typological." Through his careful reading of the scriptures, Matthew discerns fundamental correspondences between the story of Jesus and the story of his people Israel, correspondences that are founded in God's providential ordering of both. Just as he finds Jesus' pivotal place in the history of Israel displayed

in the divinely ordered patterns of the Messiah's genealogy, so too Matthew learns through the oracles spoken by the ancient prophets that Jesus' life recapitulates the key events of Israel's history, bringing that story to its God-ordained culmination. In his flight to Egypt, the Messiah who will save his people from their sins (Matt 1:21) participates in Israel's exile, suffering in solidarity with his kinsfolk under foreign kings whose brutal tyranny is graphically instantiated in the slaughter of Rachel's innocent children. The divinely orchestrated return of the son of God to his homeland similarly prefigures the forgiveness and restoration of God's beloved son Israel that will be accomplished through Jesus' death and resurrection. And in his characterization as a "Nazorean," the identity of this son of David as Israel's eschatological king is enigmatically revealed.

That Matthew sees the course of Jesus' life providentially following the contours of Israel's history finds further confirmation in his account of the beginning of Jesus' ministry. Coming to John for baptism, Jesus "fulfill[s] all righteousness" by standing in solidarity with his sinful people and taking on himself the sign of their repentance (Matt 3:15). Endowed with the Holy Spirit and acknowledged as God's beloved son by a voice from heaven, Jesus is led by the Spirit out into the wilderness. Unlike Israel of old, however, this son of God faithfully endures the trial in the desert, refusing to test the Lord and repudiating the worship of false gods. Once more, Matthew finds the words of the prophets fulfilled as Jesus returns to Galilee and relocates to Capernaum (Matt 4:14–16/Isa 8:23–9:1). The connection between Isaiah's vision of a victorious Davidic scion arriving to usher in God's reign of justice and peace (Isa 9:2–7) and the inauguration of Jesus' public ministry is underscored by the evangelist, who observes, "From that time Jesus began to preach and say, 'Repent, for the reign of heaven is at hand'" (Matt 4:17). Having called his first disciples, the nucleus of a restored Israel, Jesus ascends a mountain and begins to teach the law of God's kingdom (Matt 5:1–7:29). In interpreting Torah, Jesus assumes a role that his contemporaries would have associated with the scribes of their own day, as well as with the prophets of old.²⁴ But the sovereign authority with which Jesus teaches suggests that he is neither a scribe nor simply a prophet. In continuity with the Mosaic tradition but exercising the prerogative of a "new Moses,"²⁵ Jesus identifies the commandments to love God and neighbor as the sum and substance of "the Law and the prophets" (Matt 7:12; cf. 22:40).

Matthew frames the Sermon on the Mount with two passages that reveal the presence of God's reign in Jesus' healing of the sick (Matt 4:23–25; 8:1–17). By crafting these narrative bookends for the sermon, the evangelist intimates that Jesus' "fulfillment" of the Law and the prophets (Matt 5:17) occurs as his saving ministry to Israel unfolds. Matthew observes that Jesus' healing of the sick and demon-oppressed fulfills what was said through the prophet Isaiah: "He himself took our infirmities, and he bore our diseases" (Matt 8:17/Isa 53:4). Prophetic texts again figure prominently in Matthew's characterization of "the deeds of the Messiah" (Matt 11:2). In response to John's question, "Are you the one who is to come, or do we await another?" Jesus describes his ministry with a pastiche of phrases from Isaiah (Matt 11:5, echoing Isa 29:18; 35:5–6; 42:18; 26:19; 61:1). Isaiah's oracles of salvation find concrete realization in the course of Matthew's narrative, as when Jesus heals a man made blind and deaf by an evil spirit (Matt 12:22–30). Lest the reader miss

the point, Matthew prefaces this latter pericope with a further summary of Jesus' healing ministry, capping it off with yet another lengthy quotation from Isaiah (Matt 12:15–21). Here, the prophecy of the Lord's Spirit-empowered "servant" who quietly performs works of compassion and justice (Isa 42:1–4) comes to narrative expression as Jesus forbids those he has healed to "make him known" (Matt 12:16).

Jesus performs the prophetic word not only through deeds of power and miracles of healing, but also by his public teaching. Addressing the crowds in parables, Jesus takes up the prophets' reproof of Israel for their habitual hard-heartedness toward the divine summons to repent. This is seen not only as Jesus himself cites Isaiah's rebuke to obdurate Israel (Matt 13:10–15/Isa 6:9–10), but also as Matthew identifies Jesus with "the prophet" who speaks in the psalms. By connecting Jesus' parabolic teaching on the reign of God with the opening words of Psalm 78 (Matt 13:35/Ps 78:2), the evangelist represents Jesus as the culmination of a long line of prophets who, as in the psalms of Asaph (Psalms 73–83), retold the story of Israel's rebellion and of God's stubborn faithfulness, and who looked ahead in hope beyond judgment to the restoration of God's just rule through "the man of [God's] right hand" (Ps 80:17). In the case of the disciples, Jesus' teaching reveals "the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven" (Matt 13:11) that even the prophets of old could not fathom (Matt 13:16–17). The crowds may regard Jesus as John the Baptist *redivivus* or one of the ancient prophets come back from the past (Matt 16:14), but at Caesarea Philippi and on the mount of Transfiguration, God reveals what flesh and blood cannot divine: far more than a prophet (cf. Matt 11:9), Jesus is the Messiah, the son of David, and the beloved son of God (Matt 16:13–20; 17:1–8). Not even the disciples can yet comprehend what this identification signifies, however, and Jesus' thrice-repeated prediction of his passion and resurrection falls on deaf ears (Matt 16:21–23; 17:22–23; 20:17–19). Only as these events unfold will his identity and his role in the divine plan be fully revealed.

As the disciples arrive in Jerusalem for Passover, Matthew once again portrays Jesus as bringing the words of the prophets to fruition by his actions. Though the crowd identifies him as a prophet (Matt 21:11), Jesus orchestrates a highly symbolic entrance into the city (complete with two animals, in Matthew's telling of the story!), thereby proclaiming his advent as Zion's peaceful king foreseen by the prophet long before (Matt 21:5/Zech 9:9). Jesus performs the vocation of a prophet through a parabolic act of judgment against the temple authorities, appropriating the words of Isaiah and Jeremiah to interpret his deeds (Matt 21:12–13). Teaching in the temple, Jesus delivers authoritative interpretations of Torah (Matt 22:15–40) and expounds Davidic utterances as prophecies pointing to his imminent suffering and consequent exaltation as Israel's rightful king (Matt 21:42/Ps 118:22–23; Matt 22:43/Ps 110:1). In his fierce denunciation of the accredited teachers of Israel (Matt 23:1–36), Jesus assumes the mantle of the prophets, and he foresees for himself a fate like theirs as he laments Jerusalem's intransigence (Matt 23:37–39). Lastly, Jesus prophesies the impending destruction of Jerusalem and its temple. Drawing on the words of Isaiah (Matt 24:20/Isa 13:10; 34:4) and Daniel (Matt 24:15/Dan 9:27; Matt 24:30/Dan 7:13–14), he outlines the divinely ordained course of events that will culminate in the glorious advent of the son of Man to usher in God's reign on earth. Matthew's so-called Apocalyptic Discourse (Matt 24:1–51) extends a long-standing tradition of scribal

prophecy that rewrites and reconfigures earlier oracles to illuminate the divine plan in light of contemporary events. The evangelist's sustained attention to the fulfillment of ancient prophecies in the course of his Gospel narrative assures the reader that Jesus' own predictions will just as surely come to pass in God's time (cf. Matt 24:34–35).

The events of Jesus' betrayal, arrest, trial, and execution unerringly unfold in accordance with the divine purpose revealed through the prophets. In addition to narrating the fulfillment of prophecy through explicit citations from Zechariah (Matt 26:31/Zech 13:7) and "Jeremiah" (Matt 27:9–10/Zech 11:13; cf. Jer 18:2–3), Matthew puts in Jesus' own mouth the affirmations that "things must happen this way" in order for "the scriptures to be fulfilled" (Matt 26:54) and that "all this has taken place so that the words of the prophets would be fulfilled" (Matt 26:56). Fulfillment again takes a narrative form as Matthew draws detailed descriptions from Psalms 22 and 69 (regarded as the words of David the prophet) to recount the Messiah's suffering, humiliation, and abandonment.²⁶ Sharing the afflictions of the psalmist, Jesus sheds his blood to save his sinful people (Matt 1:21; 26:28), and in so doing manifests God's profound solidarity with all the righteous sufferers of Israel.

As the Gospel concludes, Matthew no longer has to speak explicitly of fulfillment; the progression of the narrative suffices for the attentive reader. In Jesus' burial and resurrection on the third day, the sign of Jonah is fulfilled (Matt 12:39–41; 16:4). Likewise, Jesus' own words of prophecy are resoundingly vindicated, as the angel triumphantly attests: "He has been raised, just as he said" (Matt 28:6). "All authority in heaven and on earth" has now been entrusted to the son of Man (Matt 28:18/Dan 7:14); raised in glory, Jesus properly receives the worship that belongs to God alone (Matt 28:17; cf. Matt 4:10). As God's plan for the ages moves toward its determined end, Jesus commissions his disciples to baptize "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matt 28:19). And as they go forth to teach all nations to obey the commands of God's exalted son (cf. Ps 2), Emmanuel, "God with us" (Matt 1:23/Isa 7:14), vows to remain with them always, even to the end of the age (Matt 28:20).

Matthew's practice of appealing to prophetic texts as authoritative commentary on Jesus' story is not the sort of superficial prediction–fulfillment scheme one associates with proof-texting apologists. Rather, the evangelist carefully arranges his narrative to demonstrate that the course of Jesus' life continues—and brings to its culmination—the providential design of God revealed in "the law and the prophets." Above all, as he recounts the story of Jesus, God's obedient, beloved son who gives his life "for many," Matthew shows that it is in Jesus' life of devotion to God and loving self-sacrifice for others that the true intent of the Law and the prophets finds its paradigmatic expression (Matt 7:12; 22:40) and, in just this way, becomes a pattern of life his followers may emulate.

1 Peter: The Prophets and the Shape of Discipleship

The circular letter known as 1 Peter presents a striking example of the way New Testament authors draw on the prophets as resources for shaping patterns of Christian

discipleship.²⁷ Writing to converts suffering marginalization and maltreatment as “Christians” at the hands of their neighbors (1 Pet 4:16), Peter locates his hearers at “the end of times” (1 Pet 1:20). The same God who elected Jesus Christ before the foundation of the world has now in mercy chosen these “foreigners” and brought them into God’s own household. Ransomed and cleansed by Jesus’ blood, they have been given new birth into a living hope through his resurrection. And though their faith is now severely tried by suffering, God’s power continues to safeguard them “for a salvation ready to be revealed at the last time” (1:5), that is, “at the revelation of Jesus Christ” (1 Pet 1:7, 13).

Peter underscores the privileged position of his hearers in the divine plan by observing that the prophets of old “prophesied about the grace destined for you” (1 Pet 1:10). They did so precisely because it was “the Spirit of Christ in them” that “testified beforehand to the sufferings destined for Christ and the glories to follow” (1 Pet 1:11). Although the prophets searched assiduously to discover, in addition, the time and circumstances to which the Spirit was pointing, it was revealed to them only that they were prophesying for the sake of a generation yet to come. But now, at long last, Peter claims, God has disclosed the full meaning of the ancient prophecies by this same “Holy Spirit sent from heaven” speaking “through those who preached the good news to you” (1 Pet 1:12).²⁸

Two convictions expressed in the opening paragraphs of the letter prove foundational to the ethical vision of 1 Peter. First, because God has mercifully embraced them in Christ, Jesus’ followers now find their identity inextricably bound up with his. Through Jesus’ death and resurrection, they have been redeemed from sin and granted new life as children of God. Christians may presently be called to suffer in solidarity with Christ, but they do so under God’s fatherly protection, knowing that their inheritance is secure. Second, the ancient prophets serve the present generation specifically by bearing witness to the sufferings and glories destined for the Messiah and his people. The prophetic writings thus play a crucial role in fostering a community of disciples whose lives manifest the distinctive character of Christ as they share his sufferings in anticipation of sharing his glory.

The significance of the prophetic writings for the ethical formation of Christ’s followers can perhaps be seen most clearly in 1 Peter 2:21–25. In calling the members of the community to subordinate themselves to human social structures for the Lord’s sake, Peter emphasizes that they do so as free people who, as God’s slaves, are bound to show honor to everyone but to fear God alone (1 Pet 2:13–17). The author first addresses those of lowest social status (1 Pet 2:18–25), lifting up household slaves as models for the “honorable conduct among the Gentiles” (1 Pet 2:12) incumbent on every member of the community: “If you suffer for doing what is right and endure it, this is commendable in God’s sight” (1 Pet 2:20; cf. 3:17). Peter anchors his strenuous summons in the reality that Christians have been granted a new identity in Christ, who “suffered for you, leaving you an example so that you would follow in his footsteps” (1 Pet 2:21).

As he traces the pattern laid down by Christ (1 Pet 2:22–25), Peter draws nearly every detail from Isaianic prophecies concerning the Lord’s “servant.” A quotation of Isaiah 53:9 establishes that Jesus suffered unjustly (1 Pet 2:22). Jesus’ refusal to return insult for insult or to threaten revenge (1 Pet 2:23) recalls the servant’s silence in the face of

persecution (Isa 53:7). And the servant's confidence that God will vindicate him in judgment (Isa 50:8) underlies Peter's explanation that Jesus endured because "he entrusted himself to the One who judges justly" (1 Pet 2:23). Isaiah's oracles similarly provide the theological grounding for the exhortation to follow in Christ's steps. Because Christ "bore our sins" (Isa 53:4) in his body on the cross, "we" ourselves have died to sins; "healed by his bruise" (Isa 53:5), we are now enabled to live for righteousness (1 Pet 2:24). Though you were "like sheep going astray" (Isa 53:6), Peter reminds his audience, "you have now returned to the shepherd and overseer of your souls" (1 Pet 2:25; cf. Isa 40:11).

Isaiah's expressions and concepts have been so thoroughly assimilated by the New Testament writer that we find them woven into the fabric of the letter in other passages as well. The exhortation in 1 Peter 2:1 to put away all "deceit" and slander anticipates the use of Isaiah 53:9 to characterize Jesus' own integrity of speech in 1 Peter 2:22. This Isaianic depiction of Jesus finds a further echo in the prohibition on returning "insult for insult" that concludes Peter's *Haustafel* (1 Pet 3:9, echoing 2:23/Isa 53:7). 1 Peter 3:18 reprises the logic of Isaiah 53:4 to explain how Jesus' death enables the audience to continue to "do what is right," even in the face of suffering: "For Christ died for sins once for all, the just one for the unjust, in order to bring you to God" (recalling 1 Pet 2:24–25/Isa 53:4–6). And in a final exhortation to those who, in God's providence, suffer unjustly, Peter returns once more to Isaiah's servant songs. Just as Jesus committed himself to the righteous Judge (1 Pet 2:23/Isa 50:8), so they too must "entrust their lives to the faithful Creator" and persist in doing what is right (1 Pet 4:19).

Romans 9–11: The Prophets and the Purpose of God

From the opening of his letter to the Romans, Paul maintains that the gospel he has been called to proclaim was "promised beforehand through [God's] prophets in holy writings" (Rom 1:2). It is only natural, then, that as he wrestles in Romans 9–11 with the question of God's faithfulness to Israel, the apostle to the Gentiles turns to his sacred scriptures to gain fresh insight into the divine purpose. In these chapters Paul assembles a veritable chorus of scriptural witnesses to testify alongside him to the divine determination to show mercy to Israel and the nations through Jesus Christ. Read through the lens of the gospel, prophetic texts enable Paul to elucidate patterns in God's dealings with his people that both illuminate Israel's present obduracy and lead the apostle confidently to affirm that in the mystery of God's providence "all Israel" will at last be saved (Rom 11:26).

Four features of Paul's appeal to the prophets in Romans 9–11 deserve comment here.²⁹ First, as the letter is read out by Paul's emissary, the Roman assemblies hear Moses (Rom 10:5, 19), David (Rom 4:6; 11:9), and Isaiah (Rom 9:27, 29; 10:16, 20; 15:12) step forward, as it were, to speak at the apostle's side. This rhetorical strategy concretizes Paul's hermeneutical claim that "the Law and the prophets" together bear witness to the justice and faithfulness of God, now revealed through his gospel (Rom 3:21). The apostle freely conflates and combines scriptural sources, blending the prophecies of Isaiah

with those of Hosea (Rom 9:27/Hos 1:10; Isa 10:22), Moses, and David (Rom 11:8/Deut 29:4; Ps 69:23; Isa 29:10). All the same, he does not represent the prophets as an entirely undifferentiated ensemble. “Moses writes” (Rom 10:5), and “David” pronounces an imprecation on his rebellious people (Rom 11:9–10/Ps 69:22–24). Most remarkably, Isaiah acquires a distinctive persona through the vivid introductions Paul composes for the prophet: “Isaiah cries out over Israel” (Rom 9:27); “Isaiah dares even to say . . .” (Rom 10:20). Isaiah even appears as a fellow preacher of the gospel, lamenting with the apostle and his fellow heralds, “Lord, who has believed our message?” (Rom 10:16). Whether they speak separately or in concert, Paul’s rhetoric ensures that Moses and the prophets are heard as living voices who continue to proclaim “the word of Christ” to Israel.

Second, Paul discovers in the narrative and prophetic texts of scripture patterns of divine action that illuminate God’s plan for Israel’s future. In retelling the history of the patriarchs and of the Exodus generation, Paul focuses his hearers’ attention on the faithful character of the primary actor in Israel’s story: the God who elects according to his gracious promise (Rom 9:8), sovereign purpose (v 11), life-giving calling (v 12), and lavish mercy (vv 15–16). In prophecies of Israel’s exile and in promises of restoration for God’s people on the other side of judgment, Paul discerns God’s purpose to show mercy to Gentiles as well as to Jews. The pattern of reversal Paul discovers in Hosea, where God calls “beloved” those who were “not loved,” is so sweeping as to embrace even Gentiles in its scope (“Esau have I hated,” Rom 9:13/Mal 1:2–3). Yet, for just this reason, the prophetic word in Hosea continues to hold out hope for God’s still-recalcitrant people Israel as well (Rom 9:25–26/Hos 2:23 and 1:10). Isaiah gives voice to this hope, proclaiming that even in judgment God has graciously left for Israel a remnant (Rom 9:27–28/Isa 10:22–23; 28:22) and seed (Rom 9:29/Isa 1:9), the promise of their future regeneration. Drawing insight from Moses (Rom 10:19/Deut 32:21) and Isaiah (Rom 10:20–21/Isa 65:1–2), Paul envisions this divine plan unfolding in two stages. In the present time, God has preserved a “remnant” of Israel, chosen by grace (Rom 11:5; cf. 9:11), while the “remainder” God has hardened (Rom 11:7). By God’s providential design, Israel’s “loss” has brought riches to the world, opening an opportunity for salvation to come to the nations (Rom 11:11–12). But this anomalous situation is only temporary. According to the “mystery” revealed to Paul through the scriptures, when “the fullness of the Gentiles” has entered, then “all Israel”—the “remnant” and the “remainder”—will be saved (Rom 11:25–27/Isa 59:21; 27:9). God has locked up all people in disobedience that God may show mercy to all (Rom 11:30–32).

The prominence of the divine voice in the passages Paul appropriates from the prophetic writings represents a third notable feature of Romans 9–11. In first-person speech through the prophets, God professes unconditional love for Jacob (Rom 9:13/Mal 1:2–3) and mercifully calls the one who is “not loved,” “beloved” (Rom 9:25–26/Hos 2:23; 1:10). God claims personal responsibility for placing the stumbling stone in Israel’s path (Rom 9:33/Isa 28:16; 8:14). The divine “I” resolves to make Israel jealous with a “no-nation” (Rom 10:19/Deut 32:21) and to be found by those who did not seek God (Rom 10:20/Isa 65:1). In the first person, God laments Israel’s stubborn resistance to his persistent appeals (Rom 10:21/Isa 65:2) and reveals that he has nonetheless determined to preserve a faithful remnant in the present time (Rom 11:4/1 Kgs 19:18). Fittingly, then, it is God’s

own voice that confirms Paul's confidence in the future salvation of "all Israel": "This will be my covenant with them, when I take away their sins" (Rom 11:26–27/Isa 59:21; 27:9).

Finally, Paul's appeal to the "mystery" of God's providential design for Israel and the nations places the apostle firmly within a tradition of prophetic interpretation attested in the later prophetic writings themselves. Like Daniel (Dan 9:1–19), Paul ponders the oracles of the prophets who preceded him, urgently seeking to discern the outworking of the divine plan for Israel's future in the midst of his people's present distress. In Paul's case, as in Daniel's, only God is able to supply the requisite insight into the prophetic scriptures.³⁰ And so, having graciously been granted a glimpse of the divine "mystery," Paul concludes with a paean to God's unfathomable wisdom. Joining his voice to the chorus of the prophets, the apostle asks in wonder and awe, "Who has known the mind of the Lord?" (Rom 11:34/Isa 40:13).

NOTES

1. See the classic study of Aune 1983.
2. On perceptions of "the prophets" in the Second Temple period, see Barton 1986.
3. Compare Philo's *Life of Moses*, which examines its subject under the rubrics of king and lawgiver, high priest and prophet. Josephus claims that as a prophet, Moses has no peer (*Ant.* 4:329; similarly, Heb 3:5; see Ex 33:11; Num 12:6–8; Deut 34:10).
4. David is explicitly labeled a prophet in Acts 2:30; cf. *11QPsalms*^a (11Q5) xxvii 11 (see further Acts 4:25; Mark 12:36//Matt 22:43; Matt 13:35, and compare Heb 4:7 with Heb 3:7). Correspondingly, New Testament writers often regard the psalms as prophetic utterances.
5. See Allison 1993.
6. One similarly finds in Josephus's writings that prophetic activity continues even as "the prophets" are spoken of as eminent figures belonging to Israel's glorious past (Gray 1993).
7. See Aune 1983: 153–188. For an attempt to understand the historical Jesus as a prophetic figure, see Allison 1998.
8. As Barton shows, the ancient prophets are widely regarded in the Second Temple period as interpreters of Torah (Barton 1986: 154–178). Compare the memory of the Teacher of Righteousness as authoritative guide to *halakah* as well as inspired interpreter of the prophets; see *Damascus Document* (CD) i 8–11; *1Q Peshier to Habakkuk* (1QpHab) vii 1–viii 3.
9. "Listen to him!" Luke 9:35, echoing Deut 18:15; for the expected "prophet like Moses," see Acts 3:22–23; 7:37.
10. For the prophets as martyrs, see, e.g., Matt 5:11–12; 23:29–33, 37; Luke 11:47–51; 13:34; Acts 7:52; Rom 11:23; 1 Thess 2:5; Rev 16:6.
11. E.g., 1 Cor 11–14; 1 Tim 1:18; Heb 2:4; 1 John 4:1–3; Rev 2:20; 10:11; 19:10. See further Aune 1983.
12. See Bauckham 1993.
13. Acts 13:16 mentions "the reading of the Law and the prophets." References to "reading" Moses or the Law appear in Acts 15:1; 2 Cor 3:15; Luke 10:26 (cf. John 5:39, which refers to "investigat[ing] the scriptures"). Matthew 21:42 speaks of "reading in the scriptures" words from Psalm 118. If taken as the words of Jesus (rather than an authorial aside, as in Mark 13:14), the instruction to "let the reader understand" in Matthew 24:14 will refer to the one reading Daniel's prophecy.

14. ¹⁴ A scroll of the Minor Prophets discovered at Naḥal Ḥever (8HevXIIgr) dates to the last half of the first century B.C.E. The surviving manuscript contains parts of Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, and Zechariah.
15. Compare the references to “prophetic scriptures” (Rom 16:26) and to “every prophecy of scripture” (2 Pet 1:20; cf. 2 Tim 3:16). A considerable number of citations from the prophets are marked, “it is written,” with no more specific indication of their source (e.g., Matt 26:31). Paul once introduces a citation from Isaiah with the phrase, “it is written in the law” (1 Cor 14:21; cf. Rom 3:19).
16. This is the case, moreover, only in John’s Gospel (John 12:37–41) and in Romans. Nonetheless, New Testament writers draw on Isaiah far more frequently than on any other prophetic book, with the exception of the Psalms. Deuteronomy, Exodus, and Genesis rank behind the Psalms and Isaiah as the scriptures most often cited in the New Testament. The Dead Sea Scrolls reflect a similarly intense interest in Isaiah and the Psalms, together with the Books of Moses.
17. In Luke 24:44, the risen Jesus says, “It is necessary for everything written about me in the law of Moses and the prophets and the psalms to be fulfilled.” Whether one finds evidence here for an emerging tripartite canon is debated. In any case, the psalms are here said to contain prophecies about Jesus that “must be fulfilled.” It is likewise in their character as prophetic texts that the psalms play a crucial role both in Luke’s passion narrative and in the apostolic preaching about the resurrection and exaltation of Jesus in Acts.
18. See Barton 1986.
19. The New Testament writers thus show no concern to delimit the collection of “the prophets.” All of the emphasis is rather placed on the unity of “all the prophets” in their testimony to Jesus.
20. Carson and Williamson 1988 provide a concise overview of the use of scriptural texts in the New Testament writings.
21. See further Blenkinsopp 2006: 129–168; Hays 2014: 35–53; 2016: 105–190.
22. On the key role that Nathan’s oracle (2 Samuel 7) plays in early Christian “messianic exegesis,” see Juel 1987; cf. *4QFlorilegium* (4Q174) i 1–13.
23. Note the seminal insight of Dodd 1952 that rather than cherry-picking isolated texts, the earliest Christians made sense of Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection against the backdrop of wider passages of scripture. See further Hays 1998, 2016.
24. See n. 8. In controversy with Pharisaic critics (Matt 12:1–8), Jesus appeals to a prophetic text (Hos 6:6) to explicate the true intent of Mosaic legislation regarding the Sabbath (Matt 12:7; cf. 9:13).
25. Matthew organizes the bulk of Jesus’ teaching into five lengthy discourses that recall the five books of Moses. See further Allison 1993.
26. Matt 28:34/Ps 69:22a; Matt 28:35/Ps 22:19; Matt 28:39/Ps 22:8; Matt 28:43/Ps 22:9; Matt 28:46/Ps 22:2; Matt 28:48/Ps 69:22b.
27. See Davis 2014: 207–240 for Isaiah’s far-reaching influence on the vision of Christian discipleship that comes to expression in Matthew’s Sermon on the Mount.
28. The view of prophecy articulated in 1 Peter 1:10–12 has often been compared to *1Q Pesher to Habakkuk* (1QpHab) vii 1–5.
29. Fuller treatments of this complex discourse may be found in Hays 1989; Wagner 2002.
30. See Rom 16:25–26; cf. *1Q Pesher to Habakkuk* (1QpHab) vii 4–5: “. . . the Teacher of Righteousness to whom God made known all the mysteries of the words of his servants the prophets.”

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CHAPTER 22

RABBINIC RECEPTION OF THE PROPHETS

ISAAC B. GOTTLIEB

“RABBINIC reception of the Prophets” implies a unified approach of a particular group. However, the term “rabbinic” covers thousands of individual statements made by named or unnamed rabbis, recorded within a vast literature (Mishnah, Midrash, Talmud) that spans over 750 years (225–1000 C.E.). What is more, these texts are characterized by the exegetical style called the *derasha*, or homily, the teachings of a sage based on his unique interpretation of a biblical verse or verses. For these reasons, statements about prophecy in rabbinic literature may well be the opinion of a single sage or an anonymous editor, rather than a widespread belief. Therefore, gathering hundreds of such remarks would still not amount to a definitive statement about how the rabbis received prophets. Instead, I have tried to select remarks that speak about basic issues and central themes applicable to prophets and prophecy in general, in the hope that they reflect a consensus.

In the study of rabbinic literature, greater importance and authority are generally attached to statements recorded in Mishnah and Talmud. Although Midrash contains much of the information relevant to our subject, we know little about the authorship, dating, and provenance of its individual homilies or collections of homilies. For example, J. D. Eisenstein published two volumes containing 200 small Midrash texts, most of which are relatively late. Nonetheless, Gershon Brin (2006: 418) makes one of these texts (*Midrash Hallel*) his very first source with which to answer the question, what did the prophets see?

(Ps. 103:4)—*His glory is in the heavens*—Did the nations know where the Lord’s glory (*kevodo*) resided? Israel as well would not have known if not for the prophets who taught this to Israel. Micah said, *I saw the Lord seated upon His throne, with all the host of heaven standing in attendance to the right and to the left of Him* (1 K. 22:19 = 2 Ch. 18:18), Ezekiel said, *The heavens opened and I saw visions of God* (Ez. 1:1); Isaiah said, *I beheld my Lord seated on a high and lofty throne, and the skirts of His robe filled the temple* (Is. 6:1); Daniel said, *As I looked on, Thrones were set in place, and the*

Ancient of days took His seat. His garment was like white snow (Dan. 7:9); from all this we learn, that his glory is from (*min*) the heavens.¹

DID THE PROPHETS SEE?

Although Brin (2006) would have it that this passage explains how, in the rabbinic view, prophets envisioned God, in fact it seems to be dealing with the question of locale: Where was the LORD or his *kavod* (meaning “presence”) to be found when the prophets apprehended Him? As to what or whom the prophets actually saw, the following *derasha*, also cited by Brin, more specifically addresses the question:

Said Rabbi Yudan: Great is the power of the prophets that they can compare the image of the Great One above to the image of Man, as it says (Dan. 8:16), *I heard a human voice from the middle of Ulai (River) calling out*. R. Judah son of R. Simon said, it is rather from here (Ez. 1:26): *Upon this semblance of a throne, there was a semblance of a human form* (*Numbers Rabbah* 19, 4).

This is actually a late version (*Numbers Rabbah*, Provence, twelfth century) of a text found in several earlier Midrash works (*Genesis Rabbah* Theodor-Albeck, Genesis 27; *Deuteronomy Rabbah* 1, 3; *Ecclesiastes Rabbah* 2; 8; *Midrash Psalms* 1): “Said R. Yudan: Great is the power of the prophets that they compare the image to its Creator,” citing the verses from Daniel 8 and Ezekiel 1, as in the preceding *derasha*. It is hard to know whether the rabbis believed that the prophets saw the LORD in the form of a man, or whether the prophets were expressing what they saw in human terms. The latter understanding is articulated in one of the sources noted earlier, *Midrash Psalms*:

Hezekiah bar Hiyya taught: Blessed are the prophets, who in figurative language liken the Creator to His creation, and the Planter to His plant. Thus Scripture says, *The Lord God is a sun and a shield*, and again, *The lion hath roared, who will not fear? The Lord God hath spoken, who can but prophesy?* (Amos 3:8), and further: *Behold the glory of the God of Israel came from the way of the east; and His voice was like the sound of many waters; and the earth did shine with His glory* (Ez. 43:2). Thus the Prophets speak to the ear by way of what it can hear, and delight the eye by way of what it can see.²

The different metaphors and similes for God—sun, shield, lion, waters—show that these were figures of speech to express the inexpressible in human terms. The rabbis thus touched upon the nature of prophecy and its literary form. They recognized that each prophet had his own way of expression:

The prophecies of Isaiah son of Amoz (Is. 1:1). This is what the verse means, *I spoke to the prophets, and I granted many visions* (Hos. 12:11). Said the Lord, ‘Of course I spoke

to the prophets, but I granted many visions; the prophecy of one is not like that of another. Amos saw Me standing, as it says, *I saw my Lord standing by the altar* (Amos 9:1); Isaiah saw Me seated, as it says, *I beheld my Lord seated on a high and lofty throne* (Is. 6:1). Moses saw me as a hero, as it says, *The Lord, the Warrior* (Ex. 15:3); Daniel portrayed me as an old man, as it says, *And the hair of His head was like lamb's wool* (Dan. 7:9). Therefore it says, *And through the prophets I am imagined* (Hos. 12:11).³

WHO IS A PROPHET?

The eye is not satisfied with seeing (Ecc. 1:8). Samuel b. Nahman said: All the good things, blessings, and consolations which the prophets beheld in this world were not seen by them for nothing, but in virtue of having meditated and performed precepts and righteous acts. Now if you say that they did see these things, has it not been already stated, *Neither hath the eye seen except Thee, O God* (Is. 64:3)? But if you argue that they did not see them [at all], they surely did see a part, as it is stated, *For the Lord God will do nothing, but He revealeth His counsel unto His servants the prophets* (Amos 3:7). How did they see? As [one peeps] through a crack in the door. (*Ecclesiastes Rabbah*, I.8, 6).⁴

R. Samuel b. Nahman seems skeptical about the ability of prophets to foresee events. On the other hand, he cites scriptural evidence that indeed God reveals his actions to men. His solution sets forth a minimalist view of how the prophets actually saw: as if through a crack in the door. Further, even this limited prophecy was not bestowed arbitrarily, but was earned through the study of Torah (“having meditated”) and performance of the commandments.

The connection between prophecy and the study of Torah is elucidated in the first Mishnah in tractate *Avot*, otherwise known as The Ethics of the Fathers:

Moses received the Torah from Sinai and gave it over to Joshua. Joshua gave it over to the Elders, the Elders to the Prophets, and the Prophets gave it over to the Men of the Great Assembly.

In this view, “the function of the prophet was to bridge the historical gap between the primordial revelation at Sinai and the rabbinic leadership” (Blenkinsopp 1996: 14). Although the function of the prophet as tradent of Torah (i.e., Pentateuchal Law) may seem anachronistic from the critical point of view, Blenkinsopp notes that Wellhausen’s view of Israelite history notwithstanding, “specific prophetic indictments often will be found to correspond to legal stipulations, and verdicts of condemnations to curses attached routinely to ancient law codes. All this has obliged us to reconsider common assumptions about the prophet as radical innovator preaching a radically innovative ethic” (1996: 15). I would note that many interpreters of Mishnah understand the preceding passage as relating to what the rabbis called the Oral Torah, rather than Scriptures, viewing the prophets as a link in the unbroken chain of tradition.⁵

Not only the prophet had to be saintly; Israel had to merit prophecy:

And They Said unto Moses: 'Speak Thou with Us and We will Hear.' This tells that they did not have the strength to receive more than the Ten Commandments, as it is said: *If we hear the voice of the Lord our God any more, then we shall die* (Deut. 5:22). From that time on the Israelites merited that prophets should be raised among them, as it is said: *I will raise thee up a prophet* (Deut. 18:18) . . . but by their merits they brought it about sooner.⁶

PROPHET AS MESSENGER

R. Eleazar taught in the name of R. Jose ben Zimra: None of the prophets, as they uttered their prophecies, knew that they were prophesying, except Moses and Isaiah who did know. . . . R. Joshua the Priest bar Nehemiah maintained that Elihu also prophesied and knew he was prophesying, for he said, *My lips shall utter knowledge clearly* (Job 33:3).⁷

Apparently, some prophets were simply vehicles for transmitting the word of God, while others understood the import of their message. This distinction is made on the basis of *derashot* that revolve around the interpretation of particular words in the verse being cited. Thus, Elihu in the book of Job used the words “knowledge clearly”; therefore he must have understood the content of his prophecy.⁸ What these homilies show us is that R. Jose and R. Joshua thought that some prophets understood and others not at all. Perhaps this distinction is similar to that drawn between ecstatic prophets, whom scholars identify with the pre-Classic seers in the days of Samuel, Elijah, and Elisha, and the Classic prophets from the eighth century onward whose prophecies were preserved. Thus Andersen and Freedman understand that when “Amos insists that he is not a *ben-nabi*,”⁹ this means that he is not of the ecstatic groups, but is rather “the voice of true prophecy.”¹⁰ From the Midrash cited at the beginning of this section, it seems that some of the rabbis also distinguished between seers who passed on prophecy without understanding, and the writing prophets, who interpreted God’s words and presented them in their own style.

PROPHECY AMONG THE GENTILES

This subject is covered admirably by Brin (2006: 422–426), who cites over fifteen midrashic sources. What can we learn from these extensive comments that express various views? It seems that the question of prophecy among the Gentiles was central to rabbinic theology. The notion of reward and punishment and the concept of repentance are closely bound up with the functions of the prophets. It was they who admonished

and chastised, but also they who encouraged their audience to repent. If the nations of the world had no one to reprimand them, could they be held accountable for their sins? How could they repent, if not called upon to do so? Rabbinic reception of the book of Jonah is closely tied to these questions (see further discussion later in this chapter).

On the other hand, some rabbis thought that prophecy was a gift unique to Israel, and to maintain this position the rabbis were willing to challenge the simple meaning of many chapters and verses. Several scholars seem to have been influenced by this rabbinic position; Kaufmann deems the messenger-prophet “a phenomenon peculiar to Israel” (1977: 450). Brin (2006) finds support for the view that prophecy was exclusive to Israel in the Bible itself, as expressed by Amos (2:11): *And I raised up prophets from among your sons and nazirites from among your young men.*¹¹ But Blenkinsopp notes (1996: 41) that “the Hebrew Bible itself attests that prophecy was not confined to Israel,” citing Jeremiah 27:1–15 as proof that Jeremiah spoke to the nations as well.

Did the rabbis believe that there were no prophets from *among* the Gentiles, or that no Israelite prophets were sent *to* the Gentiles? *Sifre Deuteronomy* 175 believes that both statements are correct:

A prophet from the midst of thee—and not from outside the (Holy) Land—of thy brethren—and not from foreigners—will the Lord thy God raise up unto thee (Deut. 18:15)—and not unto the nations. How then am I to obey the command, *I have appointed thee a prophet unto the nations* (Jer. 1:5)? (A prophet) unto those who behave like the nations.¹²

However, the Talmud (*BT Baba Batra* 15b) enumerates heathen prophets and explains:

Seven prophets prophesied to the heathen, namely, Balaam and his father, Job, Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite, Zophar the Naamathite, and Elihu the son of Barachel the Buzite. . . . But did not all the prophets prophesy to the heathen?—Their prophecies were addressed primarily to Israel, but these addressed themselves primarily to the heathen.

The identical enumeration of foreign prophets appears in *Seder Olam* chapter 21 as well.¹³ However, it limits prophecy among the nations to the period before the giving of the Torah, after which prophecy was found exclusively among the Israelites.

In line with the opening sentences of this chapter, the preceding sources present a fine example of independent and contradictory views as expressed in different parts of rabbinic literature regarding the nature of prophecy.

PROPHECY OUTSIDE THE LAND OF ISRAEL

R. Abba then opened [his funerary address for Rav Huna]: “Our Master [said he] was worthy that the *Shechinah* (Holy Spirit, i.e. prophecy) should abide with him,

but [the fact of his being in] Babylon prevented it.” Thereupon R. Nahman, son of R. Hisda—some say it was R. Hanan, son of R. Hisda—referred to [the text]: *The word of the Lord came expressly unto Ezekiel the priest, the son of Buzi in the land of the Chaldeans by the river Chebar* (Ez. 1:3). His father tapped him with his sandal, saying to him: “Have I not told you not to worry everybody [with this point]? What is meant by the [double expression] ‘Hayoh [hayah]’? That it had been [had come] before [he came to Babylon].”¹⁴

Further expression of this idea, that there is no prophecy outside the land because the Holy Spirit that enables prophecy does not dwell there, is found in the following:

Jonah said: ‘I will go outside the Land of Israel, to a place where the Divine Presence is not revealed, so as not to render Israel guilty, because the Gentiles are quick to repent.’ (*Mekhilta de-Rabbi Ishmael, Masekhta de-Pisha*, ch. 1, pp. 3–4)

THE ORDER OF PROPHETS

Seder Olam Rabbah, or *Seder Olam*, is a chronology detailing the dates of biblical events from the Creation to Alexander the Great. Traditionally it is attributed to R. Yose ben Halafta of the Tannaitic period (about 160 C.E.). According to *Seder Olam* chapter 20, Isaiah, Hosea, Amos, and Micah all prophesied during the same period of time. This is derived primarily from the names of the same kings cited at the beginning of each book, during whose reign they all prophesied, and from mention of an earthquake that occurred two years after Amos began prophesying in the days of King Uzziah (Amos 1:1). That the earthquake itself took place in Uzziah’s time (eighth century B.C.E.) we know from a verse in Zechariah (14:5): “And the Valley in the Hills shall be stopped up . . . as it was stopped up as a result of the earthquake in the days of King Uzziah of Judah.” The rabbis thought that Isaiah gave his first prophecy on the day of the earthquake itself (Isa 6:1, 4), while Micah preached during the reigns of later kings. All these calculations result in the following chronological order: Hosea, Amos, Isaiah, and Micah.¹⁵ That is to say, Hosea prophesied first in this group, and Micah last. However, the actual order of the prophetic books as found in the Masoretic Hebrew Bible today is Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi.

According to *Seder Olam*, the prophecies of Obadiah were given in the time of Amaziah, King of Judah, and those of Joel, Nahum, and Habakkuk in the reign of Manasseh (seventh century B.C.E.), “But because Manasseh was evil, these prophets make no reference to him.”¹⁶ Zephaniah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel are all identified with the age of the Destruction of the Temple (Guggenheimer 1998: 178). Daniel is apparently recognized by *Seder Olam* as a prophet, for it classes him together with Baruch ben Neriah as prophesying in the time of Nebuchadnezzar (Guggenheimer 1998: 178).

Finally, Haggai, Zachariah, and Malachi were all prophets in the second year of Darius, the Persian king.¹⁷ However, the spirit of prophecy continued until the arrival of Alexander the Great (see further discussion later in this chapter, in the section “The End of Prophecy”).

Seder Olam is a Midrash; the most significant Talmudic text in rabbinic literature for information about Prophets is *BT Bava Batra* 14b–15b. Regarding the order of the prophetic books, the Talmud there says,

The order of the prophets: Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Isaiah, and the Twelve. Let us see: Hosea came first, as it is written, *When the Lord first spoke to Hosea, the Lord said to Hosea go get yourself a wife*. . . . (Hos. 1:2). Was it with Hosea that He spoke to first? Were there not many prophets between Moses and Hosea? Said R. Yohanan, Hosea was the first of the four prophets who prophesied during that particular era. These were: Hosea, Isaiah, Amos, and Micah. If this is the chronology, let Hosea be moved forward to precede Isaiah? Since Hosea’s prophecy was written down at the same time as Haggai, Zecharia, and Malachi, and these three were the last of the prophets, Hosea’s prophecy is included with their prophecies in the final book of Prophets.

But let the book of Hosea be written as a separate book, and moved forward [before Isaiah]? Since the book of Hosea is short, the Sages feared it would be lost if it were written separately.

The Talmud (*BT Bava Batra* 15a) goes on to record who “wrote” each biblical book (*u-mi ketavan*). The sense of the verb *katab* here is “arranged” or “edited.” Regarding the Twelve Minor Prophets, the Talmud says that these, together with Ezekiel, Daniel, and The Scroll of Esther, were arranged by the Men of the Great Assembly. In rabbinic historiography, this body of Sages followed the period of the *Soferim* or Scribes, a yet earlier judicial body, of which Ezra the Scribe was a member. All the books mentioned as edited or arranged by the Men of the Great Assembly must therefore be post-exilic in their current shape.

REBUKE AND CONSOLATION

Rashi (Ex 7:1) notes that “every expression relating to the word ‘prophecy’ (*leshon nevu’ah*) denotes a person who announces and proclaims to the people words of rebuke.” While Rashi (1040–1105) was a medieval commentator, no doubt he is expressing the spirit of earlier rabbinic ideas; indeed, the role of rebuke in prophecy concerns many a rabbinic statement.

For example, *Sifre Deuteronomy* 342 is an unusually lengthy piece that speaks of prophecy from Moses through Hosea, Joel, Amos, Micah, and Jeremiah. Its theme is as follows: “Since Moses had earlier spoken harsh words to Israel (e.g., the *Song* in Deut. 32; Deut. 9), he now spoke words of comfort to them” (Deut. 33, *This Is the Blessing*). “And

from Moses did all the prophets learn to first utter harsh words, then to return and comfort them.” Hosea is then singled out as “the prophet who said the most difficult things to Israel,” but who ended with warm words of consolation. It may be of interest to note that there are about 750 *derashot* on the book of Hosea, and the second most popular topic among them is consolation; the rabbis in their homilies could find words of comfort in Hosea even when the verse itself, read simply, was clearly a reprimand.¹⁸

Sifre Deuteronomy proves its point from six different prophets, concluding with Jeremiah. It then poses the following question: Perhaps after words of consolation, the prophet returned to reprimand the people? This is shown to be false, based on Jeremiah 51:64:

*And say, ‘Thus shall Babylon sink and never rise again, because of the disaster that I will bring upon it.’ . . . Thus far the words of Jeremiah. Say then, once the prophets speak to them with words of comfort, they do not return to utter reprimands.*¹⁹

However, in a parallel Midrash, R. Eleazar expressed the opposite view, that Jeremiah in fact ended with rebuke and chastisement, by understanding that the fall of Babylon was a bad thing.²⁰ I will have more to say about the organization of prophecy around rebuke and consolation, as I discuss rabbinic perceptions of prophecy for individual prophets, following the order of the Masoretic Hebrew Bible: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi. Note that not every prophet is dealt with, only those for whom a rabbinic comment of general value can be found.

ISAIAH

The rabbis thought Isaiah to be the greatest among the prophets, comparable only to Moses (see earlier discussion under “Prophet as Messenger”). They said that he was born circumcised (*Shoher Tov* 9, 7), which seems to indicate a level of perfection, being whole and complete from the beginning. He is said to have lived one hundred and twenty years (*Aggadat Bereshit* 14), like Moses, and like Moses, he called himself *‘eved*, a servant of the LORD, and the LORD in turn called him “servant” as well (*Sifre Deuteronomy* 27). “All that Ezekiel saw in his visions, Isaiah already had seen before him” (*BT Hagigah* 13b). However, the descriptions in Ezekiel are more ecstatic, as he was like a country boy who saw the king, while Isaiah, more placid in his descriptions, was likened to a city dweller.²¹ He is said to have reduced Judaism to two commandments: “Thus said the LORD: Observe what is right and do what is just” (Isa 56:1).²²

Isaiah prophesied more than all the other prophets, and in addition he prophesied to all the nations of the world. At the conclusion of two quite lengthy homilies about Isaiah, parallel in content but differing in language, we read: “Why was Isaiah fit for all this praise and honor? Because he justified Israel and always sought to defend them”

(*Midrash Rabbah Leviticus*, Soncino edition, chapter X 1–2, pp. 121–123; *Pesikta Rabbati* 33, *Anokhi Anokhi*). Defending the Israelites before God, despite having told them their sins, is what the rabbis sought in each prophet. Where they did not find this behavior, they took the prophet to task (see later discussion under “Hosea”). The rabbis appreciated a prophet who hated rebuke and loved consolation. In fact, the final lines of this Midrash observe that Isaiah’s style favored repeating words of consolation:

Whereas all prophets prophesied single words of comfort, thou shalt double words of cheer: for instance, *Awake, awake* (51:9); *Bestir thyself, bestir thyself* (51:17); *Rejoice, yea I will rejoice* (61:10); *I, even I, am He that comforteth you* (51:12), *Comfort ye, comfort ye, my people* (40:1).²³

It therefore comes as no surprise that in rabbinic homilies (*derashot*) on the book of Hosea, the verses most quoted besides Hosea are from Isaiah and Psalms, which indicates the popularity of these two books as a source for homilies—one reason being the language of love and consolation in Isaiah.²⁴

JEREMIAH

The Talmud (*BT Baba Batra* 15a) makes him the redactor of his own book and the books of Kings and Lamentations. He is one of eight prophets who were priests and were descended from Rahab the harlot. In addition, he was born circumcised, as it is written: (Jer 1:5) “Before I created you in the womb, I selected you; Before you were born I consecrated you.” He is compared to Job, because both cursed the day they were born (Job 3:3; Jer 20:14). The reason Jeremiah did so is because he prophesied only bad for Israel when in fact he wanted, like all other prophets, to be the bearer of good tidings as well.²⁵ He prophesied together with Zephaniah and the prophetess Huldah. Jeremiah addressed crowds in the marketplace, Zephaniah spoke in the synagogues, and Huldah spoke to the women.²⁶ The rabbis applied Proverbs 9:7 to Jeremiah:

To correct a scoffer or rebuke a wicked man for his blemish, is to call down abuse on oneself. “A corrector” is Jeremiah, “a scoffer” is his generation; he calls down abuse on himself, for he used to chastise Israel, telling them *eicha* (Woe).²⁷

The Talmudic order of biblical books places Jeremiah first, followed by Ezekiel and Isaiah.²⁸ Knowing that Isaiah was the earliest of the three, the Talmud inquires why Isaiah was not first. The answer given is that the book of Kings ends with the destruction of Jerusalem, and Jeremiah is completely about destruction, so they were juxtaposed. It should be noted that this gloomy description of Jeremiah is contradicted by *Sifre Deuteronomy* (see earlier discussion under “Rebuke and Consolation”). Ezekiel is next because it opens with the Destruction but ends with consolation, and Isaiah follows

because it is completely a book of consolation. In this way, destruction was connected to destruction and consolation to consolation. Clearly the rabbis understood that the order of prophets was primarily, but not only, chronological; it was also topical or associative. A major topic was the balance between rebuke and consolation in each prophet; this was the scale on which the rabbis weighed all prophecy, as the following Midrash shows.

In a lengthy piece in *Midrash Lamentations Rabbah*, the rabbis noted that while Jeremiah was full of harsh prophecies, Isaiah, though earlier, had already provided the antidote for them, by reciting a prophecy of consolation that included the very same words used by Jeremiah, albeit in an opposite sense. Having opened with the theme sentence, “Because the people of Israel sinned from A to Z (*me-alef ad tav*), they were consoled from A to Z,” the Midrash presents a verse of criticism from Jeremiah that begins with *aleph* and matches it with a verse of consolation from Isaiah beginning with the very same letter, now found in a context of consolation rather than doom.²⁹ In this way the poet goes through the entire alphabet.

In *Midrash Tannaim* on Deuteronomy 18, Jeremiah is compared to Moses. Each prophesied for forty years, each spoke to both Judah and Israel, both suffered the scorn of their own tribesmen, one was thrown into the Nile, the other into a well, one came with words of admonition and the other in similar fashion. There was, however, one difference: Moses spoke with the LORD face to face, whereas God spoke to other prophets, including Jeremiah, by placing His words in their mouths (Deut 18:18): “I will raise up a prophet for them. . . I will put My words in his mouth.”

EZEKIEL

The differences between ritual law in Ezekiel and the laws in the Torah, specifically in Leviticus, were a major subject for the rabbis. After all, it was their belief that the entire Bible had no contradictions:

Rab Judah said in Rab's name: In truth, that man, Hananiah son of Hezekiah by name, is to be remembered for blessing. But for him, the Book of Ezekiel would have been placed in the Genizah [literally 'hidden,' i.e. excluded from the canon], for its words contradicted the Torah. What did he do? Three hundred barrels of oil were taken up to him, and he sat in an upper chamber and reconciled the differences (*BT Shabbat* 13b).

However, we have no record of how he reconciled the contradictions or how he sustained himself on oil alone.³⁰ In *BT Menahot* 45a, the rabbis cited the following contradiction: Ezekiel 45:18 reads, “Thus saith the Lord GOD: In the first month, in the first day of the month, thou shalt take a young bullock without blemish; and thou shalt purify the sanctuary. And the priest shall take of the blood of the sin-offering (*hatat*),” whereas in Numbers 28:11 the offering for the new moon is called an *olah* (whole offering).

According to the proposed answers, the rabbis took three approaches, all of which assumed that Ezekiel's words did not contradict the laws of Torah. First, they admitted that they had no resolution for the problem at the present time and hoped for a future explanation. Second, the sacrifices in Ezekiel were specifically for the inculcation of the Second Temple in the days of Ezra and were not intended to replace the regular offerings in Leviticus and Numbers. Third, Ezekiel was interpreting the Torah laws, not changing them.³¹

Another focus of rabbinic attention in Ezekiel was the prophecy of the Dry Bones (Ezek 37:1–14). Was this a vision of the prophet, or did all that he described actually take place? Second, what was the meaning of the prophecy or the event? Was it symbolic, or are we to take it literally, meaning that the dead arose from their graves? These questions were a matter of debate early on, between tannaitic rabbis in the first and second centuries C.E. Some thought that the dead stood on their feet, recited praise, and then died. Others thought that they indeed went back to the Land of Israel, where they married and had children. “R. Judah son of Beteira stood on his feet and declared: ‘I am one of their children’s children’” (*BT Sanhedrin* 92b). However, R. Judah ben Ilai (*BT Sanhedrin* 92b) stated that this chapter was a *mashal*, or example. What the example stood for—whether resurrection of the dead in the future or the nation rising up and leaving Babylonia—is not stated.³² The tannaitic debate between symbolic versus literal interpretation was continued by the medieval Jewish exegetes, and doubtless the question was relevant to many other prophecies as well.

MINOR PROPHETS

The name “Minor Prophets” does not refer to the stature of its authors. Latin *minor* means “smaller in length.” Out of fear that such small compositions, if written individually on scrolls, would be lost (see earlier discussion under “The Order of Prophets”), all twelve books were written on a single parchment scroll.³³ The Aramaic/Hebrew name for this book—it is counted as one book among the twenty-four in the Masoretic Bible—is *The Twelve* (*tre asar/shnem asar*).

Hosea

A large number of rabbinic *derashot* on this book try to defend Israel against its detractors, one of whom was the prophet himself. So, for example, the homilies in the first two chapters punish Hosea for speaking harshly about the people of Israel instead of rising to their defense. Hosea's marriage, which looks like a prophetic parable or metaphor of rebuke to the House of Israel, becomes in the eyes of the rabbis a personal punishment for the prophet for failing to stand up on behalf of his people. The rabbis understood that Hosea wanted God to send away His wife, as it were, the community of Israel (*Knesset Yisrael*),

as punishment for their iniquities. The prophet was therefore punished measure for measure, when he was commanded to take a wife, bear children with her, and then divorce her against his will. This explanation is laid out in *BT Pesahim* 87b (Soncino translation).

This theme is even used to explain a major difficulty in Hosea: How is it that chapter 2 opens with the words, “The number of the people of Israel shall be like that of the sands of the sea” (2:1), when chapter 1 was entirely severe chastisement?

The Holy One, blessed be He, said to Hosea, ‘Thy children have sinned,’ to which he should have replied: ‘They are Thy children, they are the children of Thy favored ones, they are the children of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob; extend Thy mercy to them.’ Not enough that he did not say thus, but he said to Him: ‘Sovereign of the Universe! The whole world is Thine; exchange them for a different nation.’ Said the Holy One, blessed be He, ‘What shall I do with this old man? I will order him: *Go and marry a harlot and beget thee children of harlotry* (Hos. 12); and then I will order him: *Send her away from thy presence*. If he will be able to send [her] away, so will I too send Israel away. . . .

As soon as he perceived that he had sinned, he arose to supplicate mercy for himself. Said the Holy One, blessed be He, to him: ‘Instead of supplicating mercy for thyself, supplicate mercy for Israel, against whom I have decreed three decrees because of thee.’ . . . [Thereupon] he arose and begged for mercy, and He annulled the decree[s]. Then He began to bless them, as it is said (Hos. 2:1): *Yet the number of the children of Israel shall be as the sand of the sea . . . and it shall come to pass that, instead of that it which was said unto them: Ye are not My people,’ it shall be said unto them: Ye are the children of the living God.’ And the children of Judah and the children of Israel shall be gathered together* (Ibid., 2) . . . *And I will sow her unto Me in the land; and I will have compassion upon her that hath not obtained compassion; and I will say to them that were not My people: ‘Thou art My people. . . .* (Ibid., 25).

Joel

The prophecies of Joel, Nahum, and Habakkuk were given in the reign of Manasseh (seventh century B.C.E.), “but because Manasseh was evil, these prophets make no reference to him.”³⁴ Joel, the second of the Minor Prophets, offers no clue as to his time. *Seder Olam* places him in the reign of Amaziah in the seventh century B.C.E. The Talmud says that Joel was edited in the Second Temple period, which might mean that it is a post-exilic work, as indeed are all the others mentioned in the same breath (see earlier discussion under “The Order of Prophets”).

A verse from Joel is found in *Mishnah Ta’anit* 2, 1:

What is the order of service on a fast? They carry the ark out to the open area of the town, and they place burnt ashes on the ark, and on the head of the *Nasi*, and on the head of the president of the court; and everyone else puts ashes on his head.

The elder among them says before them words of admonition: Our brothers, it is not said about the people of Nineveh: And God saw their sack cloth and their

fast, but rather: *And God saw their deeds, that they had returned from their evil way* (Jonah 3:10); and in the prophets it says: *And rend your heart, and not your garments* (Joel 2:13).

No doubt the rabbis saw in Joel a paradigm for the service on fast days, based on the fact that he too called for just such an observance: “Solemnize a fast, proclaim an assembly, gather the elders—all the inhabitants of the land—in the House of the LORD your God, and cry out to the LORD” (Joel 1:14). Joel called for a day of mourning, fasting, and prayer in the wake of a severe plague of locusts and subsequent famine. Some rabbinic sources maintained that Joel’s prophecy about an attack of locusts was to be read as an allegory: locusts stood for Israel’s enemies. This line of interpretation is found in the Aramaic *Targum Jonathan* and was later adapted by Isaac Abravanel (fifteenth-century Portugal, Spain). Perhaps the allegorical reading served to introduce one of the classic subjects of biblical prophecy, rebuke to the nations, as we do not find in Joel the usual rebuke to Israel for their sins.

Amos

The rabbinical order of the Twelve places Amos chronologically right after Hosea, though in fact the order of the books in MT is Hosea, Joel, Amos, but some modern scholars see Amos as the earliest of all the writing prophets.³⁵ The Septuagint arrangement is Hosea, Amos, and Micah, based on the size of each in descending order.

The rabbis in the Talmud deal with an exegetical crux in Amos: the same expression is repeated eight times, in prophecies to Damascus, Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab, Judah, and Israel. Here is the earliest occurrence (Amos 1:3): “Thus said the LORD: For three transgressions of Damascus, and for four, I will not revoke it.”

What is the meaning of this conceit? *BT Yoma* 86b understood it to mean that the LORD was prepared to forgive the first three iniquities, but the fourth was the straw that broke the camel’s back. This sense was adopted by many of the medieval commentators, such as Rashi, R. Joseph Qara, and David Qimḥi.

Obadiah

The rabbis feared (*BT Bava Batra* 14b) that a small book written on an individual parchment might get lost. Because Obadiah has only 21 verses, they included it in the Twelve Minor Prophets. The rabbis identified Obadiah with Obadyahu, in charge of King Ahab’s household. Midrash tends to identify unknown biblical characters with more famous ones, and in this light our prophet was identified with the story in Kings.³⁶ “Said R. Isaac: Why did Obadyahu merit prophecy? Because he hid one hundred prophets in a cave (1K 18:4).”³⁷ There is, however, no support for this identification in the text of Obadiah itself.

Seder Olam chapter 20, lines 11–12, has a different dating. *We have received tidings from the Lord . . . “Up! Let us rise up against her for battle”* (Ob. 1:1). When did this war [against Edom] take place? In the days of Jehoshaphat (c. 870–848 B.C.E.), as it is written, *There is no king in Edom* (1K 22:48).³⁸ Rashi cites both rabbinic views, while Ibn Ezra (1089–1164) writes that “we do not know when he (Obadiah) lived.” However, he deduces from verse 10 onward (“For the outrage to your brother Jacob”) that “this prophecy about Edom [was said] after the exile of Jerusalem to Babylonia.”

Jonah

If the placement of this book in the group of The Twelve is considered to be part and parcel of its reception by the rabbis (according to *BT Bava Batra* 15a, the Minor Prophets were arranged by the Men of the Great Assembly), then we may conclude that though the book takes the literary form of a narrative and one of its four chapters is a psalm of thanksgiving, the rabbis understood the work to be prophetic. Uriel Simon has made rabbinic ideas about Jonah, which we summarize in the following, the cornerstone of his introduction and commentary.³⁹ Indeed, more than any other of the Minor Prophets, the book deals with subjects central to rabbinic Judaism.

One such idea is that Jonah comes to teach the power of repentance and its ability to nullify a divine decree. For this reason, a verse from the book is included in the Mishnaic service for fast days (see earlier discussion under “Joel”), for the people of Nineveh indeed fasted, prayed, and abandoned their sinful ways. Further, the entire book was ordained in the Talmud as the *haftara* reading (liturgical reading of Prophets) for the Day of Atonement, which shows that the rabbis thought *teshuvah* (repentance) to be its dominant theme.

Another rabbinic view is that the book comes to teach that prophetic universalism is preferable to Jewish particularism; Jonah was wrong in trying to avoid his mission to Nineveh, lest the reaction of its people reflect badly upon the Israelites, who were not so quick to repent as were the Assyrian Gentiles. To combat such reasoning, all the “good” characters in the book—the people of Nineveh and the sailors—are Gentiles, representatives of many nations and beliefs.⁴⁰ Jonah’s error is cited in the Midrash:

Jonah said, ‘I will go outside the Land of Israel, to a place where the Divine Presence is not revealed, so as not to render Israel guilty, because the Gentiles are quick to repent.’ (*Mekhilta de-Rabbi Ishmael, Masekhta de-Pisha*, ch. 1, pp. 3–4)

Another rabbinic view sees Jonah’s attempt to flee as an effort to preserve the truth of prophecy and his personal standing as a prophet, opposed to the concept of God as merciful and forgiving. To this end, the Midrash constructed a hypothetical event:

Why did he run away? The first time, God sent him to restore the territory of Israel and His word was fulfilled (2 Kgs 14:25). . . . The second time, He sent him to

Jerusalem to destroy it. Because the people repented, the Holy One Blessed be He acted in accordance with His great mercy . . . and did not destroy it. The third time, he sent him to Nineveh. Jonah reasoned with himself, saying: I know that this nation is quick to repent. . . . Is it not enough that Israel calls me a false prophet, but idol-worshippers will do so as well! I shall run away instead. . . . (*Pirke de-Rabbi Eliezer* 10)

A fourth view sees Jonah as coming to argue on behalf of strict justice (*middat ha-din*) and against compassion and mercy (*middat ha-rahamim*). To counter this approach, Jonah is rescued by the whale and later made to suffer by the withering of the plant that saved him from the heat of the sun. Both incidents come to teach him that the world cannot survive if conducted in accord with the full severity of the law. To this end, the rabbis provided Jonah's response to the final rhetorical question with which the book ends:

Then the Lord said: *You cared about the plant, which you did not work for and which you did not grow . . . and should I not care about Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than twelve myriad persons who do not yet know their right hand from their left, and many beasts as well?* (Jon 4:11)

Then he fell on his face and said: "Conduct your world according to the attribute of mercy, as it is written: *To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness*" (Dan 9:9).⁴¹

Although the rabbis took the story of the fish that swallowed Jonah to be true—later rationalist commentators saw it as a prophetic vision or dream—the Midrash already made allowance for this miracle to have been considered part of nature: "R. Jonathan said: the Holy One Blessed be He stipulated with the sea that it would split before Israel. . . . R. Jeremiah son of Eleazar said: The Holy One Blessed be He made such a condition not only with the sea, but with everything that was made during the six days of creation. . . . 'I commanded the ravens to feed Elijah . . . and the fish to vomit forth Jonah'" (*Genesis Rabbah* 5, 5).

Micah

The final verses of Micah (7:18–20) speak of God's mercy in forgiving Israel's sins:

Who is a God like you, forgiving iniquity and remitting transgression; Who has not maintained His wrath forever against the remnant of His own people, Because he loves graciousness! He will take us back in love; he will cover up our iniquities, You will hurl all our sins into the depths of the sea. You will keep faith with Jacob, loyalty to Abraham, as you promised on oath to our fathers in days gone by. (Mic 7:18–20)

As this is a central idea in rabbinic Judaism (see previous discussion under "Jonah"), these verses were appended to the *haftara* reading (a reading of Prophets in the synagogue) on the Sabbath between *Rosh Hashanah* (New Year) and *Yom Kippur*. First the final chapter of Hosea is read, and then the three verses from Micah. They are also

recited in the *tashlikh* ceremony on *Rosh Hashanah*, in which sins are “cast off” into the water. These customs show that the Rabbis considered repentance and the LORD’s response of loving kindness to be major themes in the prophets.

THE END OF PROPHECY

Brin states (2006: 417) that the rabbis believed that prophecy ceased at the beginning of the Persian period. He is most probably basing his claim on *Tosefta Sotah* 13; *BT Sota* 48b; *BT Yoma* 9b: “After the last prophets, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, died, the spirit of prophecy [*ruah ha-qodesh*] departed from Israel” (*BT Yoma* 9b). Kaufmann deduces from this statement that “the end of the Persian period, therefore, is the end of prophecy, and the beginning of the Greek kingdom is the beginning of the wisdom period” (1977: 481 n. 2). However, if we take into account those sources that count Daniel as a prophet, prophecy extended past the Restoration Age into the Second Temple period. This is supported by *Seder Olam*, chapter 30:

And the hairy he-goat is the king of Greece (Dan. 8:21)—that is Alexander of Macedonia—until that time the prophets prophesied by the Holy Spirit. But thereafter, *Incline thine ear and hear the words of the wise* (Prov. 22:17).

R. Abdimi from Haifa said: Since the day when the Temple was destroyed, prophecy has been taken from the prophets and given to the wise. Is then a wise man not also a prophet?—What he meant was this: Although it has been taken from the prophets, it has not been taken from the wise.

Amemar said: A wise man is even superior to a prophet, as it says, *And a prophet has a heart of Wisdom* (Ps. 90:12). Who is compared with whom? Is not the smaller compared with the greater?

R. Johanan said: Since the Temple was destroyed prophecy has been taken from prophets and given to fools and children.

Whatever the import of each of these sayings in *BT Bava Batra* 12b, clearly R. Abdimi and R. Johanan agree that prophecy extended past the Persian period, though according to R. Johanan it might have ended with the destruction of the Second Temple.

PROPHECY FOR ONE AND ALL

Despite the preceding *derashot*, the rabbis believed that prophecy would one day become the legacy of all:

Said the Lord: In this world, only individuals prophesied. But in the World to Come, all of Israel will become prophets, as it is written, *After that, I will pour out My*

spirit on all flesh; Your sons and daughters shall prophesy, etc. (Joel 3:1). (*Tanhuma Beha'alotekha* 17)

A further expression of this belief is to be found in *Aggadat Bereshit* 68:

In this world, the prophets prophesy: This one says, *I saw the Lord on the altar*, as it is written: *I saw my Lord standing by the altar* (Amos 9:1). Ezekiel said: *The word of the Lord came . . . by the Chebar Canal* (Ez. 1:3). Amos said, *[I saw the Lord] on top of a wall*, as it is written: *He was standing on a wall checked with plumb line* (Amos 7:7), *Haggai the prophet . . . prophesied to the Jews in Judah and Jerusalem* (Ezra 5:1). But in the future, [everyone] will see Him, as it says: *The Presence of the Lord shall appear, and all flesh, as one, shall behold for the Lord Himself has spoken* (Is. 40:5).

NOTES

1. Eisenstein 1905: Vol. 1, 128a. Brin notes that the Septuagint and Vulgate, like this Midrash, included Daniel in the section of Prophets. See also Qumran 4Q Flor II:3 אשר כתוב בספר דניאל הנביא "which is written in the book of Daniel the prophet" (2006: 383). Kaufmann adopts the traditional view: "Even the book of Daniel, though received into the canon, remained outside the corpus of the prophets" (1977: 473). See, however, the next citation of Daniel 8:16.
2. *The Midrash on Psalms*, trans. William G. Braude (Vol. I; New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1959), 6.
3. *Aggadat Bereshit*, ed. Solomon Buber (Krakow: Josef Fischer, 1903), ch. 14; for a slightly different translation, see Lieve M. Teugels, *Aggadat Bereshit Translated from the Hebrew with an Introduction and Notes* (Leiden: Brill, 2001), 45.
4. *Midrash Rabbah Ecclesiastes*, trans. A. Cohen (London: Soncino Press, 1939), 30.
5. Note Blenkinsopp's remarks about oral and written law (1996: 17).
6. For Moses was a prophet who preceded Deuteronomy. *Mekhilta Bahodesh* 9 on Exodus 20:16, *Mekhilta De-Rabbi Ishmael* (Vol. 2, trans. Jacob Z. Lauterbach; Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 2004), 341.
7. Braude, *Midrash on Psalms*, 90, 4.
8. Brin, *Studies*, 421.
9. Francis I. Andersen and David Noel Freedman, *Amos: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary* (AB 24A; New York: Doubleday, 1989), 332.
10. Andersen and Freedman, *Amos*, 332.
11. Brin, *Studies*, makes this point twice (417, 424), yet I could find no commentators on Amos who thought that this verse implied that there was no prophecy among the nations.
12. But in fact are Jews. *Sifre: A Tannaitic Commentary on the Book of Deuteronomy*, trans. Reuven Hammer (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1986), 202.
13. See Guggenheimer 1998; cf. "The Order of Prophets" in the following discussion.
14. Ezekiel 1:3 reads, "The word of the LORD came," the Hebrew being *hayoh hayah*, which is taken to be a pluperfect with the sense, "The word . . . had already come to Ezekiel in the Land of Israel" (i.e., Ezekiel received prophecy in Israel before he went down to Babylon). The source of this story is *BT Mo'ed Katan* 25a in the Soncino translation.

15. Hosea has pride of place because “the LORD first spoke to Hosea” (Hos 1:2). See *BT Pesahim* 87a.
16. Guggenheimer 1998: 172 (Obadiah), 176 (Joel, Nahum, Habakkuk). “In all Ashkenazic manuscripts one reads ‘in the days of Jehoshaphat’ instead of ‘in the days of Amaziah’” (172). In European manuscripts, Joel is not listed (177 n. 7). Regarding Joel, Rashi cites three traditions about when he lived, which means that Rashi did not have “Joel” in his copy of *Seder Olam* either.
17. Guggenheimer 1998: 178. Jonah is the only one of the Minor Prophets not mentioned in this chapter. In ch. 18 he is made to be a contemporary of Elisha and in ch. 19 he is said to have prophesied to Jehu, king of Israel (Samaria).
18. See numerous examples in Ben-Yashar, Gottlieb, and Penkower 2003.
19. Jeremiah 51:64 prophesies the fall of Babylon, definitely a vision of consolation. This is reckoned to be the last verse of the prophet, as chapter 52 is but a variant of 2 Kings 24–25.
20. *Pesikta de-Rab Kahana* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1975), Piska 13, 264.
21. Who presumably saw the king more frequently.
22. *BT Makkot* 24a.
23. *Midrash Rabbah Leviticus*, 123.
24. See Ben-Yashar, Gottlieb, and Penkower 2003.
25. *Pesikta de-Rab Kahana*, Piska 13, 263; *Pesikta Rabbati* (Ish Shalom), 26.
26. *Ibid.*
27. *Lamentations Rabbah*, Introduction (Petihta).
28. *BT Bava Batra* 14b. The MT order is Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel.
29. Where he could not come up with a consolation beginning with the same letter, he used one of the words from Jeremiah’s prophecies of doom, or else a word that was the antonym of Jeremiah’s key word.
30. Rashi (*BT Shabbat* 13b) explains that the oil was to light his lamp so that he could read the texts and for sustenance.
31. Rimon Kasher, *Ezekiel: Introduction and Commentary, Mikra Leyisra’el* (Tel Aviv: Am Oved, 2004), Vol. 2: 898–899 (Heb.).
32. Kasher, *Ezekiel*, Vol. 2: 721–722.
33. It seems that the order of Hosea, Amos, Micah, and Joel in the Septuagint is also based on relative length, from longest to shortest.
34. *Pesikta de-Rab Kahana* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1975), Piska 13, 264.
35. Shalom M. Paul, *Amos: Introduction and Commentary, Mikra Leyisra’el* (Tel Aviv: Am Oved, 1994), 3–4 (Heb.).
36. See Cogan 1992: 3.
37. *BT Sanhedrin*, 39a.
38. Guggenheimer 1998: 172. This is the version found in all Ashkenazic mss of *Seder Olam*. However, Oriental and Sephardic mss read, “in the days of Amaziah,” but then the verse from 1 Kings 22:48 makes no sense, because no king of Edom is mentioned in Amaziah’s war.
39. See Simon 1999.
40. “Hardly any Jewish Bible scholar still adheres to this exegetical line, but it remains attractive to most Christian scholars” (Simon 1999: ix).
41. *Midrash Jonah* (*MS de Rossi* 563), in Chaim M. Horowitz, *Sammlung Kleiner Midraschim* (Berlin, 1881), 35.

FOR FURTHER READING

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CHAPTER 23

EARLY CHRISTIAN RECEPTION OF THE PROPHETS

RONALD E. HEINE

THERE was no acceptable early Christian understanding of Jesus of Nazareth without a dependence on the Hebrew prophets. Marcion, who attempted to depict Jesus without the prophets in the mid-second century, was abruptly dismissed from the church as a heretic. Others, labeled Gnostics, also presented descriptions of Jesus devoid of a dependence on the prophets, but they too suffered Marcion's fate. Origen expressed well the early Christian mind when he suggested that the message of Christ must be accompanied by that of the prophets who prepared his way (*Hom. I Reg.* 28, 7).

The Pauline letters, the earliest Christian literature, join the prophets with the essentials of the message about Jesus (Rom 1:2; 9:32–33; 1 Cor 15:3–4). The proclamations about Jesus in the Acts of the Apostles are laced with references to the prophets (Acts 4:11; 8:32–35; 10:43; 13:27). The Lukan tradition indicates that Jesus himself had made this connection (Luke 24:25–27). Skarsaune has argued that the mid-second-century Christian, Justin, understood his interpretation of the prophetic Scriptures to be in the direct line of the interpretation that the apostles had learned from Christ (1987: 11–13).

Justin attributed his conversion to Christianity to learning about the Hebrew prophets (*Dial.* 7–8). A central argument for the Christian faith in his *1 Apology* is based largely on the prophets. The trustworthiness of the prophetic message about Jesus was confirmed for him by the predictions about the desolation of Jerusalem and the conversion of Gentiles. Evidence of both was readily available in his day. This verification gave credence, he thought, to those passages that spoke of things related to Jesus and the events of his life that could not be verified. In his conclusion to the presentation of the prophetic testimony to Jesus, he says that it was these visible confirmations that convinced Christians that Jesus of Nazareth was the Son of God (*1 Apol.* 30, 53). The testimony of the Hebrew prophets was essential to the earliest Christian understanding of who Jesus of Nazareth was.

I am omitting a discussion of the “proof from prophecy” argument that was widely used in the early Christian centuries from the middle of the second century until well into the fourth century because this topic has been treated adequately in many studies that are readily available (see Albl 1999; Heine 2007; Prigent 1961; Skarsaune 1987; Ungern-Sternberg 1913). In the following sections I will argue, first, that the church of the second century was influenced by the reading practice of the synagogue in its reading and exposition of the Hebrew prophets, and that this reading and exposition was not exclusively apologetic in its orientation. I will then turn to the third and fourth centuries and show that Christians in these centuries saw Christ as the key to the unity between the prophets and the Gospel. Finally, I will look at how four Christian authors of the third and fourth centuries interpreted the same prophetic passage and argue that, although they are associated with different schools of interpretation, they were separated primarily not by interpretative methods but by theological views.

THE HEBREW PROPHETS IN THE SECOND-CENTURY SYNAGOGUE AND CHURCH

In the ancient synagogue the Torah was read sequentially each Sabbath in a continuous cycle, accompanied by a reading from the prophets called a *haftarah*. The prophetic readings were taken from either the Former or the Latter Prophets and were not sequential but were selected to complement the reading from the Torah. These two readings were followed by a homily that interpreted and applied either of the texts read.

The continuous cycle of reading the Torah is documented in the Mishnah (Megillah 3.4; *The JPS Bible Commentary Haftarot* 2002: xix, xxi). There were two cycles, one associated with Palestine and called the triennial cycle, and one associated with Babylon and called the annual cycle. The triennial was the older and completed the reading of the Torah in three or three and a half years. This cycle may have existed as early as the first century C.E. in Israel (Heinemann 1968: 41; Perrot 1988: 137; *The JPS Bible Commentary Haftarot* 2002: xxi). The New Testament provides evidence that a prophetic reading accompanied the Torah readings in the first century C.E. synagogue. At Pisidian Antioch, Paul was invited to address a word of exhortation to the synagogue “after the reading of the law and the prophets,” and earlier, at the synagogue in Nazareth on the Sabbath, Jesus was given “the scroll of the prophet Isaiah” to read, after which he delivered the homily based on the Isaiah text read (Acts 13:15; Luke 4:16–20). These passages attest to the reading of a prophetic text after the Torah reading, with a homily following the reading of the prophet.

The selection from the prophets was related to the reading from the Torah by a “verbal and thematic link between” the two, so that the prophetic reading “resembled” the Torah reading. This practice “existed already before the fall of the temple” (Perrot 1988: 157). Certain prophetic books were used more than others in these readings. Based on a study of the ancient Geniza fragments of the triennial cycle, Wacholder noted that the link

between the Torah and the prophetic readings was based on “the first significant words or phrases of the two divisions of Scripture.” He observed further that the “dominant theme” of the prophetic readings in the triennial cycle is the eschatological “messianic kingdom” (Wacholder 1971/1940: xxxi).

Wacholder’s concluding observations are of particular interest for the early Christian reception of the Hebrew prophets. He observed that nearly half of the prophetic readings in this cycle come from the book of Isaiah, and of these, “some two-thirds . . . from chapters 40–66.” The other favored set of prophetic texts was “the Twelve Minor Prophets, which, with Isaiah account for more than three-fourths of the known ‘Triennial’ haftarot” (Wacholder 1971/1940: xxxii–iii; *The JPS Bible Commentary Haftarot* 2002: xxviii). Perrot suggested that many synagogues may have possessed only the five scrolls of the Torah plus scrolls of such books as Isaiah, the Twelve Prophets, and the Psalms. “These,” he says, “were the books most in use” (Perrot 1988: 154–155).

The scriptural and commentary manuscripts found at Qumran confirm the importance of these same works of the prophets in the Jewish community there before the Common Era. More manuscripts of the text of Isaiah were found at Qumran than of any other prophetic writing. There are also fragments of more commentaries on Isaiah from Qumran than on any other prophetic writing. The Book of the Twelve Minor Prophets, likewise, was popular at Qumran. There are more manuscripts of the Psalms from Qumran than of any book among the Hebrew Scriptures (Abegg, Flint, and Ulrich 1999: 267, 279, 417–418). This same preference for the Psalms, Isaiah, and the Twelve Minor Prophets appears in the New Testament (Perrot 1988: 154). In the Apostolic Fathers, Isaiah is cited more than any other book of the Hebrew Scriptures, followed by the Psalms. In Justin’s *Dialogue with Trypho* from the middle of the second century, references to Isaiah exceed those to any other book of the Hebrew Scriptures (Childs 2004: 341). That early Christians preferred the same books that were most used among the Jews at Qumran and most read in the prophetic readings that accompanied the Torah readings in the triennial cycle surely is not coincidental.

The earliest reference to the reading of scripture in Christian worship is in 1 Timothy 4:13, where Timothy is instructed to “give attention to the reading, the exhortation, and the teaching.” The following verses make clear that this is the public reading of scripture, and the instruction of a church on the basis of it. All of these activities occurred also in synagogue services (Dugmore 1944: 71; Perrot 1988: 153). The earliest explicit reference to the reading of the *prophets* in Christian worship is in Justin’s *1st Apology* 67. He says that Christians assemble on Sunday and “the Memoirs of the Apostles or the writings of the prophets are read as long as possible. Then,” he adds, “when the reader ceases, the leader delivers a warning and challenges us to imitate these good teachings” (1 *Apol.* 67). There are two important points to note in relation to these statements. First, in the preceding chapter, Justin identifies “the Memoirs of the Apostles” as “Gospels,” which means that Gospels and the prophets were read in worship (Skarsaune 2007: 71–74). Second, this is not an apologetic use of the Hebrew prophets, for the *Christians* present are *warned* on the basis of what has been read, and are exhorted to *imitate* what they have heard. We must look more closely at each of these points.

Justin's description of the reading of scripture in Christian worship differs significantly from the practice of the synagogue: there is no mention of reading from the Torah. Since Justin addresses this *Apology* to the Roman rulers and the people (1 *Apol.* 1), he must intend his words to describe Christian worship in general. The reading of Torah, however, was primary in the synagogue. The earliest Christians seem to have dethroned Torah from its place of privilege in the reading for worship, and replaced it with Gospel (see Gamble 1995: 214–215; Skarsaune 2002: 385).¹ The Hebrew prophets, who were thought to tell the story of Jesus in advance of his coming (Rom 1:2), were read as well. Whether Justin means that Gospels *and* prophets were read each Sunday, with the prophetic reading following Gospel on the pattern of the Jewish *haftarot*, or whether he means that one or the other could be read is not clear (Skarsaune 2002: 385 n. 18). Apart from two general references to the reading of Scripture in public worship in Tertullian (*Apol.* 39.3; *An.* 9.4), which date from the end of the second century or the beginning of the third, there are no other explicit references to the practice of public reading in the church in the Christian literature from the second century. There are, however, references to the conjunction of Gospel and prophets in this literature that suggest that the two groups of writings were commonly understood together.

Ignatius of Antioch (first quarter of second century) says to the Philadelphians, "I flee for refuge to the gospel . . . and to the apostles. . . . And we also love the prophets, because their proclamation was directed to the gospel . . ." (Ign. *Phld.* 5). "Gospel" may not refer here to a written document, but it is clear that he means the story of Jesus, contained in what were later, at least, called Gospels. In the same letter, Ignatius says the "gospel" relates "the coming of the Savior, our Lord Jesus Christ, his passion, and resurrection." He then adds, again joining Gospel and prophets, "For the proclamation of the beloved prophets was aimed at him, but the gospel is the completion of his immortality" (*Phil* 9.2; see also Ign. *Magn.* 9.2). In his letter to the Smyrnaeans, Ignatius refers to some who neglected those considered the typical recipients of Christian charity (widows, orphans, oppressed, prisoners, hungry and thirsty), which probably means they did not contribute to the gifts offered each Sunday for distribution among such people (see Justin, 1 *Apol* 67). Furthermore, they abstained from the Eucharist and prayer. These are all activities of the Christians gathered for worship. A few lines further on, he adds that it is right that the Smyrnaeans avoid these people, but they should, he says, "give attention . . . to the prophets and especially to the gospel, where the Lord's passion is revealed and his resurrection accomplished" (Ign. *Smyrn.* 6–7). It would have been in the assembly of the church for worship that the Smyrnaeans would have heard the prophets and the Gospel, and participated in the Eucharist, prayer, and charitable giving. Polycarp (d. mid-second century) also joins Gospel and prophets in his letter to the Philippians when he refers to "the apostles who proclaimed the gospel to us, and the prophets who previously proclaimed the Lord's coming" (Pol. *Phil.* 6.3). The Hebrew prophets were closely associated with the Gospel in the minds of second-century Christians, and this association was impressed on them by the regular weekly reading and instruction from them in conjunction with instruction in the story of Jesus.

The other point about the reading of the prophets in Christian worship in Justin's remarks in 1 *Apology* 67 relates to the implied understanding and application of the texts

read. Frances Young has argued that the driving force in the early Christian appropriation of the Hebrew Scriptures was “the reading and telling, explaining and exhorting, that went on in the Christian assemblies.” In this, she continues, “the earliest communities functioned rather like synagogues, and the reading of scripture was central to their regular gatherings” (Young 1997: 221). She examines *2 Clement*, a Christian homily from the mid-second century. *2 Clement* is probably an example of the kind of homily of warning and exhortation to which Justin refers that followed the reading of scripture. Young notes that in *2 Clement* “the prophetic passages of warning” are not “directed at Jews,” but at Christians (Young 1997: 221).

Scripture citations in *2 Clement* are also instructive. The language of some New Testament epistles is echoed, but never identified. A quotation from Genesis is introduced as “scripture” (*2 Clem.* 14.2). Otherwise, all scriptures in the treatise come from either the Hebrew prophets or the Gospels. There are eight citations from Isaiah; Ezekiel and Jeremiah are each cited once. There is an echo of another text in Jeremiah and of one in Malachi, and a quotation from an unknown source is introduced by the words, “For the prophetic word says” (prophetic texts in chs. 2, 3, 7, 8, 11, 13–17). There are eleven references to Gospels in *2 Clement* (in chs. 2–6, 8–9, 12–13). No personal name, such as Matthew or Mark, is attached to any of these quotations. They are all sayings of Jesus, and most often are introduced with some form of the words, “The Lord says.” Four of these six, however, are not from the later recognized canonical Gospels, but perhaps from the lost *Gospel of the Egyptians*. What this survey suggests is that, in this homily at least, the words of the Hebrew prophets and the sayings of Jesus are the recognized authorities for the church. This is in agreement with Justin’s statement noted earlier that the *Memoirs of the Apostles* (i.e., Gospels) or the prophets were read each Sunday in the Christian assemblies in the mid-second century.

The somewhat fragmentary evidence that we possess of the second-century Christian reading practices in worship suggests that they carried over from the synagogue the practice of using the Hebrew prophets in both reading and instruction in their weekly assemblies. The prophets were considered to have proclaimed Jesus as Messiah prior to his coming, and they contained numerous strong exhortations to religious faithfulness, justice, and the practice of important early Christian virtues such as charity. It was not a polemical setting, but a worship setting in which the majority of early Christians became familiar with the words of the Hebrew prophets.

CHRISTIAN INTERPRETATION OF THE HEBREW PROPHETS IN THE THIRD AND FOURTH CENTURIES

In the third century, Christians began treating entire books of the Old Testament in either commentaries or homilies that ran consecutively through a book. Hippolytus

may have been the first to do this, but his work of biblical exposition has been lost except for fragments (Jerome, *Vir. ill.* 61). It is Origen's works that provide the earliest examples of this approach to the prophets. He wrote commentaries on Isaiah, Ezekiel, and the Twelve Prophets, and produced homilies on Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel. The commentaries have perished, but there are extant twenty homilies in Greek on Jeremiah plus two additional homilies on Jeremiah, nine on Isaiah, and fourteen on Ezekiel in Latin translations by Jerome.

The treatment of entire prophetic books increased considerably in the fourth century, though again, the majority of these exegetical writings have not survived. The following produced commentaries or homilies on some or all of the prophetic books: Apollinaris of Laodicea, Cyril of Alexandria, Didymus the Blind, Diodore of Tarsus, Eusebius, Jerome, John Chrysostom, Theodore of Mopsuestia, and Theodoret of Cyrus.² The writers of these commentaries have traditionally been divided into those taking the Alexandrian "allegorical" approach to interpretation, and those taking the Antiochene "historical" approach. Modern studies are showing, however, that these categories are inadequate to describe the complexities of early Christian exegesis and that more nuanced categories and terminology need to be used (Clark 1999: 70–73; Guinot 1997; Mitchel 2007; Young 1997).

It is true that those authors connected with Antioch tended to show more concern for the setting in the biblical context than those connected with Alexandria. This concern for "history" among the Antiochene Fathers has, as Wiles once noted, "a genuine modern ring," which encourages "anachronistic judgments." But, he adds, they "cannot be treated as nineteenth- or twentieth-century critical historians. . . ." Theodore of Mopsuestia, the quintessential example of an Antiochene exegete who emphasized the literal or historical meaning, he continues, "as much as Origen, was a child of his age" (Wiles 1970: 490–491). No early Christian commentary or homily was ever composed for the sake of uncovering what modern biblical scholars would call the historical situation of the ancient Hebrews. Not even the commentary on the Twelve Prophets by Theodore of Mopsuestia is interested in this. Wiles points out that Theodore explains the exegete's task to be "to explain words that most people find difficult" (Wiles 1970: 491). What Theodore means by "history" is "reading texts at face value" and seeing the fulfillment of prophecies within events that are described as happening among the Israelites in the Old Testament period (*Commentary on the Twelve Prophets* 2004: 23). Even he admits that a few of the prophecies have their ultimate fulfillment in Christ (*Commentary on the Twelve Prophets* 2004: 24, 26–27), although in his commentary on the Twelve Prophets, which is his only preserved commentary on the prophets, he treats only six texts in all Twelve Minor Prophets as christological (Simonetti 1994: 69).

The "Usefulness" of the Teachings of the Prophets

The principle of looking for the usefulness of a text was an aspect of ancient education. Students reading a philosophical author with a teacher were provided with a

series of standard questions that would guide them in their understanding of the text (Neuschäfer 1987: 57–67). One of these questions was about the usefulness of the text being read. Origen applies this to the opening words of Jeremiah, where it says the prophet prophesied into the fifth month of the captivity. He asks why he continued to prophesy after Jerusalem had fallen, and answers that the prophet was calling on the Hebrews to repent and experience the mercy of God, rather than continuing to suffer captivity. This, he says, shows “something *useful* from the record containing the times of the prophecy, because” the merciful God “is urging those who hear it not to experience the sufferings of captivity” (*Hom. Jer.* 1.2; emphasis added).

The Pauline statement that the things experienced by the ancient Israelites “were recorded to warn us” (1 Cor 10:11) provided the Fathers of the third and fourth centuries with a Scriptural way of understanding the topic of usefulness. This concept forms the basis of much of the interpretive work of these Fathers. Origen frequently appealed to this verse (Heine 1997: 136). He did not usually deny or neglect the literal event described in Scripture. Instead, he applied the principle of usefulness in accordance with the Pauline understanding and lifted up the words of the text (one of his favorite words for a non-literal meaning was the Greek term *anagōgē*, “lifting up”) so that they spoke meaningfully to the new Christian context in which they were being read and applied (see *Hom. Ezech.* 7.8; 12.2).

The concept of usefulness was not employed exclusively by Origen and the later Alexandrian school of interpretation. John Chrysostom of the Antiochene school also used it. In his second homily on Isaiah, he complains that some, on seeing dates and names in scripture, dismiss the scriptures in general as containing only dates and names. He insists that the inspired author does not mention dates “pointlessly or to no purpose. The mouths of the inspired authors,” he says, “are the mouth of God . . . ; such a mouth would say nothing idly. . . .” The dynamic driving such a statement is the assumption that all words in Scripture must be *useful* because they are inspired words (cf. 2 Tim 3:16). “What are you saying?” Chrysostom asks. “God makes a statement, and you dare to claim, There is nothing *useful* in what is said?” (PG 56.110; *John Chrysostom Old Testament Homilies* 2003: 65). Origen had made a similar statement regarding the usefulness of the list of Hebrew encampments in Numbers 33 (PG 12.782; *Hom. Num.* 27.1). Chrysostom, as well as Origen, was concerned to find interpretations and applications of the biblical text that would be useful to the audience he was addressing (PG 56.111).

The Unity between the Hebrew Prophets and the Christian Gospel

The close connection between the Hebrew prophets and the Christian Gospel was essential to most early Christians. As noted earlier, this connection appears in the earliest Christian literature and continues as a constant motif in the writings of the Fathers. To fail to see Christ in the prophets would mean that they had no vital connection with the

Gospel. This was not a trivial issue for the Fathers. They were pressed by some, claiming to be Christians, who dismissed the prophetic witness to Christ completely, such as Marcion, against whom Tertullian argued in the early third century (*Against Marcion*), the Gnostic Heracleon, against whom Origen argued a little later (*Commentary on John*), and the Manichees, against whom Augustine argued in the late fourth century (*Against Faustus*).

Some of the Fathers applied the transfiguration story in the synoptic Gospels to the issue of unity. This account of Jesus, Moses, and Elijah conversing on the mountain, and the subsequent voice from the cloud, became an icon that some of the Fathers used to indicate the unity of Scripture. So far as I have discovered, the symbolic connections between the three persons and Gospel, Prophets, and Law was first made explicit by Origen. I have not found this usage of the story outside the Origen tradition. John Chrysostom, for example, joins Moses and Elijah as “towers among the prophets of the Old Testament,” but he does not identify them with bodies of literature (PG 49.307). He proposes several reasons that Moses and Elijah were on the mountain, but again, none links the two figures with the corresponding bodies of literature (PG 58.550–551). Tertullian may have understood the three figures in this way, but he does not make the connection explicit (*Marc.* 4.22, 34). There seems to have been no use of the figure of Elijah in particular to refer to the literary corpus of the Hebrew prophets prior to Origen.

Origen says that the figure of Elijah is used by way of synecdoche, so that the one figure stands for all the prophets. He understands Peter’s suggestion to make three tabernacles as an attempt to separate law, prophets, and Gospel. The divine voice instructing them to “hear” the Son alone prompts Origen to say, “For Moses, the Law, and Elijah, Prophecy, have become one only in the Gospel of Jesus” (*Comm. Matt.* 12.38, 40, 43; *Cels.* 6.68; *Hom. Lev.* 6.2; *Comm. Rom.* 1.10). Origen’s lengthy exposition of the transfiguration narrative sets the guidelines for the iconic use of this story to suggest the relation of the three parts of Christian scripture by later Fathers.

In the fourth century, Jerome uses the story to show this unity. He says of the three disciples, “If they had not seen Jesus transformed . . . they could not have seen Moses and Elijah. . . . For if you read the law, that is Moses, and if you read the prophets, that is Elijah, and you do not understand them in Christ, you also do not understand how Moses speaks with Jesus, or how Elijah speaks with Jesus . . .” (*Tract. Marc.*, CCSL 78: 481). He states his appreciation for the Law and the Prophets, but asserts that their function is to lead the reader to Christ. He insists that he is not “detracting” from them, but that he is “praising them because they preach Christ” (*Tract. Marc.*, CCSL 78: 484).

Augustine, who shared many hermeneutical similarities with Origen (Cameron 2012: 208), likewise identifies Moses and Elijah with the Law and the Prophets. In response to Peter’s request on the Mount of Transfiguration to make three tabernacles, Augustine says the voice from the cloud instructs him to listen to Christ. “Christ is the Word of God; the Word of God is *in* the law; the Word of God is *in* the prophets” (*Sermo* 78.3; PL 38.491). Furthermore, the voice from the cloud did not refer to Moses and Elijah as “my beloved sons.” “It is one thing to be the only begotten,” Augustine says, “and another to be adopted. . . . Christ is the Lord; the law and the prophets are servants. They

are like vessels; he is like a fountain. Moses and the prophets used to speak and write, but when they poured out, they were filled from him” (Sermo 78.4; PL 38.491). This iconic use of the transfiguration story points to the importance of the unity of the old and new revelation for the Fathers, and to Christ as the link binding them together.

THEOLOGICAL POSITIONS AND THE CHRISTIAN INTERPRETATION OF THE PROPHETS IN THE THIRD AND FOURTH CENTURIES

In this concluding section I examine the interpretation of Isaiah 6:1–7 in the writings of four third- and fourth-century Fathers. I begin with Origen, who is considered the source of the Christian Alexandrian interpretative tradition. I next consider Eusebius and Jerome, who were both influenced by Origen’s work on Isaiah, but who also show tendencies traditionally labeled Antiochene. Finally, I look at John Chrysostom, who represents the Antiochene interpretation of Isaiah. My discussion focuses on the ways in which each of these Fathers treated three points in Isaiah’s text: (1) the significance of the historical setting of the vision (6:1a), (2) the vision of the heavenly beings (6:1b–3), and (3) the purification of Isaiah’s lips (6:5–7). Guinot treated these same three points in his earlier study on the heritage of Origen in the Greek commentators on Isaiah 6:1–7. The authors he compared were Origen, Eusebius, Ps. Basil, and Cyril of Alexandria. He also made a few remarks on Jerome’s treatment of the passage (Guinot 1987: 379–389). Guinot wanted to demonstrate the influence of Origen on later commentators. I am interested in showing the nature of what separated their interpretations, for this has traditionally been done by locating the various authors in either the Alexandrian or Antiochene exegetical traditions. This is at best an inadequate explanation for their differences, and probably an incorrect one.

Origen on Isaiah 6:1–7

Origen notes that the vision occurred after Uzziah died. He tells the story of Uzziah related in 2 Kings 13 and 2 Chronicles 26, in which Uzziah attempts to perform the duties of a priest and is struck with leprosy. Uzziah, he concludes, was a sinner, and consequently Isaiah saw no vision of God while Uzziah reigned. The situation of the Israelites in Egypt is considered to be a parallel. While Pharaoh lived, the Israelites did not call out for divine help, but when he died, they did. Origen then makes the transition into an application of the story to his audience. Drawing on Romans 6:12, “Do not let sin reign in your mortal body,” he lets King Uzziah or Pharaoh represent sin. As long as Uzziah lives

in us, we can see no vision of God. But when he dies, Origen says, I see ‘the Lord Sabaoth sitting’ and reigning “upon a high throne” (*Hom. Isa.* 5.3).³ Origen does not neglect a full literal exposition of Uzziah’s rebellious actions as related in the Bible; his interest in the story, however, is in how it is useful for his Christian audience.

Origen makes several noteworthy observations about the seraphim in the vision. First, he says there are two; second, it is God’s face and feet, not their own, that they cover; and third, they are identified as the Lord Jesus and the Holy Spirit (*Hom. Isa.* 1.2; cf. 4.1; *Cels.* 6.18). The covering of God’s face and feet by the Son and the Holy Spirit indicates that only they see God’s face and, consequently, all human knowledge of God comes through them. God’s face also represents the beginning of the cosmos and his feet its end. The uncovered midsection suggests to Origen that we know only what lies between the beginning and the end (*Hom. Isa.* 4.1). Isaiah’s statement that “all the earth is full of his glory” refers to the Incarnation. He interprets this through Paul’s statement that all things will be subject to Christ and Christ himself to God (*Hom. Isa.* 1.2). The seraph that brings the coal to cleanse Isaiah’s lips is the “Lord Jesus Christ, who was ‘sent’ from the Father to ‘take away our sins’” (*Hom. Isa.* 1.4; 4.4; see John 1:29).

This bold and striking interpretation of Isaiah’s vision of God and the seraphim reverberated in most subsequent interpretations of the Fathers. It was especially the identification of the seraphim as the Son and Holy Spirit that later interpreters either avoided or condemned. Origen had earlier attributed this view to a Hebrew teacher he had known (*Princ.* 1.3.4; 4.3.14; Daniélou 1964: 134–140). The identification seems to reflect the early economic explanation of the Trinity, in which the functions of the three members were stressed. Origen’s description suggests that the Son and the Holy Spirit are the mediators of revelation. The redemptive function of Christ is shown in the identification of Christ with the seraph that applies the purifying coal to Isaiah’s lips. The economic view of the Trinity was the prevailing Christian view in the late second and early third centuries. Few Christians would have thought Origen’s statement objectionable in his own day (see Hannah 1999).

Eusebius on Isaiah 6:1–7

Eusebius discusses this text of Isaiah in his *Proof of the Gospel* as well as in his *Commentary on Isaiah*. He thinks the Lord whom Isaiah sees on the throne is Christ, and cites John 12:41 to confirm this view. In the *Proof of the Gospel* he prefaces his discussion of the vision with a treatment of Isaiah’s argument with Ahaz in Isaiah 7, which leads to Isaiah’s statement that a virgin will conceive and give birth (Isa 7:14). He then notes how John joins the divinity and humanity of the Lord in the prologue of his Gospel (John 1:1–3, 14), and asserts that Isaiah is doing the same thing by describing his vision of the divine glory *before* he announces the one born of a virgin, that is the human manifestation. The two natures of Christ had become a pressing theological concern in the fourth century. Isaiah’s reference to the earth being filled with his glory (Isa 6:3) refers to the knowledge and praise of the incarnate Lord throughout the earth.

Eusebius suggests that the seraphim are either angelic powers or the prophets and apostles. The “wings,” however, suggest “the powers of the Holy Spirit,” which hide “the beginning and the end of the knowledge of God.” The midsection (representing the “central parts of his dispensation”) is uncovered, however, since what lies between the beginning and the end is all that humanity can know. Here there is a sort of garbled reflection of parts of Origen’s interpretation of the seraphim. The function of the wings and their meaning come from Origen. Finally, Eusebius quotes John 12:37–41 as proof that the evangelist understood Isaiah’s vision to be about Christ (*Dem. ev.* 7.1; *The Proof of the Gospel* 1981/1920: 48–52).

In his *Commentary on Isaiah*, Eusebius has a short discussion of Uzziah’s presumptuous act, which caused the glory of God to withdraw from the temple for the remainder of his life. His main concern is to identify the divine being Isaiah saw on the throne. It could not have been the Father because John 1:18 says “No one has ever seen God.” It must, therefore, have been the Son. Because Isaiah says (in the LXX) that seraphim stood “around him,” there could not have been only two as “[s]ome people suppose.” He identifies the seraphim as angels with unknowable functions referred to as wings, contrary to the meaning he gives the wings in the *Proof of the Gospel* (see previous discussion). He makes it explicit that the face and feet the seraphim cover are their own, not those of God. The Lord’s glory filling the earth refers to the preaching of his advent among the Gentiles.

Eusebius knew Origen’s identification of Christ with the seraph that brought the coal, but he could not make that identification because he had identified the figure on the throne as Christ. Nevertheless, he felt it necessary to connect the redemptive work of the seraph with Christ. He points out that *seraphim* in Greek means “those who set on fire” or who “burn.” He suggests that the coal from the altar may come from the altar on which the Lord offered himself and, furthermore, in the Gospels the Savior is said to “baptize with the Holy Spirit and with fire” (Matt 3:11; Luke 3:16). All these things, he says, “teach us about the Logos, for no one is able to receive cleansing from sins except through the divine fire” (*Commentary on Isaiah* 2013: 27–31). There is an implicit identification of the seraph with the work of Christ in this statement.

Jerome on Isaiah 6:1–7

Jerome produced an early exposition of these verses (*Epistles* 18A and 18B) around c.e. 381. Approximately thirty years later, he wrote a *Commentary on Isaiah*. I draw on both sources in the following description.

Jerome relates the story of Uzziah from 2 Kings and 2 Chronicles. He follows Origen step by step, reproducing the same examples from Scripture to make the transition to contemporary readers. Before he begins his applications, however, he separates the historical part of his work from the interpretative: “With the history said as a preface, the spiritual interpretation follows, the grounds for which the history itself has unfolded” (*St. Jerome’s Commentary on Isaiah* 931: 2015). This is a paraphrase of the Pauline

hermeneutical statement in 1 Cor 10:11 (see earlier discussion). The history “unfolded,” Jerome asserts, for the sake of the “spiritual interpretation.” The spiritual interpretation he gives is that of Origen. As long as Uzziah lived, Isaiah could see no vision. As in Origen, Pharaoh and the Israelites in Egypt provide a parallel. And, as with Origen, Romans 6:12 provides the entry for a contemporary application.

Jerome continues to follow Origen in his description of the heavenly vision. When he comes to the two seraphim, however, he makes an explicit break with Origen’s interpretation. Some of his predecessors, he says, have identified the two seraphim as Christ and the Holy Spirit. “I do not,” Jerome says, “assent to their authority” (*Epist.* 18A.4). He considered the identification of the Son and the Holy Spirit with the seraphim to be Origen’s most serious theological blunder (*Epist.* 61.2). The reason he thought this, Fürst argues, was because it subordinated them to the Father. In the fourth century, he notes, “Origen was vilified as the alleged father of Arianism” because of this subordination (Fürst 2009: 145). Jerome, always interested in ensuring his own orthodoxy, wanted to distance himself from any hint of Arianism. He does, however, continue Origen’s view that there were *two* seraphim, though in the later *Commentary*, he wavers between two and a multitude of angels (*Comm. Isa.* 3.7). Like Eusebius, he takes Christ to be the Lord on the heavenly throne, and thinks John 12:39–41 proves this. He identifies the two seraphim as the two testaments “which . . . stand around God since the Lord himself is known by means of them” (*Epist.* 18A.6). Once beyond Origen’s identification of the seraphim as the Son and Holy Spirit, Jerome again follows the details of Origen’s interpretation. The two seraphim cover the face and feet of God, “not their own,” he says. Furthermore, he follows Origen’s understanding of the face, feet, and midsection of the Lord (*Epist.* 18A.7). He understands the statement that the earth is filled with his glory to refer to the coming of the Lord and the proclamation about him to all the earth, as in Origen’s interpretation.

Because he identifies the two seraphim as the two testaments, Jerome suggests that the seraph with the coal is “the evangelical testament.” This contained a burning word of God that purged him of ignorance (*Epist.* 18A.14). In the *Commentary on Isaiah* he notes that “seraphim” means “set on fire,” and he provides a list of Scriptures that contain the word “fire,” including Jesus’ statements about baptizing with “the Spirit and fire,” and coming to “cast fire on the earth” (*Comm. Isa.* 3.7; Matt 3:11; Luke 12:49). He could not completely remove from Christ the redeeming activity of the seraph that Origen had boldly identified.

John Chrysostom on Isaiah 6:1–7

Chrysostom has six extant homilies on Isaiah 6 as well as a commentary. In discussing Isaiah 5, he provides a mini-discourse on the occasional need to allegorize Scripture. Scripture itself, he argues, indicates whether it should be allegorized, by providing the interpretation, as in Isaiah 5. This is to prevent the reader’s imagination from giving the details any meaning it wants. He does not say Isaiah 6 falls into this category, but he often insists on non-literal interpretations of the passage.

In the commentary, Chrysostom asks why Isaiah dates this vision in relation to the death of Uzziah instead of his life, and answers that it hints at something secret. He then relates the story of Uzziah's arrogant action and his subsequent punishment. Prophecy ceased when Uzziah did this. This is why Isaiah dates his vision by the death of the king (Garrett 1992: 123). Here the mention of the time suggests a secret meaning. In the homilies, this is the controlling factor when the dating of the vision is mentioned.

Isaiah's claim to see the Lord seems to contradict scripture. Chrysostom does not follow Eusebius or Jerome; he understands the one on the throne to be the creator God (see Homily 1 in his *Old Testament Homilies* 2003), but "in an assumed form." What Isaiah claims to see shows it was not the true deity. God was seated, but an incorporeal being cannot sit. Furthermore, he was seated on a throne. But God "cannot be contained" (Garrett 1992: 123, 124). Chrysostom interprets the words of the vision through a theological strainer. Monique Alexandre notes that Gregory of Nyssa cited "theological impropriety" as an indicator that the literal meaning of a text was not to be followed (Alexandre 1971: 103–104). Isaiah's vision contains statements about God that were theologically unacceptable. By the fourth century, God was considered incorporeal and incapable of being contained, because what contained him would be greater than God. Chrysostom brings Isaiah's text into harmony with the current theological understanding of God. God seated on a throne is symbolic of human judges who sit to pronounce judgment. He is about to pronounce judgment that will punish Jerusalem but will benefit the whole world. What he is suggesting is that Isaiah's words point to the forthcoming fall of Jerusalem and the later coming of Christ. In this way, Chrysostom understands Isaiah's vision to speak of the Christian era, as Origen, Eusebius, and Jerome had understood it earlier.

Chrysostom assumes that the seraphim cover their own feet. He asks, however, what their wings "hint at" (Garrett 1992: 128). The verb "to hint at" was a standard verb for referring to a hidden meaning in texts in the Classical as well as the Patristic period (Manolea 2004: 23 n. 9). Chrysostom asserts that there is a mystical meaning in the action of the seraphim. They do not have feet, he says, because they are incorporeal. The action shows their reverence in serving the Lord, which he then applies to the deportment of his congregation in worship, which seems not to have been so reverent (*Old Testament Homilies* 2003: Homily 1). The song of the seraphim, moreover, is a hymn to the Trinity. Three texts are cited to prove this: John 12:40–41, where the message of this section of Isaiah is spoken of the Son; Acts 28:25–27, where Luke says it is spoken of the Spirit; and Isaiah 6, where it is said of the Father (Garrett 1992: 128). The statement that the earth is full of his glory predicts the Incarnation (*Old Testament Homilies* 2003: Homily 1).

Chrysostom recognizes that some understand the seraph and the coal to purify Isaiah's lips to be "symbols of the mysteries that were to come." In his sixth homily on Isaiah, he applies the action to the reception of the Eucharist by his congregation and suggests that the altar in Isaiah 6 represents the altar where the Eucharist is served, and the "fire" burning on Isaiah's altar is the spiritual fire found in the Eucharist (*Old Testament Homilies* 2003: Homily 6). This is an indirect connection of the action of the seraph with the redemptive work of Christ.

All four of these third- and fourth-century authors treat the historical setting of Isaiah 6:1–7 in the same way. They relate it to the presumptuous action of Uzziah described in 2 Kings and 2 Chronicles and conclude that there was no prophetic vision so long as Uzziah lived. They all also interpret the vision in relation to theological understandings prevalent in their age. Origen sees the Father on the throne and, assuming that there were two seraphim, sees an image of the economic view of the Trinity, with the Son and the Holy Spirit functioning more or less in a mode subservient to the Father in providing divine revelation and human redemption. Eusebius, assuming that the Father cannot be seen, understands the Son as the figure on the throne. He joins the revelation of the glory of the Son in the vision in Isaiah 6 with the announcement of the virgin birth of the human Jesus in chapter 7 and sees the conjunction as Isaiah's way of proclaiming both the deity and the humanity in the one person of the Son. Jerome, like Eusebius, sees the Son on the throne in the vision. He thinks, however, that Origen's view is subordinatist, which in his day meant Arian and which must therefore be avoided. Chrysostom understands the figure on the throne to be God the Father, but not God as he truly is. Humanity cannot see deity. He, therefore, interprets the vision through categories acceptable for describing deity in the fourth century.

What these four vignettes show is that theological viewpoints, much more than hermeneutical strategies, separated theologians in their interpretations of texts of the Hebrew prophets in the third and fourth centuries. Hermeneutical strategies moved rather fluidly across school boundaries. Theological viewpoints, however, had become rigid by the fourth century, and texts were interpreted in ways that were in agreement with those viewpoints. These later expositors and preachers labored at interpreting the prophetic texts in ways that were harmonious with their understanding of Christian teachings. This labor suggests the high value attached to the texts of the Hebrew prophets by their Christian interpreters.

NOTES

1. The early Christians did not discontinue the *use* of the Torah completely, as Marcion did in the mid-second century. It was used for ethical instruction, and parts of it were considered to prophesy of Christ.
2. The lives of some of these writers extended into the fifth century.
3. Translation by Thomas P. Scheck in the appendix of his *St. Jerome: Commentary on Isaiah: Origen Homilies 1–9 on Isaiah* (ACW 68; New York: Paulist Press, 2015).

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CHAPTER 24

MEDIEVAL RECEPTION OF THE PROPHETS

MARY CHILTON CALLAWAY

THE lofty perch of serene prophetic images that adorn the facades of medieval cathedrals belies their lively, sometimes raucous, often bitterly contested place in medieval culture. The intersection of the prophets with three aspects of medieval culture offers a fruitful way into understanding their reception. The first is the problem of the unstable term “Bible” in the medieval world, and the attendant difficulty in knowing just what it meant for Christians. The second is the extended debate about practices of scriptural exegesis, as the influence of Jewish scholarship, as well as the scholastic practices in universities, challenged the long-privileged place of allegory in Christian interpretation. The third is the place of the prophets as signifiers of the complicated, fraught relation between medieval Christians and Jews. Written in a language that Christian scholars often learned from rabbis, but essential to the narrative of salvation history, the prophets embodied the ancient problem of the relation between Old and New Testaments. These three areas provide the framework for this chapter. Before turning to them, it will be helpful to clarify two concepts basic to the project.

The term “medieval” is a fusion of the Latin words *medium aevum*, meaning “middle time.” It reflects the belief of Petrarch and other early humanists in the late fifteenth century that they were living in an era radically different from the “dark ages” just prior to their time. Seeing themselves as heirs of Classical antiquity and initiators of a new era, humanists implicitly characterized the “middle time” that stood between themselves and their intellectual foundations in antiquity as behind them, in every sense of the word. The term “medieval” still often carries judgment about a way of thinking deemed simplistic and superstitious.¹ Exploring the ways that medieval imaginations apprehended the prophets requires complicating this persistent legacy of early modernity. Postmodern scholarship offers as an antidote to traditional totalizing interpretations the designation of alterity, described by one historian of medieval France as “the recognition that the past inevitably escapes us, that words, names, signs, functions—our fragile instruments of research and scholarship—are at best only momentarily empowered

to capture the reality of the past, the knowledge of which as a lived, experienced understood repository of life is always slipping away, if indeed it was ever knowable to begin with.”² This elegiac view serves as a reminder that the present chapter can offer only a modern apprehension, from a particular perspective, of medieval reception of the prophets. The “repository of life” is not only slipping away; it is also obscured from our vision because it is already part of our consciousness. We explore medieval reception of the prophets with a consciousness already influenced by medieval history and culture; this is what Gadamer calls the historically effected consciousness. One of the goals of reception history is precisely to explore the effects of the past on the present, particularly on the ways that we think about the past.

A complex *mentalité* shaped medieval apprehension of biblical history as a chronology of events both in the past and intersecting with the present. Biblical time was both linear and punctiliar, an unfolding narrative and an eternal present. The two dominant interpretive approaches to prophetic texts in medieval Christianity embody this distinctive *mentalité*. While salvation history sets the prophets into a linear progression of divine action from Israel to the church to the eschaton, allegorical and moral exegesis brings their voices to bear on Christian life in the present. An example from medieval art illustrates this dual perception of biblical time. In the widely distributed book of wood block illustrations correlating Old and New Testament scenes known as *Biblia Pauperum*, a scene from the New Testament in the center is flanked by two Old Testament images.³ The dove descending at Pentecost is framed on the left by the prophet Moses receiving the Law and the words, “As the law was written on stone tablets, in the same way the new law was written on the hearts of the faithful on the day of Pentecost.” On the right the prophet Elijah, in the garb of a medieval cleric, prays before the burning calf on the altar at Mount Carmel. The text instructs the reader, “This fire from heaven signifies that divine fire which on the day of Pentecost came down on the disciples and purified them, consuming all the faults resulting from their sins.” The images of Moses and Elijah signify the entire Old Testament—the Law and the Prophets—as the narrative witness of divine activity in the past. Yet the fire on Elijah’s altar and on the disciples’ heads is *the same fire*, and it implicitly still burns in the hearts of the faithful. The punctiliar conception is graphically signaled in the way that biblical scenes are set in European landscapes and biblical characters are clothed in medieval tunics and buskins. Other images portray prophets in an architectural frame of Gothic arches, rendering them contemporaries speaking to the reader. In medieval reception, then, prophets represent both the ancient biblical story and the immediate experience of divine presence.

PROPHETS IN A MULTIMEDIA BIBLE

Medieval reception of the prophets intersects with the rapidly evolving idea of “Bible.” A look at the prophets in some of the dominant forms illustrates the way that burgeoning commercial trade, as well as biblical scholarship, marked the way the prophets were

known. Medieval Bibles differed from modern ones because they all contained some commentary incorporated into the text. The official Bible was Jerome's Latin text, which always included his prologues standing guard over each biblical book to guide the reader with a complex hermeneutic of faith and intellectual engagement. The prologue to Isaiah reminds readers that the words before them are spoken "not so much by a prophet as by an Evangelist. Indeed the entire mystery of Christ and the church is described so clearly that you might think him to be weaving together a narrative of the past rather than prophesying about the future."⁴ Although he sets Isaiah into historical context in Judea, Jerome writes, "His whole concern was about the calling of the gentiles and the coming of Christ." Jeremiah is rendered a man of his time whose rustic speech shows his small-town origins, yet also a man of the Gospel whose mother is likened to Mary. Ezekiel is prefaced with Jerome's readerly warning that "the first and last parts of the book are wrapped in many obscure meanings." In addition to Jerome's prefaces, a decorative historiated initial in the opening word of biblical text helped the reader locate the book, often adding another hermeneutic. These beautiful illuminations typically included a scene from apocryphal legends, such as Jeremiah being stoned or Isaiah being sawn in half. They invited readers to find in the biblical words the biography of a holy martyr as well as prophecies of Christ. In addition, numerous contemporizing scenes of the prophet as medieval preacher speaking to contemporaries would encourage readers to actualize the prophetic words for their own lives.

Another form of the Bible was the *Glossa Ordinaria*, an eleventh-century text that presented the Bible a few verses at a time, surrounded by patristic commentary. Brief interlinear notes added technical information and key interpretations. In monasteries, in the cathedral school of Notre Dame, and in the newly formed Université de Paris, Christians studied biblical texts that were in visual conversation with traditional exegesis. A few examples will illustrate how the *Glossa* cultivated readers to multivalent, even conflicting, readings of the prophets. At Isaiah 6:3 an interlinear note guides readers to gloss the threefold *sanctus* with *Pater* (son), *Filius* (son), and *Spiritus Sanctus* (Holy Spirit); a marginal note says simply, "Mysterium Trinitatis." Yet these are surrounded by a lengthy description of the history and appearance of the Temple in which Isaiah saw his vision. The book of Jonah opens with Jerome's commentary noting that the "Hebrews" believe holy Jonah to be the son of the widow of Zarephath whom Elijah raised from the dead (from *Midrash Tehillim* 26.7). This is one example of the rabbinic idea that all biblical characters are somehow related, which influenced medieval Christian thinking through the *Glossa*. Jerome invites readers to a tropological reading of the book when he ends his prologue by noting that both Elijah and Jonah seemed at times to be far from the divine presence, yet brought salvation near. Psalm 139:1 is offered to readers as an interpretive key. Another short preface invites a christological reading of Jonah, whose shipwreck prefigures the passion of the Lord and who calls the world to repentance; on the same page, though, a third comment warns the reader that allegorical interpretation of Jonah as Christ does not suit the whole book. On the silver and gold for furnishing the rebuilt Temple in Haggai 2:8, the interlinear note offers guidance in the plain sense: "That is, all the succor that I will bring to you in the furnishings of the Temple." The marginal

gloss urges an allegorical reading, "Silver: this is the speech of the Scriptures; gold: this is the hidden sense that dwells in the breast of those who are sanctified." These readings reflect the medieval delight in different kinds of meaning, and illustrate the understanding of biblical time as both linear and punctiliar. Prophetic words in the *Glossa* are visually hedged in by patristic and early medieval comments, yet far from determining their meaning, the *Glossa* format seemed to complicate it.

An entirely different form of Bible by which medieval readers knew the prophets was Peter Comestor's *Historia scholastica*, a Latin paraphrase of biblical history produced in 1170 C.E. to help students at the cathedral school of Notre Dame read the narrative of biblical history, which the *Glossa* made difficult. It has been called "the single most important medium through which a popular Bible took shape, from the thirteenth into the fifteenth century."⁵ Peter Comestor explains at the beginning of his prologue that he wrote the work in response to requests from friends (*petitio sociorum*), "who, when they would read the narrative [*historia*] of sacred Scripture in order, with scattered glosses and abbreviated explanations, pressed me to take on this work so that they might use it to pursue diligently the truth of its narrative."⁶ He therefore transformed Genesis through 2 Kings into a story, supplemented with events and rulers from Greek and Roman history to help readers reckon biblical history in terms of secular history. James Morey epitomizes Comestor's achievement: "As a work of literature the *Historia* made the Bible, which can be very strange and intractable, into a coherent, orthodox, and entertaining narrative."⁷ Medieval students reading the *Historia* encountered the prophets mostly as miracle workers in stories that featured the triumph of good over evil, always in the larger context of Israel's history. Of some 886 chapters covering Genesis through Acts, the prophets have only twenty-eight: twenty for Daniel, six for Ezekiel, and two for Jeremiah. Isaiah is presented in a paraphrase of 2 Chronicles as one of the wise men who counseled the king to divert Judah's water supply into Jerusalem, and whose prayers made the waters flow abundantly into the city. The mention of Manasseh shedding innocent blood (2 Kgs 21:16) is the occasion for introducing the story of Isaiah's martyrdom, which Comestor attributes to "the Hebrews." He writes,

Isaiah was sent outside Jerusalem near the pool of Siloam to be sawn through the middle with a wooden saw. When he had been narrowed into the first section he asked to be given water so that he might drink, and when they were not willing to give it to him, God sent water from above into his mouth, and he expired, although the executioners had not yet stood up from the sawing. The name Siloe, which is interpreted "sent," is evidence that the water was sent. They did not bury him in the grave of the prophets, but under the oak of Rogel near the water passage that Hezekiah made, in memory of the miracle that God did with those waters because of the prayers of Isaiah.⁸

This tradition of Isaiah's martyrdom dominates medieval reception, especially in art. For Jeremiah, Comestor constructs an engaging narrative of a miracle worker from the first century C.E. *Lives of the Prophets* that had entered Christian tradition. After rescuing the Ark from the burning Temple, the prophet hides it in a rock, sealing it with the sign

of the Tetragrammaton “until the End.” Comestor’s adaptation of the ancient tradition that Jeremiah miraculously rid Egypt of its noxious serpents further casts the prophet in a congenial medieval idiom. The *Historia scholastica* secured lasting influence when it received official approval from the Fourth Lateran Council in 1215, and little more than a decade later the Dominicans in Paris included it with Peter Lombard’s *Sentences* and the *Glossa Ordinaria* as the official core curriculum for theology students. A hundred fifty years later, Dante acknowledged its significance when he placed Peter Comestor in the circle of the blessed (*Paradiso* 12.134). The most compelling evidence of its success, however, was its translation into French by a cathedral canon, bringing prophetic miracle stories to a wider audience.

Guyart des Moulins’s *Bible historiale* wove Comestor’s narrative together with commentary, moralizing, and copious pictures into an attractive vernacular Bible for lay Christians. Even more than in Comestor’s Latin original, the prophets in these vernacular stories take on the character of medieval saints and martyrs. The book was soon expanded to include French translations of all the prophetic books, including Daniel, with some introductory comments. Copies for nobility were illustrated lavishly, while inexpensive volumes sported many colorful cartoon-like pictures. These offer a meta-commentary on the text, highlighting medieval tropes about the prophets. A common theme is the continuity between the divinely inspired prophetic words and the vernacular text in the reader’s hands. This continuum of authority is graphically reinforced by illustrations of the hand of God reaching down from a cloud to place into the prophet’s upraised hands a codex mirroring the one in the reader’s hands. Similarly, the continuity between the vernacular *Bible historiale*, Peter Comestor’s Latin, and the sacred word is signaled artistically, by near identical illustrations of some of the prophets and Peter Comestor. An early fourteenth-century copy of the *Bible historiale* (BNF Fr. 156) begins each new section with a visual reminder of the continuity between the original words of the prophets and their vernacular adaptation. It opens with a historiated initial showing a vested Peter Comestor at a scribe’s desk, followed a few pages later by Moses in a frame of Gothic architecture, bent over a scroll at the same desk. Adorning his head are the traditional horns of Moses, as well as the pointed cap of the medieval Jew. Further into the book, Ezekiel sits at the scribe’s desk, surrounded by two Jews. These illustrations capture the complex medieval understanding of the prophets as simultaneously Jewish and Christian.

The *Bible historiale* was not a stable text, as its popularity encouraged Paris booksellers to make constant additions and refinements to suit different buyers.⁹ Almost all extant manuscripts, numbering over eight hundred, contain copious illustrations that interpret the prophets in a contemporary idiom. A 1397 French manuscript in the British Library (Royal MS 17 E VII vol. 2) has been digitized, and its interpretive illustrations are worth viewing online. Joel is introduced with a comment written in red ink to distinguish it from the prophet’s words in black. Guyart guides readers to apply the prophet’s warning to their own lives, saying in the first chapter that Joel warns people about their indecency—presumably a contemporizing interpretation of the prophet’s reference to drunkards in 1:5 (folio 101v). Throughout this manuscript, a miniature illumination

characterizes each prophet. Amos sleeps under a blanket, with God in the upper right-hand corner speaking and pointing—perhaps interpreting the difficult phrase in Amos 1:1, “the word that Amos saw.” Habakkuk opens with a picture of the prophet being carried by the hair to a cave in which Daniel chats with three smiling lions, a reference to the story in the apocryphal *Bel and the Dragon*. Five prophets wear the pointed cap and divided beard, signifying that they are Jews. Jonah, ominously pictured as a pair of legs with medieval shoes dangling outside the jaws of a fearsome monster, seems to warn readers against disobedience that could lead them into the jaws of hell. The only prophet whose image explicitly links him with Christ is Haggai, who holds a banderole with the words “Ave Maria gratia plena,” perhaps highlighting the mention of “the treasure of the nations” in Haggai 2:7. Finally, a memorable illustration of Hosea appears in another expanded fourteenth-century French manuscript of the *Bible historiale* (BNF catalogue Français 157, folio 114v). Hosea is introduced as a bearded prophet with pointed cap, seated on a stone bench, embracing and kissing a beautiful young woman in medieval dress seated next to him. The scene is framed by a Gothic arch and has an ethereal background of sapphire blue and delicate golden vines that evokes heaven. The illustration may reference Peter Comestor’s schema of interpreting Scripture, which invokes Hosea to describe the soul as the beloved, though wandering, wife of the Lord. In this popular Bible, Gomer figures both earthly desire and divine longing, human erring and God’s redeeming.

In addition to illustrations of individual prophets, frontispieces often presented a clear hermeneutic for reading the prophetic texts. In the 1397 manuscript mentioned earlier, the opening page presents a large image of the Trinity as an enthroned God the Father, with dove and crucifix. Around the throne, four Evangelists at desks write scrolls. A leafy branch with eight quatrefoils, each containing the head of a prophet, decorates the margins. None is named, though each is distinctive, and they all gaze up or across at the Trinity. Encoded in this illustration is the clear message that the prophets are necessary witnesses to the truth of the Evangelists’ writings, yet the artist’s thick dividing line renders them outside the frame. Their pointed caps and long divided beards identify them as Jews, clearly distinguished from the bare-headed, lightly bearded Evangelists, who strikingly resemble God the Father. The illustration captures medieval ambivalence toward the prophets as essential witnesses to Christian truth yet outside it, and dangerously resistant.

Recent studies of the Paris book trade have shown that production of small one-volume vernacular Bibles was a new and robust phenomenon in the thirteenth century.¹⁰ Advances in paper production made possible thinner pages than ever before, the development of a smaller cursive allowed more words on a page, and the presence of universities, cathedral schools, and interested laity provided a reliable market. Stephen Langdon’s scheme of biblical chapter divisions, devised at the end of the twelfth century in Paris, made these Bibles especially useful for scholastic disputation.¹¹ Paris Bibles are another witness to the instability of the term “Bible.” Some set more contemporary prologues next to Jerome’s, adding yet another layer of guidance for the reader. The order of the books differed from some earlier manuscripts by grouping all the historical

books except Maccabees after the Torah, an aspect of the medieval Bible that remains normative today. This arrangement highlighted the literal sense as the beginning of interpretation, and created a continuous biblical history.¹² The prologues to the prophets encouraged readers to interpret them in the context of this history; at the same time, christological interpretation of their words required dissociating them from it. In an engaging essay on vernacular Bibles in medieval France, Margriet Hoogvliet captures the rich diversity of medieval biblical reading practices, referring to the Bible as a “flexible text” read selectively and discontinuously in many different forms. In addition to abridgements and paraphrases, there were single biblical books, sermons on biblical books, and lectionaries for the church year. In monasteries, the breviary set prophetic passages into a cycle of prayer shaped by the liturgical year. Monks would experience prophetic poetry when they sang daily canticles throughout the church year (Isaiah 12, 26, and 38; Habakkuk 3; Jonah 2). An illuminated French breviary shows Jeremiah at prayer, as if in solidarity with the monks, set in the midst of the page of readings leading up to Holy Week. Such continually changing contexts characterized the medieval experience of reading the prophets in the Bible.

PROPHETS PERFORMING ON A MEDIEVAL STAGE

The textual Bible was only one of multiple media in which medieval people experienced the prophets. Evidence from popular culture is evanescent, but widespread use of biblical dramas suggests that the prophets were contemporized, accessible characters. One of the earliest and most influential liturgical dramas was the eleventh-century *Ordo Prophetarum*, also called *Processus Prophetarum*, featuring costumed actors representing biblical prophets proclaiming their prophecies of the Messiah in metered Latin verse. It dramatically enacts parts of the early fifth-century sermon *Contra Judaeos, Paganos, et Arianos sermo de Symbolo*, whose traditional, though mistaken, attribution to Augustine established its lasting authority. Whereas Augustine had described Jewish faithfulness as a witness to God’s law until the eschaton, his disciple Quodvultdeus, who became bishop of Carthage, wrote with vitriol of Jewish stubbornness. His *Contra Judaeos* includes an extended presentation of thirteen prophetic witnesses to Christ as the Messiah, grouped as Old Testament prophets, Jewish prophets in the Gospels, and blessed pagan prophets. They are invoked with, “You, O Jews, I prosecute,” a line used in the play *Adam*.

Early twelfth-century drama such as the Christmas play from *Carmina Burana* used prophets to teach themes of the Incarnation at Advent and Christmas, while the more complex twelfth-century Anglo-Norman play *Adam* engaged the prophets in an extended Lenten meditation.¹³ This dramatic enactment in Old French, performed both within and outside the church, united the mystical power of the ancient

prophets with the familiarity of costumed contemporaries speaking the vernacular. The play begins with a dramatic enactment of the Fall and the story of Cain and Abel, and ends with a vivid scene of the harrowing of hell, when Christ redeems the prophets and other Old Testament characters who have been banished there throughout the play. The group included Moses, David, and Balaam, along with the usual major prophets and the New Testament “prophets” Elizabeth, Simeon, and John the Baptist. More surprising was the appearance of Nebuchadnezzar, Virgil, and the Sibyl as prophets. Nebuchadnezzar recites Daniel 3:25, exclaiming with surprise that there were not three but four men in the burning furnace into which Daniel’s three friends had been thrown, and the fourth looked like “a son of God (*similis filio Dei*).” The Roman poet Virgil would appear to the congregation like a biblical prophet when he entered reciting from his Fourth Eclogue, “Behold from the heavens a single new offspring has been sent.” He was followed by the mysterious Sibyl, whose prophetic authority first appeared in second century B.C.E. Jewish texts. Her place in the medieval constellation of prophets was assured by Augustine, who devotes Chapter 23 of his *City of God* to her prophecy of Christ’s judgment at the last day. This prophecy is a fixture of the Mass for the Dead, where it appears in the thirteenth-century hymn *Dies Irae* as evidence for the coming judgment that will reduce the world to ashes. Processing into the nave at Christmas with the biblical prophets, she chants, “From heaven a once and future king will come, present in the flesh to judge the world” (*Sibylline Oracle* 163–165). The awesome Sibyl is balanced by the comic character of Balaam, who rides into the nave on a wooden ass propelled by actors hidden under the colorful cloths decorating the animal. The messianic prophecy of Balaam’s fourth oracle (Numbers 24) is preceded by a slapstick confrontation of ass, angel, and impatient prophet. This scene was so popular that it took on an afterlife in Rouen and then in Chester in the fourteenth century as the *Festum asinorum*. In this Feast of the Ass, holy prophets are replaced by a bumbling Balaam, angry angel, and visionary ass. In some versions, the Mass ended with the priest braying and the people responding in kind, “Hee-haw.”¹⁴

Eleven costumed actors narrate the life of Jesus through prophecies, though also exhorting the congregation to keep God’s law. Jeremiah enters with a scroll, dramatically proclaiming the words of Jeremiah 7:2–3. At the words “who enter in at these gates to worship the Lord,” the stage directions instruct the actor, “And with his hand he will point to the doors of the church.” In this play the prophets literally stand between Adam’s sin and Christ’s salvation, bearing witness to the human need for penance and redemption. Their unique status as both prefiguring and participating in salvation is apparent near the play’s end, when Christ descends into the jaws of Hell to spring them loose from the demons holding them. The play ends with Nebuchadnezzar as prophet proclaiming hope to the congregation through his altered version of Daniel 3:25. Traditionally, Nebuchadnezzar’s reference to one “like a son of God” is taken as christological prophecy; here, he describes *all four* of the young men as “sons of God,” restored to the divine image forfeited by the sin in the Garden at the beginning of the play.

These plays highlight the unstable amalgam of patristic and early medieval thought forms that characterizes medieval reception of the prophets. What may have been a rhetorical trope in fifth-century patristic writings became in medieval drama a statement about flesh-and-blood Jewish neighbors. In *Adam*, Isaiah's prophecy of the virgin conceiving is interrupted by "somebody from the synagogue" who disputes it, asking, "Is this serious or a joke?" He taunts Isaiah with, "You seem like an old dotard to me; your mind is addled. You appear to be senile." The stage directions instruct the actor to "bawl and shout, agitating his body and head, imitating with his scepter the mannerisms of a Jew and deriding the prophecies." This caricature of contemporary Jews in a dramatic enactment of the Christian accusations about Jews rejecting their own prophets was particularly dangerous because it transformed an abstract theological debate into hostility toward people living in the cathedral town where the play was performed.

PROPHETS STANDING GUARD AT THE DOOR OF THE CHURCH

The doorways of cathedrals brought the prophets into the public arena. Beginning in the twelfth century, church doors were transformed from a barrier separating the profane outside world and the sacred interior to a public proclamation of salvation history. Unlike the altar art that dominated the first millennium, cathedral façades were experienced outside the liturgy. Charles Altman notes, "Portal art interfaces, as it were, the eternal repose of the church within and the hustle-and-bustle of the world without. In general the rise of representational and narrative sculpture in Romanesque art may be related to this desire to evangelize, to make truths live for the masses."¹⁵ A good example of the prophets as part of the "medieval marquee" is the twelfth-century Abbaye St. Pierre de Moissac in the southwest of France. At the south entrance the doors are flanked by statues of Jeremiah and Paul, facing Isaiah and Peter. Isaiah holds a scroll that reads, *ecce virgo concipiet*, the first three words of Isaiah 7:14. The statue of Jeremiah is extraordinary for its pathos and serenity, signaled by the prophet's twisted posture yet gentle expression, evoking Christ's passion. These two prophets greeting worshipers as they entered the cathedral provided an elegant shorthand for the Christian mysteries of incarnation and salvation. The companion statues of Peter and Paul proclaimed the institution of the church as guardians of these mysteries. Almost subliminally, worshipers were prepared for what they would experience inside.

Nearby, one of the most detailed visual presentations of prophets in a cathedral entrance is the set of the twelve minor and three major prophets surrounding the butresses. Sculptors relied on a small set of visual cues to signal the identity of the figure. Statues of prophets sometimes wore the conical cap of the medieval Jew to identify them with the Old Testament, distinguishing them from the apostles. A banderole in the prophet's hands, often with just a few words from a key text, identified the prophet

and the idea the viewer was to ponder. Sometimes an object identified the prophet and evoked an idea: Ezekiel with a model of the Temple, or with two wheels; Jonah being disgorged from a fish, or under a bush; Isaiah with two seraphim.

The west façade of the thirteenth-century cathedral at Amiens beautifully displays medieval fascination with the exotic details of biblical prophecy and the imaginative contemporizing that interpreted these details. The twelve minor and three major prophets are represented by seven-foot statues, with two quatrefoils in the pediment below displaying scenes distinctive to the prophet above it. The viewer is invited to contemplate iconic images that evoke the prophets' stories, but in contemporary settings. Jonah sulks under his gourd outside a Gothic building; Hosea places a ring on his medieval bride's finger; Daniel sits among lions that hunch like gargoyles; Isaiah contemplates his vision of the seated Lord wearing the crown of a French monarch. Zephaniah's threat that God will search Jerusalem with lamps for evildoers (Zeph 1:12) becomes a contemporary warning in the sculpture of God inspecting a Gothic cathedral by the light of two medieval lanterns. Some prophets are playfully contemporized to reflect the architects and craftsmen who built the cathedral. Two metalworkers in medieval tunics hammering medieval daggers illustrate Micah 4:3; the Lord working on a medieval cathedral with a tool illustrates Ezek. 40:3; the seated prophet having a vision of Christ holding not a plumb line but a mason's trowel alludes to Amos 7:8. Sometimes a bizarre prophecy afforded artistic license. Zechariah 5:6–7 is slyly represented by two angels, one wearing a medieval cap, holding a large cooking pot with a naked woman perched atop its edge. Her fully sculpted buttocks and breast, jaunty posture, and finely carved, defiant face suggest that the artist chose this verse, with its feminine figure of Wickedness, for the artistic opportunities it offered. Finally, a number of images show prophets in scenes not found in their biblical books. These illustrate the way medieval Christians experienced biblical prophets as confections of multiple traditions and constructions of an artist's imagination. The four quatrefoils devoted to Obadiah all illustrate scenes from the story of Elijah (1 Kings 18) in which another, unrelated Obadiah has an important part; no text in the book of Obadiah is illustrated. Habakkuk is not represented by any image from his book, but by the apocryphal story of an angel transporting him by the hair, bread in hand, to feed Daniel in his den of lions. In medieval reception the prophets became a lively amalgam of Scripture, apocryphal tradition, and contemporary culture.

Their architectural position on the jambs of doors and as supporting pillars signaled the prophets' role as the structural support of the Christian narrative.¹⁶ For the medieval mind, prophetic words demonstrated the Nativity and Passion as part of a still-unfolding divine plan, and the prophets were the architectural foundation that supported these Christian truths. The typical placement of these statues at the top of the stairs and near the portico further suggests a parallel between their theological role of preparation for the Gospel and their practical function of preparing worshipers by focusing their imaginations as they entered the church. Christians could literally walk through salvation history, from prophecy to fulfillment, as they went from the steps of the cathedral to the nave with its narratives in stained glass to the living presence of Christ in the host on the altar.

Inside their churches, medieval Christians experienced the prophets differently in the jewel-like stained glass windows that refracted colored light across the aisles. In these artistic renderings, the prophets illustrated Gospel traditions prefigured in Israel's history. The traditional typologies that linked Balaam's fourth prophecy with the wise men following the star, Jeremiah 9:8 with Judas's kiss, Daniel's Babylonian accusers with those of Jesus, Jonah's three days in the belly of the fish with Jesus' three days in the tomb, and Ezekiel's valley of dry bones with the general resurrection were all illustrated by medieval characters in dazzling color. The prophets sometimes appeared as a group, their individuality minimized to highlight their common witness. The cathedral at Bourges contains striking stained glass windows in the apse, around the high altar. The four major prophets, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Daniel, are placed to correspond with the four Evangelists. The twelve minor prophets are similarly mirror images of the twelve apostles; the theological relation is visually encoded by the similarity of dress, nimbus, and book in the hand of each. Only the pointed cap of the Jew distinguishes prophet from apostle in these windows. These thirteenth-century windows offer evidence that medieval reception of the prophets sometimes erased the particularity of speech and context displayed in the biblical books, in order to present "the prophets" as a unified witness to the narrative of salvation history. In these images, the orderly unfolding of the divine plan from prophecy to fulfillment is all a Christian needed to know about the prophets.

A unique image of the prophets is found under the rose window at the south end of Chartres Cathedral, where five large rectangular windows (dated 1200–1235) show Virgin and child flanked by the four major prophets. Each standing prophet holds an Evangelist seated on his shoulders. On the left, Jeremiah holds Luke, and Isaiah holds Matthew; on the right, Ezekiel holds John, and Daniel holds Mark. This image of Evangelists on the shoulders of prophets is not traditional, but rather reflects a contemporary idea, found in the work of late twelfth-century scholar Jean de Salisbury (d. 1180), secretary to Thomas Becket. Writing about his teacher Bernard of Chartres in his *Metalogicon*, he said, "We are dwarves seated on the shoulders of giants. If we see more and further than they did, it is not because of our insight, or our greatness, but because we have been raised up by them."¹⁷ These windows change the patristic understanding of the prophets as forerunners eclipsed by the subject of their prophecies to a new idea of the prophets as teachers of the Evangelists. Perhaps the prophets in this commanding window were intended to convey to thirteenth-century Christians a reminder of their debt to their forebears.

THE PROPHETS AT THE INTERSECTION OF INTELLECTUAL DEBATE

The second contested area of medieval life embodied in the prophets was the challenge that developing academic traditions posed to the patristic traditions that had

dominated for some seven hundred years. In the eleventh century, John Cassian's fourfold sense of Scripture was the norm; it was inscribed in the physical layout of the *Glossa Ordinaria*, embodied in the figures of stained glass windows, and performed in the lectionary readings. The classic example is Jerusalem, mentioned often by the prophets. In the plain sense, it is the ancient city; allegorically it represents the earthly church, struggling against enemies from without and weakness from within. In the tropological (moral) sense, Jerusalem is the Christian soul, the locus of divine indwelling. Finally, in the anagogical (mystical) sense, Jerusalem is the heavenly city that will be revealed at the end of time. These senses were complementary, forming an organic whole whose meanings opened onto one another. The *Glossa Ordinaria* imbued generations of readers with this complex approach to prophetic texts. The Enlightenment insistence on a single meaning, which had the unintended consequence of fueling Fundamentalism in the late nineteenth century, would have been inscrutable to the medieval mind.

Peter Lombard's prologue to his commentary on Isaiah offers an example of the traditional allegorizing exegesis that guided early medieval readers of the prophets. On the construction of the Tabernacle in Exodus 36:31–34, he writes,

The five bars which hold together the boards of one side of the tabernacle are the five books of the Law, which uphold the Church against every shock; she is rightly called the tabernacle while toiling and militant in her pilgrimage on earth. The five other bars at the west side are the five prophetic books: Isaiah, Jeremias, Ezechiel, Daniel and the book of the Twelve Prophets. They join together the boards on the other side of the tabernacle; for they firmly establish the doctrine of the Church's preachers, and overlay them with the gold of heavenly wisdom.¹⁸

Lombard's allegorical reading reflects the view that Christian exegesis should privilege figural interpretation that supports the church's teaching.

The confluence of intellectual traditions from Jews and Arabs into the cathedral schools and universities of Paris in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries challenged this traditional reception of the prophets. The proximity of the city of Troyes, with its significant population of Jewish scholars, offered Christians access to Jewish learning and new appreciation of the *hebraica veritas*. In the early eleventh century, Spanish Jews fleeing persecution had brought their knowledge of Arabic and their linguistic expertise to northern France. Their legacy endured most notably in Rashi and his heirs, who transformed Jewish exegesis by subordinating midrash to historical and linguistic exegesis. His format of lemmatized commentary kept the reader close to the biblical text, as did his translation of technical Hebrew words into contemporary French; he offers *cristal* for the rare stone in Ezekiel 1:16 and the homey *boillant* for the inscrutable Hebrew describing Jeremiah's pot in Jeremiah 1:13. Peter Comestor had been dean of the cathedral in Troyes before going to the new University of Paris in 1168, and finally to the school of St. Victor. The characteristic emphasis on Scripture as history that marked Jewish exegesis is a hallmark of Comestor's narrative *Bible historiale*.

Some of the scholar-monks at the school of St. Victor in Paris had adopted Jewish traditions of Troyes into Christian exegesis before Comestor popularized them. A striking example is Ezekiel 40–48, the prophet's vision of the new Temple. The text is so difficult that ancient exegetes from Jerome on had abandoned attempts at a plain sense. Appealing to Ezekiel's description of the structure on a high mountain as "*like a city*," Gregory (540–604) developed an elaborate allegory of Ezekiel's Temple as the church, positioned between Heaven and earth in her role as mediatrix. The prophet's journey up the mountain and his steps from outer to inner courtyards of the Temple figure the Christian's passage from shadowy image to the clarity of true substance. In the mid-twelfth century, Richard of St. Victor, influenced by Rashi to privilege the plain sense, departed from this established tradition to read Ezekiel 40–48 as an architect's blueprint. Like Rashi, he supplies his commentary with extensive drawings of the entire Temple complex, including a full-page schematic illustration of the sanctuary. Like an architect, Richard uses frontal and lateral elevations to orient the viewer. He references contemporary French building practices to interpret the biblical text. Richard reads Ezekiel's description of the east gateway in the Temple wall (Ezek 40:13–15) literally, using the architectural practices of his own time. His drawing of the gateway shows a three-story gatehouse, with rounded windows and crenellations in the style of Romanesque architecture. His interest in the literal sense, at least when it involves visualizing physical structures in biblical texts, is also apparent in his drawings of the Tabernacle, rejecting traditional allegorizing in favor of architectural drawing.¹⁹

Rashi's approach to the prophets is epitomized by Andrew of St. Victor. Taught by rabbis and influenced by exegesis at Troyes, he wrote extensive commentaries on Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel. His prologue to Isaiah refers to the "abysmal depth, perplexing intricacy, the startling diversity of people and things" in the prophetic writings that daunt him, yet whose intellectual challenge seems to allure him. Perhaps the most distinctive contribution is his steady gaze at the prophet as human person, set in a particular context. His prologue to Isaiah presents a novelistic portrait, drawn from Jewish as well as Christian sources, of a noble, eloquent, holy, and brave prophet. Unlike imposing stone statues or contemporized actors in plays, this human Isaiah belongs to ancient Jerusalem. Commenting on the rod coming forth from the root of Jesse (Isa 11:1), Andrew ignores the christological sense embedded in stained glass and poetry, instead beginning with an exposition of how Isaiah has "cheered with good hope the fallen spirits of the Two Tribes, and roused them from the heavy slumber of despair."²⁰ His commitment to the plain sense is apparent in his insistence that in Isaiah 7:14 the prophet describes a sign intended for Ahaz, and that the Hebrew word rendered by Jerome as *virgo* meant simply "young woman." Even his fellow Victorine Richard attacked him for this "Judaizing" interpretation. Yet he continues in his insistence on a non-christological reading of prime prophetic texts, even interpreting the man of sorrows in Isaiah 53:3 as the people in the Babylonian captivity whose suffering expiated the sins of the unrighteous as well as their own.²¹

If the proximity of Jewish scholars to Paris brought new insights to prophetic texts, the innovations that the recovery of Aristotle introduced to the universities of Paris

dangerously challenged traditional reception of the prophets. Using dialectical reasoning, logic, and even science, scholars were empowering students to think through their own interpretations, rather than rehearse patristic teachings. The lavishly illustrated polemical *Bible moralisée* interprets Jeremiah 23:29 with the prophet, marked by a cruciform halo, standing under an image of a Gothic church, smashing a rock with a hammer. The accompanying roundel contemporizes Jeremiah with a picture of a philosopher teaching a group of students, some of whom turn to worship an idol of a demon in a medieval roadside shrine. The brief text refers to the dangerous teaching of the heretics (philosophers) as chaff with no kernel. Throughout the *Bible moralisée*, biblical prophets are pictured indicting medieval philosophers, clearly identified by one hand holding a book, the other with raised forefinger in a teaching gesture. A devil usually appears somewhere in the picture.

The real danger that the new Scholastic embrace of reason posed to ordinary Christian belief is apparent in the dramatized use of Isaiah 7:14 in the *Carmina Burana* Christmas play. Confronting the skeptical Archsynagogus, who has proclaimed the idea of a virgin bearing a child “*fantasma*” and “*non doctrinae cumulus*” (not the smartest teaching), the figure of Augustine rejects his “sophistical precepts” as defective. He deftly argues, “Reason teaches that nature is not rejected” by a unique occurrence outside the normal order. The Archsynagogus responds that the biology of reproduction “in Aristotle is explained for children.” Now trading faith for the new vocabulary of science, Augustine triumphantly ends the argument with the example of the sun’s rays penetrating glass without harming it to illustrate the descent of the Son into the Virgin’s womb.²² In this dramatic scene, medieval Christians experienced the prophet Isaiah at the intersection of traditional and contemporary philosophical modes of thinking about their faith.

THE PROPHETS AS MARKERS OF CHRISTIAN AMBIVALENCE TOWARD JEWS

The prophets embodied for medieval Christians the discomfiting paradox posed by faithful Jews living in their midst with both intimacy and distance.²³ The reception of Jonah uniquely captures the complexity. For Christians he signifies a disobedient Jew, but his three days in the belly of the fish also figure Christ in the tomb, and his deliverance foreshadows the resurrection. Jews, on the other hand, read Jonah on Yom Kippur because it teaches human sin and divine mercy in equal measure. Augustine had taught that Jews were crucial to Christian society because they provided a unique witness to the truth of the Law and the Prophets.²⁴ His scriptural basis, Psalms 59:12 (“Slay them not, lest my people forget”), became central in debates about the place of Jews in thirteenth-century Paris. The arguments turned on the distinction between the ancient recipients of the Law and *Judaei moderni*, contemporary French Jews of the thirteenth century. The former were faithful to the Law and the Prophets, while the latter had abandoned

these for the Talmud and other “heretical” writings. This construction of the Jews living in their midst gave medieval Christians license to set aside Augustine’s long authoritative admonition about the crucial witness of Jews. In 1215 the Fourth Lateran Council forbade Jews and Christians from living and working together and mandated that Jews wear distinctive clothing. In 1240 cartloads of the Talmud and other Jewish books were publically burned in Paris.²⁵ There were of course political and economic motives driving these actions, but here we consider two subtler realities behind Christian hostility, which bear on reception of the prophets.

The presence of Jews living precariously in medieval Europe implicitly raised two discomfiting theological problems for Christians. The first was why God had not delivered on promises to the chosen people and had apparently broken his word. To address this potential threat to the faith, the prophets were invoked as evidence that God had not abandoned Israel, but rather Jews had rejected God. Contemporary Jewish faithfulness to the plain sense of prophetic texts was equated with the “stubbornness” of Jews in antiquity, who had refused to listen to Isaiah (6:9–10), Jeremiah (7:26, 17:23, 19:15), and Ezekiel (2:4). This idea was graphically rendered in Bible illustrations. Throughout the *Bible moralisée*, prophets resemble Christian saints, while ancient Israelites are pictured as contemporary Jews wearing tunics and pointed hats.²⁶ The death verdict against Jeremiah in Jeremiah 26:11 is accompanied by a contemporizing roundel showing medieval Jews accusing Jesus. The text reads, “This figures the Scribes, Pharisees and people crying, ‘Crucify, crucify!’” Similarly, the vernacular *Bible historiale* popularized this contemporizing exegesis by portraying biblical prophets, sometimes with a halo, speaking to hostile, inattentive medieval Jews. The increasingly polemical identification of ancient Israel as *Judaei moderni* was designed to bolster the Christian construction of the prophets as proto-Christians whose words were rejected in antiquity and willfully misinterpreted in the present. This view of the prophets offered an answer to the troublesome question of why God’s chosen people apparently did not flourish. It also, *mutatis mutandi*, reserved to Christians the prophetic words of comfort.

A second problem for some thoughtful Christians was the persistent faithfulness of Jews who lived among them. An especially troubling manifestation was Jewish constancy in reading the contextual sense of prophetic texts rather than accepting the allegorical interpretations so compelling for Christians. That learned rabbis steeped in Hebrew so consistently read prophetic texts differently had an effect on some Christians, as the example of Andrew of St. Victor described earlier shows. Disbelieving Jews became a trope for doubting Christians, and prophetic indictments of Israel signified God’s judgment of *anyone* who did not accept the church’s teaching. Prophetic condemnation of Israel was therefore an indispensable staple of medieval Christian polemic, aimed at philosophers, heretics, and ordinary Christians with doubts. Implicit in this reading of the prophets is the belief that Christians who doubted the church’s teachings were like Jews.²⁷ Jews and philosophers are often portrayed together in the illustrations of the *Bible moralisée* as dangerous to the faithful. Peter Damian wrote *Antilogus contra Iudaeos* (ca. 1070) in response to a request that he write a treatise that would equip Christians to “block the mouths of the Jews” in arguments. Damian agreed to help

equip Christians with arguments in part, he said, because not knowing how to reason about Christ “begets error and doubt in the hearts of the faithful.”²⁸ Christian scholars after Damian took up the challenge of “Jewish disbelief,” writing treatises that ostensibly furnished Christians with arguments against Jewish interlocutors, but are more likely aimed at Christian doubt. Peter the Venerable’s *Against the Inveterate Stubbornness of the Jews* (1144), a turning point in the argumentation, invokes the prophets as chief witnesses. The argument moves from the (irrefutable) witness of the prophets and other “rational” arguments to the claim that Jews could not see the truth because they were not rational and therefore not fully human. This portrayal of Jews was dramatically enacted in the caricature of the Archsynagogus rejecting the christological interpretation of Isaiah 7:14 performed in church dramas described earlier. Though the image of the sun penetrating glass without harm is aimed at the costumed “Jew,” its intended audience was Christians in the nave struggling with real doubt. The problem of Christian doubt is addressed directly in the shepherd scene of the *Carmina Burana* Christmas play. When the angel proclaims the birth of the savior from an eternal Virgin, without carnal intercourse, a costumed devil appears three times, saying, “You shouldn’t believe such things. You should know them to be nonsense which the truth does not verify.”²⁹ The devil’s repeated warnings against being simpleminded are answered by an angel, but they nevertheless must have resonated with nagging questions in the congregation. Christian doubt was triggered in part by the intellectual resources of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, even as faith came to be buttressed with the same resources. The syllogistic theology of Thomas Aquinas seems designed to combat doubt with reason. That medieval Christians struggled with questions about some of the church’s teachings is well documented; the complex place of the prophets in this phenomenon deserves more attention.³⁰ The prophets therefore represented for Christians the twin theological dilemmas of the continued existence of Jewish faithfulness to God’s covenant in spite of the cost, and the threat of Christian doubt.

For medieval Jews, the prophets represented both an omnipresent sign of their subjection and constant assurances of God’s love. Christian triumphalism was on view everywhere, from the faith of kings and the imposing presence of large churches to the various edicts restricting Jews. The prophets had a subtle but persistent role in this relentless challenge to Jewish faith. The comely stone statues of Isaiah, Jeremiah, or Daniel adorning and supporting cathedrals were visible reminders of what had happened to their heritage. The words on prophet’s banderoles were in the church’s Latin, a reminder that the dominant culture understood the object of their prophecies to have shifted from Israel to the church. During Holy Week, Jews remained behind locked doors as Christians were inflamed by the prophecies of Isaiah and Jeremiah. In this environment, the prophets addressed the reasonable doubts of faithful Jews who wondered whether God had indeed abandoned Israel. On the other hand, in the violence of the Crusades and of local pogroms, prophetic promises sustained Jewish communities struggling with questions about God’s faithfulness. Michael Signer argues that Rashi’s commentaries reflect a hermeneutic of divine love for Israel, sometimes recasting earlier rabbinic interpretations of judgment to tropes of comfort. Commenting on Jacob’s sons listed in

Exodus 1:1, Rashi invokes Isaiah 40:26, comparing the twelve to stars that seem to disappear when they set, but which reappear according to God's plan.³¹ Another poignant invocation of a prophetic text for contemporary solace introduces Rashi's commentary to Song of Songs, read at Passover, a dangerous time for medieval Jews. To his contemporaries' question of why Israel was not yet redeemed, Rashi interprets Song of Songs by means of Hosea: "Solomon [the traditional author] understood by means of the Holy Spirit that the Israelites were destined to endure one exile after another and one destruction after another . . . They would mourn . . . and remember His initial affection, saying, 'I will return to my first husband' (Hos. 2:9) and they would remember God's steadfast love and their transgressions." Rashi concludes that Song of Songs intended to evoke for Jews Hosea's story of a woman abandoned by her husband, who later takes pity on her sorrow, remembers her beauty and good deeds, and says that she remains his beloved wife.³² At Passover in medieval France, Hosea could comfort the aching hearts of hunted Jews; throughout the year all the prophets brought hope.

Reception of the prophets in medieval culture blended ancient teachings with contemporary politics, high art, and popular entertainment; the best and worst of Christian practices; and bitter polemics as well as rich intellectual collaboration between Christians and Jews. May the retrieval of this complex legacy help complicate the term "Middle Ages."

NOTES

1. Stephen Greenblatt's *The Swerve: How the World Became Modern* (New York and London: W. W. Norton, 2012) unfortunately perpetuates this view, especially in chapter 4.
2. Gabrielle M. Spiegel, "In the Mirror's Eye: The Writing of Medieval History in America," *Imagined Histories: American Historians Interpret the Past* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1998), 253.
3. Avril Henry, *Biblia Pauperum: A Facsimile and Edition* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1987), 116, 118.
4. This and all translations of Jerome are my own unless otherwise noted.
5. James H. Morey, "Peter Comestor, Biblical Paraphrase, and the Medieval Popular Bible," *Speculum* 68 (1993): 6–35 (6).
6. *PL* 198 col. 1053.
7. Morey, "Peter Comestor," 35.
8. *PL* 198 col. 1409D–1415A.
9. For a study of the ecclesial intrigue and commercial interests surrounding this early vernacular Bible, see Rosemarie Potz McGerr, "Guyart Desmoulins, the Vernacular Master of Histories and His *Bible historiale*," *Viator* 14 (1983): 211–244 (212).
10. Laura Light, "The Bible and the Individual," in *The Practice of the Bible in the Middle Ages: Production, Reception, and Performance in Western Christianity*, ed. Susan Boynton and Diane J. Reilly (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011), 228–246.
11. Paul Saenger, "The Anglo-Hebraic Origins of the Modern Chapter Division of the Latin Bible," in *La fractura historiográfica; las investigaciones de Edad Media u Renacimiento desde el tercer milenio*, ed. Javier Burguillo and Laura Mier (Salamanca: SEMYR, 2008), 177–202.

12. Light, "The Bible and the Individual," 232.
13. The plays are conveniently available in original languages and translation in David Bevington, *Medieval Drama* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1975). For an insightful study of theological themes in *Adam*, see M. F. Vaughan, "The Prophets of the Anglo-Norman 'Adam,'" (*Traditio*) 39 (1983): 82–114.
14. *Encyclopedia Britannica*, 11th ed. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1910), Vol. X, 616.
15. Charles Altman, "The Medieval Marquee," in *Popular Culture in the Middle Ages*, ed. Josie P. Campbell (Bowling Green, OH: Bowling Green State University Popular Press, 1986), 6–15 (9).
16. The suggestion is from Emile Mâle, *The Gothic Image: Religious Art in France of the Thirteenth Century* (trans. Dora Nussey; New York: Harper & Row, 1958, 1972), 158–160.
17. My translation of Jean de Salisbury's French.
18. Beryl Smalley, *The Study of the Bible in the Middle Ages* (South Bend, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1940, 1978), 130.
19. Walter Cahn, "Architecture and Exegesis: Richard of St.-Victor's Ezekiel Commentary and Its Illustrations," *The Art Bulletin*, 76(1) (1994): 53–68.
20. Smalley, *Study of the Bible in the Middle Ages*, 138.
21. Smalley, *Study of the Bible in the Middle Ages*, 165.
22. Bevington, *Medieval Drama*, 186–187.
23. This evocative description is from John Van Engen's Introduction to Michael A. Signer and John Van Engen, eds., *Jews and Christians in Twelfth-Century Europe* (Notre Dame Conferences in Medieval Studies 10; South Bend, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2001), 1–8 (5).
24. Paula Fredriksen, *Augustine and the Jews: A Christian Defense of Jews and Judaism* (New York: Doubleday, 2008), 302–304.
25. For bibliography on the trials and burning of the Talmud, see Aden Kumler, "Faire Translater, Faire Historier: Charles V's *Bible historiale* and the Visual Rhetoric of Vernacular *Sapience*," *Studies in Iconography* 29 (2008): 90–135 (129 n. 57, 113 n. 65). Kumler shows the extensive anti-Jewish polemic in the illustrations of a richly illuminated fourteenth-century manuscript of the *Bible historiale* in the library of Charles V.
26. A fine study of Jews in the *Bible moralisée* is Sara Lipton, *Images of Intolerance: Images of Jews and Judaism in the Bible moralisée* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1999). For a broader exploration of Christian portrayals of Jews in medieval art, see Lipton's *Dark Mirror: The Medieval Origins of Anti-Jewish Iconography* (New York: Metropolitan Books, 2014).
27. On the role of Christian doubt in medieval anti-Jewish polemic, see Gavin I. Langmuir, "Doubt in Christendom," *Toward a Definition of Antisemitism* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1990), 100–133.
28. Langmuir, "Doubt in Christendom," 129.
29. Bevington, *Medieval Drama*, 196.
30. See Wendy Love Anderson, "The Real Presence of Mary: Eucharistic Disbelief and the Limits of Orthodoxy in Fourteenth-Century France," *Church History* 75 (2006): 748–767.
31. Michael Signer, "God's Love for Israel: Apologetic and Hermeneutical Strategies in Twelfth-Century Jewish Exegesis," in *Jews and Christians in Twelfth-Century Europe*, 123–149 (136).
32. Signer, "God's Love for Israel," 131–132.

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PART III

ENGAGING
THE PROPHETS

F. Situated Readings

CHAPTER 25

CONTEMPORARY JEWISH READINGS OF THE PROPHETS

MARVIN A. SWEENEY

IN his 1903 address given in honor of Kaufman Kohler, Solomon Schechter labeled higher biblical criticism as “higher anti-Semitism.”¹ Kohler had been named president of Hebrew Union College in Cincinnati. Schechter, president of the Jewish Theological Seminary of America, was the founding figure of Conservative Judaism in America. Schechter’s remarks focused on the need for modern Judaism to claim the Bible for its own as the basis for Jewish thought and self-identity. His remarks came during the heyday of the great Protestant Old Testament Bible critics of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, who employed biblical criticism as a means to reconstruct the history of Israelite religion as culminating in the emergence of Christianity.

Scholars, such as Julius Wellhausen in pentateuchal studies and Bernhard Duhm in prophetic studies, defined source criticism as the regnant scholarly approach to the study of biblical literature.² Both had pioneered source-critical methodology, in which one would examine inconsistencies and disjuncture in biblical texts in an effort to identify the later additions that had expanded and distorted the true meaning of the original layers of biblical literature. For Wellhausen the J (JHWH) source, which emphasized face-to-face communication between YHWH and humans, like the communication between the deity and a prophet, was the earliest source of the Pentateuch. It was later combined with other sources, culminating in the P (Priestly) source, which was concerned with law and ritual, representing an alleged deterioration of the relationship between YHWH and humans that was characteristic of Judaism. For Duhm, the goal of biblical criticism was to identify the words of the true prophets of the prophetic books of the Hebrew Bible and separate them from the later redactional additions of Jewish scribes who, he averred, frequently misunderstood and distorted the true meaning of the prophets’ message of salvation. Both scholars attempted to demonstrate that the principles of true religion and relationship with G-d were inherent in the earliest and most authentic forms of the Hebrew Bible, but that these principles had been obscured by later Jewish redaction.

Schechter was a rabbi and a historical-critical scholar who was well known for his work in the Cairo Genizah documents, which continue to play such an important role in our understanding of the development of Jewish history, literature, and thought. Indeed, Schechter's work in the Cairo Genizah documents played a key role in his understanding of Jewish revelation as an ongoing process in which *K'lal Yisrael*, "All Israel," frequently translated in that time as "Catholic Israel," defined Judaism in each generation. Schechter's viewpoint was inherently historical, and he viewed historical research as essential to the study of the Bible. But his concern was to employ historical research as a means to recognize the development of the Jewish people and Judaism, from the biblical period through modern times. In short, his interest was in viewing the Bible as an inherently Jewish sacred work that served as the foundation for Jewish literature, history, and thought, not as a precursor to Christianity.

The prophets do indeed play an indispensable role in the self-understanding of Christianity, particularly because Christian interpreters read them as figures who anticipate the coming of Christ. Although this may be appropriate from the standpoint of Christian theology, such an interest often distorts or ignores both the Jewish and the historical character and concerns of the prophets. With the rise of critical Jewish biblical scholarship in the latter half of the twentieth century and the outset of the twenty-first century, such issues are now beginning to be addressed. Contemporary Jewish critical scholars share many methodological foundations and viewpoints with their Christian counterparts, but there are nevertheless areas of distinctive concern to Jewish interpreters of the Bible in general and the prophets in particular. This chapter therefore addresses issues faced by Jewish scholars in the field, namely, the place of the prophets in the Tanak (i.e., the Jewish version of the Bible); the historical and social roles of the prophets; and treatment of exile, repentance, and restoration of the people to the Temple and the land of Israel in each of the books of the Latter Prophets, including Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Book of the Twelve Prophets.

THE PROPHETS IN CANONICAL CONTEXT

The prophets play a key role in defining the distinctive theological viewpoints of the Jewish Tanak and the Christian Old Testament. Indeed, the unique forms of the Tanak and the Old Testament provide the foundations for the respective worldviews of Judaism and Christianity.³

Christianity envisions a progressive movement in history from creation through the ultimate revelation of Jesus Christ as the savior of the world. The Christian Bible comprises two major sections. The first is the Old Testament or Old Covenant, which presents human history from creation through the period of human history defined by the Mosaic covenant between G-d and Israel inaugurated at Mount Sinai and its impact on the history of the people of Israel through the Hellenistic period. Overall, the Christian Old Testament understands Israel's history to be one of failure and eschatological

expectation, that is, failure to live by divine law, which culminated in the judgment and exile of the people Israel by foreign powers and the expectation that G-d would intervene in the eschaton to redeem Israel and all humankind.

To that end, the Christian Old Testament comprises four major segments. The first is the Pentateuch or Five Books of Moses, Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy, which relate the earliest history of humankind from creation through the establishment of G-d's covenant with Israel at Mount Sinai and G-d's guidance of the people of Israel through the Wilderness to the boundaries of the promised land of Israel. Key to the covenant was the Torah, understood as "Law" in Christianity, which laid out G-d's expectations for the people of Israel. The second section of the Christian Old Testament is the Historical Books, Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1–2 Samuel, 1–2 Kings, 1–2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther, and in Roman Catholic Bibles, 1–2 Maccabees, Tobit, and Judith, which trace the later history of Israel from the conquest of the land under Joshua through the exile from the land by the Babylonians, and ultimately through the post-exilic period, when Jews lived under Persian rule both in the land of Judah and in the larger Persian Empire, and in Catholic Bibles into the Hellenistic period. The Babylonian Exile, conceived as divine punishment for Israel's failure to live by G-d's Torah or Law, is key to understanding Israel's history as one of judgment for sin. The third section is the Wisdom and Poetic Books, Psalms, Job, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, and in Roman Catholic Bibles, Ecclesiasticus and the Wisdom of Solomon, which address key questions of faith and knowledge that are always pertinent in human life, thereby pointing to this section as a portrayal of concerns that are contemporary and relevant in every age in human life. The fourth and final section is the Prophets, including Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, the Epistle of Jeremiah in Catholic Bibles, Ezekiel, Daniel, and the Twelve Minor Prophets, which point to the future or eschatological expectation of salvation in the aftermath of punishment for sin.

Insofar as the New Testament follows the Prophets, the revelation of Jesus Christ in the New Testament constitutes the eschatological fulfillment of the Old Testament. Indeed, the New Testament is structured similarly to the Old, including the Gospels, which present the earliest revelation of Christ; Acts, which presents the later history of early Christianity; the Epistles, which address the always contemporary issues of Christian theology and practice; and the Apocalypse, which anticipates the eschatological second coming of Christ. Within the larger structure of the Christian Bible, the prophets play a key literary and theological role in the transition that Christians construct from Old Testament to New. They are understood to articulate Old Testament themes and traditions in anticipation of the New; crucial New Testament motifs and events are thus seen as the fulfillment of Old Testament prophecy.

Judaism reads the *Tanakh* as its foundational sacred scripture that provides the ideal basis for Jewish life and Judaism's relationship with G-d, but it also recognizes that this ideal has been disrupted or challenged at various points in Jewish history. Within the Bible, the Babylonian Exile, in which Jerusalem and the Holy Temple were destroyed by the Babylonian Empire in 587–586 B.C.E. and many surviving Jews were taken into exile, stands as the major disruption of the ideal of Jewish life under G-d in the land of Israel.

Beyond the Bible, the Roman destruction of the Second Temple in 70 C.E. and their suppression of the Bar Kochba Revolt in 135 C.E. opened another period of Jewish exile that continued until the establishment of the modern state of Israel in 1948.

Consequently, we may say that the Jewish *Tanakh* has a three-part structure that expresses its sense of the ideals of Jewish life and relationship with G-d in the *Torah*, the disruption of that ideal through the Babylonian exile in the Prophets, and the anticipation of the restoration of that ideal in the *Ketuvim* or Writings. Indeed, *Tanakh* is an acronym for the three parts of the Jewish Bible: the *Torah* or Instruction, the *Nevi'im* or the Prophets, and the *Ketuvim* or the Writings. The *Torah*, frequently mistranslated as “law,” is derived from the Hebrew verb root, *yrh*, which means “to guide, instruct,” presents the ideals of Jewish life and relationship with G-d. It includes the books of Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy, which trace the foundation of Israel in the context of the creation of the universe and the history of humankind. The *Torah* therefore presents the earliest history of Israel, beginning with YHWH’s covenant with Israel’s earliest ancestors, Abraham and Sarah, through the Exodus from Egypt, the revelation of *Torah* at Mount Sinai, the journey through the Wilderness to the promised land of Israel, and Moses’ rehearsal of YHWH’s *Torah* prior to Israel’s movement into the land. The *Torah*’s presentation of Israel’s earliest history and its covenant with G-d stands as the ideal basis for Jewish life, thought, and identity.

The *Nevi'im*, known in English as “The Prophets,” address the disruption of the ideals articulated in the *Torah* by focusing on the problem of the Babylonian Exile. The *Nevi'im* include two basic parts. The *Nevi'im Rishonim*, or the Former Prophets, includes the books of Joshua, Judges, Samuel, and Kings. These books, labeled as Prophets because Jewish tradition maintains that they are written by prophets, present the history of Israel from the entry into the land under Joshua through the period of exile from the land in the Babylonian Exile. Overall, they contend that Israel and Judah failed to observe YHWH’s covenant as articulated in the *Torah* and therefore suffered exile as punishment. The *Nevi'im Ahronim*, or “Latter Prophets,” include the books of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Twelve Prophets. These books present the words of the prophets and narratives about their activities in relation to the major events of Israel’s and Judah’s history in the biblical period. These include the catastrophes suffered by Israel and Judah, namely, the Assyrian destruction of northern Israel in 722–721 B.C.E. and the Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem, Judah, and the Temple in 587–586 B.C.E. and the subsequent exile. They also include the initial restoration of Jewish life in the land of Israel with the rebuilding of the Jerusalem Temple in 520–515 B.C.E. Overall, the Prophets interpret the history of Israel and Judah by positing that the destructions of Israel and Judah were punishments brought about by YHWH for failure to observe the covenant and that the restoration of Jerusalem in the early Persian period was an act of YHWH to demonstrate YHWH’s divine sovereignty from Zion or the Jerusalem Temple over Israel, Judah, and all creation.⁴

The *Ketuvim* or Writings include the books of Psalms, Job, Proverbs, the Five *Megillot* (Song of Songs, Ruth, Lamentations, Qohelet, and Esther), Daniel, Ezra-Nehemiah, and Chronicles. These books anticipate the restoration of ideal Jewish life in the Jerusalem

Temple and land of Israel as articulated in the *Torah* by presenting the Psalms, which serve as the hymnbook of the Temple; Job and Proverbs, which examine divine character and human conduct; the Five *Megillot* or Scrolls, which are read on major Jewish holidays; the book of Daniel, which anticipates divine action to deliver Judaism from foreign oppression; Ezra-Nehemiah, which recounts the return to Jerusalem and the rebuilding of the Temple; and Chronicles, which traces the history of the world from creation through Cyrus's decree to rebuild the Temple. Altogether, the *Ketuvim* anticipate the restoration of the Temple as the holy center of Judaism and the world of creation at large.

In both the Christian Old Testament and the Jewish *Tanakh*, the prophets play the key roles in establishing the basic structure of each Bible and therefore in expressing their unique theological worldviews. In the Christian Bible the prophets appear at the end of the Old Testament to anticipate the New Testament and thereby to facilitate the transition from the Old Covenant under Moses to the New Covenant of Jesus Christ. In Judaism, the prophets both present and interpret the disruption of the ideals of Jewish life, thought, and practice in the land of Israel by positing that they were the results of Israel's and Judah's failures to abide by YHWH's covenant. The Latter Prophets in particular anticipate a restoration in the aftermath of exile in which the people will be restored to the land of Israel and Jerusalem and the Temple will be rebuilt so that the ideals of the Torah might yet be achieved.

PROPHETS IN THE SOCIAL WORLD OF THE ANCIENT NEAR EAST

Prophets in Judaism are interpreters of the will of G-d, human events, and of creation.⁵ On the basis of their interpretation of the divine and creation, they attempt to persuade human beings to adopt specific attitudes and courses of action that are consistent with their understandings of the divine will. This function is recognized by the role that the prophets play in the structure of the *Tanakh* as discussed earlier, in the social worlds of the ancient Near East and ancient Israel and Judah, and in the conceptualization of the transmission of *Torah* in Jewish thought. Although prophets are popularly conceived as foretellers of the future, this is not the primary function of a prophet. Indeed, such a function is reinforced by the role that the prophets play in the Christian Bible as foretellers of the New Covenant with G-d, but foretelling the future is only one of the many functions that prophets perform.

Prophets serve in the ancient Near Eastern world as interpreters of the will of the gods and as interpreters of human events. Examples of prophetic speech and action in ancient Egypt, Canaan, Mesopotamia, and Israel and Judah illustrate this role.⁶

The Admonitions of Ipu-Wer, written as early as the period between the Old and Middle Kingdom (2300–2050 B.C.E.), presents the words of the Egyptian sage

and prophet Ipu-Wer, who observes the breakdown of order in Egyptian society: "Doorkeepers say, 'Let us go and plunder.' The laundryman refuses to carry his load. . . . Men of the Delta carry shields. A man regards his son as his enemy. . . . Foreigners have become people everywhere."⁷ Ipu-Wer's observations form the basis for his contention that Egypt is in need of a new pharaoh, "It shall come that he brings coolness upon the heart. Men shall say, 'He is the herdsman of all men. Evil is not in his heart. Though his herds be small, still he has spent his days in caring for them.' . . . Would that he might perceive their character from the very first generation! Then he would smite down evil; he would stretch forth the arm against it; he would destroy the seed therefore and their inheritance" (*ANET* 443). Ipu-Wer does not name the pharaoh he has in mind, but it is clear that he thinks one is needed.

Prophets likewise function as interpreters of the divine will and the human world in ancient Mesopotamia. Many prophetic texts were recovered from the ancient city of Mari during the reigns of kings Yasmah-Addu (1792–1775 B.C.E.) and Zimri-Lim (1774–1760 B.C.E.), prior to Mari's destruction by King Hammurapi of Babylon. Most of the prophetic texts deal with communication of the divine will instructing the Mari kings to act in human events, for example,

Speak to Zimri-Lim, Thus the prophet of Šamaš: Thus says Šamaš, 'I am the lord of the land! Send quickly to Sippar, the city of life, a great throne for my enjoyable dwelling and your daughter whom I desired from you! Now the kings who confronted you and regularly plundered you have submitted to your power. Now the heap of the enemies' corpses is given to you in the land! . . . Another matter: thus says Šamaš: Hammurabi, King of Kurda, has talked deceitfully with you, and he is contriving a scheme. Your hand will capture him and in his land you will promulgate an edict of restoration. Now, the land in its entirety is given to your hand. When you take control over the city and promulgate the edict of restoration, it shows that your kingship is eternal. (Nissinen, 24–25)

Cryer's study demonstrates that Mesopotamia was especially well known for its *barû* priests, who practiced divination by reading various phenomena, such as features of the livers of sacrificial animals, smoke patterns from incense and fire altars, and the courses of the stars and planets, to determine the will of the gods and thereby to interpret and influence human events. The *barû* were an educated class who learned how to read cuneiform so that they could keep records of their observations for future reference and comparison.

Biblical prophets function along similar lines, although it is noteworthy that they also interpret earlier biblical texts. Hosea contends that יהוה opposes Israel's alliance with Assyria and Egypt during the reign of the house of Jehu and argues instead that Israel should be allied with Aram. He bases his point on contentions that the land is suffering in Hosea 4 and on citations of pentateuchal traditions, such as Jacob's journey to Aram to find a bride and Moses' leading Israel out of Egyptian bondage in Hosea 12. Isaiah opposes alliances with any nation, based on his view that יהוה has chosen Jerusalem and the House of David and will therefore protect them in Isaiah 7. Indeed, Isaiah also cites

the Exodus narrative in arguing that YHWH will punish the Assyrian monarch, much like Egypt at the time of the Exodus in Isaiah 10. Jeremiah calls for observance of divine Torah, and cites the Ten Commandments in Jeremiah 7 to argue against Isaiah that even the Jerusalem Temple will not protect the people if they fail to do so. His visions of YHWH's impending punishment in Jeremiah 1 are based on objects from his everyday life as a priest, such as the priestly staff that he carries and the pots that he must use in the preparation of sacrificial meals at the Temple. And Ezekiel presupposes the imagery of the Holy of Holies in the Jerusalem Temple to inform his vision of YHWH's presence in Ezekiel 1–3. He also cites the so-called Holiness Code of Leviticus 17–26 in arguing that each generation dies for its own sins or lives based on its own righteousness in Ezekiel 18. In all these cases and more, the prophets act as interpreters of the divine will and the human world, and they base their interpretation on their observations of the world and on earlier (pre-)scriptural traditions.

It is no accident, then, that the rabbis saw the prophets as part of the chain of transmission of the Torah. The Mishnah tractate *Pirkei Avot*, Chapters of the Fathers, begins with this statement concerning the transmission of Jewish tradition: “Moses received the Torah from Sinai, and transmitted it to Joshua, and Joshua to the elders, and the elders to the Prophets, and the Prophets transmitted it to the men of the Great Assembly (the Sanhedrin). They said three things, ‘Be deliberate in judgment, raise up many students, and make a fence around the Torah’” (m. Avot 1:1). This is the classic statement concerning the rabbinic view of the transmission, interpretation, and teaching of divine Torah in Judaism, and the prophets are key to the process, that is, they are conceived by the rabbis as interpreters of Torah on a par with Moses and themselves.

It is with this role in mind that discussion may now turn to each of the major prophetic books, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Book of the Twelve Prophets, to illustrate how each is concerned with interpreting the divine will, both in relation to human events and in relation to prior tradition.

THE BOOK OF ISAIAH

Given the role that source criticism has played in the critical discussion of the book of Isaiah, it is entirely appropriate that contemporary Jewish scholarship would take an interest in the issue. With certain exceptions, Jewish scholars have found little need to assert that Isaiah ben Amoz is the author of the entire book. Indeed, the Babylonian Talmud Baba Batra 14b–15a asserts that King Hezekiah and his colleagues wrote the book of Isaiah, which would identify them as the editors of Isaiah's oracles (b. Baba Batra 14b), and the medieval interpreter, R. Abraham ibn Ezra (d. 1167 C.E.) notes irregularities at Isaiah 40:1 that suggest the possibility of an author later than Isaiah.

Contemporary Jewish scholars have been keenly interested in the discussion of the formation of the book of Isaiah, including both the present or final form of the book and the compositional process by which that final form emerged. Although much of

late nineteenth- and twentieth-century critical scholarship focused on identifying the works of the eighth-century prophet, Isaiah ben Amoz, in Isaiah 1–39, the anonymous prophet of the exile known only as Deutero- or Second Isaiah in Isaiah 40–55, and the anonymous prophets collectively known as Trito- or Third Isaiah in Isaiah 56–66,⁸ the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries have seen considerable interest in defining the process by which these blocks of material coalesced to form the present form of the book. Such efforts coincided with the increasing scholarly interest in the literary—rather than solely historical—study of biblical literature, and Isaiah, one of the major foci of source critical scholarship, naturally attracted scholars who would read the book as a coherent and unified literary work.⁹

Yehoshua Gitay's study of Isaiah 40–48 was an important methodological advance in the study of the literary and rhetorical coherence of these chapters, insofar as Gitay was one of a number of scholars who turned to classical rhetoric in an effort to develop the "rhetorical-critical" method advocated by James Muilenberg. In contrast to earlier critical scholarship that had divided Deutero-Isaiah into short generic subunits that had no clear interrelationship among themselves, Gitay studied the communicative function of these chapters in an effort to demonstrate that the various elements did in fact cohere together to produce a message focused on convincing exiled Judeans that YHWH was acting in the world to return the exiles to Jerusalem in order to restore the city.

My own work addressed the emerging interest in the interrelationships between the synchronic literary form of the book as a whole and the diachronic process of composition by which that final form was achieved. My doctoral dissertation studies Isaiah 1 and Isaiah 2–4 within the context of the final form of Isaiah 1–66 in an effort to demonstrate that each block is the product of later redaction of Isaiah's oracles. Thus, Isaiah 1 is the product of a late fifth- to fourth-century redaction from the time of Ezra and Nehemiah to focus on the distinction between the righteous and the wicked in Persian-period Judah, and Isaiah 2–4 is the product of a late sixth-century redaction that accompanied the initial return of exiles to Jerusalem to rebuild the Temple. Subsequent commentaries on Isaiah 1–39 and 40–66 refine the synchronic study of the final form of Isaiah by positing a two-part structure based on the presentation of YHWH's plans to reveal divine sovereignty at Zion in Isaiah 1–33 and the realization of YHWH's plans in Isaiah 34–66. Indeed, YHWH's role as ultimate sovereign precludes the restoration of the royal house of David and reinterprets the Davidic covenant to apply to the people of Israel at large. These works also argue that the sixth- and fifth-century editions of the book functioned as part of a Temple liturgy at the time of the initial dedication of the Second Temple and during the period of the reforms of Nehemiah and Ezra. They point to two additional compositional stages during King Josiah's late seventh-century reign in which Isaiah was read and redacted to support Josiah's program of religious reform and national restoration, and in the time of Isaiah ben Amoz himself when the initial editions of the book were first formed. Ultimately, the book of Isaiah as a whole anticipates the return of exiled Jews to a restored Jerusalem as a witness to YHWH's worldwide sovereignty.

In some cases, contemporary Jewish scholars display a reluctance to accept fully the results of source-critical analysis in the study of Isaiah. One persistent issue in Isaiah

is the contention that Isaiah 56–66 constitutes the work of anonymous Persian-period prophets known collectively as Trito-Isaiah. The absence of thematic and theological coherence in these chapters has prompted many scholars to reject Duhm's initial contention that these chapters are the product of a single prophet and to argue instead that they are the product of multiple authors. Such problems in the interpretation of Isaiah 56–66 have prompted Benjamin Sommer and Shalom Paul to reject the hypothesis of a Trito-Isaiah altogether and to argue instead that the entirety of Isaiah 40–66 constitutes the work of Deutero-Isaiah. The arguments of both scholars are based on a careful analysis of stylistic and philological similarities in the language employed in both Isaiah 40–55 and 56–66. Nevertheless, their work overlooks the significance of the distinction between the righteous and the wicked in Isaiah 56–66 in place of the holistic presentation of the people of Israel/Jacob and the city of Jerusalem in Isaiah 40–55.

Another issue is the role of the so-called Servant Songs in Isaiah 42:1–4; 49:1–6; 50:4–9; and 52:13–53:12, which Christians generally read as precursors of Christ. Harry M. Orlinsky's study of the Servant Songs demonstrates that the term "Servant of YHWH" does not constitute a technical term in Second Isaiah or elsewhere in the Bible, but emerged as a concern only in early Christianity. The servant is identified throughout Second Isaiah as Israel/Jacob in an effort to depict the experience of Israel from the late eighth-century Assyrian invasions through the Babylonian exile and beyond.

Overall, close study of the intertextual links between Isaiah 40–55 and Isaiah 1–39, on the one hand, and between Isaiah 56–66 and Isaiah 1–55, on the other, point to a continuous process of reading, reflection, reinterpretation, and rewriting that produces the final form of Isaiah as a work that presents prophetic reflection on and interpretation of the experience and traditions of Israel and Judah from the late eighth through the late fifth and early fifth centuries B.C.E. In the end, the book of Isaiah attempts to demonstrate that YHWH's worldwide sovereignty will be revealed when exiled Jews return to a restored Jerusalem in keeping with YHWH's plans.

THE BOOK OF JEREMIAH

Source criticism has been a major factor in the modern critical study of the book of Jeremiah,¹⁰ but such issues have been of less interest to modern Jewish scholars in the study of Jeremiah than they have been in the study of Isaiah. Instead, text-critical and theological issues come to the forefront for Jewish scholars in modern Jeremiah studies.¹¹

The book of Jeremiah appears in two distinct forms in the Masoretic Hebrew and Septuagint Greek versions of the text. The Masoretic Hebrew text comprises fifty-two chapters that include oracles attributed to Jeremiah in Jeremiah 1–25, a combination of narratives about Jeremiah and some oracles attributed to the prophet in Jeremiah 26–45, oracles concerning the nations in Jeremiah 46–51, and a concluding narrative concerning the fall of Jerusalem in Jeremiah 52. The Septuagint Greek text likewise comprises

fifty-two chapters, but they are approximately one-eighth shorter than the Masoretic Text and are arranged in a different order. LXX Jeremiah begins with Jeremiah's oracles in Jeremiah 1–25, places the oracles concerning the nations from Jeremiah 46–51 in the middle of Jeremiah 25, continues with the second half of Jeremiah 25 followed by Jeremiah 26–46, and concludes once again with Jeremiah 52. The difference in form between the two versions of the book is particularly intriguing because the Qumran Cave 4 Hebrew manuscripts of Jeremiah (4QJer^{bg}) present a fragmentary Hebrew text that corresponds to the presumed shorter Hebrew Vorlage of LXX Jeremiah. Consequently, 4QJer^{bg} seemingly confirms that LXX Jeremiah is not simply a translational and interpretative variation of Jeremiah; rather, LXX Jeremiah has an authentic Hebrew Vorlage.

Emanuel Tov, one of the foremost contemporary experts in text-critical theory, maintains that LXX Jeremiah constitutes an earlier form of the book of Jeremiah and that MT Jeremiah constitutes a later, expanded form of the book. Tov's position is in keeping with much of contemporary text-critical theory, which maintains that the shorter and generally more coherent form of the biblical text found in the Septuagint constitutes an early form of the biblical text known as the Old Greek that may be traced back to the early Jewish translators of the Bible into Greek in Egypt from the mid-third century B.C.E. and following. In general, such a position represents the text-critical principle of *lectio brevior*, namely, that the shorter, more coherent text of the Bible generally represents the earliest text form because later tradents and translators frequently expanded the text in later editions, such as MT Jeremiah. Furthermore, such scribes frequently misinterpreted the original intent of the text and thereby distorted or changed its meaning with their own interpretive additions, rewritings, and simple errors in copying. The fact that our earliest manuscripts of the Bible, apart from Qumran, are the fourth-century C.E. Greek Septuagint manuscripts, Codex Vaticanus and Codex Sinaiticus, whereas the earliest Masoretic manuscript is Codex Cairo on the Prophets, dated to 896 C.E., reinforces the view of many scholars that the so-called "Old Greek" represents our earliest text form, whereas the Masoretic Text is a later expansion.

But this application of the principle of *lectio brevior* to text-critical study raises critical questions. Does Judaism possess the earliest or most authentic version of the biblical text, or does the Christian Church, which reads the Septuagint as sacred scripture, possess the earliest and therefore most authentic form of the biblical text? Such a question entails the potential assertion of theological legitimacy for Christianity over against Judaism and the corresponding charge of incompetence among Jewish scribes that smacks of medieval Church persecution of Judaism as a religious tradition errant in its reading of scripture. Indeed, one may ask whether or not the principle of *lectio brevior* constitutes an adequate criterion for text-critical evaluation against the competing principle of *lectio difficilior*; that is, the more difficult text constitutes the earlier text, as later scribes have attempted to interpret, simplify, and render coherent a text, whether by redaction or translation, in their efforts to present their reading audience with a text that makes sense both in terms of its contents and in terms of its aesthetic features to a reading audience that is well educated in Greek as the dominant language of the educated class in antiquity. Adoption of such a principle presupposes the role of

scribes, redactors, and translators as interpreters who sought meaning in texts, rather than incompetents who distorted the text through their errors and the imposition of their own interpretive agendas.

But the issues raised in contemporary Jewish readings of Jeremiah are not solely text-critical. My own work has attempted to reconstruct the early oracles of Jeremiah delivered to support the program of religious reform and national restoration sponsored by King Josiah ben Amon of Judah. It has also pointed to Jeremiah's social identity as a priest as well as prophet, who reads and interprets earlier texts from Isaiah in relation to his own time. It attempts to define the distinctive structural form and hermeneutical perspectives of both the Masoretic and Septuagint versions of the book in which the earlier LXX form of the book looks to the experience of northern Israel as a model for what YHWH portends for Jerusalem, whereas MT Jeremiah is focused on Jerusalem from the outset.

Jeremiah Unterman studies the development of repentance in the book of Jeremiah redaction-critically, arguing that Jeremiah presupposed the effectiveness of human repentance early in his career during the reign of King Josiah, but that he eventually dropped the notion as he recognized the impending reality of divine judgment on Judah, as had already happened to Israel. Amy Kalmanofsky studies the rhetoric and imagery of horror in Jeremiah, which she understands as a means employed by the prophet to persuade Israel to reform.¹²

THE BOOK OF EZEKIEL

Theological issues and literary integrity have been key issues in contemporary Jewish scholarship on Ezekiel. Ezekiel is well known as a particularly problematic book. Mishnah Hagigah 2:1 stipulates that Ezekiel's vision of YHWH should not be expounded unless it is by an interpreter "who understands his own knowledge" (i.e., who, like Rabbi Akiba, is clearly an expert and fully committed to Jewish tradition). Indeed, Ezekiel 1 is the foundation of the *Merkavah* or Chariot tradition of Jewish mysticism that raises important questions concerning the character of G-d and G-d's relationship to the world. The Talmudic rabbi Hananiah ben Hezekiah burned three hundred barrels of oil working nights to reconcile the halakhic differences between Ezekiel and the Torah (b. Shabbat 13b; b. Hagigah 13a; b. Menaḥot 45a).

Ezekiel appears as a Zadokite priest from the Jerusalem Temple who was exiled together with King Jehoiachin ben Jehoiakim to Babylonia in the first exile of 597 B.C.E.¹³ Protestant scholars had great difficulties in accepting Ezekiel's priestly identity and the bizarre Temple-based imagery of the book. Consequently, they went to great efforts to strip away the priestly and Temple-based elements of the book in an attempt to portray Ezekiel strictly as a prophet and poet who spoke on behalf of YHWH.¹⁴ Such claims were based in part on the source-critical work that scholars following Wellhausen and Duhm practiced as the norm of the field during the late nineteenth and early twentieth

centuries. But in the latter half of the twentieth century, holistic literary approaches to the reading of biblical literature began to emerge as Jewish and Roman Catholic scholars entered the field.

Moshe Greenberg's commentary on Ezekiel was especially influential in prompting scholars to think about prophetic books as whole literary compositions rather than as deficient collections of prophetic oracles that were haphazardly supplemented and expanded by later redactors who did not fully understand the original text. Greenberg employed philological method as the foundation for his exegetical work, but his foci on theme and syntax enabled him to write a commentary that would take seriously the present form of the text. In assessing the overall form and structure of the text, he rejected the traditional rabbinic dictum that Ezekiel comprised two major parts, or books as Josephus maintained (viz., a book of judgment and a book of comfort), and instead argued for a relatively standard critical view that Ezekiel comprises prophecies of doom in Ezekiel 1–24; prophecies against the nations in Ezekiel 25–32; and prophecies of consolation in Ezekiel 33–48. His holistic reading led him to conclude that the book was largely the product of the sixth-century prophet Ezekiel himself. Greenberg looked to Mesopotamian texts and imagery to explain features of Ezekiel's visions and oracles. He showed little interest in Ezekiel's role as the foundation of later *Heikhalot* literature, and pursued a very conservative form of exegesis that did not allow for much probing beyond the immediate claims of the text. Unfortunately, illness prevented Greenberg from completing his commentary; he produced only two volumes on Ezekiel 1–20 and 21–37. Consequently, he asked his close friend, Jacob Milgrom, who was well known for his erudite commentaries on Leviticus and Numbers, to complete the work for him. Although Milgrom completed a commentary on Ezekiel 38–48, the volume did not appear in the Anchor Bible commentary series because of Milgrom's tenuous arguments that features of Ezekiel's Temple vision presupposed Hellenistic installations.

Other modern Jewish scholars have made marked contributions to Ezekiel studies as well. Jon D. Levenson's dissertation on Ezekiel's Temple vision in Ezekiel 40–48 challenged the prevailing view that these chapters must have been the product of later writers. Levenson maintained that Ezekiel's Temple vision constituted the culmination of the book, which could not stand without it. His training in comparative Near Eastern studies and religion prompted him to recognize the role that temples play in the ancient world as holy centers of creation. Consequently, Ezekiel's Temple vision envisioned the new Temple as the holy center of a new creation that would see the restoration of the twelve tribes of Israel around the Temple in a restored land in which even the Dead Sea would be transformed into a fertile lake filled with fish and bounded by luxuriant trees and crops. Levenson's later monograph on resurrection pointed beyond the typical preoccupation with apocalyptic scenarios of salvation among Christian commentators to the restoration of the Jewish nation at large in the aftermath of exile with implications for understanding the roots of modern Zionism, as well as ancient Judaism's repeated efforts to restore itself following disasters such as the destruction of both the First and Second Temples.

Julie Galambush explored Ezekiel's view of women in a study on Jerusalem portrayed as YHWH's wife in Ezekiel. One of the disturbing aspects of Ezekiel's thought is his apparent misogyny, insofar as he portrays Jerusalem as a sinning, polluted, and promiscuous wife who betrayed her husband, YHWH, even after YHWH had found her as an infant and raised her to maturity. Women appear to be absent in Ezekiel's final vision, although Galambush notes that the restored city of Jerusalem appears as a guardian of purity and source of fertility in keeping with Ezekiel's presumed metaphorical view of Jerusalem as the ideal wife of YHWH. S. Tamar Kamionkowski studies the motif of gender reversal in the book of Ezekiel in an effort to demonstrate how the book employs gender imagery as a means to render male powerlessness in the face of invasion, exile, and restoration brought about by G-d's efforts to restore order out of chaos.

Source criticism also plays a role. Risa Levitt Kohn demonstrates Ezekiel's dependence on the Holiness Code of Leviticus 16–26, but she also demonstrates that Ezekiel appears not to have known the P source of the Pentateuch.

My own work on Ezekiel provided a systematic study of the form and conceptualization of the book that presented the prophet's career from the time of his thirtieth birthday in Ezekiel 1–3 (i.e., the time that he would have been ordained as priest for service at the altar had he not been exiled to Babylonia) through his fiftieth year at the time of his concluding Temple vision, which would have marked his retirement as a Zadokite priest. He could not serve as a priest because he had been exiled from the Jerusalem Temple and therefore embarked instead on a career as a visionary prophet of the exile who conceived the destruction of the Temple as YHWH's attempt to purge the defiled Temple and restore it at the center of a restored Israel and a restored creation. Having been born at the outset of Josiah's reform, Ezekiel constructed his life in relation to his understanding of YHWH's plans to carry out Josiah's reform in more grandiose terms.

THE BOOK OF THE TWELVE PROPHETS

The Book of the Twelve Prophets functions in Judaism as a single prophetic book composed of twelve discrete prophetic compositions, whereas Christianity reads them as the Twelve Minor Prophets, each of which comprises a single prophetic book.¹⁵ The Masoretic form of the text presents the order of the books as Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, which indicates an interest in the experience of Jerusalem throughout by placing Joel and Obadiah among Hosea, Amos, and Micah. Other orders are apparent in some of the Dead Sea Scrolls and the LXX. The standard LXX order presents them as Hosea, Amos, Micah, Joel, Obadiah, Jonah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, which indicates an interest in viewing the fate of northern Israel as a paradigm for the later fate of Jerusalem and Judah by placing Hosea, Amos, and Micah at the outset of the sequence. Indeed, the LXX order is known in rabbinic

literature and may represent the earlier form of the text. In either form, it appears that the Book of the Twelve often challenges the viewpoint of the book of Isaiah.

Whereas Christian scholars read the individual prophets of the Twelve as individual works that have been expanded and edited to represent later messianic and apocalyptic scenarios, Jewish scholars have tended to read them as holistic works related to their historical contexts.

Hosea is a late eighth-century prophet concerned with the alliance between the royal house of Jehu and the Assyrian Empire with its interest in trade with Egypt. The alliance was formed by Jehu to relieve Israel from pressure by the Arameans, but Hosea objected to the alliance by citing pentateuchal traditions that the patriarch Jacob traveled to Aram to find his wives and that a prophet (Moses) led Israel out of Egyptian bondage into the land of Israel. In Hosea's view, alliance with Aram was preferable to alliance with Assyria. Landy highlights Gomer's and Israel's lack of voice by asking how Gomer would have reacted to her husband's baseless charges. Ben Zvi adds a dimension by noting that prophetic books are read and reread; in his case, he emphasizes a reading in relation to the Persian period and beyond.¹⁶

Joel is often read as a prophetic composition in Joel 1–2 with a proto-apocalyptic addition in Joel 3–4 because of its imagery of the moon turning to blood. Anyone familiar with the effects of the dry desert wind, known in Hebrew as the *Sharav* and in Arabic as the *Hamsin*, analogous to the Santa Ana winds of Southern California, will recognize that the blood-red moon is the result of all the dust in the air brought about by the *Sharav*. Joel is concerned with threats to the city of Jerusalem. It cites the Exodus plague tradition to portray enemy soldiers as locusts, and it calls upon its audience to turn plowshares into swords and pruning hooks into spears to defend Jerusalem, thus countering the oracle of universal peace in Isaiah 2:2–4.

Modern scholars frequently read Amos as a work of universal social justice, insofar as it calls for just treatment of the poor. Many interpreters maintain that the concluding imagery of the rise of the fallen booth of David in Amos 9:11–15 is a later addition to the text. Shalom Paul and the present writer have recognized it as Amos's call for the restoration of the House of David to power to right the wrongs inflicted on Judah by the northern kingdom of Israel, which demanded heavy tribute from Judah to pay its own tribute to the Assyrian empire in the eighth century B.C.E. Jason Radine argues that Amos is a political tract designed to explain the fall of the northern kingdom of Israel.¹⁷

Although traditional interpreters view Obadiah as a ninth-century figure from the time of Elijah (1 Kings 18), modern interpreters view the book as an exilic-period composition concerned with condemning Edom for its role in the destruction of the Jerusalem Temple.¹⁸

Christian interpreters frequently read Jonah as a petulant figure who defies YHWH's interest in granting mercy to the city of Nineveh when it repents of its sins. Jewish scholars are especially concerned with the literary character of the Jonah novella and its exploration of the interplay between divine justice and mercy as expressed in Exodus 34:6.¹⁹ A post-Shoah reading of Jonah points to the moral conundrum that Jonah, an

eighth-century prophet living during the reign of Jeroboam ben Joash (2 Kgs 14:25), faces, namely, that YHWH saves the city of Nineveh only to allow it to destroy the northern kingdom of Israel a generation later.

Micah is an eighth-century prophet who condemns the leadership of northern Israel and of Judah for its decisions that result in war, forcing Micah, a resident of the Shephelah, to flee as a refugee when the Assyrian Empire targets his home region for its assault on Judah in 701 B.C.E. Micah cites Isaiah's oracle of universal peace in Isaiah 2:2–4. Unlike Isaiah, who maintains that Israel and the nations alike will suffer divine judgment to reach such an ideal, Micah 4–5 envisions the rise of a Davidic monarch who will defeat the oppressors of Israel and thereby bring peace. Ben Zvi emphasizes how Micah is read and reread in later times.²⁰

Many Christian interpreters decry Nahum's calls for violence in his celebration of the downfall of Nineveh. But most Jewish scholars recognize the key issue of the book as the downfall of a brutal oppressor who had committed such violence against Israel and Judah.

Many Christians read Habakkuk as an expression of the principle of justification by faith (Hab 2:4) and view it as a book that condemns those in Judah who sin against G-d. A closer reading of the text indicates Habakkuk's problem: How can G-d bring the Babylonian Empire, which embodies evil, against Judah in 605 B.C.E.? Ultimately, Habakkuk affirms divine justice by portraying the downfall of the oppressor.

Zephaniah is frequently read as a proto-apocalyptic work that calls for worldwide judgment against those who sin against G-d, but a closer reading of the book points to Zephaniah's role as a supporter of Josiah's program of religious reform and national restoration of Judah in the late seventh century B.C.E.²¹

Haggai is one of the prophetic supporters of the rebuilding of the Temple, but he is also a supporter of the restoration of the royal house of David and an independent Judean state. Such a position challenges the book of Isaiah, which envisions the rule of Cyrus over Jerusalem and Judah as the will of YHWH.²²

Zechariah is normally read as a multi-authored work in which the visions of Zechariah appear in Zechariah 1–8, and the work of a proto-apocalyptic author who envisions divine judgment against the world appears in Zechariah 9–14.²³ Although earlier attempts to date Zechariah 9–14 to the Hellenistic period must be rejected insofar as Jews did not resist Alexander, but welcomed him in Jerusalem, the diachronic division of the book stands, much like Isaiah. Nevertheless, the book must also be read synchronically as a single work that envisions divine judgment against the nations as the result of the rebuilding of the Jerusalem Temple. Insofar as Isaiah's oracle of universal peace is cited at the end of Zechariah 8, it introduces the apocalyptic warfare portrayed in Zechariah 9–14 that results in the nations' recognition of YHWH at the Jerusalem Temple on the festival of Sukkot. Again, such a scenario challenges Isaiah's view that Israel and the nations will suffer together to achieve world peace.

Finally, Malachi calls for support for the Jerusalem Temple. Although many interpreters contend that such a scenario portends the failure of the Jerusalem Temple, it instead provides the bases for the reforms instituted by Nehemiah and Ezra.

CONCLUSION: THEOLOGICAL ISSUES

In conclusion, we may observe mid- to late twentieth-century works that stressed how the prophets represented the need to express holiness in the world. Martin Buber employed a combination of tradition-criticism and philosophical analysis to argue that the prophets drew their understanding of Israel's relationship with YHWH from the earlier encounter with the holy G-d at Sinai.²⁴ Levi Olan employed process philosophy in an effort to portray the prophets as advocates of the holy in a world that lacked holiness, both in relation to the ancient and the contemporary worlds.²⁵ Likewise, Binyamin Uffenheimer looked to the prophets as figures who would institute holiness in the world by bringing about the Isaian and Mican ideals of all the nations, joined by Jacob streaming to Zion, to learn divine Torah and thereby to bring about a world of universal peace.²⁶

Holiness lies at the core of the prophets, although each of the prophetic books conceives the issue differently. Isaiah envisions holiness in the world through recognition of divine sovereignty, first exercised through ideal Davidic kingship, later through ideal Persian kingship under Cyrus the Great, and ultimately by recognition of YHWH as the true sovereign. Jeremiah envisions holiness by observance and practice of Mosaic Torah (i.e., divine instruction concerning the means to construct an ideal society based on principles of holiness and justice). Ezekiel envisions holiness by means of the role that the Jerusalem Temple plays as the holy center of creation—and the obligation of the people to ensure that holy role. And the Book of the Twelve envisions holiness in a world in which the nations who have oppressed Israel have been defeated as they recognize YHWH at Zion.

Contemporary issues in Judaism, particularly the Shoah and the creation of the modern state of Israel, also play their role in contemporary Jewish readings of the prophets. Abraham Joshua Heschel's life work is deeply influenced by the Shoah.²⁷ His study points to divine pathos among the prophets, that is, an expression of divine and prophetic empathy with the suffering of human beings, whose own free will so often leads them in directions contrary to the will of the divine. Such a quality points to the vulnerability of G-d, a concept learned in Heschel's background as a Hasidic rebbe trained on the basis of Lurianic Kabbalah, which is expressed in his assertions that G-d needs relationship with human beings just as much as human beings need relationship with G-d. His study of modern Israel points to Israel's centrality in both the Bible and modern Judaism.

My own work is also profoundly influenced by the Shoah and modern Zionism. In the case of the Shoah, the questions of divine justice, power, and presence must be addressed together with questions of human responsibility.²⁸ Was G-d just in demanding that Isaiah render the people blind, deaf, and dumb, so that the divine purpose could be ultimately revealed? Or should Isaiah have stood up to G-d like Abraham and Moses and said no to the divine demand? Should we recognize Jeremiah's complaint to G-d that his forced service as a prophet rendered him like a woman who was overpowered

and raped and left with a prophetic word that, like a birthing baby, would come forth whether he liked it or not? Does Ezekiel's vision of the purging of the Temple in which the entire generation suffers, regardless of whether they were righteous or not, represent divine justice and holiness? And how should Jonah have responded when he learned that the very city that would one day destroy his own nation had been forgiven by G-d and thereby had been allowed to survive to carry out its gruesome task?

But we must also recognize that every one of the prophetic books envisions a return to Zion in the aftermath of the Shoah. Modern Zionism originated long before the Shoah as Jews recognized the need for political autonomy in a world that was inherently hostile to their existence, both in Europe and the Middle East.

Modern Zionism is rooted in the prophets, who envisioned the return of Jews to Jerusalem and the land of Israel in the aftermath of the Assyrian destruction of northern Israel and the Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem and Judah. Isaiah calls for the exiles to leave Babylon and return to Zion, albeit under Persian rule. Jeremiah looks forward to the time in which Israel and Judah will return to Jerusalem to be restored in an eternal covenant once again based on divine Torah. Ezekiel anticipates the restoration of all twelve tribes around a restored Temple and restored creation, long recognized in Judaism as the restoration of the Third Temple. And the Book of the Twelve anticipates the punishment of the nations that have oppressed Israel and their recognition of G-d at the Jerusalem Temple when Jews return to Jerusalem and the Temple is rebuilt. Indeed, Dalit Rom-Shiloni's studies of the formation of identity among returning exiles as expressed in Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Haggai, and Zechariah points to the means by which return to the land of Israel following exile became foundational to Jewish identity.²⁹

Altogether, the prophets in Judaism are advocates of holiness in the world, post-Shoah theologians, and Zionists, all positions that bespeak the core values of the Bible and Jewish tradition at large.

NOTES

1. Solomon Schechter, "Higher Criticism—Higher Anti-Semitism," *Seminary Address and Other Papers* (Cincinnati: Ark Publishing, 1915), 35–39.
2. See, e.g., Julius Wellhausen, *Die Composition des Hexateuchs und der historischen Bücher des Alten Testaments* (Berlin: G. Reimer, 1889); Bernhard Duhm, *Die Theologie der Propheten als Grundlage für die innere Entwicklungsgeschichte der israelitischen Religion* (Bonn: A. Marcus, 1875).
3. For the following, see Sweeney 2012: 20–41.
4. In Jewish liturgical practice, selections from the Prophets are read as complements to the Torah readings of the Shabbat and holiday worship service as a means further to illustrate the meaning of the Torah. See Michael Fishbane, *Haftarot* (JPS Bible Commentary; Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 2002/5762).
5. Sweeney 2005: 23–44.
6. For the following, see esp. Martti Nissinen, *Prophets and Prophecy in the Ancient Near East* (SBL WAW 12; Leiden: Brill 2003); James B. Pritchard, *Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating*

- to the Old Testament (2nd ed.; Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2011; hereafter ANET); Frederick H. Cryer, *Divination in Ancient Israel and Its Ancient Near Eastern Environment* (JSOTSup 142; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1994).
7. ANET 441–444, esp. 441.
 8. See esp. Bernhard Duhm, *Das Buch Jesaia* (HKAT III/1; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1892).
 9. For studies on Isaiah by Jewish scholars, see esp. Yehoshua Gitay, *Prophecy and Persuasion: A Study of Isaiah 40–48* (Bonn: Linguistica Biblica, 1981); Marvin A. Sweeney, *Isaiah 1–4 and the Post-Exilic Understanding of the Isaianic Tradition* (BZAW 171; Berlin and New York: Walter de Gruyter, 1988); Sweeney 1996, 2016; Paul 2012; Sommer 1998; Harry M. Orlinsky, “The So-Called ‘Servant of the L-rd’ and ‘Suffering Servant’ in Second Isaiah,” *Studies on the Second Part of the Book of Isaiah* (VTSup 14; Leiden: Brill, 1977) 1–129.
 10. Bernhard Duhm, *Das Buch Jeremia* (Tübingen and Leipzig: Mohr Siebeck, 1901); Sigmund Mowinckel, *Zur Komposition des Buches Jeremia* (Kristiana: J. Dybwad, 1914).
 11. For studies of Jewish scholars on Jeremiah, see esp. Sweeney 2005: 85–125; Emanuel Tov, “Some Aspects of the Textual and Literary History of the Book of Jeremiah,” *Le Livre de Jérémie. Le prophète et son milieu. Les oracles et leur transmission* (BETL 54; Leuven: Peeters and Leuven University Press, 1981) 145–67; see also Emanuel Tov, *Textual Criticism of the Hebrew Bible* (3rd ed.; Minneapolis: Fortress, 2012); Sweeney, *King Josiah of Judah*, 208–233; cf. Mark Leuchter, *Josiah’s Reform and Jeremiah’s Scroll: Historical Calamity and Prophetic Response* (Sheffield: Sheffield Phoenix, 2006); Unterman 1987.
 12. See Amy Kalmanofsky, *Terror All Around: The Rhetoric of Horror in the Book of Jeremiah* (LHBOTS 390; New York and London: T & T Clark, 2008).
 13. For the work of Jewish scholars on Ezekiel, see esp. Sweeney 2013; Greenberg 1983 and 1997; Jacob Milgrom and Daniel I. Block, *Ezekiel’s Hope: A Commentary on Ezekiel 38–48* (Eugene, OR: Cascade, 2012); Jon D. Levenson, *Theology of the Program of Restoration of Ezekiel 40–48* (HSM 10; Missoula, MT: Scholars Press, 1976); Jon D. Levenson, *Resurrection and the Restoration of Israel: The Ultimate Victory of the G-d of Life* (New Haven, CT, and London: Yale University Press, 2006); Galambush 1992; S. Tamar Kamionkowski, *Gender Reversal and Cosmic Chaos: A Study on the Book of Ezekiel* (JSOTSup 368; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 2003); Risa Levitt Kohn, *A New Heart and a New Soul: Ezekiel, the Exile and the Torah* (JSOTSup 358; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 2002).
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CHAPTER 26

FEMINIST INTERPRETATION OF THE PROPHETS

CHRISTL M. MAIER

STARTING in the 1970s, feminist criticism has emerged as a critical hermeneutics that aims at the liberation and empowering of women and thus evaluates female biblical characters, gender hierarchies, and implicit assumptions about women, both in the biblical texts and their interpretations (for an overview, see Wacker 2006). While there were forerunners of feminist theologians who criticized the androcentrism of the Bible, it was within the second wave of the feminist movement in the United States and Western Europe that female exegetes started to trace the “systemic androcentrism” of the Bible and its reception history. Following an egalitarian, liberationist paradigm, Elisabeth Schüssler Fiorenza was the first to outline a feminist hermeneutics, which reveals the patriarchal—later called “kyriarchal”—value system of the Bible, reconstructs an egalitarian ethos of the Jesus movement, and encourages a woman-centered actualization of the New Testament (Schüssler Fiorenza 1983; 1984). Many feminist interpreters of the Hebrew Bible have adopted her hermeneutics, to which she has added further steps of analysis since (Schüssler Fiorenza 2001). Being criticized as the limited perspective of white, Western, Christian, heterosexual middle-class women, feminist interpretation has broadened its horizon and sometimes has been renamed as “gender-sensitive” or “gender-just” (Fischer 2004). As this volume also documents, similar liberationist perspectives have been developed, among them womanist, post-colonial, and queer interpretations.

The emergence and development of feminist biblical interpretation is well documented in a couple of collections and series, starting with the *Women's Bible Commentary*, edited by Carol Newsom and Sharon Ringe in 1992, now in its third revised and updated edition. Since 1994 Athalya Brenner has collected feminist essays on specific passages or books of the Hebrew Bible in two series of *A Feminist Companion to . . .*, which number almost 50 volumes. The German compendium *Feminist Biblical Interpretation*, published in 1998 by the late Luise Schottroff and Marie-Theres Wacker, has recently become available in an English translation (Schottroff and Wacker 2012).

All these volumes are a treasure trove of feminist readings that offer a rich variety of hermeneutical perspectives and methods, which can neither be summarized nor fully acknowledged in a single essay. Whereas these volumes treat each biblical book separately, this chapter focuses on four issues that feminist interpreters have mainly addressed with regard to the prophets: (1) the gender-biased focus on male prophets of the Hebrew Bible, (2) the use and function of sexual and marital metaphors, (3) female bodies and embodiment for both the people and the deity, and (4) the gender hierarchy depicted in prophetic discourse, especially with regard to the religious activity of women.

THE LORD HAS NOT SPOKEN ONLY TO MOSES: FEMALE AND MALE PROPHETS

While most of the named prophets of the Hebrew Bible are male, the existence of female prophets—such as Miriam, Deborah, Huldah, the nameless prophetess in Isaiah 8:3, a group of female prophets in Ezekiel 13:17–23, and Noadiah—challenges the notion that prophecy in ancient Israel was a male prerogative. Based on recent analyses of ancient Near Eastern prophetic texts, feminist exegetes claim that the Hebrew Bible contains a greater variety of prophetic figures and activities than common scholarship would acknowledge. Ancient Near Eastern texts from Mari, Emar, and Assur bear witness not only to a great number of female prophets, but also to a much broader understanding of prophecy that included augury, magical practices, sorcery, and necromancy (Gafney 2008: 49–73; cf. Nissinen, Chapter 1 of this volume). A magical ritual is at issue in the polemic against the prophetically active women in Ezekiel 13:17–23 who are said to sew bands and head coverings, which they use while prophesying. The women are indicted for hunting for souls and keeping souls alive for those who can pay for it. With regard to Assyrian and Babylonian parallels for such rites, the most plausible interpretation is that these women exert magic skills (Jost 1995: 180–190; Jost and Seifert 2012: 349–352).

In her interpretation of prophecy in the Hebrew Bible through a gender-sensitive lens, Irmtraud Fischer rightly argues that the Deuteronomistic characterization of prophecy as proclamation of God's words and of Moses as the first and ideal prophet (Deut 18:9–22) constrains the phenomenon of prophecy and subordinates it to the Torah (Fischer 2002: 39–62). The Deuteronomistic idea of prophets as a series of divinely sent “servants,” to whom the people fail to listen, permeates the biblical characterization of prophecy (Jer 7:25; 29:19; Zech 1:6; Ezek 38:17; cf. 2 Kgs 17:13; Neh 9:26, 30; 2 Chr 36:14–16; Luke 11:47; Acts 7:52, 1 Thess 2:15) and has limited the portrait of “true” prophets to mere proclaimers of divine words. Moreover, the rules against “false” prophecy in Deuteronomy 13:2–6 and 18:10–12 ban communications with the Divine that are common practice in other strands of tradition, namely, divination (Balaam in Num 22:7; Josh 13:22; diviners among the Judean nobles in Isa 3:2; Mic 3:11, cf. Jer 27:9), soothsaying (in Manasseh's reign 2 Kgs 21:6, cf. Mic 5:11), augury (Gen 44:5, 15), and sorcery

(Ex 7:11; 22:17; Babylon in Isa 47:9, 12; cf. Jer 27:9). Besides, there are prophets, male and female, who are related to issues of the cult, among them Samuel (1 Sam 3:20), Huldah (2 Kgs 22:14–20), and the women who serve at the entrance of the tent of meeting (Ex 38:8). While the latter have often been interpreted as either charwomen or cult prostitutes, Fischer plausibly argues that they are cult prophets who receive visions and probably note them down on bronze boards (cf. the Hebrew word מראה, translated by LXX and Vulgate as “mirror”; Fischer 2002: 104–107). Based on a study of her student Ursula Rapp, Fischer interprets Miriam, who is introduced as prophetess and sister of Aaron in Exodus 15:20 and challenges Moses’ authority in Numbers 12, as a legitimate leader equal to Moses and Aaron (Fischer 2002: 64–94; see already Burns 1987: 122, who, however, downplays Miriam’s role as prophet). In Fischer’s view, the post-exilic text Micah 6:1–8 completes Miriam’s portrait as a classical prophet who is a legitimate proclaimer of God’s word and intermediary between God and his people.

With a similar agenda, the post-exilic editors of the Tanakh align Deborah to Moses and Samuel in assigning her a multitask role as leader, judge, and prophet (Judg 4:4; Fischer 2002: 109–130). The prophetess Noadiah appears in Nehemiah 6:14 as leader of a group of prophets who frighten Nehemiah, most probably through prophecies that proclaim him king and portray him as opponent of Persian rule (cf. Neh 6:6–7). Rainer Kessler and Fischer relate the statements about Noadiah and Miriam (Numbers 12; Mic 6:4) to a conflict about the role of prophecy in the Persian period between those who favor Persian rule and those who aim at political independence (Kessler 1996: 69–72; Fischer 2002: 255–271).

In her canonical approach to female prophets, Klara Butting, too, interprets Miriam as representative of prophecy. She further argues that the framing of the prophets’ part of the Hebrew canon by Deborah (Judges 5) and Huldah (2 Kings 22) reveals a twofold theology: first, Torah is related to history and thus to an ongoing interpretation, and second, the prophets are closely connected to the written Torah (Butting 2001: 193–203). She takes these female prophets as markers of gaps in the biblical plot and as vantage points for a feminist evaluation of the biblical tradition (203–208).

In her detailed rhetorical analysis of all texts about Miriam, Rapp elaborates the variant nuances of the female character and interprets Miriam first and foremost as representative of those Judeans who stayed in the land during the exile and who in Persian times claim their position in the conflicts about exogamy and identity. Miriam’s position of authority thus represents their claim of contributing to the interpretation of the Mosaic Torah (Rapp 2002: 387–397).

Wilda Gafney bases her search for female prophets on a broad definition of prophecy and includes Assyrian sources, the Hebrew Bible, Septuagint, Targumim, Dead Sea Scrolls, Midrashim, the Talmud, and early Christian texts. For the named and unnamed female prophets of the Hebrew Bible, she arrives at conclusions similar to those of Fischer and Rapp. Based on these known female prophets, she argues that references to prophetic groups should be interpreted as groups of mixed gender (Gafney 2008: 160–64). She also includes musical (Ex 15:20; 1 Sam 18:6–7), funerary (Jer 7:29; 9:19–21; Zech 12:10–12), and scribal guilds (Ezra 2:55 par. Neh 7:57; 1 Chr 2:55) in her exploration of

prophetic activity (119–130). While female prophetic activity is still hidden or misrepresented in the Hebrew Bible, the assumption of prophecy being a male privilege has proven to be false.

Nancy Lee takes a different approach to identify the voices of female prophets; she analyzes poetic passages in Isaiah, Micah, Jeremiah, and Lamentations in search of sound patterns in the Hebrew lyrics. In alliterations, syllable and word repetitions, and wordplays, she detects doublet and triplet patterns of sound. Taking the song of Hannah (1 Sam 2:1–10) as a prototype, Lee (2015: 18–22) attributes the triplet pattern to a woman's voice, possibly a prophetess (cf. Isa 8:3). She relates the doublet pattern to a male voice because it also persists in David's victory song (22; cf. 2 Sam 22). Since both patterns alternate in many prophetic texts and in the Song of the Sea (Ex 15:1–21), Lee posits that the lyrics of female prophets have been preserved unnamed but can still be heard (188).

THE “PORNOPROPHETICS” DEBATE

In Hosea 2, Jeremiah 2–3, 13, and Ezekiel 16, 23, there is a specific literary feature that has drawn much feminist critique: the female personification of the Israelite people or the capital city, Samaria or Jerusalem, as God's adulterous wife. The figure is depicted in sexualized terminology as unfaithful and wayward, “whoring” away from her husband by seeking other lovers and thus reveals the intention of rendering God's wrath as a just and reasonable reaction to the people's or city's renunciation. The passages announce her punishment by the “husband” in graphic language; her nakedness will be publicly exposed, she will be shamed, her body will even be violated. Although a similar characterization and fate are recorded for Nineveh in the book of Nahum, this foreign capital has not received the same attention (but see Baumann 2012).

In antiquity, marriage was a hierarchal concept in which the husband was perceived as sole proprietor and protector of his wives and children. His honor was based on his ability to provide economically for the family and to control the sexuality of the female household members. In addressing the people or the capital city as YHWH's wife, the metaphor refers to hierarchical gender relations commonly assumed in ancient Israelite society: cities and collectives, like women, can be desired, conquered, protected, and governed by men; their roles as daughter, wife, and mother are defined by association with the male head of the household (for the combination of ancient Near Eastern traditions in the female personification of the city, see Maier 2008: 60–74). Since the Israelite deity is mostly characterized as male, especially in the roles of warrior, judge, and king, the marriage metaphor offers for ancient audiences a plausible conceptualization of the relationship between the people or city and its deity.

In 1985, T. Drorah Setel was the first to name the prophetic descriptions of violent retaliation by “husband” God against his “unfaithful wife” Israel in Hosea 2 “pornography” (Setel 1985). Based on a definition of pornography by Andrea Dworkin, Setel traces features, function, definitions, and causes of pornography. As features she defines

the representation of female sexuality as negative, of women as degraded and publicly shamed, and of female sexuality as an object of male control and possession (Setel 1985: 87). As function of pornography she names “maintenance of male domination through the denial, or misnaming, of female experience” (87). Her definitions of pornography are collected citations of feminist studies, the most comprehensive of which is “material that explicitly represents or describes degrading and abusive sexual behavior so as to endorse and/or recommend the behavior as described” (88). As cause of pornography, or rather, as the base of its growth, she sees a psychological (male) need for a sense of power and superiority, which she specifically relates to the changes of the power relationship between women and men (88). Setel finds all the features of pornography in Hosea and sees the causes of such representation in the intellectual and psychological disruptions caused by the political events of the eighth century, among them a growing separation between rich and poor in Israelite society and the powerlessness perceived by the leading groups, who then seek to affirm their dignity as men against a negative characterization of women (94–95). Her short article ends with a call to assess critically the influence of such imagery on contemporary readers.

In their famous study “On Gendering Texts” (1993), Fokkeliën van Dijk-Hemmes and Athalya Brenner trace gender positions entrenched in a text with regard to their position within the textual discourse, naming them M (masculine/male) and F (feminine/female) voices. Van Dijk-Hemmes detects Setel’s features of pornography in Ezekiel 23, especially in the misrepresentation of female sexuality in verses 3 and 8, in which the sexual abuse of the two metaphorical young women is named their “whoring” (Hebrew זנה), an obvious example of “blaming the victim” (Brenner and van Dijk-Hemmes 1993: 167–176). Van Dijk-Hemmes further discusses the reaction of the implied audience to this pornographic divine speech delivered by the prophet, arguing that this illogical but powerful M voice forces its implied audience into a humiliating self-perception of being violated by enemies due to their own guilt for abandoning their God. She further maintains that M readers would identify with the wronged “husband” over against the unfaithful “wife”—a position she finds both in the text, in the appeal to women not to become such a wife (v 48), and in modern interpretations of male commentators who reassert the divine verdict. In her view, F readers cannot do so, and thus Ezekiel 23 not only misrepresents female sexuality but also distorts women’s sexual experience (176). Athalya Brenner (Brenner and van Dijk-Hemmes 1993: 177–193) labels Jer 2; 3:1–3; 5:7–8 and 13 “pornography” by demonstrating that most of Setel’s definitions apply. She then briefly analyzes the modern pornographic novel *The Story of O*, an acclaimed example of female erotic prose written by Pauline Réage, in which the female protagonist by deliberate and continuous acts of sadomasochism destroys her life and self-esteem and ends as a dehumanized and abused object. By this comparison, Brenner demonstrates the challenge to F readers not to identify with the female character and to resist such pornographic depictions by criticism and reflection.

In the ensuing debate, some feminist scholars found the label “pornography” helpful to unmask the androcentric and misogynistic rhetoric of the prophetic marriage metaphor (Hosea 2; Jeremiah 2–3; 13; Ezekiel 16 and 23), among them Julie Galambush with

regard to Ezekiel 16; 23 (1992: 124–125). Moreover, Linda Day (2000: 205–230) discovers in Ezekiel 16 a male voice that argues like an abusive husband in a case of domestic violence; this “husband” exhibits a Jekyll and Hyde dual personality that changes between generosity and battering his wife, who has neither voice nor defense. Although Day’s literal reading of the metaphor graphically reveals the misogynistic nature of the rhetoric, she does not offer any counter-strategy to avoid modern readers’ positioning with the abusive God.

Other scholars, for instance Robert Carroll and Ilse Müllner, criticized the labeling of the texts as “pornography,” arguing that Dworkin’s definition of the phenomenon is one-sided. Although Carroll also uses the term “pornographic representation” with regard to some motifs in Jeremiah 2–3 as well as Ezekiel 16 and 23, he rejects Dworkin’s definition as extreme and a thought-terminating cliché because it narrows the text’s meaning to only one ideological possibility, which misrepresents his position as a male reader (Carroll 1995: 281–282; 1996: 78–79). For Carroll, these metaphors for the nation, city, or land have little to do with the representation of women as such (Carroll 1995: 278). Instead, by poetic excess, the text deconstructs its own discourse and “functions like an antilanguage to reconstruct possibilities for a ruined culture” (Carroll 1996: 81). In a response to Carroll’s critique, Athalya Brenner clarifies her definition of pornography as a representation of sexual desire that contains abuse and violence (Brenner 1996: 84). She agrees that Ezekiel 16 and 23 are religio-political propaganda, which, in her view, uses similar rhetorical strategies as pornography, for example, stereotyping, naming, exaggeration and lying, repetition, promises and threats, heroes and anti-heroes, as well as claiming authority. Thus, she insists on disclosing the misogynistic imagery and the harm it does to modern readers, as well as on rejecting what she now calls “pornoprophetics” (85).

While Ilse Müllner concedes that naming biblical passages “pornography” has caused a thought-provoking semantic shock, she criticizes Dworkin’s definition of pornography for its sole focus on the content of the representation and for assuming that pornography leads to sexual acts. Instead, she suggests defining it as “act of representation,” that is, “pornography is a form of sexuality” (Müllner 2003: 201). In her view, these ancient texts were neither historically a certain form of sexuality nor are they likely used in a sexual context today. Instead, the texts’ pragmatics is to shock the audience, a group of men and women, and especially to feminize male readers, which according to J. Cheryl Exum is “a rhetorical strategy of abusing men verbally in the worst possible way” (Exum 1995: 250).

This interpretation of the texts’ rhetoric is substantiated by recent studies on both the propaganda and experience of war in antiquity. Cynthia R. Chapman has examined the explicitly sexual language of Ezekiel 16 and 23 against the background of Assyrian accounts of warfare. In royal inscriptions and loyalty oaths, the Assyrian king presents himself as an ideal masculine man “without rival,” victorious in the battlefield, not surrendering to other males, and able “to protect and provide for his people in a way analogous to a husband’s providing for a wife” (Chapman 2004: 59). She argues that, in the perspective of Jeremiah and Ezekiel dating from the post-Assyrian period, the sexual

violence imposed on Samaria and Jerusalem is an analogous ideological image of the defeat of these cities. Furthermore, Tamar Kamionkowski perceives the fear of emasculation as a common literary motif of the ancient Near East, which she calls the “a-weak-man-is-a-woman metaphor” (Kamionkowski 2003: 79–91). Daniel Smith-Christopher links the stripping and shaming of the female figure in Ezekiel 16:37–39 to the torture of detainees in the Abu Ghraib prison by US military personnel in 2003 and posits that the motif probably derives from Ezekiel’s experience with Neo-Babylonian warfare. Based on Neo-Assyrian reliefs and propaganda accounts of their victories, he asserts that “the image of the stripped and humiliated Jerusalem may not have ‘titillated’ the male hearers at all, but rather shocked them precisely because it reminded them of their own treatment at the hands of the Babylonian conquerors! *Thus, they would have identified with the female Jerusalem, rather than the ‘male God’*” (Smith-Christopher 2004: 155–156; italics in original). Similarly, Brad Kelle argues that “[c]ertainly the violation of women as a metaphor fits the destruction of capital cities, for the stripping, penetration, exposure, and humiliation of the women is analogous to siege warfare, with its breaching of the wall, entrance through the gate, and so forth” (Kelle 2008: 104).

In her erudite analysis of the prophetic marriage metaphor, Gerlinde Baumann introduces a twofold way to deal with biblical metaphors (2003: 44–46). She argues that the metaphor’s *explanation* should explore its historical sense and imminent intention within the ancient context of language and life, or its associated commonplaces for ancient readers. The *interpretation* should focus on the understanding of the metaphor from the perspective of modern readers by dealing with their emotional response to the ancient texts. Especially since assumptions about both marriage and prostitution have changed considerably over time, this distinction helps to comprehend the rhetoric and ideas of the metaphor’s original setting and its possibly harmful impact on modern readers. Moreover, the differences in the preceding interpretations can be explained by the emphasis that scholars put on either the historical background of the metaphor or its modern reception. For Sharon Moughtin-Mumby, however, Baumann and other scholars relapse into a substitution theory of metaphor, despite their claim to use the more recent interaction theory or cognitive approach (2008: 18–25). In her view, significant for the substitution approach is the attempt to relate all texts to an alleged common “marriage metaphor” and to seek to explicate the metaphor with regard to the lexical meaning of the Hebrew terms or to the projected sociohistorical background of the prophecy. Instead, she posits (2008: 32) that a cognitive approach sees any metaphor created by the interaction of “vehicle” and “tenor” (Richards), “focus” and “frame” (Black) or the semantic pertinence created by the context (Ricoeur). Thus, her literary-rhetorical analysis of Hosea 4–14, Jeremiah 2–3, Ezekiel 16, 23, and Hosea 1–3 calls attention to the various contexts of several sexual and marital metaphors, arguing that these texts do not add up to a drama of failed marriage and reconciliation between YHWH and his people. She rightly points out the differences among these texts, yet her renunciation of any explanation of the metaphor with regard to its ancient sociohistorical background stops short of fully exploring the significance of the violent imagery. Although Moughtin-Mumby tries to

deconstruct the prophetic rhetoric by pointing to its exaggeration, implicit counter-voices, or cross currents in the fictitious citation of the female figure, she argues that the texts cannot redeem their dreadful language (263–268) and thus are “impotent” (275). If the latter were true, these texts would not have been handed down, modern readers would not be ashamed by this strange depiction of God, and scholars would not need to either explain or dismiss these metaphors. Apart from any futile efforts to redeem this negative portrayal of divine-human relationship, it does not suffice utterly to reject the sexual metaphors as pornographic, misogynistic, or androcentric, since modern readers also ponder the questions of why they were used at all and what their authors’ message was for their “implied” readers. Baumann, for instance, can elucidate the use of these metaphors, although she resists any redeeming effort and emphasizes that most personal relationships mentioned in the Hebrew Bible are hierarchical (2003: 238–240).

Another way of deconstructing the metaphor of the unfaithful wife in Hosea is Yvonne Sherwood’s reading of Hosea 1–3, which uses semiotics and Derrida’s theory of deconstruction (Sherwood 1996). In her view, Hosea 1–3 intends to confound and shock its audience, as the characterizations of the “family” of Hosea, Gomer, and their strangely named children “invert the nation’s fundamental perceptions of itself” (148). By offering a meta-commentary to traditional and feminist readings, which reveals both their dissent with the text and their efforts to come to terms with it (265–298), Sherwood pleads for a new way of literary reading that positively assesses fragmentation and blurring, thus aligning itself with postmodern theory (322–329).

FEMALE BODIES AND EMBODIMENT

Besides the debate on “pornoprophetics,” many feminist studies of prophetic texts offer sophisticated interpretations that explore gender hierarchies, the characterization of women and their bodies, and interpretations of divine metaphors.

Female Bodies as Representation of the People

As Julia O’Brien (2008: 36) observes, apart from two articles, “all treatments of the Prophetic Books in *The Women’s Bible Commentary* [edition of 1992, C.M.] object to prophetic descriptions of women.” She further points out that feminist criticism of the prophets opposes the dominant trend of male Christian interpreters to praise the prophetic books “as the pinnacle of biblical ethos” (O’Brien 2008: 36), because the depiction of women and the divine–human relationship is rightly to be criticized as patriarchal, androcentric, and hierarchical.

Several studies treat the female metaphors and gender shifts employed in the book of Jeremiah in order to reveal the text’s rhetoric and possible audience reactions. Angela

Bauer (1999) offers a literary analysis of small passages in Jeremiah without situating their images of the feminine in the ancient context or in the overall composition of the book. In her detailed analysis of female and gendered metaphors, Maria Häusl cautions against reading Jeremiah in light of the marriage metaphor only. Instead, she differentiates several figures that are rather loosely connected to each other: the raped daughter, the woman in labor, the fatally wounded person, the woman who suffers abuse and sexual violence, the professional mourner, the beautiful and self-reliant woman, the woman whose cultic activities are deemed “false,” the young marriageable woman, and the sexually promiscuous woman (Häusl 2003: 369). Beyond Bauer, she argues for a diachronic development of these metaphors, starting with Jeremiah 4–10* and the oracles against the nations (Jeremiah 46–49*), both of which provide images of the conquered city as raped daughter, wounded person, and woman in labor, and thus a “city-theology of coping with the hardship” (381). Enhancing these images of destruction, the idea of the professional mourner is added (cf. Jeremiah 8–9*). While in earlier texts, the guilt of the female protagonist is formulated in rather general terms, later ones talk about the woman’s or the city’s unfaithful behavior toward יהוה. According to Häusl, Jeremiah 2–3* presuppose the military catastrophe and blame the female protagonist for her own destruction by using obscene sexual metaphors (373), the origin of which can hardly be determined with certainty. Drawing on female imagery of different extant texts, the oracles of salvation in Jeremiah 30–31 depict more positive gender relations (cf. Jer 31:22) and “virgin Israel” as a recipient of divine promise. Häusl’s differentiation of female embodiment and gendered depictions in Jeremiah is a significant step forward in feminist research since it demonstrates the time-dependent and functional use of metaphors without denying their possibly hazardous effect on modern readers.

In her close reading of Jeremiah 3:1–4:4, Mary Shields (2004) argues that by a rhetorical shift from the metaphor of the unfaithful wife to the daughter and to sons, who repent and circumcise their hearts, the text presses its predominantly male audience to change its behavior toward the deity. By assigning female gendered imagery a negative place in the rhetoric, it objectifies and marginalizes women, allotting to them only the roles of loyal wife, mother, and daughter (158–160). Although this rhetoric seeks to control women’s sexuality and place in society, their power in procreation cannot be completely denied, and thus the text undermines itself and allows for a critical re-reading by modern feminist scholars.

Especially the woman-in-labor metaphor, used frequently in Jeremiah (4:31; 6:24; 13:21; 22:23; 30:6; 48:41; 49:22, 24; 50:43), Isaiah (13:6–8; 21:1–4), and Micah (4:9–10) in a context describing the effects of military defeat, offers an embodiment of female experience. As Juliana Claassens (2013) demonstrates, this metaphor can be interpreted from intersecting feminist, postcolonial, queer, and trauma perspectives. The idea that the implicit male subject is constructed as a woman giving birth offers a culturally disruptive gender reversal that may be exploited as a resource for queer readings or as a “counter-language,” which in the face of imperial threat may be useful for resistant reading in service of justice and cultural transformation.

Female Embodiment of the Divine

In a countermovement to the deconstruction of androcentric and misogynistic perceptions of women and goddesses in the prophets, feminist scholars have tried to elevate more gender-balanced images of Israel's deity by pointing out that YHWH sometimes is characterized in a maternal role. Helen Schüngel-Straumann (1995) has argued that the divine compassion and reversal of emotion in Hosea 11 reflects the nursing role of a mother goddess. Yet the text remains ambiguous: the divine figure is not nurturing only, but rather oscillates between compassion and anger. As Wacker rightly points out, this "asymmetry of the contrast between 'warrior' and 'mother' may be read as a warning against constructing a gender ontology that has women to be more motherly and men more anger-prone by nature" (Wacker 2012: 382).

In the second half of the book of Isaiah, the Israelite deity assumes the role of comforter and forgiving parent to Daughter Zion, the widow bereft of her children. In oracles of salvation, God promises to bring back these exiled children (Isa 43:6; 49:22; 60:4) and to have the kings of the foreign nations serve as foster-fathers and their princesses as nursing mothers (Isa 49:23). In Isaiah 46:3–4 God assumes the role of a mother who carries her children in the womb, and in Isaiah 66:5–14 is characterized as master of the womb in the role of a midwife who assists female Zion at a smooth birth of new children. By breastfeeding her newborns, Zion serves as a mediator of God's motherly care and protection (Maier 2013: 116–120). As Irmtraud Fischer points out, there are manifold parallels between the male "servant of the LORD" and the "Woman Zion" in Isaiah 40–55, although both figures are linked to YHWH, but not to each other. While the servant is able to atone for the people, Zion serves as a motherly space of sheltering and nursing (Fischer 2012: 312).

In contrast to this positive imagery, Isaiah 47 announces the demise of Daughter Babylon: she will be punished and forced into the status of a slave woman. Moreover, Isaiah 57:1–13 rehearses the whore imagery for female Jerusalem in order to claim that only the true followers of YHWH will be able to access the Temple mount (v 13). Taken together with other passages in Isaiah 56–66 that reflect a divide in the community on religious and social concerns, the passage in Isaiah 57 reveals that the situation in post-exilic Jerusalem is a far cry from the glorious expectations presented in Isaiah 40–55 and 60–62 (Maier 2013: 120–122).

RELIGIOUS ACTIVITY OF WOMEN

Another issue of critical feminist readings of the prophets is the one-sided and negative description of religious activities of women, which are evaluated as illegitimate and sexually transgressive. Since the prophetic texts follow their own agenda, they do not portray ancient religious practice in a historically adequate way. Nevertheless, scholars aim at reconstructing these religious rituals—often with a male bias, as feminist scholars have revealed.

Sacred Prostitution and Fertility Cult

Especially in Hosea, male scholars have identified the prophetic allegation of false cultic behavior with the phenomenon of sacred prostitution and fertility rituals. For instance, Hosea 4:11–14 condemns the Israelite people for whoring away from their God and sacrificing with female cult personnel (Hebrew *הקדשות*). The Hebrew noun and its Akkadian cognate have often been translated as “cult prostitute” or “temple prostitute.” Since the daughters and daughters-in-law are explicitly charged of “whoring,” most male commentators see in Hosea 4:11–14 a prophetic indictment of illicit orgiastic rituals or sacred prostitution, a parallel of which they find in Herodotus’s description of the cult of Aphrodite in Babylon (Maier 2009: 262–267). As female experts of ancient history and religion have demonstrated, the assumed sacred prostitution is a myth generated by a positivistic reading of Sir James Frazer’s 1922 work *The Golden Bough* and a gender-biased assessment of Assyrian terms (Keefe 2001: 53–57; Assante 2003) and biblical texts (Stark 2006). As Marie-Theres Wacker has demonstrated in her detailed study on Hosea, the condemnation of Israel’s worship on the “heights” (Hebrew *במות*) reveals the power of a goddess, possibly Asherah, and polemically links the figure of Gomer with Canaanite natural religion, while portraying Israel’s national deity as YHWH-El (Wacker 1996: 300–313; cf. Wacker 2012, 376–378). Whereas Wacker points to the distortive nature and post-exilic origin of the text, major twentieth-century commentaries on Hosea see the prophetic polemic as an adequate description of a Canaanite fertility cult that included sacred prostitution and orgiastic sexual rituals practiced in eighth-century Israel (cf. the overview in Keefe 2001: 42–53). For most male scholars, Alice Keefe discloses, “female sexuality . . . serves as the marker to distinguish the purity of Yahwistic religion from the corruptions of Canaan and the syncretistic cult” (2001: 61). In such an androcentric perspective, “woman’s body can only mark that which is ‘other,’ serving to mark a negative pole of meaning against which the superiority of Israel’s truth and that of the biblical scholars is clearly delineated” (62). Keefe, however, also criticizes feminist readings that take Gomer and the female sexual body as signs of repressed but vivid female spirituality (62–65). Instead, Keefe argues that Hosea’s prophecy tries to establish the religious and social identity of the Israelite people in the socioeconomic crisis of the eighth century. The prophet pleads to perceive the land as family inheritance, not as a commodity, and speaks against the new class of royal officials who try to oppress the rural population. Thus, Gomer’s female body symbolizes the life and fertility of the social body; this idea is far removed from Western dualistic thinking that associates woman with nature, sex, and sin (220).

Women Worshipping the Queen of Heaven

In the book of Jeremiah, the worship of a female deity called “Queen of Heaven” appears twice: in the list of condemned cult practices in the temple sermon (Jer 7:18) and in Jeremiah’s dialogue with those who fled to Egypt in fear of Babylonian retribution after the murder of the governor Gedaliah (Jer 44:17–19, 25). In Jeremiah 44:19, it is the women who argue that

they face destruction because they stopped venerating the goddess and that their former rituals were approved by their husbands (cf. Jer 44:25 LXX as a direct answer to the women). The goddess is not named, yet the mentioning of incense offerings and her title “Queen of Heaven” (in Greek ἡ βασιλίςσα τοῦ οὐρανοῦ, in Latin *regina caeli*, in Hebrew מַלְכַּת הַשָּׁמַיִם but intentionally misspelled by the Masoretes as מְלַכַּת הַשָּׁמַיִם “work of heaven”) point to an astral deity. This divine epithet is recorded for the Sumerian goddess Inanna, the Akkadian Ishtar, as well as for Anat in Ugarit and Astarte in Egypt (Maier 2010). According to Jeremiah 7:18, her cult is situated in the family: the children gather wood, the fathers kindle the fire, and the women knead dough to make cakes for her (Jer 44:19 לְהַעֲצֹבָה “bearing her image”). The Hebrew word for the cakes (כֻּמְצִים) is an Akkadian loanword (*kamānu*), which in Assyrian ritual texts designates a sort of bread baked on an open coal fire with a short baking time. Presumably this goddess incorporates features of different local goddesses (Ackerman 1989). In her detailed study on the textual and iconographic sources, Renate Jost argues that the Queen of Heaven was a potent antagonist to YHWH in the pre-exilic national cult in Jerusalem and that the baking women were royal women with official roles in her cult (Jost 1995: 213–232). Furthermore, Jost supposes that the cultic image at the northern gate of Jerusalem, which Ezekiel polemically calls “the image of jealousy” (Ezek 8:3), may have represented the Queen of Heaven (1995: 169–171; cf. Jost and Seifert 2012: 347–349).

Women Worshiping Tammuz and Asherah

Among the “abominations” that Ezekiel sees in his vision of the Jerusalem temple worship are the women weeping for Tammuz at the north gate of the temple (Ezek 8:14). Jost (1995: 173–174) interprets these women as cult functionaries and points to female professional mourners (Jer 9:16–20) as a parallel. The latter, however, are not mentioned in a cultic context but within an oracle of judgment that announces the death of numerous people. Jost further links the weeping for Tammuz to the veneration of the Queen of Heaven on the basis of an Akkadian incantation of Dumuzi, Ishtar’s partner, who eats *kamānu*-cakes, which are also mentioned in the cult of the goddess (1995, 176–180; see preceding discussion). In Ezekiel 8:16, the visionary Ezekiel sees twenty-five men who worship the sun. Moreover, the account of King Josiah’s cult reform mentions the tearing down of the houses or cells of “sacred persons” (הַקִּדְּשִׁים) in the temple where the women wove coverings for Asherah (2 Kgs 23:7). Therefore, it seems likely that women and men were involved in rituals for gods besides YHWH in the pre-exilic Jerusalem temple. The passages, however, are too short to allow a reconstruction of either the ritual or the duties of these groups. Feminist scholars rightly advocate that such cultic activities of women can no longer be relegated to the level of family religion, the worship of goddesses, or minor ministry in the official cult. Due to major studies in the written and iconographic sources of the ancient Near East, it is also obvious that all deities were venerated by men and women, the determining factor being the deity’s competence and power, not its gender.

CONCLUSIONS

As this necessarily cursory overview demonstrates, feminist scholars mostly employ a hermeneutics of suspicion with regard to prophetic texts that characterize women's cultic activities and personify the people as an unfaithful woman and whore. Since metaphors are time- and culture-specific, the task at hand is first to explain the metaphors with regard to their original sociohistorical context and then to interpret them with regard to modern readers. In the second step, the existence of kyriarchal norms and gender-hierarchical relationships in the texts should be disclosed in order to disrupt any potentially harmful effect on modern readers. Therefore, many feminist readings deconstruct implicit androcentric assumptions or values and seek passages that can be used for liberating concepts. Furthermore, not only the female embodiment of humans, but also the metaphors used for the deity are to be deconstructed. The radically misogynistic and horrifying depictions of the angry and battering divine "husband" cannot be ameliorated by pointing to God's motherly and comforting role in other prophetic passages. What is today perceived as a dualistic notion of God may have been interpreted differently in antiquity.

For modern readers and interpreters, however, this divine imagery poses a problem that forbids aligning oneself with the prophetic or divine voice against the people. Rather, the ambiguity of the divine and human characterizations should be discussed.

While feminist scholars rightly reject the pejorative depictions of ancient women's cultic activities as misrepresentations of women's roles, they aim at reconstructing the sociohistorical background of such rituals in order to demonstrate that women were also involved in the cult, sometimes in a professional role, although their voices and their contribution to society were suppressed.

As feminist inquiries have demonstrated, prophetic authority in Israel and Judah was not restricted to men. Moreover, the prophetic role included not only the announcement of the divine word, but also other means of determining the future, among them soothsaying and mantic practice. As a consequence, feminist interpretation of the prophets contributes to a fuller assertion of the phenomenon of prophecy, as well as to a more inclusive depiction of the Divine. In cooperation with womanist, post-colonial, and queer readings, feminist scholars challenge the hegemony of male-centered interpretations and introduce a variety of perspectives, some of which unfold liberating perceptions of the relationship between God and humans.

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CHAPTER 27

WOMANIST APPROACHES TO THE PROPHETS

VALERIE BRIDGEMAN

WOMANISTS approach biblical texts with an eye toward understanding the underside of texts with “an a priori assumption that biblical inquiry yields its best fruits when critics look from the vantage point of the marginalized, the oppressed, the silenced, or the voiceless in current society and in ancient texts” (Bridgeman 2014: 435). In this way, the biblical text is not the starting point of inquiry. Womanist readers begin by centering the experience of black women, especially poor black women or women of color.

In many ways, Womanist biblical interpreters seek to understand the way power works to oppress or suppress life or to produce or aid human flourishing. Womanist interpreters approach the text with an ethical eye toward liberation in all facets of Scriptural witness and human existence. This approach allows for the interpreter to use historical-critical methods, literary-critical methods, and critical gender and race theories, as well as the knowledge production of “ordinary readers.” We do not read in a vacuum, but are shaped by our “intellectual heritage, the political baggage, the social assumptions, and the economic worldview one brings to one’s reading” (Weems 2015: 44). As such, Womanist interpreters may bring hermeneutics of resistance, interrogation, suspicion, and imagination as they encounter texts, histories of interpretations, and ethical implications of every reading.

Reading prophetic books (or the literary afterlives of prophets beyond the biblical books named for those prophets) calls for careful attention to the impact of stories and recorded prophetic utterances on the lives of those most vulnerable to power run amok. For Womanists, then, such interpretations do not allow for thinking only of a “biblical world,” but also of a world made by such writings. Womanists insist that such considerations mean that black women’s concerns and questions must be centered when interpreting texts. Biblical prophets are put into conversation with sources that speak to and of black women’s experiences. Thus, one may understand what a text might have “meant,” but such centering leaves the interpreter with questions of present-day

meanings and “rightness”; that is, it is written, but does it produce a free and flourishing life in God?

The prophetic books and personalities of the biblical text offer rich reflection sources for Womanist interpreters. To understand the prophets as a Womanist requires taking into consideration the interlocking systems of privilege and oppression allowed by gender, class, race and/or ethnicity, to name points along the continuum, and to see whether one may be able to uncover the ways in which oppression affects the biblical world and the world of readers, and whether liberation or a thriving life might be discovered. The Womanist interpreter, like all liberation readers, will give herself permission to say “no” to a text, if she discovers that it is not safe for humans.

In this chapter, I delineate several areas across prophetic texts that demonstrate this concern for thriving. The categories I have decided to discuss as examples of Womanist interpretive strategies are the portrayal of women, both “real” and “metaphorical”; the way children are treated and portrayed; and how poverty affects the prophetic sayings.

PORTRAYALS OF WOMEN IN THE PROPHETS

Renita Weems wrote a primer on the way prophets use metaphors when she wrote *Battered Love: Marriage, Sex, and Violence in the Hebrew Prophets* (1995). Reading Hosea, Weems rightly describes how texts are written with male readers in mind. Any use of female imagery or female worldviews, then, is designed to provoke responses from men. Her observation is based on the long held understanding that public spaces were primarily male-dominated and designed spaces, while the home and other private spaces were female-dominated spaces controlled by men.

In the prophetic books, the most prevalent images of women have to do with (sexualized) motherhood and childbearing. Women, real and metaphorical, are used to make prophetic points. It is difficult to know whether the way in which the prophets use women in their writing is accurate to their lives (i.e., how much is hyperbole or imagined social construct). The use of the husband-wife metaphor is prevalent in Isaiah, Hosea, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel, but may be found throughout the prophetic corpus (e.g., Isa 3:16–24; Hosea 2; Jer 2:20–25; 4:30–31; Ezek 16:35–42; Nah 3:5–6). In each use of woman as wife, the wife is described as unfaithful or rebellious or both, and therefore worthy of being punished. The prophet never questions the violence visited on the unfaithful wife, so the reader/interpreter knows that this violence is considered—at least by the prophet—normal and necessary. In other words, any violence inflicted on a woman, she brought upon herself.

The prophets also reverse roles on the use of the birthing-mother image. For example, Jeremiah 30:6 shows the prophet himself taking on the role of a woman giving birth. In the text, birthing and its pangs are negative consequences, which the prophet shares with the people. As noted, they represent fear and anguish the people “rightly deserved.” “At the moment of crisis, the male prophet chooses to identify with the people as female”

(Bauer 1999b: 202). Jeremiah also identifies as female when he accuses the deity of raping him in chapter 20; though the word for “rape” often is softened to “seduced” in many translations, its Hebrew root has to do with sexual violence, not “foreplay” between consenting lovers (Bauer 1999b: 203).

In an effort to reimagine the motherhood trope in the prophetic texts, Womanist Irene S. Travis reads imaginatively with the text and suggests that “God as female, as Mother, is incredibly creative and nurturing” as she reads Isaiah 42:14, for example. In her article, “Love your Mother: A Lesbian Womanist Reading of Scripture,” Travis provides readers with what might more accurately be called a “musing” on motherhood. She begins with the Jeremiah 30:6 text: “Ask now, and see, can a man bear a child? Why then do I see every man with his hands on his loins like a woman in labor?” The piece reflects her cultural understandings of motherhood: who can be one and under what conditions. As a lesbian partnered with a woman, the question she poses is directed at clergy persons who must provide care for non-conforming (non-heteronormative) families. Her controlling question is, “What are today’s women to do if they are attracted to other women yet long to become parents?” (Travis 2000: 37). She ignores the way the text actually uses motherhood, the way in which most biblical texts represent motherhood, or the way in which motherhood is normatively represented and reaches for the few texts, mostly in Isaiah and Hosea, in which God is Mother to ancient Israel/Judah. To love this God, according to Travis, is to love motherhood for all human families, even those that are not within the patriarchal framework.

Closely following images of women as mothers, the prophet portrays women as sexually promiscuous, and therefore as justifiable victims of rape. What are the assumptions at play for these examples to be effective and powerful? Among the assumptions are that women are valid and validated in society as wives and mothers (only). Barrenness is a curse, not simply because a woman cannot bear children, but because she cannot bear an heir, and more specifically a male heir. In addition, childbearing must be confined within marriage so that the patrilineal heritage may be “guaranteed” or secured. It is easy, then, to see why promiscuous behavior and adultery would be especially heinous in the prophetic imagination. Such thinking is what makes reading the book of Hosea so shocking.

“Go marry a whore,” the deity commands the prophet Hosea. Understood, then, is that there is a system that includes “whores” and that Hosea knew where to find one to marry. Were they like twenty-first-century sex workers? Were they “legitimately” illegitimate, as Phyllis Bird (2006) successfully argued in her essay, “Prostitution in the Social World and Religious Rhetoric of Ancient Israel”? These women lived on the periphery of society, surviving with no male legitimating “covering,” no safety, and very little resources. They were rendered invisible, but findable in a world where sex was commodity; the women were vulnerable to violence, to disease, to abuse, and to death. Reading Hosea, Weems, and Bird helps us understand that a harlot (whore) stands in for the deity’s people who suffer the fate of harlots because of “disobedience.” What we learn is that any willful, self-directing behavior is worthy of punishment by rape and/or death. And, readers now are left to understand that women still are vulnerable.

Can the Womanist read these stories and say that the stories and/or metaphorical use of women is “O.K.” if the one doing the raping and abusing is God? The answer is an unequivocal “NO.”

PORTRAYALS OF CHILDREN IN THE PROPHETS

If Womanist interpretation matters, it matters regarding those who are most vulnerable and furthest from the seat and center of power. Children—especially poor children—fit in these aforementioned categories most easily. The prophets use children in much the same way they use women—metaphorically to denigrate and berate men in power and to accuse said men of being fickle or erratic. Examples of such use of children are evident throughout the prophetic corpus, but especially in Isaiah and in Hosea.

In Isaiah 3, the writer describes the nation-state Judah as devoid of its leaders, presumably men: “warrior and soldier, judge and prophet, diviner and elder, captain of fifty and dignitary, counselor and skillful magician and expert enchanter” (Isa 3:2–4). The list describes those in power in society, in government, in wisdom, and in the religious world. But, the prophet declares, God will remove all these leaders because of the people’s disobedience. Instead, “boys” will be the princes and “babes” will rule them. “Children are their oppressors and women rule over them,” the prophet says (Isa 3:12). According to the prophetic text, the world is disordered and corrupt, evidenced by child leadership.

One cannot deny that these descriptions are meant to shame and denigrate men, and it seems, men with power. According to Isaiah 3:5b, “the youth will be insolent to the elder, and the base to the honorable.” This chiasmic structure equates youth to base (“low-life”) as “elder” equals “honorable” one. The NRSV obscures the androcentrism of the text in an attempt to be gender-neutral or inclusive, but it is clear that the writer means “men” and “boys.” As in a well-known colloquialism, because the people have dishonored and disobeyed the deity, a boy will be sent to do a man’s job.

When ancient Israel and Judah are depicted as “wife,” the children’s appellation reflects the disdain that the prophet claims is God’s. These children are called “children of a sorceress,” “offspring of an adulterer and a whore;” they are “children of transgression” and “offspring of deceit,” for example (Isa 57:3–4). Note also that Hosea names his children in an effort to shame their mother, thereby bringing shame also on the children. Being the child of a whore, the “son of a bitch” is and always has been intended to demean and shame.

Within the biblical world, orphans (with their mothers) are particularly vulnerable. Political powerbrokers and perhaps religious leaders as well are frequently accused of not defending the fatherless (cf. Isa 1:23). The prophets see children as vulnerable and in some ways as a constant reminder of how insolent and undisciplined God’s people

can be. Children become the primary metaphor for taunting, for insolence, and for stubbornness.

Children are servants (slaves) to their parents (Mal 3:17). They “belong” to their parents as the people “belong” to the deity as a “special possession.” Like wives, they may be beaten or spared at the whims of the master-*baal*. Those children of the upper echelon will be driven from their “pleasant houses” along with their mothers, and God will take away their “glory” (Mic 2:9), which may be read as the opposite of shame. Thus we see the shame/honor paradigm that works primarily with men in power.

Both Isaiah and Hosea say their children are “signs” from the deity (see esp. Isa 8:18 and Hosea 1–3). The use of children as metaphor is especially poignant in Hosea’s description in which he names his children in shameful ways. They are named to symbolize the deity’s judgment on the nation-state. In addition, the people are called the “children” or “sons” of the deity. They are variously described as rebellious, faithless (cf. Jer 3:14, 4:22), stupid, stubborn, or willful. Switching between the metaphors of Israel as a wife or as a child, the people are told they will be killed, orphaned, or left bereft of their children. The Sovereign, according to the prophets, will leave the people as exposed and as vulnerable as women and children.

Children and women are particularly at risk in times of war. Soldiers take no pity on them (Isa 13:18). Women and children are dashed to pieces as war collateral (e.g., Hos 10:14; Jer 13:14). Human collateral is not limited to combatants; and the fact that women and children are often deliberately sought out to kill or rape is a part of the war machine in prophetic books. Thus the prophetic corpus leaves us in a world where women and children may be used at will, by deity and by men who may be considered god-like.

Children are collateral throughout the biblical texts, and the prophets reflect that worldview. A father makes a vow (Jephthah) and his daughter is payment. A prophet (Elisha) is “offended” that children taunt him; bears rain down his (and ostensibly the deity’s) fury and the boys are shredded to pieces. A father hears that he is to sacrifice his son, and Isaac stares up at a knife. The Womanist interpreter must ask of prophetic texts and others whether God does sanction these moments. May we say back to Abraham what Jeremiah says in order to refute human sacrifice: “I never required you to pass your children through fire” (Jer 19:5)? Womanist approaches require us not to contort ourselves into accepting violence and abuse against children, but rather to stand against any text that will provide a sacred canopy over such abuse, even if the abuser is the deity.

What does it mean to read and then reject or resist what one reads? That is one of the roles of Womanist interpretation—to look a text squarely in what it actually says and then make ethical decisions about how it may function in a reading community. Or, put another way, sometimes a Womanist must point at a text as illustrating what not to do. Womanists must look at what a particular text asks of its readers and assess whether a text must be obeyed and the implications of not obeying it. If the interpreter is unable to disabuse a text of its power, she must be willing at least to name the negative and deadly implications of continuing to yield to its power, especially in the ways that power harms the most vulnerable members of community, most notably women and children. These realities are not limited to biblical texts, and Womanist interpreters are obligated

to point out how war continues to affect negatively the life of women and children, and to resist war as the hell it is. Womanist literary giant and activist Alice Walker reflects this commitment and sensibility in her book for children, *Why War Is Never a Good Idea* (2007).

POVERTY IN THE PROPHETIC TEXTS

Beyond women and children as property and collateral, we may consider the role that poverty plays in their lives. Justice and righteousness, the overwhelmingly persistent themes in prophetic books, deal especially with the way poor people are treated. And since women and children are the largest population of the poor, this theme also needs to be interrogated and investigated. Biblical texts assume that poverty happens not because of laziness, but because those who are poor have been oppressed by those who have power and means. Cuban feminist Elsa Tamez makes this case in her reading of the Hebrew prophets in her essay, "God and the Option for the Poor" (Tamez 2003: 317). Tamez sees this created poverty in the way the powerful "sell the righteous for silver, and the needy for a pair of sandals" (Amos 2:6–7), and in the way landowners oppress the poor and extort the alien (sojourner) in their midst (Ezek 22:29). In addition, not only are the poor oppressed, but those who oppress them amass wealth at the expense of those who cannot. They build houses with unrighteousness and forced enslaved labor in order to do so, according to Jeremiah 22:13 (see Tamez 2003: 317).

Poverty also is reflected in class, so it is not as easily described in gender terms. Well-to-do women, who benefit from the power structure, are accused of being culpable and culprits. Described as "cows" in Amos's words, the prophets says to these well-off women, "Hear this word, you cows of Bashan who are on Mount Samaria, who oppress the poor, who crush the needy" (4:1). Womanist interpreters must ask how those with privilege are complicit in oppressive systems. Are we capable of disrupting and overthrowing unjust systems when we benefit from those systems? Or, to ask it the way activist poet Audre Lorde did, is it even possible to use the master's tools to dismantle the master's house? What might solidarity look like among women of the land (the poor and often hungry and homeless) while women lounge on beds of ease? Has Amos accurately portrayed these women? It is possible that they do not hear the cries of the oppressed. A Womanist, even one privileged and with means, could not ignore and must respond to such cries. A Womanist would have to call to account these women and women beyond the texts to work for a just and equal society, with the conviction that none is free until all are free.

For the prophets, poverty also can lead to cannibalism, a part of the consequences of disobeying the deity. Consider how Ezekiel 5:10 reads that "parents shall eat their children in your midst, and children shall eat their parents; I will execute judgments on you, and any of you who survive I will scatter to every wind." According to the prophet, God allows or creates the poverty-laden starvation and loss that lead to such horrific

behavior as judgment. Famine and attacks by wild animals, pestilence, and bloodshed (possibly violence within the city gates) are also a part of God's judgment, according to Ezekiel 5:17. Poverty is the price of disobedience as well.

Reading from the twenty-first century, present-day Womanist interpreters must read poverty beyond the biblical texts as well. In this way, the texts serve as commentary and conversation partner for a larger enterprise. There are countless stories of people who are poor being blamed for their own poverty, without the accusers considering systemic barriers that keep people struggling to thrive. It seems the prophetic texts both resist and accept such an interpretation of the causes of poverty. Poverty is a justice issue that transcends the texts. Poverty comes from unjust systems and greed. On that point, Womanist interpreters would agree with the prophets. Womanist ethicist/theologian Keri Day picks up the themes of dehumanizing and entrenched poverty among black women in the United States in her 2012 book, borne from her graduate research, *Unfinished Business: Black Women, the Black Church, and the Struggle to Thrive in America*.

There is more to reading prophetic texts than analyzing the prophet's depictions of women and children; however, these examples allow us to see how Womanist interpreters read from the margins and expose the uses of power and oppression. Womanist biblical interpreters actively seek not only to uncover, but to empower, for the sake of liberation and freedom. The prophetic texts provide resources with which to reflect on a life worth living.

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CHAPTER 28

MATERIALIST ANALYSIS OF THE PROPHETS

GALE A. YEE

A materialist analysis is one of a series of recent methods of biblical exegesis to fall under the term “ideological criticism.” The ideological criticisms investigate the differentials in power in certain social relationships in the production of the text (who wrote it, when, and why), how these power relations are reproduced in the text itself, and how they are consumed by readers of various social groups. For example, feminist criticism studies ideologies of gender that legitimate unequal relations between men and women. Racial-ethnic or minority criticism examines ideologies of race/ethnicity in the text itself (such as who is constructed as foreign and who is not) and how one’s racial or ethnic heritage influences one’s interpretation of the text. Postcolonial criticism looks at relations between colonizer and colonized, such as the effects of the Persian colonization of Yehud on the authorship of, and their reproduction in, the text itself. Also known as socioeconomic criticism, a materialist analysis investigates economic class relations in the biblical text, such as rich and poor, elite and peasant, royal court and landowners, empire and vassal state, and so forth. Because ideologies of sexism, racism, colonization, and economic exploitation collude together in a matrix of domination, these criticisms often involve the analyses of the others. Reading the Bible ideologically means reading the Bible critically from the perspective of ideologies that oppress or ideologies that liberate one’s social relations.

A materialist analysis of texts about and by the prophets involves a twofold exploration.¹ The extrinsic analysis investigates the socioeconomic and historical contexts in which the prophets lived and worked. The intrinsic analysis involves a literary-critical study of the prophetic texts themselves, whether these are narratives about the prophet himself or the sayings attributed to him. A materialist analysis operates under the Marxist critical assumption that literary texts are the ideological productions of particular authors grounded in historical, real-life relations of power. While they help foster and sustain a distinctive worldview that structures and informs people’s lives, such texts can also disguise or explain away features of society that may be unjust, such as the

unequal distribution of wealth or access to resources in a society, or why slaves are subordinate to their masters, or why racial/ethnic foreigners are threats to the social order. At the same time, other texts, such as the prophetic oracles inveighing against economic oppression, may offer ideological critiques of these same attitudes. Since the prophets worked within exploitative stratified societies, conflict theories of social stratification, such as those propounded by Marx, are the most useful in dealing with questions of who gets what and why.

To perform an extrinsic analysis of the prophets' world, one must understand the social, political, and economic workings of the larger context of southwest Asia (the ancient Near East), which impinged on their local settings. Ancient Israel, the Levant, and southwest Asia were agrarian societies with significant smaller pastoral economies, growing crops and pasturing flocks. Thus, their economic activities were deeply embedded in social relations that were both intimately united with and dependent on the natural environment. Over 90 percent of the population was involved in this agrarian and pastoral economy.² The ruling elite that would eventually intrude on their lives was only a small but powerful minority of the overall population. Moreover, contrary to our modern assumptions that land was scarce and the population numerous, it was labor, not land, that was of primary concern. Without people to work the land to make it productive, that land would have been useless by itself. Given the high maternal and infant mortality rate and lower life expectancy in antiquity,³ securing labor was a much greater concern than owning real estate. This would become an important economic issue for royal and ruling class states that needed labor to work the land for those who did not do so in these agrarian societies.

Because of its economic marginality and geographical distance from the centers of imperial power, subsistence survival was the most prominent economic feature of the southern Levant and ancient Israel for most of their history. The traditional practices of subsistence adopted carefully refined risk-reducing strategies, such as diversification, land fallowing, and optimal usage that ensured long-term survival in a difficult agrarian context. Surpluses of crops or animals were kept, not for profit, but for survival during times of hardship. Although it may have been subject to extractive patterns during its history either as a kingdom or province, the southern Levant kept reverting to the resilient traditions of subsistence during times of crisis.⁴

THE PROPHETS AND STATEHOOD

The prophets emerged and worked particularly during the rise of the monarchic state in ancient Israel. The state was characterized by a stratified society headed by a king and a governing elite, a centralized bureaucracy, urban capital cities and regional centers, a standing army, and some sort of writing system. Under the state, grants of cultivable land were given as estates to members of the bureaucracy in return for services rendered (cf. 2 Sam 9:6–10). These estates produced the surplus needed for the expansion of state

activities. The economics of the state would be based, first, on the extraction of goods from these agricultural estates, which was then redistributed upward in this stratified society to the court, army, and other royal authorities. The tenants, indentured servants, or debt slaves that farmed the family estates and villas were expected to supply a significant portion of their produce to the palace and to be able to survive on what was left over. Second, and interconnected with the first, state economics would be based on the extraction of labor from the village communes to farm the agricultural estates, as well as workers for the building projects and soldiers for military campaigns, and other ventures of the court. Along with the natural vicissitudes of farming, such as drought, insect plagues, and so on, the diversion of labor from the subsistence farming of the village communes to the agricultural estates, building projects, and wars put a considerable strain on the rural sectors of the state.

With the state, agriculture was divided between two different economic structures that often conflicted with each other, namely, those of the village and rural sectors that operated under the practices of subsistence survival, and those of the extractive state. Because labor shortage was the main concern in southwest Asia, the primary demand in taxing the village-commune and the rural sectors was in human bodies rather than in agricultural goods. It was in the interest of the ruling elite to pull as many subsistence workers as possible into the state latifundial system and keep them there permanently. Whether the rural village communities flourished or not mattered little to them. The internal contradiction of the state was that its need for labor put intense strain on the agriculture of the village commune, which operated according to reliable subsistence survival patterns. Tensions occurred when the ruling classes wanted more labor from village communities that resisted these efforts.⁵

How the state actually arose in ancient Israel is still an ongoing discussion.⁶ Biblical scholars have become skeptical about the existence of a united monarchy ruled by David and Solomon during the tenth century B.C.E.⁷ Although Solomon is credited with building the Temple and a number of other construction projects in Jerusalem (1 Kings 6–7), no evidence of monumental architecture has been found in the city for this time period. Tenth-century Jerusalem was simply a small, secluded village that bore little resemblance to the great capital of the biblical accounts. Regarding sites attributed to Solomon, such as Megiddo and Hazor (1 Kgs 9:15), archaeology has determined that the royal monuments traditionally attributed to his tenth-century rule were actually built during the ninth century. Furthermore, there is no significant scribal activity from Judean sites before the eighth century. The marginal southern region of the Levant that would eventually develop into the kingdom of Judah was able fully to come into its own only during the eighth century.⁸ During the ninth century, however, Judah was the smaller, more monocultural and insular southern state and at times a vassal of Israel (cf. 1 Kgs 22:1–4, 44; 2 Kgs 3:7–8).

On the other hand, from the materialist perspective of the *longue durée*, or the long-term history of Israel, which focuses on the geography, economy, and population of the region, the northern part of the central hill country possessed the geographic and environmental advantages and population to develop into a strong state during the ninth

and eighth centuries. Orchards in the northern highlands produced a substantial yield of wine and oil, while a number of its valleys offered conditions very favorable for growing grain. It had a dense and diverse populace that supplied the labor force to build, govern, and maintain its bureaucratic centers, fortresses, and armies without risking agricultural production. It had access to the Mediterranean Sea and its trading partners through the maritime port of Dor.⁹

In contrast to the south, a prominent archaeological feature of northern statehood was its monumental architecture in Jezreel, Megiddo, and particularly in Samaria,¹⁰ Israel's capital city, which was bought, fortified, and named by King Omri (1 Kgs 16:24). The biblical information about Omri is rather sparse (1 Kgs 16:16–17, 21–28). However, archaeological and extra-biblical sources offer another picture, namely, that it was under Omri that a strong, cosmopolitan Israelite state developed in the northern highlands during the ninth century. His palace in Samaria was one of the largest Iron II structures in the Levant. Its hilltop location gave Omri greater access to Israel's breadbasket, the Jezreel Valley, and to the profitable trade routes moving along the coastal plain. When Omri shifted his capital from Tirzah to Samaria, it initiated a demographic and economic development westward to gain easier access to the coast and greater contact with foreign nations, such as Phoenicia. His kingdom also expanded northward toward Hazor and eastward in the Transjordan.¹¹ He opened up trade routes from Moab to Damascus and from Damascus to the Mediterranean. It was the glories of ninth-century Samaria that were retrojected back by later Judean authors and applied to the poor, isolated village of tenth-century Jerusalem as the capital of a united monarchy.¹²

Another mark of statehood was Omri's ability to conscript and maintain a standing army. He was mentioned in the Mesha Stele as a mighty king who took possession of Moabite territory in the ninth century. Even in the late eighth century, well after Jehu assassinated Omri's descendants (2 Kings 9–10), the Assyrian empire continued to refer to Israel as the House of Omri.¹³ Extra-biblical sources reveal that Omri's son, Ahab, was also a very powerful king. Like his father, Ahab was credited with building fortified cities, water systems, and expensive palaces in the north (1 Kgs 16:32–34; 22:39). The Kurkh Monolith depicted Ahab as mustering a force of two thousand chariots, ten thousand foot soldiers, and an alliance of twelve kings to engage the Assyrian ruler Shalmaneser III at the battle of Qarqar (853 B.C.E.). Although the number of chariots has been questioned, the large-scale horse facilities discovered at Megiddo and Jezreel for the breeding and training of horses makes this number quite feasible.¹⁴ Furthermore, over five hundred fragments of ninth- to eighth-century ivories found at Samaria, carved in North Syrian and Phoenician design, corroborate the detail of Ahab's "ivory house" in 1 Kings 22:39 and those condemned by the prophet Amos (Amos 3:15; cf. Ps 45:8).

It was therefore no accident that the biblical texts recorded the ministries of the prophets Elijah and Elisha during the ninth-century emergence of Israelite statehood under the Omride dynasty (1 Kings 17–2 Kings 10). According to Albertz, prophetic opposition to a ruling king was a new phenomenon in Israel's history, one tied to the economic development of the ninth century. The economic prosperity that occurred under the Omrides made it possible for prophetic groups to emerge that, unlike Nathan

(2 Samuel 7; 1 Kings 1) and the king's prophets (1 Kings 22), had no kinship or professional ties to the court. On the one hand, a wealthier population would be able to pay for prophetic services, such as healing, exorcism, and divination (cf. 2 Kgs 4:8–37; 5:1–19). On the other hand, the social stratification and exploitation that occurred in the midst of this affluence created resistance drawn from different social classes. Although Elisha was a prosperous farmer (1 Kgs 19:19–21), “the sons of the prophets” who accompanied him were often very poor (2 Kgs 4:1–7, 38–44; 6:1–7). The economic independence of these prophetic groups and their personal involvement with the victims of Omride economic development enabled them to castigate the system.¹⁵

The most widely discussed case of Omride economic extraction condemned by Elijah is found in 1 Kings 21: the story of Ahab's unjust confiscation of Naboth's vineyard/property in Jezreel through his murder, ruthlessly engineered by his Phoenician wife Jezebel. Ahab did not want Jezreel simply “for a vegetable garden” (21:1). From a materialist view of ninth-century Israel, Ahab would have desired this piece of real estate primarily for economic and military reasons. The Jezreel Valley was known, first and foremost, as a rich agricultural region. Even in the Late Bronze Age, the annals of Thutmose III described a harvest of 207,300 [+] sacks of wheat, besides forage from the areas around Megiddo.¹⁶ A large spring (‘Ein Jezreel) supplied a constant source of water. Furthermore, the area had access to the major highways of the time, such as the Via Maris (Way of the Sea) and one leading from Megiddo to Beth-Shean. The city also served as the northernmost point on the local highway, the Way of the Patriarchs, which connected the northern valleys with the central mountain cities of Shechem, Samaria, Bethel, and Jerusalem.¹⁷ These various routes suited Omride interests in maintaining good relations with their international trading partners.

Besides being located in a rich agricultural area, Jezreel was also an important military center. The archaeology of the site revealed a large casement enclosure, similar to an Assyrian structure, Fort Shalmaneser, whose military function was well known. The chapters before and after this story deal with Ahab's war with the Arameans (1 Kings 20, 21). Ahab most likely needed Jezreel as an agricultural and military base to feed and house his sizable cavalry and chariot units. Its location was ideal for assembling, outfitting, and dispatching troops to fight in Aram and in the Transjordan.¹⁸ Barley, an important part of the diet of warhorses, was cultivated in the eastern part of the Jezreel Valley. Horses can consume ten times more grain than humans on a daily basis, more during times of war, and this too was extracted from the rural sectors, along with huge food quotas for the tables of the royal court (cf. 1 Kgs 4:27–28; 18:19). As was mentioned earlier, Ahab possessed enough horses (4,000–6,000) to pull two thousand chariots in a campaign against Shalmaneser III. His concern to provide watering holes and grasses to keep his horses and mules alive, rather than provisioning his own starving people during the three-year drought, was thus quite plausible (1 Kgs 18:5). The little arable land and water that could be had during this drought were thus diverted from food production for a starving people to pastureland for Ahab's vast number of animals.

There may be an ideological rationale for the choice and construction of Jezreel for the Omride dynasty. Because of the necessity to exert social control over a diverse

population and proclaim royal legitimacy during these early years of the state, the inordinate amount of corvée labor and materials invested to build this fortification was intended to overawe, if not intimidate, the local population.¹⁹ Thus, in the case of Naboth's vineyard, the extraction by Ahab's regime had ramifications beyond the ruthless personal seizure of Naboth's property itself. It had economic and military consequences that enriched the Omride court, and was also a means of social control to exploit and oppress the rural sectors of the kingdom.

THE EIGHTH-CENTURY CONTEXT OF AMOS

The economic prosperity that characterized the time of Elijah and Elisha would also be that of the prophet Amos, who famously decried the economic abuses of his time (3:9–11, 15; 4:1–3; 5:10–13; 6:1–7; 8:4–6). The biblical texts date the prophet Amos during the time of the eighth-century Israelite king Jeroboam II (ca. 787–747 B.C.E.), during which Israel recovered from its devastating military clashes with the Aramean king Hazael (ca. 843–800 B.C.E.). Moreover, the weakening of Damascus by the Assyrians not only assisted Israel's economic revival but also its neighbor Phoenicia, strengthening their commercial ties in trade. The southern kingdom of Judah under Uzziah was also able to grow economically during this time. Jeroboam II recovered lost territory in the northern Jordan Valley and Transjordan, although the extent of the recovery is still a matter of dispute.²⁰ Although he was condemned by the Deuteronomistic Historian for not departing from the sins of his namesake, Jeroboam I (2 Kgs 14:24), his was one of the longest and most economically prosperous reigns in Israel. The eighth-century Samaria ostraca (pottery fragments) provide evidence of flourishing oil and wine production, recording their transfer to the capital city. The horse industry continued to be an important economic trading and military venture at Megiddo. Besides continued trade with Phoenicia, Assyria, and Egypt overland and through the Mediterranean, the Kuntillet 'Ajrud discoveries suggest that probably during Jeroboam II's rule, Israel controlled the ancient road from the Gulf of Aqaba to the Mediterranean, Darb el-Ghazza, and thus the profitable Arabian trade.²¹

That prosperous Israel stood at the crossroads of the international economy of the eighth century is especially significant for understanding Amos 1:3–2:8, the oracles against the nations that inaugurate his prophetic book. As the prophet most known for his denunciations of social injustice within Israel, Amos is the only prophetic book to begin with judgments against the atrocities of foreign countries, not with Israel itself. According to Jeremy Hutton, they provide the hermeneutical key to the rest of the book.²²

Each oracle begins with the sovereign LORD's formulaic accusation, punishment, and justification of retribution against his vassal nations: "For three transgressions of X and for four, I will not revoke the punishment, because. . ." These nations are guilty of heinous crimes against humanity, for which God will exact heavy punishment. In the

first oracle, Amos deploys agricultural imagery to depict the Aramean army pulverizing Gilead's soldiers, inhabitants, and landscape with threshing-sleds of iron (1:3–5; cf. 2 Kgs 10:32–33; 13:7). Gaza and Tyre are accused of human trafficking, cruelly abducting and selling slaves to Edom, which may have used them in its copper mines (1:6–10).²³ Because of their closeness to the Mediterranean, Gaza and Tyre were most likely important centers of the slave trade (cf. Ezek 27:13). The next three oracles indict nations that traditionally had ethnic links to Israel (cf. Gen 19:36–38; 25:22–34; 27:40–41). Edom is reproached for cold-blooded military strikes against “his brother” (perhaps Judah, cf. Obad 10–12; Num 20:14–21), recalling the animosities between Jacob and his brother Esau. Ammon is culpable for the sadistic wartime custom of slashing the wombs of pregnant women in Gilead (cf. 2 Kgs 8:11–12; 15:16; Hos 13:16). The crime against Moab is the shocking desecration of the bones of Edom's king.

Underscored in these oracles are the tangled histories of grievances, disputes, and conflicts among these contiguous nations surrounding Israel. A materialist analysis will focus particularly on what these oracles reveal about these entwined relations from an economic perspective. All of these countries in the southern Levant occupied a section of the critical land bridge strategically positioned between the great empires of Egypt and Mesopotamia. All of these nations wanted to extend their control over these major trade routes to partake of the economic wealth that traversed them, particularly in the fees, tolls, and taxes exacted from the traffic crossing state territories. In Israel the trade routes and international relations that were established by the Omrides during the ninth century increased in importance during the eighth, particularly with the growth of the South Arabian camel caravans, bringing the wealth of east Africa, Arabia, and the Indian Ocean.²⁴

The Israelite elites coveted the exotic luxury goods carried in this trade because they enhanced their status within this international community.²⁵ As we will see, these luxury items were particular targets of Amos's critique (cf. 6:4–6). However, with this amplified international trade, the two interlinked economic institutions in ancient Israel came into greater conflict: the agrarian base under the traditions of subsistence survival in the village communes and that of the extractive state which imposed on this community to acquire such preciosities.

The subsistence economy was local and rural, involving primarily food production for the local workforce and for crops in return for cash that peasants needed for purchasing or bartering what they themselves did not produce. This economy also included production for taxes, rents, and other creditors and elites. The trade economy was urban, interregional, and involves commodities, strategic military items, and luxuries.²⁶ According to Coote and Whitlam, Israel leveraged its geographical location through five forms of trade: military investment, transit trade, local production, labor extraction, and pilgrimage.²⁷ Because the main form of extraction from the rural sectors by the state was labor, human bodies were diverted from food production to supply services in these other elite trade projects. In military investment, for example, human laborers were needed as miners for iron ore, artisans to fashion it into weapons, construction workers to build fortresses, and soldiers to defend them.

Extractions from the rural sectors became more acute when Assyria imposed tribute obligations upon these Levant states, not in agricultural goods but in luxury products.²⁸ The contradictory goals of these two economies in southern Levant—of profit, on the one hand, and subsistence survival, on the other—led to a conflicted situation, in which “the interregional trade economy effectively bypass(ed) the local subsistence economies, while at the same time extracting more and more value from there.”²⁹ Through their exploitation, the elites became richer, while their peasant base became poorer both in material and human resources, jeopardizing the entire agrarian system.

Hutton persuasively argues that many of the atrocities condemned in Amos 1:3–2:3 can be sited along the important trade route, the King’s Highway, running northward from the port of Elath through Edom, Moab, Ammon, and Gilead, up to Aramean Damascus and beyond to Mesopotamia. Amos singled out several cities along this Transjordan artery that came under God’s judgment for their violence: Damascus (1:3, 5), Teman (1:12), Bozra (1:12), Rabbah (1:14), and Kerioth (Kir-hareseth, 2:2). The western coastal cities of Tyre and Gaza also did not escape fiery punishment for their human trafficking on trade routes heading eastward to the slave markets of Edom (1:6, 9). All of these locales were enmeshed in bonds of economic, military, and social violence resulting from their strategic geographical settings within southwest Asia.³⁰

For Hutton, the oracles against Judah and Israel (Amos 2:4–8) form the climax of Amos’s condemnations of the nations and must be viewed within the context of his ex-coriation of the atrocities that arose from the economic prosperity of their neighboring states. Judah’s crime was rejecting the law (*torah*) of the LORD, many of whose laws covered a number of “human rights” violations committed by the nations in military conflicts and slave trafficking recounted in Amos 1:3–2:3.³¹ Moreover, Judah’s rejection of God’s *torah* in Amos could be compared with Isaiah’s similar judgment against Judah (Isa 5:24), whose economic crimes were detailed in a series of woes in Isaiah 5:8–24 and 10:1–4. These consisted of seizures of property from farmers, perhaps because of crop failure or excessive taxation (Isa 5:8), or even from outright royal confiscation (cf. 1 Kings 21), by the “nobility of Jerusalem” (Isa 5:14). These were guilty of self-indulgent drunken feasts (Isa 5:11–12), like those condemned in Amos 6:1–7 and, as we will see, in 2:7–8. These drunken binges for Isaiah were symptomatic of a twisted judicial system that “acquits the guilty for a bribe and deprives the innocent of their rights” (Isa 5:22–23), turning aside the needy from justice, robbing the rights of the poor, and preying upon the widow and orphan (Isa 10:1–2).

Amos’s oracle against Israel was even more explicit in condemning the economic abuses that arose in an exploitative system of the haves versus the have-nots. Amos accused Israel of “selling the righteous for silver and the needy for a pair of sandals” (2:6). This difficult verse could mean that the rulings of corrupt judges can be bought at any price, with a bribe of silver or even with an ordinary pair of sandals. The verse could also mean that Amos condemned the actual selling of people into slavery “because of a pair of sandals,” in the case of a creditor so merciless that he would force one into bondage for such a trivial debt.

On the basis of the Hittite law 22a, which states that the captor of a runaway slave should be rewarded with a pair of shoes, Avi Shveka argues that Amos condemned the extradition of runaway slaves to their masters and the phenomenon of debt-slavery in principle.³² Because securing labor to work the land or other economic projects of the elites was a top priority, debt-slavery was one of the ancient institutions that kept humans toiling in these ventures through a pernicious cycle. According to Norman Gottwald, surplus labor from the rural sectors was taken in two rounds of extraction, a tax cycle and a debt cycle. The tax cycle took the form of material and human resources, which interfered with traditional agrarian and pastoral practices that reduced risks. Drought, pestilence, military conflicts, and the increased taxation to pay foreign tribute worsened the abilities of farmers and pastoralists to keep up with tax payments, often forcing small holders to sell their land. Their impoverishment led to a second round of extraction in the form of loans at hefty interest rates, forcing them to sell their labor or that of their loved ones as debt-slaves until the loan was paid.³³ Although the biblical laws of debt manumission (Ex 21:2–11, Deut 15:1–18, Lev 25:39–46) revised earlier law codes in their attempt to deal with the difficult conditions endured by slaves, they did not abolish this exploitative system, and the vicious cycle of debt slavery continued to persist among the peasant classes.³⁴ Through this system, the Israelite elites continued to “trample the head of the poor into the dust of the earth, and push the afflicted out of the way” (Amos 2:7a; cf. Job 24:4).

In another disputed verse, Amos 2:7b indicts an Israelite father and son who *yēlēkū hnʾrh*, which is translated variously as “go to the same girl” (JPS), “go in to the same girl” (NRSV, following the LXX), “use the same girl” (NIV), “go to the same prostitute” (NAB), or “resort to the temple girls” (NEB). These translations assume different sexual offenses committed by the father and son. In the JPS, NRSV, and NIV, it can refer to any girl whom the offenders share sexually, or perhaps to a girl employed in their household as a domestic worker or slave whom they sexually abuse (cf. Ex 21:7–9). In the NAB, the girl is a sex worker used by both men. Furthermore, because of the religious references to “my holy name,” “every altar,” and “house of their God” (2:7b–8), the NEB translates *hnʾrh* as “the temple girls,” or cult prostitutes. However one interprets *yēlēkū hnʾrh*, that Amos condemns the sexual exploitation of women within the wider socioeconomic context is quite plausible.

Nevertheless, because this egregious act does not appear elsewhere in Amos’s oracles, Moughtin-Mumby offers a credible alternative for *yēlēkū hnʾrh* that does not involve the sexual exploitation of women, but has connections with other parts of the book’s social justice themes.³⁵ We have already observed Amos’s focus on geography and the many specific place names on trade routes in the oracles against the nations. This emphasis on international cities and geopolitics frequently appears in other passages in his work.³⁶ Accordingly, Moughtin-Mumby argues that *hnʾrh* should be translated as a place name, Naarah, a city on the border of Ephraim near Jericho (Josh 16:7; 1 Chr 7:28): “A man and his father go to Naarah.” Like the other cities on important trade routes in Amos’s oracles against the nations, Naarah was near a road known as “the way of the wilderness” or the “way of the border,” which would have designated the later boundaries between

Israel and Judah.³⁷ Furthermore, Moughtin-Mumby contends that the repetition of *yṭw* in Amos 2:7–8 is a wordplay. In the Hiphil in 2:7 it meant “turn aside” or “pervert” the “way of the afflicted,” as in Proverbs 17:23, where the wicked “pervert the ways of justice.” Its duplication in Amos 2:8 to describe the offense of the father and son as “stretching out” reiterates the offense against social justice in 2:7, thus unifying the passage. “The men’s ‘turning aside’ (*yṭw*) of the needy (2.7) and their ‘stretching out’ (*yṭw*) and drinking beside every altar (2.8) amount to the same thing: a serious travesty of social justice.”³⁸ With the fines they impose on the poor and afflicted, they buy wine, which they sanctimoniously drink in the house of their God (2:8).

By reading *hnʾrh* as a city rather than as “the girl,” thematic connections can be made with the rest of the book of Amos. The ones who go to Naarah to stretch out on garments and imbibe wine (2:8) resemble the good-for-nothings of 6:4–5 who “lie on beds of ivory and lounge on their couches” and “drink wine from bowls.” It is clear from Amos 6:1 that Amos is targeting the leadership (“notables”) of both states, Zion (Jerusalem) of Judah and Mount Samaria of Israel, as he does in the oracles against the nations. Here in 6:4–5 the conspicuous consumption of the elites at the expense of the oppressed rural sectors is unmistakably evident in references to their inlaid ivory beds,³⁹ their eating, not only meat itself (a rarity in the subsistence diet),⁴⁰ but the tenderest cuts of meats (6:4), their idle leisure (6:5), their drinking wine from bowls of costly metals,⁴¹ and their finest oils for anointment (6:6). But because of their indifference to the “ruin of Joseph,” they will be the first to be exiled and their *marzēaḥ* will pass away (6:7). Amos explicitly describes the occasion in 6:4–7 as a *marzēaḥ* (6:7), a particular banquet celebrated in different areas of southwest Asia for over three millennia B.C.E. According to John McLaughlin, its constitutive features are its definable upper-class membership, its religious connection, and its alcohol consumption. Although some scholars think that it might have a connection with funeral rites, McLaughlin rejects this.⁴²

McLaughlin also rejects the possibility that Amos 2:6–8 is a *marzēaḥ*, because it does not involve the copious drinking that supposedly characterizes such a banquet. Moughtin-Mumby demurs, arguing that McLaughlin accepts the possibility that Amos 4:1 alludes to a *marzēaḥ*. Here, the wealthy women of Samaria, notoriously depicted as the “cows of Bashan,” demand drink from their husbands and thus through their greed “oppress the poor” and “crush the needy.” However, there is no clear hint of a religious context or even the drinking of wine in 4:1, yet these features are present in 2:6–8. Furthermore, it is not that certain that *excessive* drinking is a necessary criterion. For Moughtin-Mumby, McLaughlin’s dismissal of 2:6–8 as a possible *marzēaḥ* is overly hasty. Both 2:6–8 and 6:4–7 focus on the social injustices that arise from the exploitation of the poor and needy that makes the extravagant banquets, such as the *marzēaḥ*, possible for the upper classes.⁴³

Amos’s oracle against Israel in 2:6–8 concludes and forms the climax of his diatribe against the nations and the first section of his book. He accuses the Israelite elite of selling the righteous and needy into debt-slavery, trampling on the head of the poor and pushing aside the afflicted. He lambastes upper-class men who head to Naarah to enjoy

the sumptuous feasting and camaraderie of the *marzēah*, and hypocritically use the fines they squeeze from the poor to drink wine “in the house of their God.” All of these serious moral and economic abuses are made possible by their involvement in and control over the significant international trade routes that crisscrossed their land. “The participation of the economic elites in the trade of luxury-goods throughout the Levant and beyond effectively constitutes participation in the same economic system driving their increasingly parasitic extraction of subsistence goods from the local economies under their sway.”⁴⁴

The oracles against the nations that inaugurate Amos’s work are not inconsistent with or ancillary to his condemnations against Israel in the succeeding chapters. They become the hermeneutical key to the rest of the book. Because of their involvement in the international economy of that strategic land bridge in southern Levant, the Israelite elites are complicit in the violence and cruelty resulting from the complicated military histories and economic relations of the contiguous states located there. When Amos castigates Israel’s socioeconomic exploitations in the remainder of the book, his indictments are driven by this wider brutal context in which Israel’s economy is embedded.⁴⁵

CONCLUSION

A materialist reading is an ideological analysis of the economic power relations that both produce the biblical text and are encoded in its literary discourse. To perform such an analysis for the prophets, one must not only understand the socioeconomic and historical contexts in which the prophets lived and worked, but also be able to detect the ideologies of class relations within the biblical texts themselves. Such an analysis must consider not only the local or national setting of a prophet’s ministry, but also the wider international context of the Levant and southwest Asia. These societies were primarily agrarian ones. Thus, the social relations and economic pursuits of a major part of the population were very much bound up with and reliant on the physical environment. Because of high infant and adult mortality rates, a major economic issue in such a society was having enough labor to farm the land, as well as cope with unpredictable weather forecasts, insect invasions, and so forth. To deal with these, subsistence strategies developed to ensure survival, such as crop rotation, fallowing, and surplus storage for times of famine (see Genesis 41).

This chapter first discussed the development of the Israelite state in the ninth century, because the prophets as a social force separate from the royal court seemed to have emerged during this time. The prophets particularly condemned the state’s oppression and exploitation of the agrarian sectors of the society. From a materialist perspective of the *longue durée*, which concentrates on the geography, economy, and population of an area over the long term, northern Israel enjoyed the geographic, ecological, and demographic advantages to emerge as a strong state.

Israel became a force to be reckoned with during the ninth century under its powerful king Omri, who developed successful trade relations, especially with his northern neighbor Phoenicia, and also opened up important routes from Moab to Damascus and Damascus to the Mediterranean. He built great fortresses in Megiddo, Jezreel, and particularly his expensive capital city Samaria. Another mark of statehood was Omri's standing army and extensive military campaigns, which were also continued under his son, Ahab. Extra-biblical sources describe Ahab as heading a military coalition against Assyria with two thousand chariots and ten thousand foot soldiers.

There were, however, sinister features that emerged with the rise of the state. Social relations became very stratified between the majority of people who work the land and a small minority who live off the labor of the peasantry in relations of extraction and exploitation. Labor was pulled from the rural sectors to farm the agricultural estates that fed the ruling elites, and to work on their various building projects or fight in their military campaigns. The demands on the peasantry for greater production, especially to obtain expensive luxuries, conflicted with the subsistence survival strategies that they traditionally held. Because Israel was situated on a strategic piece of real estate amid the various empires of southwest Asia, it unavoidably became involved in their numerous international politics, military conflicts, compromises, and particularly their economic greed for more resources and territory.

The most well-known example of monarchic abuse of power in the ninth-century was Ahab's unwarranted seizure of Naboth's vineyard in Jezreel, supposedly for a "vegetable garden" (1 Kings 21). In reality, his desire for this piece of land had more to do with his economic and military objectives. Jezreel was a rich agricultural area with access to major highways and trade routes of the time, not only toward the southern kingdom of Judah, but also northward to his major trading partner, Phoenicia. Moreover, Jezreel was an important military center, which accommodated his large chariot and cavalry detachments. Its fortress may also have been a means to control and coerce the local population.

The discussion then shifted to the eighth-century prophet Amos, who worked during the prosperous reign of Jeroboam II, and whose prophecies clearly denounced the materialism and social injustices of his time. The materialist analysis focused on the oracles against the nations in Amos in 1:3–2:8, which cleverly followed a geographical progression toward their final indictment of the nation of Israel. All of these eight nations occupied the strategic land bridge in the Fertile Crescent between the empires of Mesopotamia and Egypt. Crisscrossing these nations were major trade routes and highways that connect them with these imperial centers and with each other. These trade routes, as we saw, were particularly utilized and expanded during the ninth-century Omride dynasty in the rise of the Israelite state. Through them flowed enormous wealth, but with a dark underside of human trafficking and brutal military campaigns. Within these nation-states, the economies were divided between the subsistence survival of the rural sectors and that of the urban elites, which exploited these sectors to cash in on the wealth flowing from the international trade. Amos denounced the Israelite elite for their

complicity in this trade, which indirectly exploited the poor and the most vulnerable in that society.

As one reads the narratives of the prophets from a materialist perspective, one realizes that things have not changed much in the twenty-first century, thousands of years later. In the United States and in many other parts of the world, the gulf between the rich and the poor is becoming increasingly wider. The interregional trade during the eras of Elijah and Amos becomes considerably magnified in today's globalization and economic interdependency. And the exploitation, human trafficking, military clashes, and so on that infected Israel and its surrounding nations continue to be a cancer in today's world. The economic oppression decried by the prophets continues in virulent form in many communities across the globe. Their challenge to us today to denounce this cancer becomes all the more urgent.

NOTES

1. For a thorough discussion, see Yee 2003: 9–28.
2. Carol Meyers, *Rediscovering Eve: Ancient Israelite Women in Context* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2013), 42; William G. Dever, *The Lives of Ordinary People in Ancient Israel: Where Archaeology and the Bible Intersect* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2012), 142.
3. It is difficult to determine precisely the mortality rates for infants and adults. Ancient and modern mortality tables suggest an infant mortality rate of around 50% to 70%. Bronze Age skeletal remains near Jerusalem suggest a life span of 30–40 years for men and 20–30 years for women, with Iron Age life spans even shorter. See Meyers, *Rediscovering Eve: Ancient Israelite Women in Context*, 97–102.
4. Boer 2015: 75–79.
5. Boer 2015: 30–31.
6. For theories on the rise of the monarchy, see Paula M. McNutt, *Reconstructing the Society of Ancient Israel* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1999), 104–142.
7. Thomas C. Römer, *The So-Called Deuteronomistic History: A Sociological, Historical, and Literary Introduction* (New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 97–102. For differing archaeological views on the united monarchy, see Israel Finkelstein, Amihai Mazar, and Brian B. Schmidt, *The Quest for the Historical Israel: Debating Archaeology and the History of Early Israel* (Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2007), 101–39.
8. Israel Finkelstein, “A Great United Monarchy? Archaeological and Historical Perspectives,” in *One God—One Cult—One Nation: Archaeological and Biblical Perspectives* (BZAW 405; ed. Reinhard G. Kratz and Hermann Spieckermann; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2010), 3–28.
9. Israel Finkelstein, *The Forgotten Kingdom: The Archaeology and History of Northern Israel* (Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2013), 108–113, 160–162.
10. David Ussishkin, “Samaria, Jezreel and Megiddo: Royal Centres of Omri and Ahab,” in *Ahab Agonistes: The Rise and Fall of the Omri Dynasty* (LHBOTS 421; ed. Lester L. Grabbe; London and New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 293–309; Lester L. Grabbe, “The Kingdom of Israel from Omri to the Fall of Samaria: If We Only Had the Bible . . .” In *Ahab Agonistes*, 54–99.
11. See the map of Israel's expansion in Finkelstein, *Forgotten Kingdom*, 79.

12. Finkelstein, *Forgotten Kingdom*, 155–158, and Daniel E. Fleming, *The Legacy of Israel in Judah's Bible: History, Politics, and the Reinscribing of Tradition* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012); also, see the various essays in Andrew G. Vaughn and Ann E. Killebrew, eds., *Jerusalem in Bible and Archaeology: The First Temple Period* (Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2003).
13. *Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament* [ANET] (ed. James B. Pritchard; 3rd ed.; Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1969), 284.
14. Deborah Cantrell, *The Horsemen of Israel: Horses and Chariotry in Monarchic Israel (Ninth–Eighth Centuries B.C.E.)* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2011), 7–9, 76–113; Grabbe, “The Kingdom of Israel from Omri to the Fall of Samaria,” 301–307.
15. Rainer Albertz, “Social History of Ancient Israel,” in *Understanding the History of Ancient Israel* (ed. H. G. M. Williamson; Proceedings of the British Academy 143; Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2007, 347–367 (361–363); Hannelis Schulte, “The End of the Omride Dynasty: Social-Ethical Observations on the Subject of Power and Violence,” trans. Carl S. Ehrlich; *Semeia* 66(1994): 133–148 (140–141, 145–146).
16. Pritchard, ANET, 238.
17. Grabbe, “The Kingdom of Israel from Omri to the Fall of Samaria,” 54–99; Eric H. Cline, *The Battles of Armageddon: Megiddo and the Jezreel Valley from the Bronze Age to the Nuclear Age* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2000); Jennie R. Ebeling, Norma Franklin and Ian Cipin, “Jezreel Revealed in Laser Scans: A Preliminary Report of the 2012 Survey Season,” *NEA* 75(4) (2012), 232–239.
18. Shawn Zelig Aster, “The Function of the City of Jezreel and the Symbolism of Jezreel in Hosea 1–2,” *JNES* 71(1) (2012): 31–46 (37–39).
19. Finkelstein, *Forgotten Kingdom*, 109–112; H. G. M. Williamson, “Tel Jezreel and the Dynasty of Omri,” *PEQ* 128(1) (1996): 41–50 (46–50).
20. Izabela Jaruzelska, *Amos and the Officialdom in the Kingdom of Israel: The Socio-Economic Position of the Officials in the Light of the Biblical, the Epigraphic and Archaeological Evidence* (Poznan, Poland: Adam Mickiewicz University Press, 1998), 34–41; Finkelstein, *Forgotten Kingdom*, 129–131.
21. Finkelstein, *Forgotten Kingdom*, 135–138; Jaruzelska, *Amos and the Officialdom*, 84–92.
22. This section is indebted to the excellent study by Jeremy M. Hutton, “Amos 1:3–2:8 and the International Economy of Iron Age II Israel,” *HTR* 107(1) (2014), 81–113.
23. Although Edomite copper mining seems to have stopped by the end of the ninth century, the horrific memories of slavery in its mines most likely persisted during Amos's time. Cf. Thomas E. Levy and Mohammad Najjar, “Condemned to the Mines: Copper Production and Christian Persecution,” *BAR* 37(6) (2011), 30–39, 71.
24. John S. Holladay, Jr., “Hezekiah's Tribute, Long-Distance Trade, and the Wealth of Nations Ca. 1000–600 BC: A New Perspective (“Poor Little [Agrarian] Judah” at the End of the 8th Century BC: Dropping the First Shoe),” in *Confronting the Past: Archaeological and Historical Essays on Ancient Israel in Honor of William G. Dever* (eds. Seymour Gitin, J. Edward Wright, and J. P. Dessel; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2006), 309–331; Finkelstein, *Forgotten Kingdom*, 112–113, 131–138.
25. For example, some of the palace booty Sennacherib seized from the seventh-century Judean king Hezekiah included “30 talents of gold, 800 talents of silver, choice antimony, large blocks of carnelian, beds (inlaid) with ivory, armchair (inlaid) with ivory, elephant hides, ivory, ebony-wood, boxwood, multicolored garments, garments of linen, wool (dyed) red-purple and blue purple, vessels of copper, iron, bronze and tin, chariots”

- (cited in Holladay, "Hezekiah's Tribute," 312). Most of these items were not native to Israel or Judah.
26. Robert B. Coote and Keith W. Whitelam, *The Emergence of Early Israel in Historical Perspective* (Sheffield: Almond, 1987), 65; see especially Chaney 2014: 34–60.
 27. Coote and Whitelam, *The Emergence of Early Israel in Historical Perspective*, 67–70.
 28. Holladay, "Hezekiah's Tribute," 321–328.
 29. Hutton, "Amos 1:3–2:8," 107.
 30. Hutton, "Amos 1:3–2:8," 107–109.
 31. Hutton, "Amos 1:3–2:8," 109–110.
 32. Avi Shveka, "'For a Pair of Shoes': A New Light on an Obscure Verse in Amos' Prophecy," *VT* 62(1) (2012): 95–114.
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 35. Sharon Moughtin-Mumby, "'A Man and His Father Go to Naarah in Order to Defile My Holy Name!': Rereading Amos 2.6–8," in *Aspects of Amos: Exegesis and Interpretation* (ed. Anselm C. Hagedorn and Andrew Mein; LHBOTS 536; New York: T & T Clark International, 2011), 59–82.
 36. Cf. Egypt (2:10; 3:1, 9; 4:10), land of the Amorite (2:10), Samaria (3:9, 12; 6:1; 8:14), Bethel (3:14; 4:4; 5:5–6; 7:10), Bashan (4:1), Harmon? (4:3), Gilgal (4:4; 5:5), Sodom and Gomorrah (4:11), Beer-sheba (5:5), Damascus (6:25), Zion (6:1), Calneh (6:2), Hamath (6:2), Gath (6:2), Lo-debar (6:13), Karnaim (6:13), Lebo-hamath (6:14), Wadi Arabah (6:14), Judah (7:12), Sheol (9:2), Carmel (9:3), Caphtor (9:7), Kir (9:7), Edom (9:12).
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CHAPTER 29

POSTCOLONIAL READINGS OF THE PROPHETS

STEED VERNYL DAVIDSON

As socially engaged critiques of power, prophets and postcolonial studies form the perfect combination. This pairing, though, works easily only with oversimplified versions of the prophets and the postcolonial optic.¹ More than simply the voice in the public square speaking truth to power, prophets and particularly the literature that follows in their wake, prove to be more intimately related to and compromised by power. Not only the anti-colonial, postcolonial studies embrace a range of discursive and social practices that identify and critique the actions of concentrations of power in various forms, the self-reflexive nature of postcolonialism eschews overgeneralizations and reductive approaches to issues of power. As a pair, postcolonialism and prophets prove a complex combination. Just as power can be diffuse, the fight against diverse forms of oppressive power appears in different guises with multiple allegiances. While not an exclusive portmanteau term for resistance to oppressive power, postcolonialism shelters myriad critiques of power that produce more cacophony than ambiguity. To be sure, postcolonialism's primary focus remains on historical and current geopolitical arrangements and the consequences that flow from these political orders (Huggan 2013: 10). Accordingly, postcolonial readings of the prophets offer critical revisions of these texts and their relevance for contemporary discourses through heightened attention to imperial power.

Literary texts serve as the significant, although not the only, venue for postcolonial investigations of discursive practices around empire. The prophets as literary texts gesture to social figures set within the shifting fortunes of ancient Israel and Judah amidst the geopolitical transformations caused by ancient Near Eastern empires. Despite this framing, the popular perception of the figure of the Hebrew Bible prophet extracts the prophet from the broader imperial nexus of power to remain a mostly localized religious reactionary force. For instance, while the New Testament makes generous use of prophetic texts, only Acts 7:43, and in a vague and generalist way,

places the prophets in the context of ancient empires. This severed connection can also be seen in the deployment of the figure of the Hebrew prophet as an oppositional voice and actor, not so much against the logic of empire, but as a force of resistance to identified leaders and a limited set of policies. The amorphous nature of empires, their ability to mutate easily, and their penchant either to coopt or silence oppositional voices, lends urgency to engage the prophets with imperial considerations in the foreground.

The shape-shifting quality of empire makes empire a pressing area of study for those concerned about the corrupting influences of power. At the end of the twentieth century, empire seemed like a historical legacy lost to the modern world. To the extent that empire stood as a holdover in the new millennium, it was marked as a diffused form of power, described by Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri as a “*decentered* and *detrterritorializing* apparatus of rule” (2000: vii; emphasis original). Yet within a decade and a half of the opening of the twenty-first century, territorial and non-territorial expansionist actions feature prominently in the news headlines. After military campaigns waged by the United States and its allies in Afghanistan and Iraq, the violent challenges to the artificiality of boundaries drawn by European colonial powers in Africa and Asia following European wars in the early twentieth century, imperialism and colonialism still frame the geopolitics of the modern world.² Greater diversity in technologies of conquest means that more powerful nations have different ways of pursuing the will to power that marks the imperial path. Postcolonial studies provide a tool of inquiry that examines the records of empires and, particularly for the purposes of this study, investigates their discursive practices. Because texts neither emerge nor exist outside of communities, the imperializing discourses of texts such as the prophets had an impact on lived practices and affect living realities.

This overview of the prophets from the postcolonial optic focuses attention on the literature produced in the name of prophets. This literature in its final form offers a narrative of the entity known as Israel/Judah, simplistically referred to as a nation, to situate it within the broader geopolitical movements of the ancient world. This narrative offers at once a critique of specific imperial actors and a solid affirmation of the logic of empire. In its embrace of empire as a mechanism of power, the collection of prophetic books points to the eradication of the named imperial actors on the path of a vision for a new world marked by a more benign imperial power. Essentially, the literature advocates fighting empire with empire and does so through voices positioned as historically engaged messengers of the divine will. After initial explorations of the central notions of prophets and postcolonial studies, this overview situates the formation of the collection of texts known as the prophets in the aftermath of the collapse of the Neo-Babylonian Empire and the rise of the Achaemenid Empire that ushered in the Persian period. Attentive to ways in which these two empires bookend the collapse of the Judean monarchy and the need to reimagine a new political configuration with a center in Jerusalem, the overview examines various themes in prophetic texts that contribute to the imperial bias of the collection. The chapter ends with consideration of counternarratives to the dominant shaping of the prophetic corpus.

THE POSTCOLONIAL OPTIC AND THE BIBLE

The term “postcolonial” attempts to capture the history and legacies of modern European territorial expansions. This umbrella term draws from several streams of anticolonial practices during different periods of decolonization in former European colonies, producing, in the words of Timothy Brennan, “unstable alliances with clashing objectives” (2013: 143). Literature offered one of the central areas of colonial critique and therefore accounts for the strong emphasis in postcolonial studies on literary criticism and related approaches. Since political movements played critical roles in decolonization, anticolonial practices that aim at social transformation also provide bedrock for postcolonial engagement. Inevitably as an academic discourse that gains its reputation in elite metropolitan academic institutions, albeit an insurgent one, refractions of postcolonial studies reflect the limited concerns of thinkers who, despite their national and racial origins, still occupy positions of privilege within intellectual circles.³ At times the divide between the abstract and the engaged depends on the level of devotion to Marxist categories.⁴ Undoubtedly fueled by the Marxist vision of the successful organization of the underclass to overthrow oppressive owners of capital, anticolonial movements understand the fight as involving much more than the recovery of indigenous identity. In Marxist historiography, anticolonialism was a struggle against capitalist power, which in the last centuries of the previous millennium expressed itself as particular forms of imperialism/colonialism. The reach and impact of global capital, particularly through the rise of neoliberal economic policies since the 1970s, replaced the dismantled empires with what Neil Lazarus calls “a deterritorialized and geographically anonymous behemoth” (2011: 7), a tool of capitalism. Although the digital age offers new venues, and perhaps limitless ones, for conquest, territorial occupation tied to the interests of resources still persists, making imperialism/colonialism an ongoing concern.

The obdurate nature of empire notwithstanding, the term “postcolonial” still proves an apt descriptor of this mode of inquiry. Rather than a claim to a neat conclusion of colonialism, the unhyphenated form of the term captures the full historical concern of the postcolonial optic from colonialism’s inception to beyond the formal end of colonial relationships.⁵ Precisely in this period, in the aftermath of formal empires where imperializing tendencies still persist in old and new forms and where global dominance stands as more than a cartoonish reality but a real possibility, the term “postcolonial” centers attention on the significant movements shaping the world as it currently exists.

With its eye firmly on the history and legacies of empire, postcolonialism’s concerns emerge primarily around the implications of imperial dominance. Nicholas Harrison lists these as “power relations and patterns of (mutual) influence between colonizer and colonized; the question of subjective and political agency; nationhood, nationalism and anti-colonial resistance, Eurocentrism, universalism and relativism; ‘race’ or ethnicity, gender and identity” (2003: 7). Lazarus highlights preoccupations such as “migrancy, liminality, hybridity, and multi-culturality” (2011: 21) that emerge from the

preponderance of poststructuralist methods; these tend to dominate postcolonial studies at some levels, but can best be seen as secondary concerns. In any event, the varied interests that cluster around postcolonial studies intersect with biblical studies in many respects.

The Bible's production in the context of empire, as well as its signal contribution to the European colonial project, opened the way for postcolonial studies in biblical studies. With more available data from the Roman Empire, postcolonial approaches to New Testament texts tend to focus heavily on historical data, producing what Stephen Moore call "empire-attuned" studies (2011: 14). On the other hand, being less intimately connected to the histories of the Neo-Assyrian, Neo-Babylonian, and Persian Empires, Hebrew Bible/Old Testament postcolonial work leans toward poststructuralist methodologies to emphasize issues of identity, ambivalence, exile, and diaspora. Foregrounding the imperial presence in texts, whether at the discursive level or as a serious actor in the production of these texts, presents opportunities for deconstructionist as well as materialist readings that may be put in the service of socially engaged reflections. The narrative of the Judean nation that unfolds in the Hebrew Bible not only plays out in the background of a succession of empires, but also consistently seeks to position the nation as a vital character in the meta-narrative of the ancient Near East.

PROPHETS IN POSTCOLONIAL PERSPECTIVE

While the figure of the Hebrew prophet as a historical person seems suitable for postcolonial studies, this overview pays attention to the prophets as literature. The task of historical recuperation both of various named prophets and the socio-political-religious phenomenon of Israelite prophecy may prove useful for postcolonial inquiries at some point. However, the relationship between prophets, prophecy, and prophetic literature remains complex to the point where, admittedly, they are not always the same thing (Ben Zvi 2009: 73). Nonetheless, the final form of the literature creates a fictive relationship between what may or may not have been real individuals called prophets functioning in defined or unique social and religious contexts. Part of the authoritative appeal of the prophetic book lies in the encounter between the reader and the named messenger of the book, who emerges as a medium between both heaven and earth as well as the past and present/future, forming what Ben Zvi describes as a "transtemporal bridge" (2009: 77). The constructed figure of the prophet serves the purposes of the framers of the collection to provide a body of literature that enlists support for a new mutation of imperial power. The figure of the Hebrew prophet available in the texts stands as a representation of the mode of production of these texts that navigate multiple layers of power. The lived experiences of imperial power in real and imagined ways fill in some of the background context of the Hebrew prophets (Davidson 2010: 24–25). Given that prophetic books make little pretense of naming an "author," the books need to be viewed

as products of the time in which they were finally assembled, representing the socio-cultural and theo-political forces that give rise to them.

The sites of power within Judah that produce the prophetic texts are not completely sealed off from the formative influences of imperial power. In fact, these sites are formed by and in reaction to imperial power. Gayatri Spivak makes the case concerning feminism, which holds true for the way imperialism defines those whom it dominates, that feminist discursive practices are already constituted by “the field of their production.” Therefore, as with women in relation to men and the dominated in relation to imperial power, women and the imperialized exist “in the sense that they must be understood *as* unlike (non-identical with) it and yet *with* reference to it” (Spivak 1999: 47, emphasis original). Spivak’s point holds merit as well for understanding cultural representations in literature in an age of imperialism. Not only do empires deploy literature as a medium for their message, but literature also participates in the world framed by the will of empires. While holding ancient empires as the background scenery against which the tableau of the prophetic texts unfolds, the imperial background serves as more than simply decorative background, operating as the controlling frame for representation in prophetic texts.

The final form of prophetic texts emerges at the critical juncture in history between the collapse of the Neo-Babylonian Empire and the rise of the Persian Empire. Although not a liminal period, the transition from the hegemony of Babylon (mostly represented as repressive in the Bible) to Persian rule, seen as the dawn of a new era, offers the framers of prophetic texts the opportunity to re/imagine the nation.⁶ If on the one hand Babylon serves as the signifier for the collapse of the Judean state apparatus, on the other hand Persia presents opportunities to reconstitute the nation. No mere reassembling of the old parts would suffice, since prophetic theology relentlessly critiqued the previous incarnation of the nation and its practices. The transition from Babylonian rule to Persian rule marks the transition from the empire that destroys the nation to the empire that oversees the (re)defining of the nation. The prophetic literature represents a vision for the nation built upon the presuppositions of empire. Rather than a full-throated critique of empire, the prophetic texts endorse a vision for a future structured by imperial power. While this new imperial power will maintain the tools of former empires, its rule will be just, promising an era of flourishing following the reconstitution of the scattered pieces of the Judean community. Like other earthly powers of the ancient Near East, this envisaged imperium operates as a theocratic monarchy centered in a restored Jerusalem/Zion that hosts no throne for an earthly ruler. Engaging the divine warrior motif, the prophetic vision describes the subduing of nations and empires through the mechanisms of conquest available to ancient empires. The endorsement or naming of an earthly ruler is unimportant for this prophetic manifesto. An era of flourishing on the other side of the collapse of empires and nations, secured by the divine imperium, makes up the critical contours of the prophetic vision.

The prophets represent a unique form of literature addressing the needs of the nation. In comparison with other prophetic texts in the ancient Near East and the precursor texts called the Former Prophets, the prophets combine historiography,

oracular reports, brief biographies, and other elements to present a distinctive corpus. This corpus in its final form circulates largely among the literate in Persian-era Yehud but remains aware of the diasporic nature of the nation. As literature, the prophets attend to the task of history and reconstituting identity in the aftermath of disaster, something that Kanishka Goonewardena presents as the alternative to war for a diasporic community. Goonewardena describes such historiographies as ideological in that they offer a combination of the imaginary and reality. He further notes that the effective historiographies engage the harshness of the community's experience but also face the prospect of social death (2004: 683). The prophets offer an imagined future for the fractured Judean community through the mode of history, thus providing the venue to face the nation's existential threat, and from there to imagine a new future. The historical mode of reporting, along with the imperial messenger form, positions the prophets in the mode of imperial discourse. Elements of these books, such as nationalist concerns, violent language, and patriarchal/masculinist perspectives, as well as the idea of global conquest present in the oracles against the nations, reflect imperializing discourses. Utilizing this discourse situates the prophets as sympathetic to empire as the way of being for the nation in the future.

THE DISCOURSE OF EMPIRE IN THE PROPHETS

The genre of prophetic literature may be marked more by slippage than coherence. Nonetheless, several common themes and motifs appear consistently across the corpus, at least from a postcolonial optic, making cautiously generalizing statements possible. The exceptions to commonly observed characteristics demonstrate, rather than disprove, the power of knowledge production at work in these texts. These exceptions enable the postcolonial task of exposing the functions of imperial discourses within these texts as an oppositional act. This section explores themes and motifs in the prophets that employ imperial discourses as the mechanism for assessing and imagining the nation.

Textuality as Imperialism

The transformation of various modes of prophetic communications into text represents the capture of prophetic speech by the purposes of the framers of the prophetic corpus. Whether original or not, the superscription on each prophetic book witnesses the translation of speech into text in a form that renders it accessible to literate classes who, as Walter Ong indicates, possess greater access to the language than non-literate speakers of that language (1982: 7). The codification of formerly oral performances

involving practices of divination without fully representing those divinatory practices in the texts demonstrates the transformation of speech into a specialist product that shifts the previous content and context of those oral performances. As Ong offers, writing “tyrannically” locks words “into a visual field forever” (1982: 12), enabling texts to colonize the minds of readers with their fixed meanings. This tyranny operates narrowly upon the literate, and textuality takes no account of the non-literate, who, as Althea Spencer-Miller points out, are excluded from written productions and thereby shut out of formerly oral communications.⁷ Codification of the prophets as texts renders vast sections of the Judean community mute and dependent upon the literate for the single meaning of texts.

Prophetic literature not only shares the imperializing tendencies of texts, the works fix the prophets as authority figures on several levels, not least among them being the consistency of their message since they say the same thing all the time and can always be deemed to be correct every time they are consulted. Written prophecy serves as the ideal medium for prophets since they gain the automatic authority of textuality relieving them of the pressure of fully proving their authenticity. Hence the superscriptions can get by introducing the content of books with vague phrases such as “the vision” (Isa 1:1, Obad 1), “the word of the LORD came” (Jer 1:1, Ezek 1:3, Hos 1:1, Joel 1:1, Amos 1:1, Mic 1:1, Zeph 1:1, Hag 1:1, Zech 1:1), and “an oracle” (Nah 1:1, Hab 1:1, Mal 1:1). A prophetic text is a doubly authenticating product, deriving authority as a written text and representing a figure accepted as authoritative by virtue of being a divine messenger.

Essentially, prophetic literature is a product of elite society, intended for the most part for an elite readership. In the ancient world, literate readers and writers operated within the leadership structure of the society, most likely in royal palaces and temples. While the cadre of the literate circle of Judah would have been dismantled and dispersed with the collapse of the monarchy, the compilation and formation of the prophets indicate the existence of a community performing the work of erstwhile royal scribal groups.⁸ The Persian-enabled leadership in Yehud, as well as priestly communities, most likely form the core within which prophetic texts circulated. The ethos of monarchal society frames the message of the prophets through the use of the messenger formula. While the messenger formula is not unique to this corpus, the direct address to the reader, unlike the third-person reporting of the activities of prophets in the Former Prophets, positions the reader as the chief recipient of the divine message. The fiction of participating intimately in the lofty world of divinity and monarchal power conscripts the reader’s sympathies to the culture of royalty and power. The bulk of the textual material in the prophets consists of second-person address, transmitted through the medium of the prophet *cum* text. The striking absence of God—a disembodied voice mediated through the prophet *cum* text—reinforces the notion of the absent distant power that asks hearers/readers to accept passively the messenger and the message. As text, the prophets image the imperial structure of spatial and qualitative distance that separates the divine, the imperial, from that over which it presides.⁹ Readers of the prophets enter into an experience in which the standards and values of dominant power obtain, predisposing them to the vision of empire.

Imperializing through History

Operating at the level of royal culture, the prophets present their message largely in the form of history, or more precisely, an evaluative report about the past. The historical report concerns the nation, as most of the superscriptions indicate. Regnal years provide an obvious dating formula within which to situate the words of the prophets. Since the texts present largely the words of these prophets rather than their actions, recording these words in a historical context invites the reader to hear the words in relation to the broader history of the nation. Instead of providing a historical account of the nation, the prophets present a theological evaluation of the nation in the context of its history. Dates referencing Judean and Israelite kings (Isa 1:1; 6:1; 7:1, Jer 1:2–3; 25:1; 26:1; 27:1; 28:1, Ezek 1:2, Hos 1:1, Amos 1:1; 7:10, Mic 1:1, Zeph 1:1) as well as rulers of empires (Isa 39:1, Jer 40:1, Hag 1:1, 15; 2:10, Zech 1:1, 7; 7:1) establish the historical concerns of the prophets. These concerns deal largely with the nation and its fortunes in the midst of empire. Even in those books that do not explicitly use date formulas, history and the nation's place in those events remain concerns.¹⁰ In any event, as the content of the prophets demonstrates, the nation's path intersects significantly with named imperial powers. The ability to touch the otherness of the past in the form of the text invests the reader of the prophets with a seductive power; therefore the reader is likely to be sympathetic with the producers of the text that enables history to, as Ananda Abeysekara puts it, "appear" (2013: 510). Structuring their message within the categories of lived history, the prophets opt for historicization as the mode of representing the nation. Since historicization is not a neutral activity, the postcolonial optic examines how the "present" that shapes the prophets represents the "past," particularly as this concerns regimes of power.

Like most of the Bible, the prophetic books are the products of compilations and editing of preexisting textual material, resulting from the work of various tradents who processed primary material into the final form of the text. The processing of oral and other material into history stands as an act of power. Assuming all the words in the prophets to be original, as Edelman contends, writing recontextualizes these words, creating a new time and literary categories for these words (2009: 41)—no longer contemporary speech but history, no longer prophecy but history. That the prophets deal with imperial concerns and history places this corpus in the column of what Ranajit Guha notices in relation to the historical accounts of peasant revolts during the British Raj (1858–1947): "at the very intersection of colonialism and historiography, endowing it with a duplex character linked at the same time to a system of power and the particular manner of its representation" (2001: 124). The framers of the prophetic texts adopt, in Guha's terms, a "colonialist knowledge" (2001: 137) through which they interpret the world of the nation as the means of controlling the representation of the nation in texts and future discourse. By standing behind the more acceptable figures of the prophets, the framers easily hide themselves and the interests that they serve. In addition, through the minimalist biographies and narrative development of the prophets as characters,¹¹ the texts achieve the goal of prophecy *cum* history, neutrality, transparency, and ultimately credibility.

Imperializing Monarchies

The history of the nation offered in the prophets represents the nation as a failed state. Leaders possess few redeeming qualities and are constantly eviscerated as inadequate. The few named kings appear impervious to prophetic counsel—Ahaz disregards Isaiah (Isa 7:3–17; 8:16–22), Jehoiakim displays open antagonism to Jeremiah (Jer 36:1–32), Zedekiah shifts from solicitous (Jer 37:3–5; 38:14–23) to feckless (Jer 38:1–6, 24–28) to oppositional (Jer 37:17–21) in his relationship with Jeremiah, and the unique picture of Hezekiah's piety during the Assyrian crisis seems designed to set him up as a contrast to Ahaz, as a means of proving monarchal stubbornness to the prophets (Isa 7–8; cf. 36–38). One of the few positive mentions of a king occurs in reference to a golden period under an unnamed king in Jeremiah (22:15–16). Should that king be Josiah, then Zephaniah's placement of a searing critique of apostasy and official misconduct in the lament against an unnamed city, most likely Jerusalem (Zeph 3:1–5), stands to dilute the otherwise positive perception of Josiah (2 Kgs 22:1–2). The prophets do not play favorites with royal personalities and use the standard monarchal expectations of the ancient world, such as establishment of justice, protection for the poor, defense of the rights of the powerless, and so on, to evaluate the performances of the Judean kings (Isa 1:10–17, 23; 3:13–15; Jer 21:11; 22:1–3, 13–19; Hos 5:1–2; Mic 3:9–12; Zeph 3:3). The kings' utter failures contribute to the weakening of the fabric of the nation, making its destruction inevitable. The failed Judean monarchy is a historical artifact necessary to the prophetic purposes, for the prophets gesture to the rehabilitation of kingship in the future. In the prophets, monarchy consistently remains one of the single viable institutions for divine action. Imperial monarchs carry out the divine plan of punishment (Isa 10:5, Jer 27:6, Hab 1:5–11) and redemption (Isa 44:28–45:1, 13). The future contains monarchy and empire in various configurations. Isaiah (chs. 9, 11), Jeremiah (17:24–27; 22:1–5; 23:5–6; 33:17–22), and Amos (9:11–12) express confidence in the resurgence of the Davidic monarchy. Haggai appears to play to Davidic sentiments with its endorsement of Zerubbabel as the divinely chosen leader following the subduing of the nations (Hag 2:20–23). In any event, Haggai envisages centralized power playing a critical role in the future. Ezekiel, while muting the power of the monarchy, still includes it in the new Jerusalem (Ezek 44–48). Micah embraces a future ruler from a small clan as well as a collection of rulers to protect against a presumed Assyrian invasion (Mic 5:2–6). The structure of rule remains the same in the future, where leadership concentrates at the top.

Envisioning the future leadership also requires including divine power. In this regard, theocratic monarchy still obtains. However, the prophets, with few exceptions, do not explicitly underwrite an earthly monarch, even as they endorse the contours of imperial power. Zechariah represents the strongest assertion of exclusive divine power in the future. Expressing disappointment with earthly rulers (Zech 10:3–5; 11:4–17; 13:7), Zechariah presents divine kingship (14:9, 16) in the future in the form of the divine warrior (9:14–15; 14:1–5). Whatever future exists for the nation comes courtesy of divine power and complements its unrivaled military prowess.

Oracles against the Nations

The oracles against the nations serve as a key device in communicating the power and conquest of the divine imperium.¹² This concentration of passages, focused on foreign nations, provides an extensive geographic tour of destruction and conquest. The collections create what Edward Said refers to as an “imagined geography” that produces boundaries of discrimination (1978: 54). For each geographic place listed, a set of characteristics and moral failures that label the place and its people not “us” is given, setting the stage for either its destruction or conversion, functioning, as Said thinks imagined geographies do, to legitimate a vocabulary (1978: 71). Without offering consistent justifications, the oracles against the nations display an unnamed center’s will to power, taking control of geographic space by either making everything “us” or subjecting “them” to utter annihilation.¹³ With the exception of the Amos collection and perhaps Isaiah 22, all of the oracles focus on foreign nations imaginatively to depict both a swath of destruction and subjugation outside Jerusalem and at the same time a security shield that ensures stability in the region. The oracles against the nations conceive of a central power that deploys heavenly and earthly forces with deadly consequences: well-armed warriors (Isa 13:4, 17–18; Jer 46:3, 9; 50:9, 11, 29; Ezek 28:7–8; Nah 2:3–5), outfitted war horses (Jer 45:4; 50:40–41; Ezek 26:7–14), divine combat with and without weapons (Isa 14:22–23, 25; Jer 46:25–27; 50:35–38; Ezek 25:4–5, 7–11, 13–14, 16–17; Amos 1:4–5, 7–8; Obad 2–4, 8–9; Nah 2:13; Zeph 2:11–15; Zech 9:4), the use of unseen forces (Isa 13:15–16; Jer 49:28–32; 50:21–24; Ezek 27:28–33; Nah 2:2; Zeph 2:4), and the forces of nature and the cosmos (Isa 13:13; 14:9; 19:5–6; Ezek 27:34; 31:15–18; Nah 1:2–8). This arsenal of weapons reflects a well-outfitted army supported by resources acquired to maintain an empire. To be sure, the language of conquest lies in other places in the prophets in addition to the oracles against the nations. Together these passages contribute to the vision of the nation moving into a future with the rest of the world subdued, its security guaranteed, and its place as a viable power ensured.

The imperial dimensions of the prophets exist also at the level of the territorial imagination present in the oracles against the nations, as well as the violence required to achieve those ambitions. The lists of nations seem to defy a clear rationale for their composition and variously include foreign nations long since gone and those present, nations near and far, nations better known than others, empires posing real threats and those of lesser strategic danger, neighboring states with shared antagonism as well as ties of blood, in addition to nations that may generate a visceral reaction in readers. The lists of nations map control of territory that stretches across vast distances, sketching out the limits of the world known to readers. In this regard, the lists aspire to a global reach. While no single collection of the oracles entirely maps all known territory, the cumulative impact of the collections in the prophets underscores the global scope of the divine imperium requiring the rupture of planerity that Spivak advocates that forestalls the ideas of control that globalization invokes (2003: 72). Although violence pervades much of the prophets, the direct deployment of the mechanism of power to achieve the goal of dominance draws attention to instances of violence in the oracles against the nations.

Largely symbolic violence in texts, the rhetoric of violence in these oracles reflects the structures of ancient empires that used war as an instrument of foreign policy. While the atrocities detailed in the oracles remain gruesome, the violence implicit in empires remains hidden in the texts but forms the logic of territorial conquest and control of resources necessary to support an empire.

Morality Earns Territory

The moral logic that accompanies the use of violence in the prophets grants moral superiority to the holder of the more lethal weapons. The territorial violence stands out as a significant form of punishment for moral failure. The prophets apply the logic of territorial displacement and conquest across the board to both Judah and foreign nations. The indictments against Judah for its numerous failures lead to exile as the form of punishment. Similarly, foreign nations that breach implied legal codes face territorial loss. The oracles against the nations in Amos illustrate the application of the principle that immorality results in territorial conquest. Regardless of the infraction, the punishment includes destruction of city walls and other fortifications, decapitation of that nation's leadership through exile of the king and other nobles, cutting off of the residents of the city, and exile of either the king or residents. The descriptions of the punishments stop short of depicting the final fate of these nations, but the actions described in the punishments make it clear that these nations are now vulnerable and easily conquered. Ideas of manifest destiny link territory with morality, enabling the easy calculus that empire equals divine favor.¹⁴

The prophetic equation of landlessness with penance for sin committed, with restoration to the land occurring after having served the term of punishment, underlines, in part, an imperial vision of the subjugation of the world. If the divine right given to empires to discipline Judah derived from their morality, then the aftermath of the exile means that absolved Judah now inhabits a stronger moral position than these empires and therefore possesses a destiny to determine the fate of the territory of the nations. This ethos informs in part the Puritan pursuit of territorial acquisition in New England. Puritans hold the link between morality and territory both as justification for territorial wars and as self-critique for failures of whatever sort. Not surprisingly, Puritan preaching reflects the contours of the prophets as seen in the Puritans' embrace of the jeremiad. Sacvan Bercovitch views the strikingly unique version of this oral discourse in New England states as including the standard themes of reprisal, but tying these directly to the promise of a divinely appointed mission in a new land.¹⁵ Inspired by the exodus motif, the Puritan claims rest upon obligation to be obedient to the disciplinary regime of the covenant or risk losing the land. Just so, several of the prophets rehearse the exodus as a promise of land bound by an obligation to a defined way of living (Jer 2:7–8; 7:21–26; 11:4–5, Ezek 20:5–10; 23:5–10, Hos 8:1–14; 11:1–7). African American re-reading and reappropriation of the exodus, particularly through the figure of Moses as a representative prophet upholding the ethos of prophetic texts, challenge these claims by

linking the promise not to land but to what Eddie Glaude sees as community in pursuit of righteousness (2000: 54).

Imperializing Gender

Gender provides a noticeable trope for the moral discourse of the prophets. This operates differently for Judah than it does for the other nations. The prophets represent Judah's sin largely in terms of sexual transgressions. Since the feminization of nations and cities serves as a long-standing trope, the vehemence of the metaphors, more than their gendered form, appears striking. While brief references to women in various social situations exist in the prophets, women as sexually and religiously deviant forms the core representation of women, making real Hazel Carby's wry observation that representation at times can be worse than being left out (2009: 444). Reading these prophetic representations metaphorically to refer to Israel/Judah surfaces an intense repulsion of the female figure in the male gaze. By making the sexually transgressive woman visible, the prophets perform the act of unveiling that Frantz Fanon sees not as an act of liberation but as a means of making an otherwise hidden woman available, surrendered to the imperial will (1965: 44).

The grotesqueries of Ezekiel (chs. 16 and 23) and Hosea (chs. 1–3) serve to justify the moral interventions prescribed by a deeply patriarchal culture. While male sexual oppression clearly operates in representing the woman largely as sexually aberrant, the rhetoric deployed in these metaphors applies also to the sexualized military aggression of territorial conquest. Here too Fanon notices the link between violence and eroticism prevalent in colonial discourse (1965: 45).

The prophets participate in the imperialist trope of sexual domination to indict their own nation. In doing so, they put a huge distance between that sexually anomalous woman and the domesticated Judean woman who is hardly represented in the texts. By rendering one of "ours" foreign in several ways, that woman becomes subject to imperializing propaganda of being hypersexual and therefore an object both of sexual fascination and adventure, following what Musa Dube views as the Pocahontas script (2000: 73). Amina Mama points out that the imperialist sexual discourse rarely remains only at the level of territory but ultimately expresses itself in the actual bodies of women (2001: 254). Given such histories, the postcolonial optic needs to read Hosea not simply as a thought experiment, but as rhetorically sharing in the imperial record of sexual violence against women. The prophets apply the imperialist sexual trope to Judah precisely to control its territory in the interests of morality and in the process subject its women to a sexual regime of power for the benefit of preserving its territory.

Having established the gendered moral discourse with regard to Judah, the prophets also apply a similar discourse in relation to the foreign nations. While evidences of the sexually deviant woman appear, particularly in relation to Babylon (Isa 47:1–13; Jer 51:1–5, 6–10, 33; see Nah 3:4–7 for Assyria), the feminized male appears as the more common trope for foreign nations. Soldiers of foreign nations serve as the object of taunts that

view them as effeminate and therefore unable to stand up to the might of the invading army (Jer 48:41; 49:22; 50:24, 37, 43; 51:30, Nah 3:13). Imperializing rhetoric is inherently masculinist in nature, extolling traditional male values such as bravery, adventure, strength, and military prowess. In this rhetoric, these values inhere in the imperial male but remain absent in the conquered male, who by virtue of his defeat proves less masculine and therefore more feminine. Partha Chatterjee states, “the ‘hypermasculinity’ of imperialist ideology made the figure of the weak, irresolute, effeminate babu a special target of contempt and ridicule” (1993: 69).¹⁶ The feminization of foreign males in the prophets centers on childbirth as a trope, used equally for the Judean populations and God (Isa 42:14; 66:7–8; Jer 4:31; 30:6; Mic 4:9–10) as well as foreign ones (Isa 13:8; 21:3; Jer 22:23; 49:24). By making men perform childbearing, the taunt hits at the productivity of the conquered population since the men no longer perform their role as producers of seed. The taunt participates in the imperial logic that distorts gender arrangements through the imposition of foreign values as the means to capture the productive labor of the population. While the prophets appear uninterested in altering the culture of foreign nations to maximize resources, they point to the reduction in population, either through deaths or diminished childbirth, as a means of destabilizing those nations. Desolate territory, more than acquisition of productive lands, forms the critical concern for the prophets, since this fate functions as suitable payback for Judah’s desolation (Jer 48:34; 49:2; 51:26; Ezek 25:3–13; 29:12; Joel 3:19; Zeph 3:6).

Vengeance and Violence

The prophets hold vengeance at a high premium. Vengeance motivates the destruction of foreign nations and opens the space for the restored nation to occupy a leadership role in the world to prevent injustice. As a corrective to wrongs perpetrated by powerful nations, the prophetic vision has much to commend it. In fact, aspects of the future world order challenge imperialist thinking. These, however, are minor voices. Isaiah’s notion of the nation as servant sits amid visions of centralized Zion exercising a compelling influence on the world (Isa 2:2–4; 42:1–4; 49:1–6; 65:17–23). Ezekiel’s restored Jerusalem overcomes several previous limitations but blames these on foreigners (Ezek 44:4–14). Zechariah anticipates a world gathering at Jerusalem but prescribes drought for those who stay away, with specific punishments for Egypt (Zech 14:16–19). The imperfection and incoherence of the visions notwithstanding, the language of vengeance in the prophets raises concern not because it is unwarranted, but rather because it speaks through the voice of power. The callous disregard of human life in the discourse suggests that being right stands at a higher premium than justice. By representing the destruction of enemies as a simple task and the death of innocents as balancing the moral scales, the prophets speak not through voices that experience the anguish of suffering but through eyes blinded by zeal. The prophets are spurred on by the instruments of power to entrench a singular vision. This outlook reflects the tendency of colonial powers to view the colonized as eager to occupy the place of power and to overturn reality. More than

simply the response of the oppressed, revenge fantasies exist in the mind of the oppressor who, as Bhabha points out, fears that a sudden overturn of the power structure will only lead to an exchange of position (1994: 44).¹⁷ Yet this fear of the oppressed seeking vengeance through grotesque and heartless acts of violence represents more the insecurity of the imperial project.

The imperializing discourse of vengeance infuses the prophetic discourse in relation to vengeance with the jaundiced perspective of power. By providing vivid descriptions of vengeance, the prophets enlist national outrage for the excesses perpetrated by other nations. The outrage easily conscripts consent to the rightness of the act of vengeance and excuses the violence, no matter how outrageous. By conscripting consent, the rhetoric of vengeance in the prophets engages in the discourse of empire through what Hardt and Negri notice as the tendency to justify empires not so much on force “but on the basis of the capacity to present force as being in the service of right and peace” (2000: 15). The pursuit of vengeance in relation to other nations has the effect of “worlding” the nation, to use Spivak’s popularization of a Heideggerian term (1999: 114, 115 n. 4). As the nation asserts its presence in the world, this happens not in the mode of anti-colonial nationalism that Lazarus describes as “seldom narrow, sectarian, or chauvinistic” but in a mode that pursues solidarity across nations and cultures (2011: 65). The rhetoric of vengeance in the prophets reflects the ethos of empire that views itself as self-sufficient to the point of the elimination of other nations.

A POSTCOLONIAL PROPHETIC COUNTERDISCOURSE

Ironically, the prophets provide a counterdiscourse to empire. This counterdiscourse can be discovered in the fractures of the texts located in the early stages of the growth of these texts, where voices critique monarchical failures in relation to the defense of the powerless. Establishing a precise historical context for these voices—when they were spoken, against which king, their actual social circumstances—proves elusive because prophetic books were compiled out of textual fragments of archival material. At best, close readings may be able to discern textual layers and note the shifting theopolitical ideologies at the different stages of growth. Such historical revision may prove useful for charting the growing adherence to imperialist ideologies in the formation of the texts and therefore provide the basis for counter-imperial discourses. At the level of the prophetic corpus, the exceptions to the collection offer a counter-imperial discourse that challenges the accepted wisdom of the shape of the corpus. Daniel and Jonah defy the convention of the prophetic book through their unique style, and each one has been marginal to the collection, in its own way. Daniel’s focus on the imperial center and Jonah’s presentation as a

character from the margins provide the opportunity to examine decentralization in the way Trinh Minh-Ha speaks in relation to women. Trinh offers that “being made aware of the margins within the center and the centers within the margins” aptly describes the plight of the native women who experience marginalization from powers at both the margins and the center (1991: 18). In different ways, these two books present opportunities to analyze the prophets at the intersections of power. Daniel functions more as a critique of imperial power from the ambivalence of statelessness. Jonah, on the other hand, walks in the space of anti-imperialist critique, employing the categories that form the center of prophetic power.

Jonah as Postcolonial Prophetic Critique

As exceptions to the corpus, Daniel and Jonah stand as an insurgent presence to destabilize prophetic normativity. As characters perceived as being prophets (see Matt 11:39 and 24:15), Daniel and Jonah fit uneasily with what may be determined as the social role of the prophet. The books interrogate the content and focus of the prophetic message, providing avenues to expose the imperial cooptation of the prophets. The example of Jonah suffices to prove the point. Jonah refuses to answer the direct question posed to him about his occupation. Unlike Amos, who disavows being a נביא (prophet) or even a חזה (seer), as Amaziah calls him (Amos 7:12–15), Jonah willingly self-identifies as a Hebrew but never provides his occupation. This silence stands alongside the slippery designations of prophets in other books. The literary form of Jonah 1:1 and 2:1, in addition to the notice from 2 Kings 14:25, does more to designate Jonah as a prophet than the actual content of the book. Jonah’s impious response to the divine summons stands out in the corpus, but his refusal revolves not so much around the message itself as the recipients of the message, creating what Terry Eagleton regards as a “surrealist farce” (2001: 178).¹⁸ The farcical nature of the book of Jonah exposes the fallacy of prophetic anti-imperial declarations. Prophetic judgment against an empire does not lead to the collapse of empire as a mode of rule, and empires can forestall their demise through cosmetic changes. Jonah protests that he anticipated the saving of Assyria as the outcome of his efforts (Jon 4:1–2). He declares that prior to his departure he made this known as the center of his objections to the mission. The refusal to self-identify as a prophet points to Jonah’s critique of the emptiness of the prophetic task to speak against power since empires can merely repent, rather than evolve into more egalitarian social arrangements.

The fantastical nature of the book of Jonah notwithstanding, the book offers a unique look at imperial critique. While hiding details as to what constitutes the Assyrian “wickedness,” the book reveals the grandeur and size of Nineveh and subtly hints at this being an imperial city built upon the resources of empire. Jonah delivers an oracle against Nineveh in the heart of the city. The immediate response of the people and their king fuels questions about the intent of the oracles against the nations in other prophetic books and whether they were intended for the target audience.

Taking those speculations an additional step, the book of Jonah raises the question of whether prophetic proclamation envisages imperial repentance. Paying attention to Jonah's stated objections would suggest an uneasy collusion between prophets and empire that does not result in the fundamental changes needed to address the inequities posed by empire.

The co-optation of the prophetic voice occurs in the Assyrian king's words. He functions more as a prophet than does Jonah. Like Joel, the king orders a widespread fast to avert the crisis (Joel 1:4; 2:12, 15; cf. Jon 3:7). The king's order to put on sackcloth in the midst of disaster resembles similar orders given by other prophets (Isa 32:11; Jer 4:8; 6:26; 49:4; Ezek 7:18; Joel 1:8, 13; Amos 8:10; cf. Jon 3:8a). And his calculus on the possibility of individual transformation forestalling divine action resembles the consideration Jeremiah makes in the production of the prophetic scroll (Jer 36:7; cf. Jon 3:8b–9). The elision of the prophetic voice with that of an imperial king points to the coziness between prophets and empire such that prophets serve not as a challenge to the structures of empire, but merely as the moral corrective to individualized misbehaviors to prevent divine judgment. The threat to the city, as initially given to Jonah, concerns not the city's wickedness but that of its residents (רעהם, Jon 1:2). The king envisages personal transformation rather than fundamental change in imperial policy (Jon 3:8). Jonah objects to participating in the pacification of empire if the prophetic message to empire provides the means to secure the territorial integrity of the empire against divine wrath. The imperialist claim on indigenous territory often relies on the characterization of indigenes as immoral and thus unworthy of possessing their land. Exposing the imperialist logic of "morality equals territory" present in the prophets, Jonah also reveals the gaping hole in the generalizing statements of prophetic judgment that focus more on individual than systemic injustices.

The peculiar ending of the book of Jonah provides a further opportunity to interrogate prophetic support of empire. The question posed to Jonah offers a Hobson's choice between care for the bush and the lives of the residents of Nineveh. In this question, the interests of empire are posed through the lives of its residents, remembering that Nineveh is an imperial city, thus raising their lives to a value superior to that of the bush. The question asks the prophet to take sides by pitting the small bush against the residents of the empire. This choice between the interests of vegetation versus those of large population centers reads as the imperial discourse that places modernity and its industrializing quests as a superior value to traditional communities and their concerns about the environment. The choice also poses the stark difference between the ephemerality of the bush and the enduring nature of the imperial city, thereby asking the prophet to relinquish solidarity with the vulnerable in preference for the powerful. Jonah's answer to the question remains immaterial to the purposes of the book. In this case, the question, more than the answer, serves to illustrate the critique presented by the book. Prophets have been so compromised by empire that they easily abdicate advocacy for the vulnerable, whether they be insignificant economically or politically, like the poor, or voiceless, like the environment.

CONCLUSION

As a contextualized form of reading, the postcolonial optic foregrounds imperial power at various levels of texts and their production. This reading position limits the conception of the biblical texts through their modes of production as tools of resistance. Certainly the postcolonial optic does not exclude resistant readings as an option, but instead queries whether tools of oppression like texts produced by elite writers and privileging elite culture can function successfully as modes of resistance. The imperial and imperializing dimensions of the Bible and prophetic texts in particular call attention to the presence of empire in the production and reception of the texts. Such attention is required lest the contemporary mutations of power mask themselves in ways that redirect the oppositional tasks required in an age not completely devoid of imperializing tendencies. The postcolonial optic shows not only the pervasive power of imperializing thought, but also its limits. Counter-discourses already pave the way for resistant reading strategies, but these first require exposing the dominant discourse, the task that postcolonial readings perform.

NOTES

1. Fernando Segovia popularized this term for biblical studies. By it he means “a field of vision forged in the wake of imperialism and colonialism but still very much conscious of their continuing, even if transformed, power” (1998: 51 n. 3).
2. See Neil Lazarus’s assessment of imperialism in the modern period in *The Postcolonial Unconscious* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press), 1–20, and the alert summary of “liberal imperialism” by Priyamvada Gopal, “Renegade Prophets and Native Acolytes: Liberalism and Imperialism Today,” in Huggan 2013: 197–216.
3. Edward Said, Gayatri Spivak, and Homi Bhabha have been regarded as seminal in the academic phase of postcolonial studies. Bhabha’s work provides pivotal concepts such as hybridity and ambivalence, courting the criticism that it reflects metropolitan interests. See in particular Aijaz Ahmed’s trenchant critique of Homi Bhabha, *In Theory: Classes, Nations, Literatures* (Radical Thinkers, Book 25; London: Verso, 2000), 68.
4. On the implications of the overdependence upon poststructuralist methods and the loss of Marxist analysis in postcolonial studies, see Graham Huggan, *The Postcolonial Exotic: Marketing the Margins* (London: Routledge, 2001), 3–5; Crystal Bartolovich, “Introduction: Marxism, Modernity, and Postcolonial Studies,” in *Marxism, Modernity and Postcolonial Studies*, ed. Crystal Bartolovich and Neil Lazarus (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002), 1–19.
5. For a discussion of the hyphen in the term as well as conceptual field of “postcolonial,” see Quayson 2000: 76; McClintock 1993: 293; Ashcroft, Griffiths, and Tiffin 2007: 124, 181.
6. The presumption that the prophets come to their final form during the early Persian period informs the contention of a new imperial era influencing the vision present in the prophets. See Ben Zvi 2009: 83 for a discussion of the conditions in the Persian period that gave rise to the notion “prophetic book.”

7. Althea Spencer-Miller critiques Ong's hierarchy of textuality over orality and offers anticolonial affirmation of the complexities of orality in comparison to written texts. See Spencer-Miller 2013: 29–46, 61–64.
8. A fuller description of the formation of prophetic books from textual fragments in a central archive can be found in Edelman 2009: 29–54.
9. Although a common theological notion that focuses almost exclusively on divine beneficence, transcendence structures multiple relations of power that may take violent forms. For a postcolonial engagement with transcendence as wholly Other, see Rivera 2007.
10. The books that lack historical superscriptions explicitly reference historical details in some form. Joel's indication of a devastating locust swarm may point to a particular event (Joel 1:4). Obadiah's animus toward Edom may well be timeless but also may be generated from a specific set of events (Obad 12–14). Jonah's and Nahum's dealings with the Assyrian Empire provide a fictive historical context within which they should be read. Habakkuk's pointing to the rise of the Babylonian Empire as an instrument of punishment sets it on par with evaluations in other prophetic books (Hab 1:6). While Malachi's presumed relationship with Deutero-Zechariah may account for the absence of explicit date references, through this relationship Malachi achieves a historical setting in the post-exilic period.
11. Only the Major Prophets offer an attempt at character development, with Jeremiah providing the fullest depiction of the prophet. Based on its size, the book of Jonah compares favorably with the Major Prophets in terms of sketching out the character of the prophet.
12. The oracles against the nations are here considered as Amos 1–2, Isaiah 13–23, Jeremiah 46–51, Ezekiel 25–32, Joel 3:1–21, Nahum, Obadiah, Zephaniah 2:4–15, and Zechariah 9:1–8.
13. Apart from the indictments in the Amos oracles and those of Ezekiel 25, hubris emerges as the only clearly identifiable charge against nations (Isa 16:6; Jer 48:29; Ezek 28:17; Zeph 2:10; Zech 9:6).
14. Robert Williams articulates the link between morality as the pretext for land displacement. He underlines several imperial actions as far back as Pope Innocent IV in the thirteenth-century authorization of military action in Jerusalem on the grounds that the Holy Land was occupied by moral and religious infidels (1990: 14).
15. Sacvan Bercovitch, *The American Jeremiad* (anniv. ed.; Studies in American Thought and Culture; Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 2012; orig. pub. 1978), 7–9.
16. In India, *babu* is an affectionate term meaning “little boy.”
17. See also Fanon's reflection on the difficult decision of Algerian anti-colonialists to engage in violence (1965: 55).
18. Eagleton deconstructs the figure of God in the book of Jonah by showing that divine mercy renders the prophetic task meaningless.

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CHAPTER 30

QUEER READINGS OF THE PROPHETS

JENNIFER J. WILLIAMS

QUEER theory, which exposes cultural power structures, reveals cultural productions, and destabilizes gender norms, sits at the center of queer readings of the Bible. Queer theory is indebted to postmodern thinking and a celebration of the fragmentation, incoherence, and provisionality of human subjectivity and history. Queer readings of the prophets reveal the ambiguity and complexity in the prophetic texts, namely through uncovering fissures and weaknesses in sex/gender systems and binaries that operate as being self-evident. In this way, a queer reading of the prophetic material opens opportunities to reclaim sexuality and embodiment in ways that previous scholarship had not considered possible.

QUEER THEORY

Queer theory owes much to feminism and grew out of lesbian and gay studies during the 1990s. However, queer theorists expand beyond issues of sex and gender and resist simplistic understandings of gay and lesbian identity by considering how complex differences in class, ethnic culture, social generations, geography, and sociopolitical orientation influence social location, self-identification, and sexual identity (see Stone 2001: 20–21).

Queer theory “is a critical theory concerned principally with cultural deployments of power through social constructions of sexuality and gender” (Schneider 2000: 206). Queer theory’s interest in the destabilizing of power structures and binaries owes much to Michel Foucault. Foucault critiques power and identity as cultural productions and points to a reciprocal relationship between the dominant and the subjugated wherein subjugation of some makes the dominant possible (see Schneider 2000: 209–211). In this vein, Foucault identifies a simultaneous cultural repression of and obsession with sex,

and categorizes homosexuality as a cultural, namely heterosexual, invention that comes from a religious and psychiatric interest in defining subjects based on their sexuality (see Foucault 1978: 23).

Judith Butler's contributions to queer theory add to Foucauldian thought with an investigation of gender as a performance of cultural norms, rather than a predetermined biological certainty. Butler notes how binary notions of sex and gender inevitably and inadvertently regulate, privilege, and make natural heterosexual normativity (Butler 1999: 177–179; and see Stone 2001: 25). For Butler, gender norms are inefficient, never quite reaching that to which they aspire, and the compulsory performance or reiteration of the norms creates failures in gender expectations or “heterosexual regimes” (Butler 1993: 26; 1999: 179). These failures of gender expectations offer subversive potential for the destabilization and transformation of sex and gender norms (Butler 1993: 26). With these theoretical underpinnings, queer theory focuses on the instability of categories, namely in relation to sexual identities and the constructions of gender in society and culture, and challenges the binary constructions of heterosexual and homosexual.

The term “queer,” although it bears the weight of its historical associations with gay males, now incorporates the variety of sexual minorities and gender expressions. It questions normative, “natural,” and taken-for-granted cultural associations concerning sexuality, sexual identity, and gender identity. Queer can also refer to anything outside the norm and that which subverts or perverts what is typically considered normal or natural (see Stone 2001: 28, 18). “Queer” can be used as a verb meaning “to spoil or to interfere” (Goss 2009: 140; Macwilliam 2011: 46). Queering is a process, as much as a set of propositions about the limitations of gender and sexual privilege, and it means continual interrogation of *any* norms.

QUEER READING IN BIBLICAL STUDIES

One conception of queer readings of biblical texts assumes that this approach is identity-based and is espoused by those who make up LGBTQQIAA¹ communities. Often these kinds of readings are about problems related to exclusion and justice as readers analyze the relationship between non-dominant sexual identities and their religious texts, theologies, traditions, politics, and ethics (see Schneider 2000: 208; Stone 2001: 17). Contrary to this essentialist assumption, queer theory defies positivist claims and thereby asks, as Macwilliam does, “Who cares?” in regard to the identity of the one completing a queer reading (Macwilliam 2011: 201). Straight interpreters can also use queer reading strategies.²

Queer readings of biblical texts illuminate the instability and incoherence of the text, focus on the reader's response and experience, oppose attempts at the subjugation of others, consider sexually loaded situations, places, and characters, and critique essentialism, androcentrism, and heterosexism (see Sprinkle 2009: 70–72.). These trajectories focus on the text and are often less concerned with the socio-historical situation of the biblical writers or

their intended audiences. However, queer readings often examine the cultural particularity of identities and practices related to constructions of heterosexuality, homosexuality, and sexuality of all varieties. They explore how “homosexuality” and “sexuality” in the ancient world were construed in very different ways than late twentieth-century constructions of homosexual identity and sexuality.³ Using poststructuralism and deconstruction, queer reading aims “to demonstrate that there were elements embedded in the text that subverted the writers’ gender assumptions” (Macwilliam 2011: 157). Queer readings also fit into reader-response criticism and constitute a more playful, experimental, and constructive approach (Macwilliam 2011: 158). Thus, queer readings include strategies that transgress or point out transgressions of seemingly prescribed boundaries within texts.

Queer readers consider texts through cultural practices such as “camp,” drag performance as parody, and cruising (Butler 1999; Koch 2001; Macwilliam 2011; Runions 1998). They may analyze contemporary films (Runions 1998) and employ a multitude of theoretical perspectives. Queer readers often employ a mode of writing that challenges fixed notions of academic writing.

Queer readings may utilize word plays, sexual innuendos, overt sexual language, euphemisms, expletives, intentional provocation, and “vulgar” language. This sexual frankness might be off-putting to some readers, which is partly the point. The queering process includes stepping outside discursive norms through the use of shocking language, continuing the practice of resistance to the dominant culture (Sprinkle 2009: 65–72). In fact, there is evidence of similar practices in biblical texts. It is very likely that Ezekiel’s use of florid and vulgar language in shocking ways was intended to disrupt his audience’s complacency (see Ezek 16 and 23:11–21; Macwilliam 2011: 184–191; Tarlin 1997). Similarly, queer writers’ use of candid language for sex and bodies may have similar goals of not only disturbing an audience but also reclaiming the power of living in queer(ed) bodies. Flaunting immodesty and shamelessness, Roland Boer revels in critics’ objections that his writing is “self-serving and icky . . . anticipated with fear and trembling” and that he is “a purveyor of pornography” and an “agent of provocation.”⁴ Marcella Althaus-Reid explains the impetus for intentional provocation in queer writing: “The problem we are facing here is that, after all, we still cannot influence imperial theologies, which are based on a kind of inter-temporal interpellative nature, unless we speak clearly, and indecently, queeringly clear” (Althaus-Reid 2000: 95).

FEMINISM, GENDER CRITICISM, AND QUEER READINGS

In many ways, queer theory and queer readings of the Bible are bound to feminist thought and feminism’s relationship to normative structures (see Sprinkle 2009: 72–74). Both feminism and queer theory focus on the critical analysis of sex and gender. Where feminism points out that sexism is built on structures that feminize evil and

require the subjugation of the female so that the masculine remains valorized and good, queer theory notes how sexuality is a social construction wherein heterosexuality has been deemed normative and homosexuality functions to retain heterosexuality's norm-defining status (Foucault 1978; Rubin 1999: 149; Schneider 2000: 211).

Even though both consider power relations and social constructions of sex and gender, theoretical differences and ideologies create room for conflict between feminist and queer theorists. In undermining identity categories, queer theory undermines resistance to male and heterosexual oppression; this criticism is often coupled with the accusation that it is a gay male erasure of feminist and lesbian concerns (Macwilliam 2001: 51; see Guest 2012: 7). In this way, queer theorists might be criticized for not adequately accounting for enduring differences between men and women in regard to experience and access to resources. Queer theorists respond that feminist readings can perpetuate binary oppositions. For example, focusing on gendered metaphors or distinct feminine imagery actually imposes order on unruly texts (Macwilliam 2002: 392), and this underplays "the untidiness of the text" that a queer reading demonstrates (Macwilliam 2002: 393). Furthermore, some might argue that feminism's heterosexual assumptions and feminist-defined sex/gender distinctions have gone unaddressed and unquestioned, rendering feminism "misleading and often irrelevant" when discussing the realm of sexuality (Guest 2012: 44, 49, 59).

Feminists criticize ways in which queer readings can reinstate misogynistic tendencies of the text when those readings take a positivistic approach. Gay men might simultaneously resist and desire the oppressor, participating in the advantages of male oppression and remaining complicit with it (Macwilliam 2011: 51). For example, Macwilliam's use of camp in reading Ezekiel 23:11–21 points to the outrageous and shocking nature of a text's offensiveness as it employs "proverbial models of penile superabundance" in the descriptions of penises "like those of donkeys and . . . emission . . . like that of stallions" in 23:20 (Macwilliam 2011: 184–186). Macwilliam's queer reading enjoys such titillating features of the text, does not condemn the text, and revels in the shocking details of the metaphor (2011: 191). But the reification of the phallus, even from a newly configured queer perspective, may threaten to reinscribe the cultural phallocentrism that continues to erase or problematize female bodies.

In response to these conflicts and theoretical inadequacies, new nomenclature and postures, such as gender criticism/studies, genderqueer criticism, and masculinity studies, continue to emerge to broaden the lens (Guest 2012: 25; Sawyer 2007).⁵ The movement toward gender criticism is an attempt to address the constructions of sexed categories, exposing gender bending, reversals, and transformations, and the myriad ways of doing sex and gender (Guest 2012: 19–20). Queer and feminist readers and theorists alike have responded to critiques and are beginning to note where various theories fail to account for all kinds of sexual difference (see Schneider 2000: 210–211). Thus, scholars engaging in theories that consider gender and sex require rigorous self-reflection (Macwilliam 2011: 51–54). Male queer theorists must actively interrogate male privilege, in general, as well as acknowledge their positions as male readers and continually engage in self-critique of their own presuppositions. Feminist biblical

scholars must confront heteronormativity. More and more frequently, these scholars are called to adopt strategies that move beyond antagonisms and into alliances while focusing on interconnections between the various theoretical positions (see Guest 2012: 63–76).

EXPOSURE AND THE POSSIBILITY OF EMBODIMENT

This chapter demonstrates gender fluidity in the prophetic literature's language and metaphors as well as the "queer" images of destruction and restoration. The chapter then moves into a queer straight woman's reading that takes a positive and constructive approach to female sexual imagery and embodiment in the prophetic texts by considering the euphemism of the threshing floor and imagery of the land as moist.

QUEERING THE PROPHETIC TEXTS

Gender Instability and Fluidity in Prophetic Texts

Prophetic texts repeatedly utilize a marriage metaphor wherein Israel is portrayed as a promiscuous daughter/wife and the LORD becomes the wronged father/husband (see Isa 54:1–8; Hosea 1–3; Jer 3:14; 31:22).⁶ Passivity and femininity most often are associated with Israel and her cities, while YHWH and the ruling classes (i.e., the leaders, priests, and prophets) are active, are portrayed as male, and have masculine attributes (Runions 1998: 232–233; see O'Brien 2008: 31–39). The female images are often depicted as experiencing devastating violence and are blamed for their own destruction.⁷ While feminists aptly critique the consequences of the marriage metaphor and the sexualized gendered language, they fail to point out the evidence of instability of the texts' gender dynamics (cf. Bauer 1999: 55). Macwilliam claims that focusing on the "root metaphor" of marriage or distinct feminine imagery has an inherently dichotomizing effect (Macwilliam 2002: 392). Instead, a queer reading reveals the metaphor's distorting effects and blurs the elements of the tenor (e.g., male citizenry/faithfulness/apostasy) and the vehicle (e.g., wife/loyalty/adultery); "the marriage metaphor requires men to think of themselves and their relationship to the divine in a way that wholly undermines their cultural expectations" (Macwilliam 2011: 96).

Tarlin's reading of the character of Ezekiel provides a helpful example of how the prophetic text defies the masculine/feminine binary. The confluence of erotic desires with violence, the shattering and feminizing of male subjectivity, and the homoerotic relationship Ezekiel has with YHWH enables the character's new subjectivity (Tarlin

1997:180–183). Ezekiel lives in solidarity with others as he experiences the violence that males usually inflict on females, but he exists as a symbolically castrated masculine body, simultaneously possessing a penis and renouncing it (Tarlin 1997: 182).

Many fluctuations occur in gendered language and address in prophetic texts. For example, repeated shifts in masculine and feminine, singular and plural address occur in the early chapters of Jeremiah (see Macwilliam 2011: 85–90). Jeremiah 2:2 refers to Jerusalem in the second-person feminine (2fs) person, but in 2:3, there is no addressee, and yet Israel is referenced in the third-person masculine (3ms). Macwilliam raises the issue of the ambiguity in addresses and wonders if Jerusalem is still the addressee, or if Jerusalem and Israel refer to the same group. “House of Jacob” and “House of Israel” are addressed in the masculine plural in 2:4–6, and masculine images continue until verse 16, when an unidentified 2fs suffix emerges (Macwilliam 2011: 85). Jeremiah 3:6–11 refers to Israel as female, but then speaks directly to the male audience with the masculine singular imperative “Return!” and a second-person masculine plural (2mpl) suffix in 3:12. Besiegers surround Jerusalem and the cities of Judah because “she was disobedient to me” (4:17). Shortly thereafter, indictments are directed at a 3mpl “them” (4:22). A similar ambiguity arising out of the transgression of gender codes through the shifting gender of verbs occurs in Micah (see Runions 1998: 228).

Alongside fluctuations in gendered language and imagery, queer readers might recognize expressions of transgender experiences in the prophetic texts. The LORD’s people bear pain and go forth much as a woman bears a child. Micah 4:9–10 contains this childbirth imagery when Daughter Zion writhes in pain and leaves for Babylon. This birth imagery is common, but prophetic texts allude to biological ambiguity as males experience the pain of childbirth. The imperatives in Jeremiah 30:6 pose a rhetorical question that one must certainly answer in the negative, “Ask and see whether a male can bear a child.” However, the observed reality defies biological expectations, “Why then do I see every man, his hands on his loins like a woman bearing a child, and all of their faces are turning pale?” In order to demonstrate that the world is chaotic with desolation, the prophetic texts give evidence of seemingly impossible events. Isaiah 26:17–18a describes a collective group of men without a successful birthing experience, “Like a pregnant woman drawing near to giving birth, she writhes and cries out in her pain; thus were we in your presence, LORD. We conceived, we writhed when we bore wind.”

Prophetic texts describe men as ontologically female in ways other than experiencing childbirth. In an oracle of restoration and victory, triumphant and powerful Israel feeds off the defeated nations and kings: “You shall suck the milk of the nations, and you shall suck the breasts of kings” (Isa 60:16). Two elements of this image require comment. First, the image of power presents the victor as a suckling infant. Second, the defeated male kings are depicted as lactating women. In an unflattering evaluation of women, male troops become women in Nahum 3:13, “Look at your troops! They are women in your midst.”

The LORD displays gender-bending tendencies. Koch comments on the “manifold and unlimited images of divinity” in Isaiah (see Isa 44:24–28; Koch 2006: 376). “God is redeemer, mother, craftsman, artist, trickster, genius, employer, divine, city planner,

climate-controller, international politico and architect. . . . The supply of imagery for God is virtually inexhaustible, elastic and diverse" (Koch 2006: 380). God is not solely "Father" (or husband). And the LORD displays various maternal aspects, such as a mother bearing children (Isa 42:14; 46:3–4) and a woman with a "trembling womb" (Jer 31:20).⁸ The LORD is like a nursing mother (Isa 49:15), and professes to be a comforting mother (Isa 66:13). YHWH possesses feminine qualities and seems gentle and motherly in Hosea 11:3–4 (Macwilliam 2011: 99). YHWH weeps, laments, and cries out for the fate of the people and cities in Jeremiah 8:19–9:3; God is a healer and restores health in Jeremiah 30:17 and 33:6.

While masculine subjects might assume biologically female experiences or even gendered roles that females typically inhabit, women also assume masculine roles in prophetic texts. Jeremiah 31:22 describes a new alternative reality, "How long will you turn here and there, O apostate daughter? For the LORD has created newness on the earth: a female encompasses a man." The TNK emphasizes the shifting of gender roles with, "A woman courts a man." Similarly, typical authoritative structures become reversed when "[c]hildren oppress my people, and women rule over them" (Isa 3:12).

Erin Runions locates gender bending in Micah as metaphorical bodies in this prophetic text dress in drag. Even though they are violently punished, Runions argues that these gender benders are hybrid presentations of gender that "destabilize the reader, highlighting, shaking and perhaps loosening commitments to oppressive gender codes and the bodily ways in which these are manifested" (Runions 1998: 226). This "gender fuck" is a "mixing of masculine and feminine gender codes in ways that subvert the present bipolar gender system" (Runions 1998: 225).⁹ Runions considers passages containing abrupt shifts in the gender of the verbs and pronouns, which occur with no obvious change in subject (1998: 228).¹⁰ Also, Samaria in Micah 1:6–7 is stripped and made desolate for her assertion of male power and commerce that resembles pimping; Amazon Zion in 4:8–14 receives a male body with iron horns and pulverizing hooves; Madame Jacob in 2:12 is likened to the feminine remnant of Israel, a passive flock, gentle dew, and evasive rain (Runions 1998: 229–231). Using Homi Bhabha's concept, Runions argues that Micah produces hybridity through these figures (1998: 236). In a postcolonial framework, colonizers require mimicry and need both to disavow difference and to produce difference in order for there to be a power differential between the colonizers and the colonized (Runions 1998: 235). The demand for conformity and repetition of norms, coupled with the reality that the norms are iterated differently, leads to hybridity emerging as the excess (Runions 1998: 236). A similar phenomenon occurs in Micah as the hybrid images question the naturalness and originality of norms by showing how gender norms can be repeated differently: females take on male roles, YHWH can make a female more powerful than a man, male figures seem passive and divinely protected (Runions 1998: 240).

Even the image of the prophets themselves, in their composition of the prophetic texts, reveals embedded and prescribed gender roles. Roland Boer argues for "the scribal pen(is) on his testicles" for the phrase קסח הספר ויבמתו in Ezekiel 9:3 (Boer 2010: 96). This translation, along with his claim of other instances of sexual, masturbatory, and phallic

language and imagery in the prophetic texts, shapes Boer's argument for the particular prophetic production of masculinity (i.e., "organizing the sausage-fest") and that power, writing, and masculinity are inextricably tied to one another in the prophetic material (2010: 97). The male prophets, obsessed with their perceived power, elite scribal class, and their own phalluses, invariably implement their power and metaphorically "get themselves off" by exercising their power in the production of prophetic materials.

However, to queer the situation even more, the power-hungry, masculinized prophets themselves display gender-bending tendencies. Both Jeremiah and Isaiah experience labor pains (Jer 4:19; Isa 21:3). In a transgender move, the LORD calls Jeremiah "daughter of my people" and urges him to assume a female mourning position (6:26; see Bauer-Levesque 2006: 388). Isaiah expresses his own gender-bending identity as he identifies himself as both a bridegroom and a bride, and even praises the LORD for making him a cross-dresser in Isaiah 61:10. Finally, the LORD's shocking command to Hosea to marry a prostitute creates what Macwilliam calls an "unmanning" of Hosea: his manliness is subverted and his virility negated by a woman whose potential progeny "cannot be unquestionably his" (Macwilliam 2011: 113).

One might even interpret YHWH as participating in not only gender-bending but also homoerotic behavior with the male prophets. According to Macwilliam, Jeremiah in 20:7 is not a prophet assuming a female persona and experiencing rape, but instead male Jeremiah imagines himself in an enticing and powerful sexual relationship with male YHWH (Macwilliam 2011: 38; cf. Bauer 1999: 113). Rather than reading this as a scene of violence, Macwilliam reads more ambiguity in the event and suggests that it could be an instance of sex with one who is a "demanding and ineluctable seducer" (2011: 38; see Guest 2012: 111).

Male bodies are feminized in these texts when men (or YHWH) bear children, lactate, become like women, or lose elements of their masculinity. Female bodies are masculinized by ascribing to them physical power and iron horns. Such gender-bending images rupture the prevailing androcentrism in the prophetic texts. The gender fluidity, marked by shifts in masculine and feminine imagery and address, complicates other formerly assumed binary conceptualizations (e.g., Israel and Jerusalem/God and male/female). Men are not so manly anymore. And this gender-bending practice must be taken seriously if readers continue to use the biblical text to inform constructions of community and theology, as well as erroneously to reinforce essentialist claims of gender roles and constructions. Categories like sex and gender that are literarily fluid in this respected and influential text become potentially fluid in other ways as well, for example in terms of how we understand the history from which the texts derive, or how we understand the ways in which the texts speak to us today.

Restoration in the Prophetic Texts

The prophetic texts depict restoration as a breakdown of previous and expected boundaries. Geographic formations experience reversals in the familiar restoration vision of

Isaiah 40:4: “Every valley will be lifted up, and every mountain and hill will be low; and the hilly ground will be a level place, and the rough places a plain.” Even the recurrent prophetic metaphor of a woman in labor experiences a remarkable change. The eschatological vision of Jerusalem in Isaiah declares woman/city giving birth without labor and pain: “Before she writhed, she bore. Before her pain came to her, she delivered a male” (66:7). These destabilized structures and reversals commence the revelation of the LORD’s work and glory. The new vision of reality implies new, previously unknown, and even unimaginable ways of being. This is a queer reality.

At the same time, there are ways in which the prophetic texts sometimes re-establish previous structures. When restoration either comes or is envisioned, it does not necessarily imply good news for everyone. In this sense, restoration constitutes putting things right again. This implies reinstating old boundaries and systems. Jeremiah 4:4 describes hope in terms of the “circumcision” of the heart, and thus in male images (O’Connor 1998: 181). Zechariah 8:3–6 illustrates this kind of peaceful restoration, in which everyone returns to their normal operations as the elderly sit in the plazas in Jerusalem and children play in the streets. As O’Brien writes, “The prophets cannot be seen as wholeheartedly countercultural nor as wholeheartedly committed to challenging *all* ideologies that make humans into gods” (O’Brien 2008: 38, emphasis in original). Restoration in prophetic texts is neither wholly egalitarian nor a complete overturning of expectations.

Micah contains the simultaneous breaking down and re-establishing of structures and presents restoration in hybrid and utopian ways (Runions 1999). The idyllic images become undermined in Micah 4:1–8, where utopic elements are put into question, then reinforced, and then destabilized once again so that images of oppression remain (Runions 1999: 286–288, 291). Runions raises questions about the relationship the LORD has with the nations, as the divine appears as a shepherd king who gathers (and controls?) his passive flock. Nations look like docile guests on the mount of YHWH, and images of the Promised Land imply conquest and violence along with them (Runions 1999: 289–291). Thus, the repetition of utopian themes gives way to their distortion; contradictions emerge and the restoration vision is no longer idyllic (Runions 1999: 295). A queer reading, therefore, constitutes one way to raise questions about the prophetic images of restoration, how thorough or contradictory these images are, and the ways in which boundaries and structures are broken or reinstated through the prophetic revisioning of the future.

Summary

A queer reading reveals that the prophetic texts depart from gender and sex expectations as these texts draw attention to the speciousness of fixed binary oppositions. Queer readings expose the ambiguities and tensions within gender codes in the biblical texts, but also within other formal and normative structures in the texts. Queer readings demonstrate the contingency of sex/gender systems, and they work toward the transformation of hegemonic systems.

A GENDERQUEER FEMINIST, OR QUEER STRAIGHT WOMAN'S, READING

Discourse transmits and produces power; it reinforces it, but also undermines and exposes it, renders it fragile and makes it possible to thwart it.

Foucault (1978: 100–101)

This queered straight feminist reading attempts to reclaim female embodiment and sexuality, as female bodies and sexual experiences have been negatively imaged and co-opted by male authors and the mostly male interpreters of the prophetic material (see Guest 2012: 87). By taking female sexual euphemisms and imagery to their fullest potential, this queer reading uncovers positive aspects of female sexuality embedded in the texts. Appreciation of female sexuality does not exist overtly in the texts, nor was it intended by an imagined author. Rather, sexual images serve primarily to link illicit female sex with Israel's apostasy. However, a queer reading that unearths positive valences of the euphemism of the threshing floor and the sexual and metaphorical potential of gardens, vineyards, and land provides a constructive evaluation of female sexual imagery in the prophetic material. The sexual euphemisms turn on themselves, thereby thwarting the original intent of the euphemisms and reclaiming sex (especially female sexual experience) as something worthy of celebration.

The writers of biblical texts often used euphemisms and innuendos to talk about sex. Well-known examples of euphemistic language in reference to sex include “to know” (ידע) in Genesis 4:1, “to lie with” (שכב, usually with עם), “to enter (בוא plus אל), “come near to a woman” (נגש אל-אשה) in Exodus 19:15, and “approach” (קרב plus אל) in Genesis 20:4. “Feet” (רגלים) often alludes to the male member or genitalia in general. Agricultural imagery supplies the vocabulary for euphemisms for female sex organs. Both the specific euphemism of the “threshing floor” as well as garden and land imagery serve as linguistically appropriate placeholders for female sexual parts. This queer reading suggests that water flowing from the land evokes the image of a woman experiencing sexual arousal or reaching sexual climax. Thus, moist land, in continuity with the euphemism for female sex organs, need not only represent fertility but can also indicate female sexual pleasure.

AGRICULTURAL AND SEXUAL IMAGERY IN ANCIENT SOUTHWEST ASIAN TEXTS

Both ancient southwest Asian and rabbinic sources utilize the euphemism of the threshing floor and images of gardens and land to refer to sex and sexual locations.¹¹ Ancient southwest Asian texts frequently celebrate sex, female sexuality, and arousal, and sex acts connote pleasure and prosperity.¹² Thus, sexual desire, agricultural imagery, and

financial prosperity frequently coincide in both literal and figurative ways in these texts.¹³ Gardens and irrigated land also refer to women and women's sexual organs.¹⁴ Similarly, threshing floors frequently denote women's spaces and correspond with images of fertility and abundance of food.¹⁵ And finally, flowing water alludes to sexual experience and female orgasm or sexual arousal.¹⁶

The Niddah Tractate from the Babylonian Talmud mentions the "threshing place" as a euphemism not for a place of sexual activity but for the female sexual apparatus. In order to avoid further impropriety, the Talmud uses one euphemism to define another. "What is meant by threshing place? The place where the attendant [i.e., euphemism for the male member] threshes" (*b. Nid.* 41b). The employment of the euphemisms demonstrates a rabbinic hesitancy to talk about sexual acts.¹⁷

These examples demonstrate a linguistic continuity in ancient southwest Asian, biblical, and rabbinic writing practices. Metaphorical and agricultural imagery, specifically "threshing floors" and gardens, can symbolize women, women's sexual apparatus, and sexual locations in general. The objective behind this usage varies widely. At times, the metaphorical language celebrates female sexual experience; other times, the texts utilize the language to avoid indecorum.

AGRICULTURAL AND SEXUAL IMAGERY IN THE PROPHETS

Plundered Threshing Floors

The threshing-floor euphemism adds the potential for new meaning in passages that employ the literal image of plundered threshing floors. When David is told, "The Philistines are waging war in Keilah, and they are plundering (שסס) the threshing floors" (1 Sam 23:1), "threshing floor" refers to the place for gathering sheaves. Although this is an account of a raid on an actual threshing floor, the terminology provides the possibility that sexual violence may be being evoked. "Plundering," which occurs in both roots שסס and שסס, most often happens to groups of people (Judg 2:14, 16; 1 Sam 14:48; 2 Kgs 17:20; Ps 44:11; Isa 17:14; 42:22, 24; Jer 30:16). In the five instances in the prophetic literature where plunder terminology is used without explicit reference to the destruction of people (Isa 10:13; 13:16; Jer 50:11; Zech 14:2; Hos 13:15), the verses occur in contexts related to violence against women. For example, Zechariah 14:2 lists that the feminine "city will be captured, houses will be plundered, and the women will be raped," and Isaiah 13:16 describes similar events. Thus, although the threshing floor does not function euphemistically in the original text of 1 Samuel 23:1, a subtext of sexual violence is conceivable and ancillary to the raids of a literal threshing floor.

In a similar way, Daughter Babylon is a threshing floor at the time of being trodden in Jeremiah 51:33. Hosea 9:1 provides prostitution imagery in a direct link to Israel's

apostasy and prostituting “against your God” and claims that “you have loved the wages of a prostitute on all threshing floors.” The threshing floor serves as a euphemism for female parts, female subjects, and places of sexual activity, and it can carry both positive and negative connotations. A closer look at three prophetic verses demonstrates how the euphemism works in a variety of ways.

Jeremiah 2:25

It is possible that even the euphemism of the threshing floor for female sexual organs was itself too risqué to use. A textual discrepancy in Jeremiah 2:25a indicates some scribal reluctance to employ the euphemism and allude to female sexual organs: “Withhold (fs imperative) your feet (2fs suffix) from being bare and your threshing floor (*kethib* with 2fs suffix)/your neck/throat (*qere* with 2fs suffix) from being parched.” The *kethib* גורֶתֶךָ (your threshing floor) and *qere* גְּרוֹתְךָ (your throat/neck) indicate an issue of an interchange of the consonants ו and ר. The verse’s overriding sexual imagery, euphemisms at work, and both the term “thirst/parched condition” (צמאָה) and the vocabulary often associated with it, make a strong case for “your threshing floor.” Female sexual imagery pervades the verse, even if the passage denigrates female sexual desire. The passage uses the metaphorical vehicle of a restive camel and a lustful wild ass in comparison to Israel’s apostasy and “going after the Baals” (2:23). The second-person directives and ass imagery create a comparison between Israel and a female animal in heat. While the first half of Jeremiah 2:25 uses sexual euphemisms to indicate sexual desire, the second half of 2:25 emphasizes an insatiable desire for going after foreign gods. The implications for this metaphor reinforces the familiar dichotomous pairs of illicit sexual desire versus proper behavior, apostasy versus proper worship, female versus male, and wild/uncontrollable versus disciplined/in control, such that the former element of the pairs becomes debased.

The use of the euphemisms “feet” and “threshing floor” and the imperative urges people to protect against indecent sexual experiences. Bare “feet” lead men to sexually illicit acts and compromising situations. Dry “threshing floors” seek moisture (and thus sexual stimulation). The blurring of the metaphor’s tenor (sexual activity of the wild ass) and its vehicle (Israel’s apostasy) makes synonymous the avoidance of sexually illicit circumstances with the protection against apostasy. But the female ass in heat is easy to find, uncovered and thirsty for sex, and thus, the underlying accusation is that avoiding apostasy is as difficult for the Israelites as avoiding seeking sex is for a female ass in heat.

“Thirst,” from the root צמא, in Jeremiah 2:25 signifies a parched condition, and never appears with “throat/neck” (גרון). Instead, צמא references the thirsty condition of people, land, or a person’s נפש (Isa 5:13; 21:14; 32:6; 35:7; 44:3; 55:1; Amos 8:11, 13).¹⁸ The single biblical instance of a thirsty throat occurs in Psalms 69:4, but here “thirst” derives from the root חרר. חרר usually describes burned or scorched objects, rather than things that are dry or parched. Thus, it is more likely that צמא describes the condition of a threshing floor than a throat (regardless of whether the “threshing floor” is a literal piece of land used for the gathering of sheaves or the euphemism for a female or her sexual parts).

Isaiah 21:10

Isaiah 21 contains sexual connotations and images of female sexual parts. Isaiah 21:3 describes a woman in labor and the pain in the loins that accompanies giving birth. Idolatrous images lay shattered on the ground of fallen female Babylon in 21:9. Then 21:10 follows with the agonizing cry, “O my threshed one and the sons of my threshing floor.” The employment of the parallel synonyms for threshing in this verse, דוש and גרנה, perpetuates the familiar metaphorical link between religious observance and sexual impropriety. Defeated female images, who are shattered and threshed, enable continuity in this oracle.

Micah 4:12

The last part of Micah 4 is mostly concerned with images of restoration. While many nations line up to defeat the woman Zion and say, “Let her be profaned and let our eyes gaze upon Zion,” the LORD has other plans (4:11). The nations neither know nor understand in Micah 4:12, “for he (the LORD) has gathered them like sheaves to the threshing floor (גרנה).” The following verse continues the threshing floor imagery, “Arise and thresh, Daughter Zion.” Like Isaiah 21:10, this imperative that Daughter Zion should “thresh” uses the verbal form of דוש. Also as in Isaiah 21:10, דוש and גרנה are used in parallel. Utilizing the “threshing floor” as a euphemism, Micah suggests that the nations are not necessarily gathered to a place but could be gathered to Zion herself. Thus, Zion assumes both a passive and active role. She is the threshing floor to which nations are gathered, and she is also the one who threshes. Once again, the euphemism enables both the connection of threshing floor imagery with females and the confusion and blending between a metaphorical vehicle (the sheaves at a threshing floor) and a tenor (the nations at the hands of Daughter Zion).

Summary

All three texts are problematic, as they utilize the threshing-floor euphemism pejoratively for female sexual experience. The texts depict female sexual behavior as illicit and draw attention to sexualized violence against women. In Micah, the overtly phallic imagery that destabilizes gender boundaries, the daughter Zion, with an iron horn, arises (stands erect) and threshes (4:13). She is not profaned. She will not be gazed upon. She will do the threshing, because the LORD has already gathered the other nations as sheaves. The condoning of this kind of sexually charged violence reinforces that sometimes this kind of action is “good.” Or at least it is good when it isn’t happening to “us” (i.e., the Israelites). “We” must be the threshers. The passage reinforces the virtues of male power in the sex act, a rhetorical move potentially abhorrent to feminists and other readers.

However, even if these “threshing” images in Jeremiah, Micah, and Isaiah do little to celebrate female sexual desire and experience, they *do* demonstrate how the threshing floor and threshing vocabulary connects to the sex act and place of sexual activity in general, as well as female sexual organs and experience in particular. The euphemism

and land imagery contain the key for a deconstruction of meaning and a recuperation of female sexuality in the prophetic material.

The Pejorative Use of Gardens and Vineyards as Sexualized Locations in the Prophets

Other Hebrew terms, like garden (גן) and vineyards (כרם), correspond with threshing floor imagery, represent sexual experience and female sexual expression, and can carry sexual (albeit negative) connotations in the prophetic literature. The garden represents unacceptable worship practices as people inappropriately make sacrifices in gardens, or purify and consecrate themselves, and then eat the flesh of swine (see Isa 65:3–5; 66:17; see Edelman 2014: 136–143). Gardens suggest sexuality and fertility, but are also attributed to the goddess Asherah and worship of her, and thus gardens link sexuality and apostasy. Similarly, sexual images pervade references to apostate Israel who “went up on every high hill and under every luxuriant tree, and she played the harlot there” (Jer 3:6; see Hosea 4:12–13; Isa 1:29; Jer 3:13; 2:20). The passage alludes to a cultic ritual practice wherein sexual intercourse was performed under trees in order to appeal to the fertility gods (Ackerman 1992: 152).¹⁹ No longer a connection in metaphorical terms but an explicit correlation, sexual behavior becomes illicit when enacted through the rituals of fertility cults.

Vineyard (and pomegranate orchard) imagery works in similar ways (see Edelman 2014: 124–126). Isaiah 5:1 begins with, “Let me sing for my beloved, a song of my lover regarding his vineyard.”²⁰ The male owner of the vineyard (i.e., the LORD) performs decidedly masculine, active, penetrating, and implicitly sexual activities as he digs about, plants, sows, and builds the vineyard. But the vineyard behaves poorly and produces bad fruit (5:2). The imagery of the uncontrollable vineyard coincides with the illicit sexual imagery used to condemn Israel. Metaphorical dichotomies continue: the male character, the LORD (revealed in 5:7), hopes for faithful worship as an owner of a vineyard hopes for good fruit. But the female character, played by Israel the apostate, is a rebellious vineyard with sour grapes.

The Use of Gardens, Vineyards, Threshing Floors, and Land in Restorative and Sexual Terms

A Titillating Transition: Song of Songs

In the Song of Songs, erotic imagery abounds in the description of the lovers’ kisses (1:2), beauty (4:1), and breasts (4:5), and in the lovers’ quest for each other, and a queer reading further accentuates the book’s erotic and pornographic elements. Song of Songs 4:12–16 describes the woman as a garden, and in a seductive invitation replete with sexual innuendo, she tells her beloved to “come into his garden and eat its choicest fruits.”²¹ In

contrast to the heteronormative, modernist interpretation that the book's subject is a divinely ordered marriage (see Burrus and Moore 2003: 25–34), Roland Boer's positive assessment of the Song of Songs celebrates the book *as* pornographic material; he both subverts and evades heterosexuality, retrieving the eroticism of the ancient text (Burrus and Moore 2003: 34–36).²²

A similar kind of queer reading of the prophetic material might embrace the efforts of the thirsty and impatient camel of Jeremiah 2:25 and delight in the moment in which she finds a bull to satisfy her sexual craving. Or one might imagine Daughter Zion of Micah 4:12 standing tall, with her S/M paraphernalia, ready to do some “threshing” among her eager lovers. And it is possible to focus on the attentive gardener's sensual care of the vineyard—or perhaps his inability to pleasure her in the right way—rather than the fruit that the she-vineyard produces (see Isa 5:1–2).

The prophetic texts' images of threshing floors, gardens, vineyards, and land carry other queer possibilities as well. The prophetic literature often depicts Israel's restoration as a well-watered threshing floor, garden, vineyard, or land, abundant in fruit and grain. Israel's destruction in dry desert, wasteland, insufficiency imagery (Amos 4:9; Hos 9:1–2; 13:3), juxtaposes a fecund Israel replete with abundant and moist gardens, vineyards and lands. Numerous images of Israel's restoration combine threshing floor (גרן), garden (גנה), water (מים), grain (דגן), oil (יצהר), wine (יין), wine vats (יקב), fresh wine (שותיר), vineyard (כרם), and other agricultural vocabulary.²³ Certainly this vocabulary carries connotations of fertility, but it also has potential sexual undertones. Moist land is most desirable.

As Israel builds fortified cities, fruitful gardens and vineyards accompany and make evident Israel's restoration and security (Ezek 28:26). Ezekiel 36:35 depicts devastation's reversal: “This land that was desolate has become like the garden of Eden; and the wasted, desolate, and thrown-down cities are unassailable and inhabited.” The Hebrew terminology and images repeatedly intertwine in these images of restoration. Israel will enjoy the produce of these gardens and vineyards and will eat fruit (Isa 65:21; Jer 29:5; Amos 9:14). Threshing floors are connected to wine in Joel 2:24, “The threshing floors will be full of grain, and the wine vats will overflow with fresh wine and oil.” The fruitful and well-irrigated lands become symbols of the LORD's comfort and restoration for Israel, and the proper response is Zion's joy and correct worship (Isa 51:3).

Taking the Euphemism and Imagery “All the Way” in the Prophets

If these images of the garden, vineyard, threshing floor, and land, in their negative manifestations, can represent illicit or unacceptable female sexual experiences, then it is possible that in their positive and restorative manifestations, these same images can represent positive images of female sexual experience. If the euphemism of the threshing floor and the sexualized imagery of the garden and vineyard are taken to the fullest extent, a restored Israel is like a section of moist land, and thus like a woman's satisfied or aroused sexual organs. In this way, the overriding negative message in prophetic literature that emphasizes a pejorative attitude toward female sexual activity inevitably works against itself and enables a queered and positive reading of female sexual experience.

The enjoyment of gardens and eating fruit is not only about full bellies in a literal sense. The imagery also implies the newfound space for joy and sexual enjoyment when security rather than war is the new reality and rebuilding commences. "Eating fruit" bears much sexualized imagery in positive and satisfying terms. Just as Song of Songs closes with an image of eating fruit (4:16) and Lu-diğira describes his mother as a piece of fruit, so too do eating fruit and enjoying the garden provide positive images of sex in general and female sexual experience in particular. Beauty, flourishing, and prosperity link with virile men and fertile women in restorative images in Zechariah 9:16–17: "For how good they will be and how beautiful they will be! New grain will make the young men flourish and new wine the young women."

Arguably, Israel's restoration through images of fruitful harvests suggests agricultural and economic prosperity as well as fertility and repopulating, but the garden imagery dwells on the experience of sensual pleasures, namely eating and sex. Peace and prosperity enable a situation conducive to various manifestations of Israel's physical enjoyment.

The imagery is most restorative for female sexual experience. Isaiah 58:11 offers, "The LORD will lead you continually, and satisfy your appetite in parched places, and your bones he will invigorate, and you will become like a watered garden, like a spring of water whose waters never fail." Israel, now addressed in the 2ms person, is a well-watered garden. The transgender moves reverberate: Israel, the assumed male audience, is sometimes portrayed as the promiscuous woman, other times addressed as men, and finally becomes restored to a sexually satisfied woman. Wet and fecund Israel's waters never fail. Woman's sexual experience and her potential for becoming moist in the throes of sexual arousal and climax are now portrayed not only in positive terms, but as the very image of Israel's restored state. Similar abundant and sexually charged imagery overflows in Jeremiah 31:12. New life, itself, is a watered garden, or in other words, a joyfully aroused woman.

Desirable restoration occurs through the image of any kind of wetland. At times, images of restoration portray rainwater moistening the land. The LORD acts as divine gardener, cultivating a moist and fertile land by the LORD's bestowing water upon the earth (see Isa 44:3; Jer 51:6; Amos 5:8; 9:6). But the moisture in the land need not always derive from the heavens above. Sometimes the water springs forth from the land herself. Mountains drip sweet wine, hills stream with milk, and the channels of Judah flow with water in Joel 4:18. With allusions to the Exodus narrative, the LORD causes water to enthusiastically surge from the land in Isaiah 48:21, "He caused water to flow from the rock for them; he broke the rock and the water gushed out." The passage supplies a form of זרב or "gush," which is the same term that describes the idyllic fertility of the promised land "flowing/gushing" (זבת) with milk and honey (see Ex 3:8; 33:3; Jer 11:5; 32:22; Ezek 20:6; 20:15). This is also a term used in reference to fluid from the genitals, often a woman's menstruation or a man's discharge (see Leviticus 15).

Gushing water and dripping mountains symbolize only one part of restoration's new, bountiful and destabilizing quality. The almost inconceivable reversals of Isaiah 35:5–7 include blind eyes and deaf ears opening and speechless tongues crying aloud. Waters emerge from the desert and "the parched ground will be like a muddy pool and

the thirsty ground like a spring of water.” Thirsty threshing floors (Jer 2:25) and thirsty grounds will be quenched. In the recuperative end, what was will be turned on its head. The image of restoration is wet and orgasmic!

CONCLUSION

It would be a stretch to consider the restorative image of moist gardens, threshing floors, vineyards, and ground symbolizing a woman reaching sexual arousal or climax as intrinsic to the text’s meaning or intended by an author. But the euphemism of the threshing floor and the agricultural imagery in ancient southwest Asian literature enables a positive reading of female sexual experience that counters the prophetic literature’s tendency to stigmatize female sexuality. And as this reading challenges a variety of prevailing attitudes, this can be categorized as a queer reading in three ways.

First, this reading queers the prophetic texts by creating the possibility of reading something positive about female sexual experience and thereby thwarting prophetic texts that spend much time denigrating female sexuality, emphasizing illicit female sexual behavior, and comparing female sexual experience to Israel’s apostasy. Embedded in the prophetic discourse of illicit female sexual behavior resides the potential for subversion. Specifically, within the threshing floor euphemism and garden and moist land imagery sit the very seeds of recuperation for positive and celebrated images of female sexuality. It is a queer reading because it uses the power of transgressive (readings of) sexuality to invite the text to destabilize its own phallogentric discourse. Euphemisms and metaphors, taken to their fullest extent, can confuse discourse and meaning.

In order to avoid replacing one sexual essentialism (e.g., the prophetic literature’s tendency to denigrate female sexual experience) with another (e.g., any kind of essentialist claim regarding all “female sexuality”), this reading merely points to the incoherence in the prophetic texts and the breakdown of the prophets’ phallogentric metaphorical strategies. This reading ruptures, rather than replaces, the strategies.

Second, this reading queers some feminist interpretations of the prophetic material. Feminists rightly challenge the problematic patriarchal roles and gendered hierarchies promoted in the prophetic literature, but seem to have little to say about female sexuality that is positive or constructive. This queer reading still notes the problematic aspects of the text, especially the derogatory sense that the threshing-floor euphemism carries. But the reading makes the queer move of playing with the texts, letting the texts turn on themselves, and reveling in the sexually evocative elements of the texts (cf. Rubin 1999: 166–167). In an attempt to create alliances rather than antagonism, this reading, which focuses on a particular form of female sexuality, might quell feminist fear that women’s lives and concerns could be lost by way of a queer reading (see Guest 2012: 7). Yet, it pushes feminist interpreters to address erotic elements and embrace titillating imagery in these texts.

Third, this reading is queer because it reclaims elements of sexual experience that have been considered illicit and indecent for far too long. This reading forces the reader to confront erotic elements, namely female eroticism and the sexual experience of arousal and climax, that still reside in the shadows of “proper” theological, academic, ecclesial, and even feminist biblical studies discourse. It is part of this chapter’s impetus to challenge the reader to consider the lack of frank engagement of the multitudes of human sexual expression and female erotic experiences in positive and constructive ways within biblical scholarship specifically and in ecclesial and cultural conversations in general.

This queer reading follows many gay male readers as it reclaims sexual experience, namely the desire for female sexual arousal and orgasm, as something good, if also something subversive. Sexuality is good in itself and potentially good for all. Female sexual desire is desirable; the female subject ought to delight in carnal pleasures and erotic experience. She need not understand her own sexuality by way of the prevailing misogynistic perspective that has previously assessed its relative worth (see Rubin 1999: 150–151).

NOTES

1. LGBTQIAA denotes those who identify as Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer, Questioning, Intersex, Asexual, and/or Ally.
2. As a cisgender straight woman, I am interested in reading queerly because it serves as a way of resisting a variety of social conventions of sexual normality. See Ken Stone 2001: 1–31. Transgression of any norm, not just in regard to sexual identity, matters to me as it is a way of uncovering and destabilizing oppressive structures. I stand as an ally with people who do not fit into culture’s “norms.” I desire to be a partner in the queer endeavor, and much like Macwilliam, to use “the insights of queer theory as a contribution to that general effort to wrest the Bible from the grip of heteronormativity” (Macwilliam 2011: 54). I know that as a heterosexually identified scholar engaging in genderqueer criticism, I enter a queer-informed territory, the boundaries of which I did not define (see Guest 2012: 160). I am encouraged by queer readers and theorists who continue to engage in the discovery (and self-discovery) of heteronormative biases and the liberation of sexuality that have remained buried and burdened far too long by “proper” cultural, ecclesial, and academic discourses and expectations.
3. See Dale B. Martin, “*Arsenokoitês* and *Malakos*: Meanings and Consequences,” in *Biblical Ethics and Homosexuality: Listening to Scripture* (ed. Robert L. Brawley; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1996), 117–136; Dale B. Martin, *Sex and the Single Savior: Gender and Sexuality in Biblical Interpretation* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2006); Stephen D. Moore, *God’s Beauty Parlor: And Other Queer Spaces in and around the Bible* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2001).
4. Roland Boer. “About,” *Stalin’s Moustache*, n.p. [cited June 25, 2014]. <http://stalinsmoustache.org/about/>. See Virginia Burrus and Stephen D. Moore, “Unsafe Sex: Feminism, Pornography, and the Song of Songs,” *BibInt* 11 (2003): 24–52.
5. See Athalya Brenner, review of Deborah W. Rooke, ed., *A Question of Sex? Gender and Difference in the Hebrew Bible and Beyond*, *RBL* [<http://www.bookreviews.org>] (2008).

6. I use "Israel" here and throughout this chapter, but city, cities, Zion, Jerusalem, and Judah are used almost interchangeably, along with Israel, throughout the prophetic texts as the female element of the metaphor.
7. See Kathleen M. O'Connor, "Jeremiah," in *Women's Bible Commentary* (ed. Carol A. Newsom and Sharon H. Ringe; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1998), 178–180. See Guest 2012: 87–105.
8. See Bauer-Levesque 2006: 391, and Phyllis Trible, *God and the Rhetoric of Sexuality* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1978), 45.
9. The term "gender fuck" began appearing in writing in the early 1970s. Deryn Guest comments on the edginess and indecency of this term, especially as it appears "within the respectable (decent) domain of biblical studies"; see Guest, "From Gender Reversal to Genderfuck: Reading Jael through a Lesbian Lens," in *Bible Trouble: Queer Reading at the Boundaries of Biblical Scholarship* (ed. Teresa J. Hornsby and Ken Stone; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2011), 9–43. Guest provides the helpful footnote on page 9, "According to Bergman the term made an early appearance in a 1974 article for Gay Sunshine by Christopher Lonc, entitled 'Genderfuck and Its Delights' and prior to that, it was associated with the Cockettes, a 1970s drag troupe." See also David Bergman, *Camp Grounds: Style and Homosexuality* (Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press, 1993), 7.
10. Runions looks particularly at Micah 1:9, 10–11, 2:10, 2:12, and 6:12–13.
11. A love charm from ancient Mesopotamia describes the garden as the location for sexual activity. See Benjamin R. Foster, "Seated on Her Thighs," in *From Distant Days: Myths, Tales, and Poetry of Ancient Mesopotamia* (Bethesda, MD: CDL Press, 1995), 331. In the "Love Lyrics of Nabu and Tashmetu," lines 31–32 contain "Let me go to the garden" and imply the sex act. Line 38 equates sex with connection to the divine in "Bind your days to the garden and to the Lord" (345). In ancient sources like these, gardens carry the symbolic value of fertility and metaphorical sexuality and are associated with the actions of plowing and sowing; a fertile harvest becomes possible when a garden receives proper care, and this is directly linked to the garden as a place for sexual activity. See Edelman 2014: 115–156.
12. Lu-diġira says that his mother "is a lover, a loving heart who never becomes sated with pleasure" in lines 45–46 of "Lu-diġira's Message to His Mother" (Jeremy A. Black, *The Literature of Ancient Sumer* [Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2004], 191). See also in the same work, "A šir-namursaġa to Inana for Iddin-Dagan" (262–269) and "A Hymn to Inana" (92–99).
13. An incantation in a ritual that seeks to enliven traffic in a brothel/tavern contains, in lines 9–10: "Just as when rain has fecundated the earth, plants become plentiful, so too may there be many a basket of (sprouting) malt for me" ("Ishtar at the Tavern," in Foster, *From Distant Days*, 350).
14. Lu-diġira describes his mother as a well-watered garden within lines 32–39: "She is a garden . . . She is an irrigation ditch . . ." in "Lu-diġira's Message to His Mother" (Black, *Literature of Ancient Sumer*, 191).
15. See Mark S. Smith, *Ugaritic Narrative Poetry* (ed. Simon B. Parker; Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1997). *Kirta* (lines 7–8 of Column III in 1.CAT 1.14; Smith 1997: 16); *Aqhat* (lines 28–31 of Column I, 6.CAT 1.19; Smith 1997: 68; lines 6–7 in CAT 1.20 side 2; lines 25–26 CAT 1.22 side 1).
16. Lines 2–5 contain: "As a river moistened its banks I make myself moist, I make my body moist. I have opened my seven doors for you Erra-bani" ("Look at Me!" in Foster, *From*

- Distant Days*, 334–338. See also “Seated on Her Thighs” in Foster, *From Distant Days*, 331–332).
17. Euphemisms in the Talmud are frequent, having been used whenever it was necessary to avoid unsuitable expressions. “Man should always express himself in fitting terms” (*b. Pesah.* 3a) was a favorite saying of the rabbis. See also *b. Yebam.* 100a, where women and threshing floors are equated in order to make a point about inheritance.
 18. In non-prophetic texts: Psalms 42:3, 63:2, 107:33; Deuteronomy 8:15.
 19. Susan Ackerman, *Under Every Green Tree: Popular Religion in Sixth-Century Judah* (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1992), 152.
 20. A queer reading also raises questions about the gender and sexuality of the speaker. If this is a male speaker (possibly Isaiah himself?), then the text contains homoerotic overtones, as Isaiah claims that the male vineyard owner, the LORD, is his lover.
 21. See Edelman 2014: 124–126, and Ronald A. Veenker, “Forbidden Fruit: Ancient Near Eastern Sexual Metaphors,” *HUCA* 70 (2000): 57–73.
 22. See Roland Boer, “Night Sprinkle(s): Pornography and the Song of Songs,” in Roland Boer, *Knockin’ on Heaven’s Door: The Bible and Popular Culture* (Biblical Limits; New York: Routledge, 1999), 53–70; Roland Boer, “The Second Coming: Repetition and Insatiable Desire in the Song of Songs,” *BibInt* 8 (2000): 276–301.
 23. See Isaiah 36:17; 62:8; 51:3; 58:11; 65:21; Jeremiah 29:5; 31:12; 32:15; Ezekiel 28:13, 26; 31:8–9; Joel 2:19, 24; Amos 9:14; Zechariah 9:17. Other associated and recurring terms also include harvest (קציר), wine press (גת), bread (לחם), fruit (פרי), oil (שמן), and vine (גפן).

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CHAPTER 31

POSTMODERN ENGAGEMENTS OF THE PROPHETS

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POSTMODERNISM is a descriptive term widely applied to a variety of cultural expressions such as art, literature, music, philosophy, and architecture, as well as biblical criticism. Shaped by literary critics and philosophers such as Jacques Derrida, Roland Barthes, Michel Foucault, Luce Irigaray, Julia Kristeva, and Jean-François Lyotard, postmodernism is often viewed as a reaction beginning in the late nineteenth century. Whereas modernists sought comprehensive theories and narratives to describe culture and its ideas, and believed that scientists, philosophers, and critics had access to these ideas apart from their cultural and individual vantage points, postmodernists rejected meta-narratives and totalizing theories in favor of subjective narratives and their consequent multiple perspectives. Modernists believed that universal truths were accessible through science and philosophy. Postmodernists challenged the notion of universal and foundational truths, and posited that all truths are relative to their cultural context and an individual's perception of them.¹

In significant ways, biblical criticism is a product of modernism developed by figures such as Julius Wellhausen, Hermann Gunkel, John Bright, and Gerhard von Rad, who believed that the Bible's textual and contextual history could be revealed by applying scientific methods of inquiry to it. Not only did the tools of biblical critical scholarship provide insight into the worlds that produced and transmitted the Bible; it also granted access into the Bible's religious truths. As John J. Collins observes, historical biblical criticism developed primarily within Protestant Christianity, and many of its scholars "sought to reconcile their findings with traditional faith" (2005: 7). Thus modernist Bible scholars not only worked to understand the truth *about* the Bible, they worked to understand the truth *within* the Bible. They believed that the study of the Bible's physical reality—the historical events and artifacts associated with it—revealed a metaphysical reality.

The general shift in the second half of the twentieth century from a modernist to a postmodernist perspective was manifest within biblical criticism. The postmodernist

rejection of foundational truths, and its embrace of subjectivity and the multiplicity of meanings, challenged the methods, assumptions, and goals of biblical criticism and forced the discourse of biblical critical scholarship to change. Under the weight of the postmodernist critique, Bible scholars could no longer claim objectivity in their methods, nor could they proclaim the truth of their discoveries. For many, this was a personal crisis of faith, for all this was a professional crisis of practice and purpose. Doubting their objective access to the Bible's worlds, and no longer engaged in the pursuit of universal truths, biblical scholars questioned what they knew about the Bible and what they could know about it. As Collins observes, by the end of the twentieth century, though scholars have more information about the ancient world than their predecessors, there was a "progressive shedding of certitude" (2005: 9–10).

In many ways, the increasingly diverse faces of biblical scholars changed the face of biblical scholarship and oriented it toward postmodernism. Women, Blacks, Asians, Jews, and atheists joined the ranks of biblical scholars. They identified the biased ideology of their more established White, male, Christian colleagues, and introduced a multiplicity of perspectives into the field. The multiple perspectives of this generation of scholars shifted the focus of biblical scholarship away from the task of understanding the Bible's inherent meaning, what A. K. M. Adam calls "subsistent meaning," and led to an embrace of multiple meanings that are constructed by those who engage in the study of it (2006: 3–6). As Adam observes, the meaning of a text is derived from its interpretation, "from the experience of attempting to arrive at a shared understanding" (2006: 5).

Postmodernist biblical interpretation describes an orientation to the Bible as opposed to a precise methodology of its interpretation. Though an umbrella term that encompasses a broad range of scholarship, there is an essential identifying characteristic of the postmodern orientation articulated well in *The Postmodern Bible*:

The various critical stances brought together here under the sign "postmodernism," for all their differences, share a suspicion of the claim of mastery that characterizes traditional readings of texts, including modern biblical scholarship . . . by raising doubts about the capacity to achieve ultimate clarity about the meaning of a text, postmodern readings lay bare the contingent and constructed character of meaning itself.²

Fundamental to postmodern interpretation, the "suspicion of the claim of mastery" not only dismisses the notion that there is a single, accessible, inherent meaning to a text, it also often assumes that texts have subtexts—that there are hidden, sometimes conflicted, meanings embedded intentionally or unintentionally within a text. Postmodern interpreters do not accept a text at face value, but seek to elucidate the subtexts within it. They seek to understand the ideologies that shape a text, whether the author's or the society's that produced the text, and look for ways in which a text supports or challenges these ideologies. The postmodernist hermeneutic of suspicion also places an enormous burden on the reader, who must be a resistant and a self-reflexive reader simultaneously. Understanding "the contingent and constructed character of meaning itself,"

postmodern readers must be aware of their own biases and assumptions, as well as the biases and assumptions presented by the text itself. Embracing the subjectivity of interpretation, postmodern critics speak comfortably in the first-person voice, as I do in this chapter.

By focusing attention on the role of the reader and the act of reading, reader response, feminist, and ideological criticisms can all fall neatly within the broader category of postmodernist biblical criticism. In particular, feminist literary criticism overtly exercises a hermeneutic of suspicion, expanding perspectives and revealing subtexts. By challenging objective claims of knowledge and determinate meanings of texts, feminist scholars, along with other postmodernist scholars, offer new and provocative readings that seek to destabilize traditional interpretations of the Bible, as Mieke Bal writes:

My goal is rather to show, by the sheer possibility of a different reading, that “dominance” is, although present and in many ways obnoxious, not unproblematically established. It is the challenge rather than the winning that interests me. For it is not the sexist interpretation of the Bible as such that bothers me. It is the possibility of dominance itself, the attractiveness of coherence and authority in culture, that I see as the source, rather than the consequence, of sexism.³

With the intent to destabilize, postmodernism challenges every aspect of biblical critical studies, but it offers a particular challenge to scholars who engage in biblical theology. As I mention earlier, many biblical scholars of the late nineteenth and early twentieth century were Christian men of faith who consciously or unconsciously read the Bible as salvation history, and used their scholarship to bolster their belief. The postmodernist critique makes it difficult to study, let alone to do theology. For postmodernists, there are no metaphysical truths, only relative and subjective beliefs. All that is knowable is what can be experienced by human beings. Viewed within this postmodernist perspective, the Bible’s depictions of God and God’s encounter with humanity become about the complexities of the human condition, and reflect humanity’s religiosity, as opposed to a metaphysical reality.⁴

For these reasons, postmodernism offers a unique perspective on the Bible’s theologians—the prophets who talk about truth and God. The biblical prophets certainly were not proto-postmodernists. They believed in an objective, cohesive, transcendent, and knowable truth, which they equated with God’s word. For the prophets, God’s word is truth. Their task is to discern, embody, and communicate the true word of God. A variation of the phrase *כה אמר יהוה* (“thus says YHWH”) appears countless times in the prophets to verify the prophets’ message,⁵ as does the expression *דבר-יהוה* (“God’s word”).⁶ A true prophet bears God’s word. Jeremiah receives the word of God (*ויהי דבר-יהוה אלי*) while in his mother’s womb, and thereby is designated God’s prophet.⁷ Ezekiel eats God’s words in order to become God’s prophet.⁸ Desperately, Hosea, Amos, and Isaiah implore Israel to hear God’s word.⁹

Although I recognize that the prophets were not postmodernists, I contend that it is possible to do a postmodern interpretation of their books, which I offer now. In fact,

I would argue that the prophetic books provide particularly fertile territory for postmodern interpretation. As human recipients of the divine word, the prophets, more than any other figures in the Hebrew Bible, represent the subjective human experience, and therefore are an appropriate focus for postmodern interpretation. It is also my contention that a postmodernist reading of the prophets, perhaps ironically, enables a return to biblical theology—though from a distinct perspective. Postmodern interpreters such as myself are not looking to reveal God's eternal truth that is transmitted through the prophet and his text. Instead, we are interested in "God discourse"—in observing how the prophets express their experience of God. We engage in theological anthropology more than theology proper, raising questions about the nature and meaning of being a religious human, while recognizing the multiple, if not infinite, ways these questions can be answered.

Since the prophets equate the word with transcendent, objective truth, I engage in a postmodern analysis of the representation of the body in the biblical prophets. I contend that the prophets experience God through their bodies, and that bodies play a significant role in God discourse. Rife with complex meaning, bodies in the prophets are fitting subjects for postmodern interpretation. Whereas words in the prophetic books reflect God's *objective* truth, bodies reflect *subjective* human experience, particularly, I argue, the experience of the prophet. Bodies are also a powerful rhetorical resource for the prophets. In my analysis, I explore how the prophets use their bodies, or the image of bodies, to communicate effectively with their audience, as well as to express their experience as prophets.

The elements that together identify my analysis as postmodern are my focus on the subjective experience of the prophet; my embrace of subtext and multiple meanings; my attention to gender issues; my consideration of the text's effect on its audience; and my presentation of a counter-narrative. In isolation, many of these elements are not definitive markers of postmodernism. A scholar engaged in reader response criticism may work to reconstruct the prophets' historical audience. Similarly, a gender scholar may work to reveal the gender norms of ancient Israel. As a postmodern interpreter, my goals are different. I focus on the biblical text, not its historical context, and engage with what is implicit, not explicit, in the text. I seek to uncover not the gender norms of ancient Israel, but the gender attitudes reflected in the biblical text. I do not seek to reconstruct the prophets' ancient audience, but hope to consider the rhetorical impact a text could have on any audience. Because it employs a variety of critical methods, and because it focuses on what is implicit in the text, my analysis meets the essential identifying criterion of postmodern interpretation—diversity in method and meaning, as George Aichele, Peter Miscall, and Richard Walsh observe:

Diversity in postmodernism includes not just different methods of reading and interpreting the Bible but also variety within any one method. . . . What unites this methodological jumble is agreement that no final or essential interpretation of the text is being produced. Other readings are always possible, and often invited. (2009: 384)

For many reasons, the image of the body is a rich site for postmodern reflection. Societies imbue bodies with a complex of meanings and associations, as Jon L. Berquist writes:

Bodies are more than just anatomy, however. In human societies, people talk about the body and describe the ways that they experience the body. Societies form complex sets of beliefs about the body, about what the body can and should be and what it means when bodies do certain things.¹⁰

As sites of cultural reflection, bodies embody multiple meanings that reflect their specific cultural contexts and invite interpretation.¹¹ By definition, physical bodies represent nonverbal communication. If the word is text, as I suggest it is in the prophetic books, then the body is a kind of subtext. As a medium of expression, the body is opaque and requires translation. In order to read a body, one must understand the cultural values that shape it. Body language, the ways bodies are used and represented in texts, reveals a society's cultural, moral, and aesthetic values, as well as its anxieties. For example, in the biblical context, a menstruating body raises a host of anxieties related to ancient Israel's notions of purity, wholeness, and status, particularly as they relate to women.

My postmodern analysis focuses on rhetorical and literary representation of bodies in the prophetic books. I consider two ways that the biblical prophets present the body throughout their books, which I label the *shocking body* and the *narrative body*. The multiple ways in which the prophets use the body suggest that they recognize its rhetorical power as well as its subtlety. As we will see, the body can be a blunt rhetorical tool that demands a powerful emotional response, and a narrative device that requires interpretation and conveys theological meaning. Used in these ways, the image of the body is oriented to the reader and reflects postmodern interest in examining the ways a text engages its audience. Just as the prophets want to communicate the word of God, the prophets want these bodies to be read and interpreted.

Yet the body can also be a subtle means of communication that, whether consciously or not, reveals the prophets' experience of personal vulnerability and their burden of having to communicate God's word. Used in this way, the image of the body, particularly the prophet's own body, is featured in God discourse, reflecting the postmodern concern for how humans experience the divine. As I suggest in the final section, it also reveals a counter-text to the prophet's meta-narrative by conveying a personal voice of resistance. There is, I argue, a tension between the word and the body, evident throughout the prophetic books, which is particularly revealed in Jeremiah 20. My analysis of this chapter shows that though the prophet's words suggest compliance, his "body language" communicates reluctance to speak for God. I contend that Jeremiah's body language speaks for other prophets who, like Jeremiah, are physically overpowered, even held captive, by God's word.

SHOCKING BODIES

Dead bodies appear frequently in the prophetic books. Of course, war produces corpses. Therefore, it is reasonable to assume, as a modernist reader would, that the prophets who were active during the rise and fall of two powerful Mesopotamian empires—Assyria and Babylonia—would have seen dead bodies, perhaps heaped in the streets, as Nahum 3:3 describes:

Charging horsemen, flashing swords, glittering spears;
Many slain, heaps of corpses, no end of dead bodies—they stumble over their bodies.¹²

Similarly, Amos 8:3 describes corpses “cast about everywhere.” Ezekiel 6:5 mentions bones scattered throughout Israel. Isaiah 5:25 describes the dead lying “like refuse in the streets.” Jeremiah 25:33 envisions corpses strewn from one end of the earth to the other. The stylized nature of these depictions suggests that they are more than descriptive of a bloody reality. Not only are dead bodies heaped and strewn across the face of the earth in the prophetic books, they also are dragged about and consumed by wild animals.¹³ The frequency and consistency of these images suggest that they are literary constructs meant to convey the horror Israel experiences (or anticipates) at the hands of its enemies.

Stylized representations of violated and dead bodies are common in the Mesopotamian world, which kept a visual and textual record of its military exploits. In her study of these images, Zainab Bahrani remarks that though they “contain a kernel of a historical record of an event,” Mesopotamian images of war and violence, such as a pile of decomposing corpses, are not purely mimetic.¹⁴ According to Bahrani, visual and literary representation in Mesopotamia “was thought of not as imitating the natural world but as participating in it and affecting it in supernatural, even magical ways.”¹⁵ Bahrani identifies images like those in the reliefs adorning the Assyrian royal palace in Nineveh of the decapitated Elamite king Teumman to be performative imagery—an imagery that alters reality, that “creates through the act of representation.”¹⁶

Bahrani’s notion of performative imagery is useful in analyzing the body images found in the prophets, particularly those found in the oracles against the foreign nations in which the prophets envision the downfall of Israel’s enemies.¹⁷ When seen as performative, these images of dead, wounded, or diseased bodies are more than depictions of a historical or even an emotional reality. In Bahrani’s words, these images “make things happen.”¹⁸ By using this imagery, the prophets seek to reconstruct their social-political reality, enabling Israel to triumph over its enemies. Thus, the image of the slain and heaped Ninevite corpses in Nahum 3:3 triggers change and works to construct a new reality—one in which Israel triumphs over Assyria.

Most often though, the prophets direct their attention toward Israel, and depict Israel's dead and violated bodies. For example, in Jeremiah 8:1–2, the prophet describes how Israel's dead will be exhumed—their bones laid out before the sun, moon, and stars that they had once worshiped. These images, I contend, are meant to make things happen as well, though I do not think that the prophets sought to destroy their Israelite audience, as they did their enemies. Jeremiah did not want to disinter Israel's dead. Instead, I suggest that the prophets employ performative imagery primarily to activate a change in the religious behavior and moral attitude of their audience. The prophets employ images of shocking bodies—violated, unsettling bodies—to engage their audience and to initiate this reform. By employing these powerful images, the prophets seek to transform a sinful Israel, portrayed with diseased and wounded bodies, into a redeemed Israel that has, as Ezekiel envisions, a new heart and body.¹⁹ As a postmodern interpreter, I now consider the form and function of these shocking bodies in order to understand what values they communicate implicitly, and how they work to engage their audience.

As many passages in the prophetic books convey, images of violated bodies are emotionally effective. Isaiah 66:24 illustrates this well:

They will go out and look at the corpses of those who rebelled against me.
Their worms will not die; their fire will not go out.
They will be a horror to all flesh.

The body language of this passage is easy to interpret. Decomposing bodies are displayed as a warning; they are meant to be seen. Viewers of these bodies—whether directly or indirectly through the text—will know what happens to those who rebel against God, and will learn not to rebel. Jeremiah 19:7–8 offers another example of the pedagogical power of horrific body language:

I will make their corpses food for the birds of the sky and the beasts of the earth.
I will make this city an object of horror and hissing; everyone who passes
by it will be appalled and will hiss over its wounds.

Images such as worm-infested corpses, heaped bodies, and human carrion were as difficult for an ancient audience to encounter as they are for a contemporary audience. As such, they are an important part of the prophetic rhetoric that seeks to unsettle its audience in order to initiate its reform, as Yvonne M. Sherwood observes:

Whereas false prophecy daubs reality with whitewash, soothes the eyes, generates “pretty songs,” and smooth words (Jer 6:14; Ezek 13:8–13), true prophecy shocks, dislocates, refuses to pander to the eyes, produces unbearable visions and unseeable spectacles.²⁰

With explicit candor, Sherwood notes how the prophets transform bodies into unseeable spectacles:

The prophets make us gag with ugly spectacles. . . . They blur the boundaries between the national and the individual body and display that body as a fucked body, a raped body, a diseased body, a mutilated body, a body at the limits of its own skin and self-containment, a body terrified by a confrontation with its own mortality, its own being-as-refuse, a body degraded by the blood on its skirts and the shit on its face.²¹

Though Sherwood describes the variety of shocking bodies, what she terms “ugly spectacles,” I offer a few more specific examples. These examples, along with those I have already given, suggest common features that mark the representation of shocking bodies in the prophets.

In Micah 3:2–3, the prophet accuses Israel’s leadership of abusing their power and presents another image of dead bodies:

Haters of good and lovers of evil,
You have stripped the skin from them;
You have flayed the skin from their bones.
And after eating the flesh of my people,
And stripping their skin off and smashing their bones,
You have cut it up into a pot,
Like meat in a caldron.

In this passage, Micah accuses Israel’s leaders of doing the unthinkable, eating human flesh. It is not difficult to see why a gruesome stew of dismembered human bodies is shocking and therefore an effective image. Jeremiah 19:9 presents a similar image:

I will cause them to eat the flesh of their sons and the flesh of their daughters, and they shall devour one another’s flesh—because of the desperate straits to which they will be reduced by their enemies, who seek their life.

Ezekiel 24:3–12 also describes a bloody stew, although in this passage, Ezekiel does not identify the ingredients as human flesh. He compares a blood-filled and encrusted pot to the city of Jerusalem, which he calls עיר הדמים (“the city of blood”). Jerusalem, then, is like a stew pot filled with rancid human flesh. God threatens to cook Jerusalem until its bones, those of its inhabitants, are charred.

Bodies do not have to be dead to be shocking in the prophetic books. Diseased bodies are also part of the prophets’ repertoire. Hosea 5:12–13 describes sick Israel:

I am like pus to Ephraim; decay to the house of Judah.
When Ephraim became aware of his sickness, Judah of his sores,
Ephraim repaired to Assyria—he sent envoys to a patron king.
He will never be able to cure you, will not heal you of your sores.

Micah 1:9 also describes infected Israel:

Indeed her wound is incurable; it has reached Judah and
spread to the gates of my people, to Jerusalem.

The image of the incurable wound appears throughout Jeremiah.²² Jeremiah 14:19 serves as an example:

Have you rejected Judah? Do you loathe Zion?
Why have you smitten us so that there is no cure?
We hope for well-being, but find no good;
For a time of healing, and meet terror instead.

The preceding passages indicate that God afflicts Israel with disease as punishment for sin. Other passages suggest that God punishes Israel with more than disease. Isaiah 10:5 relates that God beats Israel with “the rod of his fury,” Assyria. Micah 6:13 also states that God beats Israel for its sin: “Indeed I have beaten you sore, made you desolate for your sins.” Similarly, Jeremiah 30:14 relates that God afflicts Israel with “cruel punishment” for its great sins. Isaiah 1:5–6 describes Israel’s beaten body:

For what will you be beaten again? You continue to rebel.
Every head is sick, every heart is afflicted.
From head to foot no spot is sound.
Bruises, welts, festering sores—
Not pressed out, not bound up, not softened with oil.

Like the dead, diseased, and beaten body, the exposed female body also shocks. Time and time again, the prophets display a naked female body in an effort to shock their audience into reform.²³ In comparison, the naked male body rarely appears. In Hosea 2:11–12, God threatens to strip female Israel of her clothes and expose her genitals. Israel’s skirts are lifted and her genitals revealed in Jeremiah 13:22 and 26. Similar imagery appears in Nahum 3:5–6 and Isaiah 47:2–3. Ezekiel 16:37 describes how God will strip Israel before her lovers as punishment. Ezekiel 23:29 predicts how Israel’s enemies, her former lovers, will strip her naked.

Having offered several examples of shocking bodies that appear in the prophetic books, I consider briefly what these images have in common. As a postmodern interpreter, I am concerned with subtext, and seek to reveal the implicit values that inform and shape the text. As Berquist observes, dead, diseased, beaten, and female bodies violate the Bible’s perception of the ideal body, which is whole. According to Berquist, a whole body is a body with all its “parts and functions,” and which “contains itself within fixed boundaries.”²⁴ It is also male. In Israelite society, female bodies cannot be ideal because they regularly leak, and more important, because they lack a defining member, as Berquist notes:

In ancient Israel, the concept of whole bodies excluded women, because the culture defined the whole body as possessing a penis. . . . All bodies were measured against the ideal, and the ideal was defined as male.²⁵

In other words, female bodies, along with decaying, wounded, and diseased bodies, are not whole. They are open bodies in flux.²⁶ Their borders violated, these bodies threaten to dissolve, as Sherwood observes:

They take the secure body, the adult body, the civilized body and infantilise it (stripping it down to its shit and genitals) and hurl it forward towards death, entropy, disease, nakedness, rape and waste.²⁷

Open bodies are rhetorically powerful because they remind those who view them of their physical vulnerability, both as individuals and as communities, and ultimately of their mortality. Prophets use them to push their audience to their limits and to force them to respond. As Sherwood notes, they take “their language, and the human body, to the edge” and construct “a highly disturbing discourse, traumatized by diseased and dying bodies.”²⁸ Diseased and dying bodies also are rhetorically powerful because they register Israel’s sinful state and God’s displeasure. The prophets understand that God afflicts and wounds Israel. Therefore, Israel’s diseased and wounded body is a significant part of God discourse in the prophetic books by serving as a sign of God’s anger and rejection of Israel.

As I mentioned earlier, prophets use images of shocking bodies in order to initiate reform. Understanding and harnessing the power of images, they want their audience to view decaying, dismembered, diseased, beaten, and female bodies, and to be changed. Like those who pass by Israel’s decomposing bodies²⁹ or those who witness Israel stripped naked,³⁰ they will be horrified. Not wanting to become them, viewers of these shocking bodies, the prophets’ audience, should reform their behavior to avoid this fate.

NARRATIVE BODIES

Bodies not only trigger emotional responses, they also tell stories in the prophetic books. I call these storytelling bodies “narrative bodies.” As I mentioned earlier, prophets rely primarily on words. Words are their currency, and mark them as true prophets. Yet prophets also rely on their bodies to communicate God’s messages. They perform sign-acts, bodily performances akin to theater, which appear, at times, to require a live audience. In Ezekiel 4:1–3, God commands Ezekiel to carve a brick with the image of Jerusalem. He is to surround the brick with towers, battering rams, and military camps. Then, he must lie before it with an iron plate placed between him and the city to enact Babylon’s siege of Jerusalem. Ezekiel’s performance will be a sign, *אמ*, to the house of Israel who will witness his performance and understand its fate.

The prophet continues to perform before Israel, lying for 390 days on his left side and 40 day on his right, enacting the years of Israel and Judah's punishment respectively. While Ezekiel is lying on his side, God commands the prophet to eat barley cakes baked on human excrement before their eyes. Israel will watch and learn that, as God says in Ezekiel 4:13, "The people of Israel will eat their bread, impure, among the nations to which I will banish them." Like Ezekiel, Isaiah also engages in live theater. In Isaiah 20, God commands the prophet to walk naked and barefoot for three years as a sign, *אֶת, וְמוֹפֶת*, to Egypt and Nubia that Assyria will conquer them and send their captives naked and barefoot into exile. This is one of the rare examples in which a naked male body appears in the prophetic texts. Micah 1:8 is another. While naked, Micah laments and wails for Israel's fate.

In all of these examples, the prophets use their bodies to tell a story, whether to Israel or to foreign nations. The message of these sign-acts is relayed in the moment of the performance. In order to be understood, the prophets' actions and bodies must be seen. The benefits of communicating through a full-body live performance, as opposed to a spoken or written message, remain unclear. These performances could be understood as effective pedagogical tools that "belong to the history of teaching aids and provocative street theatre," as Bernhard Lang suggests.³¹ They also could be seen as theatrical manifestations of Bahrani's performative images, employed to effect change. Seen in this way, Ezekiel's private siege and impure meal are not warnings to Israel. Instead, they alter reality and determine Israel's future.

Interestingly, not all of the prophets' bodily acts are done before a live audience. At times, God commands the prophets to do physical acts privately. In Ezekiel 3:24–27, God commands Ezekiel to shut himself up in his house bound by cords, one assumes without an audience. In Jeremiah 13:1–11, God commands Jeremiah to wear a loincloth until it is soiled. He must then bury it, and, after a period of time, dig up the decaying loincloth. As in Ezekiel's bondage episode, there is no mention of an audience. Jeremiah, like Ezekiel, appears to be alone. Arguably, these private bodily acts function like the public ones, either as pedagogical or performative acts. Since both are recorded, whether done publicly or privately, the prophets' physical actions—their body language—function as effective pedagogy that communicates Israel's doomed fate. A reader of the text may be as shocked by the image of bound Ezekiel as a firsthand viewer would be. Also, performative acts may not require an audience to be effective. Whether witnessed or not, Jeremiah's burial of the loincloth may determine Israel's fate.

Though the impact on a reader or viewer of the prophets' physical actions may be the same, I suggest that when done privately, these acts carry a distinct message for the prophets as characters within the text, and, by extension, for would-be prophets included among the texts' intended audience. Private sign-acts teach a valuable lesson to the prophets about the nature of prophecy. Through their bodies, through physical experience, Jeremiah and Ezekiel learn the intensity and the intimacy of their personal relationship with God as prophets. In bondage, Ezekiel learns what it means to embody the word of God. He must be physically overpowered, literally tied down, in order to be

God's prophet. Ezekiel's body is constrained, his tongue restrained, before God forcibly opens his mouth. From this he learns that his body serves the word of God—perhaps even against its instinct. In this episode, his body becomes a prisoner of God's word. Though the lessons learned from this experience are not spelled out by Ezekiel, a post-modern interpreter is willing to fill in the textual gaps, and to listen for what is implicit. Ezekiel never explicitly says that he feels overpowered by God, and yet he describes being at the mercy of a divine spirit that forces him to stand³² and even carries him away by the hair of his head.³³

Like Ezekiel, Jeremiah receives a lesson about divine intimacy through his body. God uses the prophet's body as a way to teach him about the intimate relationship between God and Israel. God commands Jeremiah to wear a loincloth because, as Jeremiah 13:11 states:

Just as the loincloth clings to the loins of a man thus the whole house of Israel and Judah cling to me, says YHWH, to be my people, for fame, praise, and glory.

This passage is startling because of its bold body language. It associates God with a male body and Israel with the garment that covers God's male genitals. By dressing and undressing, Jeremiah receives a full-body lesson about Israel's intimate relationship to God that must be felt by the prophet in order to be understood. Ideally, when obedient, Israel protects and reflects God's glory like a loincloth protects and reflects a man's virility. Sin-free Israel has this kind of relationship with God. Sinful Israel is another story. When Israel is disobedient, God discards Israel like a rotten and soiled loincloth that no longer protects or reflects God's glory.

Not only does the lesson of the loincloth help Jeremiah understand God's relationship to Israel, it also helps him understand his own relationship with God as a prophet. Again, the text does not explicitly state the lesson learned. Jeremiah does not reflect on what it feels like to take the loincloth off, bury it, and then dig it up. Yet it seems logical to assume that a lesson was intended for the prophet alone, since God commands him to act physically without an audience. His body must wear the loincloth like God's body wears Israel. Through his body, through a physical act that involves his body, Jeremiah experiences what it feels like to be God—to wear and then discard Israel. This physical identification with God, I argue, is only possible for a prophet who embodies the word of God. Only a prophet can physically stand in for God and experience God's reality through his body.³⁴

I consider two more body-centered texts that are not sign-acts, but function more as parables that feature bodies. As I did with the shocking bodies, I conclude this section by considering common features of these body narratives, both the sign-acts and the parables, which I argue comprise a coherent body narrative about God's relationship to Israel. The first body narrative occurs in Isaiah 3:16–26. In this text, Isaiah describes the coifed and adorned daughters of Zion who arrogantly walk about, mincing as they go. With sartorial detail, God threatens to strip the daughters of their finery and

to expose their genitals. Isaiah 3:24 captures the tragic transformation that will be the daughters' fate:

Instead of perfume, rot;
 Instead of a girdle, rope;
 Instead of set hair, baldness;
 Instead of a robe; sackcloth;
 Indeed, shame in place of beauty.

In this passage, the prophet does more than assault his audience with shocking images. He tells a story about Israel's transformation—from beauty to ugly spectacle, from pride to disgrace.

Although we can never know why Isaiah chooses to tell the story of Israel's transformation through the gendered bodies of the daughters of Zion, a postmodern interpreter is willing to raise this question, and to consider the prophet's motivation for incorporating gendered imagery. Just as the shocking images discussed earlier may contain a kernel of historical record, the Isaiah passage also may capture the reality of conquest in which Israelite women were stripped of their finery, and perhaps even violated.³⁵ Yet, as a postmodernist, I suggest that the body imagery in this passage, like the shocking images discussed previously, reflects more than historical reality. It conveys social anxieties and serves a particular rhetorical function. As Alice A. Keefe suggests, "the female body, as the generative source of the life of the community, metonymically represents the social body."³⁶ Therefore, just as diseased bodies register God's displeasure, violated female bodies register social upheaval and are a measure of a society in chaos.

Isaiah uses women's bodies to tell this story because they convey Israel's social distress. Given the frequency with which they appear throughout the prophetic books, they seem to pack a powerful rhetorical punch. Especially when naked and diseased, women's bodies appear to have a greater shock value than male bodies. They also offer the most apt, effective, and damning critique for Israel. With their roaming eyes, the haughty daughters of Zion get what they deserve, just as sinful Israel that strays from God gets what it deserves. Whereas Jeremiah in the loincloth body narrative identifies with God, in this body narrative, Isaiah forces his presumably male audience to identify with shameful and shamed women.³⁷ They must witness their humiliation, and understand that they could suffer a similar fate if they do not reform. This is an example of the "highly disturbing discourse" described by Sherwood in which the prophets seek to traumatize their audience, by forcing them to resist what they must witness.³⁸

Thus far, the narrative bodies I have considered are all in crisis. Subjected to overwhelming force, they are made to do actions they do not want to do, and are stripped of things that they prize. The last narrative I consider presents bodies in a different way. Ezekiel 37 does not describe bodies in crisis. Instead, it offers a prophecy of hope through the image of restored bodies. In Ezekiel 37, God transports the prophet to a valley filled with dry bones and commands Ezekiel to say to the bones:

Listen to the word of God! Thus says my Lord YHWH to these bones:
Indeed I am bringing breath to you and you will live. (Ezekiel 37:4–5)

Obedient to God, Ezekiel prophesies and the bones begin to assemble. Muscle and flesh grow upon them. Breath enters them and restores the bodies to life. In Ezekiel 37:14, God reveals what this means for Israel:

I will put my breath in you and you will live. I will place you on your
own soil and you will know that I, YHWH, have spoken and have
acted—declares YHWH.

The body imagery of Ezekiel's hopeful prophecy is the opposite of the imagery found in Isaiah 3—or for that matter, the body imagery that I have discussed so far—and therefore provides an interesting point of comparison. Whereas Isaiah strips female bodies and transforms them into shocking bodies, in this body narrative Ezekiel transforms shocking bodies—dead bodies—into whole bodies. Though one assumes that God restores both male and female bodies, Ezekiel's whole bodies are genderless. Composed of bone, flesh, and spirit, they bear no clothing or body part that marks their gender. Remarkably, these restored bodies become like the prophet's body and are receptacles for the divine spirit. God's spirit enters and animates the dead bodies, just as God's word enters Ezekiel and his spirit compels the prophet's body. God's word overpowers human flesh, though in a decidedly more positive way than is described in Ezekiel's bondage episode. Just as God forcefully opens Ezekiel's mouth and controls his body, God opens the graves of his people in exile, and carries their revived bodies to Israel.

The narrative bodies I have discussed in this section tell a common story about God's relationship to Israel and the prophet, and therefore are a significant resource for God discourse. Like clothes on a body or flesh on bones, these narratives reveal that God relates intimately and physically to Israel and, even more intimately and physically, to the prophets. God's relationship to Israel and the prophets is not abstract, but full-bodied. The word or spirit of God is more than sensed, it is felt throughout the body. It enters, animates, and controls the human body.

Each of the narratives I have discussed depicts the human body as subject to divine spirit, and, at times, as overpowered by that spirit—particularly the prophets' bodies. These narratives also reveal that God can sever God's relationship with human beings, and abandon their bodies. In the body narratives, the naked body—one without clothes or flesh (often a female body)—is a body without God, while the clothed body is a restored body reconciled with God, as Isaiah 61:10 illustrates:

Let me rejoice in YHWH;
Let my body rejoice in my God.
For he has clothed me in the clothes of salvation;
Wrapped me in a cloak of triumph,
Like a groom adorned with a priest's turban,
And a bride bedecked with her finery.

A COUNTER-NARRATIVE

Shocking bodies and narrative bodies manifest a common vulnerability. As we have seen, bodies can be beaten, stripped, infected, and killed. Subject to such abuse, bodies, like withering grass, capture the precariousness of human experience, in contrast to the divine word, which is true and fixed; as Isaiah 40:8 describes: “Grass withers, flowers fade, but the word of our God stands forever.”³⁹ I have suggested that body language in the prophets may reflect Israel’s experience at the hands of its conquerors Assyria and Babylonia. I have also suggested that stylized body language is a potent part of the prophets’ rhetoric directed toward Israel. By depicting vulnerable bodies, the prophets remind Israel of its vulnerability. Like bodies, nations can be breached and therefore must be protected. By forcing Israel to witness these images, the prophets hope to change its behavior. No one wants to become a diseased, exposed, or dead body. Though disturbing, the body language serves the prophets’ mission and supports their meta-narrative of Israel’s sin, punishment, and restoration. Unsettling body language works to condemn, reform, and ultimately restore Israel.

Wary of meta-narratives, postmodern interpreters look for ways that texts work against them, by including counter-texts that challenge the meta-narrative. I conclude my postmodern analysis of the representation of the body in the prophets with a discussion of Jeremiah 20, which I contend is an example of a counter-text. In Jeremiah 20, the prophet employs body language in protest of his mission and in defiance of God. Through his body language, this time directed to God and not Israel, Jeremiah communicates his anger at God, and his desire to be freed of his body—the medium through which God exercises control over the prophet.

Jeremiah 20 opens with a prose section that describes Jeremiah’s physical abuse at the hands of Pashhur, the Temple’s chief priest. After hearing Jeremiah prophesy, Pashhur has the prophet flogged and imprisoned. Many scholars connect the prose section with the text that precedes it, as opposed to the poetry that follows.⁴⁰ Though I recognize the challenges in seeing Jeremiah 20 as a unified text, I contend that the prose section provides an essential context for the poetry. In the poetry, Jeremiah speaks as a victim of physical violence, which is described in the prose section. His cry for vengeance in the poetry therefore is based on personal experience. A reader understands why the prophet rails against his persecutors in Jeremiah 20:11: “Therefore, my pursuers will stumble and not succeed. They shall be greatly shamed and not prosper, with an ever-lasting humiliation that will not be forgotten.”

Jeremiah’s physical abuse not only explains the rage he feels toward his abusers, it also explains the rage he feels toward God, which he expresses in the poetry section. Jeremiah is justifiably angry at the people for abusing him. He is also justifiably angry at God for not protecting him from them. In Jeremiah 1:18–19, God promises Jeremiah a degree of physical protection. Although God admits that Israel will attack Jeremiah, God suggests

that Jeremiah will not suffer from their assault because God is with Jeremiah. Just as walls protect a city from being penetrated, God will protect the prophet from attack. Jeremiah's experience at the hands of Pashhur reveals to the prophet that God does not protect Jeremiah from physical assault.

In physical and emotional distress, Jeremiah turns to God in 20:7–9:

You seduced me, YHWH, and I was seduced.
 You grabbed me and prevailed.
 I became a laughingstock all day, everyone mocked me.
 Whenever I speak, I cry out.
 I cry out: "Violence and destruction!"
 The word of God has become for me constant shame and humiliation.
 When I say that I will no longer mention him or speak again in his name,
 It becomes within me like a burning fire, shut up within my bones.
 I was helpless to contain it. I was unable.

Jeremiah directs his anger against the God who did not protect him—against the God who seduced him into service by promising him protection. Jeremiah's tone in this passage is as desperately aggressive as the cries of a trapped animal. He accuses God of forcing him to become a prophet—a role that causes him great suffering. It is a role that he longs to relinquish, but from which he sees no release.

It is difficult to ignore the sexual innuendoes of Jeremiah's accusation against God. The verb "to seduce" (פָּתָה) also appears in rape legislation found Exodus 22:15,⁴¹ while the verb "to grab" (חָזַק) appears in rape legislation found in Deuteronomy 22:25.⁴² I contend that Jeremiah intentionally uses rape language to convey his feelings of betrayal, and that his choice of language reflects the physicality of his relationship with God, and aptly describes the strained relationship between God and the prophet.

As we saw earlier, the prophet's relationship with God is intimate and physical. The body narratives showed that being a prophet is a full-body experience. God's words enter the prophet's body, as Jeremiah's call narrative makes clear in 1:9:

YHWH sent his hand and touched my mouth. YHWH said to me:
 "Indeed I have placed my words within your mouth."

Initially, as Kathleen M. O'Connor notes, Jeremiah is "wedded body and spirit to the prophetic word. . . . So faithful has Jeremiah been that he understands God's word as his food, part of his body, inseparable from his being."⁴³ A similar lesson is learned by Ezekiel when God commands him to eat the scroll of woe. Whereas the word tastes sweet to Ezekiel, to Jeremiah God's word causes shame and humiliation. Jeremiah's physical suffering elicits a crisis for the prophet. Unable to understand why God allows the body who serves the word to suffer, he feels physically violated. Jeremiah's rape language expresses his violation.

Having physically penetrated the prophet, God's words now burn unbearably within Jeremiah's body. As Jeremiah 5:14 states, these burning words were meant as a weapon against Israel:

Therefore, thus says YHWH, the God of Hosts:

Because they spoke thus, I am putting my words in your mouth as fire. This people is wood; it will consume them.

Now, God's words afflict the prophet's body. Jeremiah wants to deny them, but cannot. Trapped within his bones, the words refuse to be denied or contained. Like bound Ezekiel, raped Jeremiah is overpowered by God's word. Physically, he must continue to prophesy. As long as he has a body, he must be God's prophet.

The only way to release Jeremiah from his role as prophet is to release him from his body. In Jeremiah 20:14–18, the prophet expresses his desire that he have no body:

Cursed is the day upon which I was born.

The day my mother gave birth to me, may it never be blessed.

Cursed is the man who announced to my father: A son is born to you!

A male delighted him.

Let that man become like the cities that God overthrew without relenting.

He shall hear cries in the morning and alarm at noontime,

Because he did not kill me in the womb so that my mother would be my grave,

Her womb pregnant forever.

Why did I come forth from the womb to see hardship and suffering,

And to end my days in shame?

Jeremiah's mention of his mother's womb recalls the moment when God designated him to be a prophet while in his mother's womb. His death-wish now—more specifically, his desire never to have been born—seems to be a denial of that mission. It is also a denial of his body. The two, as I have been arguing, are inextricably linked. Without a body, the prophet cannot be a repository for the divine word. Without a body, he cannot be a prophet. Jeremiah's image of his mother's eternally pregnant body reflects his desire to be bodiless more than it reflects his desire to die. He could have asked God to kill him. Instead, he wishes that he had never been born. The only way that Jeremiah can end his agony as God's prophet, no longer to feel the fire of God's words, is not to have a body.

This is Jeremiah's fantasy and his protest, directed in anger and desperation toward God. Though reflecting his own brutal physical reality, Jeremiah indeed may speak on behalf of all prophets whose vulnerable bodies are overpowered by God's word. Jeremiah's protest may be a chance for the prophet to vent against his circumstances and against God so that he can resume his duties with complicity. It is also possible that the prophet employs performative imagery directed, this time, to God. Jeremiah hopes to affect God, even shock God, with his body language. Perhaps God will see Jeremiah's physical suffering, see what God has done to Jeremiah's body, and leave

him alone. His desire that his mother's womb be his grave is a desire to be bodiless. At heart, this is not a desire to be dead, but a desire to no longer have a body. If he does not have a body, he cannot be God's prophet. It is as if Jeremiah wants to be like Ezekiel's dry bones. He wants to be stripped of his body, and thus of his relationship with God.

CONCLUSION

A good postmodern interpretation does not draw conclusions, but instead makes suggestions for possible ways to read texts. My postmodern analysis of the representation of the body in the biblical prophets has suggested a variety of ways that bodies communicate and are themselves subject to interpretation. I have considered how bodies are powerful rhetorical resources for the prophets who rely on shocking bodies and narrative bodies to communicate their message and to move their audience. Prophets tell stories about bodies and with their bodies, using emotionally affective body language to effect social and moral change. They construct images of dead, diseased, beaten, exposed, and female bodies, creating ugly spectacles of vulnerable bodies to unsettle their audience and shock them into reform.

I have also considered how bodies, as the medium through which the prophets experience God, are central to God discourse. The prophets use bodies to reflect the nature of God's relationship with Israel. A diseased, wounded, or naked body is a body abandoned by God. Prophetic body language reveals that God relates physically and intimately to Israel. If obedient, God will protect Israel's bodies, wrapping their bones in flesh and clothing them in robes of triumph. If disobedient, God will strip them naked and discard them to rot and become carrion for birds and beasts.

Embodying the divine word, prophets have a particularly physical and intimate relationship with God. They even identify physically with God—experiencing through their bodies what God experiences. At times, this physical intimacy is unbearable for prophets who feel overpowered or imprisoned by God's word. Jeremiah speaks for these prophets when he expresses his desire to be bodiless—to be free of God's word and his prophetic mission.

Indeed, representations of bodies in the biblical text prove to be rich sites for postmodern reflection on the prophets. Not only do we gain insight into how the prophets appealed to their audience, but we also are privy to the subjective human experience of those who committed their lives and bodies to serving God's truth. Though the prophets implore their audience to listen to God's word, I contend that it is necessary to read their bodies and the bodies they present in their books. Providing subtext to text, prophetic body language often reveals what words cannot. It conveys cultural and personal values and anxieties, illuminates the role of the prophet, and attests to the intimate and physical relationship between God and Israel, and between God and the prophet.

NOTES

1. A. K. M. Adam (1995: 1–25) helpfully distinguishes between modernist and postmodernist perspectives.
2. The Bible and Culture Collective (George Aichele, Fred W. Burnett, Elizabeth A. Castelli, Robert M. Fowler, David Jobling, Stephen D. Moore, Gary A. Phillips, Tina Pippin, Regina M. Schwartz, and Wilhelm Wuellner) 1995: 2–3.
3. Mieke Bal, *Lethal Love: Feminist Literary Readings of Biblical Love Stories* (ISBL; Bloomington and Indianapolis: Indiana University Press, 1987), 3.
4. See Burke O. Long, “Ambitions of Dissent: Biblical Theology in a Postmodern Future,” *JR* 76(2) (1996): 276–289.
5. For examples, see Isaiah 7:7; 8:11; Jeremiah 2:2; 4:3; Ezekiel 7:2; 30:2; Amos 1:3; 5:3; Micah 2:3; 3:5; Nahum 1:12; Zechariah 1:3; 3:7.
6. For examples, see Isaiah 1:10; 28:13; Jeremiah 2:1; 20:8; Ezekiel 6:1; 15:1; Micah 1:1; Haggai 1:3; Zechariah 7:4; 8:1.
7. Jeremiah 1:4.
8. Ezekiel 3:1–3.
9. Isaiah 1:10; Hosea 4:1; Amos 3:1; 5:1.
10. Jon L. Berquist, *Controlling Corporeality: The Body and the Household in Ancient Israel* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 2002), 3.
11. Berquist, *Controlling Corporeality*, 5.
12. All biblical translations in this chapter are my own.
13. Wild birds and beasts eating dead bodies is a common image in Jeremiah. See Jeremiah 7:33, 16:4, 19:7–8; 22:19; and 34:20.
14. Zainab Bahrani, *Rituals of War: The Body and Violence in Mesopotamia* (New York: Zone Books, 2008), 59.
15. Bahrani, *Rituals of War*, 57.
16. Bahrani, *Rituals of War*, 52–53.
17. Oracles against the nations can be found in Isaiah 13–23; Jeremiah 46–51; Ezekiel 25–32; Amos 1:3–2:3; Obadiah; Nahum; Zephaniah 2:4–15; and Zechariah 9:1–8.
18. Bahrani, *Rituals of War*, 53.
19. Ezekiel 37:1–14.
20. Yvonne M. Sherwood, “Prophetic Scatology: Prophecy and the Art of Sensation,” *Semeia* 82 (1998): 183–224 (211–212).
21. Sherwood, “Prophetic Scatology,” 214.
22. Jeremiah 8:22; 10:19; 14:17; 15:18; 30:12–15; 46:11; 51:8–9.
23. Sherwood notes the pervasiveness of female body imagery; see “Prophetic Scatology,” 193. I examine the ways in which gender effects the rhetorical impact of passages that depict naked and violated women in “The Monstrous-Feminine in the Book of Jeremiah,” in *Jeremiah (Dis)placed: New Directions in Writing/Reading Jeremiah* (ed. A. R. Pete Diamond and Louis Stulman; New York and London: T & T Clark, 2011), 190–208, and in *Dangerous Sisters of the Hebrew Bible* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2014), 53–68.
24. Berquist, *Controlling Corporeality*, 19.
25. Berquist, *Controlling Corporeality*, 35–36.
26. According to Seong-Hyuk Hong, understandings of disease in the ancient Near East reflected an “invasion etiology” in which hostile, supernatural forces invaded the human body. Reflecting this understanding of illness, the Bible equates health with wholeness. See *The*

Metaphor of Illness and Healing in Hosea and Its Significance in the Socio-Economic Context of Eighth-Century Israel and Judah (New York: Peter Lang, 2006), 72. Similarly, Candida R. Moss writes, "The surface of the body was not a sealed boundary; it was a permeable membrane through which manifold hostile objects could enter the body and wreak havoc in it." Moss observes how in the ancient world the female body was considered to be more porous. See "The Man with the Flow of Power: Porous Bodies in Mark 5:25–34," *JBL* 129 (2010): 507–519 (513).

27. Sherwood, "Prophetic Scatology," 214.
28. Sherwood, "Prophetic Scatology," 215.
29. Jeremiah 15:4; 18:16; 19:8; 29:18; 34:17.
30. Hosea 2:12; Ezekiel 16:37; 23:10, 29.
31. Bernhard Lang, "Games Prophets Play: Street Theatre and Symbolic Acts in Biblical Israel," in *Hebrew Life and Literature: Selected Essays of Bernhard Lang* (Surrey: Ashgate, 2008), 185–195 (193).
32. Ezekiel 2:2.
33. Ezekiel 8:3.
34. This is true for the prophet Hosea, whom God commands to marry promiscuous Gomer. Hosea's experience as Gomer's husband mirrors God's experience as Israel's metaphoric husband.
35. Plundering women was, and still is, a reality of war. Deuteronomy 21:10–14 records the procedure of taking a woman captive in which the woman is stripped of her "captive garment" [שמלת שביה].
36. Alice A. Keefe, *Woman's Body and the Social Body in Hosea* (London and New York: Sheffield Academic Press, 2001), 175.
37. Though we cannot know for sure who comprised the prophets' audience, most scholars assume that prophetic discourse was directed primarily to Israel's men and secondarily to its women.
38. Sherwood, "Prophetic Scatology," 215.
39. Isaiah 40:6 makes explicit the analogy between flesh and grass.
40. See William L. Holladay, *Jeremiah I* (Hermeneia; Philadelphia: Fortress, 1986), 534–538; and Jack R. Lundbom, *Jeremiah 1–20* (AB 21A; New York; London; Toronto; Sydney; Auckland: Doubleday, 1999), 842–844.
41. The verb also appears in other sexually suggestive passages such as Judges 14:15 and 16:5. Sandie Gravett considers whether or not the root should be translated as "rape" in "Reading 'Rape' in the Hebrew Bible: A Consideration of Language," *JSOT* 28 (2004): 279–299 (294–296).
42. The verb has sexually suggestive connotations in Proverbs 7:13; Isaiah 4:1; 2 Samuel 13:11; Judges 19:25.
43. Kathleen M. O'Connor, *Jeremiah Pain and Promise* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2011), 83. In Jeremiah 15:16, the prophet describes joyfully eating God's words.

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G. Interdisciplinary Interventions

CHAPTER 32

THE PROPHETS AND THEOLOGY

SHANNON CRAIGO-SNELL

A Christian theologian approaches the biblical texts with the assumption that they offer insight for living faithfully today. This does not mean that a theologian would be uninterested in the historical context in which the text originated, issues of authorial intent, literary sources, or patterns of redaction. Each of these areas of study, and others besides, provide vital resources for understanding biblical texts more fully. Yet theologians, either implicitly or explicitly, engage Scripture with an eye toward the current life of their own communities. This both limits and liberates theological readings of biblical texts.

Christian philosopher Nicholas Wolterstorff writes that Christians assume there is “a surplus of significance for the Bible.”¹ Christians keep going back to these texts with the conviction that there is more meaning to be had. In part, this is due to the capacity of Scripture to speak to new situations. One correlate of this high estimation of the Bible is that any particular theological interpretation of a text is necessarily partial and provisional. Because the texts speak to each new day, the reading of any given day is incomplete.

At the same time, the movement toward hearing what a biblical text says to a specific community today gives a theologian enviable freedom. She can say that a group of texts can operate in a particular way today without saying that this is the intended, original, or only way for these texts to operate. Indeed, she could go so far as to use contemporary theories to conceptualize ancient texts, without anachronistically imagining that such theoretical concepts were alive in the culture of the text’s production.

That is exactly what I will do in this chapter. I suggest that one aspect of prophetic literature is bimodal instruction in religious affections. Furthermore, I contend that contemporary Christian communities, particularly in the United States, need such instruction today.

AFFECTIONS

While the term “affection” indicates sentiment or warm feeling in common usage, within theological discourse it means something more. It references a way of being in the world that involves the whole person. It indicates the integration of emotion, intellect, and volition, such that how a person feels, thinks, and acts in the world form a coherent whole. Affections are also steadfast. Although they are neither static nor unalterable, affections do not change with the wind. Finally, Christian affections are formed in relationship with God, through Scripture, through practices including prayer, study, and worship, and through the work of the Holy Spirit.

Don Saliers describes affections as “deep emotions” that “necessarily [involve] the intellect” (1980: 9, 11). Christian affections intertwine emotion and belief. For example, the emotion of gratitude for creation is bound to intellectual beliefs that creation is good and comes from God in some fashion. Similarly, the emotion of remorse over sin is linked to beliefs about the goodness of God and the ways in which humanity falls short in relation to God. In these examples and others, experiencing the particular emotion requires the related belief. At the same time, holding the particular belief requires the emotion. There is room for great diversity between individuals and communities regarding how such emotions are experienced, but if remorse over sinfulness is completely lacking, the belief that one is sinful is not really present, either. “[I]n matters of religion (and morals as well),” Saliers claims, “the having of certain emotions is *part* of what it means to hold certain beliefs” (1980: 26; emphasis original). Thus Saliers calls affections “belief-laden emotions.”

Affections also involve the will, for they play a role in how a person interprets and interacts with the world around her. Saliers writes, “Only when religious emotions become deep and abiding motives ought we to speak of them as holy affections which are the distinguishing marks of true religious faith” (1980: 11). To my knowledge, Saliers does not go so far as to say bluntly that if there is no volitional aspect of an affection, the emotion and belief are lacking also. For example, if there is no will to amend one’s ways, there is no remorse over sin and no belief in one’s own sinfulness. Although Saliers might not state this directly, the pattern is easily inferred.

What is implied in Saliers’s writing is clear in the words of Jeremiah. He repeatedly calls his community to change their behavior (e.g., Jer 18:11). This is presented not solely as enacting obedience, but also as part of how people know God. Jeremiah 22: 15–16 queries:

Did not your father eat and drink
and do justice and righteousness?
Then it was well with him.
He judged the cause of the poor and needy;
then it was well.
Is not this to know me?
says the LORD.

In the text of Jeremiah, beliefs about God, emotions in relation to God and others, and the will to act justly or unjustly are not separate. These are all intertwined and equally under both the command and the judgment of God. Jeremiah 17:9 states,

I the LORD test the mind and search the heart,
to give to all according to their ways,
according to the fruit of their doings.

This braiding of heart, mind, and will in Jeremiah indicates what Saliers portrays as religious affections, which are central to his understanding of Christianity. He writes, “there is . . . a pattern of particular affections with constitutes and governs the life of the Christian.” More fully,

Whatever else it may include, the Christian faith is a pattern of deep emotions. It is gratitude to God for creation and redemption, awe and holy fear of the divine majesty, repentant sorrow over our sins, joy in God’s steadfast love and mercy, and love of God and neighbor. To confess faith in God is to live a life characterized by these emotions. The relation between being a Christian and possessing a pattern of such emotions is so intimate that anyone who lacks this particular gratitude, fear, penitence, joy, and love, can be said to be Christian in name only. To say that one loves God while dwelling in hatred for one’s neighbor is to misunderstand who God is. (1980: 8, 11–12)

Saliers argues that religious affections involve emotion, intellect, and will, in ways that are both intertwined and inseparable. Of course deep emotions and religious affections do not belong to Christians alone. What is distinctive to Christianity is the particular pattern of specific affections. These are not merely given or simply chosen by each individual, but are rather formed and rehearsed in Christian communities through studying Scripture, through communal worship, and—most central for Saliers’s work—through Christian practices of prayer. Repeated prayers of thanksgiving help form the affection of gratitude as an abiding disposition in the person. This affection is steadfast; it does not come and go quickly with changing circumstances. Saliers writes:

In learning new affections and desires, such as longing for the Kingdom of God, we also come to see why thanksgiving is appropriate in all circumstances of life. This does not require denial of our feelings of anger, terror, or anguish in the face of evil and death. But it does place these experiences within the sphere of life. . . . This is the peculiar incorrigibility of religious beliefs and affections which characterize the Christian life. Even when the world is filled with death, we give thanks, for God’s love endures forever. (1980: 58)

Saliers emphasizes that Christians are formed in a particular pattern of religious affections through prayer and worship that are rooted in Scripture. This is one way in which

Saliers envisions the relationship between Christians and the Bible. His writings on affections describe the “formation and shaping of our human passions by the Word.” This does not imply that Christianity is singular, nor that the Bible has a single meaning, nor that the Bible necessarily yields a single pattern of particular affections. Rather, Christianity—always a multiplicity of diverse communities—interprets and responds to Scripture in study, worship, and prayer. Participating in these ongoing traditions predisposes the Christian to understand, feel, and will in particular ways. Saliers also emphasizes that “no one should be deceived into thinking this is possible within the scope of human resources alone” (1980: 57–58). The grace of the Holy Spirit is necessary for integrated and steadfast affections.

“Passion” is another term within Christian discourse that indicates roughly the same territory as “affection.” Recognizing that the two terms are interchangeable in much Christian theology, Roman Catholic theologian G. Simon Harak prefers “passion” due to its connotation of “being moved.”² Passion indicates being affected by others, by circumstances, or by events. Like Saliers, Harak is interested in the intertwining of emotion, belief, and volition within Christian life. Like Saliers, he also contends that affections or passions are learned, formed through practices such as liturgy and prayer. Learning such abiding Christian dispositions—Christian virtue—is “learning how to be moved (angered, shamed, delighted, drawn) by the right persons and things, to the right extent, for the right reasons, in the right way, at the right time.”³

Where Saliers writes of a pattern of affections, Harak describes a “dossier” of passions that shape how a person interacts with the world. This dossier forms the person’s disposition, which involves emotion, intellect, and volition.⁴ One of Harak’s contributions is to emphasize that passions are learned in relationship. He explores how passions are formed in various ways, beginning with infant–caregiver relations. When he turns specifically to Christian passions, Harak analyzes the Spiritual Exercises of Ignatius of Loyola as an intensive training program that shapes the Christian’s dossier of passions in relationship with Jesus Christ. Through guided engagement with Scripture, the Exercises train the Christian to “feel with Jesus,” “struggle with Christ,” “labor with Christ,” and “be moved as Jesus was moved.”⁵ The relationship that enlivens and governs Christian affections is relationship with God. This relationship is the origin, sustaining energy, and goal of the formation of Christian affections. These affections are thus oriented to God or, to borrow a term from theologian Marilyn McCord Adams, “Godward.”

The category of affections, or passions, conveys that Christian faith is whole-personed, integrating intellect, emotion, and volition. This involves formation, in which Christians learn to understand, feel, and will in particular patterns. This formation occurs in communal practices—such as study, worship, and prayer—and is rooted in Christian interpretation and response to Scripture. Christian affections are steadfast, as they are formed over time and not easily swayed. Finally, Christian affections are formed in relationship with God and enabled by the Holy Spirit.

AMERICAN DIS-AFFECTION

In many ways, the notion of whole-personed Christian faith formed through practices and relationships sounds like simple common sense. Of course faith includes emotion and changes how people act in the world! Jesus commands: “You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your strength, and with all your mind; and your neighbor as yourself” (Luke 10:27). However, in other ways this description of faith is unusual, polemical, and threatening. I have noted three characteristics of Christian affections: They are integrated, steadfast, and Godward. Each of these is problematic in the contemporary United States.

Integration

In philosophy, theology, and social theory, integration of the whole person has not been a dominant goal in modern thought. Modernity has been marked by distinction, division, and specialization. In the seventeenth century, philosophical accounts of human knowledge emphasized the importance of reason, often in contrast with emotion, bodily sensation, and ethical commitments.⁶ In certain intellectual circles, religious rituals were derided as superstition.⁷ Formation in religious traditions was seen as an entryway for error and a cause of intolerance.⁸ A general approbation for religion governed by rationality was part of a shift in thinking about what constitutes faith. John Locke’s *The Reasonableness of Christianity*, published in 1695, portrays Christian faith as intellectual assent to propositional truth claims about God.⁹ In the early modern period, desire for tolerance among different religious groups helped fuel a tendency toward reducing Christianity to a minimum number of baseline beliefs. While the imperative toward ethical action was often included in such accounts, ritual practices and emotion were suspect.¹⁰

The past four hundred years have produced myriad critiques of the epistemology and theological anthropology of the early modern era. Yet even amid critiques and diverging views, it is still commonplace to conceptualize faith as assent to particular truth claims about God. It is easy to imagine that Christian faith makes no particular demands regarding abiding emotions that shape interactions with the world. There is not a shared cultural sense that Christian faith entails a distinctive pattern of deep emotions. Furthermore, the idea that such a pattern of emotions should be formed through disciplined practices cuts against the grain of American economic and political life. The various ideas associated with postmodernism have been the strongest criticism of modernity’s assumptions. However, postmodernism is also a continuation of modernity. Postmodernism does not honor the integrated person, but rather questions the possibility of integration and highlights the fragmentation of the self. The ideal of integration inherent in affections is, to put it bluntly, out of style.

In this light, the concept of affections is a defense of whole-personed Christianity and a polemic against early modern reductions of faith to mere belief. An appreciation for Christian affections runs counter to much of the philosophy and theology of the early modern period. Philosophically, the concept of affections—with its account of beliefs, emotions, and volition intertwined—contradicts epistemologies that valorized universal, abstract truth modeled after mathematical equations. Theologically, the concept of affections implies a theological anthropology quite different from early modern portrayals of the human person as an individual, autonomous, rational, free agent.

Steadfastness

In the hub of global consumer capitalism, emotions are profoundly commodified. Much of the American economy runs on advertisements that manipulate our emotions in order to promote sales of products and services. When we watch television, drive past billboards, read magazines, or visit websites, we are inundated by advertisements attempting to get us to buy something based on our emotional responses. On another level, in each of these situations, what is being bought and sold is our attention (i.e., access to our emotions). While television commercials sell products to consumers, television stations sell consumer attention to purveyors of products in the form of small segments of time wedged inside the sparkly setting of a show or sporting event. In order for this setup to function, consumerist economies need individuals to have predictably malleable emotions: easily swayed, not too intense, and brief in duration. Furthermore, we are formed to have precisely this type of emotional register, as the advertisement-entertainment cycle of emotional manipulation targets children and even infants. In this context, the idea of religious affections—that emotions should have an abiding character, that emotions should be intertwined with intellectual beliefs, and that belief-laden emotions formed in religious communities should shape how a person acts in the world—is countercultural and economically dangerous.

American culture does valorize one emotion: happiness. The Declaration of Independence states, “We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.” Our founding document declares that the government should be organized in the way that seems “most likely” to affect the “Safety and Happiness” of its citizens. Happiness is enshrined in America’s aspirational identity. It is the one goal that needs no further justification, the dearest clichéd wish of parents for their children, the lure and promise of innumerable magazine articles. It is peddled by massive pharmaceutical companies in direct-to-consumer advertising.

Increasingly, it is also a research topic, as polls and experiments attempt to measure and evaluate happiness. Who is happy and why? Where are people happy? What fosters happiness and what inhibits it? Researchers in various fields investigate connections between happiness and health, economics, biology, psychology, public policy, and various

other disciplines.¹¹ Gallup conducts polls regarding happiness, as do the Centers for Disease Control.¹² The United Nations commissioned a World Happiness Report, and there is a peer-reviewed *Journal of Happiness Studies*.¹³

The American fascination with happiness might appear to contradict my contention that our consumerist economy molds us to have plastic emotions suited for manipulation by advertising. It might appear that happiness is our national affection. However, the happiness pursued in contemporary American culture is not necessarily intertwined with beliefs and volition in the way that is characteristic of affections. The Declaration of Independence describes the right to the pursuit of happiness as a self-evident truth, using precisely the language of the early modern epistemology and anthropology that the concept of affection counters. In contemporary American culture, happiness is presented in a way that is remarkably untethered. In our cultural imagination, happiness does not require a “because” or “therefore.” It is a goal in itself, self-evidently worthwhile and requiring no further action beyond its own pursuit.

This untethered quality has prompted criticism of the American goal of happiness. Viktor Frankl, a neurologist, psychiatrist, and philosopher, wrote a book about his experiences in the Nazi concentration camps of World War II entitled *Man’s Search for Meaning*. It was first published in 1959. In it Frankl writes, “To the European, it is a characteristic of the American culture that, again and again, one is commanded and ordered to ‘be happy.’ But happiness cannot be pursued; it must ensue. One must have a reason to ‘be happy.’”¹⁴ Frankl’s own work emphasized meaning, a category that has been deployed in distinction from happiness in recent scholarship. Current studies of happiness often measure momentary pleasure while overlooking forms of satisfaction that result from caring for others and fulfilling longer-term commitments.¹⁵

Our collective striving toward happiness is not, then, an affection, which would necessarily include beliefs and volition. It is, I suspect, part of what makes our emotions so commercially malleable. Pursuing happiness untethered to beliefs or ethical actions, we are susceptible to many paths and promises for momentary pleasure.

God-Directed

In addition to malleability in our emotions and volition, consumer capitalism also requires that our emotions and volitions not be focused toward God. While advertisements generate quick emotions, over time they also shape us toward particular goals, including physical attractiveness through conformity to idealized norms, acclaim in professional life, wealth (or its appearance), and high-consuming family life. These goals are not only distinct from God, they are also in conflict with the emotions and desires that God has for humanity, as described in the prophetic texts. Jeremiah states that God “delights” in “justice and righteousness in the earth” (Jer 9:24). When the community delights in things other than God, or God’s righteousness and justice, this is portrayed as foolishness and idolatry. Jeremiah prophesies exile and destruction for those who trust in their own “strongholds” and “treasures,” rather than in God’s righteousness (48:7).

The converse of Jeremiah's wisdom is this: trusting in God and delighting in righteousness counters the desire for human strongholds of wealth, work, or status, as well as the value of worldly treasures. This means that God-directed affections are an obstacle to consumer capitalism. In the fourth century, Augustine wrote to God, "thou hast made us for thyself and restless is our heart until it comes to rest in thee."¹⁶ Our twenty-first-century economy of consumption relies upon our hearts staying restless.

Of course, advertisements are not the only type of formation to which we are exposed. Every school, club, team, and business socializes its members toward particular goals and ideals, even if these remain unstated. Political engagement and national identity likewise inculcate particular values. Everyone is formed through multiple relationships, from the infant and caregiver bond to our neighborhoods and coworkers. For the most part, the thoughts, emotions, and desires created through these various relationships exist in something of a hodge-podge, with moments of similarity and conflict. However, formation in relationship with God threatens the flourishing jumble. Formation in relationship with God has a totalizing effect, mitigating all other claims, ordering all other desires. Exodus 20:3 states, "You shall have no other gods before me." Furthermore, formation in relationship with God directly counters some other types of formation, as it inculcates care for the poor, compassion for the suffering, humility, and other virtues.

CONSUMING APATHY

Christian affections are integrated, steadfast, and Godward. Contemporary American culture works against all three of these characteristics, with fragmenting views of the human person, the commodification of malleable emotions, and sites of formation that shape us toward ideals both different from, and counter to, relationship with God. These three aspects of contemporary culture combine to produce apathy.

In *The Prophetic Imagination*, Walter Brueggemann describes the situation into which the prophets of the Hebrew Bible speak as one of "world-weariness, satiation, boredom, and vanity."¹⁷ One of the roots of this predicament was the affluence enjoyed by some members of the empire. When a significant portion of the population has enough, the need for freedom and justice for all persons can appear less urgent. Power differentials and economic inequity can become further exacerbated as those who have enough want more. They become immune to the idea that those who have less are equals, not servants. Connecting Solomon's empire to current reality, Brueggemann writes, "As we know from our own recent past, such an exploitative appetite can develop insatiable momentum so that, no matter how much in the way of goods or power or security is obtained, it is never enough" (2001: 27). The affluence of one segment of the population helps generate a culture aimed at achieving self-satisfaction, where satiation is the goal. This kind of culture exists in a mutually sustaining relationship with empire. Brueggemann calls this "a royal consciousness committed to achievable satiation" (37).

There is a kind of “numbness” with satiation—having enough and never enough—that Brueggemann terms a “consuming apathy” (xx, 40).

Brueggemann interprets Solomon’s empire-building success as also a direct betrayal of the community and consciousness formed by Moses. “[Solomon] had traded a vision of freedom for the reality of security. He had banished the neighbor for the sake of reducing everyone to servants. He had replaced covenanting with consuming, and all promises had been reduced to tradable commodities” (2001: 13). Brueggemann links this explicitly with the loss of passion. Describing the shift from a Mosaic to Solomonic consciousness, Brueggemann writes, “The gift of freedom was taken over by the yearning for order. The human agenda of justice was utilized for security. The god of freedom and justice was co-opted for an eternal now. And in the place of passion comes satiation.” Passion here refers to “the capacity and readiness to care, to suffer, to die, and to feel” and it is, Brueggemann contends, “the enemy of imperial reality.” He writes: “Imperial economics is designed to keep people satiated so that they do not notice. Its politics is intended to block out the cries of the denied ones. Its religion is to be an opiate so that no one discerns misery alive in the heart of God” (2001: 35).

The dynamic here is odd yet familiar. Want and plenty are not opposites in this scenario, for it is plenty that creates want. In part, this is because the abundance is not distributed equally in the community. In part, it is because the plenty is not the right sort of abundance. The satiation Brueggemann analyzes is an overflowing plate with no nutritional value that leaves the diner hungrier than she was before the meal. Our desires can be fulfilled and overfilled, but this will not help if we want the wrong things. We seek satiation from things that cannot truly satisfy, and so we never have enough. We grow distracted from everything but our own all-consuming consumption.

Brueggemann states clearly that his depiction of the Solomonic royal consciousness also characterizes the cultural situation in which he wrote *The Prophetic Imagination*, which was first published in 1978. His portrait of America as a place of consumerist empire in which individuals and communities are numbed by satiation seems prescient. Yet I wonder if anyone in 1978 could have imagined the emotional landscape of the United States today. Brueggemann describes an affluence that leads to a constant desire for more in such a way that numbness and apathy ensues. What happens when the affluence is not full plates as much as constant influx of emotional stimulation? News of the joys and suffering of people around the world is instantly available to us, as our emotional responses are sought, sold, and monitored. Brueggemann wrote this text during the Cold War, before the fall of the Berlin Wall. It was before home computers were widely used, long before people had laptops and cell phones. He wrote this account of consuming apathy, of numbness due to satiation, before the twenty-four-hour news cycle started, before the World Wide Web was invented. He wrote this account before search engines such as Google provided access to an exploding universe of information, while also tracking our online activities and personal information, curating the kinds of information offered to us based on our own particular likes and dislikes. Brueggemann’s preface to the second edition of *The Prophetic Imagination* was written before 9/11 altered expectations of media coverage, before Facebook was invented,

before Twitter fueled the Arab Spring, before social media existed. The very aspects of American culture that he identified as problematic in 1978 have become exponentially more pronounced, while Brueggemann continues to levy his powerful critique.

The terms “empathy fatigue” and “compassion fatigue” have been coined to describe the diminishment of concern that results from ongoing or repeated exposure to the suffering of others. These phrases have been applied most specifically to workers who provide direct care, such as hospice workers, nurses, or counselors. Those who deal with human suffering, day to day and face to face, can become somewhat desensitized through emotional exhaustion. Some researchers suggest that these terms also could be applied more broadly to general populations that are repeatedly exposed through the media to the suffering of others.¹⁸ While donations might pour in after the first severe hurricane in a given year, after the fifth hurricane they are less generous. This might be partly due to financial concerns, yet research suggests that compassion fatigue also plays a role.¹⁹

It is unclear how recent changes in technology, including the advent of smart phones and social media, will affect the emotional capacities of contemporary Americans. One can imagine that the increasing influx of emotional stimuli might contribute to an advanced case of the consuming apathy that Brueggemann describes. While we are consuming—both goods and emotional stimuli—it is important to remember that our attention and emotions are also being consumed. Our empathy, outrage, fear, and desire are the grease that keeps the wheels of our consumer economy rolling. They are skillfully manipulated, directed, bought, and sold.²⁰ Somewhat paradoxically, the numbness of consumerist empire is not due to a lack of emotions, but rather an overabundance of quick, shallow responses that make deep and abiding emotions—such as the affection of compassion—difficult.

TEACHING AFFECTION

Saliers and Harak both point to sustained, disciplined religious practices as key to forming affections. Yet there are times when such practices appear inadequate to the task, either because the practices are not being performed well or because the countervailing societal forces are overwhelming. Both Jeremiah and Amos attest to these difficulties. Jeremiah declares that simply performing the rituals of worship, without justice and obedience, is not enough. “Your burnt offerings are not acceptable, nor are your sacrifices pleasing to me” (Jer 6:20). Amos says likewise:

I hate, I despise your festivals, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies. Even though you offer me your burnt offerings and grain offerings, I will not accept them; and the offerings of well-being of your fatted animals I will not look upon. Take away from me the noise of your songs; I will not listen to the melody of your harps. But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream (Amos 5:21–24).

While worship can and should play a vital role in forming religious affections, it can become fragmented, such that it does not engage emotions, intellect, and will together. If worship does not address all of these aspects of the human person, then it loses its capacity to form affections. While Amos speaks clearly of worship that is lacking the will to justice, one can imagine that worship could also be fragmented by lacking sincere belief about God, or lacking appropriate emotion. If any one of these is lost, then worship is broken and distorted.

Saliers emphasizes that the distinctive pattern of specifically Christian affections is learned through studying Scripture, worship, and prayer. Harak stresses that passions are shaped in relationship, but this also involves intense study of biblical texts as the norm and medium of relationship with God. The words of the prophets, as biblical texts, are included as vital to learning affections for both Harak and Saliers. One of the things the prophets do is speak a word of wholly formed affections, a word that can both shatter and reform our own affections.

Brueggemann argues that one of the essential tasks of the prophets who addressed the Solomonic empire was to “cut through the numbness.”²¹ This involves bringing the fears and grief of the community into public expression. Such expression is not the mere reporting of something already felt, but rather the provision of language, metaphors, and symbols that enable individuals to experience passions and to share them communally. The passions that Brueggemann believes will counter the royal consciousness are not simply strong emotions unconnected to anything else. Rather, they are rooted in the reality of God. For Brueggemann, it is because God is free that empire is false, because God cares for the marginalized that apathy is unacceptable, because God has promised faithfulness that the pain of hope must be borne. God is a God of passion. God “is one whose person is presented as passion and pathos, the power to care, the capacity to weep, the energy to grieve and then to rejoice” (2001: 36–37). Here Brueggemann is drawing upon the work of Abraham Heschel.

In his classic text *The Prophets*, Heschel describes the words of the prophets as breaking through emotional numbness. He states, “Reading the words of the prophets is a strain on the emotions, wrenching one’s conscience from the state of suspended animation.” At times his imagery is even violent: “The situation of a person immersed in the prophets’ words is one of being exposed to a ceaseless shattering of indifference, and one needs a skull of stone to remain callous to such blows.”²²

Heschel frames the emotional power of the prophets’ words within a larger argument regarding the pathos of God. Long traditions in both theology and philosophy assert that God must be impassive. Some who argue for the impassivity of God assert that a God who suffers in response to others would be dependent, derivative, or unstable. The freedom and power of God would be compromised. For others, the assertion that God is impassive is linked to a general devaluation of emotion in contrast to reason. While the Bible includes numerous depictions of God displaying emotions in response to human activity, those who believe God must be impassive often interpret these depictions as pedagogical. In order to educate humanity about the Divine, God is described as having emotions such as anger and jealousy. Heschel rejects the idea that these accounts of God

as emotional are simply educational illustrations. He argues that such readings are fundamentally based on a depreciation of pathos and are simply inconsistent with biblical texts. For Heschel, the words of the prophets affirm that God is concerned with humanity. He writes, “God does not stand outside the range of human suffering and sorrow. He is personally involved in, even stirred by, the conduct and fate of [humanity].” God is “also moved and affected by what happens in the world, and reacts accordingly.”²³ Within this frame, Heschel describes the prophets as experiencing “*sympathy with the divine pathos*.”²⁴ Reading the words of the prophets is an emotional strain because these words impart the pathos of God. The reader is impassioned by God’s pathos, by the strange wonder that God is concerned with the world.

Brueggemann describes the prophet Jeremiah as sharing in and expressing the grief of God. The prophet becomes a mediating figure between God and Judah in a way that includes bringing the pathos of God to public expression and asking the community to grieve with God. Jeremiah has a “ministry of articulated grief” that publicly expresses the grief of God and thereby provides language, symbols, and metaphors that allow and demand the people of Judah to grieve with God.²⁵

Looking at this through the conceptual lens of affections described earlier, it appears that Jeremiah is modeling holy affections for the people of Judah. His participation in divine pathos both shatters apathy and performs affections appropriate for the people of God. This is a pedagogy of affections that are integrated, steadfast, and God-directed.

The prophetic pedagogy of affections is bimodal. First, it deconstructs apathy and malformed affections. This is done by fierce participation in the pathos of God, which undoes apathy, and by declaring the judgment of God, which rejects malformed affections. Second, through the very same means of participation and judgment, the prophets offer a glimpse of well-formed affections. The full formation of affections happens over time, through disciplined religious practices, but the prophets take part in the constructive process by showing us something of what it looks like. The prophets call us out when our affections are lacking or malformed, and they instruct us on what well-formed affections should be. In various places, the prophets speak specifically to the characteristics of affections described earlier; affections are integrated, steadfast, and God-directed.

Integrated

Amos holds our feet to the fire regarding integration, pointing out the places where our emotions, beliefs, and volition do not cohere. The book of Amos begins with God pledging to punish Israel’s neighbors for their transgressions. This is quickly followed by an indictment of Judah and Israel. Any relish of the oracles against the nations is turned on its head when the prophet’s true target is revealed. Those who are in covenant with God have transgressed as much as their neighbors. Amos 3:2 states, “You only have I known of all the families of the earth; therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities.” The intimate relationship between God and Israel does not mean that Israel has extra latitude to behave badly. Rather, because the people of Judah and Israel know

something of who God is, their emotions and actions should be in accord with their beliefs about God.

Judah and Israel are rebuked specifically for breaking covenant with God through disobedience and injustice. “For three transgressions of Judah, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they have rejected the law of the LORD, and have not kept his statutes” (Amos 2:4). “For three transgressions of Israel, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they sell the righteous for silver, and the needy for a pair of sandals” (Amos 2:6). This can also be seen as judgment on the disintegration of affections. The people are indifferent to the needy—their emotions do not align with who God shows Godself to be through relationship with the people, including the law. The people exploit the poor—their actions do not align with who they know God to be.

In response to indifference to the needy and exploitation of the poor, God threatens exile, mourning, and lamentation. It can be useful to consider the covenant between God and Israel in light of suzerain treaties in the context of the ancient Near East. God then appears as “the suzerain par excellence in Israel.”²⁶ The honor or shaming given by the suzerain to vassals influenced social hierarchy among the vassals. For God to diminish Israel right along with her neighbors is, in effect, a public shaming that alters her social status. The words of Amos undo Judah and Israel, and threaten their security, hope, status in the world, and conception of their status in relationship with the divine.

Yet Amos’s statements of judgment are set between the oracles to the nations at the beginning of the book and the promise of restoration at the end. God’s judgment is not the final word—there is an opportunity for repentance and a promise of restoration. Carolyn Sharp writes, “this is precisely Amos’s goal: to humble his audience so that they can be spiritually ready to encounter God.”²⁷ Also, by participating in God’s concern for the poor, Amos models affections that are well formed in relationship with God. This is bimodal prophetic pedagogy.

Steadfast

The topic of Israel’s fickle ways appears in numerous prophetic books, often in sharp contrast to God’s unwavering faithfulness. In Exodus 34:6, God describes Godself:

The LORD, the LORD,
a God merciful and gracious,
slow to anger,
and abounding in steadfast love
and faithfulness,
keeping steadfast love for the
thousandth generation.

Jeremiah pronounces God’s judgment on the fickleness of Israel. The people do not respond to God with incorrigible affections that abide even when circumstances change.

Instead, they complain and rebel against God (Jer 2:29) and seek favor elsewhere. One of the metaphors that Jeremiah uses to describe this fickleness concerns water. Instead of accepting the life-giving water from God, the people look for refreshment in other places. Jeremiah 2:13 states, “my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living water, and dug out cisterns for themselves, cracked cisterns that can hold no water.” The “apostasies” of Israel are described as going to Egypt, “to drink the waters of the Nile,” and going to Assyria, “to drink the waters of the Euphrates” (Jer 2:19, 17).

Another metaphor Jeremiah employs is that of adultery. Israel, who once was as devoted to the LORD as a bride to her husband, is now “faithless” (Jer 2:2; 3:6). Israel is portrayed as an adulteress who takes many lovers. “[A]s a faithless wife leaves her husband, so you have been faithless to me, O house of Israel, says the LORD” (Jer 3:20).

The harsh judgment of Israel’s fickle ways is accompanied by moments of assurance of God’s steadfastness. The faithless are commanded to return, relying on God to “heal [their] faithlessness” (Jer 3:22). This is not entirely comforting, since God’s steadfastness is reflected in intolerance for sin as well as willingness to forgive. Jeremiah echoes the words of Exodus in his prayer, saying, “You show steadfast love to the thousandth generation” (Jer 32:18). The LORD uses the same language in promising restoration, declaring that the streets of Judah and Jerusalem shall once more ring with

“the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride, the voices of those who sing, as they bring thank offerings to the house of the LORD:

‘Give thanks to the LORD of Hosts,
for the LORD is good,
for his steadfast love endures forever!’” (Jer 33:11).

Jeremiah rebukes Israel’s lack of steadfast affections, calls the people back to faithfulness, and provides a glimpse of what steadfast affection would be.

God-Directed

The difficulty of having affections that are not directed by and toward God is perhaps the most common target of prophetic judgment, for it is a type of idolatry. Like Amos, Hosea employs a bimodal prophetic pedagogy in affections. First, Hosea pronounces judgment on the people of Israel for breaking covenant with God and worshiping idols. “Set the trumpet to your lips! One like a vulture is over the house of the LORD, because they have broken my covenant, and transgressed my law” (Hos 8:1). And again, “[w]ith their silver and gold they made idols for their own destruction” (Hos 8:4). Like a husband made cuckold, God is shamed by Israel’s unfaithfulness.

If Amos’s words serve to humble the people, Hosea’s go further. They shame Israel. Some of the mechanisms for shame are quite explicit. God threatens to strip Israel naked, which was a cultural practice for shaming people, particularly enemy prisoners.

Israel is shamed by being called a whore and a harlot, and threatened with barrenness and miscarriage in a cultural setting wherein having children conveyed honor (Hos 9:11, 14). Other mechanisms for shaming Israel in the book of Hosea are less explicit but no less powerful. Sharp notes that the place-names mentioned throughout the text refer to sites of Israel's past unfaithfulness. She writes, "The history suggested by the place-names in Hosea is a stunning history of transgression, illegitimate desire, and death. Every time the audience figures out another reference in Hosea's subtext, they deepen their own shame."²⁸

Second, Hosea's pronouncement of judgment is also the public expression of the pathos of God. Hosea's witness tells us, according to Sharp, "that idolatry wounds the heart of God." The prophet's words "convey God's anguish about a beloved who has repeatedly gone astray."²⁹ Hosea, participating in the pathos of God, models what integrated, steadfast, God-directed affections look like and instructs the people on how to feel, think and act well in relationship with God. The prophet pleads, "Return, O Israel, to the LORD your God," and God promises to "heal their disloyalty" and bring abundant new life (Hos 14:1, 4, 5–7). Hosea's words guide belief (only God should be worshiped), emotion (embarrassment and remorse for breaking covenant relation), and volition (the will to amend behavior and return to God). Furthermore, this affection is learned in relation to God.

OPPOSING APATHY

While I have looked to three prophets to explore how they counter affections malformed in three ways, these separations are largely heuristic. Injustice, fickleness, and idolatry are deeply intertwined. God cares for all, particularly the poor, the stranger, the orphan, and the widow. Therefore, faithfulness to God entails justice, while injustice speaks of honoring something (wealth, comfort, prestige, security) before God. Jeremiah announces God's judgment for all three offenses. As mentioned earlier, Jeremiah calls out the fickleness of looking for living water in all cracked cisterns and foreign rivers, complaining and rebelling against God when things get rough, and taking lovers other than God. Jeremiah 2:26–28 condemns Judah's idolatry:

As a thief is shamed when caught, so the house of Israel shall be shamed—they, their kings, their officials, their priests, and their prophets, who say to a tree, "You are my father," and to a stone, "You gave me birth." For they have turned their backs to me, but not their faces. But in the time of their trouble they say, "Come and save us!" But where are your gods that you made for yourself: Let them come, if they can save you, in your time of trouble; for you have as many gods as you have towns, O Judah."

And in Jeremiah 5:28–29, Judah is called out for injustice: "they do not judge with justice the cause of the orphan, to make it prosper, and they do not defend the rights of the needy. Shall I not punish them for these things?"

Fickleness, idolatry, and injustice are all mixed together in Jeremiah, as offenses against God. When seen in the light of religious affections, this makes perfect sense. Beliefs about who God is are necessarily intertwined with emotions and also with volition. Believing that God cares for all and demands justice requires willing justice and working toward it. Of course (especially taking into account a Christian doctrine of sin) we fall short of this goal, but we at least are moving toward it. Therefore if we are not yearning and striving for justice, we do not truly believe that God cares for all. Whatever we are worshiping, it is not the God of the prophets; we are likely changing our direction, looking for whatever might sanctify our own selfishness.

The prophets spoke a needed word in their own contexts and they do so in ours, as well. There are numerous factors that work toward the malformation of Christian affections. We are shaped through all sorts of social forces to have affections that are not fully formed or are simply malformed. We not integrated: our emotions, beliefs, and volition do not cohere. We are not steadfast: we are trained to have malleable, easily commodified desires. We are not God-directed: what affections we do have are rarely formed from and toward God, energized by the Holy Spirit. Badly formed and overwhelmed by a surfeit of emotional stimulation, we are world-weary. We need the bimodal pedagogy of the prophets to shatter us by bringing the pathos of God into our communities, and by showing us what holy affections look like.

NOTES

1. Nicholas Wolterstorff, *Divine Discourse: Philosophical Reflections on the Claim that God Speaks* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1995), 185.
2. G. Simon Harak, *Virtuous Passions: The Formation of Christian Character* (New York: Paulist, 1993), 3. Harak discusses Saliers's work on pp. 41–43 and uses “passions” and “affections” interchangeably on p. 47.
3. Harak, *Virtuous Passions*, 3. Note that part of the difference in word choice is based on conversation partners. While Saliers's primary conversation partner on this issue is Edwards, Harak is here drawing upon Aristotle.
4. Harak makes a substantial contribution to this discourse about passions and affections by recognizing the role of the body in this dossier. Whereas Saliers emphasizes the interplay between intellect and emotion, Harak persuasively argues for the centrality of embodiment in Christian passions and in knowledge, more generally. I have engaged this aspect of Harak's work in *The Empty Church: Theater, Theology, and Bodily Hope* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2014). In this text I include “body” in my description of whole-personed faith.
5. Harak, *Virtuous Passions*, 106, 110, 116, 120.
6. Abraham Heschel (1962) traces the history of dualism between reason and emotion back through Greek philosophy and Stoicism. He provides a wide-ranging analysis of passion or pathos in theology and philosophy across centuries and among religious traditions.
7. See John Locke, *The Reasonableness of Christianity: As Delivered in the Scriptures* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1999), 57, 68. A fuller exploration of this issue would engage the relationship between deriding ritual and anti-Judaism.

8. For examples of this type of thinking, see René Descartes, *Discourse on Method and Related Writings*, trans. Desmond M. Clarke (New York: Penguin Books, 1999) and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *Émile*, trans. Barbara Foxley (London: Everyman, 1993).
9. See Locke, *Reasonableness of Christianity*.
10. See Matthew Tindal, *Christianity as Old as the Creation* (New York: Garland, 1978). Early modern reductions of Christianity to belief have been very influential, but they have also been highly contested. Jonathan Edwards, an avid student of Locke's work, developed his defense of religious affections in order to expand the early modern discourse. Jonathan Edwards, *A Treatise Concerning Religious Affections: In Three Parts* (Edinburgh: Printed for W. Laing and J. Matthews, 1789). See also Kathryn Reklis, *Theology and the Kinesthetic Imagination: Jonathan Edwards and the Making of Modernity* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2014).
11. There are many recent books on happiness available, including Daniel Todd Gilbert, *Stumbling on Happiness* (New York: Knopf, 2006) and Jonathan Haidt, *The Happiness Hypothesis: Finding Modern Truth in Ancient Wisdom* (New York: Basic Books, 2006).
12. Founded in 1935, Gallup, Inc., is a consulting company in Washington, D.C., that conducts polling and other research to analyze public opinion in the United States on political, economic, and social issues. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention is a public health agency of the US Department of Health & Human Services. Founded in 1946 and with headquarters in Atlanta, Georgia, the CDC addresses matters of infectious disease, environmental health, workplace safety, and other issues related to the health of US citizens.
13. John F. Helliwell, Richard Layard, Jeffrey Sachs, Sustainable Development Solutions Network, and Columbia Earth Institute. *World Happiness Report 2013* (New York: Sustainable Development Solutions Network, 2013) and *Journal of Happiness Studies* (Netherlands: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 2000).
14. Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (New York: Washington Square Press, 1984), 162.
15. See Roy F. Baumeister, Kathleen D. Vohs, Jennifer L. Aaker, and Emily N. Garbinsky, "Some Key Differences between a Happy Life and a Meaningful Life," *Journal of Positive Psychology* 8/6 (2013): 505–516. Some research finds that acts of kindness result in feelings of happiness, and other studies recount that remembering the happiness that resulted from prior acts of generosity can prompt current acts of generosity. See Kathryn E. Buchanan and Anat Bardi, "Acts of Kindness and Acts of Novelty Affect Life Satisfaction," *Journal of Social Psychology* 150(3) (2010): 235–237. See also Lara B. Aknin, Elizabeth W. Dunn, and Michael I. Norton, "Happiness Runs in a Circular Motion: Evidence for a Positive Feedback Loop between Prosocial Spending and Happiness," *Journal of Happiness Studies* 13(2) (April 2012): 347–355.
16. Augustine, *Confessions* (The Library of Christian Classics Vol. VII, *Augustine: Confessions and Enchiridion*, trans. and ed. by Albert C. Outler; Philadelphia: Westminster, 1955), 31.
17. Brueggemann 2001: 33. In this passage Brueggemann suggests that the tone of Ecclesiastes reflects the Solomonic empire, although the date does not.
18. Katherine N. Kinnick, Dean M. Krugman, and Glen T. Cameron, "Compassion Fatigue: Communication and Burnout toward Social Problems," *Journalism & Mass Communication Quarterly* 73(3) (1996): 687–707.
19. Deborah I. Frank and Sally P. Karioth, "Measuring Compassion Fatigue in Public Health Nurses Providing Assistance to Hurricane Victims," *Southern Online Journal of Nursing Research* 7(4) (Nov 2006): 1–13 (7). I have written about this subject briefly in "Kairos in

- the Chronos: Prophetic Calls in Contemporary Culture,” *Philosophy and Theology* 23(2) (2011): 257–276.
20. For one level of analysis of this, see Susan D. Moeller, *Compassion Fatigue: How the Media Sell Disease, Famine, War and Death* (New York: Routledge, 1999).
21. Brueggemann 2001: 45; see also 50.
22. Heschel 1962: 8, xxv.
23. Heschel 1962: 288–289. Note that Heschel demurs from metaphysical discussions of the essence of God; see 619–621.
24. Heschel 1962: 31, emphasis original.
25. Brueggemann 2001: 48–49. On prophets as mediating figures, see Carolyn J. Sharp, *Old Testament Prophets for Today* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2009), 15; and Bruce C. Birch, Walter Brueggemann, Terence E. Fretheim, and David L. Petersen, *A Theological Introduction to the Old Testament* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1999), 300.
26. Saul M. Olyan, “Honor, Shame, and Covenant Relations in Ancient Israel and Its Environment,” *JBL* 115 (1996): 201–218 (205).
27. Sharp, *Old Testament Prophets for Today*, 39.
28. Sharp, *Old Testament Prophets for Today*, 47.
29. Sharp, *Old Testament Prophets for Today*, 44, 41.

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CHAPTER 33

THE PROPHETS AND ETHICS

TRACI C. WEST

THE Hebrew Bible is often cited in the constructive claims of Christian ethics that describe how religious insights should address social problems.¹ Its texts are also lifted up by Christian social activists decrying the moral consequences found in specific unjust public practices. In most cases these references to Hebrew Bible passages by Christian ethicists and activists are likely to include the insistent words of the prophets. The moral approach and concerns of the Hebrew prophets have been particularly evident in Christian liberationist theo-ethics in the Americas, as well as some decolonial analyses in Africana religious studies.² Language such as Amos's "let justice roll down like waters" (Amos 5:24) or Micah's "what does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with God?" (Mic 6:9) commonly imbue the justice goals of social ethics and activism with foundational theological meaning.

Isaiah's vision was invoked by Martin Luther King, Jr., in what was perhaps one of the most well-known and celebrated public oratory expressions of Christian social ethics in twentieth-century US history. In his "I Have a Dream" speech at the 1963 March on Washington, King proclaimed: "I have a dream that one day every valley shall be exalted, every hill and mountain shall be made low, the rough places shall be made plain, and the crooked places shall be made straight and the glory of the Lord will be revealed and all flesh shall see it together" (Isa 40:4–5). He was protesting the maintenance of racist segregation in everyday Southern life that was based on a belief held by most white Christians at that time in white people's inherent superiority. King thereby identified Isaiah's universal claim, "all flesh shall see it together" (Isa 40:5), with an anti-racist understanding of the equality of all human "flesh."

Declarations in the books of the prophets about God's judgment against those who exploit the poor, as in Ezekiel's claim "[n]ow this was the sin of your sister Sodom: she and her daughters were arrogant, overfed and unconcerned; they did not help the poor and needy" (Ezek 16:49), and poetic peaceable images such as "[t]he wolf shall live with the lamb, the leopard shall lie down with the kid, the calf and the lion and the fatling together, and a little child shall lead them" (Isa 11:6) can help to constitute a baseline vision for liberative Christian social ethics. They can offer criteria for measuring the ethical

adequacy of Christian social vision and offer guidelines for how the kin-dom of God should be realized in contemporary communal relations. Yet what kinds of patriarchal messages are also inculcated within a vision such as Ezekiel's (16:49)? Ezekiel's assertion about the immorality of Sodom (exploitation of the poor) utilizes the common literary device found in the prophets of metaphorical references to femaleness to depict the people's sinfulness. When the Hebrew prophets are cited with an untroubled interpretation of their contribution to Christian ethical claims, certain distorting aspects of scripturally based ethics may be neglected. In some instances, proscriptive messages derived from the prophets can carry implications that stymie the conceptualization of justice in Christian ethics and impede the potential for its lived actuality in social practices, even as they inspire scrutiny of injustice.

METHODOLOGICAL CONSIDERATIONS: THE BASICS AND THE AMBIGUITIES

There is a temptation to gloss over any hermeneutical impediments to acquiring a consistently righteous social vision from the Hebrew prophets. This scripture provides such useful tools for articulating core concerns for Christian social ethics. The blistering rhetorics of critique displayed by the prophets are unique and varied in calling attention to religious and political hypocrisy and corruption. They offer contemporary Christian communities models of sorrowful lament for and angry denunciation of injustice. They hold the capacity to break open moral imaginations frozen in deadened indifference to the prevalence of systemic hypocrisies and corruption in churches and society. But if one probes the cultural assumptions underlying the denunciations and laments of the prophets as well as the lenses that interpreters bring to those texts, pivotal ethical concerns can surface. They are related to the method of interpretation. As Christian feminist Hebrew Bible scholar Susanne Scholz explains, the "Bible has undoubtedly shaped culture but culture too has shaped the biblical meaning—which itself is shifting, turning, and open rather than historically fixed, static, and closed."³ This kind of attention to the role of culture is crucial. It ensures the incorporation of perspectives from the Hebrew prophets within Christian ethics in a manner more meaningful than the appropriation of scriptural verses as slogans for current moral agendas.

The significance of methodological ethics concerns is especially noticeable when gender is taken into consideration. Certain metaphorical references to femaleness and female embodiment in the Hebrew prophets provide apt examples. There are references to sexual violence against women, mocking images of the whore/prostitute/adulteress, or to life and death in the womb that can inform contemporary debates about abortion rights. A focus on *how* to interpret the fierce rhetoric and vivid poetry of the Hebrew prophets for contemporary Christian ethics becomes more urgent and complicated. The incorporation of gender analysis can be especially revealing for

an ethics focus on biblical hermeneutics, but always as a part of the broader cultural production of meaning related to political realities such as colonialism in the ancient B.C.E. world. This gendered sociopolitical lens allows for some disruption in the uninterrogated conferral of moral authority to exclusively male (prophetic) speech-acts captured in these texts. And unfortunately, the tendency to leave undisturbed the intellectual limitations and warped understandings of human capacities that are attached to such exclusivity too often continue to be standard hermeneutical practice in religious studies.⁴

Admittedly, there may be inherent tensions between the core aims of the prophetic vocation and the crafting of ethics that can also contribute to the hermeneutical challenges involved in how Christian ethical reflection can access prophetic material with integrity. Christian ethicist Joe Pettit distinguishes between ethicists and prophets. Prophets powerfully denounce and “point to injustice and, in so doing, demand a response. Ethicists take their time trying to figure out what that response should be, and they are right to take their time, as the proper response may be highly complex and quite tentative. The power of the prophet, on the other hand, is diminished by complexity and tentativeness.”⁵ Pettit may underestimate the cultural politics entangled in how ethicists utilize the power of the prophet to authorize their claims, even when they formulate tentative and complex responses. Yet he identifies what can be a difficult but perhaps also a creative analytical tension to maintain. Such a tension results when one attends to the layers of cultural politics encompassed in the process of interpreting the Hebrew prophets. This tension may be particularly apparent if the task of deciphering gendered messages from these androcentric ancient perspectives becomes a routine element of one’s interpretation. By unpacking these cultural layers, more tentative appropriations of the prophetic material for ethical claims become necessary. They must coexist within a method that also includes unambiguous, declarative assertions about what should be considered ethical human relations.

I discuss method in this chapter in order to reveal some of the distinctive ways in which Christian social ethics has appropriated and engaged the Hebrew prophets. Neither exhaustive nor intended as typical representations of the field, I have selected three differing approaches that illustrate how the message of the Hebrew prophets can be understood in Christian ethics. Walter Rauschenbusch pioneers a social ethics understanding of the prophets as essential to Christian moral history. Emilie Townes finds Christian ethical significance in the form of lament in Joel. Selected social activist appropriations of prophetic language demonstrate embodied, lived ethics. All of them offer contrasting hermeneutical methods that address US sociopolitical contexts: Rauschenbusch in New York; Townes on healthcare crises that impact African American communities nationally, and social activism and political leadership especially in Massachusetts, California, Ohio, and Illinois. I recognize the limitations in the contextual particularity of this focus in light of the broad spectrum of Christian and Jewish religious communities that claim this scripture as morally significant around the globe. But I utilize my own US context in an attempt to emulate the self-critical, sociopolitical specificity of the material in the Hebrew prophets. All of the methodological

illustrations offered here highlight the goals of ethicists in articulating contributions that prophetic material from the Hebrew Bible can make to Christian ethics.

Assessing the variations among an array of approaches underscores the invitation to pay attention to method in Christian ethics. That is, ethics involves some parsing of how moral claims are conceived. How does one identify the ways in which the Hebrew prophets equip Christian believers with ethical vision? Many of the lively discussions of the Hebrew prophets and ethics have focused on the range and content of the ethical ideas raised in those texts, highlighting how the prophets reflect on political and religious issues of their time. Many religion scholars, primarily those in biblical studies, engage in the endeavor of clarifying the historical distinctiveness of the ethical ideas of the prophets. Several have wrestled to varying degrees with the challenge of figuring out what constitutes an authentic representation of the sociopolitical realities of Israel from the eighth to the sixth centuries B.C.E. as depicted by the prophets. At the same time, those scholars try to find within those depictions subject matter relatable to contemporary religious and political concerns. Their primary concern is with offering a nuanced and accurate interpretation of “the ethics of Israel’s prophets.”⁶ Or, said differently, this scholarly focus concentrates on helping the contemporary reader to understand the distinct moral worldviews present in the Hebrew prophets and how they may or may not be translatable to present moral concerns.

In more topical approaches, some Christian ethicists rely upon non-biblical sources to help make this translation. They utilize a conjoined approach to biblical and non-biblical sources. Hilary Marlow writes about contemporary Christian environmental ethics derived from the Hebrew prophets.⁷ Her contemporary ethic concentrates on “the principle of interconnectivity,” drawing on a shared basis from both the science of ecology and the worldviews articulated by the prophets in which they assume a fundamental interrelationship between God, human beings, and the natural world.⁸ At times Christian ethicists can appear insufficiently cautious in making the hermeneutical leap from the contexts of the biblical authors to current ones. Christian ethicist Kyle Fedler includes a chapter on the Hebrew prophets as he makes a broader case for recognizing the biblical foundations of Christian morality. He reflects on Jeremiah 2:23–25, a passage that concludes in verse 25: “But you said, ‘It is hopeless, for I have loved strangers, and after them I will go.’” Fedler points out the section (vv 23–24) where the prophet compares the unfaithful love of foreign gods by the people Jeremiah addressed “to a sex-crazed camel in heat.”⁹ Fedler then asks, “Does the same kind of divided loyalty characterize the contemporary worshipers of Yahweh known as Christians?”¹⁰ He answers this question affirmatively, concluding that the “number of other gods in our society are as numerous as the gods of the ancient world.”¹¹ He lists examples of tempting gods in our contemporary US context, such as political party, nation, race, fame, sex, and youthfulness. But in order to conclude that the number of gods is the same, how can one be certain that the criteria for what should be considered a god in the ancient world would have an equivalent definition in contemporary settings? In addition, this Jeremiah text refers to a camel as a lustful female wild ass. The passage illustrates one way in which the rhetoric of the prophets incarnates in female form the people’s desertion of Yahweh.

It trains the reader/interpreter to maintain an association of femaleness—in this case, even a non-human creature's female sexual desire—with evil.¹²

The crafting of contemporary ethics based on ancient scriptures requires some acknowledgement of the differences in the two sociohistorical contexts, as Fedler offers. But there are widely divergent views about what kinds of accommodation of the moral understandings drawn from the prophetic text are required by those differences and how that accommodation is achieved. Ethicists often seek out a universal moral point from particular cultural references in the Bible and utilize a comparative-analogy approach to acquire it. In this example of an ethical reflection on Jeremiah 2, loyalty to and honoring of gods are assumed to be transcultural, transhistorical values with meaning beyond cultural particularity. Again, an ethics focus on extracting the universal moral point highlights the need to attend to the cultural politics at work when one is interpreting the biblical text. The insistence on the primacy of moral universals can be instrumental in allowing the disparaging cultural message about femaleness to be ignored because it may be seen as a negligible particularity in the text.

Identification of the specific sociopolitical reference point and the message about it expressed by the prophet may be subordinated to the broader moral point about contemporary culture that the ethicist intends to make. The comparative-analogy approach can ensure this subordination. When Christian ethicist James Gustafson maps several approaches to the use of scripture in ethics and their attendant problems, he identifies the issue of control as key for the analogy method.

The primary question in the use of Scripture for moral analogies is that of control. If present events are in control, then one first responds to these events and then on the basis of that response seeks biblical events that are similar to the present ones. . . . Thus the choice of Exodus would be more congenial for a negative judgment on present repression of a small power by a great power than would some of the prophetic interpretations of the role of a great power in chastising a lesser power for its violation of God's ways for the nations. . . . Biblical support could be found for the opinions one has formed on independent ethical bases. If Scripture is in control, then one is faced with the persistent question of which events are most nearly consistent with certain central tendencies of the biblical, theological, and moral witness.¹³

The problem of selecting scripture from differing sections of the Bible such as Exodus or the prophets to confirm moral positions on which one has already independently decided can also surface in interpretations of a single passage when the interpreter relies on analogy as a method of interpretation. The dichotomy Gustafson describes entails a struggle over control at the center of this issue that resembles a standard emphasis in Christian ethics dating back to the African bishop of Hippo, Augustine. In this traditional framework, Christian morality consistently involves a wrestling match between human will and divine will, the city of humankind and the city of God. In this aspect of Gustafson's mapping of the use of scripture in Christian ethics, the moral struggle apparently takes the form of the control of present events verses the control of sacred scripture. It is unclear how the scripture could ever be in control, however, when it is

always the interpreter who must decide “the central tendencies” of the “biblical, theological, and moral witness” and then, most importantly, decipher its meaning. And any Christian interpreter is inevitably part of historically located cultural patterns that are also, unmistakably, “shifting, turning, and open” (as Scholz describes).¹⁴

Analogies constitute a commonly utilized tool of interpretation. Therefore, reliance on the conventional notion of a struggle over the control of the moral meaning of scripture in a contest between biases rooted in the present and the scriptural witness rooted in the past requires scrutiny. It offers a rudimentary backdrop for reflecting on Christian ethics methods of interpreting the Hebrew prophets.¹⁵ But besides its misleading presumption of cultural fixedness in the past (worlds of the scripture) and in the present (world of the interpreter), this framing may be too limiting precisely because it is so rigidly dichotomous rather than dialogical. The dichotomy radiates with a stifling competitiveness. It resembles the zero-sum game of an abusive boyfriend or spouse whose relational compass routinely registers in modes of control. This hermeneutical schema can narrow the potential for forms of ethical learning from the text that are out from under the control of the attempt to advance already systemically advantaged group interests. It neglects imaginative forms of learning in service of broader human flourishing, along with all of creation. This dichotomous approach may obscure the potential for a more frenetic, culturally variable process of ethical learning that even includes learning from the mysteries and silences in the text.

On specific ethical topics, however, the task of learning from the silences in certain texts of the Hebrew prophets does not always reap productive results. Topic-driven ethical inquiry on matters such as abortion is often unabashedly concerned with the utility of the scripture text for generating moral absolutes. As Christian ethicist Allen Verhey maintains, although there are references to God’s formation of and communication with the fetus in the womb in Jeremiah 1:5 and Isaiah 49:1, scripture is silent about induced abortions. “No prophet mentions it,” he notes in his discussion of the silence on this topic in both Hebrew Bible texts and the New Testament.¹⁶ Verhey then gives opposing examples of Christian scholars who conclude that this silence either means abortion is not an option for believers, or that one should be reticent to judge the morality of another’s choice (of abortion).¹⁷ The challenge of reading from silence provides evidence for his diagnosis of the mistaken use of scripture in contemporary community life. It can inflame moral passions on both sides of abortion debates when concerned, as Verhey characterizes them, on the one hand, with what is “oppressive to women” and, on the other hand, with what protects “the lives of the unborn.”¹⁸ As his discussion demonstrates, in the search for a definitive moral absolute deduced from the silence of the prophets (and the rest of the Bible), a topical Christian ethics hermeneutical concern can produce an unsatisfying ping-pong effect. This kind of reflection incorporates another fiercely competitive ethos. Sides are formed in order to formulate a trans-historical absolute truth on a specific topic, not unlike the formulation of a dichotomized competition between the theological witness of scripture and present biases.

Verhey’s view on this silence in the prophetic text is disputed by biblical and Jewish studies scholar Elliott Friedman and Hebrew Bible scholar Shawna Dolansky, who refer

to the poetry of Jeremiah 20:14–18 describing its expression of the wish of the prophet to have been killed in his mother's womb as a "blatant reference to abortion."¹⁹ For these biblical scholars, the moral meaning of the text pivots, in part, on a correct understanding of the language of the text, and such an understanding should be derived from its own Hebrew Bible context. Friedman and Dolansky explain that "the word that Jeremiah uses for abortion . . . always refers to 'killing' and never to 'murder,'" unlike the word "murder" that is used in the Ten Commandments.²⁰ Their scholarly perspective delegitimizes the use of this particular passage to oppose abortion as murder. These (and other) biblical scholars hold to a claim that they construct the moral meaning of the prophet's words from within the language and worldview of the biblical text.

Within the field of Christian ethics, Beverly Harrison demonstrates what difference it makes when the cultural politics of gender relations are primary for one's biblical hermeneutics on the topic of abortion.²¹ Harrison wrote one of the first major texts of US feminist Christian social ethics, *Our Right to Choose: Toward a New Ethic of Abortion* (1983). She supports the importance of what she terms a theological-moral hermeneutic approach to scripture that embraces the positive theological values and moral principles from the past and continues to make claims on contemporary Christians.²² But she stresses a radical political translation that is necessary and a good end in itself. Harrison explains that "transcending social relations in which women were considered the property of males, however beloved, represents a positive moral breakthrough not fully envisaged by either ancient Israel or the New Testament Christian community."²³ The *a priori* moral absolute in this method of interpretation assumes a theologically rooted notion of the common good that incorporates social change. One must not only take into account changes in social understandings as part of the task of interpreting scripture for Christian ethics. As Harrison commends, one must also be mindful of certain changes, such as evolving social relations that reflect gender equality and that support women's agency outside male control (ownership) as constituting a societal good that is beyond the scope of the worldview of the text. Rather than engaging in a competition for ahistorical moral claims, in this Christian ethics approach it is the responsibility of the reader to bring biblical norms into dialogue with such newer moral orientations.²⁴

It is this historical question of social change that lies at the heart of almost all of the ways that Christian social ethics engages the Hebrew prophets. The writings of the Hebrew prophets are primarily concerned with faithful communal responses to changing sociopolitical realities that constricted communal well-being. Most Christian social ethics approaches to interpreting these texts share this same concern. The political nature of the prophetic scripture texts demands a response to a series of questions about how, in Christian social ethics methods for interpreting them, notions of sociopolitical change are conceptualized. How does one account for the inevitability of historically evolving political change in the values that societies hold? How is one's understanding of such change incorporated in the process of extracting theo-ethical meaning from prophetic scriptures? What choices are made by Christian interpreters of the text about how to identify the type of sociopolitical change and/or the maintenance of the status quo addressed in the prophetic material? How are the goals of sociopolitical change and/or

the maintenance of the status quo part of the act of interpreting the moral meanings in the prophet's historical context and message? How are those goals involved in deciding when the text is relatable to contemporary Christian faithfulness? A Christian theological figure devoted to a historical reading of the significance of the Hebrew prophets for guiding Christian faith and ethical engagement of injustice in society could not represent a better initial case study for these core methodological ethics questions about historicity and social change.

CHRISTIAN SOCIAL ETHICS

APPROPRIATIONS OF THE PROPHETS

The treatment of the Hebrew prophets in Walter Rauschenbusch's 1907 *Christianity and the Social Crisis* provides an example of a Protestant retrieval of Hebrew scripture in order to establish how "the historical roots of Christianity" were inextricably and fundamentally tied to human moral impulse. The prophets helped to establish a connection between morality and religion that was not merely a private matter, Rauschenbusch argued, but constituted "public morality on which national life is founded."²⁵ Rauschenbusch (1861–1918) was born to German immigrant parents in Rochester, New York, and served as pastor of a German-speaking Baptist immigrant congregation in a poor neighborhood called "Hell's Kitchen" in New York City (1886–1892). This experience deeply influenced his writing and teaching during his subsequent academic sojourn as a professor in the German department and then professor of church history at Rochester Theological Seminary (1897–1917). Within US-based Christian thought, he is considered a major voice of the Social Gospel movement. Rauschenbusch developed Christian theology and social ethics largely in response to economic conditions, such as the industrial exploitation of workers and the squalid housing conditions, untreated illnesses, and high child mortality rates of people in the tenements near the church he served.

In his chapter on the Hebrew prophets in *Christianity and the Social Crisis* (1907), he focused on Amos, Hosea, Isaiah, and Jeremiah, viewing them as "entirely on the side of the poorer classes."²⁶ For Rauschenbusch, this emphasis in the writings of the prophets provided support for contemporary struggles for labor rights, including the right to strike, and for the betterment of the lives of the "proletarian immigrant in our cities."²⁷ He translated the moral worldviews of the ancient context into terms that reflected reformist critiques made by Progressive Era political leaders. His critics faulted him for too closely linking Christian biblical and theological understandings with concrete societal policies.²⁸ In addition to providing details about economic reform, the overarching aim of Rauschenbusch's discussion of the prophets steadfastly focused on what their ideas could teach Christians about the nature of religion. "When the prophets conceived Jehovah as the special vindicator of these voiceless classes," he explained, "it was another

way of saying that it is the chief duty in religious morality to stand for the rights of the helpless.”²⁹ Rauschenbusch argued against understandings of (Christian) religion, popular among some then and now, as chiefly a matter of individual piety. Instead, he identified the centrality of social accountability to the poor, as articulated by the Hebrew prophets, as religion’s defining ingredient.

In his description of the religious understandings for which the prophets served as a conduit, he insisted that “the championship of the poor by the prophets was not due to the inflow of novel social ideals,” but inspiration from nobler elements of religious faith to which “they clung in the face of distorted social conditions created by the new commercialism.”³⁰ Rauschenbusch’s use of language such as “the new commercialism” evidenced a sharp critique of current socioeconomic trends, as well as an attempt to convey distinctive dynamics in the agrarian socio-historical setting that threatened the religious values the Hebrew prophets wanted to preserve. While he credited the content of the faith tradition they received with serving as a catalyst for their prophetic vocation, it is the unique qualities of boldness and responsiveness to sociopolitical realities in the manner in which they gave expression to their religious faith that he stressed most strongly.

In her discussion of Rauschenbusch’s chapter on the prophets in *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, feminist Hebrew Bible scholar Phyllis Trible notes a few of its problems related to this emphasis. She criticizes his celebration of the role of the prophets as the best aspect of Old Testament faith, though one that was unfortunately muted. “Thus, he disparages Judaism,” Trible asserts, “by claiming that true prophecy survived in Christianity” through Jesus and the primitive church.³¹ Rauschenbusch’s approach lines up with a long-standing and dominant anti-Judaistic tradition of Christian interpretation of the Hebrew Bible. For him and many other Christian thinkers and church leaders, the Hebrew prophets were not considered in the context of the Jewish tradition to which they belonged, but instead were seen as representing a historical precursor to Christianity. To such Christian exegetes, the extent to which the ancient Israelite communities failed to heed the warnings and judgments the prophets delivered serves as a further indication of the historical necessity for Christ’s salvation in the person of Jesus of Nazareth. As a budding church historian, Rauschenbusch nevertheless construed the historical foundations of Christian social ethics established by the prophets as both essential and powerful for an authentic understanding of the significance of Jesus. His approach demonstrates how the cultural politics of Christian–Jewish interreligious understandings mediate Christian interpretations of the Hebrew Bible. The ways in which the Christianizing³² of ethical points elicited from the Hebrew prophets can reinforce Christian superiority to Jewish tradition seem far removed from, and perhaps even oppositional to, the commitment of those Israelite prophets to their faith and peoples.

In many respects, Rauschenbusch’s arguments made a concerted effort to inhabit the logic and social world of the prophets in order to draw forth particular connections to social problems of his day. In certain of those instances, unfortunately, he imbued the moral meaning that he extracted from the prophetic texts with derogatory notions of race and cultural bias that were current in US society. He explained the ancient

sociopolitical circumstances that created a need for Jeremiah's derision of the confidence of the people "after the great reformation under Josiah (623 B.C.E.)."³³ He followed up this discussion of Jeremiah with a laudatory description of Ezekiel's "task to batter down and discourage complacent confidence" by those who believed themselves to be a "sifted remnant" left in exile. Utilizing a hypothetical scenario, Rauschenbusch then sought to deliver a startling realization to his readers. He utilized vivid and familiar communal reference points in order to help them grasp how unwelcome the radical message of those prophets must have been for their audiences.

"How would we feel if a preacher should use a public gathering on Decoration Day³⁴ or Thanksgiving Day," he inquired, "to predict that our country for its mammonism and oppression was cast off by God and was to be parceled out to the Mexicans, the Chinese and the negroes [*sic*]? In the sense of our security and strength we should probably simply laugh at him."³⁵ Rauschenbusch's audience was most likely Euro-American whites. It is probable that he made an accurate assessment of their fears when basing this scenario on a supposed threat that "Mexicans," "Chinese," and "negroes" posed to their racially inflected national pride. Apparently, most in his Euro-American white audience would have regarded "Mexicans," "Chinese," and "negroes" as outsiders to "our country," a view that a preacher could also plausibly assert as shared by God. For certain new immigrants from Europe, this juxtaposition might have reinforced their emerging sense of belonging and status as white Americans.³⁶ As the child of German immigrants, it might even have bolstered Rauschenbusch's sense of his own white Americanness, though I do not know whether it did.³⁷

The cultural politics of interpretation of the prophets that flows throughout this example are revealing. Rauschenbusch can be seen as reading the politics of his cultural context in a manner that emulates the prophets. He seeks a political scenario to which his audience can relate in order to convey a morally indicting theological message. His hypothetical preacher also demonstrates the political style of the prophets by attempting to stir up discomfort in aspects of their national life where they feel "security and strength." Rauschenbusch seems to count on latent racial hostility on the part of white citizens, perhaps fueled by his contemporary political ethos.

During the last half of the nineteenth century, there was a massive land-grab in the West by Euro-American whites displacing Mexican Americans from their territory as subsistence landowning farmers and forcing them to become seasonal agricultural workers, domestic workers, or miners.³⁸ There was also an increasing migration from Mexico to the United States due to the worsening conditions under Mexico's brutal dictator, Porfirio Díaz.³⁹ The anti-Chinese sentiment was nationally so strong during the late nineteenth century that it garnered the historic termination of the immigration of Chinese people through the passage of the 1882 Chinese Exclusion Act, renewed again in 1892.⁴⁰ African Americans in the South were experiencing extreme forms of social, economic, and political backlash to Reconstruction, including the race-based denial of economic opportunities. The discrimination was reinforced by the terrorist violence of white Christian Southerners. As historian Leon Litwack notes, "between 1890 and 1917, to enforce deference and submission to whites, some

two to three black southerners were hanged, burned at the stake, or quietly murdered every week.”⁴¹ In response to these conditions, between 1870 and 1910 almost half a million impoverished African Americans migrated from the South to Northern urban centers such as New York.

Therefore to illustrate the stinging critique of the prophets for his readers, Rauschenbusch's example enabled his (presumably white Christian) audience to reflect on the experience of God's judgment through racialized cultural lenses. He invited them to imagine what it would be like for them if for their “mammonism and oppression” (apparently exempting any white supremacist self-understandings) they were not merely being “cast off by God.” They would also endure the shame of being subordinated to supposedly racially inferior peoples. This sense of the racial inferiority of certain groups would be easily imagined as such, since each group mentioned by Rauschenbusch was currently undergoing a variety of extreme yet popular public practices that ensured their social status as inferior and subordinate to whites. The method Rauschenbusch employs does not provide an equatable analogy-comparison based on the three groups of peoples the prophets' audiences would have viewed as inferior to them (Babylonians, Assyrians, Egyptians) as much as it represents an attempt to adopt the logic and style of Jeremiah's and Ezekiel's derision of the faithful. Rauschenbusch offers this analysis to make a moral point about God's judgment against Christian complicity in certain forms of “mammonism and oppression” in contemporary societal relationships and to incite social change.

The anti-Judaistic assumptions incorporated in his view of the role of the prophets in Christian history and the white supremacist biases embedded in certain of his examples undermine Rauschenbusch's overarching point about heeding the prophets' message of God's judgment against oppression. They do not, however, cancel out a critical appreciation for the significance of his effort to craft biblically based Christian ethics focused on social inequalities in the United States. His method offers valuable insights into the role of culture within Christian social ethics interpretations of the prophets.

Even the troubling, white racism inflected aspects of Rauschenbusch's approach convey an essential reminder for the ethics necessary for biblical hermeneutics. One must bring suspicion specifically to the derisive cultural assumptions and references in the prophetic material when crafting ethical conclusions for contemporary society based on that material. At whose expense are the moral lessons of the texts taught when they are offered through such culturally specific, frequently gendered, mocking metaphors and allusions?⁴² What kind of ethics for contemporary cultural understandings are taught by the derisive portrayal of Israel as the wife who is punished for adultery through the humiliation of being stripped naked in Hosea 2, or the symbolic, pornographic sexual violence against the two sisters depicted as deserving of this punishment because of their supposed sexual promiscuity in Ezekiel 23?

But as feminist Hebrew Bible scholar Gale Yee has insisted, the patriarchal gendered cultural messages in these ancient texts must not be separated from their messages about other exploitative systemic communal relations in the ancient world. Referring to the sociopolitical message these tropes in Hosea and Ezekiel conveyed, Yee explains

that a “condemnation of class exploitation, shortsighted foreign policies, and oppressive colonial relations was accomplished by perpetuating stereotypes of gender.”⁴³ Again, the task of liberationist social ethics is to retain a focus on the means by which the critique is attained. Derision remains morally corrosive. Neither images of sexualized violence against women functioning as an ancient vehicle for anti-colonialist critique nor the mocking invocation of Chinese immigrants, Mexican immigrants, and African Americans as supposed outsiders can teach a sufficiently expansive theological concern for communal worth and dignity.

In its concern with the means by which the Hebrew prophets delivered their messages, the Christian social ethics pioneered by Rauschenbusch in 1907 crafted a richly meaningful, though on some points racially problematic, link between form and content. This linkage forged in *Christianity and the Social Crisis* both ignited and at times undercut a religiously based ethical social vision sharply critical of systemic socioeconomic exploitation in the United States. A socially visionary linkage of form and content also constitutes one of the most compelling and common aims found in both the Hebrew prophets and most normative claims of more contemporary versions of liberationist Christian social ethics.

In her examination of health crises in African American communities, womanist Christian social ethicist Emilie Townes focuses on the book of Joel. Her method casts a spotlight on how contemporary ethical analyses can emerge from specific attention to the literary form of the prophetic material. She includes a poetic form for her own text that is interspersed throughout parts of the opening and closing sections of her study *Breaking the Fine Rain of Death: African American Health Issues and a Womanist Ethic of Care* (1998).⁴⁴ It underscores the relationship between the form and content in the ethical message she garners from Joel.

if we learn anything from Joel
 it is to know that the healing of brokenness and injustice
 the healing of social sin and degradation
 the healing of spiritual doubts and fears
 begins with an unrestrained lament
 one that starts from our toenails and is a shout by the time it gets to
 the ends of the strands of our hair⁴⁵

The alignment on the page, punctuation, and metaphorical language of Townes’s sentences break with standard academic prose, alluding to the form of the prophetic poetry in the Hebrew Bible. In particular, Townes concentrates on the form of lament that Joel models. Drawing on the work of Walter Brueggemann, she names the function of lament: formfulness. This formfulness disciplines the communal process of social and spiritual healing as well as reflection within the academic discipline of ethics. Based on the Hebrew prophet Joel, Townes argues that the “formfulness of communal lament has a deep moral character that helps the discipline of social ethics do its work in our contemporary contexts.”⁴⁶

Writing almost one hundred years after Walter Rauschenbusch, Townes more explicitly delineates the work of the discipline of Christian social ethics from its relationship to the Hebrew prophetic texts. She describes her appropriation of the book of Joel as an illustration of how scripture represents a singular but not exclusive grounding element for Christian social ethics. According to Townes, as it asks about responsible communal relatedness to God and to each other, the discipline of social ethics includes ongoing inquiries, for example, about how one ought to respond in that relatedness and about the “path to salvation” as it investigates “social structures, processes and communities.”⁴⁷ It seeks a better understanding of how social contexts “shape and direct our sense of moral self and moral action.”⁴⁸ Rauschenbusch’s intent was an espousal of US Christian social ethics that engages the prophets as historical guides, enabling the embrace of an egalitarianism that ought to be endemic to Christian religious morality. Townes utilizes the literary style of specific material in the Hebrew prophets as a kind of organizing framework that shapes the emphasis in her standardized Christian ethics inquiry.

Based on the formfulness of Joel’s lament, she outlines a necessary, despairing acknowledgment—alongside hope for change—related to healthcare crises among African Americans. These crises include disproportionately high rates of breast cancer mortality, obesity, and HIV and AIDS. For Townes, these alarming national trends in black communities are too often met by silence in predominantly African American churches. After citing dismal national statistics related to substance abuse and violence throughout all communities in the United States, she summarizes her ethical point with images from Joel, asserting that “[w]e are in need of a communal lament, and we have forgotten how to cry out against the plague of locusts that visits us hourly. . . . Just as the whole community of Judah must lament, so all of us are in this together.”⁴⁹

Townes revels in a literary approach where the form (of Joel) provides a tool for illuminating the ethical content of the text, that is, its interrogation of social structures, processes, and communities. But form does not determine in any primary way the subject matter of that ethical content. The formfulness of Joel’s lament does, for example, discipline Christian ethics to attend to despair, a category the discipline of Christian ethics might otherwise neglect. Her literary method avoids the quest for contemporary sociopolitical reference points that offer analogous resemblance to the historical realities the prophets criticized. The prophetic form, nevertheless, signals the need for concretized moral work on corrupt societal relationships. There may be too much room for a variety of content in the literary method of Townes. In her conceptualization, as it attends to “structures of evil and wickedness that make us ill,”⁵⁰ Christian social ethics borrows this judgmental frame from the prophets and aptly applies it to racially marked disparities in the delivery of adequate healthcare. If metaphorical allusions in her framework such as “structures of evil and wickedness that make us ill” can be interpreted as referencing any category of social condition or community, this method could be a bit too malleable. It could perhaps be used to re-victimize those already harshly judged and disenfranchised. The broad utility of the shaming modeled in the prophetic material may allow for this troubling possibility, which is similar to its function in the racially myopic aspects of Rauschenbusch’s approach.

In one of the concluding points of Townes's study, she lists action steps for African American churches to develop an expansive ministry to address HIV and AIDS in their communities. After identifying ministry strategies as salvific "forms of communal lament" this section concludes with Joel 2:18–19, where God says "I am sending you grain, wine, oil, and you will be satisfied; and I will no more make you a mockery among the nations."⁵¹ If one is to claim the words of Joel as disciplining Christian social ethics, as Townes does, it requires more than an assessment of social processes in accord with Joel's lament format. Not unlike the inclusion of socioeconomic reforms such as labor rights mentioned by Rauschenbusch, Townes points to HIV and AIDS ministry tasks. They reflect the specificity of the sociopolitical references pervasive in the Hebrew prophets and point to the need for materialized moral actions. The understandings in the biblical text mention specifics, such as instructing exiles to build houses and live in them (Jeremiah 29), the problem of bribery of religious leaders (Micah 3), and rejection of the receipt of accrued interest (Ezek 18:8). A discussion of Christian ethics appropriations of the Hebrew prophets requires more attention to methods concretized in lived theo-ethics.

For centuries, the words of the Hebrew prophets have been a source of authority for Christian ethical engagement of public policies by social activists. Prophetic texts have been deployed through multiple methods in public advocacy by individual leaders and collectively by groups as a means of conscientization. In US history, for instance, in 1830s Boston, Massachusetts, the black abolitionist orator Maria Stewart drew upon these texts for a particular form of persuasion. She invoked Jeremiah 9:1, "Oh that my head were waters, mine eyes a fountain of tears, that I might weep day and night for the slain daughters of my people!" As Africana studies church and society scholar Valerie Cooper observed in her study of Stewart's use of scripture, "this reference to Jeremiah is a way of wrapping herself in the prophet's mantle and tear-stained persona."⁵² The words from the Hebrew prophet contribute to an apologetic formula that helped to authorize her radical anti-slavery message. They signify her humility at the beginning of her speech, not unlike non-biblical rhetorical devices conventionally employed by nineteenth-century white women writers. The words of Jeremiah lend Stewart a space of legitimacy to name the unethical in the face of grave dangers for black abolitionist public speakers and the social stigma and dominant Christian prohibitions against women (of any racial background) speaking in public to mixed gender audiences during this antebellum period.

Several scholars discuss the ways in which texts from the Hebrew prophets have been utilized more recently to lend authority to the political demands of organizations in social justice movements. In her study of congregation-based community organizing in several twenty-first-century US cities, Christian urban ministry scholar Helene Slessarev-Jamir found that Hebrew prophets such as Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Micah were a major source of inspiration for the leaders and were frequently quoted by them.⁵³ The leaders' understanding of communal ethics emerged, in part, from the inspiration those prophetic texts provided. Based on her interviews of community activist congregational leaders, Slessarev-Jamir explains that these texts, along with certain New Testament

passages and the work of contemporary liberation theologians, represent a prophetic tradition that became a collective resource for them. It contributed “scaffolding necessary for the public articulation of the ethical nature of the organizations’ demands and the maintenance of the activists’ continued engagement in this work.”⁵⁴ This prophetic tradition provided models of faith-oriented, materialist ethical claims about justice in which the Christian activists could root their actions.

Sociologist Richard Wood offers his own observations on the impact of the reading of prophetic scripture in his study of religion, race, and community organizing. He describes the reading of Amos 5:21–24, starting with “I hate, I despise your feasts, I take no pleasure in your solemn festivals” at a joint gathering of thousands of Latino, African American, white, and Hmong protestors in Sacramento, California.⁵⁵ The event continued with a prayer by a local clergy member, asking God to “send upon us the spirit of Amos.” It was, in Wood’s estimation, an example of how the use of the language of religious faith in the public arena “helped to promote the interests of low-income Americans.”⁵⁶ As his analysis demonstrates, the sacred meaning of the Amos text can expand into a form of social ethics in action. When the multiracial group of socioeconomically impoverished protestors experienced its reading at their mass meeting, the text functioned as mass protest spirituality. It became a liturgical expression of public protest against unfair state policies.

Similarly, in a study of religious ethics and labor rights organizing, Christian social ethicist Melissa Snarr discusses a weekly protest ritual at city council meetings in San Diego, California.⁵⁷ A leadership duo that changed from week to week, comprising a clergy member partnered with a low-wage worker, stood together during the public comment section of the meetings to speak in support of a city ordinance that would increase wages. They concluded with either Micah 6:8, “He has told you, O mortal, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?” or with Amos 5:24, “let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream.” Snarr points to the ethical impact of the scripture citation as helping to construct an alternative notion of time. Social activism such as this reading of the ancient Hebrew prophets, she argues, “declares that the specific time-space of a proceeding (such as a city council meeting) is not limited to that historical moment but is connected to transcendent meaning and communities that precede and exceed the present action.”⁵⁸ Rather than an analogous correlation between the issues the council was considering and those raised in the Micah or Amos texts, oddly, it is the dissonance between the historical time-space of the scriptural contexts and the city council meeting that helps to produce a sense of moral continuity. Of course, the impact of that moral continuity still depends on the degree to which the contemporary audience (city council) values the synergistic combination of religious faith and social action essential to the messengers in both ancient and current contexts.

The public reading of the words of the prophets can also sometimes serve this same communal ritual function in the protests of internal justice movements of Christian communities, but only if the ritual occurs in a way that is somehow discordant with the standard inclusion of scripture in church worship practices. A version of Micah 6:8

was sung at national protests by the United Methodist Church's Reconciling Movement Network (RMN). RMN consists of Methodist church activists who focus on equal rights for lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender persons in opposition to their church's discriminatory rules barring them from ordination and from receiving pastoral care such as marriage counseling and the ritual celebration of their marriages. The executive director of RMN, Troy Plummer, gave the context in a blog he submitted from the 2004 quadrennial national meeting of representatives of the eight-million-member United Methodist denomination in Cleveland, Ohio. He wrote: "Tuesday of the second week started a daily prayer witness with volunteers lining the entrance in prayer (standing, kneeling, sitting, eyes open, eyes closed). Spontaneously we broke into song 'What does the Lord Require of You?' that reverberated through the entry area. Many entrants were brought to tears, others sang along. It continues to be a powerful witness."⁵⁹ The words of the hymn consist solely of a paraphrase of Micah 6:8. Its stanzas repeat: "What does the Lord require of you? What does the Lord require of you? Justice, kindness, walk humbly with your God. . . ." ⁶⁰ The Micah text was utilized as a musical ritual. It ritualized a liberationist Christian ethics of dissent. The scripture passage sung by the protesters formed a public accusation of religious hypocrisy against the majority of delegates who walked into the hall to vote to retain the discriminatory rules maintaining the innate superiority of heterosexuals in their Protestant denomination.

As with the need for a discordant connection with the routine reading of scripture in church settings, there are also limitations on the authenticity of its embodiment of liberationist Christian social ethics when Christian public policy advocates and leaders mention Hebrew prophetic texts in secular public discourse.⁶¹ Micah 6:8 was repeatedly referenced as a source of moral authority by the mayor of Chicago, Richard J. Daley, a lifelong Catholic who was known for being a corrupt machine-politics boss from 1955 until he died in office in 1976. On the evening of his first election and on several subsequent occasions, Daley spoke of his desire to embrace mercy and "walk humbly with my God."⁶² The language of the Hebrew prophets can be serviceable, therefore, for granting moral authority in the public discourse of Christian leaders in a manner that legitimates the abuse of power in the formation of public policy. At the same time, it can also morally assist in challenging the abuse of power in policies as varied as ending centuries of US chattel slavery, increasing low wages of municipal workers, or ending church discrimination against their gay, lesbian, bisexual, and transgender members.

CONCLUSION: VITAL ETHICS DERIVED FROM THE PROPHETS

The liberationist character of Christian ethical engagement with the Hebrew prophets stressed in this chapter assumes a vital sense of vocation and ongoing theo-ethical reflection. For liberationist Christian social ethics, the task of interpreting the ethical

concerns of the Hebrew prophets and relating them to contemporary concerns should be seen as part of the Christian interpreter's vocational journey. This vocational aspect may be too easily overlooked. It assumes a Christian faith commitment to sort through the cultural politics of the prophets' words and contexts in a manner that incorporates a critical self-consciousness about the cultural politics informing the contemporary interpreter. This commitment is a matter of ethics and faith in God that extends beyond a merely rhetorical posture or sloganeering.

In an essay on Jeremiah, biblical studies scholar Lai Ling Elizabeth Ngan describes how her process (as a scholar) of reading the text is mediated by her social location in relation to oppressive structures and her own Christian faith journey. "It enlarges my valuation of life in this world. Something shifts in my understanding and in the way that I see," she explains, "[a]s I am reading Jeremiah, Jeremiah is reading me."⁶³ Ngan's conceptualization, though offered in biblical studies, vividly captures the vocational aspect of "doing" Christian theo-ethics when engaging the Hebrew prophets. At once a measure of control is given up and claimed in order to expand one's faith-filled valuation of life within the sociopolitics of this world.

The ethics methods of interpreters necessarily differ because of the varied geopolitical particularities and social locations they must consider. A liberationist social ethics engagement of the Hebrew prophets links those particularities to theo-ethical reflection on activist hermeneutical inquiry. It is an inquiry that pivots on support for social change that increases our collective well-being and respectful connection to all of creation. Ethics insistently inquires about how the interpreter's engagement of the prophets has informed their conclusions. And after receiving the first response explaining this linkage, it queries again the method hidden behind that first response.

NOTES

1. I am grateful for the research assistance that I received on this chapter from Elyse Ambrose Minson and Tejai Beulah, and for suggestions on early drafts from Althea Spencer-Miller.
2. See the discussion of Ezekiel and Amos in Allen Dwight Callahan, *The Talking Book: African Americans and the Bible* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2006), 60–61, 108. Examples of post-colonial South African perspectives include Makhosazana K. Nzimande, "Isaiah" [136–146], and Madipoane Masenya (ngwan'a Mphahlele), "Jeremiah" [147–156] in Page et al. 2010.
3. Scholz 2007: 62.
4. See a discussion of these problems in Judaism, Islam, Hinduism, and Buddhism in Elisabeth Schüssler Fiorenza, Karen Derris, Rachel Adelman, Karen Pechilis, and Ayisha A. Hidayatullah, "Special Section: Comparative Feminist Hermeneutics," *JFSR* 30(2) (2014): 57–130.
5. Joseph S. Pettit, "The Spoil of the Poor Is in Your Houses: Profits and Prophets in a Disrupted Society," *JSCE* 27 (2007): 33–55 (35–36).
6. Dempsey 2000.
7. Marlow 2009.

8. Marlow 2009: 275–276.
9. Fedler 2006: 121.
10. Fedler 2006: 121–122.
11. Fedler 2006: 122.
12. Gale A. Yee, *Poor Banished Children of Eve: Woman as Evil in the Hebrew Bible* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2003), 2.
13. James M. Gustafson, “The Place of Scripture in Christian Ethics: A Methodological Study,” in his *Theology and Christian Ethics* (Philadelphia: United Church Press, 1974), 121–145 (123). Also see his more in-depth discussion of the prophets and ethics in Gustafson 1988; Ogletree 1983.
14. Scholz 2007: 62.
15. See Cosgrove 2002, esp. “The Rule of Analogy,” 51–89.
16. Allen Verhey, *Reading the Bible in the Strange World of Medicine* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003), 197.
17. Verhey, *Reading the Bible*, 198.
18. Verhey, *Reading the Bible*, 194.
19. Friedman and Dolansky 2011: 48.
20. Friedman and Dolansky 2011: 49.
21. Beverly Wildung Harrison, *Our Right to Choose: Toward a New Ethic of Abortion* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1983; reprint, Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 2011). Even though she focuses on passages from Exodus and Psalms, I still find her discussion relevant to the prophetic material. She prefaces her discussion of Psalms 139:13–16 with an assertion I construe as inclusive of Jeremiah 1:5 and Isaiah 49:1: “Several of the finest poets of the ancient Israelite tradition rely heavily on imagery depicting God’s passionate love for humankind and the result of procreation as preexistent and extending from before conception to beyond death” (69).
22. Harrison, *Our Right to Choose*, 71.
23. Harrison, *Our Right to Choose*, 71.
24. Harrison, *Our Right to Choose*, 71.
25. Walter Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis* (New York: Macmillan, 1907; reprint, Library of Theological Ethics; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1991), 8.
26. Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 11.
27. Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 12.
28. In 2005 he was criticized by Christian leaders such as Rick Warren, pastor of a California mega-church and best-selling author, who commented that “Rauschenbusch was a liberal theologian and he basically said we don’t need this stuff about Jesus anymore; we don’t need the cross; we don’t need salvation; we don’t need atonement; we just need to redeem the social structures of society and if we do that people will automatically get better. This is basically Marxism in a Christian form.” Quoted in Tim Suttle, *An Evangelical Social Gospel? Finding God’s Story in the Midst of Extremes* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 2011), 74.
29. Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 12.
30. Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 16.
31. Phyllis Trible, “Response: A Rhetorician for Righteousness,” in *Christianity and the Social Crisis in the 21st Century: The Classic That Woke Up the Church*, ed. Paul Raushenbush, 33–37 (36).
32. This is a term he used in his writings. See Walter Rauschenbusch, *Christianizing the Social Order* (Boston: Pilgrim, 1912).

33. Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 37.
34. Now known as Memorial Day; in 1907, at the time Rauschenbusch wrote *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, "Decoration Day" commemorated those who died during the Civil War.
35. Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 37–38.
36. See David R. Roediger, *Working Toward Whiteness: How America's Immigrants Became White: The Strange Journey from Ellis Island to the Suburbs* (New York: Basic Books, 2005); Noel Ignatiev, *How the Irish Became White* (New York: Routledge, 2009).
37. Rauschenbusch's racially troubling, cautionary view continues elsewhere in the book in an example of his meeting with "the best and ablest men," who include Swedish and German Americans. After noting the problem of their limited progeny, he warns: "The intellectual standard of humanity can be raised only by propagation of the capable. Our social system causes an unnatural selection of the weak for breeding, and the result is the survival of the unfittest" (Rauschenbusch, *Christianity and the Social Crisis*, 275). Also see Gary Dorrien's discussion of Rauschenbusch's advocacy of German immigration in Dorrien's *Social Ethics in the Making: Interpreting an American Tradition* (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2009), 92–95. Dorrien concludes: "Despite his general inclination to resist the prevalent racism of his culture, he resorted to racist tactics in the service of his ethnic group" (93).
38. Teresa L. Amott and Julie A. Matthaei, *Race, Gender, and Work: A Multicultural Economic History of Women in the United States* (Boston: South End Press, 1991), 72–73.
39. Amott and Matthaei, *Race, Gender, and Work*, 73–75.
40. See Ian F. Haney López, *White by Law: The Legal Construction of Race* (Critical America; 10th anniv. ed., New York: New York University Press, 2006; orig. pub. 1996).
41. Leon F. Litwack, *Trouble in Mind: Black Southerners in the Age of Jim Crow* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1998), 284.
42. In her discussion of this extreme violence in Ezekiel, Renita Weems asks, "What kind of audience did the author imagine would find this brutality to be a just recompense for adultery? Who could have harbored such hostile misogynistic feelings against women, even promiscuous women?" (1994: 96).
43. Yee, *Poor Banished Children of Eve*, 164.
44. Townes 1998.
45. Townes 1998: 12.
46. Townes 1998: 24.
47. Townes 1998: 26.
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52. Valerie C. Cooper, *Word, Like Fire: Maria Stewart, The Bible and the Rights of African Americans* (Carter G. Woodson Institute Series; Charlottesville: University of Virginia Press, 2011), 132–133.
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59. Troy Plummer, Thursday, May 6, 2004, Pittsburgh, PA, <https://groups.yahoo.com/neo/groups/UMCalledOut/conversations/topics/2509>, accessed June 20, 2014. Hymn: "What Does the Lord Require of You?," words by John Carter, © 2009 Hope Publishing.
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62. Melvin G. Holli and Paul M. Green, *A View from Chicago's City Hall: Mid-Century to Millennium* (Mount Pleasant, SC: Arcadia Publishing, 1999), 11. Columnist Jim Bishop writes, "After each election, he whispered the same speech because he knew no other: 'As mayor of Chicago, I shall embrace charity, love mercy, and walk humbly with my God'" (Jim Bishop, column for King Feature Syndicates, "Daley: Last of the Dinosaurs," July 31, 1978).
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CHAPTER 34

THE PROPHETS AND PASTORAL CARE

MICHAEL S. KOPPEL

IN 1991 Charles Gerkin published *Prophetic Pastoral Practice: A Christian Vision of Life Together*, in which he develops a practical theological model in response to this question: “[P]astors and lay persons need to gain clarity about just what sort of human beings we are seeking to help persons become under our care.”¹ Variations of this question have implicitly and explicitly informed scholarship in pastoral theology and care over the past 25 years. Psychology as a field and psychotherapy as a practice exerted a profound influence on religious communities and the formation of pastoral leaders in the twentieth century. In the twenty-first century, pastoral theology and care have continued to expand and develop to include a diversity of scholarly voices with an emphasis on contextual approaches to individual and communal soul care.

Larry Kent Graham addresses the division between the pastoral and the prophetic in *Care of Persons, Care of Worlds*, and advocates for a psycho-systemic model of care with persons that includes interpreting, challenging, and transforming the systems and structures that impede health and well-being. Graham argues that prophetic and pastoral dimensions of ministry have been “fractured into competing claims” and that a “new constructive relationship” between “prophetic perspectives and the orientation of contemporary pastoral care” is needed.² My pastoral theological view assumes that God calls people to *shalom*, the experience of wholeness within self and alongside others in covenant community. Pastoral care thus pertains to relationships with individuals and within communities, and is primarily a listening-focused activity in which clergy and lay people engage with an intention toward well-being. Pastoral care providers serve as stewards of story listening and sharing, which is often a tension-filled space marked by ambiguity and complexity. Care with individuals and community necessarily requires reflection on practices to remove impediments and to cultivate wholeness.

I consider salient connections between pastoral care and the prophets in order to foster a covenant relationship, and propose a method for care that assumes that coming to understand who we will become must start with current identity and experience.

Caregivers and care receivers cooperatively share in this work, which requires (1) bringing a pastoral theological and care lens to the prophets and prophetic texts; (2) surfacing connections and disconnections raised by the mutual engagement of texts and pastoral care issues; (3) exposing potentially harmful care practices; and (4) affirming beneficial care practices for individuals and communities.

Pastoral care in dialogue with the prophets can mutually inform well-being as well as needful change in personal and communal life. Abraham Heschel argued against type-casting the prophets; they do not inhabit one role, but many: “poet, preacher, patriot, statesman, social critic (all—not just one or two).”³ Pastoral caregivers also inhabit many roles, often becoming “scavengers” who collect the discarded and use it for life.⁴ Pastoral multiplicity finds parallels in prophetic multiplicity. In the Hebrew Bible, the most often used term for prophet is *nabi*, or intermediary, one who stands between God and the people in order to move them toward action or to frame the meaning of events. Pastoral caregivers also stand “between” God and people, helping individuals and communities to interpret experience and to discern life-giving action.

The prophets and pastoral care both emerge from and speak to cultural contexts. While concerns are often shared among people from different backgrounds and historical locations, care practices are also inherently local and particular. The prophets, too, are located in contexts with messages tailored to their communities. Literature in the field of pastoral theology and care reflects a methodological and practical commitment to contextual analysis that considers intersecting dimensions of personhood: personal, familial, ecclesial, social, and political realities; mental and physical health; gender; ability; class; ethnicity; sexual identity and orientation; power and authority; and, history.⁵

Pastoral caregivers help people to observe, draw connections, engage interpretations, and take steps that make sense within an individual’s or congregation’s worldview. Pastoral care leaders need to be aware of the disruptions that may occur in people’s lives, and to assess regularly who benefits from these disruptions. Otherwise, care may inadvertently instigate emotional retreat or defensiveness, the opposite of the desired outcome. The prophets also are contextual messengers as they interpret the relationship between God and God’s people in history. The prophets give attention to what the field of pastoral care calls “particularities,” the concrete and specific concerns that occupy most pastoral care conversations. People care about their lives and how God is present with them. So do the prophets.

PASTORAL IMAGINATION

Walter Brueggemann identifies the two primary tasks of the prophetic consciousness: to criticize and to energize. Prophetic consciousness challenges what he calls the royal consciousness: “The task of prophetic ministry is to nurture, nourish, and evoke a consciousness and perception alternative to the consciousness and perception of the dominant culture.”⁶ Such ministry requires that pastors and congregants continually lift up a

more just and peaceable world of relating in all matters of life. Pastoral care draws from a rich constellation of metaphors to describe this important work.⁷ Movement toward an alternative future includes an honest reckoning with the present, not as one hopes it might be, but as it actually is. Vital questions also include the following: What possibilities are being lifted up, and at whose expense? Who is included and excluded?

What does it mean to criticize and energize from a pastoral care perspective? Since ministries of care require an alliance of trust between pastoral care providers and people in need, it would be ethically inappropriate to be critical of individual people, but nevertheless appropriate to evaluate critically practices that bring harm to others. The model of prophets energizing people toward a shared goal (or reorienting self and community toward covenant commitments) can support communal and congregational pastoral care by helping groups of people to claim and carry out various ministries. In one-to-one care conversations, the energizing experience that matters most is the care receiver's ability to lay hold of vision that becomes lived reality. In congregational care, groups of people share in the energy of owning their responsibility to care with and for one another. In groups and with individuals, pastoral care leaders experience blessings when outer and inner events align in occasions of grace and possibility, moments that Carl G. Jung called "synchronicity." Energy comes from being present for spiritual and emotional epiphanies and from building covenant community together.

Growth in awareness is a key component of pastoral care. Pastors commit themselves to practices that increase the ability to see self and relationships with clarity and compassion in order to care effectively for others. Awareness, however, is not a static state but a continually developing capacity to open ourselves to see, and this seeing acknowledges that something exists, regardless of whether we like it or not. This seeing carries ethical responsibility, but so does "not seeing." Choosing to ignore, deny, or not-see something does not negate its existence, but only diminishes one's ability to take constructive action to affirm or work against its existence. Choosing to see and taking responsibility for seeing, as well as opening ourselves to what we do not yet see, can cultivate fruitful and life-saving work in pastoral care.

Awareness includes attention to details as well as the large picture. Prophetic pastoral caregivers hold in tension these dimensions of seeing in order to help people expand their worldview when the tendency is to focus on detail, or to narrow the view when the tendency is to globalize. The goal is to foster a whole seeing or consciousness. Prophets and pastoral caregivers together share a passion for growth into wholeness by helping people to become free of maladaptive patterns of mind and habit and to recognize the previously unnoticed. In the Temple sermon, Jeremiah 7:5–7 calls God's people to recognize the responsibility and benefit of living in right relationship with one another: "For if you truly amend your ways and your doings, if you truly act justly one with another, if you do not oppress the alien, the orphan, and the widow, or shed innocent blood in this place, and if you do not go after other gods to your own hurt, then I will dwell with you in this place, in the land that I gave of old to your ancestors forever and ever." Family genograms⁸ and community mapping benefit the practice of care. These tools help pastoral

caregivers and others see patterns, both beneficial and detrimental, which develop in families of origin and influence dynamics within congregations.

Dream images provide yet another means to foster sight through access to a symbolic world. Pastoral caregivers can invite people to pay attention to dreams as one means to tap unconscious knowledge and wisdom. Some people immediately dismiss dreams because the images presented can prove vexing, disturbing, surprising, or baffling. Instead of discounting images because of these qualities, however, we can instead learn to hold and to ponder them in a different way. Practices of keeping a dream journal, drawing, reflecting, and painting can be beneficial means to connect with the unconscious.

The visions in Amos 7–9 reflect this symbolic and surfacing of the unconscious: God presents the symbol and then asks Amos, “What do you see?” New things are revealed in this process. This dialectic occurs also in Jeremiah 1:11–16: God’s question, “Jeremiah, what do you see?” leads to unfolded meaning. Visions and dreams contain specific, and some would say peculiar, images and symbols. They may be initially puzzling, but upon further reflection offer an expanded form of seeing and knowing. Pastoral care practitioners stay sensitive to particularities in dream images, helping people to interpret what they see by (1) reflecting on various features; (2) evoking feelings and making associations; and (3) connecting internal meanings with outer events. Dreams can carry the residual imprint of an individual psyche, and they can also represent meaning for communities, so benefit and learning can emerge from group sharing. In listening and responding to dreams, caregivers can encourage people to preface their response with the statement, “If this were my dream. . .” to indicate personal reflection on an image.

ANGER AND FAITH

Anger is a complex emotion with options toward constructive or destructive action. At the core for many people is how to work with simmering anger. Anger may signal discontentment with the status quo, as it sends the message: things ought not to be so. And yet, they are. Anger is a challenging emotional state for many Christian people who have equated “meek and mild” with an idealized standard of what it means to be a person of faith. The prophets challenge this notion, as well as many other pre-established notions of what it means to live faithfully. The prophets continually recast and reshape anger through recognizing and harnessing its energy in an effort to call, castigate, and care for communities while simultaneously challenging and cajoling entrenched and established power structures. Prophets prompt individuals and communities to make way for increased expression of God’s just realm, and for the peaceable coexistence of peoples and values. The prophets also speak to the ways that people get sidelined or absorbed by the mundane. Such absorption in triviality angers God. In Jeremiah 11–20, the prophet expresses his personal anger and despair (cf. 15:10: “Woe

is me, my mother, that you ever bore me, a man of strife and contention to the whole land! I have not lent, nor have I borrowed, yet all of them curse me"). This very personal despair also represents the experience of the people as a whole as well; catharsis of the many is felt through the one.

Anger is a form of communication that calls people to attention. One author suggests that people learn to "make friends" with their anger instead of immediately moving into preconditioned patterns of reaction, which typically include avoidance or explosion.⁹ This dynamic energy source can move us toward compassionate action (for others and self) and also toward wayward recklessness. The energy of anger itself is not the problem, but rather its expression. We often associate anger with righteousness and holiness in the prophets. Pastoral care practice helps people harness anger for beneficial and life-giving use; one method for doing this includes (1) hearing the call; (2) discerning God's lure; and (3) strategizing a response.¹⁰ However, it must also be acknowledged that anger occurs within cultures and organizational networks; in short, not all anger carries the same potential for transformation. Consider the anger of a parent toward a child: anger inappropriately expressed in this context can do irreparable damage. Anger expressed between people of relatively equal status, such as friends or colleagues, may be uncomfortable and emotionally messy, but it is less likely to be soul-debilitating.

Anger in the Bible relates to persons, groups, and God, and it is most helpful for care purposes to distinguish what is called for in each situation. Most theologically nettlesome is God's anger. In Hosea 11:1–9, God's anger in verses 5–7 is sandwiched by love (v 1: "When Israel was a child, I loved him and out of Egypt I called my son;" v 8: "How can I give you up, Ephraim? . . . My heart recoils within me. . ."; v 9: "I will not execute my anger. . ."). God's heart holds anger and love, and God chooses to withhold one while expressing the other. Still, both are present, reflective of a relational God who is affectively hurt by a wayward people. Perhaps God models an authenticity that people can emulate: instead of pretending not to be angry, we can recognize how love intermingles with jealousy, hurt, sadness, and shame. God's anger also has an uncontrollability; see Jeremiah 7:16–20 (cf. v 20: "Therefore thus says the Lord God: My anger and my wrath shall be poured out on this place, on human beings and animals, on the trees of the field and the fruit of the ground; it will burn and not be quenched"). This anger is not restricted to the Hebrew Bible. Consider Matthew 13:41–42: "The Son of Man will send his angels, and they will collect out of his kingdom all causes of sin and all evildoers, and they will throw them into the furnace of fire, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth." God's anger can be frighteningly deep and can carry great destructive potential. So it is with us. Sometimes people are surprised by the depth of anger reflected in words spoken (e.g., "I cannot believe I said that; the power of it really scared me"). Absent reflective self-awareness, people can channel anger into horrifying action. For caring with anger and depending on context, the prophets offer messages of caution, challenge, and comfort.

LISTENING AS PROPHETIC ACT

We view the prophets speaking more often listening, yet often they do listen since prophecy is “human utterance inspired by a divine or transcendent source.”¹¹ The prophets listen with their whole bodies, “overwhelmed by the grandeur of divine presence” and from this receptive space they speak words of true speech.¹² The process, however, can be more turbulent and far less genteel than the image modern readers may harbor of psychotherapeutic listening that occurs in a clinical hour. In Jeremiah 1 (v 4: “Now the word of the LORD came to me saying. . .”) a simple conversation with God marks the prophet’s call, while in Isaiah 6, dramatic imagery surrounds the prophet’s call (v 2: “Seraphs were in attendance. . .”; v 4: “The pivots on the thresholds shook at the voices of those who called . . .”). Before Isaiah can speak, his lips must be cleansed with burning coal (v 6), and even that is not enough to make his message heard and understood by those he addresses (vv 9–10).

Prophets call us to live more aware of ourselves, our relationships with others, and our primary connection to the Holy. Listening is hospitable and intimate activity that requires up-close attention, and often calls for a response. “Listening,” as opposed to “hearing,” is used to distinguish the experience of empathic care from perfunctory reaction. Listening indicates an intellectual and emotional attunement to another person’s inner world that is attentive and respectful. Such a stance is an artful poise that relies on honed experience as well as pastoral care theory that helps practitioners unravel the cultural values and assumptions brought to listening.

Not all listening is the same; it requires more or less of us, depending on the situation. A template can frame different types of listening¹³ that occur between persons and within small groups. *Consonant* listening recognizes points in common, and is relatively easy to engage. We can relate to another’s joys and difficulties because we share them. The caution is that personal experience is limited, and it is possible to impose our experience or draw unhelpful conclusions. *Dissonant listening* recognizes points of disagreement, conflict, and discord among those present. A difference in experience and worldview can become so uncomfortable that listeners tune out emotionally or discount the other in an effort to regain equilibrium. *Harmonious* or *interpathic listening* indicates the learned ability to stand in the tension-filled space that contains elements of consonant and dissonant listening, as it allows persons and communities to express the fullness of their experience. In this context, *harmonious* is a term that captures the need for care practitioners to create space so that people can name and others can listen to the so-called positive as well as negative aspects of experience. This type of listening indicates a position that only God may usually see—the full blended wholeness of people and communities, replete with ambiguities and complexities. *Harmonious* or *interpathic* listening is the intentionally skilled practice of regularly checking in with one’s self and imaginatively inhabiting the mindset of another, recognizing that such interpersonal

relating must be done in humility and respect. Pastoral caregivers and communities of faith can mutually practice and model interpathic listening for the world.

Listening becomes prophetic in persons and communities when people catch glimpses of real and possible alternatives in the midst of their lived experience. The grand vision and soaring rhetoric of public prophetic proclamation matters little if people cannot somehow metabolize, by making their own, parts of a larger covenant worldview. Beneficial pastoral care helps people and communities sort and make sense of their experience. Pastors can encourage beneficial change in peoples' lives as they support them to take one sensible step at a time toward a new future. The prophets bring to the fore a capacity for *social listening*, an ability to take in the entirety of a situation and offer a response based on what is needed. Jeremiah provides language that the people themselves cannot speak because trauma has robbed them of this ability. The prophets "listen" to the evildoers in order to indict them. One inherent challenge for social listening and the rhetorical response is that people internalize the wrong message. The law-abiders take in the message intended for the evildoers.

Effective pastoral care requires connected relationship between the one who provides and the one(s) who receive. Jeremiah 4:19 demonstrates the prophet's felt identification with the people ("My anguish, my anguish! I writhe in pain! Oh, the walls of my heart! My heart is beating wildly; I cannot keep silent; for I hear the sound of the trumpet, the alarm of war"). The prophet empathizes with the people, both feeling and knowing the circumstances of their situation. People who experience empathy report the following qualities: "zest, action, knowledge, a sense of worth, and greater sense of connection that leads to desire for more connection."¹⁴

Pastoral and prophetic listening attends to the whole body. The prophets help modern religious people return attention to our bodies, since we can easily live as thinking creatures, caught in our heads and split from connection to larger reality. The method of focusing aids pastoral and spiritual care practitioners with healing the wounds of the dualistic split.¹⁵ By paying attention to felt experience, people can acknowledge and release troublesome feelings that get stuck in the body and cause ongoing pain. This theory suggests that since the body carries its own form of knowledge, people can learn to use the rational mind in order to reveal the body's intelligence. The practiced ability to inquire about bodily experience opens the possibility for people to release thoughts that otherwise take hold and cause distress. People benefit when care providers and receivers bring compassionate presence to this practice, which fosters the ability to be present to whatever is. Such practice helps people accept their real selves, as opposed to their imagined selves, and paradoxically makes way for shifts in experience so that over time what has been vexingly troublesome transforms, thus offering greater sense of inner freedom.

Imagery in the prophets signifies the visceral dimension of faith: knowledge of God and intimacy with the Holy dwells in the body. Ezekiel listens to God and eats the scroll (Ezek 3:3), taking the word deeply into his being and then speaking from that space. Jeremiah experiences the pleasure of eating God's word (Jer 15:16: "... I ate them, and your words became to me a joy and the delight of my heart"). Eating is to internalize and to be at one with the word, without separation. True experience also "speaks" through

gestures of the body, indicating that more than just custom is at work. Ezekiel falls on his face when God appears (Ezek 1:28b: “When I saw it, I fell on my face and I heard the voice of someone speaking”). And when Jeremiah considers not speaking what he has heard from God, he realizes the physical impossibility of this thought as “felt experience” akin to “something like a burning fire shut up in my bones; I am weary with holding it in, and I cannot” (Jer 20: 9b).

RESPONSES, OBJECTIONS, AND DECISIONS

The prophetic voice calls us to go deeper, and it can be mutually expressed by caregivers and care receivers. In a class on cross-cultural care, I expressed frustration about a systemic dilemma (while making sure not to reveal personal details). A student, having internalized the course material, simply said, “It’s a tension for you.” The student’s reflective statement became a prophetic voice. Hearing my reality named, I shared more of the issues involved, and conveyed to the class that this dynamic—of mutual call and response—could become part of their pastoral care practice. The prophetic voice emerges from students as well as teachers, parishioners as well as pastoral caregivers, and this voice crosses cultural, institutional, political, and social borders. Showing others how to receive and respond can be transformational in contexts of care. The prophets demonstrate mutual care response when they feel the suffering of the people (see Isa 40:2: “the prophet says that his people have paid double for their sins”). But the prophets also showcase a danger of mutual care: identifying too closely with the suffering of another person, and glorifying suffering (e.g., the Suffering Servant who does not complain).

When God calls, the prophets’ immediate response is to say “no.” Instead of acceptance, the prophet replies with hesitations, denials, and refusals, which are all objections to the call. Consider Jeremiah (1:6), who says, “For I am merely a youth. . . .” This literary feature reflects a key point in care: refusals protect a care receiver’s personal boundaries as people hold the right to say “no” to pastoral care. The phenomenon of care receivers deflecting advice also points up the inadvisability in pastoral care of attempting to give solutions when people in suffering situations mostly need compassionate accompaniment. Pastoral caregivers learn to receive the objections as an important step in the process of people taking ownership of an idea or possible action, not as a personal rejection of the care provider. Refusals effectively serve as a protective layer for personal and social relationships that may gradually recede as trust and acceptance grow. Still, care providers do well to honor these responses as real, and not fabricated. In Exodus 4:13, Moses offers this all-too-human reaction to God: “O my LORD, please send someone else.”

Changing lives is one purpose of the prophets and of pastoral care. The prophets intend to draw people toward a decision by (1) urging them to change in order to avert punishment, or (2) alerting them to inevitable punishment as a direct consequence of their actions. The prophets contextualize the peoples’ experience, as they offer warning

or comfort, depending on the circumstances. Neither prophets nor caregivers want to leave people unmoved; they just happen to carry out their work in different ways. A prophet goes to endless lengths in order to move people toward God. In the book of Jeremiah, the reader often cannot distinguish between the prophet's and Divine love, frustration, and pathos. Language reflects entwined experience. Prophetic pastoral care is also concerned about personal and communal movement toward God's justice, mercy, and love. Care providers themselves must be willing to plumb theological depths in order to benefit others. Pastoral caregivers help people navigate the decision points through a variety of practices: guiding, healing, empowering, liberating, confronting, and interrupting. Neither the prophet nor the caregiver can remain unaffected.

GRIEF, PAIN, AND SUFFERING

Pastoral caregivers accompany people through the valleys of grief. This ministry includes being with people through the rhythm of ordinary losses (such as the death of an elderly parent) as well as the traumatic (such as the catastrophic system loss in times of war or social migration). Whether and how pastors care for people in their grief can come to define a ministry. Pastoral folk wisdom suggests that congregants are willing to forgive pastors for mistakes and oversights, as long as they meet people at the times of deepest need, such as grief and loss. Pastoral presence communicates meaningful care through physical availability that may include periods of reflective silence interspersed with conversation. Intentional silence, the holding of space and being there for others, fosters emotional and spiritual healing, as it signals respect for stories that cannot or cannot yet be spoken. Caregivers, through receiving words of suffering and embracing holy silence, convey love and value for people.

Pastoral care and theology tend to loss, pain, and trauma; such personal and communal experiences also concern the prophets. Different types of loss—such as material objects, relationships, hopes and dreams, role in family and society, or large-scale societal loss—affect people in different ways. While the circumstances surrounding a loss differ, as do the emotional capacities for working with it, pastoral theological wisdom recognizes the importance of grieving as a process of working through emotional attachments. Sometimes the attachments involve people or things we love changing or dying; attachments also include viewpoints and habits of life that can be either life-enhancing or death-dealing. Regardless, grief care needs to be an intentional practice of individual and communal soul cultivation so that people can live into new possibilities. As a process, grief can be imagined as seismic shifting of worldview, involving primary commitments and psychological connections. “The capacity to grieve,” Brueggemann argues, “is the most visceral announcement that things are not right.”¹⁶ Grieving can be intensely difficult internal work and carries with it the growing recognition that life as it has been known will never be the same again. With loving attention and in time, people

may come to image grief as “a mosaic,” labor-intensive in the arrangement of particular pieces that form singular beauty that cannot be replicated.¹⁷

Tears often accompany soul suffering, and they reflect our humanity and God’s divinity. God and the prophets know suffering and pain, and can be partners in pastoral care as they shed tears of anguish as signs of relational connection with God’s people. Most interpreters attribute the tears in Jeremiah 8:18–9:2 to Jeremiah, but Kathleen O’Connor says they are God’s.¹⁸ The divine sorrow leads to two wishes: (1) to weep forever (“O that my head were a spring of water, and my eyes a fountain of tears, so that I might weep day and night for the slain of my poor people!”; 9:1/8:23 Heb.), and (2) to escape (“O that I had in the desert a traveler’s lodging place, that I might leave my people and go way from them!”; 9:2/9:1 Heb.). A God who weeps suggests helpful pastoral care practices, as the image allows pastors to release from rigid gender and social expectations and to be an *embodied* presence with others. It is necessary, however, to watch how often (“always,” “sometimes,” or “never”)¹⁹ and under what circumstances one cries. Ongoing assessment is required of care providers in order to help, and not burden, the vulnerable.

The prophets suffer as they inhabit the intermediary space between God and the people. Jeremiah 8:18–19 (“My joy is gone, grief is upon me, my heart is sick. Hark, the cry of my poor people from far and wide in the land: ‘Is the Lord not in Zion? Is her King not in her?’”) prompts confusion: Is it God or Jeremiah speaking in anticipation of suffering to come? Ezekiel is told to not mourn the loss of his wife (24:15–16), just like those in exile who could not mourn. The prophets speak to a community of disobedient people, and the prophets suffer along with the people. It can be especially problematic when texts intended for the whole are internalized by marginalized people, further exacerbating their suffering (as may be the case, for example, with someone who has been abused).

DEATH AND VIOLENCE

Given the prevalence of means to deny death, pastoral caregivers can lead others with a prophetic question: How do we live faithfully in light of our mortality? For the prophets, death has various dimensions: God’s limit for creatures (Isa 40:6–8); continual threat through emotional and physical separation from self and community; curse for covenant violation; and enemy of God that will be defeated in the end.²⁰ Pastoral caregivers need to grow in comfort with talking to people around death and dying, being willing to discuss the topic and to challenge harmful theological notions such as death as a form of punishment. Death can just as well be a result of choices people make. It can also simply be a mysterious unknown, for which no rational explanation seems sensible.

The prophets refuse to let people hide behind excuses and façades, and they are particularly insistent on matters of life and death. The prophets reinforce a beneficial care practice for pastors and other caregivers: learning to use the language of death (e.g., Jeremiah 7, Isa 5:25; Jer 9:20–22). Such language use holds up a mirror to contemporary care by

helping people to face and to name reality in direct and care-filled ways. The choices made and theological reflection on meaning will be different depending on the person's or community's social location, but the prophets provide a rich tapestry for the interpretation of death. In Isaiah, the Suffering Servant sees suffering and death positively; the Servant songs serve a redemptive function, which can be either helpful or problematic: this theological view provides a meaningful explanation for suffering, but it can also stifle effective action toward change of contexts and relationships that precipitate pain and suffering. Helping individuals and communities to navigate faithfully the landscape of their concrete reality is the tension-filled work of prophetic pastoral care.

The prophets and pastoral care temper one another, in necessary and important ways. Interpreters often want to find more comfort than is present in the texts. Helping people to make sense of the textual language represents constructive work that pastoral theologians and caregivers bring to the conversation. The prophets' messages can be startling. Hosea 10:10 delivers the warning: "I will come against the wayward people to punish them; and nations shall be gathered against them when they are punished double for their sins." Since God loves Israel (11:1), though, God will not execute fierce anger (11:9). The intertwined messages of "I love you" and "I am going to punish you" are further complicated by confusion about whether God or the prophet is speaking. Also people need to wonder what kind of love is actually communicated through punishment, or whether love ever can be conveyed appropriately in this way. Jeremiah 8–10 also confuses love and punishment. One can hear language in a parenting style that says, "This spanking is going to hurt me more than it will hurt you!" Pastoral care questions need to be raised: Under what circumstances is punishment helpful or harmful? And for whom? How does the connection of love and punishment create problems in faith communities?

Texts and human practices need to be interrupted when life and well-being are threatened. The textual method of stopping and questioning a text and blurring the boundaries between the contexts of texts and readers brings readers to a moment of ethical decision-making.²¹ Interrupting the text correlates with the pastoral care practice of interrupting. Space is created for people to decide what to do with a text: whether to imitate, complete, retell, or just take a hard look at it. This practice of pastoral care interruption might not initially fit well with the hermeneutics of some people of faith who may be accustomed to accepting texts and situations rather than challenging them. But this practice is essential for those who intend to thrive by resisting death-dealing aspects of familial, cultural, and ecclesial life.

Pastoral caregivers need to be watchful of how liturgical and biblical language can be unhelpfully internalized by those who have been traumatized or violated, and are especially sensitive. Consider this line from a contemporary version of the Lord's Prayer in *A New Zealand Prayer Book*: "In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us."²² The seemingly beneficial rendering of the traditional language, "Forgive us our debts [or sins] as we have forgiven our debtors [or those who sinned against us]," can still liberate or burden. Imagine yourself as a poor person of Judah after Babylon devastated the land. You and your family and entire community have been traumatized by these events. Now

imagine yourself praying: “Forgive us for absorbing the hurts.” Or perhaps you are a young adult who has just been sexually assaulted by your boyfriend: “In the hurts I have absorbed, forgive me.” How might this language be injurious? Even more challenging, imagine yourself as an adult who as a child lived in a hostile and abusive household with a primary care provider who belittled and intimidated you. You absorbed the hurt of that environment, and now you are asked to forgive. Pastoral caregivers must help guard against the perpetuation and internalization of messages that reinforce the social and self-blame of the victimized and vulnerable.

Pastoral care steps into the textual gaps in order to interpret experience and theology so as not to blame those who have been injured, which could result in re-traumatization. Meaningful care instead strengthens an alliance toward justice with those vulnerable and calls to account perpetrators and patterns of dysfunctional and oppressive systems. Rarely does this mean just one thing since people inhabit complexity. The injured can also participate in injuring themselves and others. Beneficial care practices, though, rest upon pastors and other practitioners who anticipate the difference between how language *may function* for different audiences and how it *actually functions*. Caregivers must pay attention to how people internalize language as they make sense of their interior world. For a traumatized, injured, or in-pain person to internalize a prophetic message intended for a whole community or for a privileged elite is problematic. The prophetic literature can serve as *cathartic release* as the faithful hear the prophet bear witness to punishment of the wicked, and know that God’s justice stands with them.

GROUP PROCESS

Prophetic pastoral care includes and extends beyond individualized conversations. Care in groups and community settings opens people to the wider communal dimensions of faith, potentially opening heart and mind toward just and right relationship. Encounter with others, especially around a biblical text, establishes “a ‘contact zone’ or ‘the space of colonial encounters’ where separated peoples come into contact with one another.”²³ A contact zone creates a shared social space for those who have been interpersonally and socially disconnected to connect with their own human dignity. People who experience social and ecclesial marginalization bear the imprints of that harm in mind and body. Self-imposed and socially inflicted patterns interlock to reinforce a dominant consciousness that keep people sick and resistant while also in need of change. A group contact zone opens the possibility for people to learn about others and to know themselves more fully, and to build bonds of trust. Groups and gathered communities offer benefits to support health and to challenge systemic patterns.

Groups offer potential for people to develop alternative relationship practices. Such is the hope for pastoral care classrooms, clinical settings, and congregations: helping people grow in faith, mindful of our interdependence. Groups carry out a prophetic function that individuals alone cannot accomplish. Enlightened leadership works to

safeguard the boundaries so that groups do not reify false beliefs, separate insiders and outsiders, and resist critical feedback. Participation in groups enlarges our humanity when together we ask questions, analytically reflect, and take action for the common good. This is vital for what Judaism calls *tikkun 'olam* (repair of creation).

Different kinds of ecclesial groups have various purposes: therapeutic, educational, and missional. Some serve primarily therapeutic purposes, as is the case with church support groups, while others have educational functions, such as confirmation. Still others may be task-focused, such as a judicatory mission group. Pastoral leaders and educators can respect the primary functions of groups while also working to harness their prophetic power that emerges from being together with and for others. Groups can also resist the prophetic by becoming insular and protective. Pastoral care providers, thus, need to pay attention to the prophetic possibilities as well as limitations of groups as they help create “safe-enough” space. Practitioners need to adopt covenant guidelines and policies for nonviolent action and communication. Pastoral care practice with groups needs to include personal and social analysis in order to expose patterns that fuel misconceptions and harmful stereotypes. Group contact theory, for communication within institutional settings and for coalition work within and beyond organizations, provides a theoretical platform to develop fruitful ministry. Caring leaders know that destructive power differentials can exist within any human network; thus groups need to hold themselves accountable to covenant standards even as they advocate toward justice and peace for all.

LIFE'S PROPHETIC DIMENSION

Pastoral care helps people tune in to their experience, providing the space for knowledge of self and God, and championing people who are ready to take prophetic action. A parishioner once spoke of riding his bicycle on a spring day following a long, hard winter. With sunshine filling the sky, a slight wind, and blossoming beauty all around, he spoke about grief convulsions that caught him by surprise, which he interpreted as inner prompting to draw closer to the things he holds dear. Perhaps it is true, as the opening voice-over conveys in the movie *Patch Adams*²⁴: “All of life is a coming home.” The prophets and pastoral care together call and care for people toward home by communicating a message attuned to the time—whether before, during, or after exile.

The prophetic dimension of care asks that caregivers attune themselves to the alternative vision being presented in peoples' experience. Sometimes caring work involves watching as the story unfolds. In 2011, after emergency surgery to release an infection near his brain, my father awoke in the intensive care unit of a Sacramento hospital and spoke a few words. Having trouble understanding what was being said, the physician called me over. My father, through post-anesthesia haze, kept saying with slurred speech: “I'm here. I'm not dead yet.” The physician wondered if it was a form of hallucination. I said, “No, it's his sense of humor.” I knew then he would be fine. Most unhelpful in the experience was the chaplain who, upon learning that my father had just had brain

surgery, said, “It’s not a good prognosis.” Regardless of whether she spoke a truth that the physicians could not utter or she was simply wrong, the chaplain’s statement was infuriating. Hospital chaplains should never cross the professional boundary of communicating a medical prognosis with patients and families. Given this experience, it was all the more surprising and delightful to witness my father’s steps forward in the following weeks and months. A couple of years ago, he actively sought a new church home with my mother when their church closed. “It’s not easy looking for a new church after nearly 45 years in one place,” said the man who had been irregular at best in church attendance for the last 25 years. He grasped something through his experience that may be known only to him or only to God. What occurred in private certainly had a public expression as they together participated more deeply in community with others, for others. People inhabit the prophetic dimension of faith as they allow for and work toward “the possible future” that includes and extends beyond their own personal well-being.

FAMILY SYSTEMS THEORY

Pastoral care and the prophets share common ground in helping manage anxiety triggered in situations of stress and transition. Systems theory bends toward the optimistic: it posits that problems are not located in people, but rather within relationship patterns established between people in a community. It is a helpful complement to theories that tend primarily toward the individual psyche. Family systems theory informs pastoral care practice in significant ways, by providing pastoral leaders with a conceptual framework to manage anxiety. It helps leaders to name what is going well in healthy situations and what seems to be amiss in unhealthy ones. When processes and relationship function well in a congregation or community, pastoral care providers have much to celebrate. In times of stress and transition, when anxieties rise, pastoral caregivers need to be able to interpret the situation and to contribute beneficially to the emotional and relational environment.

Leaders can positively affect the tenor of an organization by relating with people in emotionally available and respectful ways and by adhering to role responsibilities and boundaries. Deeply embedded in family, political, and social systems, the prophets see the dysfunctional patterns and name them (Amos 2:6; Mic 2:1–2; Jer 7:5–11). People resist the prophetic message because it means the entire family system has to shift. A shift causes disequilibrium in the status quo; healthy as well as unhealthy systems tend toward the state of *homeostasis*, or keeping things the way they are. Patterns are developed within families and organizations over a long period of time, and the *extended family field* can be as influential as current living members. Instead of taking sharing responsibility for what needs to change, families and societies displace energy on to one who is labeled as *identified patient* but is actually the carrier of a system’s pathology; this is also known as scapegoating. *Emotional triangles* emerge when two people, usually in conflict, draw a third person into the disagreement to stabilize the tension,

which complicates that relationship and causes increased stress for “the third” who gets drawn in. Being able to reposition oneself out of such complicated relational dynamics is a helpful pastoral care skill as well as life skill. Systems pastoral care requires that pastors bring intellectual clarity and emotional connection to any context of ministry. This leadership posture allows care practitioners to be responsive and not reactive. Reactive patterns include compliance (agreeing when one would rather disagree), rebellion (doing other than what is needed or asked for), power struggle, or emotional distancing.²⁵ Responsive caregivers tend to their own thoughts and feelings, and support and encourage others to do so as well. Effective pastoral caregivers and prophets need to stay emotionally connected to people, to respect their own and others’ personal and professional boundaries, and to clarify responsibilities and expectations. The goal is not simply to avoid being drawn into unhealthy patterns within a system, but to contribute to the emotional and spiritual flourishing of a community.

PROPHETS AND PLAY

We do not ordinarily associate pastoral caregivers or the prophets with the practice of play. This has to do, in part, with the definition of play, which I define as the developed capacity within one’s self and between self and others for delighting in God’s presence and restructuring the barriers that inhibit such experience.²⁶ Play can be a practice that fosters enjoyment within already established parameters, and it also includes the ability to invert habits of mind and society that stifle growth and creativity. Play as holy activity can be as much about self-transcendence as it is about social transformation. As self-transcendence, play has the ability to lessen that which solidifies a sense of self, such as perfectionism and narcissism, and fosters abilities to laugh at one’s self and with others, to improvise, to engage in efforts just for their own sake, and to make mistakes and to learn from them. Play, in this sense, develops first-order change, that which is internal and interpersonal change, but is not related to larger systems. As social transformation, play also seeks to reorder social structures, laws, and regulations that injure and marginalize people. Play, in this sense, is second-order change,²⁷ which alters systems. Both aspects of play are important, and both serve liberating purposes for the human psyche and God’s realm. Play becomes a prophetic activity, beneficial for personal and social transformation as pastoral caregivers and receivers welcome themselves as God’s beloved works-in-progress who, along with the prophets, seek the transformation of the world.

CONCLUSION

Intersections between the prophets and pastoral care expose rich possibilities for biblical interpreters and for care practices. The work can be rigorous because the two have

often been disjoined. Yet drawing connections and insights, while provisional, necessarily enhances understanding of the prophets' contexts as well as our own. Each person and community of faith must make real the vision of God's *shalom*. Judgment is rendered not in reaching the goal, but in faithfulness to the task of cultivating well-being for self and others. Charles Gerkin wondered, "What sort of human beings are we helping people become?" This evocative question continues to beckon theoretical and practical response in pastoral care.

NOTES

1. Gerkin 1991: 15.
2. Graham 1992: 18.
3. Heschel 1962: xiv.
4. Dombkowski Hopkins and Koppel 2010: 9.
5. A sample of this growing body of literature, particularly in relation to gender and ethnicity specific care, includes Montilla 2006; Wimberly 2006; Stevenson-Moessner and Snorton 2010; Poling and Kim 2012.
6. Brueggemann 1978: 13.
7. See Dykstra 2005.
8. See, for example, McGoldrick, Gerson, and Petry 2008.
9. Saussy 1995: 141, 139.
10. Saussy 1995: 117.
11. Richardson and Bowden 1983: 473.
12. Heschel 1962: 16.
13. Dombkowski Hopkins and Koppel 2010: 161.
14. Van Deusen Hunsinger 2006: 157.
15. Gendlin 1982.
16. Brueggemann 1978: 20.
17. See Kelly 2010.
18. Dombkowski Hopkins and Koppel 2010: 148.
19. Dombkowski Hopkins and Koppel 2010: 149.
20. Hunter 2005: 261.
21. Fewell 2003: 32–36. Also, see Dombkowski Hopkins and Koppel 2013: 2.1–2.18. The author expresses appreciation to Dr. Hopkins for her indefatigable collegiality and wisdom, valuable gifts that aided in the research and writing of this project.
22. *A New Zealand Prayer Book* (= *He Karakia Mihinare o Aotearoa*; London: William Collins, 1989; reprint San Francisco: HarperCollins, 1997), 181.
23. Dombkowski Hopkins and Koppel 2010: 158.
24. The 1998 film *Patch Adams*, directed by Tom Shadyac for Universal Pictures, was released in the United States and Canada. It depicts the story of a doctor, Hunter "Patch" Adams, who advocated the importance of humor for the healing of patients and the transformation of the US healthcare system. See Adams's book, *Gesundheit! Bringing Good Health to You, the Medical System, and Society through Physician Service, Complementary Therapies, Humor, and Joy* (with Maureen Mylander; Rochester, VT: Healing Arts Press, 1993).
25. See Richardson 1996: 93–100.

26. Koppel 2008: 14–15.
27. For a distinction between first-order and second-order change, see Paul Watzlawick, John Weakland, and Richard Fisch, *Change: Principles of Problem Formation and Problem Resolution* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1974).

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CHAPTER 35

THE PROPHETS AND HOMILETICS

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IN many churches today, the least preached portion of the Bible is the prophetic literature. The reasons for this may vary, but many preachers will attest to their discomfort about tackling prophetic biblical texts.

Some clergy avoid the prophetic books of the Hebrew Scriptures because of the prophets' harsh oracles of judgment against Israel and Judah. They assume that in order to follow in the prophets' footsteps they, too, need to discern and proclaim a Word from God against the very people they are called to love and serve, and they are uncomfortable doing so. Consequently they take the path of least resistance, and avoid taking on the prophetic mantle altogether.

Others associate prophetic preaching with social justice preaching—preaching that names and addresses the corporate sins of nations and communities—and they are all too aware that preachers who dare address such issues from the pulpit do not always fare well in ministry. All we have to do is remember the number of prophetic pastors who suffered threats, were harassed, and even lost their jobs during the US Civil Rights movement, or who have been vilified for preaching against their nation's engagement in a popular war, to remember how costly such preaching can be. Prophetic preaching challenges and criticizes the status quo. And such criticisms do not make for popularity and prosperity in ministry.

Still others were raised or are ordained in denominations that tend to favor preaching from non-prophetic biblical texts, and thus find themselves following that same pattern in their own ministries. Consider, for example, pastors from sacramental liturgical traditions who preach from the Revised Common Lectionary, but who are subtly encouraged to favor preaching from the Gospels or Epistles over preaching from the Hebrew Scriptures, given that their liturgies regularly lead to the Communion table (thus encouraging a christological sermon focus). This is not to say that there are not prophetic passages in the New Testament as well; at the very heart of its witness is the prophet

Jesus. But over time such preaching diminishes the importance of preaching from the whole Christian canon—including the Latter Prophets (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Book of the Twelve) in the Old Testament.

We have also encountered seminarians who have been attending church their entire lives, yet for whom the whole notion of “prophetic preaching” is altogether novel. Marvin McMickle bemoans the way in which certain African American congregations have favored preaching a prosperity gospel, or engaging in worship that is devoted to “getting your praise on” at the expense of prophetic witness.¹ Pastors from Pentecostal and certain evangelical traditions attest to the fact that a strong emphasis on personal conversion and individual engagement with the Holy Spirit can override concerns for prophetic witness in their denominations.

In this chapter, we begin by debunking some of the myths related to prophetic preaching and its nature, positing that such preaching ultimately offers hope and good news in the midst of a discordant and unjust world. We will then show how the very prophetic books that are too often avoided in the pulpit offer themes and perspectives that are essential for living our lives as people of God today. Third, we will address challenges involved in trying to bridge the ideational and ethical differences between the social values and theologies of ancient Israel and those of contemporary Christian congregations. Finally, a concluding section will illustrate how the biblical prophetic literature may be helpful for advancing the broader aims and purposes of Christian preaching as those have been identified by contemporary homileticians.

INTRODUCTION: PROPHETIC PREACHING IN THE CONTEMPORARY CHURCH

First, we pause to define what we mean by the term “prophetic preaching.” By “prophetic preaching” we are referring to two kinds of homiletical practices. First, “prophetic preaching” here will signify preaching that confronts and challenges the status quo in light of the witness of the Scriptures. As Walter Brueggemann defines it, “*The task of prophetic ministry is to nurture, nourish, and evoke a consciousness and perception alternative to the consciousness and perception of the dominant culture around it*” (2001: 3; emphasis original). Such preaching engages both in *criticizing* the old unjust order and in pronouncing God’s judgment upon it, and in *energizing* its hearers by positing a new vision of God’s intended future and calling them to live into it (Brueggemann 2001: 3–5, 9–19). When such preaching is undertaken in conjunction with the Latter Prophets, preachers become engaged in what homiletician John McClure has called “an imaginative reappropriation of traditional narratives and symbols for the purpose of critiquing a dangerous and unjust present situation and providing an alternative vision of God’s future.”²

A second homiletical practice that we consider to be “prophetic preaching” is preaching that mediates for contemporary believers any of the dimensions of truth-telling

and identity formation performed by the prophetic books. Critique of social injustice is only one aspect of the rich resources offered by the Latter Prophets for the reformation and building up of congregations of believers. The ancient prophets call their audiences to deep reflection on Israel's sacred traditions, candid acknowledgment of communal and generational sin, and courageous embodiment of holy living in witness to the power of their God.

Debunking Three Myths about Preaching and the Prophets

1. Prophetic preaching is not primarily angry, judgmental preaching. The Hebrew prophets loved and identified with their people, and we, following in their footsteps, are called to do the same.

Biblical scholar Balmer H. Kelly used to maintain that how we interpret the Hebrew prophets has a lot to do with the tone of voice we use when we read their words aloud.³ If we read their words in judgmental and condemnatory tones, then likely we will perceive them that way. But if we remember that the prophets loved their people, and yearned for them to listen to God and follow God's ways, then we may read and hear them differently.

At times the prophets do speak with a righteous rage against the injustices and misperceptions they observe around them. "I hate, I despise your festivals, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies," says the God of Amos (5:21). "Therefore says the Lord God: My anger and my wrath shall be poured out on this place, on human beings and animals, on the trees of the field and the fruit of the ground; it will burn and not be quenched," proclaims Jeremiah (7:20). Yet even that rage is born out of love for the poor and the oppressed in their midst. Furthermore, anger over the people's sins is not all that we hear in the prophetic corpus. We also hear of God's compassion: "When Israel was a child I loved him, and out of Egypt, I called my son" (Hos 11:1). We hear promise: "The wolf shall live with the lamb, the leopard shall lie down with the kid, the calf and the lion and the fatling together, and a little child shall lead them. . . . They will not hurt or destroy on all my holy mountain" (Isa 11:6, 9). We hear consolation: "Comfort, O comfort my people, says your God. Speak tenderly to Jerusalem, and cry to her that she has served her term, that her penalty is paid, that she has received from the LORD's hand double for all her sins" (Isa 40:1–2). And we hear redemption:

The days are surely coming, says the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah. . . . I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people. . . . I will forgive their iniquity, and remember their sin no more. (Jer 31:31, 33b, 34c)

The prophets loved their people enough to confront them, much as a parent who has had to confront a recalcitrant and wayward child. They couched their words of correction within a corpus of literature that also conveyed their desire that the people of God turn from their erring ways and respond to the God who embraced and loved them still. Prophetic preaching today calls us to love our people that much as well.

The Hebrew prophets also identified with their people. Jeremiah laments, “For the hurt of my poor people I am hurt, I mourn, and dismay has taken hold of me. Is there no balm in Gilead? Is there no physician there? Why then has the health of my poor people not been restored? O that my head were a spring of water, and my eyes a fountain of tears, so that I might weep day and night for the slain of my poor people” (Jer 8:21–9:1). Our call, then, as prophetic preachers is not so much to take on the mantle of righteous judgment, standing against our people armed with the Word of God, as it is to take on the mantle of loving companion, standing with our people under the Word that judges us all.

2. Prophetic preaching is not solely about criticizing unjust practices and bringing people news of God’s judgment. The Hebrew prophets also energized their hearers by proclaiming the best news imaginable: that God is at work in the world, that God is doing a new thing in our midst, and that we are invited to embrace and live into the new reality God is bringing to pass. Consequently, prophetic preaching is filled with hope.

There is no question but that there is a criticizing element at work in the Hebrew prophets of old. But in many prophetic books, prophetic critique is counterbalanced with visionary language of promise and hope. For example, in First Isaiah we find this frightening oracle of judgment: “Therefore says the Sovereign, the LORD of hosts, the Mighty One of Israel: Ah, I will pour out my wrath on my enemies, and avenge myself on my foes! I will turn my hand against you; I will smelt away your dross as with lye and remove all your alloy” (Isa 1:24–25). But these harsh words are immediately followed by a vision of restoration: “I will restore your judges as at the first, and your counselors as at the beginning. Afterward you shall be called the city of righteousness, the faithful city” (Isa 1:26). Or again, in Isaiah 10 we find searing words of judgment: “The light of Israel will become a fire, and his Holy One a flame; and it will burn and devour his thorns and briers in one day. The glory of his forest and his fruitful land the LORD will destroy, both soul and body, and it will be as when an invalid wastes away” (Isa 10:18). But in the next chapter, we hear the promise of a shoot that shall come forth from the stump of Jesse—foretelling the advent of a wise and faithful ruler—and of God’s establishment of a peaceable kingdom (Isa 11:6–9).

All too often, prophetic preachers today proclaim the judgment of God without also proclaiming the hopeful vision of the new and re-creative things God is already bringing to pass. We hear too few “I Have a Dream” sermons that inspire the people of God with a new vision for the future of justice and equality that God intends, and too many sermons dedicated to analyzing the social ills of our day, calling people to

accountability but offering little in terms of hope for the future. At its best, prophetic preaching should be filled with hope, because despite human frailty, belligerence, and disobedience, God is still at work in the world, and ultimately, the future belongs to God.

3. Prophetic preaching is not partisan political preaching. It transcends lines of division among political parties, calling upon people of faith to align themselves with a new standard of living and acting: that revealed in the Word of God.

The prophets of old dared to speak truth to power, no matter which party or group was in control. Think of Nathan confronting David (2 Samuel 12), Elijah confronting Ahab and Jezebel on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18), and Jeremiah's conflicts with Jehoiakim (Jeremiah 36) and Zedekiah (e.g., Jeremiah 37). Those prophets were certainly "partisan" in the sense that they consistently announced that God stood on the side of the poor and the oppressed and against the oppressors, but they were not partisan in terms of viewing any one person or group as having a monopoly on what God requires. They were free agents of God who used their freedom boldly to call all people—including their own communities—to greater faithfulness.

All too often, prophetic preaching today aligns itself with one political party or another, advocating its agenda and criticizing its opposition. The Hebrew prophets call us to reclaim the freedom inherent in the prophetic calling. It is God who sets the agenda for prophetic preaching. While such preaching may well call upon us to confront politicians and others in power, we are also called continually to test our proclamation against a higher standard than the ones politics offers us. Does a particular policy or action benefit God's poor and oppressed people? Does it further the will of God for peace, equality, and justice on earth? Does it liberate people and set them free to become all that God intends them to be?

Recent Homiletical Work with the Prophets

In recent decades, preaching from the prophets has not been a major focus for homiletics. While occasional books have been written in this area, more work needs to be done. Elizabeth Achtemeier (1998) has encouraged pastors to reclaim the "Book of the Twelve" for preaching. Achtemeier lamented the fact that the Common Lectionary included only twelve passages from the sixty-six chapters of the Minor Prophets to be used as texts of the day, with three books (Obadiah, Nahum, and Zechariah) omitted altogether. She also noted that most of the texts included occurred during Year C, which means that congregations encounter few texts from the Minor Prophets in the two other years of the three-year cycle (1998: 1). She urged lectionary-based preachers to add more texts from the prophetic corpus to their preaching schedule in order to do justice to the fullness of the biblical witness. Achtemeier's book provided brief commentary on the historical context, theological context, and sermon possibilities from each of the Minor

Prophets. Her interpretive approach arises out of her Biblical Theology orientation to the Scriptures, in which there is a strong emphasis on the God who acts in human history to judge, redeem, and save.

James Ward and Christine Ward (1995) look at prophetic preaching from biblical, theological, and homiletical perspectives. The Wards examine not only how the preacher might move from biblical text to sermon, but also how a preacher can begin with contemporary issues and use prophetic literature to address them. They posit a “problem-resolution-new possibility” sermon form as holding great promise for preaching the prophets, and provide examples of sermons using this form in their book.

While Achtemeier tends to envision the preacher taking on the mantle of prophet and bringing a word of God’s judgment to a sinful people from without, the Wards stress the fact that “the prophet is the representative of the community and not merely its critic or adversary. . . . Deep down, there is no difference between the prophet and the people. In their humanity, their responsibility, and their need, they are one. It is this oneness that makes prophetic preaching possible” (1995: 12). The Wards acknowledge that the prophetic witness of the Scriptures is not limited to the books of the Hebrew prophets: “In a sense the whole Bible is prophetic, for the judging and saving word of God comes to the people of God through the whole scriptural witness”; however, they choose to deal with the prophets “not only because of their intrinsic merit but because they ordinarily receive less attention in preaching than other parts of the Bible” (1995: 13).

Other books call for a reclamation of prophetic preaching in general, but are less focused on preaching a particular portion of the biblical corpus (see, e.g., McMickle 2006 and Tisdale 2010). While these authors draw wisdom and inspiration from the Hebrew prophets for taking on the mantle of prophetic witness today, they tend—with the Wards—to see the whole of the Scriptures as fertile ground for prophetic preaching. Similarly, Ronald Allen and John Holbert urge preachers to adopt “a hermeneutic of critical solidarity between the church and the Hebrew scriptures”⁴ in order to avoid the supersessionist tendencies that are frequently seen in Christian preaching. Contending that the First Testament is “a paradigm of God’s presence, purpose and power,” they outline a twelve-step sermon preparation process that can assist in preaching this Testament without belittling or diminishing its import for either Christians or Jews. They specifically refer to prophetic literature both in their chapter on texts and themes that are suitable for preaching from the Old Testament (for example, *hesed* in Micah 6 and in the book of Jonah, “deliverance” in Amos 9, and “justice” in Amos 5) and when they discuss “texts that apparently offer little to the Christian pulpit” (as in their discussion of the dangers of preaching prophetic judgment upon Israel and other nations today).⁵

Also instructive in this regard are a number of writings by Walter Brueggemann. In “Preaching to Exiles” (Clarke 1998: 9–28), Brueggemann considers biblical exilic literature—which includes prophetic and other texts—to be important for countering the “defeatist sensibility” in whose thrall he finds the contemporary Church (13). He offers six learnings from biblical exilic texts relevant for homiletics:

1. Preachers should help congregations grieve the loss of “old patterns of life and faith” (10).
2. Preachers should carry with us cherished memories and artifacts of life as it had been (15).
3. Preachers should claim biblical “motifs voiced as hope against despair” (17).
4. Preachers should promote a sense of the sacramental as response to the holiness of God (19).
5. Preachers should acknowledge “that the world is *not morally coherent*” (26; italics original) and face the theological crisis catalyzed by the issue of suffering.
6. Preachers should practice strategic storytelling, building congregations’ capacity to engage the “risky process of negotiation” (23) required of believers in a secular culture.

We turn now to two dimensions of the prophetic corpus important for preaching: key themes and motifs in the prophetic texts, and ways in which the actions of the prophets might shape prophetic preaching today.

THEMES AND MOTIFS IN THE LATTER PROPHETS

Preaching invites believers into meaningful engagement with the transforming power of Scripture. Scripture is not a single story or even a single grand meta-narrative. The “Heilsgeschichte” model so popular in the mid-twentieth century speaks part of the truth of what Scripture signifies. But not all of Scripture is about God’s sovereignty or love; not every biblical text concerns itself with grace or narrates redemption. Scripture is “about” countless refractions of the Holy in the lives of communities of believers rejoicing and struggling, praying and lamenting, and surviving over many centuries in a variety of regions and subcultures of the ancient world. These diverse refractions of the Holy are articulated in dialogue with one another, as Walter Brueggemann has made clear in his heuristic model of Old Testament dialogism as the testimony and counter-testimony of courtroom witnesses.⁶ Yet Christian readers can tend to focus on the surface meaning of passages or tropes in isolation. It is vitally important for the preacher to become steeped in the longer arcs and delightful complexities of God’s Word, so that in preparing each sermon, the preacher can be formed by the depth and fullness of God’s revelation, even if most of what the preacher knows will not be spoken in any given preaching moment.

The prophetic call for justice and moral integrity (e.g., Amos 2:6–8; 5:24; Mic 6:6–8) has been heard well and deeply by Christians. But we know from our work with divinity students preparing for ministry that other dimensions of the Latter Prophets can tend to blur together in believers’ imaginations, if they have read the prophets at all. Here

we will focus here on two other motifs shared across prophetic books: the Exodus, and changing the heart. Then we move to salient motifs in Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Book of the Twelve. We hope this discussion will assist in organizing the theological and ethical resources of the prophetic corpus for preachers. We hope it may also stir the imaginations of those who preach the Gospel, drawing them deeper into the vitality and complexity of ancient prophetic witness.

Exodus Traditions

Amos, Ezekiel, and Deutero-Isaiah work in diverse ways with the ancient tradition that the LORD delivered the Israelites from slavery in Egypt and protected them through their wilderness journey to the Promised Land. Amos, a master of ironic reversal, alludes to the Exodus in scathing ways aimed at disrupting his audience's self-confidence as a covenant people. Amos 3:1–2 offers a blistering word of judgment against “the whole family that I brought up out of the land of Egypt,” foregrounding not God's gracious redemption of a beloved people but that people's unique accountability: “You only have I known of all the families of the earth; therefore I will punish you for your iniquities.” Amos 9:7 mocks the people's self-assurance as cherished subjects of God's redemption, the prophet suggesting that God has redeemed many peoples, including Israel's hated enemies: “Are you not like the Ethiopians to me, O people of Israel?” says the LORD. “Did I not bring up Israel from the land of Egypt, and the Philistines from Caphtor, and the Arameans from Kir?” The prophet's rhetoric of dispossession, surely alienating or even insulting to his ancient audience, runs at the core of Israelite self-understanding. Amos's prophetic barbs may be hard to hear, but they may motivate the implied audience to seek to become worthy heirs of their covenantal heritage once again.

Ezekiel, too, uses the Exodus tradition in a deconstructive mode. He dramatizes his people's enduring sinfulness, underlining his governing theological claim that the LORD does all—for weal or woe—for the sake of the holy Name rather than as a response to the imagined merits of Israel. Ezekiel 20 characterizes the Israelites as having been defiant from the moment God swore to redeem them from slavery. The prophet rails that Israel refused to cast away their detestable idols and rejected God's ordinances. The deliverance from Egypt becomes a history of Israel's malfeasance in which God was poised on multiple occasions to destroy the people. This rereading of deliverance as shame and barely escaped obliteration is extraordinary for the way in which it highlights God's power for judgment.

Deutero-Isaiah reclaims the Exodus tradition in the post-exilic age, when Israel's release from captivity in Babylon was assured or had already happened. In luminous poetry, Isaiah describes the people being led home, rejoicing, in a new exodus through wilderness that has blossomed and become a place of springs (Isaiah 35; 40:1–11; 43:1–21; 52:7–12). God's power to deliver is rearticulated, framed as a new thing that had always been God's plan from of old. The coupling of ancient deliverance and redemption in new circumstances would have been formative for believers seeking to actualize ancient

sacred traditions in the Persian period and later. Isaiah's stirring imagery of deliverance is regularly claimed in today's Christian congregations; the theological possibilities are particularly rich for the season of Advent.

How might preachers engage Scripture's deconstructive uses of Exodus traditions? Drawing on Amos and Ezekiel, contemporary preachers may ironize false understandings, not only of secular culture, but also of the Church. Those who preach a "prosperity gospel" may be sobered by Ezekiel's emphasis on God's deliverance as being for the sake of God's Name rather than as a reward for righteous behavior (Ezek 36:22; cf. Titus 3:5). Preachers who insist on the privileged position of a particular theological position or liturgical practice (literalist biblical interpretation, say, or full-immersion baptism) may be brought up short by the searching critiques of Amos. A Christian homiletical word spoken in love must stop short of shaming those who hold dubious views, but the preacher may show deftly just how inadequate are the foundations of believers' misreadings of theological tradition that yield a spiritually unhealthy sense of entitlement.

Changing the Heart

The importance of changing the heart is articulated in vivid terms in Jeremiah and Ezekiel, who in artistic and rhetorically sophisticated ways urge Israel, "Get yourselves a new heart and a new spirit!" (Ezek 18:31). The "heart" was understood in Israelite culture not primarily as the site of affective dispositions such as romantic love but, rather, as the seat of cognition, discernment, and moral judgment. Rebelliousness is inscribed on the heart, per Jeremiah, using a trope implying indelible fixity: "The sin of Judah is written with an iron pen; with a diamond point it is engraved on the tablet of their hearts" (Jer 17:1). The calcification of sin in the moral faculty of the people is dramatized by Ezekiel via the metaphor of "heart of stone" (Ezek 11:19; 36:26). For these prophets, sin is embedded at the very core of God's covenant community. It is not simply a matter of bad ethical choices, or a maturity that is still to evolve as life lessons are learned; the prophets would have contested the notion cherished in some streams of contemporary spirituality that communities or individuals are "works in progress" with which God is not yet finished. The transformation enacted by God, then, will disrupt the sinful heart in graphic ways. Consider Jeremiah 31:33: "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts," an engraving that will overwrite the sin inscribed there. Ezekiel is characteristically dramatic, envisioning the renewal of God's people with language evocative of surgery, if not vivisection: "I will remove from your body the heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh" (36:26). Even if the contemporary preacher does not ground the notion of original sin in these prophetic passages, there is substantive material here for exploration of ways in which sin has become constitutive of our thinking and living.

We turn now to selected motifs in Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel, followed by brief mention of themes in the Book of the Twelve.

Isaiah

The theological vision of the Isaiah traditions centers on God as the Holy One of Israel. Key to Isaianic theology is confession of a Creator transcendent in power, one who has planned and superintended Israel's history since ancient days. By comparison, other nations and their impotent deities are worthy only of derision. Isaiah of Jerusalem forcefully taunts enemies (see Isa 10:15–19 against Assyria and 14:4–21 against Babylon). The mockery of idols in Deutero-Isaiah is robust: “You, indeed, are nothing and your work is nothing at all; whoever chooses you is an abomination” (41:21–24). Those who rely on anything other than God are deluded, trusting in blocks of wood rather than the living God who controls creation and history (44:9–20; 45:9–21; 46:1–11).

God is named many times in Isaiah as the Holy One of Israel, starting in the opening verses of the book, where the people's rejection of God's authority is thrown into sharp relief (1:4).⁷ The majesty of God as Holy One is dramatized in the scene of the divine throne in Isaiah 6: the six-winged seraphim singing praises as the Temple shakes and fills with smoke renders in vivid imagery the power of God as King for a people whose communal life is organized and energized by the rituals of holiness. The contemporary preacher may draw in creative ways on this trajectory of profound theological thinking in Isaiah. For example, the preacher might inspire a renewed awe in God's power that could be catalytic for jaded and exhausted believers; the preacher might dramatize the futility of trusting in the “idols” of our contemporary context according to paradigms of corporate success, global media reach, or personal achievement; or the preacher might embolden a community battered by political oppression, poverty, or crime.

Another key motif at the center of Isaianic witness is the figure of the Suffering Servant as one who may seem vulnerable or powerless, but who will nevertheless effect reconciliation. The four Servant Songs (42:1–4; 49:1–6; 50:4–9; and 52:13–53:12) and related passages about the LORD's servant constitute a series of personifications of a multivalent figure who brings about God's purposes. Scholars have made excellent cases for the Servant being Israel itself (see, e.g., Isa 41:8), an actual king already known, a hoped-for royal or messianic figure, or the prophet himself as witness to the unfolding plan of God. For Christians, the dominant stream of interpretation regarding the Servant has been christological: this suffering figure beloved and appointed by God must be a foretelling of Christ. No single identification works well for every mention of the Servant. That fact itself could be used to illustrate the richness of scriptural signifying. The motif of the Suffering Servant invites homiletical appropriations that explore aspects of courageous and sacrificial leadership in the faithful community as those may be conceived before the time of Christ, during Jesus' own ministry, and in vocations in the subsequent history of communities of believers.

Jeremiah

A major motif in Jeremiah is the theological claim that God had tirelessly sent God's “servants the prophets” to the people of Israel, generation after generation, in a fruitless

attempt to turn them from their stubborn sinfulness (see 7:25; 25:4; 26:5; 29:19; 35:15; 44:4). The prophets had warned the community of its sin again and again, and thus the people now have no way plausibly to deny their own accountability. The goal of the prophets' exhortations and warnings had been to catalyze repentance. They sought to turn the people from moral sins and from religious malfeasance, construed not only as actual idolatry—worshipping other deities—but also as the metaphorical “adultery” of trusting in political alliances with foreign nations instead of in YHWH. Here, the preacher may invite listeners into the wondrous heritage of all God’s “servants the prophets,” teaching not only about the biblical prophets, but also about the saints (those recognized by church hierarchies and unofficial local saints), activists, poets, and others who have called communities to reform. A congregation may come to understand itself as being addressed by prophetic voices on a specific issue in their common life, or may come to embrace its own prophetic vocation more fully.

A second theme prominent in Jeremiah is the theme of inescapable divine judgment. The LORD was coming to punish the whole earth for iniquity, and the covenant people would not be (had not been) spared. The prophet writhes in agony, bitterly grieved at the desolation to come (4:19–21; 8:18–9:1 [Heb. 8:23]), but his intercessions will not succeed, as the LORD makes clear: “As for you, do not pray for this people, or lift up a cry or prayer on their behalf, for I will not listen” (11:14; cf. 14:11). Even Israel’s most venerable intercessors would not avail: “Though Moses and Samuel stood before me, yet my heart would not turn toward this people!” (15:1). The LORD vows to enact a terrifying new “exodus” that releases the people not to freedom but to pestilence, the sword, famine, and captivity (15:2–3).

The contemporary preacher should take care to work appropriately with the pathos and terror of the Jeremiah traditions, because readers of the Bible should not be left to struggle with these texts unaided. One possibility is to read “texts of terror” in Jeremiah from the perspective of trauma studies.⁸ Individuals and communities who have suffered grievous harm must be free to name their truths and wrestle with their pain in ways that yield meaning. Horrific experiences of invasion, siege, famine, death, loss, and forcible deportation are inscribed at the heart of the biblical witness; thus these traumas should not be ignored in Christian engagements of the Gospel. For proclamation to be effective, it must take account of believers’ despair and urgent theological questions about how we understand God’s agency in a world riven by violence. Without such truth-telling, preachers risk offering superficial words of comfort that cannot engage the traumatized and oppressed of this world, those for whom Jesus took up the scroll of Isaiah and read (Luke 4:18).

A third motif in Jeremiah is explored through the laments of the prophet, psalm-like compositions sometimes called the “confessions” of Jeremiah (11:18–20; 12:1–6; 15:10–21; 17:14–18; 18:18–23; and 20:7–18). In these poetic expressions of anger and anguish, Jeremiah struggles with his vulnerability to violent opposition: “I was like a gentle lamb led to the slaughter” (11:19); “You, O LORD, know all their plotting to kill me. Do not forgive their iniquity” (18:23). He acknowledges his frustration at the apparent flourishing of the wicked: “Why does the way of the guilty prosper? Why do all who are treacherous

thrive?" (12:1). Perhaps most memorably, Jeremiah dares to accuse God of violating his subjectivity through the compulsion of the prophetic vocation:

O LORD, you have enticed me, and I was enticed;
you have overpowered me, and you have prevailed. . . .
If I say, "I will not mention him, or speak any more in his name,"
then within me there is something like a burning fire
shut up in my bones;
I am weary with holding it in, and I cannot. (20:7, 9)

In these moments of struggle, Jeremiah stands in solidarity with all those who cannot fully understand God's purposes. Confusion and outrage can be faithful responses, especially in times of disaster when God seems to be distant or even working against a community's well-being.

Ezekiel

The visionary and disturbing language of the prophet Ezekiel offers compelling theological motifs for preachers. First, though, it must be acknowledged that Ezekiel's witness is a resource fraught with risk for contemporary appropriation. The florid language of punishment, shame, and slaughter employed by this prophet-priest underlines the loathsomeness of his people's sin and the ruthlessness of God's response.⁹ His rhetoric is designed to break through the audience's spiritual hardness of heart. It gives the believer much to ponder about the repellent nature of sin, but Ezekiel's language is so offensive that much of Ezekiel is rightly not read in worship contexts. Yet the intensity of the prophet's diction, which contrasts the vileness of rebellion against God with the luminous power of the Almighty, may be salutary for cynical hearers today, if a preacher is careful to avoid a homiletic of shame that could harm or traumatize listeners.

Here we will focus on three motifs: the eschatological Temple vision, the refrain "Then they [you] will know that I am the LORD," and the Valley of Dry Bones. First, we consider the eschatological vision of the new Temple in Ezekiel 40–48. Today's preacher can work with Ezekiel's words and with images from the history of reception to draw hearers into this magnificent vision. The specifics of Temple measurements and sacrificial rubrics may not be usable for every Christian preacher. But Ezekiel 40–48 promises a restored Jerusalem in an Edenic setting, something that can speak powerfully to believers in our anxious and conflict-riven world. The following images could be compelling indeed for a preacher helping a congregation to imagine renewal and hope:

- Sacred water flowing from the holy precincts into the desert, freshening stagnant water and providing habitat for countless fish;
- Abundant trees bearing fruit in every season and offering leaves for healing;

- A community that warmly embraces the alien, giving the outsider an inheritance among God's chosen people;
- A glorious city, flourishing in faithfulness and unassailable in holiness, renamed "The LORD is There."

A second motif in Ezekiel presents theological richness and challenge in equal measure. Dozens of times, this prophet employs a refrain from God, "then they [you] shall know that I am the LORD," to underline the point that God brings about everything that happens, whether for good or ill. It is not due to Israel's merit or covenantal love that God has redeemed Israel, nor is it because enemies are strong that Israel has suffered military defeat. Everything transpires under the control of the sovereign God for God's own purposes and especially for the sake of protecting God's holy Name. Thus we read,

I, I myself will bring a sword upon you. . . . I will lay the corpses of the people of Israel in front of their idols, and I will scatter your bones around your altars. Wherever you live, your towns shall be waste and your high places ruined. . . . The slain shall fall in your midst; then you shall know that I am the LORD. (6:3, 5–7)

This troubling image of a violent God is countered by irenic images of promise using the same diction of divine agency:

I will make with them a covenant of peace and banish wild animals from the land, so that they may live in the wild and sleep in the woods securely. I will make them and the region around my hill a blessing; and I will send down the showers in their season; they shall be showers of blessing. . . . They shall know that I am the LORD, when I break the bars of their yoke, and save them from the hands of those who enslaved them. (34:25–27)

Ezekiel is uncompromising: All that happens is in the plan and control of God. The prophet offers a wrenching honesty that purveyors of superficial versions of this theology do not. Every preacher should wrestle with the obvious theological challenge regarding God's agency in history and presence (or perceived absence) in trauma. Again, because the risk of doing harm from the pulpit is high with any unvarnished application of Ezekiel's theology, the preacher should consider with utmost seriousness how to work responsibly with this prophetic book. Some preachers may choose to be informed by their studies of Ezekiel without engaging these challenging texts from the pulpit.

Finally, Ezekiel offers a graphic vision of revival in his vision in the Valley of Dry Bones (37:1–14). The preacher should not hurry too quickly past the horrifying vastness of the image of slaughter (the valley "full" of bones) and the implication that the dead had long been forgotten (the bones "very dry"). Believers who have felt abandoned by God, seekers who find themselves in a spiritually desolate landscape, and communities struggling with violence or loss may need more here than a proleptic gesture toward

the resurrection of the individual in Christ. They may need to linger over Ezekiel's dramatic slow-motion narration of hope for rebuilding. The promise here—even amid the horror—is potentially catalytic: God can revivify the broken and abandoned body of a beloved community, bone by bone and sinew by sinew.

The Book of the Twelve

Much in the Minor Prophets may capture the imagination of the preacher. There may be the added benefit of the freshness of the material for congregations not accustomed to exposition of these prophetic books. Apart from well-known passages such as Amos 5:24 (“Let justice roll down like waters”) and Micah 6:6–8 (“What does the LORD require . . . but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?”) and the story of the fish in Jonah, significant portions of the Book of the Twelve may be unfamiliar to many. Among the themes and rhetorically artistic moments worthy of homiletical attention in the Minor Prophets are the following:

- Relationship metaphors in Hosea that figure God's covenant with Israel—especially Hosea 11, where God speaks with tender compassion about Ephraim as beloved child;
- Joel's unforgettable image of an unstoppable horde of locusts as metaphor for the Day of the LORD; God's promise that on the far side of judgment “I will pour out my spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions” (2:28);
- Ironical reversals and cunning rhetorical traps in Amos, along with doxologies that evoke God's power to destroy (4:12–13, 5:8–9, and 9:5–6), all intended to drive a complacent audience to “seek God and live” (5:4, 5:6; cp. 5:14);
- The terrible cost of fraternal betrayal explored in Obadiah;
- The compelling narratology of Jonah, which dramatizes the recalcitrance of God's servants, limns the challenges of the prophetic vocation, and shows the complexity of God's mercy;
- Micah's beautiful vision of the elevation of the Temple and reconciliation among all peoples (Mic 4:1–4//Isa 2:1–4);
- Nahum's affirmation of God's power to protect the faithful community by thwarting enemies, even one as notoriously cruel as Assyria;
- Habakkuk's desperate “O LORD, how long shall I cry for help, and you will not listen? Or cry to you, ‘Violence!’ and you will not save?” (1:2), which poses a theological question urgent for beleaguered individuals and communities in every age;
- Zephaniah's chilling depiction of God preparing a sacrifice in which the wicked will be “consecrated” for doom;
- The sardonic way in which Haggai holds the leaders of his people accountable, pointing to their living in “paneled houses” while God's Temple “lies in ruins” (1:4);

- The proto-apocalyptic visions of Zechariah 1–6, which have given rise to a fascinating history of interpretation;
- Malachi's insistence on integrity in liturgical leadership (chs. 1–2) and his memorable description of the LORD's Day as being like a refiner's fire (3:1–4).

One purpose of the preacher's art is to draw believers more deeply into Scripture. The inventive preacher will find many compelling avenues into God's Word in the Book of the Twelve.

PERFORMATIVITY AS WITNESS IN THE LATTER PROPHETS

In ancient Israel and Judah, the prophets mediated God's truth to their communities using every resource at their disposal. They witnessed to the purposes of God using not only the eloquence of their spoken oracles, but also their bodies and their relationships. The prophetic books, too, use creative strategies for communicating the Word of God. In addition to exhorting their audiences through the themes, motifs, and images that comprise the content of prophetic oracles, the prophets use a variety of performative tactics to make the redemption and judgment of God vivid. Contemporary preachers can learn much from the innovative ways in which the ancient prophets lived their vocation as witnesses for God.

Performativity Embodied: Sign-Acts

Within the plots of biblical books, several of the prophets perform sign-acts to illustrate messages of judgment and hope for their audiences. Prophetic sign-acts have been compared to street theater. These were dramatized public acts through which the prophet framed a radical understanding of a particular moment—present or future—in Israel's unfolding history. These sign-acts were expository utterances: They portrayed salient dimensions of ways in which God was acting or would soon act in the life of their communities.

Through actions rich with signification, the divine Word is written through the bodies of the prophets and their social and political relationships. The naming of their children, too, serves as a signifier for deeper theological truths. A child will be born, Isaiah is told (7:14), who will be named Immanuel ("God with us") as part of an oracle about the routing of Israel's enemies in the Syro-Ephraimite crisis. Isaiah's child Maher-shalal-hashbaz ("swift is spoil, plunder has hastened") represents Assyria's looting of conquered nations (Isa 8:1–4). Hosea's children Lo-Ammi ("not my people") and Lo-Ruhamah ("not pitied") are renamed in positive terms to signal redemption (Hos 1:6–10; Heb. 1:6–2:1).

Commanded to marry a sex worker named Gomer, Hosea's obedience is taken to embody the faithfulness of God to Israel, imaged as an adulterous and unrepentant prostitute. Amos's visions are icons of performative art. Each vision report constitutes a drama enacted in the moment of looking. Locusts devouring Israel's future, a shower of destroying fire, and something perhaps like a plumb line (scholars disagree about what this is): all are images of impending judgment. Amos also reports seeing a basket of figs (8:1–3), the visual and verbal blending in an alarming wordplay that suggests the horrific end of Israel, with “dead bodies . . . cast out in every place.”

Jeremiah wears a ruined loincloth as a sign that the covenant people God fashioned to cling to him have become defiled and good for nothing (Jer 13:1–11). The prophet is commanded by God not to marry, this as signifier of the upcoming rupture of Judah's communal “body” through invasion and siege: mothers, fathers, sons, and daughters will die of disease and lie unlamented and unburied (Jer 16:1–9). Ezekiel is warned by God that his wife will die and that he is not to mourn; the loss of one cherished is to be a sign of God's profanation of the Temple (Ezek 24: 15–27). Other signs by which Ezekiel dramatizes the Word of God involve lying bound on his side and eating rationed bread baked on dung to symbolize the coming siege of Jerusalem, and digging through the wall of his house and leaving with baggage to enact exile. What the LORD says to Ezekiel is relevant for all of the performative prophetic acts of the prophets: “I have made you a sign for the house of Israel” (Ezek 12:6).

Contemporary preachers may also be called to engage in prophetic sign-acts to give witness to their deepest beliefs about God and God's purposes for our world. A prominent Presbyterian pastor in Richmond, Virginia, not only preached peace regularly during the Vietnam War; he also gave away most of his income so that he would not be required to pay taxes that supported the war efforts. A congregation in New Haven, Connecticut, refused to hold any marriages in its church sanctuary until its denomination approved church marriages for same-sex couples. In a state capital city where many youth of color had lost their lives to gun violence, an ecumenical group of Christians—including local pastors and at least one bishop—gathered each week at the locale of one of the shootings to give witness to their opposition. Many of them never spoke publicly at these rallies, but their silent witness spoke volumes.

Performativity Spoken: Rhetorical Strategies

Prophets engage a host of complex rhetorical strategies to render their spoken words persuasive for their audiences. Abraham Heschel wrote of the righteous indignation and wrenching pathos of the biblical prophets:

The world is a proud place, full of beauty, but the prophets are scandalized, and rave as if the whole world were a slum. . . . To us a single act of injustice—cheating in business, exploitation of the poor—is slight; to the prophets, a disaster. To us injustice is

injurious to the welfare of the people; to the prophets it is a deathblow to existence: to us, an episode; to them, a catastrophe, a threat to the world.¹⁰

The drama of prophetic rhetoric and narrative secures the audience's attention and teaches the audience about what is at stake in the engagement of God with the world. Following are illustrative examples.

Deconstructing Tradition: Hosea and Isaiah 56

The poetic material in Hosea is turbulent and fragmented. One feature of this material is the prophet's deployment of geographical place-names that evoke Israel's past transgressions of sexual and other boundaries. The prophet effectively shames the audience intelligent enough to recognize the significance of each place-name in their own history.¹¹ Further, Hosea 4–13 is characterized by images of extreme violence, sickness, predation, and bereavement.¹² The prophet's discourse powerfully disrupts the audience's subjectivity as God's people: As God thunders, "I have hewn them by the prophets, I have killed them by the words of my mouth" (6:5). In a striking contrast, Hosea 14 offers lovely images of redemption that highlight restored relationships and fruitfulness. God's love "will be like the dew to Israel"; Israel "shall flourish as a garden, they shall blossom like the vine," and God will be to them "like an evergreen cypress" (14:5–8). Hosea's surprising move from rhetorics of shaming and violence to imagery of healing and fruitfulness may work to reform an implied audience whose subjectivity had become fatally distorted.

Isaiah 56:1–8 rewrites the halakhic legislation in Deuteronomy 23:1–3 prohibiting certain foreigners and those with crushed genitals from participating in Israel's worshiping community. Insider/outsider boundaries are inscribed with care in Deuteronomy and elsewhere in ancient Israel's legislation. But Isaiah proclaims a new thing: the LORD will honor eunuchs with "a monument and a name better than sons and daughters . . . an everlasting name that shall not be cut off" (56:5); God will bring foreigners to Mount Zion and "make them joyful in my house of prayer" (56:6). Isaiah's revoicing of tradition is astonishing.

The significance of ancient deconstructive witness for contemporary homiletics cannot lie in direct application of shaming techniques or rhetorics of violence; it goes without saying that such rhetorical practices could traumatize listeners. Nor should the Christian preacher seek to overturn Jewish halakha in any direct way as Isaiah 56 does, given the risk of perceived supersessionism in the Christian context. But instructive points of connection may be drawn between the ancient prophetic witness and our own Gospel proclamation. Isaiah 56 invites into the Temple those excluded from Israel's communal self-understanding in some streams of biblical tradition; contemporary preachers may fruitfully meditate on this move of radical inclusion as a hallmark of God's grace. Mulling the witness of Hosea and Ezekiel, the preacher may consider ways in which a congregation relies in dysfunctional ways on the "tradition history" of that community. The preacher may make visible the unhealthy aspects of a submerged

narrative of the church or nation, inviting listeners to step out of a story that once may have been adaptive but that can no longer sustain them.

Richard Lischer has described how Martin Luther King, Jr., deconstructs then-contemporary views of the nation in a sermon he preached in 1967 at Ebenezer Baptist Church. King begins by citing how “humanity . . . was destined for greatness” but was “dogged by its own failures to live up to God’s will.” Then King “brings his argument home to America, which is a great nation but. . . . The finest scientific minds have used their knowledge to make napalm to burn up villages and little babies. Scientists in the greatest country on earth have used their geometry and algebra to design better bombs. . . .”¹³ And so it goes. Eventually King’s rhetoric leads toward “the vocabulary and cadences that resonate [with] the First Epistle of John,” his text for the morning: “We know the truth, yet we lie. We know we ought to be just, and yet we are unjust. We know we ought to love, and yet we hate. We know we ought to follow the road that is high and noble. And yet we walk the low road. We know we ought to be pure, and yet we’re impure.”¹⁴ This is the kind of rhetoric that shakes people out of complacency and into action.

Truth and Irony: Amos

Amos uses irony to marvelous effect. The entrapment sequence in Amos 1–2 has the implied audience cheering God’s raining of punishment upon Israel’s enemies—Syria, Philistia, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab—only to be brought up short when Judah and Israel are named in the list of targets for divine wrath. A sarcastic call to transgressors to worship (4:4–5) is followed by a list of divinely wrought punishments that have failed to bring Israel back to God (4:6–11). “Prepare to meet your God, O Israel!” (4:12), then, becomes a chilling invitation to doom. The long-awaited Day of the LORD is to be “darkness, not light, and gloom with no brightness in it” (5:20); liturgical festivals designed to please God are despised by the deity; the divine justice so celebrated in Israel’s worship will come like a raging flash flood, sweeping away everything in its path (5:21–24).¹⁵ The performance of ironic reversals in Amos leaves the implied audience more vulnerable than straightforward theological propositions would have. The center of the book of Amos, then, is framed on a concentric structure of chiasms¹⁶ that position three imperatives at the heart of the prophet’s message: “Seek me and live!” (5:4); “Seek the LORD and live!” (5:6); and “Seek good and not evil, that you may live!” (5:14). Thus the discourse of Amos is animated by an ironizing of traditional theological claims that compels the audience to recognize its reliance on the LORD.

Charles Campbell and Johan Cilliers (2012) offer this example of how Will Campbell, an outspoken Southern Baptist preacher and proponent of racial equality and social justice during the Civil Rights movement, used irony in one of his sermons to unmask conventional assumptions and call people to a more radical biblical faith:

A fellow came by my house a few years ago and I asked him, “Do you believe the Bible literally?” He responded, “Yes, sir, my brother, word for word.” I said, “Well fantastic.”

I stood up, gave him a courtly bow and ceremoniously got my hat and cane, extended my hand and said, "I didn't know there was anyone else in the world who believed the way I do. The Bible says that the day has come to proclaim the opening of the doors of the prison and letting the captives go free. I've been looking for years to find someone who agreed with the literal interpretation of that scripture 'cause there's this prison in west Nashville and I can't tear the thing down by myself, but if there's 15 million folks out there who believe in the literal interpretation of Scripture, we can get them all together and raze that prison to the ground." He looked at me kind of funny and said, "Well now, what Jesus meant by that was. . . ." I shouted, "Don't you go exegeting on *me*." He said he believed in Scripture literally. But the prison's still standing.¹⁷

Desmond Tutu is a master of using the art of irony and lampooning in his sermons and speeches. During the height of the anti-Apartheid movement in South Africa he addressed the minister of law and order of South Africa with these words: "Mr. Minister, we must remind you that you are not God. You are just a man. And one day your name shall merely be a faint scribble on the pages of history, while the name of Jesus Christ the Lord of the church, shall live forever. . . ."¹⁸

Vivid Imagery: Micah, Isaiah, and Nahum

Dramatic imagery is central to prophetic rhetorical technique, leaving the audience with indelible impressions. Micah's depiction of corrupt rulers as cannibals serves to dramatize the evil of Israel's leaders and the horror experienced by those who are exploited, prompting in the audience a revulsion that is ethically formative: "Should you not know justice?—you who hate the good and love the evil, who tear the skin off my people, and the flesh off their bones; who eat the flesh of my people, flay their skin off them, break their bones in pieces, and chop them up like meat in a kettle, like flesh in a cauldron" (Mic 3:2–3). Equally vivid is Nahum's evocation of the terror of battle. The prophet uses a cascade of verbless clauses to suggest the chaos of an unstoppable military advance: "The crack of whip and rumble of wheel, galloping horse and bounding chariot! Horsemen charging, flashing sword and glittering spear, piles of dead, heaps of corpses, dead bodies without end—they stumble over the bodies!" (Nah 3:2–3).

As every preacher knows, a well-crafted image may endure in the imagination of an audience long after the rest of the sermon has been forgotten. Isaiah's depiction of the Peaceable Kingdom (Isa 11:6–9) is effective not only because of its lovely theology of peace but also because of the artistry with which the prophet "paints" the imagery. Malachi rebukes Israel's people and priests for their inadequate offerings and unethical practices, then offers an unexpectedly magnificent image to catalyze renewed devotion in his chastened audience: "But for you who revere my name the sun of righteousness shall rise, with healing in its wings. You shall go out leaping like calves from the stall" (Mal 4:2). Vivid prophetic images perform compelling dramas in miniature concerning what is at stake for the community. A preacher's use of dramatic imagery can open the heart and mind to new possibilities and can spur the audience to face what needs to be faced.

Good preaching not only invites congregations into the truth of the Gospel, it stirs up in believers' hearts a yearning for the Word of God and a holy curiosity about the ways in which God makes mercy, grace, and power known to us. The prophets themselves are preaching through the themes and motifs of their witness, and through the ways in which they perform God's truth with their bodies and rhetorical strategies. Their mediations of the divine Word are endlessly creative as they seek to draw their people closer to the Holy. The contemporary preacher's interpretive strategies must likewise be creative, drawing on the best in biblical scholarship and homiletical theory as the preacher seeks to make God's truth known.

CHALLENGES FOR PREACHING FROM THE PROPHETS

Violent Rhetoric in the Prophetic Corpus

A number of challenges face the Christian who preaches on the prophets. Chief among them is the violent rhetoric of some prophetic texts, which presents a serious stumbling block for their contemporary appropriation. This cannot be resolved simply by skipping over the most problematic texts. Consider the prophetic book most beloved in Christian tradition: Isaiah. The same Isaiah who offers beautiful images of the desert in bloom and the joyous return of the redeemed from captivity (Isaiah 35) also gives us the image of Israel enjoying the plunder of enemy nations and the abjection of vanquished monarchs in chains (45:14). The stirring call to restorative justice in Isaiah 61 is followed by the image of a vengeful God pouring out the blood of peoples (63:1–6). In each of these cases, the preacher cannot responsibly claim the first text without reckoning with the second.

Christian and Jewish traditions have struggled for centuries over how to work with these texts. A quasi-Marcionite rejection of the Old Testament is not an option for orthodox Christians, and sidestepping the problem does not serve our congregations well. We urge preachers to engage in sustained and prayerful wrestling, both with the texts themselves and with the hermeneutical issue writ larger. Helpful resources include Julia O'Brien's *Challenging Prophetic Metaphor: Theology and Ideology in the Prophets* (2008) and Eric Seibert's *The Violence of Scripture: Overcoming the Old Testament's Troubling Legacy* (2012).¹⁹ Newer methods of biblical interpretation, too, can be helpful. On violence in biblical texts, see in the present volume Chapter 26 (Christl Maier's "Feminist Interpretation of the Prophets"), Chapter 27 (Valerie Bridgeman's "Womanist Approaches to the Prophets"), and Chapter 29 (Steed Davidson's "Postcolonial Readings of the Prophets"). Further, preachers who immerse themselves in the history of reception of difficult texts may glean insights into the varied ways in which exegetes have addressed the violence of some biblical texts.²⁰

Equating Israel and “Our Nation” in Christian Preaching

One temptation for the preacher is to draw a direct correlation between God’s address to Israel in the prophetic books and God’s purposes for the preacher’s own nation. For example, the inclination to read US history as the history of the new “Israel” has a venerable pedigree going back to New England Puritanism. Harry S. Stout explains, “From the start of their movement in England, Puritans had used covenant theology to interpret Scripture and to explain the terms by which God saved sinners (the covenant of grace) and called individual nations to be his people (the federal covenant).”²¹ God was understood to “dis covenant” apostate nations, and Puritan ministers claimed the prophetic mantle as they warned their congregations about the possibility of divine punishment:

... [M]inisters found a variation on the [biblical] rhetoric of failure that served both to incite popular repentance and to reinforce their own self-image as the unappreciated saviors of New England. Increasingly they used occasional sermons to expand upon their own indispensability to New England’s covenant. ... For typological identification, they turned to the Hebrew prophets whose words of warning were not appreciated by the children of Israel.²²

But to read the Hebrew Scriptures in this way can be problematic on several fronts. First, in so doing, a preacher comes dangerously close to denying and usurping the unique covenantal relationship ancient Israel had with God. Second, we fall prey to a prideful nationalism that erroneously assumes that God has initiated that same sort of covenant with our own nation (versus all other nations of the earth). Finally, we dislodge the prophetic witness from its historical context, and in too facile a way collapse the distance between “then” and “now.” As Achtemeier reminds US preachers,

The modern equivalent of Israel is not the United States of America, and American citizens, as a group, are not the covenant people of God. The United States is a pluralistic union, made up of persons of varying faiths and unfaiths, and there is no way in which it can be called God’s chosen nation. ... The preacher cannot lift a prophetic text out of its historical context and apply it, without further ado, to a modern congregation. ... The words of the prophets ... become God’s word to us very often on the basis of analogy. Our relation to God is analogous to Israel’s relation to him in the text, or our historical situation is analogous to Israel’s situation in the Old Testament history.²³

Preaching the Prophetic Books in a Narrow Promise/Fulfillment Mode

It is true that the theme of “promise” is significant in the prophetic books of the Hebrew Scriptures. It is also the case that Christians will invariably hear some of the promises

within the First Testament through the lens of God's work in Jesus Christ, and the fulfillment of those promises they have witnessed in Him. For example, the Church through the ages has interpreted the Suffering Servant songs of Isaiah as prototypes of the suffering and death of Christ.

However, problems arise when the Old Testament is solely or primarily interpreted in a "promissory" way in Christian preaching. First, to do so risks ignoring the historical contexts in which the promises to Israel and Judah were first made, and what those promises meant to the people who first heard them. For example, Isaiah's promise to King Ahaz of the birth of a child named Immanuel (Isa 7:1–17) meant something altogether different in eighth-century Judah than it does when we read it during Advent in a Christian church. Second, to focus only on "promise" in the Old Testament and "fulfillment" in the New denies the "fulfillment" that can also be observed *within* the First Testament, for example the fulfillment of the promise to the Israelites of a land they will one day inhabit, or the fulfillment of the promise to the Jews in the Babylonian Exile of their ultimate return to their homeland. Third, to focus solely on the "fulfillment" of promises in the New Testament may tempt hearers to forget that there are still yet unfulfilled promises within its corpus as well. We have not yet seen the "new heaven and new earth" that God will bring into being, or the fullness of the eschatological reign of God inaugurated in Christ. As Holbert asserts, "both Judaism and Christianity continue to yearn for the coming of eschatological shalom. Each community knows something of the fulfillment of God's pledges, but both communities and their testaments are partners in awaiting the final fulfillment of divine promise."²⁴

Finally, to engage consistently in a promise/fulfillment mode of preaching may contribute to the supersessionist manner in which Christians have tended to treat the Old Testament in Christian preaching—acting as if it were a lesser and unequal canonical partner, one that needs the Gospels and Epistles to "fulfill" it. Allen and Holbert call us instead to see the First Testament as containing a "paradigm of God's presence, purpose and power (as well as paradigms of human response to the divine presence and purpose)."²⁵ By dynamic analogy, preachers "acknowledge real differences between the worlds of the contemporary Christian listener and of the First Testament but at the same time . . . discover points of positive contact."²⁶

THE PROPHETS AND THE PURPOSES OF PREACHING

The prophetic literature constitutes a marvelous resource for scripturally grounded theoretical work in homiletics. The scholarly literature on homiletics is vast and cannot be surveyed in any comprehensive way here. Instead we will offer brief soundings in homiletical theory via an important collection of essays by prominent homileticians: *Purposes of Preaching*, edited by Jana Childers.²⁷ Following are just a few of the ways in which

the prophetic literature may contribute to the aims of Christian preaching as those have been identified by leading contemporary scholars in homiletics.

- Charles Campbell asserts that the goal of Christian proclamation is “the building up of the community of faith as a people who practice the way of God, as embodied in Jesus Christ, in and for the world” (24). Toward this end, preachers must help congregations “resist the powers of death” (25) that promote vengeance, “violent domination of the ‘other,’” spiritual competitiveness, and the desire for wealth (34). The literary trajectory of Micah is relevant here: resistance to misuses of power in Micah 1–3 yields to reconfigurations of theology and ethics in community (chs. 4–6) and a renewed focus on God as the agent of transformation (ch. 7).
- Jana Childers presses for incarnational preaching that foregrounds integrative embodiment of the Word, “[allowing] God’s Word to work through one’s own personality and expressiveness in such a way that both preacher and congregation are opened” to God’s purposes in Jesus Christ (47). A relevant prophetic model is Jeremiah, whose identity as priest, experiences of local opposition, and struggles with his vocation suffuse his first-person testimony and the ways in which his legacy is represented in third-person prose traditions within the book that bears his name.
- Teresa Fry Brown argues that “the central focus of preaching is seeking to mine the mysteries of God” (50) in a way that “provides hope-filled reconstruction of community with God at the center and fully in control” (52). Relevant here is the multivalent witness of the book of Isaiah. Isaiah 40–55 hymns the unfathomable purposes of God, celebrating the LORD’s sovereignty over creation and human history; Isaiah 56–66 engages the post-exilic work of reconstruction with words of uncompromising challenge and luminous promise.
- John McClure invites preachers to “learn to speak the language of *resistance*” and “learn to speak the language of *love*,” helping congregations deconstruct ways in which “the principalities and powers . . . co-opt the very language we speak” in order to lure us into false understandings of our identity (84–85, emphasis original). Relevant to McClure’s project is the dramatic way in which Hosea uses violent rhetoric to name the sins narrated in Israelite traditions, then reforms both language and theology in his resignifying of Israel as God’s beloved children (11:1–9; 14:1–9).
- Christine Smith avers that preaching should extend hospitable listening to those who have been silenced, decenter the powerful (104–107), “re-member the body of God and the body of the community” by claiming relationship with the marginalized and dispossessed (108), and foster right relationship in community (109). Amos’s revision of notions of privilege (3:1–2; 6:1–7), disclaiming of institutional power (7:14–15), and solidarity with the oppressed are most relevant here.
- Thomas Troeger calls preachers to use imaginative and creative means to confront “humanity’s genius for resisting grace” (117), helping congregations see “the possibility of refreshing the holiest dreams of the human heart” (122) and opening

believers to “our continuous dependence upon the source of all that is” (124). Highly relevant for this work is Ezekiel, with his remarkable vision of the divine Chariot and his insistence that in every moment, the community of faith must recognize that God alone is the LORD.

Other valuable insights are offered in *Purposes of Preaching* by Ronald Allen, Lucy Lind Hogan, Mary Donovan Turner, and Paul Scott Wilson. The horizon before us is expansive indeed. Much fruitful theorizing and transformative praxis may be done at the intersections of homiletical theory and interpretation of the biblical prophets.

NOTES

1. See McMickle 2006, especially chs. 5 and 6.
2. John S. McClure, *Preaching Words: 144 Key Terms in Homiletics* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2002), 117.
3. Balmer H. Kelly made this suggestion while a professor at Union Theological Seminary in Virginia (now Union Presbyterian Seminary) in the late 1970s when Nora Tubbs Tisdale was one of his students.
4. Ronald J. Allen and John C. Holbert, *Holy Root, Holy Branches: Christian Preaching from the Old Testament* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1995), 11.
5. Allen and Holbert, *Holy Root, Holy Branches*, 85–131.
6. Walter Brueggemann, *Theology of the Old Testament: Testimony, Dispute, Advocacy* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1997).
7. The divine appellations “Holy One of Israel” or “Holy One” occur also at 5:19, 24; 10:20; 12:6; 17:7; 30:11, 12, 15; 31:1; 37:23; 41:14; 43:3, 14; 45:11; 47:4; 48:17; 54:5; 60:14. The breadth of passages here shows that this theological understanding was central to the Isaiah traditions early and late.
8. Kathleen M. O’Connor offers an interpretation of Jeremiah from the perspective of trauma studies: *Jeremiah: Pain and Promise* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2012).
9. See, for example, Ezekiel 6:11–13, 16:1–52, and 23:1–49.
10. Abraham J. Heschel, *The Prophets* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1962), 3–4.
11. See Carolyn J. Sharp, “Hewn by the Prophet: An Analysis of Violence and Sexual Transgression in Hosea with Reference to the Homiletical Aesthetic of Jeremiah Wright,” in *Aesthetics of Violence in the Prophets*, ed. Chris Franke and Julia M. O’Brien (LHBOTS 517; New York: T & T Clark, 2010), 50–71.
12. For graphic images of rottenness and dismemberment, see Hosea 4:5; 5:14; 9:11–14; 10:14; 13:8, 16.
13. Richard Lischer, *The Preacher King: Martin Luther King, Jr. and the Word That Moved America* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997), 127.
14. Lischer, *Preacher King*, 127–128.
15. The Hebrew נחל איתן, often translated as “everflowing stream,” is better understood as a dangerous permanent flash flood.
16. For detailed arguments about structural features of Amos, see Jörg Jeremias, *The Book of Amos: A Commentary* (OTL; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1998).
17. Charles L. Campbell and Johan H. Cilliers, *Preaching Fools: The Gospel as a Rhetoric of Folly* (Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 2012), 196.

18. Address by Desmond Tutu as quoted in Allan Boesak's sermon "The LORD and the Lords," *Walking on Thorns: The Call to Christian Obedience* (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1984), 10.
19. Julia M. O'Brien, *Challenging Prophetic Metaphor: Theology and Ideology in the Prophets* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2008); Eric A. Seibert, *The Violence of Scripture: Overcoming the Old Testament's Troubling Legacy* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2012).
20. On reception history, two commentary series may prove valuable when relevant volumes on the prophets are completed: the Blackwell Bible Commentaries and the Eerdmans Illuminations series, which engage reception of biblical texts in patristic, medieval, and modern exegesis and in art, literature, and music. Preachers may also wish to consult the projected five-volume work *Hebrew Bible/Old Testament: The History of Its Interpretation*, edited by Magne Saebø (Vols. I–III; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1996–2014).
21. Harry S. Stout, *The New England Soul: Preaching and Religious Culture in Colonial New England* (25th anniv. ed.; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), 17.
22. Stout, *New England Soul*, 113.
23. Elizabeth Achtemeier, *Preaching from the Old Testament* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1989), 132–134.
24. Allen and Holbert, *Holy Root, Holy Branches*, 27–28.
25. Allen and Holbert, *Holy Root, Holy Branches*, 32.
26. Allen and Holbert, *Holy Root, Holy Branches*, 36.
27. Jana Childers, ed., *Purposes of Preaching* (St. Louis, MO: Chalice, 2004).

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*H. Future Horizons in the Study
of the Prophets*

CHAPTER 36

FUTURES IN PROPHETIC STUDIES

WALTER BRUEGGEMANN

OF course, no one knows about the future of study of the prophets. But two things seem clear. First, we are likely to be surprised by new emerging methods and perspectives, new critical judgments, and new interpretive extrapolations. Second, we are sure to continue rich diversity in method, perspective, critical judgment, and interpretive extrapolation. More than surprise and diversity we cannot know.

THE USUAL AND OTHERWISE

No doubt scholars will continue the well-worn paths of study. On the one hand, critical work will continue, both to ponder (and construct) historical settings of “original” utterance/writing, and to consider the processes for arrival at the “final form of the text.” We will continue to observe close source analysis and dissection, largely a German enterprise, and we will likely see “final form” drawn later and later.

On the other hand, interpretive focus on the “canonical” “final form” of the text will continue to trace the large thematic coherences of prophetic literature, thematic coherence as deftly articulated by Ronald Clements:

This message concerned the destruction and restoration of Israel, but special emphasis was attached to the latter. This was because this restoration was still looked for in the future, while the destruction was believed to have already taken place. The prophets therefore were felt to have foretold the future, but in certain very broad categories. . . . Distinctive patterns have been imposed on the prophetic collections of the canon so that warnings of doom and disaster are always followed by promises of hope and restoration. . . . The various preserved prophecies of a whole series of inspired individuals acquired an overarching thematic unity. This centered on the death and rebirth of Israel, interpreted theologically acts of divine judgment and salvation.¹

I find this approach most helpful, but am also aware that this approach is at times tempted to be reductionist in the interest of more dogmatic commitments. Both of these approaches—critical and canonical—will continue to energize our common work.

Beyond these staples of the discipline, newer ways of reading—feminist, post-colonial, reception history—will claim more and more of our attention. As more interpretive voices from outside the old hegemonic establishment gain a hearing, we will increasingly notice that the prophetic texts are not objects to be analyzed, but lively voices that continue to engage in compelling contemporary ways.

INTERPRETIVE CURRENTS THAT INFORM MY WORK

I take this opportunity, however, to focus on my own interests in research, for likely most of us anticipate such futures in scholarship in terms of what we ourselves might hope to do. Since I have been at this task so long, I think it is not necessary that I should do so covertly. My interest and expectation for future study of the prophets is much more in an interpretive or hermeneutical direction, although I am attentive to and informed by more critical work. I will identify four facets of such interpretive work that are attempts to take seriously methods and perspectives that move in an interpretive direction beyond critical preoccupations. Texts that are as durable and generative (and “classic”) as these continue to evoke interpretation that will run risks for the sake of a faithful contemporary reading.²

Rhetorical criticism, the signature term of my teacher, James Muilenburg, is an attempt to take seriously the actual articulation of the text with all of its subtlety, ambiguity, and cunning.³ One of the problems with much critical and canonical work is that in the end there is not much attention to or interest in what the text actually voices. Thus I anticipate that attention to rhetorical specificity of the prophetic texts will continue to be generative for us. It is crucial that most of the prophetic corpus is expressed in poetry that posits an open-ended imagination that refuses the closure and certitude of settled epistemology. Poetic idiom insists on elusiveness that witnesses against settled opinion and that attests inscrutability that will not be managed. Thus Seamus Heaney could say:

The poet is on the side of undeceiving the world. It means being vigilant in the public realm. But you can go further still and say that poetry tries to help you be a truer, purer, wholer being.⁴

Mutatis mutandis, the prophetic poetry is a summons to ancient Israel to be a “wholer” people in the context of the reality of YHWH’s purpose and will. It was said of Heaney at his death that in his own poetry he was “anxious that his lyrical gift not cushion hard truth.”⁵ So it is with these ancient prophets who speak in such a lyric of hard

truth that served to undeceive, both about denial and about despair. Such an accent on rhetoric requires great attentiveness to image and metaphor, on which see, for example, the old but model essay of Muilenburg on the images of “adversity.”⁶ Attentiveness to such playful, elusive matters pushes us to go beneath the flat work of historical criticism and the larger thematizing of canonical approaches.

More than that, the rhetoric serves the anticipatory capacity to envision a world other than the taken-for-granted world that is in front of us. If we take the destruction of Jerusalem in 587 B.C.E. as a pivotal point in prophetic literature, then we may say that pre-587, the taken-for-granted world is that of the royal-priestly establishment of the city with its mantras of chosenness, and post-587, the taken-for-granted world functions as and understands itself as an imperial power that imagined itself to be ultimate and beyond an answering to anyone for anything (see Isa 47:7–10). The “undeceiving” of prophetic discourse insisted on a world that these hegemonic centers of power, both pre-587 and post-587, had erased from awareness. The poetry, through all kinds of astonishing and affrontive imagery, refuses such erasure and insists on this other world that is before, behind, and beneath the conjured world of hegemonic power. Such a mode of discourse is inherently subversive, as it voices a sub-version of reality that refuses the dominant version. So much is inchoate in the “rhetorical criticism” of Muilenburg, a continuing project of sub-version in our interpretive work.

The capacity to take seriously such a subversive alternative to settled taken-for-granted public reality requires a move beyond a critical mode to what Paul Ricoeur has termed a “*post-critical*” perspective.⁷ By and large, critical scholarship generated in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries was a rejoinder to rigid orthodoxy; it is contained within the permits of Enlightenment rationality wherein the character of YHWH who dominates prophetic poetry is viewed variously as a “paper God” or as simply a new inclination in “religious history.” Enlightenment rationality could not seriously entertain such a God as attested by the prophets: a real character or a lively agent.

Of course not! But it is Ricoeur’s “second naïveté” that knows that, and yet can in good faith consider the voicing of such a character and such a world that comes with YHWH as a lively option to be considered.⁸ Thus I anticipate that post-critical work, outside the regime of conventional criticism, might entertain this lively character without whom the prophetic literature loses most of its seriousness.

The form critics, of course, have taught us that prophetic discourse, before and after 587, is largely constituted by speeches of judgment and promissory possibilities, both genres of which bear the voice and come with the authority of YHWH.⁹ The utterance of such speeches of judgment amount to an insistence that there are *non-transgressible limits* to human conduct and to public policy. The utterance of *promissory possibility* attests that there are, in the human process, ongoing *originary stirrings of fidelity against circumstance, no matter what*. Both such *non-transgressible limits* and such ongoing *originary stirrings of fidelity against circumstance, no matter what*, depend upon the utterance and sanctions of YHWH given in prophetic discourse. Our common critical bent is to ask if such claims concerning the shape of lived history might be said otherwise without the “supernatural” claim of a character and agent. To the question we may honestly

answer that it could be said differently, as for example in much sapiential articulation. But the fact is that the prophets characteristically do not say it otherwise; they say it this way with appeal precisely to such a character and agent. As a result, we must ask, what is lost if the agent who utters is explained away, or what is gained if the character who speaks is taken seriously? Like every good poet, these poets had no accidental words. They no doubt utilized the rhetoric of character and agent with great intentionality. The effect of such intentionality—in considering these two prophetic dominant genres—is that both non-transgressible limit and originary stirrings of fidelity are grounded in a personal, passionate resolve that causes our conversation about the world to be one of unnerving contestations of fidelity and infidelity. Such a remarkable claim—to which we have grown much too accustomed—is an astonishing claim. Thus I judge that the casting of lived reality in terms of contestation about fidelity depends upon such rhetoric that is a counter to the common reductionisms of technical reason and commodity transactions. Such post-critical insistence is acutely upstream in our critical world that wants to honor the norms of rationality all around us, norms that preclude such agency. But then, I have no doubt that in the ancient processes of utterance, transmission, and canonization the same acute upstream quality was required. I suggest that our capacity for such upstream interpretation is a faithful counterpoint to that ancient work, hazardous as it was then (on which, see Amos 7:1–17, Jer 36:26, and Isa 50:6).

Appreciation of such rhetoric in a post-critical frame of reference moves in the direction of *post-colonial study*. The categories of “empire-colony” imply that interpretation in the colony continues to be done on the terms imposed by the empire. No doubt in that ancient world of Babylonian and/or Persian hegemony, moreover, that temptation was acute and often observed in order to accommodate the requirements of empire. At the same time, however, poetic idiom linked to the agency of YHWH permitted utterance and expectation that refused to be contained in imperial categories. *Mutatis mutandis*, if the interpretive community of church, synagogue, or guild is a colony with a distinctive perspective, we are able to see about ourselves that as a colony we tend to operate with the assumptions of empire, that is, in our case, within the rationality of the Enlightenment that has morphed into market ideology that requires and limits certain modes of expression that serve certain horizons of public possibility. Post-colonial interpretation, against such an imposed or assumed inclination, at least may entertain the chance that reality can be voiced and lived outside of or against dominant expectations. Thus it is not an accident that playful attempts at the contemporaneity of prophetic utterance do not normally arise in the tenured guild, but arise among the socio-economic-political outliers who are not inured to guild rationality or to imperial requirement. It is exactly such outlier perspective that permits and evokes fresh readings that let us see and hear afresh what is at stake in prophetic utterance.

But of course, such risky alternative to imperial requirement evokes all kinds of necessary accommodations that may arise from actual threat or intimidation. Thus we are to see the prophets engaged in endless contestation in which there are various voicings of alternative and voicings of accommodation. The reason for that, obviously, is that a stance of emancipated possibility is not a settled state; it is rather a restive impulse

that waxes and wanes. Such ebb and flow, moreover, is discernible, not only in the ancient text but in our own interpretive work as well. The articulation of a counter-world that refuses the requirements of empire is endlessly contested and results in an uneasy ambiguity.

Thus I imagine that the ancient voices—and perhaps our own contemporary interpretation—may be not unlike the risks of peasant work that James C. Scott has discerned in his several studies.¹⁰ Resistance to dominant power by relatively powerless people with few “weapons” is a delicate process of caution, vigilance, and risk-taking, but not risks that are too hazardous. I can imagine that in the face of the Jerusalem establishment, or later in the face of imperial power, prophetic figures variously ran risks, sometimes more boldly than at other times. And I can imagine that we, situated as we are in “colonies” of church or guild or other communities with distinct identities and interpretive perspectives, may run interpretive risks, sometimes more boldly than at other times. The nature of these poetic voicings and the nature of dominant context require that our reading should be in some way engaged in the contestation that is mapped out in these texts.

It is clear that *reception history* will gain increasing traction in our work in time to come. Reception history is the awareness that meanings in texts are not all given by the text, but arise “on the other end” in the act of reading or hearing the text. Against an assumption that a text has one “original” meaning in one “original” context, reception history is the recognition that we “receive texts” with great imagination, propelled by the insistences of our own context in which we receive. The emergence of reception history as a method (if it is a method) is a resolve to accept such imaginative reception not as a mistake, but as a serious, legitimate enterprise to be appreciated as a pivotal point of the process of engaging an ancient text that claims authorization beyond our reason.

From the perspective of historical criticism, reception history is in principle out of bounds. To be sure, much reception history is quite quixotic; some of it is grotesque, especially interpretation that makes easy and direct connections between the ancient utterance and contemporary events. Thus, for example, I can remember during World War II, concerning the list of forfeited luxury items in Isaiah 3:18–23 that includes “tyres” (now translated as “turbans”), it was argued that this was a prediction of “tire rationing.” But the practice should not be judged by its most objectionable examples. Clearly much of what we now call “reception history” was often a serious attempt at theological exposition and interpretation done in good faith. The old mantra that “God has yet more light to break forth from his word” and the contemporary mantra of my church, the United Church of Christ, that “God is still speaking” indicates a readiness to move beyond what might be identified as “original” meaning.¹¹ The possible legitimacy of such reception, moreover, is made even more compelling when we recognize that a good deal of so-called “objective” interpretation has been in fact a disguised form of reception history. Beyond that, I cannot think of a study of the prophetic literature that does not contain within it some tacit act of “reception,” that is, meaning found “on the other end.” For all of these reasons, I believe that important interpretive questions are the following: How

shall we practice reception history ourselves in our own emerging social context? How shall we be trustworthy receivers? I pose these questions with four reference points:

1. How shall we receive prophetic texts in a closed world of scientism that is exemplified by the most notorious of the so-called “new atheists”? The potent combination of technical reason and the reduction of all of life to commodity that can be measured and managed make the question of “reception” an urgent one. Our conventional criticism has been ready to accommodate prophetic literature to that dominant ideology, or at best to take snippets of “justice” (as in Amos 5:24) without considering the systemic issues of a dominant narrative that is increasingly a narrative of death.¹² I suggest that Robert Jenson has it about right when he concludes:

We must have the audacity to say that modernity’s scientific/metaphysical, metanarrative is . . . not the encompassing story within which all other accounts of reality must establish their places, or be discredited by failing to find one.¹³

His reference point is Darwin, but from Darwin it is an easy move to connect his critique more generally to the social context of dominant culture. The dominant narrative of Western capitalism, expressed as scientism and commoditization, is not an adequate narrative for the long-term sustenance of a viable public life. The prophetic literature, like much else in the Bible, counters that dominant narrative with a narrative of neighborly justice and a theocentric focus that centers on the holiness of God. Thus justice against injustice and holiness against profanation become life-or-death issues. Our “reception” of this literature puts a very different agenda before us about public policy and social relationships.

2. How shall we receive prophetic texts in world of military globalism wherein the combination of military and economic power carries all before it? That combination of power, moreover, is increasingly in the hands of a privileged, protected oligarchy that cares hardly at all about the common good or about the crisis of the environment. Its hubris has been eloquently expressed by Francis Fukuyama, even though Fukuyama himself has happily forsworn the arguments of his well-known book, *The End of History and the Last Man*.¹⁴ In that context, we are met in prophetic literature with narrative, song, and oracle, peculiar utterances that have behind them no coercive power, either military or economic. The capacity of this collage of utterances, moreover, is the enactment of “sign,” a primitive performance of elusive reality that impinges on the settled arrangements of power. We may ponder how it is that the performance of sign in that ancient world was taken seriously, either in the entitled world of Jerusalem or later in the midst of arrogant imperial power. But that is what we have been given—signs in the context of originary utterance:

- so Amos can report visions of curses and finally an end (Amos 8:1–3);
- so Isaiah can refuse Ahaz’s defiance and issue a sign, a time-clock carried by a “virgin” (Isa 7:10–17);
- so Jeremiah can command a rock into the river to anticipate the fall of mighty Babylon (Jer 51:63–64).

The signs are not in a vacuum. They live and bear meaning only in a world of holy resolve that is not at the behest of violent power. The sign, issued in a variety of contexts, runs toward “the sacramental,” always constituted by concrete contextual performance that defies settled regimes and refuses settled power arrangements. Historical criticism has been ready to explain or explain away such signs; but we have evidence in our own time of the helplessness of worldly power in the face of such signs. That wonder runs all the way from the Eucharist in Pinochet’s Chile to Nelson Mandela at a rugby match.¹⁵ Each time we read such texts and imagine their performance, we are invited to a critique of sign-vacant power and to an alternative that allows for transformation that is not available in conventional settlements.

3. How shall we receive prophetic literature in a society of denial? The old dominant ideology of chosenness in Jerusalem insisted upon proclaiming false peace:

From the least to the greatest of them,
Everyone is greedy for unjust gain;
and from prophet to priest,
everyone deals falsely.
They have treated the wound of my people carelessly,
saying, “Peace, peace,”
when there is no peace. (Jer 6:13–14; see 8:10–11)

Hananiah is a parade example of how old conviction had morphed into an ideology that permitted denial (Jeremiah 28). The denial is, first of all, a denial concerning social reality; but that denial is matched by a dismissal of YHWH as agent and character:

. . . those who say in their hearts,
“The LORD will not do good,
nor will he do harm.” (Zeph 1:12; see Jer 5:12)

And now we live in a US society of denial in which “pretend” is the hallmark of the dominant ideology. Thus it is readily claimed that more weaponry makes us safe. We eagerly trust that the economy will recover and all will soon be well. We think short-term about “natural resources” and refuse to consider the long-term savaging of creation. In the face of such “pretend” comes this ancient poetic truth-telling:

- Against military security:

But you refused and said,
“No! We will flee upon horses” —
Therefore you shall flee!
And, “We will ride upon swift steeds” —
Therefore your pursuers shall be swift!
A thousand shall flee at the threat of one,
at the threat of five you shall flee

until you are left like a flagstaff upon the top of a mountain,
like a signal on a hill. (Isa 30:15–17)

- Against easy economic recovery:

Like a cage full of birds,
their houses are full of treachery;
therefore they have become great and rich,
they have grown fat and sleek.
They know no limits in deeds of wickedness;
they do not judge with justice
the cause of the orphan, to make it prosper,
and they do not defend the rights of the needy.
Shall I not punish them for these things? says the LORD,
and shall I not bring retribution on such a nation such as this? (Jer 5:27–29)

The poem ends with a double question. No reader can doubt the intended answer.

- Against environmental indifference:

I looked on the earth, and lo, it was waste and void;
And to the heavens, and they had no light.
I looked on the mountains, and lo, they were quaking,
And all the hills moved to and fro.
I looked, and lo, there was no one at all,
And all the birds had fled.
I looked, and lo, the fruitland was a desert,
and all its cities were laid in ruins.
before the LORD, before his fierce anger. (Jer 4:22–26)

In the face of such mendacity, the poetry erupts. It erupts because of deep impassioned conviction. It erupts, so say the prophets with their formula, “Thus saith the LORD,” because there is a holy resolve that is dissatisfied. It may even erupt among us, because we receive it, whatever our notion of “revelation” might be, as a word that will not be disregarded. We say “not disregarded” because it is heard as compellingly offensive in contemporary vacuums of entitlement. It is offensive because it will not make peace with “pretend.”

4. How shall we receive prophetic literature in a hand-wringing society of despair that reaches the conclusion that nothing can be done? We are, in our society, very close to such a conclusion when we are honest. The problems are too big and complex, the political will is too weak, ergo the future is lean indeed. Our mood will shortly be not unlike the near despair of exiled Israel:

My way is hidden from the LORD,
And my right is disregarded by my God. (Isa 40:27)

The LORD has forsaken me,
 my LORD has forgotten me. (Isa 49:14)
 Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost;
 we are cut off completely. (Ezek 37:11)

And then, in a burst of poetry, there is a counter:

The days are coming . . .
 In that day . . .

In that day—restoration! In that day, *shalom*! The days of disarmament (Isa 2:2–4)! The days of renewed social relationships (Jer 33:10–11)! We have among us no thicker utterance of hopeful possibility in the face of despair than that of Martin Luther King, Jr., “I have a dream.” In his utterance, King reiterated the prophetic refusal to accept despair, precisely because of originary stirring of fidelity about which he had no doubt.

Now of course, this reading of reception history comes close to “preaching.” It is not, however, preaching in any way that we sometimes understand preaching, nothing here of coercion, authoritarianism, closure, moral scolding, or dogmatism. This reception is rather a note of elusive expectation that lets ancient words touch present social reality. And when that word touches a new context, there is transformative potential.

FROM CRITICISM TO CONTEMPORANEITY

I suggest that all of these methodological options that move beyond historical criticism will be major accents in the future study of the prophetic corpus. It is a happy prospect, in my judgment, that many younger scholars no longer assent to “the wall of separation” between critical study and theological exposition with an edge of contemporaneity, a wall that is the legacy of Enlightenment rationality. That “wall of separation” was an acutely “modern” notion, reflective of the valuing of “objective” possibility. Whatever else one may make of the term “postmodern,” this is certainly “post” to the old assumptions of objectivity that is no longer on the horizon. All of these practices that I have enumerated—rhetorical, post-critical, post-colonial, reception history—require the interpreter to be dialogically engaged diligently with a text that is “still speaking.” It is in the nature of the canonical process that the ancient texts have been produced, shaped, and transmitted for subsequent use. These several methods are, in my judgment, faithfully in sync with canonical intentionality.¹⁶ The prophetic corpus is shaped for reperformance and interpretation, so that future study, to some extent moving beyond the recovery of “original meaning,” will perforce include some decisive measure of contemporaneity in the task of exposition. I believe, beyond that, that our social, cultural context of crisis evokes and requires, as an ethical matter, the offer of an imaginative antidote to the lethal preoccupations of our culture in terms of sex,

money, power, and control. Testimony in the prophetic corpus is shaped canonically for long-term retelling. It is testimony that always and everywhere disrupts what had been thought to be settled.

NOTES

1. Ronald E. Clements, "Patterns in the Prophetic Canon," in *Canon and Authority: Essays in Old Testament Religion and Theology*, ed. George W. Coats and Burke O. Long (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1977), 42–55 (45, 49, 53).
2. On the "classic" in Christian horizon, see David W. Tracy, *The Analogical Imagination: Christian Theology and the Culture of Pluralism* (New York: Crossroad, 1981).
3. See Phyllis Tribble, *Rhetorical Criticism: Context, Method, and the Book of Jonah* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1994).
4. Quoted in Margalit Fox, "He Wove Irish Strife and Soil into Silken Verse," *New York Times* (August 31, 2013), B12.
5. Francis X. Clines, "Seamus Heaney, Poet of 'the Silent Things,'" *New York Times* (August 31, 2013), A14.
6. James Muilenburg, "The Terminology of Adversity in Jeremiah," in *Translating and Understanding the Old Testament*, ed. Harry Thomas Frank and William L. Reed (Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1970), 42–63.
7. Paul Ricoeur, *The Symbolism of Evil* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1967), 352, and many other places in his writings.
8. Ricoeur, *Symbolism of Evil*; see also Mark I. Wallace, *The Second Naiveté: Barth, Ricoeur, and the New Yale Theology* (Studies in American Biblical Hermeneutics 6; Macon, GA: Mercer University Press, 1990).
9. See Claus Westermann, *Basic Forms of Prophetic Speech* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1967; repr. Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1991); and Westermann, *Prophetic Oracles of Salvation in the Old Testament* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 1991).
10. James C. Scott, *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1985); and Scott, *Domination and the Arts of Resistance: Hidden Transcripts* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1990).
11. The formula comes from a sermon of John Robinson in 1620 when the Puritans set out to the New World. He affirmed that more of truth and light yet could be given in and through Scripture. See Edward Winslow's account of the sermon in *Hypocrisy Unmasked: A True Relation of the Proceedings of the Governor and Company of the Massachusetts against Samuel Gorton of Rhode Island*, a 1916 reprint of the 1646 original in the Library of Congress.
12. The verse from Amos is engraved at the Martin Luther King Memorial in Montgomery, Alabama. It is likely that most who visit the memorial have little understanding of the narrative world of Amos or the socioeconomic crisis to which his words refer.
13. Robert W. Jenson, *Canon and Creed* (Interpretation; Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2010).
14. Francis Fukuyama, *The End of History and the Last Man* (New York: The Free Press, 1992).
15. On the Eucharist as transformative act and sign in Chile under Augusto Pinochet, see William T. Cavanaugh, *Torture and Eucharist: Theology, Politics, and the Body of Christ*

(Oxford: Blackwell, 1998). As the first Black president of South Africa, Nelson Mandela went to a 1995 rugby match between the South Africa Springboks and the New Zealand All Blacks for the Rugby World Cup. Mandela wore a Springboks team shirt and cap, performing presidential identification with what was, in that context, primarily a White Afrikaner team. It was a majestic gesture and a magical, transformative moment for South Africa.

16. See James A. Sanders, "Adaptable for Life: The Nature and Function of Canon," in *Magnalia Dei: The Mighty Acts of God: Essays on the Bible and Archaeology in Memory of G. Ernest Wright* (ed. Frank Moore Cross, Werner E. Lemke, and Patrick D. Miller, Jr.; Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1976), 531–560.

CHAPTER 37

THE PROPHETS

Looking Forward

LENA-SOFIA TIEMEYER

WHAT are the most important issues and challenges for future scholarship on the Latter Prophets? To start with a very general yet nevertheless important point, are we all reading the same biblical text? This matter is not limited to the Latter Prophets but spans the entirety of the Hebrew Bible. It is unrelated to multiple and diverse reading strategies. There are many reading communities and many reading methods, and this plurality is to be treasured rather than being objected to. It is furthermore independent of textual and literary criticism and whether we read the MT or the LXX or some other version. Again, it is fruitful to explore the distinct reading of one ancient version and to compare it with the reading of another ancient version. It is finally also not an exegetical issue. Our imperfect understanding of biblical Hebrew, combined with our incomplete understanding of the literary conventions and stylistic characteristics of ancient Israel, naturally gives rise to different interpretation of a given word or sentence on a most basic literary level. In time, further research will hopefully grant us a deeper and more precise understanding of the text.

The problem that I perceive to exist lies elsewhere. In my view, many scholars do not see eye-to-eye with each other's methods. There seems at times to be a gap between different scholarly understandings of *what the text is really about*. In particular, those Bible interpreters who approach the texts of the Hebrew Bible canonically sometimes fail to differentiate properly between what the text actually states and what a given statement has been understood to mean by later traditions, including that of the New Testament. This lack of distinction sometimes makes dialogue unnecessarily complicated. In general, there is a need for a deeper methodological awareness. On the one hand, those scholars who are doing canon criticism need to spell out that their canonical interpretations do not reflect the plain meaning of the text. On the other hand, those scholars who do not share a canonical interest should nevertheless be respectful of the canonical significance of a given text and grant it legitimacy as a valid and important reading of the text.

In some cases, a scholar may be reluctant to listen to the plain meaning of the text. We may be so preconditioned to hear a specific message that we cannot hear anything

else. For instance, we “know” that God is a God of love and justice. When encountering a text that seemingly preaches the opposite, we thus intuitively search for an interpretation that enables us to uphold our view that God is just. Such an approach, in turn, causes consternation, unease, and annoyance in other scholars who do not share our preconceived viewpoints. Carly Crouch’s monograph on ethics and military violence, a book that discusses key texts from the latter prophets (Amos, Isaiah, and Nahum), is a good example of a book that breaks the mold by showing that the annihilation of your enemies was considered to be ethical in ancient Near Eastern warfare.¹ This is not a comfortable conclusion, yet this interpretation is in line with the plain meaning of (select) texts and thus needs to be reckoned and interacted with.

The (in)ability to read the plain sense of the text touches many areas of the Latter Prophets. In the case of the sexual and marital metaphors in the prophetic literature, for example, it is sad to observe the divide between those exegetes who uphold God’s justice and compassion, no matter what the text actually says, and other exegetes who are so fixated on God’s violent character and unjust behavior that they cannot acknowledge a more nuanced picture. There is truth on both sides of the debate, and I seek more honest and open-minded dialogue.

On a related note, I would like a wider selection of scholars to address key topics in the prophetic literature. On the above-mentioned subject of gendered language and on sexual and marital metaphors in the prophetic literature, I would, for instance, welcome more studies written by female scholars who regard themselves as evangelicals. Evangelical perspectives on these matters are often (although by no means exclusively) voiced by male scholars. The collection of articles on evangelical engagement with feminist Old Testament hermeneutics, edited by Andrew Sloane, is a good beginning, yet also a case in point.² Out of eleven contributions, only three are written by female scholars.

Speaking of feminist scholarship, I perceive there to be something akin to an impasse in the field in the sense that so much has been written on such a limited range of topics. The research on sexual and marital metaphors has had great impact on the field of Hebrew Bible scholarship,³ as have the various studies on the literary persona of Zion.⁴ I believe that feminist scholarship is now ready to go beyond these and related topics and to venture into new grounds. I very much look forward to the future publication of the *Wisdom Bible Commentary: A Feminist Commentary on the Old and New Testaments*.⁵ It is my hope that this commentary series will interact with the full range of biblical texts from a feminist perspective. Going beyond feminist critique, I would also like to see a widening of the field so that other gendered perspectives come to the forefront. In recent years, I have particularly welcomed the study of the prophetic literature through the lens of gender study.⁶

COLLABORATION AMONG SCHOLARS

Continuing on the topic of scholarly diversity, I would welcome more cooperation across the gulf between German-speaking and English-speaking scholars. A few excellent

edited volumes have been published recently that genuinely try to bridge the gap between the two scholarly traditions.⁷ This is a good beginning and a tendency to be encouraged, yet much remains to be done. A substantial number of published Ph.D. theses, from both sides of the Atlantic, pay no more than lip service to the interpretive traditions of the other “camp.”⁸ More specifically, I would like to see volumes in which scholars from various traditions not only write independent articles on a shared topic, but truly *engage* with the research of one another, with the aim of mutual benefit and with the hope that the insights of the combined scholarly traditions can generate new and fruitful results.

MODELS FOR THE PRODUCTION OF PROPHETIC LITERATURE

Moving on to the production of prophetic literature, there are currently three main critical models for understanding textual development. The first model assumes that a prophetic book contains several, originally independent blocks of texts, which were later put together by a redactor. The second model assigns a more creative role to the redactors. They are authors and interpreters in their own right, and they are driven by the need and desire to update the older prophetic message in order to make it relevant to their own contemporary times. In most cases, this model presupposes that a text/book has gone through several subsequent redactions, which has resulted in a text consisting of multiple textual layers, the earliest of which may go back to the assumed historical prophet.⁹ Recently, a third model has gained popularity, namely that the text may be an authorial unity but its author should not be identified with any historical prophet. Rather, the prophetic book is a scribal work from beginning to end, and the prophet speaking and acting on its pages is a literary persona that need not bear any resemblance to a specific historical character.¹⁰ This is an interesting development, as it argues, on the one hand, for literary unity of a given text yet, on the other hand, postulates a very late date for that text, which is completely detached from any original prophetic *ipsissima verba*. This is a significant new trend, and I foresee more monographs that will adhere to the same lines of thinking. In a sense, it betrays a disillusion with traditional redaction-critical studies, preferring instead to interact with the extant text rather than with any hypothetical earlier core. At the same time, it also recognizes the need to locate the historical situation that gave birth to the book and to interpret it accordingly. In my view, redaction-critical scholars must begin to interact with this trend in order to establish some common ground for dialogue.

STUDY OF ANCIENT SOCIAL CONTEXTS

On a related topic, there is a need to investigate further the social location of the prophetic books. Were they written by and for the post-exilic literati, as some scholars have

argued,¹¹ or do some texts mirror a more “proletarian” *Sitz im Leben*, in the sense that they reflect the views of the non-elite population? Is it possible that some of the prophets, such as Hosea and Amos, were literate “freelance writers” who lacked ties to the establishment and thus were in a unique position to criticize the ruling classes, or are the prophetic books rather examples of educated fiction, the compositions of post-exilic scribes who criticized past rulers through the imagined prophetic personae—who exist only on the written pages of the book bearing their name—in order to instruct their contemporary readers?

As we emphasize the prophetic books and their production, and as we gradually disassociate the biblical prophetic literature from the prophetic professional men (and women) who functioned in the ancient Near East,¹² we inevitably begin to treat prophecy as a scribal endeavor that had the scriptorium as its *Sitz im Leben*. This ultimately means that we are disregarding the claims of the prophetic books themselves, namely that God overpowered a human being, spoke to him, and commissioned him to convey the divine message. We do well to remember that men and women in the ancient world believed that the deities communicated with humankind and that the biblical texts, written in this culture, reflect this belief. We cannot reach the experiences themselves, of course, but we can study the ways in which they are articulated. For instance, how did the authors of the prophetic book describe the prophetic experience, and how did later translators and commentators interpret these statements? I am pleased to see a growing interest in religious experience and the world behind the text. The articles in the two volumes of *Experientia* have broadened the field and reflect new attempts to link text and experience.¹³ This is a good beginning, yet a quick glance over the table of contents in the two volumes reveals that only a few articles deal with the prophetic experience. There are some signs that interest in reading the prophetic literature with a focus on its phenomenological aspects is increasing. In a recent volume, Rodney Werline has analyzed Zechariah 1–6 from the perspective of religious experience.¹⁴ This field is wide open to further explorations, yet we need to take care lest we revert back to the type of uncritical studies that explore the “prophetic mind.” We are limited to the study of *the text*, that is, the literary depiction of the (assumed) phenomenological event.

There is, in many respects, a dichotomy between treating a prophetic book as the product of a group of learned scribes and reading it as an account of an individual prophet’s personal experience. On the one hand, it is possible to assume that the scribes invented the stories about the prophets and their experiences. Along this line of thinking, Jeremiah is portrayed as a tormented human being overpowered by God’s presence (e.g., Jer 20:7–18), yet he never existed. Instead, the literary persona of Jeremiah is modeled after some “ideal” prophet who lives only in the scribes’ written recollection. On the other hand, as the notion of an anguished prophet who is overwhelmed by God’s awesome manifestation and is compelled to speak his words is a concept to which readers can relate, it cannot be excluded that the extant literary presentation of the prophet Jeremiah has as its origin a historical person named Jeremiah. Likewise, the idea of the interceding prophet in select parts of the Hebrew Bible (Jeremiah, Amos, cf. Abraham, Moses, and Samuel) is a literary construct, yet this idea presumably reflects a reality in

which prophets were associated with the task of intercession. How else would the intended readers have been able to relate to the extant literary depictions in the first place?

PSYCHOLOGIZING APPROACHES

This brings us to the notion of psychological readings of the prophetic literature. Does the biblical text reflect the personality of the prophet? Should we interpret a prophetic text in the light of the author's (presumed) personal experiences? These issues have come to the forefront especially in the study of the book of Ezekiel. At the one end of the spectrum, David J. Halperin suggests that many of the descriptions of God and of women in the book of Ezekiel are the result of the author's (i.e., Ezekiel's) damaged mind,¹⁵ and Daniel L. Smith-Christopher maintains that the theology of the book of Ezekiel has been influenced by the prophet's experiences of violence and humiliation at the hands of the Neo-Babylonian soldiers.¹⁶ At the other end of the spectrum, Ruth Poser argues that it is preferable to view the traumatized prophet Ezekiel as a literary figure and thus to categorize the book of Ezekiel as literature of survival. Poser maintains that Mesopotamian military campaigns, with their policies of siege, mass deportation, and forced migration, form the psycho-traumatic background of the book of Ezekiel. The difference between the viewpoints of Smith-Christopher and Poser lies in their respective understanding of authorship. While Smith-Christopher sees the book of Ezekiel as the immediate expression of the prophetic author's distress, Poser understands the book as a later reflection of the suffering of the people of Judah.¹⁷ There is clearly much work to be done in this contentious area, as well as a need for astute methodological guidelines to help us navigate around the multiple pitfalls that are present in these types of studies.

ATTENTION TO RECEPTION HISTORY

Turning to the afterlife of the prophetic literature, I am pleased to see an increased interest in the reception history of the Bible. This is a vast and potentially very fruitful area of study. So far, several good monographs exploring the reception of the book of Isaiah have been published.¹⁸ In contrast, remarkably few books deal with the reception history of the rest of the prophetic literature.¹⁹ The Blackwell Wiley biblical commentary series is, in my view, an important step in the right direction. So far, however, only one book devoted to the prophetic literature (Nahum to Malachi)²⁰ has been published, but more volumes are in production. As for future projects, scholars might like to emulate Brill's current Themes in Biblical Narrative (TBN) series, which focuses on themes and characters in the Pentateuch and beyond, to fit the specific requirements of the prophetic literature.

Reception history further provides good opportunities for scholarly collaboration across gender, religious affiliation, and country of origin. So often, books and articles of reception history tend to be limited to the English-speaking realms. I would like to see collections of articles, tightly edited around one small book, section of a book, or literary character, written by scholars from different language traditions with expert knowledge of and access to the religious traditions in their own culture and to the academic writings in their own language. This, in turn, will hopefully foster collaboration across language borders. Especially important on this score will be the incorporation of non-European and non-American perspectives. To conclude, there are challenges lying ahead, but also ample opportunities for new venues of research and fruitful collaboration across language and culture borders.

NOTES

1. C. L. Crouch, *War and Ethics in the Ancient Near East: Military Violence in Light of Cosmology and History* (BZAW 407; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2010).
2. Andrew Sloane, ed., *Tamar's Tears: Evangelical Engagements with Feminist Old Testament Hermeneutics* (Eugene, OR: Pickwick, 2012).
3. See, e.g., Sharon Moughtin-Mumby, *Sexual and Marital Metaphors in Hosea, Jeremiah, Isaiah, and Ezekiel* (OTM; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008).
4. See, e.g., Julia M. O'Brien, *Challenging Prophetic Metaphor: Theology and Ideology in the Prophets* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2008); and Elizabeth Boase, *The Fulfilment of Doom? The Dialogic Interaction between the Book of Lamentations and the Pre-Exilic/Early Exilic Prophetic Literature* (LHBOTS 437; London: Bloomsbury T & T Clark, 2006).
5. This is a planned 60-volume new commentary series. General Editor: Barbara E. Reid; Old Testament Prophets Editor: Carol J. Dempsey (under contract with Liturgical Press). So far, two volumes are available on the Prophetic literature: Stacy Davis, *Haggai, Malachi* (Wisdom Commentary; Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2015), and Julia O'Brien, *Micah* (Wisdom Commentary; Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2015). See further <http://www.wisdomcommentary.org/Home>.
6. Most recently, see the various articles in Jonathan Stökl and Corrine L. Carvalho, eds., *Prophets Male and Female: Gender and Prophecy in the Hebrew Bible, the Eastern Mediterranean, and the Ancient Near East* (AIL; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2013). For yet another perspective, see also Susan E. Haddox, *Metaphor and Masculinity in Hosea* (StBibLit 141; New York: Peter Lang, 2011), who explores the use of metaphor in the book of Hosea from the perspective of masculinity studies.
7. See, e.g., Rainer Albertz, James D. Nogalski, and Jakob Wöhrle, eds., *Perspectives on the Formation of the Book of the Twelve: Methodological Foundations—Redactional Processes—Historical Insights* (BZAW 433; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2012).
8. There are several good exceptions. Øystein Lund's monograph *Way Metaphors and Way Topics in Isaiah 40–55* (FAT II/28; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2007), on the way metaphors in Isaiah 40–55, for example, is a showcase of scholarly interaction across language barriers, with about equal attention given to English and German scholarship.
9. See, e.g., Jacob Stromberg, *Isaiah after Exile: The Author of Third Isaiah as Reader and Redactor of the Book* (OTM; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011).

10. See, e.g., Jason Radine, *The Book of Amos in Emergent Judah* (FAT II/45; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2010); James M. Bos, *Reconsidering the Date and Provenance of the Book of Hosea: The Case for Persian-Period Yehud* (LHBOTS 580; London: Bloomsbury T&T Clark, 2013); and Alexander Prokhorov, *The Isaianic Denkschrift and a Socio-cultural Crisis in Yehud: A Rereading of Isaiah 6:1–9:6* (FRLANT 261; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2015).
11. See, for example, many of the articles in Diana V. Edelman and Ehud Ben Zvi, eds., *The Production of Prophecy: Constructing Prophecy and Prophets in Yehud* (London and Oakville, CT: Equinox, 2009).
12. For a solid study of the prophetic personnel in the ancient Near East and their counterparts in ancient Israel, see Jonathan Stökl, *Prophecy in the Ancient Near East: A Philological and Sociological Comparison* (CHANE 56; Leiden: Brill, 2012).
13. Frances Flannery, Colleen Shantz, and Rodney A. Werline, eds., *Experientia*. Volume 1: *Inquiry into Religious Experience in Early Judaism and Early Christianity* (SymS 40; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2008); Colleen Shantz and Rodney A. Werline, eds., *Experientia*. Volume 2: *Linking Text and Experience* (EJL 35; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2012).
14. Rodney A. Werline, "Assessing the Prophetic Vision and Dream Texts for Insight into Religious Experience," in *"I Lifted My Eyes And Saw": Reading Dream and Vision Reports in the Hebrew Bible*, ed. Elizabeth R. Hayes and Lena-Sofia Tiemeyer (LHBOTS 584; London: Bloomsbury, 2014), 1–15.
15. David. J. Halperin, *Seeking Ezekiel: Text and Psychology* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1993).
16. Daniel L. Smith-Christopher, *A Biblical Theology of Exile* (OBT; Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2002). See also Paul M. Joyce, *Ezekiel: A Commentary* (JSOTSup 482; London: T & T Clark, 2007).
17. Ruth Poser, *Das Ezechielbuch als Trauma-Literatur* (VTSup 154; Leiden and Boston: Brill, 2012). Poser is open to the possibility that the group of authors behind the book were themselves victims of and eyewitnesses to the catastrophe of the destruction of Jerusalem.
18. See, e.g., Joseph Blenkinsopp, *Opening the Sealed Book: Interpretations of the Book of Isaiah in Late Antiquity* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2006).
19. A notable exception is Yvonne Sherwood, *A Biblical Text and Its Afterlives: The Survival of Jonah in Western Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000).
20. Richard Coggins and Jin H. Han, *Six Minor Prophets through the Centuries: Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi* (BBC; Hoboken: Wiley-Blackwell, 2011).

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